Qur'anic Reflections

Insights into the objectives of the Qur'anic verses

Part 1/3

In the name of Allah
the All-Merciful
the Ever-Merciful

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Insights into the objectives of the Qur'anic verses

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The English Convoy

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Dedication

To our beloved Prophet Muhammad, *Sala-llahu Alayhi Wa-Sallam*, who taught us that our pride and strength lie in our adherence to the Noble Qur'an, by saying: "Verily, through this book (The Noble Qur'an), Allah exalts some people and humiliates others."[1]

To the honorable companion Zayd Ibn-Thabet, who collected the Qur'an, and was entrusted with the most important task in history while still in his prime.

To the youth of Islam, children of the honorable companions who were called upon in the heat of battle: "People of the Qur'an, honor the Qur'an with your deeds!"

To the people of the Qur'an, who are Allah's people and servants, I dedicate this book to you: Qur'anic Reflections - An insight into the objectives of the verses of the Qur'an.

Amr Khaled

[1] Narrated by Omar Ibnul-Khattab, Sahih Muslim, Riyadus-Saliheen.

Acknowledgements

To the honorable scholars, righteous professors and unknown soldiers who took part in preparing this Qur'anic material, and who did not spare knowledge, nor effort, nor time. May Allah reward them on my behalf and on behalf of the people of the Qur'an.

Amr Khaled

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Preface

"Praise be to Allah[2] Who has sent down upon His bondman the Book and has not made to it any crookedness." (TMQ 18:1)[3]

""Praise be to Allah, Who guided us to this; and in no way could we have been guided, unless Allah has guided us!" (TMQ 7:43)

This book is not an interpretation of the meanings of the Qur'an, and its aim is not to give a detailed explanation of the ayahs (verses) of the Qur'an. If this is what you are after then you should refer to the main *tafseer* (interpretation) books, like *tafseer* At-Tabari or Ibn-Kathir or any of the other interpretation books that fill our Islamic libraries. This book's idea is different and so is its aim.

The idea behind this book haunted me for ten years, especially in Ramadan of each year, when Muslims all over the Islamic world dedicate their time to reading the entire Qur'an during this blessed month. However, I found it truly regrettable that this genuine desire to read the Qur'an was not associated with a clear understanding of each surah's objectives, reasons of revelation, and the core message addressed to us. As a result, I found people reading the Qur'an and feeling that its meanings were somewhat alien to them. Some might even find them enigmatic or meant to be read without proper understanding of their essence or purposes. Others might grasp the meaning of the wording of the ayahs, but find no connection between one ayah and the next, and instead consider them a series of unrelated ayahs in one surah. They might even think that there is no main objective that links all the ayahs of the surah. This is the cornerstone of this book. It is a humble piece of work that breaks the barriers between the youths of our *Ummah* and the Noble Book of Allah (*SWT*[4]).

This book shows how the ayahs of each surah are well-knit and closely related. It demonstrates that every surah has one topic and a specific objectives, and that although at first glance the ayahs might seem scattered and unrelated, when you look closely you will discover the topic of the surah and the amazing correlations between the ayahs. This will lead you to a clearer understanding of the objective of the surah, increase your love of the book of Allah, and strengthen your belief in its divine nature, a revelation from the Wise, the All-Aware**: "And if it had been from (any where) other than the Providence of Allah, indeed they would have found in it many difference (s)." (TMQ 4:82).**

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[2] The word Allah is the Arabic term for God. Although the use of the word "Allah" is most often associated with Islam, it is not used exclusively by Muslims; Arab Christians and Arabic-speaking Jews also use it to refer to the One God. The Arabic word expresses the unique characteristics of the One God more precisely than the English term. Whereas the word "Allah" has no plural form in Arabic, the English form does, and the word 'Allah' in Arabic has no connotation of gender. Allah is the God worshipped by all Prophets, from Adam to Noah, Abraham, Moses, Jesus and Muhammad.

[3] TMQ=Translation of the meaning of the Qur'an. This translation is for the realized meaning, so far, of the stated (Surah: ayah) of the Qur'an. Reading the translated meaning of the Qur'an can never replace reading it in Arabic, the language in which it was revealed.

Details about the translation of the meaning of the Qur'an used in this book: "Towards Understanding the Ever-Glorious Qur'an" By Dr. *Muhammad Mahmoud Ghali*, Al-Azhar University – Third edition: 2003 – Dar An-Nashr for Universities – All rights reserved to publisher.

[4] *Suhanahu wa Ta'ala* = Glorified and Exalted Be He.

Therefore, one sees that each surah of the Qur'an is a fundamental entity, achieving a clear goal; and each ayah serves this goal. The title of the surah itself is related to its objective (this sheds light on the choice of title for the surahs of the Qur'an such as: Al-Baqara (The Cow), Al-'Imran (The family of 'Imran), Yunus (Jonah) and An-Naml (The Ants)).

Moreover, every surah is closely related to the previous and the following surahs, because the order of the Qur'anic surahs was also revealed by Allah *(SWT)*. We, therefore, come to the conclusion that the surahs of the Qur'an are one continuous series, so that if you understand their objective (or objectives), you will grasp Allah's aim and what He wants to teach you from this book.

Even if you do not understand every single ayah or word, comprehending the general objectives of the surahs leads you to understanding the Qur'an in its entirety.

Thus, this book is equally useful to the public and the inexperienced, providing them with the essential principles to understand the Qur'an, as well as to those who memorize the Qur'an and those interested in the science of *tafseer*. This is a humble attempt on my behalf to present the core ideas and topics of the surahs of the Qur'an.
The method adopted in exposing the Qur'anic reflections is as follows:

- Pinpointing the objective of the surah.
- Clarifying the relation between the title of the surah and its objective.
- Exposing the relation of each surah with the previous and next surah.
- Choosing a few ayahs to comment on.

Once again, I would like to stress that this is not an interpretation of the meanings of the Qur'an but a mere effort and attempt to help the youths better comprehend the ayahs of the Qur'an and the correlation between the surahs. No one can ever have the last word on the subject of the Qur'an. Any attempt made to fully comprehend and grasp the topics and core ideas of the surahs is a far-reaching task, because of the eloquence of Allah's words, the unfathomable depths and accuracy, in addition to my limited and meager abilities.

This is a joint effort exerted by me and the commendable research-team who prepared this material. Any success is due to Allah's grace, and any errors or mistakes are of our own doing. I cannot help but think of what Al-Asfahani said, "I have noticed that when a man finishes writing a book, he cannot help but say later on, "if only I had not written it that way; if only I had added to it, it would have been better; had I brought this forward it would have improved the work; had I omitted this it would have embellished it." And this is a great lesson that highlights human imperfection.

After this brief introduction, I invite you, dear reader, to open your version of the Qur'an and join us in these meaningful Qur'anic reflections with my book.

Surat Al-Fatiha - (The Opener)

Surat Al-Fatiha is a Makkan surah. It is the fifth surah in the order of revelation and comprises of seven ayahs.

To start with, there are many questions to be raised. What is the secret of surat Al-Fatiha? Why does it inaugurate the Holy Qur'an? Why is it called 'the mother of the Holy Qur'an'? Why do we recite it at least 17 times daily? Why is our prayer invalidated if we do not recite surat Al-Fatiha in it?

Significance of Al-Fatiha

Narrated by Abu Said Ibn Al-Mu'alla: 'While I was praying in the mosque, the Prophet (*SAWS*[5]) called me but I did not answer him. Later I said, "O Allah's Messenger! I was just praying (when you called me)." He said, "Did not Allah say, **"Give your response to Allah (by obeying Him) and to His apostle when he calls you." (TMQ 8:24)**?" He then said to me, "I will teach you a surah which is the greatest surah in the Qur'an, before you leave the mosque." Then the Prophet (*SAWS*) took hold of my hand, and when he intended to leave (the mosque), I said to him, "Didn't you say to me, 'I will teach you a surah which is the greatest surah in the Qur'an?'" He said, "(Yes,) *Al-hamdu-lillah Rabb il-alamin* (praise be to Allah, the Lord of the *alamin*) which is *al-Sab'a al-mathani* (the seven repeatedly-recited verses) and the Grand Qur'an which has been given to me." [6]

Allah *(SWT)* demonstrates to us in surat Al-Hijr (The Rocky Tract) the sublimity of the Qur'an by saying what can be translated as, **" And indeed We have already brought you seven of the oft-repeated (i.e., the Opening Sûrah " Al-Fatiha", as it includes praise and laudation in seven verses) and the magnificent Qur'an."(TMQ 15:87) '**The seven of the oft-repeated verses' refer to Al-Fatiha for being repeatedly recited.

The Prophet *(SAWS)* says, "By Him in whose hands my soul lies, Allah did not reveal in the Torah, in the New Testament, in the Book of Psalms nor in the Qur'an anything like it; it is the seven oft-repeated verses."[7]

Hence, this surah has been given many attributes like: 'the mother of the Holy Book', 'the seven oft-repeated verses', and 'the comprehensive' and 'self-consistent (Surah)', owing to its all-inclusive meaning, and blessings other surahs draw from it.
This surah inundates the believer's life with its sublime lights. It is a divine grace that blocks the ways of temptations and leads the believer to the gates of mercy.

What secret lies within it? What is the sublimity hidden in the heart of this marvelous surah; the surah that many Muslims recite without understanding its meanings and messages?

Comprising the objectives of the Qur'an

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[5] *Sala-llahu Alaihi Wa-Sallam* = All Prayers and Peace of Allah be upon him.
[6] Narrated by Abu Said Ibn-Al-Mualla, Sahih Bukhari, Book 60.
[7] Last part of the previous Hadith.

Surat Al-Fatiha comprises all the meanings of the Qur'an. This is the inherent secret. Every meaning included in the Qur'an has been found in Al-Fatiha, and all the meanings and denotations of the Qur'an have been summed up in these seven ayahs. Let us savor together, and explore, the sublimity of the first surah of the Qur'an.

The core ideas of the Qur'an

The content of the Holy Qur'an revolves around three pivots presented to those who believe in or recite it:

1- Beliefs (to believe in Allah)
2- Acts of Worship (to know how we manage to worship our Lord in Whom we believe)
3- Way of life (The way chosen for us by Allah *(SWT)*)

First and foremost, the Qur'an teaches us righteous beliefs, i.e. believing in Allah *(SWT)* in the most appropriate way and on the basis of proper principles.

Secondly, it promotes proper acts of worship (rituals). However, acts of worship are not adequate on its own, because Islam is an all-inclusive way of life.

Surat Al-Fatiha includes these three objectives. Concerning faith, one recites Allah's words, which can be translated as, **"1- In The Name of Allah, the All-Merciful, the Ever-Merciful. 2- Praise be to Allah, the Lord of al-alamin (mankind, jinn and all that exists) 3-The All-Merciful, the Ever-Merciful. 4-The Possessor of the Day of Doom."(TMQ1:2-3).** Monotheism and the belief in the Day of Judgment are the essences of the Islamic belief. Concerning the acts of worship, we recite what can be translated as **"5-You (solely) do we worship, and You (solely) do we beseech for help (for each and every thing)."**

Concerning the Muslim's way of life Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, "**Guide us to the straight path. The Path of the ones whom You have favored, other than that of the ones against whom You are angered, and not (that of) the erring. (It is customary to say "amîn" "amen" at the end of this surah). (TMQ 1:5-7).**

All the Qur'anic surahs that follow Al-Fatiha either clarify the beliefs or explain the meaning of **"Praise be to Allah, the Lord of al-alamin (mankind, jinn and all that exists)"** and the meaning of **"3-The All-Merciful, the Ever-Merciful"** and that of **"4-The only Owner (and the only ruling judge) of the Day of Doom"**. Moreover, they show us how to worship Allah *(SWT)* **"5-You (solely) do we worship, and You (solely) do we beseech for help (for each and every thing)"** Moreover, they relate the principles to be followed in this life, as well as the deeds of the tyrants, the fate of the desperate people, and the ways of the saved souls; hence we find many ayahs explaining the meaning of **"6-Guide us to the straight path."**

Basics of Islam

Surat Al-Fatiha reminds us of the basics of our faith, its great meanings and denotations:

1- Remembering the boons and endowments of Allah *(SWT):* **"Praise be to Allah, the Lord of al-alamin (mankind, jinn and all that exists)".**
2- Showing sincerity when reciting, "**You (solely) do we worship".** This means we worship You and no one else, our Lord. You alone we worship and You alone we ask for assistance, "**and You (solely) do we beseech for help (for each and every thing).**
3- Seeking good and righteous company, **"Guide us to the straight path. Guide us to the straight path. The Path of the ones whom You have favored,"**
4- Warning us of bad company, **(other than that of the ones against whom You are angered, and not (that of) the erring.)" (TMQ 1:5-7).**

5- Remembering and reiterating the most beautiful names of Allah, with the emphasis on '**The All-Merciful, the Ever-Merciful'**, because the relationship between Allah *(SWT)* and mankind is dependant upon mercy. This is the reason why 'The All-Merciful, the Ever-Merciful' is repeated twice.
6- Following the right path, **"Guide us to the straight path"**
7- The Day of Judgment and the believer's preparation for it, **"**
8- The importance and the code of supplication (the surah ends with a supplication).
9- The unity of our *ummah*, as you will find that all the subject pronouns addressing the reader and the supplications in Al-Fatiha are in plural. If a man is praying alone in his room, his prayers will not be accepted if he says, "You alone I worship, and You alone I ask for help" or "guide me to the right path". We have to say, "**guide us", "You (solely) do we worship"** and **"You (solely) do we beseech for help"** all in the plural. It makes you feel that you belong to one *ummah* and that you are not alone in this universe.

The worshipper's delicacy with Allah

In addition to what we have underscored so far, this surah teaches the worshippers of Allah how to show Him respect, because it is divided into two parts. The first part is a tribute to Allah and the second is a supplication addressed to Him. We can see the praising in the following *ayaat,* **"Praise be to Allah, the Lord of al-alamin (mankind, jinn and all that exists). The All-Merciful, the Ever-Merciful. The only Owner (and the only ruling judge) of the Day of Doom." (TMQ, 1:1-4).**

The following half is a supplication, "**Guide us to the straight Path. The Path of the ones whom You have favored, other than that of the ones against whom You are angered, and not (that of) the erring".** The number of the letters of praise in the first half of Al-Fatiha is exactly equal to the number of the letters of supplications in the second half!

Hence, the surah teaches the individual how to address Allah. If he wishes to supplicate, it is preferable to start with words of praise first (so he starts by praising and glorifying Allah, then greeting the Prophet Muhammad *(SAWS*). Afterwards, he can supplicate and ask for anything, and Allah will grant him his *du'aa* (supplication) if Allah wills.

Holding a dialogue with Allah

Reciting Al-Fatiha bestows upon you the greatest honor: to enter into a dialogue with Allah *(SWT),* as explained in the following Hadith Qudsi: "Abu-Huraira reported: The Prophet of Allah *(SAWS)* said, "If anyone observes prayer in which he does not recite umm al-Qur'an, it is deficient [he said this three times] and not complete." It was said to Abu-Huraira, "At times we are behind the imam." He said, "Recite it to yourself", for he had heard the Messenger of Allah *(SAWS)* declare that Allah said, "I have divided the prayer into two shares between Me and My worshipper, and My worshipper will be endowed with whatever he asks. When the worshipper says, "Praise be to Allah, the Lord of the *alamin*", Allah says, "My worshipper has praised Me". When he says, "the All-Merciful, the Ever-Merciful", Allah says, "My worshipper has lauded Me". When he (the worshipper) says, "The Possessor of the Day of Doom", He says, "My worshipper has glorified Me". And sometimes He would say, "My worshipper entrusted (his affairs) to Me." And when he (the worshipper) says, "You (solely) do we worship and you (solely) do we beseech for help", He (Allah) says, "This (faith) is between Me and My worshipper, and My worshipper will be endowed with whatever he asks". Then, when he (the worshipper) says, "Guide us to the straight path, the path of the ones whom You have favored, other than that of the ones against whom You are angered, and not (that of) the erring", He (Allah) says, "This is for My worshipper, and My worshipper will be endowed with whatever he asks."

Thus you feel every time you recite Al-Fatiha, Allah *(SWT)* answers you. What a great honor it is for you to be mentioned by Allah although we just utter Allah's words. He, glorified be He, is worthy of all praises the way eligible to Him.

Omar's sensitivity

Omar Ibn-Abdul-Aziz *(RA)* used to recite Al-Fatiha, one ayah after the other, with a pause between each ayah. When he was asked for the reason of these silent pauses he answered, "To enjoy Allah's reply (to my supplication)."

If every heart were to feel Allah's reply when reciting this surah, it would have flown from happiness.

The compiler of graces of all times

Do you now feel the significance of this surah? Ibn-Al-Qayyem says on this subject, "Allah *(SWT)* revealed 104 books; he summed up their meanings in three books: the Torah, the New Testament and the Qur'an. And He summed up these three books in the Qur'an; and He summed up the Qur'an in Al-Fatiha; and He summed up all the meaning of Al-Fatiha in **"You (solely) do we worship, and You (solely) do we beseech for help".**

This ayah is divided into two halves, and both are essential in Islam, worshiping Allah *(SWT)* i.e. practicing His rituals, **"You (solely) do we worship"**, relying on what Allah has created on this earth and using it to achieve success in life in order to rule earth according to His methodology (as we are going to see in surat Al-Baqara). The

companions of the Prophet (*SAWS*) comprehended this ayah very well and applied its two parts in their lives, thus achieving success in this life and in the hereafter.

Today, we see some Muslims applying one half only, **"You (solely) do we worship",** restricting their understanding of Islam to mere religious practice. Meanwhile, the West applies the second half **"You (solely) do we beseech for help"**, and goes about using the earth's resources to rule it and replenish it. Islam however preaches a balance between the two, and this is what surat Al-Fatiha shows clearly.

The key to the Qur'an

So why was it called Al-Fatiha (the Opener)?

There are two interpretations. First, it is the opening surah of the Qur'an that is why it is called Al-Fatiha (as this word is derived from the Arabic word 'fataha' which means 'to open'). However, a less conspicuous reason is that it holds the key to the Qur'an (i.e. its meanings). Its first ayah opens every surah of the Qur'an. This surah holds all the treasures of the Qur'an. If you understand Al-Fatiha, you will understand all the surahs of the Qur'an that come after it.

One of the great things about the Qur'an is that all its surahs are sequential in their meanings and objectives. Each surah is related to the one preceding it according to the order of the Holy Qur'an, and it can only be related to the surah that precedes it; except Al-Fatiha. If you recite Al-Fatiha before any surah, you will find a related or complementing meaning within them both. Therefore, we start our prayer with Al-Fatiha followed by any surah, without losing the coherence in meaning.

Two surahs to explain two words

I would like to draw your attention to the interconnection between Al-Fatiha and the two surahs that come after it according to their order in the Holy Qur'an: they are Al-Baqara and Al-'Imran. One recites ayah six in Al-Fatiha, which can be translated as, **"Guide us to the right path"**.

While surat Al-Baqara begins with what can be translated as, **"This is the Book (the Qur'an), there is no suspicion about it, a guidance to the pious"** refers to Allah's words in surat Al-Fatiha, which can be translated as, **"Guide us to the right path",** to say that these words will be explained in surat Al-Baqara.

How? Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, "**Guide us to the straight Path, the Path of the ones whom You have favored, other than that of the ones against whom You are angered, and not (that of) the erring."** Those who have earned Allah's anger and those who went astray are attributes of people who deservedly incurred Allah's wrath upon themselves, or who have strayed from His path. Surat Al-Baqara explains **"other than that of the ones against whom You are angered,"** while Al-'Imran explains, "**and not (that of) the erring."**

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A whole surah (i.e. Surat Al-Baqara), composed of 286 ayahs, explains one expression in Al-Fatiha, "**other than that of the ones against whom You are angered"** and a whole surah, Al-'Imran, sheds light on "**not (that of) the erring."**

There is great consistency in terms of objectives and topics, which will become clearer and more tangible as we look into the two surahs in detail.

Mercy upon all creatures

We notice that **"the All-Merciful, the Ever-Merciful"** was repeated twice in the surah: **"In the name of Allah, the All-Merciful, the Ever-Merciful"** and **"the All-Merciful, the Ever-Merciful".** We can feel from this accentuated meaning that Allah's mercy encompasses this life and the hereafter.

The first time it came after **"Praise be to Allah, the Lord of the alamin (mankind, jinn and all that exists)".** Therefore, the *alamin* and everything in this life functions by virtue of Allah's grace or mercy. After **"the All-Merciful, the Ever-Merciful"** came **"The Possessor of the Day of Doom"** to point out that the Day of Judgment shall take place only by virtue of Allah's Omnipotence and graces. This surah appeases our fears and reminds us that the origin of this universe is Allah's grace, and that the basis of the relationship between Allah and His worshippers is mercy.

Al-alamin and people

Mentioning the word *al-alamin* (man and jinn) in this context has a graceful meaning. Al-Fatiha – which is the first surah of the Qur'an – starts with **"Praise be to Allah, the Lord of the alamin (mankind, jinn and all that exists)",** whereas the last surah of the Qur'an ends with **"of jinn and men".** Hence the Holy Qur'an starts with the word "*al-alamin*" and ends with the word "men" (meaning mankind), suggesting that this Qur'an was not just revealed for Muslims but to guide the entire humanity.

Gratuitous graces

Surat Al-Fatiha has an unmatched feature, as it does not require any of the difficult rules of *tajwid*[8]. It is easy for anyone to recite this surah, even those who do not speak the Arabic language.

Verily, Al-Fatiha is your gateway to understanding the Qur'an and holding an intimate conversation with Allah. How can we achieve this total submissiveness in our prayers and feel all the invoked meanings?

The balance of submissiveness

The Prophet *(SAWS)* says, "The worshipper only earns for his prayer as much as he has been concentrating on it."

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[8] *Tajwid* is the system of rules regulating the correct oral rendering of the Qur'an. It is believed to be the codification of the sound of the revelation as it was revealed to Prophet Muhammad, and as he subsequently rehearsed it with the Angel Jibril (Gabriel). Thus the sound itself has a divine source and significance, and is significant to the meaning.

How would you feel then, if you were only rewarded for half, or a quarter, or an eighth of your prayer? Let us recite surat Al-Fatiha together and contemplate its ayahs and their meanings.

If you feel one day that you were not quite submissive in your prayer, then you should know that there is a divine endowment that you have forgotten. If you had said, "**Praise be to Allah**" thoughtfully, you would have felt more and more subdued in your prayer and would have felt wholeheartedly every endowment and grace that Allah has bestowed upon you. Designate for each *raka'a* an endowment or a grace to reflect upon and to praise Allah for. Can you enumerate Allah's endowments? Try. Starting from Islam and faith, to the grace of the revelation of the Holy Qur'an and sending of Prophet Muhammad (*SAWS*), all the wealth and health you are enjoying, your senses; sight and hearing etc… **" ... in case you number the favor (s) of Allah, you (cannot) enumerate them. Surely man is indeed constantly unjust, most disbelieving."(TMQ 14:34).**

When you recite, **"the All-Merciful, the Ever-Merciful"** you remember Allah's mercy on his creations, which extends from this life to the hereafter - then eventually you will be submissive in your prayer. Likewise, when you read what can be translated as, **"The Possessor of the Day of Doom",** it will remind you of the Day of Judgment and its terrors. You will ask Allah to have mercy on you on that day. Eventually, you will feel total submissiveness in your prayer.

As for the fifth ayah of Al-Fatiha, which can be translated as, **"You (solely) do we worship, and You (solely) do we beseech for help"**, the mere utterance of the words **"You alone"** renews in you your devotion to Allah every single day, and you become more aware that He alone is to be worshiped and that He alone is the one who can help you. This will make you submissive in your prayer.

This ayah, as I said before, encompasses all the meanings in the revealed holy books. Therefore do not skim through it – make it your motto in life and renew its meaning in your heart every time you read it.

Furthermore, when reciting the sixth ayah, which can be translated as, "**Guide us to the right path"**, you must feel that no one else, save Allah, can guide you to the right path in life and keep you firmly on it. There is absolutely no one, but Him, who can guide you through the *sirat* so that you can cross it to reach Him. This belief augments your hope in Allah's mercy, grace, and your fear of His punishment. Bearing all that in mind, you will then be submissive in your prayer.

Share with them felicity

When reciting the seventh ayah, which can be translated as, **"The path of the ones whom You have favored"** it should invoke in your mind all those on whom Allah has bestowed his grace before you. For example, in the first *raka'a*, remember Prophet Ibrahim (Abraham) *(AS)*, Adam *(AS)*, Nuh (Noah) *(AS)* and the Seal (last) of the Prophets Muhammad *(SAWS)* and ask Allah to guide you to their path. Then try in the second *raka'a* to reflect on great men like Abu-Bakr, Omar Ibnul-Khattab and the rest of the companions, may Allah be pleased with them. In the third *raka'a* remember Salahu-deen (Saladin) and the other heroes of Islam. Finally, in the fourth

raka'a contemplate the Muslims living around you and your virtuous companions, and pray that Allah maintain these righteous ties. This is how to keep this ayah before your eyes at all times.

When you recite the second half of this ayah, which can be translated as, "**other than that of the ones against whom You are angered, and not (that of) the erring)",** it should remind you of the enemies of Islam, and the non-believers throughout ages; those who strayed from the right way or lost their way and earned Allah's wrath.

All these meanings, repeated at the end of the surah, leave thousands of good and bad role models from the past and present, to give the reader of the Qur'an an overall feeling of submissiveness and closeness to Allah, and a firmer pledge to follow His decrees, prayer after prayer, thus reviving our prayer.

The key to understanding the Qur'an

This is surat Al-Fatiha, the personal identity of every Muslim, and his or her gateway to understanding the Qur'an.

After contemplating some of the great aspects of this surah, and understanding the key to entering the realm of the Qur'anic meanings, let us embark on a journey of enlightenment, delve into and analyze His ayahs and decrees, exerting strenuous efforts to learn from the correlations between the surahs.

Surat Al-Baqara - (The Cow)

This is a Madinan surah, and the first surah to be revealed in Al-Madinah after the Prophet's emigration. The complete revelation thereof covered the Madinan period; hence, the revelation has synchronized with the establishment of the Islamic society since its very beginning. Surat Al-Baqara is the longest surah in the Qur'an comprising of 286 ayahs.

How dare we be afraid while cherishing this surah in our hearts?

There are two Ahadith about surat Al-Baqara. The first Hadith is narrated by Imam Muslim: 'Narrated by An-Nawwas Ibn Sam'an (*RA*), "I heard Allah's Messenger *(SAWS*) saying, "On the Day of Resurrection the Noble Qur'an and those who recited it and acted upon it will be brought forth. The (two) surahs Al-Baqara and Al-'Imran will plead on the behalf of those who recite them."[9]

The two surahs will defend those who have learnt them by heart and recited them regularly.

In another narration, Abu-Umama said he heard Allah's Messenger *(SAWS)* saying, "Recite the Qur'an, for on the Day of Resurrection it will come as an intercessor for those who recited it. Recite the two bright ones, Al-Baqara and Al-'Imran, for on the Day of Resurrection they will come as two clouds, or two shades, or two flocks of birds in ranks, pleading for those who recited them. Recite surat Al-Baqara, for taking recourse to it is a blessing and giving it up is a cause of grief, and the magicians cannot confront it." [10]

The heat of the Day of Resurrection is scorching; the sun draws closer to the heads of the creatures, and then surat Al-Baqara comes to shade those who have learnt it, applied its teachings, and recited it regularly.

The second Hadith about surat Al-Baqara is narrated by Muslim. Abu-Huraira, may Allah have mercy on his soul, said, "Allah's messenger (*SAWS*) said, "…Satan runs away from the houses in which surat Al-Baqara is recited" [11] and in another narration "Satan does not enter it (i.e. the house in which surat Al-Baqara is recited) for three days." Therefore, many people persist on reciting surat Al-Baqara to prevent Satan from entering their houses.

Where are the holders of surat Al-Baqara?

The Prophet *(SAWS)* used to call on Muslims in the heat of battle saying, "Where are the holders of Al-Baqara?" It seems that the holders of Al-Baqara were a special breed who used to jump promptly to answer the Prophet's call (*SAWS*).

In this respect, I call everyone to cherish in his heart surat Al-Baqara (i.e. to recite and memorize this surah and most importantly to follow all the commandments

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[9] Riyad-us-Saliheen
[10] Sahih Muslim, Book 4
[11] Sahih At-tirmithi

mentioned therein) in order to be one of the finest people in this life and part and parcel of those endowed with Allah's shade (on the Day of Judgment) in the Hereafter.

The objective of the surah

Probing and exploring the objective of the surah assists us in understanding the progression of the ayahs and discovering the correlations between its different topics. Some scholars have even said that the different chapters of the Qur'an were called "Surahs" because each one dealt with one topic. The ayahs of the surahs are like a fence that encircles the objective of the surah and revolves around it to serve its meaning. (Remember that the word "Surah" is derived from the Arabic word "sur" which means "a fence" in Arabic.) Thus, every surah has one core idea and one objective. Now, let's raise a question, what is the objective of this surah? What is the core idea that ties together the 286 ayahs over two and half *ajzaa'* (parts)[12] of the Qur'an?

This surah's main objective is the succession of man on earth. To put it simply, it calls upon us, "You Muslims are responsible for earth". Those who recite surat Al-Baqara must know that they are responsible for earth, and that their guiding lodestar in life is surat Al-Baqara.

Lucky are those who take an example (and a warning) from others

Allah *(SWT)* entrusted many nations throughout history with the responsibility of ruling earth. Some succeeded and some failed. It is time for this nation to take the responsibility and achieve this divine goal. Allah *(SWT*) does not favor anyone, not even the nation of Muhammad *(SAWS)* over any other nations. If it fails in its mission, it will be replaced by another, just as the nations before it. Hence, it is clear why surat Al-Baqara is the first surah in the Qur'an after Al-Fatiha. It is the surah that outlines the methodology of Islam. This also clarifies why it is the first surah to be revealed in Al-Madinah over the nine years which the Prophet (*SAWS*) had spent there. The reason is quite conspicuous. The Prophet immigrated to Al-Madinah when the Muslims were the victims of incessant persecution in Makkah and settled there to found the *Ummah.*

That's why this surah was revealed during the foundation stage of Islamic society. It guides the *Ummah* to recognize the mode of taking responsibility for earth. Anyone reciting this surah should know that every ayah asks him to fulfill the mission for which he was created. O Muslims, you are responsible for reform, replenishment and guidance on earth. It is incumbent upon every person not to be a failure in life, to be able to guide people and to achieve success. All this is explained in surat Al-Baqara.

The sections of surat Al-Baqara

Surat Al-Baqara is composed of an introduction then two sections, followed by the concluding section.

[12] The singular is *Juzu* meaning one part.

The first section, covering the first part (*juzu)*' of the Qur'an, describes three types of people entrusted by Allah to rule earth. The second section is composed of the ayahs from number 142 to number 283, describing a number of commandments and prohibitions that should be followed by the *Ummah*.

The first *juzu* of the Qur'an:

This *juzu* is composed of eight quarters**:**

- The first quarter (*hizb*) deals with different kinds of people in order to display the three groups existing on earth as they will be given responsibility for earth.
- The second quarter talks about the experience of the first successor of earth: Adam (*AS*).
- From the third to the seventh quarter, the ayahs deal with a nation that had been granted the responsibility for earth for a long time, but they failed: the Israelites.
- The eighth (and last) quarter talks about the successful succession of Prophet Ibrahim *(AS)*.

The trial Adam had passed through was a preparatory instructional experience. The confrontation between Adam *(AS)* and Satan was the starting-point of Adam and his descendants' responsibility for earth. The Israelites were an example of failure when they were given the same responsibility. The surah, then, details their mistakes - not to insult them, but to tell this Ummah, "Be careful not to follow the example of the previous ruling *Ummah*!"

The last quarter is an example of the successful experience of succession, as represented by Prophet Ibrahim *(AS),* to whom Allah entrusted earth.

This is a logical order. It started out with Adam, the first trial, and ended with the successful experience to raise our morals.

The introductory ayahs**: Three types of people**

The introductory ayahs present three types of people. The traits of the first type, the pious, are traced in the first five ayahs. The second types, the disbelievers, are described in the next two ayahs. The characteristics of the third type, the hypocrites, are revealed in the last 13 ayahs (8 - 20) due to the great perils they represent.

It is as if the introduction addresses you by saying, "These are the types of people, so choose for yourself. Which of these types you want to be? Only one of these types will bear the responsibility for earth."

Notice that the first trait of the pious people, as mentioned in the following ayah, in which Allah (*SWAT*) says that they **"believe in the Unseen (*Ghaib*[13]…)" (TMQ 2:3).**

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[13] *Al-Ghaib*: literally means an unseen thing. But this word includes profound meanings: belief in Allah, Angels, Holy Books, Allah's Messengers, Day of Resurrection and *Al-Qadar* (Divine Pre-ordainments). It also includes what Allah and His Messenger (*SAWS*) mentioned about the knowledge of the matters of past, present, and future e.g., news about the creation of heavens and earth, botanical and zoological life, facts about the nations of the past, Paradise and Hell.

The most important attribute of the *Ummah,* which leads mankind, is their belief in the unseen. By contrast, the worst trait of the previous nation (i.e. the Israelites) was their absolute materialism, which will be further illustrated.

Adam: the first successor on earth

After the introductory ayahs comes the story of Adam *(AS).* The story starts with the following pivotal ayah in which Allah says what can be translated as, **"And (remember) as your Lord said to the Angels, "Surely I am making in the earth a successor." …" (TMQ 2:30).**

As a human being, you are responsible for earth as was your father Adam *(AS).* Earth is not the responsibility of those who disobey Allah and renounce His laws. Adam *(AS)*, the progenitor of the entire human race, was the first person who was given this responsibility. Notice that the angels' question, concerning Adam's *(AS)* creation, did not imply objection to Allah's will. In fact, they were afraid of having Adam succeed them. They were devoted to worshipping and glorifying Allah. Allah answers them in the same ayah, **""Surely I know whatever you do not know." (TMQ 2:30).**

Allah teaches Adam *(AS)* the "technology" of life

The following ayah is also pivotal, **"And He taught Adam all the names" (TMQ 2:31).**

What does this mean?

It means that Allah *(SWT)* taught Adam *(AS),* what we refer to as, "the technology of life". He taught him the names and functions of all creations, such as the sun, the moon, the sea, the trees, and the crops. The ayah resembles a warning to the believers. They should know how to manage everything on earth in order to be responsible for it. Here we find a fine reference in ayah 22, which can be translated as, **"Who has made the earth for you (as) a bedding, and the heaven an edifice (TMQ 2:22).** Allah *(SWT)* details here the means of Adam's succession on earth and how mankind (i.e. the children of Adam) can make optimum use of land, sky, plants and so on.

This is a warning not to restrict the teachings of Islam to mere acts of worship. A Muslim has to seek knowledge by the aid of which he (or she) can manage life and earth. Allah *(SWT)* taught Adam *(AS)* how to manage earth to make us understand that devoutness alone is not enough. Both, science and technology are crucial elements of this succession as well.

Disobeying Allah is the reason of replacement

The following ayah describes Adam's experience with *Iblis* (Satan). Allah says what can be translated as, **"Then Ash-Shaytan (The all-vicious, i.e., the devil) caused them to slide back therefrom, so he drove them out of what they (both) were in …" (TMQ 2:36).**

This proves that Allah replaces those who disobey him with those who obey His commandments. It seems as though this ayah is addressed to us today by saying, "Oh, nation of Muhammad, you have been taking the responsibility for earth for 1300 years; and whatever has befallen you in the last century is the result of your disobedience. Take an example from what had happened to your progenitor Adam *(AS)*." However, Adam's fault cannot be compared to the grave sins committed nowadays, day and night. Therefore, learn from your previous mistakes and avoid sins to reclaim succession on earth.

The next ayahs, up to ayah 38, go on relating the story of Adam. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"We said**, **"Get down out of it altogether, then, if ever there should definitely (The verb has an emphatic ending, thereby saying that guidance will come) come up to you guidance from Me, then whoever follows My guidance, then no fear will be on them, neither will they grieve." (TMQ 2:38).**

Guidance sent from Allah *(SWT)*, as mentioned in this ayah, was the Holy Qur'an – as indicated in the beginning of the surah, **"That is the Book, there is no suspicion about it, a guidance to *Al-Muttaqun* [the pious believers of Islamic Monotheism who fear Allah much (abstain from all kinds of sins and evil deeds which He has forbidden) and love Allah much (perform all kinds of good deeds which He has ordained)]." (TMQ 2:2).**

It is the same guidance that we pray for when reciting surat Al-Fatiha (the Opening chapter of the Holy Qur'an), **"Guide us to the straight Path." (TMQ 1:6)**. Do you savour now the sweetness of the Qur'an and the correlation between its ayahs?

The Israelites' experience

Surat Al-Baqara then relates the Israelites' experience (starting form ayah 40). It is indicative of their failure in the divine trial of being in charge of earth.

Duty: Remembering Allah's graces & boons

In the first ayah, on this subject, Allah says what can be translated as, **"O Seeds (Or: sons) of Israel) remember My favor wherewith I favored you, and fulfill My covenant (and) I will fulfill your covenant, and do have awe of Me (only)." (TMQ 2:40).**

Allah addresses, for the first time, the Israelites by saying what can be translated as, **"…remember My favor…"** Likewise, the first ayah with which Allah addresses us in the Qur'an is, **"Praise be to Allah, the Lord of the '*Alamin* (mankind, jinn and all that exists)." (TMQ 1:2).** It is as if the first duty of the *Ummah* to be in charge of earth is to remember Allah's blessings.

Examples of the graces Allah bestowed upon the Israelites

Allah *(SWT)* mentions some of the blessings He bestowed upon the Israelites. Allah says what can be translated as, **"And (remember) as We separated the sea for you**. **So We delivered you and drowned the house of Firaawn (pharaoh) (while)**

you were looking (at them). (TMQ 2:50) Allah also says what can be translated as, **"Then after that We forgave you so that you might be grateful." (TMQ 2:52).**

He also says what can be translated as**, "And We overshadowed you with mists and We sent down manna and quails upon you. "Eat of whatever good things We have provided you." And in no way did they do injustice to Us, but they were doing injustice to themselves. (TMQ 2:57).**

These successive ayahs deal with the blessings and faults of the Israelites to warn us and dissuade us from committing the same sins.

Sins of the previous nations

Allah (*SWT*) displays the Israelites' sins in what can be translated as, **"And (remember) as you said, "O Mûsa (Moses) we will never believe you until we see Allah openly." (TMQ 2:55)**. This shows us that they represent a very materialistic nation. Absolute materialism is a fatal sin that can lead to the nations' replacement by other nations. This brings to mind the first trait of the pious, mentioned at the beginning of the surah, **"Who believe in the Unseen…" (TMQ 2:3).**

The ayahs go on enumerating the grave sins of the Israelites such as disbelieving the revelations of Allah, killing the Prophets wrongfully, disobeying Allah, transgressing and cheating in the matter of the Sabbath. Then we reach the story of the Cow, the main story of the surah.

Why this title?

Some people might wonder why this surah is called surat Al-Baqara. They would say that it relates the story of the Cow. Nevertheless, the surah comprises many other stories as well. So, why was this story in particular chosen as a title?

In fact, the story of the Cow exemplifies the major sins committed by the Israelites. It is used as the title of the surah to remind the Muslims, the *Ummah* in charge of earth, of these sins in order to avoid them.

Controversy is the origin of evils

The Israelites' sins are highlighted in the surah, starting from ayah 67**, "And as Mûsa (Moses) said to his people, "Surely Allah commands you to slay a cow," they said, "Do you take us to yourself in mockery?" He said, "I take refuge in Allah from being one of the ignorant." They said, "Invoke your Lord for us that He make evident to us what (cow) she is." He said, "Surely He says that surely she is a cow neither too old, nor new, middling between the two. So, perform what you are commanded." They said, "Invoke your Lord for us that He make evident to us what colour she is." He said, "Surely He says that surely she is a yellow cow, bright (is) her colour, pleasing to the onlookers". They said, "Invoke your Lord for us that He make evident to us what she is; surely the cows to us are similar to each other; and surely in case Allah so decides, we will indeed be rightly-guided." He said, "Surely He says that surely she is a cow not tractable (Literally made subservient) to stir the earth or to water the tillage, with no blemish in it.**

They said, "Now you have come with the truth." So, they slew her, and they had scarcely performed that. (TMQ 2:67 - 71).

The wisdom of choice

The story is about an Israelite who was murdered, and his murderer remained unknown, triggering speculations and accusations. Allah, thus, inspired the Israelites to slaughter a Cow, take a piece of its meat and hit the victim therewith. Allah (*SWT*) would then bring the man back to life to say who had murdered him. Allah wanted to test the Israelites' obedience. They were very materialistic and Allah intended to show them His Omnipotence and Might to bring a dead person back to life by means of another dead creature; something that would prove to them that life is not wholly materialistic.

However, the Israelites did not understand the wisdom of Allah's command. Since they believed in absolute materialism, they refused to carry out the command. Hence, the story of the Cow represents the Israelites' sins, materialism, and controversy. Moreover, they were disobedient to the Prophets and Allah *(SWT)*.

Even when the Israelites carried out Allah's command, they only did it reluctantly and out of force. This is indicated in the following ayah in which Allah says what can be translated as, **"…So, they slew her, and they had scarcely performed that**." **(TMQ 2:71).**

The story of the Cow seems to warn us against materialism, controversy about Allah's religion, prevarication of His commandments, and reluctance in carrying out His commands; that is why this surah was named that way.

The ayahs then go on until the first time Allah addresses the believers. Allah says what can be translated as**, "O you who have believed, do not say, "Raaina" (This from of the verb was used by the Jews and had a derisive connotation in Hebrew. Here in means "heed us") and say, "Look upon us and listen," (Literally: hear) and to the disbelievers is a painful torment. (TMQ 2:104).**

The Jews used to reiterate the term "*ra'ina*" when addressing the Prophet (*SAWS*), meaning in Arabic "look after us". However, their intention was to indirectly insult him with this word because of its meaning in Hebrew "listen, hope you become deaf". Thus, anyone who was not familiar with the Hebrew language mistakenly thought that Jews were saying "Look after us". Therefore, Allah commanded the Prophet's companions not to use the word "*ra'ina*" and use the synonymous word "*unsurna*" instead.

Although both words (*ra'ina* and *unsurna)* are synonymous, Allah *(SWT*) wants us to be a great and unique *Ummah*, a nation distinguished than all others, even in the terms they use. Therefore, Allah warns Muslims against following or even imitating the previous nations, namely, the Israelites, who committed major sins. Rather, all Muslims should be a distinguishable *Ummah*, even in the terms they use in their daily life.

There is a correlation between this ayah in surat Al-Baqara and another ayah in surat Al-Fatiha, where the believer is asked to be different from the Israelites. Allah says what can be translated as, **"other than that of the ones against whom You are angered**, **and not (that of) the erring**." **(TMQ 1:7).**

What about the Arab youth who nowadays blindly imitate the other nations and the West in the most trivial matters, while Allah *(SWT)* has taught Muslims to be distinguishable even in the terms they use?

Then, throughout the surah come a number of ayahs warning us against imitation, which begin with secondary and trivial matters and end with disbelief. Allah says what can be translated as, **"Many of the Population of the Book (Or: Family of the Book, i.e., Jews and Christians) would like to turn you back steadfast disbelievers, even after your belief," (TMQ 2:109).**

A successful experience: Ibrahim *(AS)*

The last *hizb* of the first *Juzu* (of the Holy Qur'an) deals with the trial of Ibrahim *(AS).* It is indeed a successful experience with which the first *juzu* ends, to serve as an appealing incentive for us to strive towards success in the tests of succession. Allah says what can be translated as, "**And as his Lord tried Ibrahîm (Abraham) with (certain) Words; so, he fully carried them out. (Literally: perfected them) He said, "Surely I am going to make you a leader for mankind." (TMQ 2:124).**

Prophet Ibrahim *(AS)* did not only succeed in passing through the tests, but he did so outstandingly, as indicated in **"so, he fully carried them out. (Literally: perfected them)".** Prophet Ibrahim tolerated all the trials he went through, such as when he was thrown into the fire and when he was commanded to migrate from his homeland to the desert where he left his wife and newborn son. He was also commanded to slaughter his son later on. Accordingly, Allah (*SWT*) told him that He would make him a leader of mankind because he obeyed Him.

The ayah, then, continues as follows, **"Said he, (Ibrahîm) "And of my offspring?" He said, "My Covenant will not pertain (i.e. is not attainable) to the unjust.""(TMQ 2:124).**

This proves that Allah *(SWT*) does not favor anyone, even from among the Islamic *Ummah.* It also shows that succession is associated with obedience, not kinship.

Prophet Ibrahim (*AS*) called Allah to send a Messenger from among his offspring, as indicated in the following ayah, **"Our Lord, and send forth among them a Messenger**, (**one) of them**…**" (TMQ 2:129)**. Indeed Allah answered their invocation by sending Muhammad… It is important to highlight here that the beginnings of these three stories started with ayahs of succession and all included trials of obedience to Allah.

The story of Adam *(AS)* starts with a test of obedience when Allah commanded him not to eat from the Forbidden Tree. Allah says what can be translated as, **"And (remember) as your Lord said to the Angels, "Surely I am making in the earth a successor …" (TMQ 2:30).**

The story of the Israelites starts with a trial of obedience and gratefulness to Allah, which is, whether they would carry out Allah's commands and thank Him for His blessings or not. Allah says what can be translated as, **"O Seeds (Or: sons) of Israel remember My favor wherewith I favored you, and that I graced you over the *'Alamin* [mankind and jinn (of your time period, in the past)]." (TMQ 2:47).**

The story of Prophet Ibrahim *(AS)* starts by testing his obedience by giving him certain commands. When Ibrahim worshipped Allah and abstained from worshipping idols, he had to face his father and his own people. Consequently, he was thrown into the fire. Furthermore, Allah commanded him to migrate from his homeland, leave his newborn baby and wife in the desert, and then slaughter his son.

Allah says what can be translated as, **"And as his Lord tried Ibrahîm (Abraham) with (certain) Words; so, he fully carried them out. (Literally: perfected them) He said, "Surely I am going to make you a leader for mankind." (TMQ 2:124).**

Blessings and graces

By the end of the first *Juzu*, a wonderful ayah summarizes the life story of Prophet Yaqub "Jacob" and the Israelites. Allah says what can be translated as, **"Or (even) were you witnesses as death was present to Yaaqûb? (Jacob) As he said to his seeds' (Or. sons) "What will you worship even after me?" They said, "We will worship your God and the God of your fathers Ibrahîm, Ismaeel and Ishaq, (Abraham, Ishmael and Isaac, respectively) One God; and to Him we are Muslims." (i.e., to Him we surrender)." (TMQ 2:133).**

As indicated in the ayah, Prophet Yaqub was devoted to conveying the message and trust of succession from his fathers, Ibrahim and Ishaq "Isaac", to his offspring of the Israelites.

The following ayah also comes at the close of the first *juzu*, after listing the three stories of Adam, the Israelites, and Prophet Ibrahim: **"Say (O Muslims), "We have believed in Allah, and whatever has been sent down to us, and whatever was sent down to Ibrahîm, and Ismaeel, and Ishaq and Yaaqûb (Abraham, Ishmael, Isaac and Jacob, respectively) and the Grandsons, (i.e., the Tribes) and whatever was brought down to Mûsa and Isa, (Moses and Jesus, respectively) and whatever was brought to the Prophets from their Lord. We make no distinction between any of them, and to Him we are Muslims." (TMQ 2:136).**

This ayah details those on whom Allah has bestowed His grace and who are being referred to in surat Al-Fatiha in the following two ayahs: **"Guide us to the straight Path. The Path of the ones whom You have favored, other than that of the ones against whom You are angered, and not (that of) the erring." (TMQ 1:6 – 7).**

I urge you to recite this *juzu* with the frame of mind of someone who intends to lead humanity to righteousness and deserves the honor of being a successor on earth; someone learning from the wrongdoings of other nations. This *Juzu* also warns us

against materialism, controversy, and prevaricating Allah's Law; it advocates us to obey Allah in all our deeds.

The second *juzu* of surat Al-Baqarah specifies Allah's commands and prohibitions, which the Islamic *Ummah* should abide by in order to lead mankind. All of these commands and prohibitions can be summarized into three concepts:

1. Obeying Allah
2. Becoming a unique nation
3. Fearing Allah

The Muslim who leads mankind has to have a methodology to organize his actions. This methodology is clearly outlined in the second *juzu* of surat Al-Baqara.

Changing the Qiblah's direction: A test of obedience and a command of distinction

The second *juzu* starts with a comment on a certain event: Allah's command to Muslims to change the direction of the *qiblah*[14] from Al-Aqsa Mosque in Jerusalem to the Ka'ba in Makkah, and the ensuing scepticism the Jews (in Madinah) tried to disseminate about Islam.

Allah says what can be translated as, **"The foolish ones among mankind will say, "What has turned them away from their Qiblah (The Qiblah is the Kaabah at Makkah, towards which the Muslims face in prayer), (TMQ 2:142).**

What is the relation between this quarter (*hizb)* of the surah and the preceding *hizb*? The first *juzu* deals with three stories, namely, the stories of Adam, the Israelites and Prophet Ibrahim *(AS).* The common factor between the three stories is their being all trials of obedience. Adam *(AS)* was tested when he was commanded not to eat from the Forbidden Tree; the Israelites were tested when they were commanded to slaughter the Cow and Prophet Ibrahim successfully passed all the tests of obedience he had gone through.

Allah says what can be translated as, **"And as his Lord tried Ibrahîm (Abraham) with (certain) Words; so, he fully carried them out. (Literally: perfected them) (TMQ 2:124).**

After Allah (*SWT*) had told the Muslims about the previous nations, He intended to frame a methodology for them; the first rule of which is obedience. The three stories were narrated in order to let the concept of obedience take root in the hearts of the people who are to lead mankind. Hence, changing the *Qiblah* to which the Muslims used to face in prayer would be a practical test of the Muslims' obedience. The ayah explains this meaning conspicuously.

"…. And in no way did We make the Qiblah which you had been (facing), except that We should know who closely followed the Messenger from him who turned over on his heels(i.e. disobey the Messenger)…" (TMQ 2:143).

[14] The direction now facing the Ka'ba, toward which Muslims look when praying

Some people might think this was easy to do. In fact, it was not all that easy for the Arabs to carry out such a command. Although they had been sanctifying the Ka'ba since the days of Prophet Ibrahim, Allah commanded the Muslims to face Al-Aqsa Mosque in prayer. Then, Allah commanded them to change the direction of the *qiblah* again towards the Ka'ba just to test their obedience to Him.

Notice the relationship between the previous *hizbs* of the first *juzu* and this *hizb*: The seventh *hizb* paves the way for the application of abrogation, which is, changing an Islamic regulation.

Allah says what can be translated as, **"In no way do We abrogate any ayah (i.e. verse, sign) whatsoever or cause it to be forgotten (except that) We come up with (i.e., bring) a more charitable one or the like of it …" (TMQ 2:106).**

The eighth *hizb* deals with the construction of the Holy Ka'ba. Allah says what can be translated as, **"And as Ibrahîm raised up the foundations of the Home (the *Ka'bah* at Makkah)…" (TMQ 2:127).**

Finally, the end of the first *juzu* shows that the abrogation of the rule, in this respect, will be the changing of the *qiblah* direction. What a beautiful correlation between the ayahs!

A unique *Ummah* with distinguishable diction

This *hizb* draws our attention to another objective. As previously mentioned in the fist *juzu*, it is important for Muslims to be distinguished and unique even in their vernacular and use of words, as indicated in this ayah: "**O you who have believed, do not say, "Raaina" (This from of the verb was used by the Jews and had a derisive connotation in Hebrew. Here in means "heed us") and say, "Look upon us and listen, " (TMQ 2:104).** The same applies to the command concerning changing the *qiblah* direction.

The Jews used to face Jerusalem in their prayers. Thus, Muslims were commanded to be different from them by facing the Ka'ba when praying. How could Allah entrust a certain *Ummah* of being in charge of leading mankind while it was imitating others? How could both, the leader and those who followed him, equally lead mankind? This necessitated a command that would clearly distinguish Muslims from the other nations; the change of the *qiblah* direction. Hence, after Allah framed a methodology for Muslims, His first command to them was to be a distinguished and unique *Ummah* and to never imitate and follow other nations.

Moderate distinction

The second *hizb* of the second *juzu* starts with the following ayah in which Allah says what can be translated as, **"Surely, As-safa and Al-Marwah (i.e. two hills near the Ka'bah) are among the way marks of Allah. So whoever makes the Pilgrimage (i.e. Hajj) to the Home, or makes the Visitation, (Umrah, sometimes called the minor pilgrimage) then there is no fault in him to circumambulate them (*As-Safa* and *Al-Marwah*)…" (TMQ 2:158)**

Some people might think that the ayah means that *tawaf* between As-Safa and Al-Marwah (circumambulation of the Ka'ba) is an optional ritual in *hajj* (pilgrimage). However, knowing the reason behind the revelation of this ayah is very important. The polytheists used to circumambulate the two mounts of As-Safa and Al-Marwah They used to place two idols, Asaf and Na'ilah, atop the two mounts and circumambulate them. Hence, when the Prophet's companions were commanded to be distinguishable, by changing the terms they were using and the direction of the *qiblah*, they felt that their *tawaf* between As-Safa and Al-Marwah was contradicting with this command. Thus, the ayah was revealed to denote that not all the actions of the disbelievers were wrong. In fact, the origin of circumambulating the two mounts was a Divine decree and an act of following Prophet Ibrahim's footsteps. Accordingly, Muslims who are the true believers in Allah's Oneness and true followers of the Prophet *(SAWS*) have to be moderate in making this distinction.

This *hizb* includes an important ayah that brings forth before Muslims another rule of their methodology. Allah says what can be translated as, **"Thus We have made you [true Muslims - real believers of Islamic Monotheism, true followers of Prophet Muhammad and his *Sunnah* (legal ways)], a just (and the best) nation, that you be witnesses over mankind..." (TMQ 2:143).**

You belong to a remarkable *Ummah*. Imagine, you will bear witness over mankind. Have you realized the magnitude of the responsibility you will have to bear on the Day of Judgment?

Islam and the all-inclusive reform

The third *hizb* of the second *juzu* starts with a series of commands aiming at reforming all the aspects of life in the Islamic community. It starts with this ayah, in which Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"It is not *Al Birr* (benignancy) that you turn your faces around in the direction of East and West; but benignancy is (in him) who believes in Allah, and the Last Day, and the Angels, and the Book, and the Prophets, and brings wealth in spite of his love for it (Or: offers out of love for Him) to near kinsmen, and the orphans, and the indigent, and the wayfarer, and the beggars, and (to ransom) necks, (i.e. captives "slaves") and keeps up the prayer, and bring the Zakat, (i.e. pay the poor-dues) and they who fulfill their covenant when they have covenanted, and the patient (ones) in misery and tribulation, and while in violence; (i.e. during fighting) those are (they) who act sincerely, and those are they who are the pious. (TMQ 2:177).**

Muslim scholars say that this ayah includes all the aspects of Islam. It includes the tenets of faith (believing in Allah, His Angels and the Holy Qur'an), acts of worship (*salat* (performing the obligatory prayers) and *zakat* (giving in money for charity)), dealings (keeping one's promise) and manners.

Let us look together at the wonderful gradation of surat Al-Baqara:

1. The change of the *qiblah* direction (in order to achieve uniqueness): **"…So turn your face towards the Inviolable Mosque (*Al-Masjid-al-Haram* (at Makkah))..." (TMQ 2:144).**

2. Moderation in this distinction: **"…Surely, As-safa and Al-Marwah (i.e. two hills near the Ka'ba) are among the way marks of Allah. So whoever makes the Pilgrimage (i.e. Hajj) to the Home, or makes the Visitation, (Umrah, sometimes called the minor pilgrimage) then there is no fault in him to circumambulate them (*As-Safa* and *Al-Marwah*)..." (TMQ 2:158).**

3. Righteousness (i.e. piety and each and every act of obedience to Allah) does not solely mean obeying the command of changing the *qiblah* - as indicated in **"It is not *Al-Birr* (piety, righteousness, and each and every act of obedience to Allah, etc.) that you turn your faces towards east and (or) west (in prayers)…" (TMQ 2:177).**

Hence, after making obedience and the Muslims' uniqueness deep-rooted concepts in the companions' hearts in the first *hizb* of the second *juzu*, Allah showed them that it was not a matter of *qiblah* but an all-inclusive reform. When Allah (*SWT*) commanded the Muslims to change the *qiblah* towards the Ka'ba, it was just a test of obedience and a command of distinction. The real objective was to perform all the acts of righteousness mentioned in the above ayah.

The language of comprehensive reform

Starting from the third *hizb* of the second *juzu*, a series of commands and prohibitions are listed to frame a comprehensive way of life for the Islamic *Ummah*:

Penal codes as indicated in the following two ayahs:

- **"O you who have believed, prescribed for you is retaliation concerning (the ones) killed:..." (TMQ 2:178).**

- **"And in retaliation there is life for you, O (men) endowed with intellects" (TMQ 2:179).**

Inheritance law in Islam as indicated in the following ayah:

- **"Prescribed for you, when death is present to any of you, in case he leaves behind some charitable (benefit), is to make testament to parents and nearest kin, with beneficence-truly (binding) on the pious."(TMQ 2:180).**

Religious legislation as indicated in the following ayah:

- **"O you who have believed, prescribed for you is the Fast, as it was prescribed for (the ones) who were before you, that possibly you would be pious**."**(TMQ 2:183).**

Piety is the guiding light

Obviously all the rules mentioned mainly focus on the believers' fear of Allah. This is conspicuous in the following ayah of *Al-Qisas*, **"And in Law of Equality (*qisas*) there is life for you, O (men) endowed with intellects, that possibly you would be pious."(TMQ 2:179).**

It is also explicit in the ayahs describing the rules of inheritance in Islam**, "Prescribed for you, when death is present to any of you, in case he leaves behind some charitable (benefit), is to make testament to parents and nearest kin, with beneficence-truly (binding) on the pious." (TMQ 2:180).**

Piety is also emphasized in the ayahs prescribing fasting, **"O you who have believed, prescribed for you is the Fast, as it was prescribed for (the ones) who were before you, that possibly you would be pious." (TMQ 2:183).**

It is emphasized again by the end of fasting rules, **"Thus Allah makes His signs evident to mankind, that possibly they would be pious." (TMQ 2:187).**

Allah's methodology will be adopted only by the pious believers, marked for their uniqueness and piety; people who want to earn Allah's satisfaction. These three pivots are shields preserving this methodology. They are coherently presented in a unique way, completely different from man's way of presenting and explaining things.

As you examine the surah more and more, you discover the thorough aspects of Allah's methodology. The Holy Qur'an first deals with the penal code, then moves to the religious legislation. Some people might wonder about the relationship between the two legislations. Actually, presenting unrelated topics subsequently in the Holy Qur'an indicates that Islam holds them all. Acts of worship are inseparable from the other rules legislated in Islam. This fact emphasizes the thoroughness of Allah's methodology and its inclusion of all aspects of life.

The impregnable shields of Islam

The fourth section deals with the legislation of fighting in the way of Allah and rules of *Jihad.*

Allah says what can be translated as, **"And fight in the way of Allah the ones who fight you, but do not transgress; surely Allah does not love the transgressors. And kill them wherever you catch them, and drive them out from where they drove you out…" (TMQ 2:190 - 191)**.

The ayahs emphasize the inevitability of *Jihad* to preserve Allah's methodology and stress on the necessity of spending money on *Jihad* (i.e. in the cause of Allah) **" And expend in the way of Allah; and do not cast (yourselves) by your (own) hands into perdition (i.e., by neglecting to expend in the way of Allah,), (TMQ 2:195).**

This methodology requires fighting (in the way of Allah) in order to protect Islam from its enemies and foes who hinder its progress; it is not a form of terrorism and bloodshed. There is a general rule in the Holy Qur'an; whenever *jihad* is mentioned, its regulations are explained as well. For example, the command of *jihad* in ayah 190 is directed against the transgressors only. The ayah also clarifies the ethics of *jihad* through prohibiting transgression.

Al-Hajj (a spiritual gas station)

The ayahs then move on to the rules of *hajj*.

Why is *hajj* mentioned immediately after talking about *jihad*?

In fact, *hajj* is the first practical symbol of *jihad.* Thus, by performing *hajj*, Allah *(SWT)* gives the Muslims a chance to practice *jihad* and change their bad habits (through psychological, physical and spiritual preparation). Notice how coherent and closely-linked the ayahs are, although they deal with various topics!

This brings to mind the supplication of Prophet Ibrahim at the end of the first *juzu.* This supplication is mentioned in the following ayah in which Allah says what can be translated as, **"…Our Lord! And make us submissive unto You and of our offspring a nation submissive unto You, and show us our *Manasik*[15] (all the ceremonies of pilgrimage – *Hajj* and *'Umrah*), and accept our repentance..." (TMQ 2:128).**

Hence, Allah revealed the ayahs (196 – 200), which elaborate on the rules of *hajj*, as an answer to the supplication of Prophet Ibrahim in ayah 128. Allah says what can be translated as, **"And perfect the Pilgrimage and the Visitation (to Makkah) to Allah; yet in case you are detained, then (make) whatever offering is the easiest, and do not shave your heads until the offering reaches its lawful destination. So whoever of you is sick or is hurt in his head, then (make) a ransom by fast or donation, or ritual (sacrifice). Yet, when you are secure, so whoever enjoys the Visitation until the Pilgrimage, then (make) whatever is easiest of offering. Yet, whoever does not find (any offering), then (make) a fast of three days in the Pilgrimage, and seven when you return, that is ten completely; that is for him whose family are not present (i.e. those who do not live in the vicinity of Makkah) at the Inviolable Mosque; and be pious to Allah, and know that Allah is strict in punishment. The Pilgrimage is (in) months well-known; so, whoever ordains (upon himself) the Pilgrimage in them, then there shall be no lying with (womenfolk), nor evident immorality, nor disputing in the Pilgrimage. And whatever charity you perform, Allah knows it. And sustain yourselves; so, the most charitable sustenance is piety; and be pious to Me, O (you) endowed with intellects! It is no fault in you that you constantly seek Grace from your Lord; so when you press on from Arafat, then remember Allah at the Inviolable Emblem, and remember Him as He has guided you, and decidedly you were even before it (i.e. before …Islam) indeed of the erring. Thereafter, press on from where the multitude (Literally: mankind) press on, and ask for forgiveness from Allah; surely Allah is Ever-Forgiving, Ever-Merciful. So, when you have accomplished your (holy) rituals, then remember Allah like the remembrance of your fathers (The pagan Arabs used to praise their forefathers at the conclusion of the pilgrimage) or (even) with stronger fervour in remembrance. So, of mankind (there are) some who say, "Our Lord, bring us (provision) in the present (life)," and in no way does he have any share in the Hereafter. (TMQ 2:196-200).**

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[15] *Manasik*: i.e. *Ihram*; *Tawaf* of the *Ka'bah*; *Say* of *As-Safa* and *Al-Marwah*; stay at *'Arafat*, *Muzdalifah* and *Mina*; *Ramy* of *Jamarat*; slaughtering of *Hady* (animal), etc.

The pillars of Islam

Unlike the other surahs in the Holy Qur'an, surat Al-Baqara details and includes the five pillars of Islam. The rules of fasting are only mentioned in surat Al-Baqara. The rules of *hajj* and those of spending money in the cause of Allah are only detailed in this surah. This same surah also mentions that Islam is not based on usury but on *zakat*. The first ayahs of the surah refer to the first pillar of Islam - the *Shahadah* (declaration of faith). Allah says what can be translated as, **"…Who believe in the Unseen" (TMQ 2:3).**

The next pillar - *Salat* - is considered the supporting shield of Islam. The subject of *salat* is repeated quiet often in several ayahs. Allah says what can be translated as, **"And keep up the prayer and bring the Zakat (i.e., pay the obligatory poor-dues) …" (TMQ 2:43)**.

Allah also says what can be translated as, **"Preserve (constantly) (i.e., observe strictly) the prayers, and the middle prayer, and rise up devoutly to Allah." (TMQ 2:238)** . The *asr* prayer has been designated in this ayah because of its great significance. It is worth mentioning that it is the only ayah in the Holy Qur'an that refers to this prayer.

Enter perfectly in Islam

Having shown different rules, a pivotal ayah is revealed. Allah says what can be translated as**, "O you who have believed, enter into peacefulness, the whole (of it), and do not ever follow the steps of As-shaytan; (The all-vicious, i.e., the Devil) surely he is an evident enemy to you. "(TMQ 2:208).**

In this ayah, Allah ordains the believers to act according to the comprehensive meaning of Islam. Islam represents all the aspects of the methodology, which Allah has framed for Muslims. The previous ayahs have shown the aspects of this methodology. These aspects include acts of worship, penal codes, laws of inheritance, *Jihad*, rules of *hajj,* and spending money in the cause of Allah. This ayah comes in this particular context to command the people to embrace Islam as a whole and adhere to all its rules. It also warns them against acting in accordance to some of these rules and ignoring others, as the Jews did. Allah says what can be translated as, **"Do you then believe in some (parts) of the Book and disbelieve in other parts?" (TMQ 2:85).**

Hence, the ayah aims to put the Islamic *Ummah* on alert, for Muslims should embrace Islam in the most perfect and appropriate way. Muslims are not allowed to accept some Islamic regulations and refuse others. This reminds us of the Muslim woman who observes her prayers but refuses to put on the veil, or the Muslims (whether men or women) who perform *qiyam* (night prayers) and yet harm their neighbours.

Completing the methodology: The family rules

Over two *hizbs* of the second *juzu*, the rules tackling family life, marriage, divorce, suckling, and engagement are detailed. Some may ask why such rules are delayed

until the end of the surah. Why not in the beginning? The surah appropriately starts with orders issued to the believers to obey Allah, be pious, observe fasting, and perform *hajj*. All these means are necessary prerequisites for preparing a good Muslim for the difficult task of building a family. Millions of religious regulations and provisions might fail to reform and ameliorate the behavior of a person who goes astray from the straight path. Hence, many ayahs of these two quarters (*hizbs*) end as reminders of your fear of Allah and that He is All-Aware and All-Watchful over everything.

This is indicated in the following ayahs, in which Allah says what can be translated as**:**

- "…**And be pious to Allah, and know that Allah is Ever-Knowing of everything." (TMQ 2:231).**
- "…**and be pious to Allah and know that Allah is Ever-Beholding of whatever you do. " (TMQ 2:233).**
- **"…And Allah is Ever-Cognizant of whatever you do." (TMQ 2:234).**
- **"…And in case you divorce them even before you have touched them, and you have already ordained for them a marriage-portion, (Literally: an ordinance) then (give her) one half of what you have ordained except (in case) the (women) remit, or he in whose hand is the knot of marriage remits; (and) that you remit is nearer to piety. …" (TMQ 2:237).**
- **"And for the divorced women (there shall be) (the necessary) enjoyment with beneficence, truly (binding) on the pious." (TMQ 2:241).**

As piety envelops the family rules, both the ethical and practical disciplines in Islam are closely related.

Who will remain firm until the end?

The story of the war that took place between Jalut (Goliath) and Talut (Saul) is mentioned in the ayahs from 246 to 252. This story is about two groups of people from among the Israelites. The first group succeeded in leading mankind, while the other failed to fulfill the same mission for several reasons. The failed group turned away from Allah's commands, abstained from fighting, disobeyed their Prophet, failed in the trial of drinking from the river, and took materialistic measures as their criteria to estimate victory and defeat. In short, this story illustrates a battle in which one party had two groups of people; one was afraid of engaging in the battle against the enemy, while the other dared to confront the enemy. The story aims at asserting the point that fighting is necessary for protecting Allah's methodology. It also proves that the cowards will never be able to take charge of earth and lead mankind.

The following ayahs describe this story, Allah says what can be translated as, **"Have you not regarded the chiefs of the Seeds (Or: sons) of Israel) even after Mûsa, (Moses) as they said to a Prophet of theirs, "Send forth for us a king, (so that) we would fight in the way of Allah." He said," Might it be that in case fighting is prescribed for you, you would not fight?" They said, "How is it that we would not fight in the way of Allah, and we have already been driven out of our residences and sons?" Yet, when fighting was prescribed for them, they turned**

away, except a few of them; and Allah is Ever-Knowing of the unjust. And their Prophet said to them, "Surely Allah has already sent forth Talût (Saul) for you as a king." They said, "However could he have kingship over us, and we have truer (right) than he of kingship, and he has not been brought affluence of wealth?" He said, "Surely Allah has elected him above you and has increased him sizably in knowledge (Literally: an outspreading of knowledge) and figure." And Allah brings (forth) His kingship to whomever He decides, and Allah is Ever- Embracing, Ever-Knowing. And their Prophet said to them, "Surely the sign of his kingship is that the coffer (In earlier Scriptures it is said to be the "Ark", and Serenity is said to be "Shechina") will come up to you; in it (are) a Serenity from your Lord, and a remnant of what the house of Mûsa (Moses) and the house of Harûn (Aaron) left (behind), the Angels carrying it. Surely in that is indeed a sign for you, in case you are believers". Then as soon as Talût (Saul) departed with the hosts, he said, "Surely Allah will be trying you with a river; so whoever drinks of it, then he is not of me, and whoever does not taste (Literally: does not feed on it) it, then surely he is of me, excepting him who scoops up (a scoop) with his hand." Then they drank of it except a few of them. Then, as soon as he passed over it, he and the ones who believed with him, they said, "We have no capability today against Jalût (Goliath) and his hosts." (But) the ones who expect that they will be meeting Allah said, "How often a little community has overcome a much (larger) community by the permission of Allah; and Allah is with the patient." And as soon as they went forth against Jalût (Goliath) and his hosts, they said, "Our Lord, pour out upon us patience, and make firm our feet, and give us victory over the disbelieving people!" So they routed them, by the permission of Allah, and Dawûd (David) killed Jalût; (Goliath) and Allah brought him the kingship, and (the) Wisdom, and He taught him (part of) whatever (knowledge) He decides. And had it not been for the repelling by Allah of mankind, some by means of others, (Literally: by means of some) the earth would indeed have corrupted; but Allah is The Owner of Grace over the worlds. Those are the signs of Allah. We recite them to you with the Truth, and surely you are indeed (one) of the Emissaries. (TMQ 2:246 - 252).

Ayat Al-Kursi: Allah's Omnipotence and Greatness

Now, we come to the greatest ayah in the Holy Qur'an, *ayat* Al-Kursi. This ayah describes Allah (*SWT*) in the most appropriate and wondrous way ever known to humanity since the dawn of history.

Allah says what can be translated as, **"Allah. There is no god except He, The Ever-Living, The Superb Upright Sustainer. Slumber does not overtake Him, nor sleep; to Him (belongs) whatever is in the heavens and whatever is in the earth. Who is there that intercedes for His Providence except by His Permission? He knows whatever is in front of them (Literally: between their hands) and whatever is behind them, and they do not encompass anything of His Knowledge except whatever He has decided. His Chair embraces the heavens and the earth; the preserving of them (Literally: them both) does not tire Him; and He is The Ever-Exalted, The Ever-Magnificent.." (TMQ 2:255).**

The ayah that follows *ayat Al-Kursi* has certain significance. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"There is no compulsion in the religion; right-mindedness**

has already been evidently (distinct) from misguidance" (TMQ 2:256) *Ayat Al-Kursi* acts as evidence to mankind, that Allah exists (and He is the Self-Existent) and that we all have to believe in Him. Thus, whoever prefers disbelief must not be compelled to embrace Islam.

As Muslims are acting in accordance to that methodology, they need an assurance that this methodology is indeed framed by Allah, Who protects those who apply His rules. This is why *ayat Al-Kursi* comes in the middle of the discussion about this methodology. Allah says what can be translated as, **"Allah is The Ever-Patronizing Patron of (the ones) who have believed. He brings them out of the (depths of) darkness into the light." (TMQ 2:257).**

Evidences and proofs

Ayat Al-Kursi is followed by three stories demonstrating daily examples in life. The first story is about Prophet Ibrahim (*AS*) with An-Namrud (Nimrod). Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"As' Ibrahîm said, "My Lord is He Who gives life and makes to die," he said, "I give life and make to die." Ibrahîm said, "Yet surely Allah comes up with (i.e., brings) the sun from the East, so come up with (i.e., bring) it from the West." Then the one who disbelieved was confounded; and Allah does not guide the unjust people. (TMQ 2:258).**

The second story is about Uzair (Ezra). Allah says what can be translated as, **"Or (such as) he who passed by a town, and it was completely devastated upon its trellises. He said, "However will Allah give life to this (town) after its death?" So Allah made him die a hundred seasons; (i.e., years) thereafter He made him rise again. (TMQ 2:259).**

The third story describes how the dead are brought back to life. Allah commanded Ibrahim to take four birds, slaughter them then cut them into pieces and put a portion of them on every hill. Ibrahim would then call them and they would come to him in haste restored to their original state. Allah says what can be translated as, **"And as Ibrahîm (Abraham) said, "Lord! Show me how You give life to the dead." He Allah) said, "And have you not believed?" He (Ibrahîm) said, "Yes indeed, but that my heart be composed." Said He, "So take four of the birds, then wring them to you (and divide them); thereafter set a portion of them on every mountain; thereafter call them; they will come up to you with hasty diligence (and) know that Allah is Ever-Mighty, Ever-Wise." (TMQ 2:260).**

These stories assert Allah's Omnipotent power to give life and cause death. Allah says what can be translated **as**, **"Allah. There is no god except He, The Ever-Living, The Superb Upright Sustainer." (TMQ 2:255)** Hence, *Ayat Al-Kursi* follows the ayahs tackling the methodology to strengthen Muslims' faith and increase their trust in Allah. Consequently, it will help them bear the heavy-laden tasks of this methodology.

The financial economic system

The ayahs show the last aspects of the divine methodology: the economic system in Islam. The Islamic economy is based on money investment, not on usury. The following ayahs warn against usury:

- **"Allah expunges riba (Interest or other unlawful) and He augments donations, and Allah does not love every most disbelieving most-vicious person. (TMQ 2:276)**

- **"O you who have believed, be pious to Allah and leave behind what remains of rib'a, in case you are believers. So, in case you do not perform (that), then take notice of a war from Allah and His Messenger (against you). And in case you repent, then you will have the capitals of your riches; you will not do injustice, and you will not be done injustice." (TMQ 2:278 - 279).**

Now, we come to the longest ayah in the Holy Qur'an, the ayah tackling debts. To assert authentication in dealings, this ayah deals with issues of debts and how contracting a debt should be written down. Allah says what can be translated as, **"O you who have believed, when you contract (i.e. when you have or contract a debt) a debt one upon another for a stated term, then write it down …" (TMQ 2:282).** This ayah comes after the story of Ibrahim when he asked Allah *(SWT*) to bring before him evidence that would consolidate his belief. Allah says what can be translated as, **"Lord! Show me how You give life to the dead." (TMQ 2:260).** Hence, the two ayahs suggest that certitude is necessary for Muslims in all aspects of their lives. Noticeably, the ayahs dealing with usury are mentioned among the ayahs dealing with spending money and investing to show that Islam offers a better alternative for any forbidden act.

Surat Al-Baqara: The sign of Imamate

Having tackled surat Al-Baqara and displayed its inclusiveness of all rules of Islam, we realize why Prophet Muhammad (*SAWS*) used to make anyone who learnt this surah by heart in charge of other people. Such a person would be cognizant of all aspects of the methodology Allah has framed for Muslims. This comprehensive methodology is represented by the Straight Path in surat Al-Fatiha and *Al-Aqidah* (creed) in *ayat* Al-Kursi. Moreover, it involves worship and dealings. Worship is indicated by the rules of fasting and *hajj*. Dealings are indicated by the rules dealing with spending money, writing down debts, and prohibiting usury. There are also the rules concerning *jihad*. These aspects are comprised in three pivots: obedience, moderate distinction (i.e. uniqueness), and piety.

Conclusion: We hear and we obey

The surah is concluded by two ayahs. They are regarded as a treasure endowed to the *alamin* from under the Divine Throne. Allah praises the believers in these ayahs. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as**, "….And they have said, "We have heard, and we have obeyed. Grant (us) Your All-Supreme forgiveness, our Lord, and to You is the Destiny." (TMQ 2:285)** The Israelites said that they heard Allah's commandments and disobeyed as indicated in, **"…They said, "We have heard, and**

we disobey." (TMQ 2:93) The Islamic *Ummah*, in contrast, raises the motto of **"We hear, and we obey"** to remain in charge of mankind.

It is followed by a supplication. Allah says what can be translated as**, "Allah does not charge a self (anything) except its capacity; it has whatever it has earned, and against it is whatever it has acquired. Our Lord, do not take us to task in case we forget or we make mistakes. Our Lord, and do not burden us with an obligation as You burdened (the ones) who were before us. Our Lord, and do not over-burden us with whatever is beyond our capability. And be clement towards us, and forgive us, and have mercy on us. You are our Supreme Patronizer, so give us victory over the disbelieving people."(TMQ 2:286).**

As man goes on in life trying to act in accordance with this methodology, he might commit sins and be unable to remain firm. Going back to the Straight Path is guidance from Allah. Therefore, the Muslims need Allah's help to pardon them and grant them forgiveness and mercy. If a Muslim fights those opposed to Allah's *Shariah* and their supporters, he has to ask Allah to grant him victory over the disbelievers. Allah indeed has answered such supplication by saying **"I did".**

Surat Al-Imran (The Family of Imran)

Surat Al-Imran was revealed in Madinah after surat Al-Anfal. It has 200 ayahs (verses) and falls in order after surat Al-Baqara in the Qur'an.

Its relation to surat Al-Baqara

Surat Al-Imran is the sister of surat Al-Baqara, attributed to the Ahadith (sayings) of the Prophet (*SAWS*). They are called "the two bright ones" in his Hadith, "Recite the two bright ones, Al-Baqara and surat Al-Imran."[16].

There is great similarity between them as they both start with **Alif-Lâm-Mîm** [These letters are one of the miracles of the Qur'an and none but Allah (Alone) knows their meanings). Moreover, they both end with a *dua'a* (supplication). It is indeed from the graces of the Qur'an that the first three surahs end with a *dua'a*:

- Al Fatiha → **"Guide us in the straight Path", (TMQ, 1:5).**
- Al-Baqara → **"…Our Lord, do not take us to task in case we forget or we make mistakes …", (TMQ, 2:286).**
- Al-Imran → **"… Our Lord, so forgive us our guilty (deeds), and expiate for us our odious deeds …)", (TMQ, 3:193).**

This is a reference to the importance of *dua'a* for a Muslim, in which he would always seek refuge.

Inspirations from the letters (Alif-Lâm-Mîm)

Perhaps one of the most important similarities between surat Al-Imran and surat Al-Baqara is that both commence with the separate letters **Alif-Lâm-Mîm**; a reference to the fact that each ayah in both surahs contains those three letters. There are many ayahs in the Qur'an that begin with separate letters (such as **Alif-Lâm-Mîm** or **Hâ-Mîm**), as if they are a key to accessing the meanings of the surahs. Another noteworthy remark is that all surahs that start with the same letters are connected in their objectives and meanings.

Some may wonder about the intent behind starting some surahs with these letters. In fact many scholars have several different interpretations regarding this matter. To simplify the subject matter and bring it closer to the mind, we can say that these letters come at the beginning of the surahs to challenge the disbelievers. It is as if Allah (*SWT*) says to the disbelievers: Are those letters not of your language? Are they not your primary substance to form a speech? Are you capable of using them to come up with something similar to the Qur'an?

Human beings may be able to build computers and cars from matter and atoms, however they cannot breathe life into them. Similarly, these letters could be used in prose and poems, but could people ever come up with a lively Qur'an? Allah says what can be translated as, **"And thus We have revealed to you a Spirit of Our Command …" (TMQ, 42:52).**

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[16] Authentic, Muslim.

Therefore, most of the surahs that start with the separate letters are followed by a glorification of the Qur'an, the revelation, or the *dhikr* (the mentioning of Allah).

Perseverance of principle

The objective that this surah revolves around is tightly related to that of surat Al-Baqara. The latter informs the Muslims that they are responsible for earth and demonstrates the methodology of succession. Surat Al-Imran emphasizes on the importance of perseverance on the methodology. Many people, after reading and starting to assume their responsibility, go off track and fall off the wagon; they go astray from the straight path, like he who devotes himself to worship in Ramadan then closes the doors of obedience and worship once it is over.

The surah speaks to those who have been pious for over 20 years and reinforces them in their faith, as well as the youth who just started to become devout. It urges both to be steadfast in their commitment to their religion in order to realize the methodology of succession of Muslims on earth.

How to preserve on the truth?

To answer this question we have to know how people get off track in the first place. People get misled either by concepts that muddle their beliefs or distractions amid their busy life, which weakens their determination. Consequently, deterioration is caused by concepts (internal) or actions (external). Therefore, the surah incites the believers to persevere in both fields and warns them against what might lead them astray.

Therefore, the surah is divided into two parts:

1) **The first part: The ayahs (1-120)**
   Staying steadfast with the concept of the straight path in facing external influences, through the talk about the People of the Scripture and the dialogue with them, which is the first dialogue between the creeds in the Qur'an.

2) **The second part: the ayahs (120-200)**
   Talks about staying steadfast in actions facing internal influences with reference to the battle of *Uhud*, which is an example of the mistakes that happen and the way to prevent them.

The surah starts with the exterior; it prepares the surrounding environment for the Muslim, and then starts dealing with the interior. The surah discusses these two core ideas through the commentary on two incidents that happened during the time of the Prophet (*SAWS*):

- The first incident: The meeting that took place between the Prophet (*SAWS*) and the delegation of the Christians of *Najran* (name of tribe). They were guests in the *Nabawi* mosque where the Prophet (*SAWS*) conversed with them for three days.

- The second incident: The battle of *Uhud* and the Muslims' defeat by the polytheists. Eighty ayahs commented on that incident since most of the believers were not steadfast in that battle and did not follow the orders of their Prophet (*SAWS*), especially the shooters.

In spite of the fact that these verses comment on incidents that took place over 1400 years ago, the surah still addresses Muslims throughout the ages teaching them how to remain steadfast, both externally and internally, in their thoughts and actions.

From the beginning until the end

The surah starts with what helps the Muslims remain steadfast, and ends with what reinforces them on the right track.
Read at the beginning of the surah, Allah says what can be translated as, **"Alif, Lam, Mîm. (These are three letters of the Arabic alphabet and only Allah Knows their meaning here), Allah, there is no god except He, The Ever-Living, The Superb Upright Sustainer, He has been sending down upon you the Book with the Truth, sincerely (verifying) what was before it (Literally: between its two hands)…) ", (TMQ, 3:1-3).**

For your divinity is one god, Allah (*SWT*), and only He will help you remain steadfast. The Qur'an is the truth and your pathway for perseverance on this religion.

In the last ayah, Allah says what can be translated as, **"O you who have believed, be patient, and vie in patience, and be garrisoned (i.e., Keep a standing army ready to defend you) and be pious to Allah, that possibly you would prosper", (TMQ, 3:200).**

We are asked to be patient and to help others be patient. We are asked to remain on guard and be prepared to face and fend off any danger coming from the outside, be it an army, a misleading thought, or mere suspicion.

The mention of the Qur'an as a factor for perseverance is repeated numerous times in the surah.

For example, ayah (7) comes to clarify the following: Allah says what can be translated as, **"He is The (One) Who has sent down upon you the Book, whereof are clear signs (i.e.** ayah **= verse) that are the Essence (Literally: the Mother) of the Book, and others co similar (Or: ambiguous). So, as for (the ones) in whose hearts is swerving, they ever follow whatever (parts) of it are co similar, (inequitably) seeking temptation (to sedition), and (inequitably) seeking its interpretation; and in no way does anyone know its interpretation except Allah. And the ones firmly established in knowledge say, "We have believed in it; all is from the Providence of our Lord." And in no way does anyone constantly remember except the ones endowed with intellects", (TMQ, 3:7).**

Thus, an accurate understanding of the Qur'an is one of the most important fundamentals for mental perseverance. Many people may stray off the right track and fall into delusory. They follow what is seemingly similar in the Qur'an without

having any awareness of the true context. The message delivered in the surah is to warn us against such delusions.

Thus, people have to be firmly equipped with knowledge. They also have to make the *dua'a* of perseverance, Allah says what can be translated as, **"Our Lord, make not our hearts to swerve after that You have guided us, and bestow upon us mercy from very close to You. You, Ever You, are The One Who is The Superb Bestower", (TMQ, 3:8).**

Ayahs that call for perseverance

There are numerous ayahs that call for perseverance in this surah. At one point, this is done by reminding us of those believers who persevered when confronting the enemy.

In the discourse about the battle of *Badr*, Allah says what can be translated as, **"There has already been a sign for you in the two communities that encountered, (The reference is to the Battle of Badr) one community fighting in the way of Allah and another disbelieving. They saw them twice the like of them, as the eye sees, (Literally: as the sight of the eye) and Allah aids with His victory whomever He decides. Surely in that is indeed a lesson for the ones endowed with beholding. (Literally: eyesight)", (TMQ, 3:13).**

At another point, the surah reminds us of when *Al-Hawâriyyûn* (the disciples) were determined to support the religion of Allah (*SWT*) and believed in it. Allah says what can be translated as, **"So, as soon as *Isa* (Jesus) perceived disbelief among them, he said, "Who are my ready vindicators to Allah?" (i.e., in the cause of Allah) The Disciples said," We are the ready vindicators to Allah; we have believed in Allah, and bear (you) witness that we are Muslims", (TMQ, 3:52).**

Speaking of the past nations, Allah (*SWT*) reminds us of the era of the Prophets and their perseverance to serve Islam, Allah says what can be translated as, **"And as Allah took compact with the Prophets (that), "Indeed, whatever I bring you of Book and Wisdom, thereafter a Messenger comes to you sincerely verifying what is with you, indeed you shall definitely believe in him, and indeed you shall definitely vindicate him …", (TMQ, 3:81).**

Moreover, in surat Al-Imran you find ayahs that prompt piety and steadfastness on the right path until death. Allah says what can be translated as, **"O you have believed, be pious to Allah with His true piety, and definitely do not die except as Muslims", (TMQ, 3:102).**

The message is: Beware of dying without being a Muslim.

The probable question here is how can one guarantee that when one does not know when he will die? The answer is to be pious to Allah (*SWT*), observe your duty, and be obedient to His commands. Subsequently, you will be guaranteed a fine ending Insha' Allah (God willing).

In the ayah that directly follows, Allah says what can be translated as, **"And adhere firmly to the Rope (i.e. the Covenant of Allah=the Qur'an) of Allah, altogether,**

and do not be disunited …" (TMQ, 3:103). Consequently, if you want to persevere on the right path, adhere to the Qur'an, surround yourself with the pious and righteous people, and beware of conflicts, Allah says what can be translated as, **"And do not be as the ones who were disunited and differed (among themselves), even after the supreme evidences came to them …" (TMQ, 3:105).**

The ayahs continue to motivate perseverance in different situations; speculate with me what Allah (*SWT*) says about perseverance when meeting the enemy, Allah says what can be translated as, **"And similarly many a Prophet there has been along with whom myriads manifold have fought; so in no way did they feel feeble for whatever afflicted them in the way of Allah, and in no way did they weaken, and in no way did they yield themselves; and Allah loves the patient" (TMQ, 3:146).**

Furthermore, ponder what Allah says that can be translated as, **"Surely the multitude have already gathered against you, so be apprehensive of them." Yet, it increased them in belief, and they said, "Allah is The Reckoner enough for us, and how excellent is The Ever-Trusted Trustee! So they turned over (Or: turned around) with favor from Allah and (His) Grace; no odious (disadvantage) did touch them; and they followed closely the all-blessed Satisfaction of Allah; and Allah is The Owner of magnificent Grace", (TMQ, 3:173-174).**

Numerous ayahs inspire Muslims to be persistent, unwavering, and not to wane under any circumstance. Since perseverance is a momentous and fateful issue, the surah warns us against elements that shake the faith of the believer and weaken his persistence.

Obstacles of perseverance: (Lusts and Sins)

In the beginning of the surah, Allah says what can be translated as, **"Adorned for mankind is the love of lusts, for women and seeds, (Or: sons) and heaped-up, heaps (Literally: "arched" hoarded cantars) of gold and silver, and horses of mark, and cattle and tillage. That is the enjoyment (Literally: the belongings) of the present life; (Literally: the lowly life, i.e., the life of this world) and Allah has in His Providence the fairest resorting", (TMQ, 3:14).**

Therefore, getting attached to life's transient wares and its fleeting pleasures are dangerous factors that run against the nation's perseverance. Allah says what can be translated as, **"Surely the ones of you who turned away the day the two gatherings encountered, surely it was only that Ash-shaytan (The ever-vicious, i.e., the Devil) made them slide back for some of that which they had earned …" (TMQ, 3:155).**

This ayah explains that some of the companions, who turned back in the battle of *Uhud*, had sins in the past by which *Iblis* (Satan) tripped them and shook their perseverance.
Another ayah holds the same concept, Allah says what can be translated as, **"And is it that as soon as an affliction befell (Literally: afflicted) you, (and) you had already afflicted (i.e. afflicted) twice over the like of it, did you say, "However is this?" Say, "It is from your own selves …" (TMQ, 3:165).**

The solution: (Repentance)

Thus the ayahs that encourage hastening to repentance are repeated in the surah. Allah says what can be translated as, **"Who say, "Our Lord, surely we (ourselves) have believed, so forgive us our guilty (deeds), and protect us from the torment of the Fire", (TMQ, 3:16) and "Except for the ones who repent even after that and act righteously; (only) then, surely Allah is Ever-Forgiving, Ever-Merciful", (TMQ, 3:89).**

Then comes this ayah, Allah says what can be translated as, **"And vie swiftly with one another for forgiveness from your Lord and for a Garden whose breadth is the heavens and the earth, prepared for the pious" (TMQ, 3:133).**

Let this ayah be a motto for the youth that commit sins, to hasten for repentance and ask for forgiveness, so that we could maintain our steadfastness and guarantee Paradise that is as wide as the heavens and earth.

It has become very clear, so far, that perseverance on the right track is an essential and crucial issue, and that the obstacles to maintaining it are numerous. This leads to the following important question: What are the factors that help us sustain perseverance on the right track?

The surah focused on five elements that serve that purpose:

1- Turning to Allah (*SWT*)

Perseverance is a blessing from Allah (*SWT*) and He is the Omnipotent Who enables us to persist on his method. That is why the surah encourages making *dua'a* to Allah (*SWT*) from the start.

Allah says what can be translated as, **"Our Lord, make not our hearts to swerve after that You have guided us, and bestow upon us mercy from very close to You. You, Ever You, are The One Who is The Superb Bestower" (TMQ, 3:8);**

"Our Lord, surely You will be gathering mankind for a Day, (and) there is no suspicion about it; surely Allah will not fail the promised (Appointment)", (TMQ, 3:9);

"Say, "O Allah, (The Arabic word has the supplication suffix umma) Possessor of the Kingship, You bring the kingship to whomever You decide, and You draw (Literally: pluck out) the kingship from whomever You decide, and You render mighty whomever You decide, and You humiliate whomever You decide. In Your Hand is (the) Charity; (i.e., the choicest) surely You are Ever-Determiner over everything", (TMQ, 3:26).

The Qur'an continues by giving glowing examples to depict how people took refuge in Allah (*SWT*).

We see the wife of '*Imran* making *dua'a* to Allah (*SWT*); Allah says what can be translated as, **"…Lord! Surely I have vowed to you what is in my belly in dedication …" (TMQ, 3:35).**

Likewise, *Zakariya* (*AS*) "Zachariah" made the *dua'a*, Allah says what can be translated as, **"Thereover Zakariyya (Zechariah) invoked his Lord (and) said, "Lord! Bestow upon me from very close to You a goodly offspring …" (TMQ, 3:38).**

The ayahs go on in the surah to encourage and entice making *dua'a*.

Of the *dua'a* of the past nations in steadfastness when meeting the enemies, Allah says what can be translated as, **"And in no way was their saying anything except that they said, "Our Lord, forgive us our guilty (deeds), and our extravagance in our Command, (Your Command to us) and make firm our feet, and vindicate us over the disbelieving people", (TMQ, 3:147).**

Also, this is the prayer of *'uli al-albab* (Men of Understanding), Allah says what can be translated as, **"Our Lord, surely we (ourselves) have heard a caller calling out to (us) to belief, "Believe in your Lord." So we have believed. Our Lord, so forgive us our guilty (deeds), and expiate for us our odious deeds, and take us to You with the ever benign (ones), Our Lord, and bring us what You have promised us by Your Messengers, and do not disgrace us on the Day of the Resurrection; surely You do not fail the Promised Appointment, Then their Lord responded to them, "I do not waste the deed of any doer among you, any male or female. The one of you is as the other (Literally: some of you from some others). So, the ones who emigrated, and were driven out of their residences, and were hurt in My way, and fought, and were killed, indeed I will definitely expiate them of their odious deeds, and indeed I will definitely cause them to enter Gardens from beneath which Rivers run." A requital from (the Providence of) Allah; and Allah has in His Providence the fairest requital", (TMQ, 3:193-195).**

2- Worshipping Allah (*SWT*)

About *Maryam* (*AS*) "Mary", Allah says what can be translated as, **"Whenever Zakariyya entered the Chamber to her... ", (TMQ, 3:37).**

Maryam (*AS*) lived in a sanctuary and devoted herself to prayers, and that was what *Zakariya* (*AS*) learned from her.

Therefore, when the angels called upon him to presage about *Yahya* (*AS*) (John) he was praying himself. Allah says what can be translated as, **"So, the Angels called out to him (as) he was upright praying in the Chamber …" (TMQ, 3:39).**

The atmosphere of worship is evident throughout the surah until the end, where Allah (*SWT*) describes the characteristics of the Men of Understanding

in what can be translated as, **"The ones who remember Allah, upright and seated and on their sides... ", (TMQ, 3:191).**

3- Da'wa (missionary activity) to Allah (*SWT*)

There is an area in the human brain called the contentment area, and there is a deeper and stronger area, that is of the identity and the sense of belonging**.**

In order to transfer a thought from the first to the latter we have to converse about it. A person could be certain about the concept of Islam; however, Islam has not become his identity. Therefore, in order to confirm the concept and actually belong to it, one has to talk about it excessively. That way, one could strengthen the idea and persist on it.

Exercising *da'wa* (missionary activity) is fundamental to perseverance, since the missionary usually is the first to hold on to the cause that he talks to people about.

Consequently, the surah contains many ayahs that encourage the believer to exercise *da'wa*, Allah says what can be translated as, **"And let (i.e. there shall indeed be. The Arabic is emphatic) there be a nation of you (who) call to charity, and command beneficence, and forbid malfeasance; and those are they (who are) the prosperous", (TMQ, 3:104);**

"You have been the most charitable nation brought out to mankind: you command beneficence, and forbid malfeasance, and believe in Allah. And if the population of the Book (Or: Family of the Book; i.e., the Jews and Christians) believed, it would indeed have been charitable for them; (some) of them are the believers, and the majority of them are the immoral", (TMQ, 3:110).

4- Having a clear goal:

Another critical factor of perseverance is having clear goals in one's life. Allah says what can be translated as, **"The ones who remember Allah, upright … "Our Lord, in no way have You created this untruthfully. All Extolment be to You! So protect us from the torment of the Fire", (TMQ, 3:191).**

Therefore, we have to understand that the universe has not immerged arbitrarily, but rather for a specific goal. The goal is to worship Allah (*SWT*), to know Him, and to be responsible for the earth (as explained in surat Al-Baqara).

5- Brotherhood:

Allah says what can be translated as, **"And adhere firmly to the Rope (i.e. the Covenant of Allah=the Qur'an) of Allah, altogether, and do not be disunited …" (TMQ, 3:103).**

Brotherhood for the sake of Allah (*SWT*) ensures righteous companionship for the believer, which is one of the most important blessings of Allah (*SWT*) on human beings. Allah says what can be translated as, **"…then He brought your hearts together, (Literally: joined "between") so you have become brethren by His favor …" (TMQ, 3:103).**

Therefore, the ayah warns Muslims against losing the gift of brotherhood and becoming divided; Allah says what can be translated as, **"And do not be as the ones who were disunited and differed (among themselves), even after the supreme evidences came to them …" (TMQ, 3:105).**

Intellectual Steadfastness

We have previously mentioned that the surah is divided into two parts. The first part of the surah (from ayah 1-120) deals with the *'aqeeda* (Faith) of the People of the Scriptures[17] (i.e. Jews and Christians); a polite, refined, and scientific way of discussing their beliefs. It does not aim at denouncing their ideas, but rather aims at strengthening the faith and concepts of Muslim believers and at purifying any misconceptions.

Coming back to this discussion, we find that the events took place in the Prophet's (*SAWS*) mosque with a group of *Nagran* Christians (a tribe by that name that lived then), who stayed in *Madinah* for three days to engage in a discourse, the first of its kind between Muslims and Christians, with Allah's Prophet (*SAWS*).

It is important to point out here that the debate, or discussion, with a second party of a different belief does not require any way of compromising any part of the faith, values, or beliefs. This could be clearly observed through the discourse present in the surah and in the Qur'an's sensible and elegant division of the stages of this discourse.

Fortifying Muslims' faith before the discussion

The surah starts by giving a boost of faith to Muslims. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as,

- **"Allah bears witness that there is no god except He, and the Angels and the ones endowed with knowledge, upright with equity (bear witness). There is no god except He, The Ever-Mighty, The Ever-Wise" (TMQ, 3:18),**
- **"Surely the religion in the Providence of Allah is Islam ..." (TMQ, 3:19),**
- **"Do they then (inequitably) seek other than the religion of Allah, and to Him has surrendered whoever is in the heavens and the earth, willingly and unwillingly, …" (TMQ, 3:83),**
- **"And whoever inequitably seeks for himself as a religion other than Islam, then it will never be accepted from him, …" (TMQ, 3:85),** and
- **"So, in case they argue with you, then say, "I have surrendered my face to Allah and whoever closely follows me (has surrendered his face to Allah) ..." (TMQ, 3:20).**

[17] Those who believe in the "Torah" or the "Gospel"

Identifying common points

It is important to find a common ground before starting any debate; this is clearly demonstrated in the Qur'an. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Say, "O population of the Book, (Or: Family of the Book, i.e., the Jews and Christians) come to a level word between us and you, that we worship none except Allah, and that we do not associate anything with Him, and that some of us do not take to themselves others (Literally: some "others") as lords, apart from Allah." So, in case they turn away, then say, "Bear witness that we are Muslims." (Literally: we have surrendered "to Allah")" (TMQ, 3:64).**

The surah denotes the belief in all of Allah's Messengers (including Prophets of the Scriptures) as another common belief that is shared with them. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Say, "We have believed in Allah, and in whatever has been sent down on us, and whatever was sent down on Ibrahîm and Ismaeel and Ishaq and Yaaqûb, (Abraham, Ishmael, Isaac and Jacob, respectively) and the Grandsons, (i.e. the Tribes) and in whatever was brought to Mûsa and Isa (Moses and Jesus, respectively) and the Prophets from their Lord; we make no distinction between any of them, and to Him we are Muslims" (i.e. we surrender)" (TMQ, 3:84).**

Testimonial evidence and proofs are the Qur'an's method of confirmation

Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as,

- **"Surely the likeness of *Isa* (Jesus) in the Providence of Allah is as the likeness of Adam. He (Allah) created him of dust, thereafter He said to him, "Be!" so he is (i.e., he was)" (TMQ, 3:59),**
- **"O population of the Book, why do you argue about *Ibrahîm*? And in no way were the *Tawrah* (The Book revealed to *Mûsa* "Moses") and the *Injil* (The Book revealed to Isa "Jesus") sent down except even after him. Do you not then consider?" (TMQ, 3:65),**
- **"Now you are the ones who have argued about what you have (some) knowledge (of); so, why do you argue about what you have no knowledge (of); …" (TMQ, 3:66),** and
- **"In no way was *Ibrahîm* a Jew, neither a Christian; (i.e. a follower of *Isa* "Jesus", *Nasraniyyan*) but he was an unswervingly (upright) (i.e. veering away from idolatry) Muslim; and in no way was he one of the associators (Those who associate others with Allah)" (TMQ, 3:67).**

Numerous ayahs that are rationally and logically convincing

Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as,

- **"In no way should a mortal (to whom) Allah brings the Book and the Judgment and the Prophethood thereafter say to mankind, "Be bondmen to me, apart from Allah." But, (i.e. But he should say) "Be lordly (i.e. teachers of Divine Law and worshipers of Allah) in that you used to teach the Book and in that you used to study (it)" (TMQ, 3:79),**
- **"And he (i.e. any religious Messenger) should not command you to take the Angels and Prophets to yourselves as lords. Would he command you to (adopt) disbelief after you have (become) Muslims? (i.e. have**

surrendered "to")" (TMQ, 3:80).

Warning the People of the Scriptures about denial or contradictions

After the ayahs have provided the logical and rational evidence, they turn to another style of discourse, one of warning and fear-provoking. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as,

- **"O population of the Book, (Or: Family of the Book, i.e., the Jews and Christians) why do you disbelieve in the signs of Allah, and you witness (them)?" (TMQ, 3:70),**
- **"O population of the Book, (Or: Family of the Book, i.e., the Jews and Christians) why do you confound the Truth with the untruth and keep back the Truth, and you know (that)?" (TMQ, 3:71),** and
- **"So, how (will it be) when We have gathered them for a Day. There is no suspicion about it, and every self will be paid in full whatever it has earned, and they will not be done an injustice" (TMQ, 3:25).**

The challenge intensifies

Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, "**So, whoever argues with you concerning him, (Or: it, i.e., the truth) even after (such) knowledge as has come to you, then say, "Come! We should call our sons and your sons, and our women and your women, and ourselves and yourselves; thereafter we should imprecate, (and) so lay (Literally: make) the curse of Allah on the liars" (TMQ, 3:61).**

This ayah is called the verse of *Al- Mobahala* (invocation); i.e. the two disputing groups would get together and pray or plead to Allah (*SWT*) that He may render the truthful group victory and curse the pseudo group; surely the *Nagran* Christians did not accept this severe challenge.

Justice and Equilibrium in the Discussion

Since Islam is such a noble religion, this discussion would only conclude in mentioning the good in some of the People of the Scripture. Not only so, but it further persuades Muslims to employ fairness in their view of them.

Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as,

- **"They are not (all) equal. Of the population of the Book (Or: Family of the Book; i.e., the Jews and Christians) is an upright nation (who) recite the signs (i.e., verses) of Allah at various times of the night as they prostrate themselves (to Him)" (TMQ, 3:113),** and
- **"And of the population of the Book is he who, in case you put in his custody a hundred- weight, (Literally: a Kantar) will pay it back to you; and of them is he who, if you put in his custody one dinar, will not pay it back to you, except as long as you are upright over him. (Or: over it) …" (TMQ, 3:75).**

The Qur'an teaches us that being a non-Muslim does not mean that all of their actions are wrong and all of their dealings are forged.

All Muslims should learn equilibrium from surat *Al-Imran* in dealing with non-Muslims. Moreover, the Qur'an praises the Prophets and Messengers of the People of the Scripture as Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, "**Surely Allah has elected Adam and *Nûh* (Adam and Noah, respectively) and the house of *Ibrahîm* (Abraham) and the house of *Imran* over the worlds" (TMQ, 3:33).**

Allah (*SWT*) also praises Virgin Mary by choosing her out of all women of the world; Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And as the Angels said, "O *Maryam*, (Mary) surely Allah has elected you … over the women of the worlds" (TMQ, 3:42).** What an exquisite principle of justice and equity, for this ayah has not come praising Prophet *Muhammad's* (*SAWS*) wife or daughter, instead it praised *Maryam* (*AS*) (Mary).

"No" to thoughtless imitation

Equally, the Qur'an warns us against thoughtlessly following the People of the Scriptures after showing us their creed. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as,

- "**O you who have believed, in case you obey a group of the ones who were brought the Book, they will turn you back after your belief into disbelievers**" **(TMQ, 3:100),**
- **"And how can you disbelieve, and the *ayat* (i.e., signs or verses) of Allah are recited to you, and His Messenger is among you? And whoever firmly adheres to Allah, then he is already guided to a straight Path" (TMQ, 3:101),**
- "**Now, you are those ones who love them, and they do not love you, and you believe in the Book, all of it. And when they meet you, they say, "We have believed." And when they go away in private, they bite at you their finger-tips in rage ..." (TMQ, 3:119),** and
- **"And do not be as the ones who were disunited and differed (among themselves), even after the supreme evidences came to them. And those will have a tremendous torment" (TMQ, 3:105).**

It is worth noting that the different core concepts on which the discourse is based were mentioned in consecutive, intertwined ayahs; first praising them, then providing proof against what they falsely believed in, and finally establishing a point of mutual agreement that is followed by a boost of faith (demonstrated clearly in some segments such as the ayahs 79- 83).

Let us not forget that in the midst of this discussion *Al-Imran* (the family of Imran), this noble family that Allah (*SWT*) named this surah after. Beginning with *Imran's* wife, her celibacy and prayers for *Maryam* (*AS*), then *Zakariya* (*AS*) (Zachariah) and his prayers, to *Isa* (*AS*) (Jesus) and his mother, and then finally to *Isa's* elevation to heaven. All are profound ayahs that address their distinguished designation and graciousness over mankind.

Concluding the surah's sections with a message of remaining steadfast

Concluding the first section with steadfastness is one of the clear signals; Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"…And in case you are patient and pious, their**

plotting will harm you nothing …" (TMQ, 3:120).

Similarly, the second section of the surah was concluded in the same manner. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"O you who have believed, be patient, and vie in patience, and be garrisoned (i.e., Keep a standing army ready to defend you) and be pious to Allah, that possibly you would prosper" (TMQ, 3:200).**

Commitment follows intellectual steadfastness

After establishing the external infrastructure against misconceptions and malicious ideas, the Qur'an moves to the reinforcement of the internal infrastructure. The Ever-Glorious Qur'an handles this subject through the commentary on the Battle of *Uhud*.

Muslims emerged from this battle feeling ashamed, broken, and disgraced because of their defiance to the orders of Prophet *Muhammad* (*SAWS*). They retreated and disobeyed orders, thus letting down the Prophet (*SAWS*). However, the Qur'an dealt with this matter in the most noble and gentle way by:

1. **Reminding them of Allah's Mercy that He bestowed upon them:**

   The ayahs also reminded them that victory is from Allah (*SWT*). Then they were reminded of the Battle of *Badr*. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as**, "(Remember) as two sections of you were about to be disheartened …"** (i.e. they do not persist on righteousness)**; "… and Allah is their Ever-Patronizing Patron; …"** (i.e. He is who strengthened them) **(TMQ, 3:122).** Allah (*SWT*) also says what can be translated as**, "And indeed Allah readily granted you victory at Badr, and you were humble; …" (TMQ, 3:123).**

   In the same context we can see that the emphasis is on victory being always from Allah (*SWT*) as He (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Yes indeed, in case you are patient and pious, and (the enemy) comes up (against) you instantly, … markedly swooping" (TMQ, 3:125).** Notice that patience and piety were repeatedly mentioned at the end of the sections of the surah. Moreover, they were linked here to emphasize the fact that both of them are essential for the descent of the Angels from the heavens and ultimately victory.

2. **The order for repentance and the return to Allah's (*SWT*) path:**

   This is another magnificent illustration of the Holy Qur'an's techniques in the area of personal development and steadfastness. Before enumerating their mistakes or reprimanding them, the Qur'an calls onto them to repent and head back to Allah's (*SWT*) path. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as,

   - **"And vie swiftly with one another for forgiveness from your Lord and for a Garden whose breadth is the heavens and the earth …" (TMQ, 3:133),** and
   - **"And who, when they (perform) an obscenity or do an injustice to themselves, remember Allah, and so they ask forgiveness for their guilty deeds- and who forgives guilty deeds except Allah (only)? - and who do not persist in the actions they performed, and they know (that)" (TMQ,**

3:135).

3. Consolation:

The ayahs lift the spirits up amongst the companions of the Prophet (*SAWS*). These are wonderful ayahs targeting Muslims of all times and places to strengthen them, despite all the hardships and pain they may be going through. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as,

- **"And do not feel feeble nor grieve; and you are the most exalted in case you are believers" (TMQ, 3:139),** and
- "**In case a blow touches you, (This refers to the Battle of 'Uhud) then a like blow has already touched the (disbelieving) people. And such days We interchange (i.e. the change of fortune) among mankind …" (TMQ, 3:140).**

The ayahs tenderly caress the companions' aches by reminding them that the disbelievers had also lost their lives in the battle and equally endured pain and hardship. Then follows a splendid ayah for perseverance in which Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Or (even) did you reckon that you would enter the Garden and Allah does not as yet know (i.e., has not yet proved, tested) who of you have striven, and that He may know the patient?" (TMQ, 3:142).** *Jannah* (Paradise) comes at a high cost and it is therefore imperative that whoever seeks it must struggle and have patience so that he/she may merit it.

4. Gentle reproaching:

After lifting up spirits, gentle reproach begins. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as,

- **"And indeed you readily coveted death even before you met it; then you have already seen it, and you were looking (at it)" (TMQ, 3:143)**,
- **"And in no way is Muhammad (anything) except a Messenger; the Messengers have already passed away before him. Then, will it be that, in case he dies or is killed, will you turn (Literally: turn (s) over on) on your heels? And whoever turns (Literally: turn (s) over on) on his heels, then he will never harm Allah in anything; and Allah will recompense the thankful" (TMQ, 3:144),** and another reprimand is,
- **"As you were mounting and did not twist about for anyone, and the Messenger was calling you in your rear …" (TMQ, 3:153).**

Imagine this scene: Muslims fleeing the battlefield in terror, running in every direction, heedless of any instructions, while the Prophet (*SAWS*) is standing firmly on the battle ground calling out for them, reminding them of the hereafter and what awaits them in it, and reminding them of the determination and circumstance of those who are long gone. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And similarly many a Prophet there has been along with whom myriads manifold have fought; so in no way did they feel feeble for whatever afflicted them in the way of Allah, and in no way did they weaken, and in no way did they yield themselves; and Allah loves the patient" (TMQ, 3:146).**

5. Back to consolation:

Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Thereafter He sent down upon you, even after suffering, secure (reassurance), a drowsiness enveloping a section of you; …" (TMQ, 3:154).**

Moreover, calling upon the Prophet (*SAWS*) to have his heart laden with sympathy for them; Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"So it was by (some) mercy from Allah that you have been lenient with them; and if you had been stern (and) harsh of heart, they would indeed have broken away from round about you. So be clement towards them, and ask forgiveness for them, and take counsel of them in the command ..." (TMQ, 3:159).**

Even after the defeat, the ayahs command the Prophet (*SAWS*) not to abandon consultation with the Muslims. Feel the majesty of this religion that blends reproaching, kindness, and consolation within the darkest and most difficult circumstance.

6. Reasons for the defeat and lack of determination:

After all that has been said we should try to understand the reasons that led to this defeat, so that Muslims everywhere would benefit from the mistakes that occurred:

a. Dispute and Disobedience: Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And indeed Allah has already sincerely (made good) His promise (Literally: was truly sincere in His promise) to you as you overwhelmed them by His permission …" (TMQ, 3:152).** Allah (*SWT*) had fulfilled his promise to you on victory **"… until you were disheartened …",** i.e. you lost your determination; **"… and contended together about the Command (i.e. the Command of Allah) …",** and quarreled amongst your selves; **"… and disobeyed (i.e. disobeyed the Messenger) …",** and this is an indication of the dangers of sin and disobedience and its consequences; **"… after He had shown you what you love (The reference is to the Battle of 'Uhud when the archers deserted their posts to share in the spoils) …"** after you have realized the signs of victory; **"…Some of you (there were) who would have the present (life) (Literally: the lowly (life), i.e., life of this world) and some of you (there were) who would have the Hereafter …"** i.e. some of you sought worldly gains out of this battle, hence was the defeat.

b. Sins: Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Surely the ones of you who turned away the day the two gatherings encountered, surely it was only that Ash-shaytan (The ever-vicious, i.e., the Devil) made them slide back for some of that which they had earned; …" (TMQ, 3:155).**

c. Reliance and attachment to people: When people rely on an individual who holds a certain idea more than their belief in that idea, their commitment to the idea weakens and so does their strength. In the battle of Uhud, some of the companions put down their weapons as soon as they heard the rumor that

Allah's Messenger (*SAWS*) had been killed; thus the ayahs came to reprimand them. Allah says what can be translated as, **"And in no way is Muhammad (anything) except a Messenger; the Messengers have already passed away before him. Then, will it be that, in case he dies or is killed, will you turn (Literally: turn (s) over on) on your heels? …" (TMQ, 3:144).**

Warning about dispute in the surah

It is noticeable that the surah specifically concentrated on the warning against dispute, as it is one of the major factors that lead to the lack of commitment and to the tremor of the internal infrastructure, whether the discrepancy is in ideology or practice. Therefore, the surah warned against:

a. **Following similar ayahs in the Qur'an for the sake of *Al-Fitnah* (incitement to rebellion), and seeking for its hidden meanings or alternative explanations:** Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"… So, as for (the ones) in whose hearts is swerving, they ever follow whatever (parts) of it are co similar, (inequitably) seeking temptation (to sedition), and (inequitably) seeking its interpretation; …" (TMQ, 3:7).**

b. **Disagreements and division over side issues:** Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And adhere firmly to the Rope (i.e. the Covenant of Allah=the Qur'an) of Allah, altogether, and do not be disunited; …" (TMQ, 3:103).** The surah *also* warns us against bickering and disagreement in Allah's ayahs. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And do not be as the ones who were disunited and differed (among themselves), even after the supreme evidences came to them …" (TMQ, 3:105).**

c. **Usury:** being one of the reasons for quarrels among Muslims, Allah (SWT) says what can be translated as, "**O you who have believed, do not eat riba, (i.e., usury; interest and other unlawful gains) doubled (and) redoubled, …" (TMQ, 3:130).**

d. **Becoming opinionated:** The ayahs instructed the Prophet (SAWS) to continue consulting his followers, despite all that had happened in Uhud. Allah (SWT) says what can be translated as, "… **So be clement towards them, and ask forgiveness for them, and take counsel of them in the command. Yet when you are resolved, then put your trust in Allah; …" (TMQ, 3:159).**

The relationship between the first and second sections:

1. **Not to rely or become attached to an individual instead of a belief:** The rumor that the Prophet (*SAWS*) had been killed confused the Muslims. Similarly, the story of the elevation of '*Isa* (Jesus Christ) to heaven disturbed the Christians and was the reason behind their current deviance from the truth. Surat Al-'Imran guides us to cherish the idea not the person proposing it, for people would die and perish but the concept and the religion remain. Therefore, this is a clear indication for Muslims not to get attached or believe

in a well known figure or missionary of Islam and to not forget the principle and the message behind it all.

2. **The importance of obedience:** Although the surah stressed on not being committed to a single person but rather to the idea being promoted, it also stresses on the importance of obedience and compliance.

- In the first section, Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, "**So, as soon as *Isa* (Jesus) perceived disbelief among them, he said, "Who are my ready vindicators to Allah?" (i.e., in the cause of Allah) The Disciples said" We are the ready vindicators to Allah; …" (TMQ, 3:52).** This ayah illustrates the aim **"… in the cause of Allah …"** and showed the means and the path, **"…Who are my ready vindicators …"**, thus they have to be the vindicators of Allah (*SWT*) and his Messenger (*AS*).

- In the second section, there is an encompassing ayah that mentions examples of people showing obedience to the Prophets throughout the centuries. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And similarly many a Prophet there has been along with whom myriads manifold have fought; so in no way did they feel feeble for whatever afflicted them in the way of Allah, and in no way did they weaken, and in no way did they yield themselves; and Allah loves the patient" (TMQ, 3:146).**

  In addition, this ayah where Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"(As you were mounting and did not twist about for anyone, and the Messenger was calling you in your rear …" (TMQ, 3:153).** That ayah reprimands Muslims for their shortcomings in terms of lack of compliance and obedience towards the Prophet (*SAWS*) in *Uhud*.

What is the reason behind the title Al-Imran?

What is the relationship between all that has been said about steadfastness and the family of 'Imran or Al-Imran? Allah (*SWT*) has chosen from this surah two symbols of steadfastness; the wife of *Imran* and *Maryam* (*AS*) the daughter of *Imran*, as their story was told in two full quarters of the surah
.
Maryam (*AS*) was adherent and dedicated to Allah's obedience and submission; she safeguarded her chastity until she earned the title in the Qur'an where Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And she who attended to her private parts, (i.e., Safeguarded her chastity) …" (TMQ, 21:91).**

Among the most dangerous issues affecting individuals and societies nowadays, is the failure to commit to obedience and chastity. Thus *Maryam* (*AS*) was a symbol of commitment to both.

As for *Imran*'s wife, her main concern was that the child she was bearing would be Allah's (*SWT*) vindicator for His religion. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"…As the wife of Imran said, "Lord! Surely I have vowed to you what is in my belly in dedication; so (graciously) accept (it) from me (free from all worldly work; to serve Your Place of worship) ..." (TMQ, 3:35).**

"In dedication" means totally submitted to Allah (*SWT*); as she wanted him to set free the *Aqsa* Mosque from the Roman aggressors. Thus, she was a symbol of commitment and absolute dedication to her cause even after learning that her newborn child was a female. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"So, as soon as she brought her forth, (i.e. gave birth to her) she said "Lord! Surely I have brought her forth, a female." And Allah knows best what she brought forth, and the male is not as the female. "And surely I have named her *Maryam* (Mary) …" (TMQ, 3:36).**

Allah (*SWT*) accepted from *Imran's* wife her sincere intentions saying what can be translated as, **"Then, her Lord graciously accepted her with fair acceptance, and caused her to grow a fair growth …" (TMQ, 3:37).**

It is worth noting that Allah (*SWT*) mentioned these two symbols in the surah, which addresses the People of the Scripture in a distinct manner with which the Qur'an brings people closer, as we have seen. Despite the fact that the Qur'an refutes what the People of the Scripture believe in, it praises the great figures that they believe in, such as *Imran's* wife and *Maryam* (*AS*).

The great value of women in the surah

Another point worthy of mention is that in the surah that deals with steadfastness, Allah (*SWT*) demonstrates the role models being two women. Even though the surah was named after the family of 'Imran, it did not mention *Imran* himself but rather focused on his wife's devotion and pure intentions to promote Allah's (*SWT*) religion, which resulted in the birth of *Maryam* (*AS*) and after that *Isa* (*AS*).

Note also that Prophet *Zakariya* (*AS*), with all his importance and merits among the Prophets of *Bani Israel* (Israelites), has learned from *Maryam* (*AS*). Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"…Whenever Zakariyya entered the Chamber to her, he found (a) provision in her presence. He said, "O Maryam, however does this (come) to you?" She said, "It is from the Providence of Allah; ..." (TMQ, 3:37),** and **"Thereover Zakariyya (Zechariah) invoked his Lord …" (TMQ, 3:38).**

Hence, the symbol of commitment in this surah is women; and the surah that follows Al-Imran is surat An-Nisaa (Women). This is the clearest indication of the honor Islam has given to women and how high it has placed their rank.

The message, then, to all youth, men and women, is to please stay steadfast on righteousness, both in your ideology as well as in practice, and learn valuable lessons from the two greatest ladies that were mentioned in this surah: *Imran's* wife and *Maryam* (*AS*) daughter of Imran.

Surat An-Nisa (The Women)

Surat An-Nisa is a Madinan surah. It was revealed after surat Al-Mumtahina and consists of 176 ayahs to be the fourth surah in the sequence of the Qur'an, exactly after surat Al-'Imran (the family of 'Imran). Surat An-Nisa is the surah that calls for justice and mercy, especially with vulnerable and weak people. After surat Al-Baqara defines the responsibility of Muslims on earth and explains the methodology that believers should follow in their lives as Allah's successors on earth comes surat Al-'Imran urging Muslims not to drift from the right path and to fulfill the obligations they are held responsible for. After these two surahs comes surat An-Nisa to teach us that the one who is entrusted with earth should be endowed with justice and mercy in his relationship with the weak and those he is responsible for. It is as if the first attribute that should characterize those who carry this responsibility is justice. Accordingly, surat An-Nisa deals with the rights of the weak groups in society such as: orphans, slaves, servants, heirs, and more importantly, women. The surah also deals with non-Muslim minorities who live under the protection of Islam and speaks of their rights. In addition, surat An-Nisa addresses the weak themselves showing them how to behave in different situations. The surah also refers to wayfarers and parents and how they should be treated. Therefore, surat An-Nisa the surah of mercy and justice. The reference to "the weak, justice and mercy" in each ayah comes as a Qur'anic marvel in that it induces no boredom on the part of the reader

The reason behind the title: always begin at home

The reason behind entitling the surah as "An-Nisa" (The Women) can be summarized in the following: if one manages to be just with his wife in his home, he will eventually know how to be just with other weak groups in the society. That is why it is the surah of the weak. Naturally, Allah (*SWT*) entitles the surah with the name of one of the disenfranchised or weak groups in society, as if to say: before I entrust you with earth, show me how just you are at home. Hence, if we are just and merciful at home, we will unquestionably exercise justice in society. Domestic justice, therefore, is a sample to which Muslims' commitment to justice in their mission on earth is measured. No one can hear this and still claim that Islam oppresses women. These allegations will no longer deceive readers of the Qur'an, mainly readers of surat An-Nisa, since the whole surah deals with the issue of justice and mercy with woman. Interestingly, surat An-Nisa is preceded by surat Al-'Imran which introduces Maryam (*AS*) "Mary" and Imran's wife as two models of steadfastness and faith, as if surat Al-Imran prepares us for the honor bestowed upon women in surat An-Nisa.

Now, let us delve into the ayahs, and read them with the intention of becoming just and merciful with everybody, especially the weak.

Justice: the Pillar of Succession

Straight from the beginning, the surah sheds light on its objective, as Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **" O you mankind, be pious to your Lord, Who created you of one self, and created from it its spouse, and from the two disseminated many men and women …" (TMQ, 4:1).** Allah (*SWT*), in this ayah, tells us that all human beings originate from the same roots, **"of one self".** Why, then, would injustice reign?

In the ayah, Allah (*SWT*) explains that women are created from men, which calls for the kindness towards women, as in the Prophet Muhammad's (*SAWS*) Hadith "Women are the full sisters (i.e. in faith) of men"[18] . It is worth noting that the surah begins with a universal appeal, **"O you mankind...",** while surat Al-Ma'idah started with a speech directed to the believers only, as Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"O you who believe..." (TMQ 5:1)**. The reason is that justice is a universal law for all nations. No nation can dominate earth if it is unjust. Justice is the basis of sovereignty, stability, and succession. In this respect, Ibn-Taimia- may he rest in peace- says, "People 's affairs become more settled with justice in spite of sins more than they do when society refrains from committing sins but is dominated by injustice. For this reason, people say that Allah (*SWT*) uplifts just countries even if they were of non-believers and that He does not support unjust countries even if they were of Muslims. It is also said that existence is sustained with justice and disbelief rather than with injustice and belief."[19]

Please note that surat An-Nisa starts with the same idea with which the preceding surah is concluded; piety. Surat Al-'Imran is concluded with this ayah, **"O you who have believed, be patient, and vie in patience, and be garrisoned (i.e., Keep a standing army ready to defend you) and be pious to Allah, that possibly you would prosper." (TMQ, 3:200).** Likewise, the first ayah of surat An-Nisa is "**O mankind! be pious to your Lord "(TMQ 4:1).**

Do not devour embers

The second ayah is a warning against another type of injustice, **"And bring the orphans their riches, and do not exchange the wicked (you have) for the good (they own); and do not eat up their riches with your riches; surely that is a great outrage" (TMQ, 4:2**). After that, Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And, in case you fear that you will not act equitably towards the orphans…" (TMQ, 4:3).** The ayah refers to an Arabic custom according to which the man used to provide the means of living for a female orphan from her own private money. When the orphan reached the age of marriage, the guardian would marry her and give her an inferior amount of money as a dowry. This ayah, therefore, defends this vulnerable group of women. It also encloses the renowned principle that permits polygamy; first justice, justice, and justice; otherwise, marry just one**; "...but if you fear that you shall not be able to deal justly (with them), then only one..." (TMQ, 4:3).**

Women's right to dowry offered wholeheartedly

In the fourth ayah, Allah (*SWT*) asserts the right of women to dowry and the importance of the fact that men should give it to them as an endowment, willingly as a gift, **"And bring the women their dowries as an endowment, so in case they are good to you concerning any portion of it, (Literally: in case they feel good in themselves to you about anything of it) then eat it up rejoicing with wholesome appetite (i.e., take it and make use of it to your profit and advantage)" (TMQ, 4:4).**

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[18] Authentic Hadith, Al-Albany.
[19] *Magmoo' Al-Fatawi* 28:146.

This mutual compassion between a husband and his wife is what Islam seeks to root in their relationship through dowry. Men are asked to give wholeheartedly and women are given the choice of whether to take what men have to offer them or to give some of it back to her husband as a sign of love. It is a wonderful ayah that combines a demand for rights and a call for mutual compassion embodied in giving wholeheartedly.

Justice even with the unwise

The ayahs proceed to deal with justice with different societal groups, including the irrational people. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And do not bring the foolish ones your riches that Allah has made for keeping you up, (i.e., as a means of support) and provide for them out of it, and give them raiment, and speak to them beneficent words" (TMQ, 4:5).** The foolish are those who are not capable of managing their wealth. If the money is left to them, they would squander it. Nevertheless, this category of people should not be exploited or abused as some people might abuse their money using their mental inferiority as a pretext.

The sixth ayah asserts the right of orphans to their money when they become adults; **"And try the orphans until they reach (the) marriageable age. So, in case you perceive in them right-mindedness then pay over to them their riches, and do not eat them up extravagantly and in anticipation of their (attaining) majority" (TMQ, 4:6).**

In the seventh ayah, Allah (*SWT*) states all women's right to inheritance, the right which used to be extorted from them during the age of *al-jahiliyya* (the pre-Islamic period), in what can be translated as, **"To the men is an assignment of whatever the parents and the nearest kin have left, and to the women is an assignment of whatever the parents and the nearest kin have left, of whatever it be, little or much, an ordained assignment" (TMQ, 4:7).**

The eighth ayah comes to link justice with benevolence. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **" And when the near of kin (Literally: endowed with kinship, "nearness) and the orphans and the indigent are present at the division, then provide for them out of it, and say to them beneficent saying " (TMQ, 4:8).**

Protect your children after your death through justice

In the ninth ayah, Allah (*SWT*) rectifies a false prevailing belief in what can be translated
as, "**And let the ones be apprehensive (of Allah), who, if ever they left behind them weak offspring, would fear (poverty) for them. So let them be pious to Allah, and let them say a befitting saying" (TMQ, 4:9).** Many people indulge in acquiring money through illegal means, offending others, on the pretext that they want to secure their children's future. In surat An-Nisa, Allah (*SWT*) overthrows this belief as He tells people that they should be just and always speak the truth if they want Allah (*SWT*) to protect their children.

In the tenth ayah, Allah (*SWT*) warns against injustice using strong words in what can be translated as, **"Surely the ones who eat the riches of the orphans unjustly, they surely only eat (up) Fire in their bellies and will roast in a Blaze "(TMQ, 4:10).**

A just division of inheritance

Rules governing division of inheritance among sons and daughters are well demonstrated in the eleventh ayah as Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Allah enjoins you concerning your children: to the male the like of the portion of two females..." (TMQ, 4:11).** This is justice because the division of inheritance is not based on sex preference or equal share between man and woman, but rather on the responsibilities and duties assigned to each of them. Men are responsible for covering the expenditures of both their houses and their wives, while women have no such responsibilities. Even when a woman gets married, it is her husband's duty to provide for her. Consequently, her share of inheritance and money remains intact.

In the twelfth ayah, Allah (*SWT*) explains in detail the principles of inheritance applied when somebody's spouse dies, **"And for you is a half of whatever your spouses have left, in case they have no children…" (TMQ, 4:12).** In brief, whenever you feel that your life is running short of justice, in your relationship with your wife or with the fragile people around you, try to read surat An-Nisa, the surah of justice, and evaluate your deeds in the light of its ayahs.

"Those are the bounds of Allah"

The ideas expressed in ayahs 13 and 14 are crucial in the sense that they encourage people to be righteous and just. Moreover, the ayahs warn the believers against the consequences of injustice and not abiding by the limits of Allah (*SWT*), as He says what can be translated as, **"Those are the bounds of Allah; and whoever obeys Allah and His Messenger, He will cause him to enter Gardens from beneath which Rivers run, eternally (abiding) therein; and that is the magnificent triumph. And whoever disobeys Allah and His Messenger and transgresses His bounds, He will cause him to enter a Fire, eternally (abiding) therein, and for him is a degrading torment" (TMQ, 4:13-14).**

What could possibly happen if humans indulge in acts of injustice? The answer is right there in ayah 17 in which Allah (*SWT*) accepts repentance**, "Surely relenting from (Literally: upon, i.e.**' **Allah relents) Allah is only towards the ones who do any odious deed in ignorance (and) thereafter they repent shortly; so Allah relents towards those and Allah has been Ever-Knowing, Ever-Wise" (TMQ, 4:17).**

The surah's emblem: "consort with them with beneficence"

The ayahs go back to justice with women as Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as**, "O you who have believed, it is not lawful for you to inherit women against their will …" (TMQ, 4:19)**. In this ayah, Allah (*SWT*) warns against inheriting women against their will, **"… (Literally: through compulsion) neither pose problems for them that you may go away with some (part) of what you have brought them except when they come up with a (demonstrably) evident**

obscenity. And consort with them with beneficence…." (TMQ, 4:19). Scholars have agreed that **"consort with them with beneficence"** means not only dealing with the wife justly, but also patiently so that he may lighten up her heart to drain off her anger, as the Prophet (*SAWS)*, himself used to do. Allah (*SWT*) proceeds to say what can be translated as, **"… so in case you hate them, then it is possible you may hate something, and Allah sets in it much charity (i.e. benefit)" (TMQ, 4:19).**

"They have taken from you a solemn compact"

Then comes ayah 20 in which both justice and realism in dealing with women are combined in which Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And in case you are willing to exchange a spouse in place of (another) spouse, and you have brought one of them a hundredweight, (Literally: a Kantar) then do not take anything of it. Will you take it by way of all-malicious (calumny) and evident vice?" (TMQ, 4:20).** Rule number one in treating wives justly is to live and associate with your wife amicably, and if you dislike her, you should try to be patient with her. If you grow impatient with her and decide to marry another, do not ever think of taking any amount of money from your first wife's dowry. No matter how huge it originally was, never touch it. Allah (*SWT*) is very strict in this point, **"Will you take it by way of all-malicious (calumny) and evident vice?"** Why does Allah (*SWT*) consider it an 'evident vice'? The reason is that, during pre-Islamic times, when Arabs wanted to remarry, they would wrongfully accuse their wives of adultery in order to oblige them to return the dowries they were given! Hence, Allah (*SWT*) scolds them strongly for this act in this ayah.

Then, we encounter one of the most magical ayahs in tendering the hearts on the one hand and in strengthening and glorifying the marriage contract on the other when Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And how should you take it, and each of you has already gone privily with the other, (Literally: some of you have been privily with (some) and they have taken from you a solemn compact?" (TMQ, 4:21).** The word **"gone privily with the other"** reflects on the deep relationship between the husband and wife. The ayah's strength lies in the fact that it takes the husband and wife back to the wonderful days and nights they spent together in their bedroom and other places before their relationship deteriorated.

The '**solemn compact**' is the marriage contract whereby you put your hand in the hand of your wife's guardian and say: "Following the teachings of the book of Allah (i.e. Qur'an) and the *Sunnah* of his Prophet (*SAWS*)". This is a severe warning for every husband should he think of dissolving the covenant, upon which he made Allah (*SWT*) a witness. It is striking that the expression '**solemn compact**' is mentioned only three times in the whole Qur'an. First, the expression was used in reference to Allah's Prophets; **"We took from them a solemn compact" (TMQ, 33:7).** Then it is used referring to *Ahl-ul-kitab* (the Jews) as Allah (*SWT*) took from them "**a solemn compact" (TMQ, 4:154)**. The third time reminds all husbands of the word or **'solemn compact'** they gave in their marriage contracts.

Of the ways Islam honored women

Women have been subject to injustice and abuse throughout history. However with Islam and the revelation of surat An-Nisa, women were given back their rights. In

pre-Islamic times, for instance, men inherited all their fathers' riches, including all their wives! Of course, this law, which was intended to humiliate women, was carried out with the exception of the heir's own mother. This act was so humiliating that Allah (*SWT*) banned it, saying what can be translated as, **"And do not marry women that your fathers married, except what has already gone by; surely that is an obscenity and detestation, and an odious way" (TMQ, 4:22)**.

The ayahs raise another issue; the rights of slave girls in marriage. Please note that Islam tackles this issue and enforces laws to protect the rights of such disenfranchised groups in a time where there were no laws to protect them. In the past, if man was unable to marry a free woman, he would then marry a slave girl. However, Allah (*SWT*) says what could be translated as, **"So marry them by the permission of their families…" (TMQ, 4:25).** In this ayah**,** Allah (*SWT*) uses the word "families" instead of "master" to encourage people to treat them mercifully and compassionately. **"So marry them by the permission of their families, (i.e. their folk) and bring them their rewards with beneficence" (TMQ, 4:25)**. The ayah also emphasizes the importance of giving their dowries wholeheartedly, without violating any of their rights because of their bondage.

"…Or taking mates for themselves"

The ayah warns women against getting involved in illegitimate relationships under the cover of friendship. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"…or taking mates for themselves" (TMQ, 4:25)**. The surah is about the mercy of Islam with woman in forbidding them from having paramours in order to protect them from the frustration and heartache that follows at the end of the affair. This is definitely the end of any relationship that begins with sin. Not only do such affairs depress women, but they also wreck their futures and stigmatize them. Women, in this respect, represent a special kind of weakness caused by their delicate hearts and strong emotions. Therefore, my advice to young ladies is that you are dear to Allah (*SWT*) and Islam protects your feelings from being exploited by oblivious irresponsible young men.

Penalty mitigation for the weak

Ayah 25 refers to an interesting aspect of Islam's mercy and justice with the weak, which in this case is regarding the slave girls. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"when they are in wedlock, (then) in case they come up with an obscenity, (5) they shall have then half the torment of free women in wedlock" (TMQ, 4:25).** This goes contrary to what is known about ancient Romanian and Indian laws that insisted on exacting severe punishments on lower classes. Islam, on the other hand, is merciful towards low classes and calls for mitigating their penalties**.**

Ayahs 26, 27 and 28 then come to remind us of the mercy and tenderness with which Allah (*SWT*) treats, not only the nation of the Prophet (*SAWS*), but also humanity in general. This is also a form of mercy with the weak. In this regard, Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Allah wills to lighten (things) for you, and man was created a weakling" (TMQ, 4:28).** Let us read the ayahs and contemplate how Allah (*SWT*) shows us His justice and mercy and reminds us of our weaknesses; **"Allah wills to make this evident to you and guide you into the enactments of the ones before you and to relent towards you; and Allah is Ever-Knowing, Ever-Wise.**

And Allah wills to relent towards you, and (the ones) who closely follow (their) lusts would have you incline (Literally: tilt away a tremendous tilting) away a tremendous inclining. Allah wills to lighten (things) for you, and man was created a weakling"(TMQ, 4:26-28).

Justice concerning money and souls

After demonstrating different aspects of social justice with regards to women, family, and society, justice in trade and financial transactions is tackled; Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"O you who have believed, do not eat (up) your riches among you untruthfully, except there be commerce by your mutual consent" (TMQ, 4:29)**. He (*SWT*) also calls for justice with human life and avoidance of bloodshed in what can be translated as, **"And do not kill yourselves (i.e. kill one another). Surely Allah has been Ever-Merciful to you" (TMQ, 4:29).**

No excess or negligence

In ayah 34, Allah (*SWT*) lays down rules that are to govern Muslim families. Men, in an attempt to be just with their wives, may become too indulgent with them, which might eventually lead some wives to sin. This ayah illustrates Islamic balance between firmness and justice. In this respect, Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Men are the ever upright (managers) (of the affairs) of women for what Allah has graced some of them over (some) others and for what they have expended of their riches. So righteous women are devout, preservers of the Unseen for. And the ones whom you fear their non-compliance, then admonish them and forsake them in their beds, (Literally: a *madaji'*= reclining) and strike them, (i.e. hit them lightly) yet in case they obey you, then do not seek inequitably any way against them; surely Allah has been Ever-Exalted, Ever-Great" (TMQ, 4:34).** In Islam, women are expected to obey their husbands in order to maintain their domestic life. If women act wrongly after they've been given all their rights, then husbands should not allow them to do whatever they please for fear of being unjust to them. Strictness is needed in this case. The means by which husbands are advised to resort to in order to help their wives return to the right path are enumerated in these ayahs in the order in which they should be used; admonishment, refraining from bed-sharing, and finally beating. It should be noted here that beating must be used only in case of ill-conduct or severe disobedience and stubbornness, which has its adverse effects on the family's welfare and might lead to destroying it. Beating, therefore, is a rare case and men should not resort to it whenever they wish on the pretext that it is mentioned in the Qur'an, neglecting the strict laws controlling this matter. The aim of beating is not causing pain but rather, it is to make a wife realize her wrongdoing. The best example to follow here is Prophet Muhammad (*SAWS)* who had never beaten a woman or a servant.

Do not be unjust to yourself

Justice becomes the subject of the ayahs again when Allah (*SWT*) warns against polytheism; **"worship Allah and do not associate anything with Him" (TMQ, 4:36).** That is because polytheism is the greatest injustice one can do to himself as the ayahs in surat Luqman indicate what can be translated as, **"Surely associating (others with Allah) is indeed a monstrous injustice" (TMQ, 31:13).** In the ayah,

Allah (*SWT*) expands the notion of justice and beneficence to cover the different groups that comprise society, especially the weak. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"and do good to parents",** which means parents, especially when they become seniors, and **"near kinsman, and the neighbour who is a stranger, (i.e. not of the family or creed or "nationality") and the companion at your side, and the wayfarer, and what your right hands possess. Surely Allah does not love whoever has been conceited (and) constantly boastful" (TMQ, 4:36).** Do you see how coherent the surah is? Even if the ayahs differ in content, they all revolve around one major idea, which is justice in all possible forms.

Obstacles in the way of justice and mercy

Allah (*SWT*) enumerates the unfavorable characteristics that negatively affect one's ability to be just and merciful, namely miserliness and hypocrisy. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"The ones who are miserly and bid (other) men (Literally: command mankind) to be miserly, and (who) keep back whatever Allah has brought them of His Grace" (TMQ, 4:37), "And also (for) (the ones) who expend their riches showing off to (other) men, (Literally: mankind) and do not believe in Allah nor in the Last Day. And whoever has Ash-Shaytan (The all-vicious, i.e., the Devil) for a comrade, then how odious is such a comrade!" (TMQ, 4:38)**.

"Allah does not do injustice so much as an atom's weight"

After teaching us about justice, Allah (*SWT*) reminds us of His bounty and grace. He treats us with His generosity prior to His justice, so why does man disdain from treating others with justice? Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Surely Allah does not do injustice so much as an atom's weight, and in case it is a fair deed, He will double it and bring from very close to Him a magnificent reward" (TMQ, 4:40).**

In the following ayah, Allah (*SWT*) reminds us that the Prophet (*SAWS)* will be a witness on our justice on the Day of Judgment. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as**, "How then will it be when We cause to come from every nation a witness and cause you to come as a witness against these?" (TMQ, 4:41).** It is as though Allah (*SWT*) is warning the unjust to be careful and think over their attitudes as the Prophet (*SAWS)* will be the witness on their injustice. Moreover, the ayah brings the glad tidings to the just, since it is the Prophet (*SAWS)* himself who will be a witness of their justice.

Then, comes a crucial ayah, which represents the essence of the surah in which Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Surely Allah commands you to pay deposits back to their qualified family (i.e. the owners) and, when you judge among mankind, that you judge with justice. How favorable is that to which Allah surely admonishes you; surely Allah has been Ever-Hearing, Ever-Beholding" (TMQ, 4:58).**

The essence of justice: obedience to Allah (*SWT*) and to the Prophet (*SAWS*)

The following ayah makes it crystal clear that obedience of Allah (*SWT*) and his Prophet (*SAWS*) constitutes the essence of justice as Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"O you who have believed, obey Allah and obey the Messenger, and the ones endowed with the command (i.e. those in authority) among you. So in case you contend together about anything, then refer it to Allah and the Messenger, in case you believe in Allah and the Last Day; that is most charitable (i.e. most beneficial) and fairest in interpretation" (TMQ, 4:59)**.

Resorting to Allah's legislations and settling disputes by referring to Qur'an and the *Sunnah* (life style and Ahadith, or sayings) of the Prophet (*SAWS*) are the mainstays of mercy and justice in society even though they might seem to be unjust. This is clear in ayah 64; if believers disobey the orders of Allah (*SWT*) and his Prophet (*SAWS*), they will be unjust to themselves; Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And in no way have We sent any Messenger except that he should be obeyed, by the permission of Allah; and if, as they have done an injustice to themselves, they had come to you, so (had) asked forgiveness from Allah, and the Messenger (had) asked forgiveness for them, indeed they would have found Allah Superbly Relenting, Ever-Merciful." (TMQ, 4:64).** How can justice be attained? The answer lies in Ayah 65 in which Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"(Yet) no, by your Lord, they will not believe till they make you judge regarding what they controvert among themselves. Thereafter they should not find in themselves any restriction about whatever you have decreed, and should submit in full submission" (TMQ, 4:65).** My word to the believers is to always resort to the teachings of the Qur'an and to the *Sunnah* of the Prophet (*SAWS*). Accept what Allah (*SWT*) and his Prophet (*SAWS*) ordained and never hesitate in following the Prophet's (*SAWS*) orders, since he is the witness of your justice on the Day of Judgment.

Fighting to protect the rights of the weak

The ayahs proceed in their discourse on warfare in exactly a whole quarter of *a hizb* (the Qur'an is divided into 30 *juz'* (parts) each *juz'* is then divided in two *hizb* and the *hizb* is divided into four quarters). This quarter begins with the ayah 74 in which Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"So, let the ones fight in the way of Allah, (the ones) who barter the present life (Literally: the lowly life, i.e., the life of this world) (seeking) the Hereafter…"(TMQ, 4:74)**. What is the relationship between this quarter and justice? For justice to persevere in society, it must be supported by a force that protects the rights of the weak. Fighting in Islam is not an ultimate objective. On the contrary, it is a means of implementing an objective. The evidence is in ayah 75 in which Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And what is it with you, that you do not fight in the way of Allah, (the way) and of the ones deemed weak among the men, women and newborns, who say, "Our Lord, bring us out of this town (i.e. Makkah, where Muslims were persecuted after Hijrah) whose population is unjust, and set for us a constant patron from very close to You, and set for us from very close to You a ready vindicator…" (TMQ, 4:75).** Interestingly, most of warfare legislations and principles are in surat An-Nisa. That is because women are primarily the makers of *mujahedeen* (fighters for the just Islamic cause), and are also fighters inside their houses. The woman who patiently bears her husband's injustice is a *mujahedah* who fights and gets martyred a hundred times a day. We can deduce from this that the inclusion of war legislations and principles in this particular surah is a sort of a message directed to woman, a message

that says (and Allah is the best Who knows) you, as well, are considered a fighter in the cause of Allah (*SWT*) when you are patient with your husband and when you protect your house.

The influence of Media on justice

There is also an important ayah in this quarter addressing the media people in every era and every place. Depicting the way media influences justice, Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And when there comes to them a command (i.e., the matter, the affair) of security or fear, they divulge it; and if they had referred it to the Messenger and to the ones endowed with the command (i.e., those in authority) among them, the ones among them who investigate would indeed know it" (TMQ, 4:83)**. The media may have a negative influence on judges and public opinion to the extent that conceptions may change radically, influencing the judgment of the most just. For this reason, rumours should be referred to their authorities. In addition, one should refrain from distorting information and jumping to conclusions. The ayah is a clear message to the Muslims of this age, who should question everything that reaches them through media.

The Danger of Hypocrisy

In addition, there comes a full quarter of a *hizb* devoted to the dangers of hypocrites in society. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"So, what is it with you that you are two communities regarding the hypocrites, and Allah has cast them back for what they earned? …" (TMQ, 4:88).**

Mentioning the hypocrites comes as a warning against their presence in society, which is the major reason behind the loss of justice and the deprivation of the rights of the weak. Hypocrites simply corrupt society and its values, especially the value of justice.

The ayahs continue until they reach the most elevated sense of justice; justice even during battle. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"O you who have believed, when you strike (i.e. journey in the earth) in the way of Allah, then be discerning …." (TMQ, 4:94).** These are the warfare ethics that Islam pioneered in promoting.

Be Positive to Achieve Justice

In the previous ayahs, the Qur'an addresses the strong and the liable, ordering them to be just and merciful to the weak. However, ayah 97 urges the weak to be positive and active, and not to be submissive or defeated. The ayah makes it clear that the weak should not await justice idly, nor should they beg for mercy from others. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Surely the ones whom the Angels take up, (while) they are unjust to themselves- (to them) (the Angels) say, "In what (condition) were you?" (i.e., In what circumstances were you? Of what religion were you?) They say, "We were deemed weak in the earth." They (the Angels) say, "Was not the earth of Allah wide so that you (could) have emigrated in it?" So, the abode for those (men) is Hell, and what an odious Destiny!" (TMQ, 4:97).**

Qasr in Prayers (allowed shortening of the obligatory prayers) as a Mercy from Allah

Allah (*SWT*) then calls attention to the boundless mercy with which He surrounds his creatures and slaves, specifying *Qasr* of prayers and the prayer of fear (special prayers prayed during time of great fear or danger) in ayah 101 in which Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And when you strike in the earth, (i.e., journey in the earth) then there is no fault in you that you shorten the prayer…" (TMQ, 4:101).** By this ayah, Allah (*SWT*) draws our attention to His over-flowing mercy so as to make us merciful towards people in return.

Justice with Non-Muslim Minorities

Finally, we see the Islamic justice towards the non-Muslim minorities in Muslim societies. In an incident that took place during the days of Prophet Muhammad (*SAWS*), a Muslim committed the crime of theft and accused a Jew of it. Another Muslim knew the truth, but under the false impression that he is standing by his Muslim brother who would be sentenced to the prescribed Islamic punishment if truth was revealed, he decided to keep this information to himself and gave a false testimony.

As a result, strongly-worded ayahs are revealed, **"Surely, We have sent down to you (i.e. the Prophet) the Book with the Truth that you judge among mankind by whatever Allah has shown you; and do not be a constant adversary of the treacherous." (TMQ, 4:105).** Then the tone becomes even harsher as Allah (*SWT*) addresses the wrongful sinners, **"And whoever earns an offence or a vice (and) thereafter throws (the blame thereof) upon an innocent one, then he has readily burdened himself with all-malicious calumny and evident vice." (TMQ, 4:112).** Allah (*SWT*) proved the Jew's innocence setting forth these civilized principles of dealing with other religions.

A Return to Women

By the end of the surah, there is a return to the divine principles associated with women in which there is great emphasis on justice and mercy. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And they ask you for your pronouncement concerning women. Say,** "**Allah pronounces concerning them, and what is recited to you in the Book concerning the orphan women (Or (possibly): women who have orphans…" (TMQ, 4:127).** There is also a call for justice in polygamy, **"And you will never be able to do justice between (your) wives, (Literally: women) even if you are (so) eager; yet do not incline away completely (Literally: incline away all inclining) (from one), so that you leave her (behind) as if she were suspended…" (TMQ, 4:129).** This is considered an unjust action on the part of the man who misuses his authorities.

Stand up firmly for justice

Ayah 135, which comes towards the end of the surah, is strongly reminiscent of the objective of the surah, **"O you who have believed, be constantly upright with equity (with others), witnesses for Allah, even if it be against yourselves or (your)**

parents and nearest kin. In case (the person) is rich or poor, then Allah is the Best Patron for both. So do not ever follow prejudice, so as to do justice; and in case you twist or veer away, then surely Allah has been Ever-Cognizant of whatever you do." (TMQ, 4:135).

The word *qawwameen* (standing firm) is an exaggerative form of the word *qa'em* (keeper of justice) used to reinforce the meaning of 'to stand firmly for justice'. The ayah also warns us against following our own inclinations, which is a major factor in inflicting injustice upon people.

Tyranny against the People of the Scripture

The surah then points out some of the mistakes of the People of the Scripture that are related to its subject matter so as to warn Muslims from their deeds, **"So, for the injustice (on the part) of (the ones) who have Judaized, We have prohibited them good things that were lawful to them…" (TMQ, 4:160).** Due to their injustice, Allah (*SWT*) prohibited some of the *halal* (lawful) things that were allowed for them.

The following ayah manifests their injustice as Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"… and for their barring from the way of Allah many (people). And for their taking riba, (Usury and other types of unlawful) and they were already forbidden it, and eating (up) the riches of mankind untruthfully; (Literally: with untruth)…" (TMQ, 4:160-161).**

Allah (*SWT*) also says what can be translated as, **"O population of the Book, (Or: Family of the Book, i.e., Jews and Christians) do not go beyond the bounds in your religion and do not say concerning Allah (anything) except the Truth. Surely the Masih, Isa son of Maryam, (The Messiah, Jesus son of Mary) was only the Messenger of Allah, and His Word that He cast forth to Maryam, and a Spirit from Him. So, believe in Allah and His Messengers, and do not say, "Three." Refrain; most charitable is it for you; surely Allah is only One God. All Extolment be to Him-that He should have a child. To Him (belongs) whatever is in the heavens and whatever is in the earth; and Allah suffices for an Ever-Trusted Trustee. The Masih (The Messiah) will never disdain to be a bondman of Allah, neither the Angels who are near-stationed (to Him). And whoever disdains to do Him worship (Literally: worshiping Him) and waxes proud, then He will soon muster them altogether to Him." (TMQ, 4:171-172).** These two ayahs deal with the deviation in the Christian doctrine. Mentioning this here serves the objective of the surah in yet another way. The deviation that took place in their religion and holy book is due to the oppression that the first generation of Christians suffered on the hands of the Romans. This, in a way, sounds like a message urging the believers to defend and support Islam to prevent it from the divergence that befell Christianity.

These two ayahs are preceded by two more that carry an emphatic warning against injustice. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Surely (the ones) who have disbelieved and have done injustice, indeed Allah would not forgive them, nor indeed guide them on any road. Except the road to Hell, eternally (abiding) therein forever…" (TMQ, 4:168-169).**

That was surat An-Nisa, a call for the observance of justice and mercy in all social classes. Moreover, this surah has the advantage of containing the largest number of references to the Most Beautiful Names of Allah (*SWT*) in its last few ayahs (42 references). These names include those of knowledge and wisdom (The Wise and The All-Knowing), and those of ability, compassion, and forgiveness that all indicate Allah's justice, compassion, and wisdom in all the laws that He decreed for the realization of justice.

Brothers and sisters in Islam, please read surat An-Nisa with the intention of applying justice primarily to your lives, at home with your family (especially wives and parents), then with your neighbours and with people in your society regardless of their religion or social class.

Surat Al-Ma'idah (The Table)

Surat Al-Ma'idah is Madinan, although some of its ayahs were revealed in Makkah after *hajjat alwada'* (the farewell hajj that the Prophet (*SAWS*) performed). It was revealed after surat Al-Fath and comes in the Qur'an after surat An-Nisa. It contains 120 ayahs and it is the only surah in the Qur'an that begins with **"O you who have believed…" (TMQ, 5:1).** This phrase recurs in the Qur'an 88 times, 16 of them are found in surat Al-Ma'idah.

Abdullah Ibn-Mas'oud says, "If you hear **"O you who have believed…,"** listen carefully, for it is either a good thing you should do or an evil sin you are forbidden to do".

The meaning of **"O you who have believed…"** is "O you who truly believed in Allah, accept Allah as your Lord and worship Him, listen and obey."

The Objective is in the call

The objective of the surah is made clear in the first call as Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"O you who have believed, fulfill your contracts..." (TMQ, 5:1);** thus urging Muslims to fulfill their commitments. The surah indicates all kinds of commitments, which range from mankind's responsibility on earth, and moves on to obedience matters, such as praying and wearing *hijab* (Islamic veil). It also points out abstaining from forbidden deeds, such as drinking alcohol and possessing illegally-obtained money.

The call **"O you who have believed…",** as mentioned above, does not recur in any other surah as much as it recurs in surat Al-Ma'idah. Even surat Al-Baqara, which consists of more ayahs, contains of only ten similar calls. These calls constitute the core ideas of the surah; wherever a call occurs, a new idea of the surah is dealt with; a new set of prohibitions and commands is given. The surah moves smoothly from one to another of these sixteen orders urging us to fulfill our commitments.

The Prophet's wife Aisha *RA* (May Allah be pleased with her) says, "Surat Al-Ma'idah is the last of the revelations of the Qur'an. Therefore, make *halal* (lawful deeds) what you find in it of *halal*, and make *haram* (sinful deeds) what you find in it of *haram.*"[20]

This surah contains the last ayah of the Islamic legislation, which was revealed during *hajjat alwada'* in which Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"…Today I have completed your religion for you, and I have perfected My favor on you, and I am satisfied with Islam as a religion for you…" (TMQ, 5:3).** The objective of the surah is starting to become clearer; now that religion, its teachings, and its principles are complete, fulfill your obligations to Allah (*SWT*), maintain them, and acknowledge what religion considers *halal* and shun what it considers *haram*. It is actually the surah of *halal* and *haram* in Islam.

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[20] Good Hadith, Ibn-Hazm.

Core ideas of the surah

As mentioned before, the call "**O you who have believed…"** moves us to a new core idea and a new detailed order. It is striking that all the ayahs of the surah revolve around the following main ideas that demonstrate a great deal of both, *halal and haram* principles:

1. Food, drink, quarry and slaughter.
2. Family and marriage.
3. Faith and *kaffarat* (prescribed acts of charity or fasting performed in repentance of doing an unlawful act).
4. Principles of worship.
5. Verdicts, judiciary rules, testimonies, and the realization of justice.
6. Organizing Muslim relations with other religions, namely with Jews and Christians.

There is great emphasis in the surah on the *halal* and *haram* of food, drink, quarry, and slaughter, which is interrelated with the title of the surah "Al-Ma'idah" (literally: the dining table). Food is a biological necessity, however, the *halal* and *haram* in it must be attentively observed. Hence, less material aspects of life should be handled with the same vigilance.

In addition, legislation is reserved for Allah (*SWT*) alone and this is stressed throughout this momentum of *halal* and *haram* principles from **"…Surely Allah judges (according to) whatever He wills." (TMQ, 5:1)** to the three ayahs that warn from straying from Allah's legislation and applying other than what Allah has revealed. In one of those ayahs Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"…And whoever does not judge according to what Allah has sent down, then those are they (who are) the disbelievers." (TMQ, 5:44).**

Progression and Coherence in the Qur'an

Observe the correlation between the previous Qur'an surahs and surat Al-Ma'idah. Surat Al-Baqara informs us of man's responsibility on earth. After that, surat Al-'Imran urges us to persevere and to be steadfast. Next, surat An-Nisa tells us that in order to persevere, we need to observe justice and compassion with the weak. Recapping that, surat Al-Ma'idah orders us to fulfill all of the above.

Thus, surat Al-Ma'idah urges us to be just to our wives, to the weak, and to the whole of mankind. It also urges us to maintain the way of life that Allah (*SWT*) mapped out for us in surat Al-Baqara. This is why Allah (*SWT*) included in it ayah 3, which declares the completion of His devised way of life.

Furthermore, note the gradual arrangement of the surahs in the Qur'an as they address the People of the Scripture:

Surat **Al Baqara:** An account of the mistakes of the People of the Scripture and a call for Muslims to be distinguished from them.

Surat **Al-Imran:** A peaceful discussion of their doctrines; one that highlights the features they have in common with Muslims.

Surat Al Nisa: A criticism of the excessiveness of the People of the Scripture and their differences about *Isa* (*AS)* (Jesus).

Surat Al Mai'da: A strongly-worded confrontation as Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Indeed they have already disbelieved, the ones who have said, "Surely Allah is the third of three."" (TMQ, 5:73).**

We can conclude from the above that Islam approaches other religions in a very progressive and gradual way.

The First Call: fulfill your contracts

"O you who have believed, fulfill your contracts. The brute of cattle (Ana'am = cattle, camels, sheep and goats) has been made lawful to you…" (TMQ, 5:1). What could be the relationship between the fulfillment of obligations and the legitimization of slaughtering and eating cattle? Allah (*SWT*) did not begin by declaring the *haram*, or illegitimate, so as to avoid rendering the surah repellent. Instead, the *halal*, or the legitimate, was mentioned immediately after the obligation fulfillment order. Thus, **"fulfill your contracts"** is followed by **"lawful to you"** to testify the boundless compassion and mercy with which Allah (*SWT*) blesses this nation.

Indeed, that is a method that *da'wa* (missionary activity) workers should use in order to win over more hearts. *Da'wa* people should not begin with what Allah (*SWT*) has forbidden if they are planning to guide people to the right path. Since everything is originally allowed, a *da'wa* worker should begin by informing people what is allowed for them and later on indicate to them what is not allowed.

In addition to the compassion and kindness that characterize the discourse here, there is another meaning to the first call. We are told in this ayah to fulfill our obligations so that the amount of *halal* we are granted does not become limited as it did with the Jews.

It is striking that this same idea is in fact referred to in the two surahs that precede and follow surat Al-Ma'idah (Surat An-Nisa and surat Al-An'am). In surat An-Nisa, Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"So, for the injustice (on the part) of (the ones) who have Judaized, We have prohibited them good things that were lawful to them…" (TMQ, 4:160).** Furthermore, in surat Al-An'am Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And to the ones who Judaized We have prohibited everything with (Literally: possessing, equipped with, owning) claws…" (TMQ, 6:146).** But what was the prohibition for? **"…(by) that We recompensed them for their inequity; and surely We indeed are sincere." (TMQ, 6:146).** They did not fulfill their obligations to Allah (*SWT*) that He deprived them of some of the *halal* that was already allowed to them. Thus, Muslims, be wary of doing what they have done lest you get the same punishment.

The Second Call: "…do not violate the way marks of Allah…" (TMQ, 5:2)

Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as**, "O you who have believed, do not violate the way marks of Allah…" (TMQ, 5:2).** Do not change the features of Allah's religion, in terms of orders and prohibitions**, "…nor the Inviolable Month, nor the offering, nor the garlands, nor the ones repairing to the Inviolable Home seeking from their Lord Grace and all-blessed Satisfaction; and when you are not on pilgrimage, (Literally: when you have become legally permissible, i.e., no longer in the sanctified state of a pilgrim) then (go game) hunting. And do not let antagonism of a people who barred you from the Inviolable Mosque provoke you to transgress. And help one another to benignancy and piety, and do not help one another to vice and hostility…" (TMQ, 5:2).**

The first ayah is thus a statement of the necessities of life and the second one is a declaration of a set of great human principles:

- Justice; emphasizing the objective of surat An-Nisa of establishing justice as Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"…And do not let antagonism of a people who barred you from the Inviolable Mosque provoke you to transgress…" (TMQ, 5:2).**
- Cooperation; emphasizing one of the messages of surat Al-'Imran, i.e. unity and avoiding dissention, as Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **" …And help one another to benignancy and piety and do not help one another to vice and hostility …" (TMQ, 5:2).** This ayah comprises thousands of examples of social relations that fall under piety, righteousness, and cooperation.
- *Taqwa* (piety and fear of Allah). Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"…and be pious to Allah; surely Allah is strict in punishment." (TMQ, 5:2).** This reminds us that this Holy book is **"…a guidance to the pious." (TMQ, 2:2)**, as mentioned at the beginning of surat Al-Baqara.

Then comes the third ayah where Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Prohibited to you are carrion, (i.e. dead meat) and blood…" (TMQ, 5:3),** indicating that the first obligation to be fulfilled is that of *halal* food since a Muslim should never eat foul food.

After this indication comes the fifth ayah, which can be translated as, **"Today the good things are made lawful for you, and the food of the ones to whom the Book was brought is lawful to you, and your food is made lawful to them. And (so) are believing women in wedlock, and in wedlock women of (the ones) to whom the Book was brought …" (TMQ, 5:5).** The ayah, as we can see here, points out two kinds of *halal*: *halal* food and good women, whether they were Muslims or *ketabiyyat* (from the People of the Scripture), as long as they are chaste and well-mannered. This allowance is a wonderful gesture that bespeaks the tolerance[21] with which Islam deals with the People of the Scripture. Even in a surah that addresses them harshly, chaste women are declared *halal* for Muslims, whether the women are Muslims or from the People of the Scripture.

[21] Acknowledging and supporting that individuals have the right and freedom to their own beliefs and related legitimate practices, without necessarily validating those beliefs or practices.

In the very same ayah, Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"…Today I have completed your religion for you, and I have perfected My favor on you, and I am satisfied with Islam as a religion for you…" (TMQ, 5:3).** The importance of this ayah lies in the fact that it is the closing of all the principles of Islam. The relationship between this particular ayah and the subject matter of the surah is that obligations do not exist unless there is some sort of completion. Since religion is now complete, you believers must fulfill your obligation to it and comply with its laws. I wonder if any of us ever felt this blessing of the completion of religion and thanked Allah (*SWT*) for it.

Once a Jew said to Omar Ibn Al-Khattab (*RA*) (May Allah be pleased with him), "O the chief of believers! There is a verse in your Holy Book Which is read by all of you (Muslims), and had it been revealed to us, we would have taken that day (on which it was revealed as a day of celebration." Omar Ibn Al-Khattab (*RA*) asked, "Which is that verse?" The Jew replied with the ayah that can be translated as, **"…Today I have completed your religion for you, and I have perfected My favor on you, and I am satisfied with Islam as a religion for you…" (TMQ, 5:3).** Omar replied, "No doubt, we know when and where this verse was revealed to the Prophet. It was Friday and the Prophet was standing at 'Arafat (i.e. the Day of Hajj)"[22]

There is a subtle touch that can be noticed here. Most of the ayahs of this surah are concluded with rather strong words, especially the introductory ayahs. For example Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"...surely Allah is strict in punishment" (TMQ, 5:2)** and **"…surely Allah is swift at the reckoning" (TMQ, 5:4).** The only exception is the third ayah which mentions the legislation in case of an urgent situation where Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"…And whoever is constrained in scantiness, (i.e., compelled by need)…"** and concludes it in what shows His mercy saying what can be translated as, **"Allah is Ever-Forgiving, Ever-Merciful." (TMQ, 5:3).**

The Third Call: the spiritual good

Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as**, "O you who have believed, when you rise up for prayer, then wash your faces, and your hands up to the elbows, and wipe your heads, (Or: "part of" the head) and (wash) your legs to the ankles…" (TMQ, 5:6).**

Some may wonder why this ayah was revealed in a surah that is about the fulfillment of obligations. Actually, the surah starts with a statement of biological necessities (e.g. food and marriage) and mundane pleasures, so it was logical for the surah to move to spiritual pleasures and spiritual purity that naturally start with *wudu'* (ablution). This way, the surah touches upon all kinds of pleasure: worship pleasure, as well as mundane pleasure. We can conclude from this that the legislations of Islam are inclusive, as legislations of dealings come hand in hand with those of worship.

Another subtle touch in surat al-Ma'idah is that nearly after every ten ayahs, there is an ayah to remind us of our obligation to Allah (*SWT*). This obligation is mentioned in the surah eleven times in clear, plain ayahs, which poses a question to Muslims.

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[22] Authentic Hadith, Al-Bukhari

Now that the life discipline which has been set out for you is complete, will you fulfill your obligation to it?

Allah (*SWT*) says in the seventh ayah what can be translated as, **"And remember the favor of Allah upon you and His compact by which He has solemnly bound (Literally: compacted) you as you said, "We have heard and we obey."..." (TMQ, 5:7).** It is noticed here that there is a connection between this ayah and the ayah in surat Al-Baqara that can be translated as, **"…And they have said, "We have heard, and we have obeyed. Grant (us) Your All-Supreme forgiveness, our Lord, and to You is the Destiny." (TMQ, 2:285).** Believers say this while the Israelites say, **"…we have heard, and we disobey…" (TMQ, 2:93).** This makes the connections between the objectives and ideas of the surahs of the Qur'an even clearer.

The fourth call (Justice)

The sequence of the ayahs proceeds until it reaches the fourth call, presented in the ayah in which Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, "**O you who have believed, be constantly upright for Allah, witnesses with equity, and let not antagonism of a people provoke you to not do justice. Do justice; that (literally: it) is closer to piety. And be pious to Allah, surely Allah is Ever-Cognizant of whatever you do" (TMQ, 5:8).**

After handling the fulfillment of obligations concerning food, drink, marriage and ablution, the ayahs move on to another very important covenant, which is justice. Justice is an obligation that must be fulfilled, even with those whom we hate or whom we fight. This ayah represents a very important pillar of Islam's tolerance and its justice towards other parties.

The fifth call (remember Allah's favors upon you)

The eleventh ayah reminds us that Allah *(SWT)* protects the believers from their enemies' betrayal; thus, believers ought to fear Allah *(SWT)* and fulfill His obligations. **"O you who have believed, remember the favor of Allah upon you as a (certain) people designed to stretch against you their hands, so He restrained their hands from you. And be pious to Allah, and in Allah let the believers then put their trust" (TMQ, 5:11).**

Allah (*SWT*) fulfills His promises to us. One of these divine promises is mentioned in the ninth ayah, in which Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Allah has promised the ones who have believed and done deeds of righteousness (that) they will have forgiveness and a magnificent reward" (TMQ, 5:9).** In light of this ayah, will we be able to keep our obligations towards Allah *(SWT)*?

The Israelites and their covenants

Allah (*SWT*) then draws on examples of people who breached their covenants with Him, and did not act on the principle of this ayah in which Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"we have heard, and we have obeyed" (TMQ, 2: 285),** as He ordained. These were the Israelites. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as,

"And indeed Allah already took compact with the Israelites and We sent forth among them twelve chieftains. And Allah said, "Surely I am with you, indeed if you keep up the prayer, and perform the *zakat*, (i.e., pay the poor-dues) and believe in My Messengers, and rally to them in assistance, and lend to Allah a fair loan, indeed I will definitely expiate for you your odious deeds, and indeed I will definitely cause you to enter gardens from beneath which rivers run. So whoever of you disbelieves after that, then he has already erred away from the level way" (TMQ, 5:12).

Hence, what was the result? Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"So, for their breaking their compact, We cursed them and We made their hearts grow hard" (TMQ, 5:13).** Allah (*SWT*) firmly warns us in this ayah against being like those who breached their covenants, or else His wrath and damnation would befall.

The story of Musa (Moses) (*AS*) and his people

The ayahs move on to depict what took place between Musa (*AS*) and the Israelites when they were asked to enter the holy land (Palestine), that *(SWT)* Allah promised for them. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"O my people, enter the Holy Land (literally: the hallowed land) which Allah has prescribed for you and do not turn back in your traces, (literally: on your hind parts) (and) so you turn over as losers". They said, "O Musa, surely there are people in it (who are) giants, and surely we will never enter it until they leave it. So, if they leave it, then surely we will be entering"" (TMQ, 5:21-22)**. They disobeyed and breached their covenant with Allah (*SWT*), and they were consequently punished by Him. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Said He, "Then surely it will be prohibited for them for 40 years (while) they go astray in the earth"" (TMQ, 5:26).** Hence, Allah *(SWT)* denied them the entrance of the holy land for a period of 40 years.

We have previously mentioned that Allah (*SWT*) starts off the surah by saying what can be translated as, **"O you who have believed, fulfill your contracts. The brute of cattle (cattle, camels, sheep and goats) has been made lawful to you" (TMQ, 5:1).** This is to encourage the fulfillment of covenants so that He (*SWT*) would not deprive Muslims of lawful things permitted for the nation. In this story, Allah (*SWT*) tells us that He had set many restrictions on the Israelites because of their violation of their covenants. Thus, the main message of this surah is that if a person honors the covenants, Allah (*SWT*) facilitates things for him. On the other hand, if a person breaches the covenants, Allah (*SWT*) makes things harder for him.

The story of Adam's two sons:

Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And recite to them the tiding of Adam's two sons with the truth as they offered a sacrifice, (literally: sacrificed an all-sanctified sacrifice) (and) it was (graciously) accepted of one of them and not (graciously) accepted of the other" (TMQ, 5:27).** Adam's son killed his brother rashly because of wrath, envy, and hatred. As for the link between the story of Adam's two sons and that of the Israelites and their entrance to the holy land is that both of the stories represent instances of violation of covenants. Whereas the Israelites breached Allah's (*SWT*) covenant because of their cowardice, Adam's son

breached it because of his rashness. Representing the two extremes, both examples lead to the violation of Allah's (*SWT*) covenants. Islam, on the other hand, always advises us to adopt the middle course in all affairs.

Immediately after this story comes the 32nd ayah to comment on it**.** Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"On that account We prescribed for the Israelites that whoever kills a self -other than for (killing another) self or (literally: nor) for corruption in the earth- then it will be as if he had killed mankind altogether; and whoever gives life to it, (i.e., a self) then it will be as if he had given life to mankind altogether" (TMQ, 5:32).**

Thus, after depicting the brutality of murder in Adam's story, Allah *(SWT)* sets out firm regulations in the following ayahs to fight corruption. The ayahs explained the restrictions on man's freedom, on theft, and on the spread of corruption on earth.

It is worth mentioning that the issue of public right has been addressed only recently while the holy Qur'an pioneered in issuing these laws more than 1400 years ago. Allah (*SWT*) explains this clearly in what can be translated as, **"that whoever kills a self -other than for (killing another) self or (literally: nor) for corruption in the earth- then it will be as if he had killed mankind altogether" (TMQ, 5:32).** Therefore, crime is not only a single assault, but also a threat facing the whole society. There is consequently a public right to be preserved.

The sixth call: (strive in the cause of Allah)

Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as**, "O you who have believed, be pious to Allah and seek (close) proximity to Him, and strive in His way, that possibly you would prosper" (TMQ, 5:35).** Thus, after listing the threat of corruption, Allah *(SWT)* orders believers in the 35th ayah to strive in His cause and to fight corruption.

It is worth noting that, in the Qur'an, the decree to carry out *jihad* (striving in the cause of Allah) is always justified. For instance, in surat An-Nisa, *jihad* is declared to support those deemed weak among men, women and newborns. In this respect, Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And what is it with you, that you do not fight in the way of Allah, and (the way) of the ones deemed weak among the men, women and newborns" (TMQ, 4:75).**

The seventh, eighth and ninth call: (Never imitate blindly)

The ayahs reach a new subdivision of the Qur'an to describe three calls for preserving the distinctive Muslim identity. The seventh call is pointed out in the following ayah in which Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"O you who have believed, do not take to yourselves the Jews and the *Nasara* (Christians) as patrons; some of them are patrons to some (others). And whoever of you patronizes them, then surely he is one of them. Surely Allah does not guide the unjust people" (TMQ, 5:51).**

The eighth call is illustrated in the following ayah in which Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"O you who have believed, whoever of you turns back from His (Allah's) religion, then Allah will eventually come up with a people He loves**

and who love Him, humble towards the believers, mightily proud towards the disbelievers, striving in the way of Allah" (TMQ, 5:54).

The ninth call, in its turn, is referred to in the following ayah in which Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"O you who have believed, do not take to yourselves the ones who take your religion in mockery and as a plaything -from among the ones who were brought the Book even before you and (from among) the steadfast disbelievers- as constant patrons" (TMQ, 5:57).**

The previous ayahs do not aim at degrading the other religions, but rather at preserving the Muslim identity. The ayahs are a call to achieve complete allegiance to Islam. Surat Al-Ma'idah does not forbid dealing with the People of The Scripture. This fact is evident in previous ayahs such as the fifth in which Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Today the good things are made lawful for you, and the food of the ones to whom the Book was brought is lawful to you, and your food is made lawful to them. And (so) are believing women in wedlock, and in wedlock women of (the ones) to whom the Book was brought even before you" (TMQ, 5:5).** This ayah permits marriage to women of the People of The Scripture.

Thus, showing tolerance and mercy are recommended in our relationship with the People of The Scripture. Nevertheless, this should not be taken so far as to lead to the loss of the Muslim's identity and his allegiance to Islam. There is a difference between showing respect, tolerance, and compassion for others and fostering productive co-operation on the one hand, and dissolving into the other's identity and, consequently, loosing one's own to the other. Hence, if the seventh and the ninth calls concentrate on forbidding taking disbelievers as patrons and loving them, the eighth call warns against the abandonment of Islam. This, in fact, is one of the most hazardous consequences of the loss of identity.

Notice also that the previous subdivision of the Qur'an warns against judging or ruling by what Allah (*SWT*) has not revealed. This was observed in the following ayahs in which Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as,
"… And whoever does not judge according to what Allah has revealed, then those are they (who are) the disbelievers" (TMQ, 5:44).
"… And whoever does not judge according to what Allah has revealed, then those are they (who are) the unjust" (TMQ, 5:45).
"… And whoever does not judge according to what Allah has revealed, then those are they (who are) the immoral" (TMQ, 5:47).
"Is it then the judgment of (pagan) ignorance that they inequitably seek? And who is fairer in judgment than Allah, for a people having certitude?" (TMQ, 5:50).

The relationship between the above-mentioned ayahs and the three calls in question is that blind imitation of others is the main reason for judging or ruling by what Allah (*SWT*) has not revealed. O youth! Fulfill your obligation of abandoning blind imitation; fulfill your obligations by alleging to your religion and abiding by its decrees and prohibitions.

The gentleness of love

One of the graces of the holy Qur'an lies in the eighth call where Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"O you who have believed, whoever of you turns back from His (Allah's) religion, then Allah will eventually come up with a people He loves and who love Him" (TMQ, 5:54).** The holy Qur'an uses gentleness and love to warn against one of the most dangerous situations one could ever get into: turning back from Islam.

The ayah does not state that those who turn back from Islam will be tormented and placed in hell. Instead, Allah (*SWT*) threatens using the tone of love and not that of hellfire. After the stern statements and commands that are used in the surah comes a gentle call to leave a special effect on the soul.

The tenth call ("Do not prohibit whatever good things Allah has made lawful for you" (TMQ, 5:87)).

Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"O you who have believed, do not prohibit whatever good things Allah has made lawful for you, and do not transgress. Surely Allah does not love the transgressors" (TMQ, 5:87).**

This ayah asks believers not to prohibit what Allah (*SWT*) has made lawful to them. Only Allah (*SWT*) has the right to determine what is lawful and what is not. Allah (*SWT*) prohibits harmful things and allows good and useful things. This notion is confirmed by the ayah that follows in which Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And eat of whatever Allah has provided you, lawful and good, and be pious to Allah, in Whom you are believers" (TMQ, 5:88).**

The link between the tenth call and the second one is that it is sinful to prohibit what's lawful just as it is sinful to permit what's unlawful; it is an act of disobedience to Allah (*SWT*) and an act of changing His decree. Therefore, the characteristics of what's lawful and what's not are gradually being clarified. Thus, every ayah adds a new concept to complete the rules decreed to Muslims.

The eleventh call: **(unlawful drinks)**

After dealing with good things that Allah (*SWT*) made lawful, the ayahs move on to deal with what's forbidden (in the same order presented the first and second ayahs). Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"O you who have believed, surely wine and games of chance, and altars (for idols) and divining (i.e., divination by arrows or in any other way) are only an abomination of Satan's doing, so avoid it, that possibly you would prosper" (TMQ, 5:90).**

Since the surah starts with listing unlawful food, it also has to address what drinks are unlawful since its name is Al-Ma'idah (the table). The main goal here is to warn Muslims against indulging in the prohibited pleasures of life. The ayah invites Muslims to fulfill their pledges in their relationship with Allah (*SWT*) and not to even taste a single drop of wine as alcohol can lead to enmity and hatred among the members of a nation.

Notice that the ayah deals with the issue of wine sternly and associates it to altars and divining that are remnants of polytheism. The objective of this warning is to protect

the nation from this destructive habit. Another remark is that the holy Qur'an uses 'avoid it' to indicate to what extent Islam prohibits and forbids wine drinking.

The twelfth and the thirteenth calls: (Be aware of affliction in what is lawful and what is not)

Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"O you who have believed, indeed Allah will definitely try you with something of the game that your hands and lances attain, that Allah may know who fears Him in the unseen…" (TMQ, 5:94).** This ayah warns Muslims against afflictions they might face and that are meant to test their faith and their application of the constraints of what's lawful and what's not.

This ayah was revealed when the companions were in a state of *ihram* (pilgrim sanctity, i.e. in the sacred precincts or in the sanctified**)**. Allah (*SWT*) was testing them by ordering them not to hunt regardless of the availability of games around them. The ayah that follows confirms the same meaning. In this respect, Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"O you who have believed, do not kill the game (while) you are in pilgrim sanctity (i.e., in the sacred precincts or in the sanctified)" (TMQ, 5:95).** There is an obvious coherence between the beginning and end of the surah in the sense that both focus on hunting regulations.

The fourteenth call: (Do not make things harder for yourselves)

The calls carry on until we reach the point where Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"O you who have believed, do not ask about things which, if were displayed to you, would vex you, and in case you ask about them while the Qur'an is being sent down, they will be displayed to you. Allah has been clement towards them, (i.e., those things) and Allah is Ever-Forgiving, Ever-Forbearing" (TMQ, 5:101).** Allah (*SWT*) reveals in this ayah one of the regulations concerning the issue of the lawful and the unlawful that many people misunderstand. Their narrow knowledge in this field pushes them to take extreme positions. They, as a result, fail to comply with the regulations they made for themselves and thus end up falling in disobedience to Allah (*SWT*). This ayah calls for balance: although Allah (*SWT*) orders us to fulfill covenants, we should not make things harder for ourselves.

There is an amazing connection between these ayahs and the story of the Israelites' cow in surat Al-Baqara. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"A people even before you already asked about them; thereafter they became disbelievers in them" (TMQ, 2:102).** This ayah refers to the excessive questions that previous nations used to pose to their messengers. Their excessive inquiries led to tightening rules, which they eventually disobeyed.

There's an ayah in surat al-Baqara in which Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"So, they slew it, and they had scarcely performed that" (TMQ, 2:71).** The Israelites inquired excessively about the nature and the color of the cow. They asked about things they were not obliged to know about and thus turned an absolute and unrestricted rule into a restricted one.

Prophet Muhammad (SAWS) and his companions is a good example to follow as he once said what can be translated as, "O people, Allah has made hajj obligatory for

you; so perform hajj". Thereupon a person said "Messenger of Allah, (is it to be performed) every year?" He (*SAWS*) kept quiet, and repeated (these words) thrice, whereupon Allah's Messenger (*SAWS*) said "If I were to say "Yes", it would become obligatory (for you to perform it every year) and you would not be able to do it"[23].

In surat Al-Ma'idah, there is clear balance between the adherence to orders and prohibitions, and the fulfillment of obligations to Allah (*SWT*) on one hand and the avoidance of unnecessary restriction of rules on the other.

The fifteenth call: **(Do not be an imitator)**

As the ayahs carry on, we reach another rule concerning what's lawful and what's not**.** Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"O you who have believed, (look) after your (own) selves (literally: upon you are yourselves). He who errs (does not) harm you when you are (rightly) guided" (TMQ, 5:105).**

Abu-Bakr (*RA*) once said in a speech, "you misinterpret this ayah". People misinterpreted the ayah and thought it meant that we are not to help in the guidance of others; those who want to stray from the right path are free to do so. This misconception led to the abandonment of the *da'wa* (missionary activity). However, the ayah really means that even if everyone alters the laws of what's lawful and what's not, and neglects the fulfillment of covenants, believers have to stand firmly and fulfill their covenant. This coincides with Prophet Muhammad's (*SAWS*) saying, which can be translated as, "Let no one of you be an imitator; acting benevolently if people act benevolently and acting badly if people act badly. Rather, if people act benevolently (you should) act benevolently, and if they act badly may you never wrong (people)".[24]

Therefore, in the last two calls, the surah concentrates on two aspects of commands and prohibitions:

-Do not make things harder for yourself.
-Do not be negatively influenced by the surrounding people.

The sixteenth call: **(the lawful and the unlawful in testimony and bequest)** Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"O you who have believed, the testimony between you, when death is present to any of you while bequeathing, shall be two (men) with (i.e. owning) a sense of justice" (TMQ, 5:106).** This ayah comes to complete the series of decrees revealed in the surah. It proves the thoroughness of Islam regarding all daily affairs, starting from food and drink; marriage and family relationships to punishment laws, international relationships, testimony, and bequest.

Let us contemplate again on this ayah that depicts the comprehensiveness of Islam with regards to all daily affairs. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Today I have completed your religion for you, and I have perfected My favor on you,**

[23] Authentic Hadith, narrated by Muslim.
[24] Weak Hadith, narrated by Al-Albani.

and I am satisfied with Islam as a religion for you" (TMQ, 5:3). Thus, be thankful to Allah (*SWT*) for the blessing granted by this religion and its honorable laws.

The legal intents in the surah

Since surat Al-Ma'idah handles the issue of what's lawful and what's not in Islam. It is the only surah that includes the five Islamic legal intents:

- Protection of religion
- Protection of soul
- Protection of mind
- Protection of honor
- Protection of money

This surah, which contains the ayah in which Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Is it then the judgment of (pagan) ignorance that they inequitably seek? And who is fairer in judgment than Allah, for a people having certitude?" (TMQ, 5:50),** clarifies that Allah's (*SWT*) set of decrees is the best guarantee for humanity's well being both in this life and the hereafter.

This is fulfilled through:

1- The protection of religion: Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"O you who have believed, whoever of you turns back from His (Allah's) religion…" (TMQ, 5:54).** Thus, the first issue addressed by the Islamic law is the protection of religion and abandonment of disbelief in Allah (*SWT*).
2- The protection of the soul: Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"On that account We prescribed for the Israelites that whoever kills a self -other than for (killing another) self or (literally: nor) for corruption in the earth- then it will be as if he had killed mankind altogether" (TMQ, 5:32).** Thus, homicide is forbidden.
3- The protection of mind: Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"O you who have believed, surely wine and games of chance, and altars (for idols) and divining (i.e., divination by arrows or in any other way) are only an abomination of Satan's doing, so avoid it, that possibly you would prosper" (TMQ, 5:90)**. The main purpose of the prohibition of wine is the protection of the mind.
4- The protection of honor: Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Today the good things are made lawful for you, and the food of the ones to whom the Book was brought is lawful to you, and your food is made lawful to them. And (so) are believing women in wedlock, and in wedlock women of (the ones) to whom the Book was brought even before you when you have brought them their rewards in wedlock, other than in fornication, neither taking them to yourselves as mates (i.e., girl-friends)" (TMQ, 5:5).** This ayah forbids pre-marital relationships between the two sexes.
5- The protection of money: Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And the male thief and the female thief: then cut (off) the hands of both" (TMQ, 5:38).**

Hence, the five legal intents are mentioned in surat Al-Ma'idah in order to prove that the aim behind adhering to these orders and prohibitions is the welfare of humankind in those five areas.

The revision of covenants on the Day of Judgment

When will the covenants be revised? They will be revised on the Day of Judgment. For this reason, Allah (*SWT*) ends this surah marvelously by saying what can be translated as, **"The day when Allah will gather the Messengers, so He will say, "What answer were you given?" They will say, "We have no knowledge; surely You, Ever You, are the Superb Knower of the (things) unseen"" (TMQ, 5:109).**

What is worth noting here is the coherence that characterizes the ayahs of this surah. At the beginning , Allah (*SWT*) asks us to fulfill obligations. In the middle, he raises the issue of what's lawful and what's not, saying what can be translated as, **"O you Messenger, proclaim whatever has been sent down to you from your Lord" (TMQ, 5:67).** By the end, He (*SWT*) concludes with what can be translated as, **"The day when Allah will gather the Messengers, so He will say, "What answer were you given?"" (TMQ, 5:109).**

The end of the surah takes us to the story of Isa (Jesus) (*AS*). This ayah comes to acquit Isa (*AS*) of all things done by the Christians who strayed away from his path. This is meant to raise again the problem of blind imitation of others. How can you Muslims follow them while Isa (*AS*) himself will renounce them on the Day of Judgment?

In order to encourage people to fulfill their covenants, Allah (*SWT*) refers to the Day of Judgment, saying what can be translated as, **"Allah said, "This is the day the sincere ones will profit from their sincerity (literally: their sincerity will benefit the sincere "ones")" (TMQ, 5:119).** The sincere ones are those who fulfill their covenants with Allah (*SWT*) and people.

Reason behind the title of surat Al-Ma'idah

Finally, we are going to address the reason behind naming the surah as Al-Ma'idah. Is it because the story of the table is told in the surah? The surah mainly discusses the fulfillment of covenants, so what is the link between this issue and the table? Allah (*SWT*) says, what can be translated as, **"As the disciples (the followers of Isa), (also called the apostles) said, "O Isa son of Maryam (Mary), is your Lord able to send down (The Arabic verb implies sending down more than once or in large quantities) upon us a Table from the heaven?" he said, "Be pious to Allah, if you are believers". They said, "We would (like) to eat of it and our hearts be composed; and that we may know that you have already (spoken) to us sincerely and that thereof we may be among the witnesses". Isa son of Maryam said, "O Allah, our Lord, send down upon us a Table from the heaven that will be (for) us a festival, for the first of us and the last (of us), and a sign from You. And provide for us; and You are the Most Charitable of providers". Allah said, "Surely I am sending it down upon you; so, whoever of you hereafter disbelieves, then surely I will torment him with a torment wherewith I do not torment anyone of the worlds" (TMQ, 5:112-115).**

The last ayah is pivotal. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, "**Allah said, "Surely I am sending it down upon you; so, whoever of you hereafter disbelieves, then surely I will torment him with a torment wherewith I do not torment anyone of the worlds" (TMQ, 5:115).** It refers to those who revoked their obligations even after Allah (*SWT*) sent down the table. Thus, the story of the table is related to that of a people who asked Allah (*SWT*) to give them a sign, and so He did. In return, Allah (*SWT*) took an abiding oath from them; an oath, if revoked, would result in severe torment.

As for our nation, Allah (*SWT*) provides it with this central ayah, which can be translated as, **"Today I have completed your religion for you, and I have perfected My favor on you, and I am satisfied with Islam as a religion for you" (TMQ, 5:3).** This ayah represents a divine gift similar to that given to the disciples, the table. The question that arises now is are the Muslims going to fulfill their covenants as the disciples did?

While reading this surah, please try to feel the nobleness of the blessings bestowed upon us by Allah (*SWT*) by completing the religion. Try, also, to tame your desires in order to fulfill the obligations of Allah (*SWT*) in all daily matters.

Surat Al-An'am (The Cattle)

About the surah

Surat Al-An'am is a Makkan surah. It is the first Makkan surah in the Qur'anic order (since all the surahs from surat Al-Baqara until surat Al- Ma'idah are Madinan surahs). It was revealed after surat Al-Hijr and it consists of 165 ayahs.

Cloudless Night

The revelation of this surah was accompanied by many signs of its distinctiveness. Firstly, the entire surah was revealed upon the Prophet (*SAWS*) in one night en bloc, whereas all the long surahs in the Qur'an were revealed sporadically. One of the marvellous signs of the *surah's* exceptionality is the descent of 70 thousand angels glorifying Allah (*SWT)* with a sweet, loud voice on the night it was revealed. How magnificent is this majestic caravan surrounding the descent of this noble surah in the dark of the night. Hence, these signs shed light on the objectives of the surah as well as its contents.

The Objectives of the surah

Surat Al-An'am begins with what can be translated as, **"Praise be to Allah Who created the heavens and the earth" (TMQ, 6:1)**. This ayah is enough to make any Muslim feel the main objective as well as the core idea of the surah from the very beginning. It is to profess belief in the unity of Allah (*SWT)*, to reject polytheism, and to fill your heart with His love and nothing but His love, that this surah was revealed for. This idea of monotheism is repeated 49 times in 49 different ayahs, which is about 30% of the surah. Hence, the reason behind its magnificent revelation and why it is accompanied by 70 thousand angels becomes quite clear. Moreover, the significance of the time of its revelation (night), which is the most appropriate time for such a spiritual atmosphere, becomes manifest.

People Addressed in the surah

Surat Al-An'am comes amidst the different ideologies, methodologies, and ethnicities in the world as a refutation of such fallacies. Whether they were the worship of idols or the forces of nature, as was the case in the age of the Prophet (*SAWS)*, or atheism and denial of Allah's existence in our modern age. Through displaying the universal proofs of Allah's omnipotence and greatness, the surah proves the falseness of such ideas. Thus, it addresses you, believers, in the first place to strengthen your faith, your love for Allah and your sincerity in worshiping Him. Moreover, it gives you the evidence with which you can prove false the claims raised by materialists and atheists, however consistent they may seem to be. This is successfully achieved through a discourse on Allah's omnipotence and the refutation of atheistic claims, such as pantheism or the accidental principle; the belief that the world was created accidentally. It is the incomparable creativity and perfection of the creation of the universe that proves, beyond all doubt, the greatness and oneness of the Creator.

The surah also addresses another group, which corresponds to those who believe in Allah (*SWT)*, yet purposely deviate from practicing the teachings of His religion. Surat Al-An'am explains to this group that faith is indivisible and that it has to be felt in the heart and expressed through actions at the same time. One part without the other will not do. This becomes clear by the end of the surah as well as in the reason behind its name. Consequently, we feel the significance of its revelation all at once, which emphasizes on the integral nature of practice and belief in monotheism.

The Correlation of the surahs of the Ever-Glorious Qur'an

Before tackling the ayahs of the surah, the sequence of the discourse with *Ahl-ul-kitab* (People of The Scripture) throughout the surahs of the Qur'an must be looked upon once more. Each of surat Al-Baqara, Al-'Imran, An-Nisa', and Al-Ma'idah discuss different features of *Ahl-ul-kitab*, leaving the discourse with the atheists (especially Makkan atheists, since the surah itself is Makkan) all to surat Al-An'am.

Another subtle observation about the relation between surat Al-An'am and the surah preceding it (Surat Al-Ma'idah) is that surat Al-Ma'idah ends with what can be translated as, **"To Allah (belongs) the Kingdom of the heavens and the earth and whatever is in them" (TMQ, 5:120),** as if to foreshadow surat Al-An'am which starts with what can be translated as, **"Praise be to Allah Who created the heavens and the earth" (TMQ, 6:1).**

A Couple of Words Flooding the Heart With Love ("Say" and "He is")

Surat Al-An'am follows a specific order strictly; four or five ayahs about Allah's omnipotence occur followed by a set of ayahs challenging materialists, atheists, and pantheists. The surah is revealed in this sequence invariably. It is quite visible that most of its ayahs begin with one of the two words that can be translated as, **"Say", or "He is".** Let us discover the reason behind this repetition as well as the relation between these two phrases and the core of the surah.

Whenever you come across an ayah that begins with what can be translated as, **"He is"**, you will find that it is about Allah's omnipotence. For instance, Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And He is Allah in the heavens and in the earth" (TMQ, 6:3), "And He is (The One) Who takes you up by night" (TMQ, 6:60), "And He is The Vanquisher above His bondmen" (TMQ, 6:61),** and **"And He is (The One) Who created the heavens and the earth..." (TMQ, 6:73)**. As for confrontational ayahs, which address the Prophet (*SAWS)* as well as every believer, they all illustrate ways of refuting atheistic claims. They positively begin with **"Say, "Which thing is greatest in testimony?" Say, "Allah is Ever- Witnessing between me and you" (TMQ, 6:19), "Say, "Who safely delivers you from the darkness(es) of the land and the sea?" (TMQ, 6:63), "Say, Allah safely delivers you from them and from every agony" (TMQ, 6:64), "Say, "He is The Determiner over sending forth upon you a torment, from above you or from beneath your legs, (i.e., under your feet)" (TMQ, 6:65)**, and **"Say, "Shall we invoke, apart from Allah, that which neither profits nor harms us" (TMQ, 6:71).** It is almost as if the ayahs are addressing readers telling them to first feel who the Omnipotent is until their hearts are filled with His love, then confront those who raise doubts about their belief in the Oneness and Greatness of Allah (*SWT)*.

Having been interested by and more than sufficiently introduced to the surah, it is time to take a close look at the confrontational as well as divine omnipotence ayahs of the surah.

A Flow of Ayahs of Omnipotence Commence the surah

Surat Al-An'am begins with three ayahs that equally indicate the omnipotence of Allah (*SWT).* Allah (*SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Praise be to Allah Who created the heavens and the earth, and made darkness(es) and light, thereafter the ones who have disbelieved unjustly set up equals (Or: rivals) to their Lord. He is (The One) Who created you of clay, thereafter He decreed a term, and a term is stated in His Sight…" (TMQ, 6:1-2),** then **"And He is Allah in the heavens and in the earth. He knows your secret and your speaking aloud and He knows whatever you are earning" (TMQ, 6:3),** and **"So they already cried lies to the Truth as soon as it came to them. Then the tidings of whatever they used to mock will eventually come up to them" (TMQ, 6:5).**

All these ayahs inspire readers to feel the omnipotence of Allah (*SWT).* Hence, if atheists turn their backs in denial, readers will feel the hideousness of their sins and the extent of their aberration and will, therefore, have a good reason to confront them with the ayahs of the surah.

Time and Place

One can observe the gentle indication included in the following two ayahs. Allah (*SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Say, "To whom (belongs) whatever is in the heavens and the earth?" Say, "To Allah."" (TMQ, 6:12),** then comes **"And to Him belongs whatever rests in the night and the daytime" (TMQ, 6:13)**. The first ayah indicates that Allah (*SWT)* is the Owner of the place **"the heavens and the earth"** and the second ayah indicates that He is the Owner of "**the night and the daytime**", the owner of the time. Glorified be Allah (*SWT)* Who has created the time and the place and has subjugated them to His Sovereignty.

What is the Sign?

Read this magnificent confrontational ayah bearing in mind Allah's ownership of time and place; **"Say, "Shall I take to myself as constant patron other than Allah, The Originator (Literally: The Renderer) of the heavens and the earth, and He is (The One) Who feeds, and is not fed?" Say, "Surely I have been commanded to be the first of the ones who have surrendered" (i.e. who have become Muslims) and definitely do not be of the associators (i.e., those who associate others with Allah). Say, "Surely I fear, in case I disobey my Lord, the torment of a tremendous Day." From whomever it is turned about (i.e., it "torment" is turned away) upon that Day, then He will have mercy on him; and that is the evident triumph" (TMQ, 6:14-16).** These ayahs guide us to knowledge and true belief by liberating us Muslims from all forms of polytheism or fear of any creatures.

Please note that the verb phrase **"Say"** invariably occurs after **"He is",** as if to tell us to first identify Allah (*SWT*) and fill our hearts with His love, then react to the claims of atheists and say who He is.

A confrontational Incident

A group of disbelievers came to the Prophet (*SAWS)* asking him to provide them with a proof of his Prophethood, and of Allah's oneness, claiming that they have already asked the Jews who claimed that they had no proof to offer. In response to that comes ayah 19 of surat Al-An'am; **"Say, "Which thing is greatest in testimony?" Say, "Allah is Ever- Witnessing between me and you; and this Qur'an has been revealed to me to warn you thereby and whomever it reaches." Do you surely bear witness indeed that there are other gods with Allah?" Say, "I do not bear witness." Say, "Surely He is only One God, and surely I (myself) am quit of whatever you associate (with Him)" (TMQ, 6:19)**. After Allah's testimony, what else can be trusted?!

Though surat Al-An'am mainly addresses polytheists, as has already been mentioned, ayah 20 encloses a hint at the Jews who denied having a witness for the Prophethood of Muhammad (*SAWS)*; **"The ones to whom We have brought the Book recognize it (just) as they recognize their sons" (TMQ, 6:20).**

The Day of Judgment: Live Scenes

The ayahs would sometimes make you visualize the scenes being described and almost hear the sounds of the people in it. Here they are, standing in front of the gates of hell; **"And if you could see (them) as they are made to stand against the Fire, so they say, "Oh, would that we might be turned back, and (then) we would not cry lies to the signs of our Lord, and we would be among the believers!"" (TMQ, 6:27)**. The ayahs then take you to a most sublime situation which was always denied by disbelievers; facing the Compeller of heavens and earth. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And if you could see (them) as they are made to stand against their Lord! He will say, "Is not this (ever) the Truth?" They will say, "Yes indeed by our Lord!" He will say, "Then taste the torment because you used to disbelieve."" (TMQ, 6:30).** Look at those sinful and immoral people who are burdened by their wrongdoings and how they are extremely tired of bearing their burdens on their backs. Just visualize them as Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"…And they will be carrying their encumbrances (Literally: whatever "they are encumbered with") on their backs. Verily odious are the encumbrances they bear!" (TMQ, 6:31).**

Patience and Steadiness in Confrontation

The ayahs do not only provide the Prophet (*SAWS*) and all *Da'wa* (missionary activities) activists with sufficient evidence and proofs to challenge disbelievers with, but they also sustain them with the power to be steadfast in spite of the disappointment and frustration they might face. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And indeed Messengers were already mocked at even before you; then what they were scoffing at redounded upon the ones who mocked at them" (TMQ, 6:10)**. He (*SWT*) also says what can be translated as, **"And Messengers even**

before you were indeed already cried lies to, (yet) they were patient against what they were cried lies to (i.e., patient with what they were accused of lying about) and were hurt, until Our victory came up to them…" (TMQ, 6:34).

Yet, the epitome of this exceedingly supportive string of ayahs is found in the following ayah; **"We already know that surely it indeed grieves you (the things) they say. Yet surely they do not cry lies to you, but the unjust (people) repudiate the signs of Allah" (TMQ, 6:33).** O Muhammad (*SAWS)*, these people do not accuse your person of lying as much as they deny the ayahs of Allah (*SWT*) and He will support you against them.

Moving Words

The surah follows the same pattern throughout its ayahs; an ayah of Allah's omnipotence followed by a confrontational ayah. In this sequence comes a magnificent ayah of omnipotence in which Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And in no way is there a beast (moving) in the earth nor a bird flying with its two wings except that they are nations like you. In no way have We neglected anything whatever in the Book..." (TMQ, 6:38).**

When disbelievers deny the words of Allah (*SWT*), a stream of thunderous ayahs comes to confront them. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Say, "Have you seen (for) yourselves, in case the torment of Allah comes up to you or the Hour comes up to you, will you invoke any other than Allah, in case you are (truly) sincere?" (TMQ, 6:40).** Allah warns them against the consequences of transgression and excessive sinfulness in order to avoid the retribution that Allah (*SWT*) exacted on disbelievers in times gone by; **"So, as soon as they forgot what they were reminded of, We opened upon them the gates of everything, until when they exulted with what was brought to them, We took them (away) suddenly; then lo, they were dumbfounded" (TMQ, 6:44).**

Another stream of confrontational ayahs starting with the word **"Say"** takes the lead, **"Say, "Have you seen (that) in case Allah takes away your hearing and your be holdings, (Literally: eye-sights) and seals your hearts, who is a god other than Allah to come up with them (back) to you?" (i.e., bring them "back" to you) Look how We propound the signs; thereafter they turn aside. Say, "Have you seen for yourselves? In case the torment of Allah comes up to you suddenly or openly, will any be perished except the unjust people?" (TMQ, 6:46-47).** The context of the ayahs softens hearts and fills them with a desire to be close to Allah (*SWT).*

A New Way of Confrontation

As the ayahs came to assist the Prophet (*SAWS)* in his *Da'wa* and confrontation with his people, they start to change their methods in order to meet the Prophet's needs *(SAWS).* For instance, ayah 57 encloses a new approach; **"Say, "Surely I am on a supreme evidence from my Lord and you have cried lies to it..." (TMQ, 6:57).** The ayah accentuates basic dogmatic beliefs and great self-confidence that unsettle opponents, a useful *Da'wa* method that can be learnt from the surah.

Allah's Inclusive Knowledge and Omnipotence

Now a new stream of ayahs about Allah's omnipotence is related in an affecting tone; **"And in His Providence are the keys of the Unseen; none knows them except He. And He knows whatever is in the land and the sea. And in no way does a leaf fall down, except that He knows it, and not a grain in the darkness (es) of the earth, not a thing wet or dry, except that it is in an evident Book" (TMQ, 6:59).** It's almost as if you can actually see the leaf falling in a desert, or atop a mountain, and the grain in the bottom of the sea.

Who can demand human souls but Allah (*SWT)* who says what can be translated as, **"And He is (The One) Who takes you up by night, and He knows whatever you indulge in by daytime..." (TMQ, 6:60).** How come his oneness is denied? How can anybody deny it? Who possesses the comprehensive knowledge of his creatures and their quantities but Allah (*SWT)* who says what can be translated as, **"And He is The Vanquisher above His bondmen, and He sends preservers over you..." (TMQ, 6:61),** which are the angels guarding and inscribing all of one's good and bad deeds.

Who rescues people from the horrors of land and sea but Allah (*SWT*) who says what can be translated as, **"Say, "Who safely delivers you from the darkness (es) of the land and the sea?..." (TMQ, 6:63)**. How come his oneness is denied? How can anybody deny it?

Hence, anyone who shows or feels any signs of denial will be sufficiently answered and thus reassured and his doubts will be effectively refuted. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Say, "He is The Determiner over sending forth upon you a torment, from above you or from beneath your legs, (i.e., under your feet)..." (TMQ, 6:65)**. Who can escape His omnipotence or hide from His inclusive knowledge?

A believer reading surat Al-An'am would be completely moved by the setting of the scene in which the surah was revealed; a nocturnal scene in which a troop of angels descend with the surah. A believer would almost hear the soft voices of the angels glorifying Allah (*SWT)* in this surah. The surah's context causes a paradigm shift in the human view point, elevating man to the realm of the heavens and earth, day and night, land and sea, sun, moon and stars. It introduces human beings to paradise, showing them the kingdom of Allah (*SWT*) from one ayah of omnipotence to another, until it reaches the following ayah; **"And He is (The One) Who created the heavens and the earth with the Truth; and the day He says, "Be!" and it is. His Saying is the Truth, and His is the Kingdom the Day the Trumpet will be blown; He is The Knower of the Unseen and the Witnessed; and He is The Ever-Wise, The Ever-Cognizant" (TMQ, 6:73).**

A Pious Trip: Prophet Ibrahim (*AS)* "Abraham" and His People

The surah then starts to relate the story of Prophet Ibrahim (*AS)* and his meditation upon the universal indications of Allah's omnipotence in the same omnipotence-confrontation pattern the surah has been following throughout. The story of Ibrahim (*AS)* cannot be considered separate from the order of the surah. On the contrary, it is employed to realize its main objective. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as,

"And thus We show Ibrahîm (Abraham) the dominion of the heavens and the earth that he may be of the ones of constant certitude. So as soon as the night outspread over him, he saw a planet. He said, "This is my Lord." Then, as soon as it set, (Literally: waned, faded) he said, "I do not love the setting (things)"" (TMQ, 6:75-76). It is the same chain of order in the surah in the sense that Ibrahim contemplates upon the signs of Allah's omnipotence. Furthermore, Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Then, as soon as he saw the sun emerging, he said, "This is my Lord, this is greater." Yet as soon as it set, he said, "O my people, surely I am quit of whatever you associate (with Allah)" (TMQ, 6:78)**. Indeed, there is no room for doubt about the great magnitude of the Lord of the universe that exceeds all limits. Thus, Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Surely I have directed my face to Him Who originated (i.e., created) the heavens and the earth, unswervingly upright, (i.e., by nature upright) and in no way am I one of the associators." (i.e., those who associate others with Allah)" (TMQ, 6:79).**

After this presentation of the signs of omnipotence, the ayahs shift to the confrontation; **"Do you argue with me concerning Allah, and He has already guided me?…" (TMQ, 6:80).** Still, Ibrahim emphasizes the Oneness of Allah. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"…And I do not fear what you associate with Him, except my Lord will decide anything" (TMQ, 6:80).** Hence**,** Allah (*SWT*) praises this method in *Da'wa* in what can be translated as, **"And that is Our Argument, (which) We brought Ibrahîm (Abraham) against his people..." (TMQ, 6:83).**

The incomparable beauty of the Qur'an is complemented by the repetition of the stories of Prophets throughout it. The repetition, however, does not render the Qur'an redundant. On the contrary, each repetition has an indispensable function in that each repetition functions to fulfill the objectives of the surah it occur in, in a unique way.

For instance, surat Al-An'am presents a specific part of Prophet Ibrahim's (*AS*) story that happens to be his contemplation upon the miracles of Allah (*SWT*) in the universe. Prophet Ibrahim (*AS*) applies the method of omnipotence and confrontation in his *Da'wa* to Allah (*SWT*). Please notice that the part where Prophet Ibrahim (*AS*) is thrown in the fire is not mentioned here, but yet the Prophet's story still supports the objective of the surah.

A strong-Worded Warning of Polytheism

As a comment on the story of Ibrahim (*AS*), comes a crucial ayah that warns against polytheism. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"The ones who have believed and have not confounded their belief with injustice, to those belong the (true) security, and they are right-guided" (TMQ, 6:82).**

When that ayah was revealed, the Prophet's companions said, "O Allah's Apostle! Who is there amongst us who has not done wrong to himself?" He (*SAWS*) replied, "It is not as you say, for 'wrong' in the ayah and 'do not confuse their belief, with wrong means 'SHIRK' (i.e. joining others in worship with Allah (*SWT*)). Haven't you heard Luqman's saying to his son, "**O my son, do not associate (others) with Allah.**

Surely associating (others with Allah) is indeed a monstrous injustice" (TMQ, 31:13)" [25].

Even in the ayahs about Prophets, who are the closest of all to Allah (*SWT*), the punishment of polytheism is clearly stated. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"...and if they associated anything (with Him), indeed whatever they were doing would be frustrated for them" (TMQ, 6:88).**

Omnipotence and Confrontation in the Same Ayah

Ayah 91 contains one of the most magnificent proofs of Allah's omnipotence; **"And in no way have they estimated Allah His true estimate as they said, "In no way has Allah sent down anything on any mortal..."." (TMQ, 6:91)**

One day, the Prophet (*SAWS)* recited this ayah to his companions and then said, "The Mighty Lord, the Exalted and Glorious would take hold of the Heavens and earth in His hand. Allah (*SWT*) in this ayah is glorifying himself saying 'I am the sovereign. I am the Holy one' ". The Prophet (*SAWS)* kept reiterating the most beautiful names of Allah so his companions looked at the pulpit, which was shaking with the Prophet (*SAWS)* above it, affected by the glory and greatness of Allah (*SWT*)[26]. The very inanimate wood actually sensed the glory of Allah (*SWT*) when there are still human beings among us whose hearts are never moved by the glory of Allah (*SWT*), not even out of fear. These people are confronted in the second part of the same ayah 91. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"...Say, "Who sent down the Book that Mûsa (Moses) came with (as) a light and a guidance to mankind? ... Say, " Allah." Thereafter leave them out, playing in their wading (i.e., plunge in vain discourse)" (TMQ, 6:91).**

A Return to the Ayahs of Omnipotence: Cannot You Feel His Love?

The ayahs here (95-103) flow with manifestations of Allah's omnipotence and extraordinary creativity; **"Surely Allah is The Splitter of the grains and nuclei Also: date-pits, fruit stones and other kernels). He brings out the living from the dead, and He is The Bringer out of the dead from the living. That (Literally: those) is Allah; then, however are you diverged (into falsehood)? The Splitter of the daybreak, and He has made the night for rest, and the sun and moon to all-reckoned (courses). That is the determining of The Ever-Mighty, The Ever-Knowing" (TMQ, 6:95-96)**. Through these ayahs, Allah (*SWT*) demonstrates His omnipotence in two different examples; once as the One who causes the seed-grain and fruit-stone to split and sprout though it is of tiny size, and once as the Splitter of the daybreak through the darkness of the endless night.

Indeed, the surah touches the genuine human nature which knows well its Creator and believes in His Oneness even though it is buried under our mundane lives. Yet this heap of polytheism sometimes obscures this human nature, obstructing it from prevailing. Surat Al-An'am comes to activate this nature and wipe the dust of polytheism off this nature to enable it to return to Allah (*SWT*) and to believe in His

[25] Authentic Hadith, Al-Bukhari.
[26] Authentic Hadith, Muslim.

Oneness. For this reason, Allah (*SWT*) addresses polytheists in what can be translated as, **"The Ever-Innovating of the heavens and the earth-however does He have a child, and He has no female companion, and He created everything, and He is Ever-Knowing of everything?" (TMQ, 6:101)**. Is there anyone who can argue against that?! Allah (*SWT*) alone creates and excels. He is the Omnipotent, the One Who has no match or partner. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"The Ever-Innovating of the heavens and the earth-however does He have a child, and He has no female companion, and He created everything, and He is Ever-Knowing of everything? That is Allah, your Lord, there is no god except He, the Creator of everything. So worship Him; and He is an Ever-Trusted Trustee over everything. Beholdings (i.e., eyesights) cannot perceive Him, and He perceives be holdings and He is The Ever-Kind, The Ever-Cognizant" (TMQ, 6:101-103)**. These ayahs prepare for the following crucial ayah which can be translated as, **"Demonstrations have already come to you from your Lord..." (TMQ, 6:104).**

Hence, throughout the ayahs the evidence of Allah's Greatness, Power, and Omnipotence become crystal clear. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"…so whoever beholds, it is for his own good, (Literally: foe his "own" self) and whoever is blind, it is to his own harm, (Literally: upon his "own" self)" (TMQ, 6:104).** Whoever believes will be the winner and whoever disbelieves shows the real blindness; the blindness of the heart which is far worse than that of the eyes.

In order to show the difference between faith and disbelief, the surah uses different examples and similes. In the previous ayah (104), for instance, atheism is likened to blindness, while in ayah (122) the comparison far exceeds this; Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And is he who was deceased, then We gave him life and made for him a light to walk by among mankind, as one whose likeness is in the darkness (es), (and) he is not coming out of them? Thus whatever the disbelievers were doing was adorned (i.e., made attractive) for them" (TMQ, 6:122).**

Now after going through all these marvelous ayahs that evince Allah's Oneness, how can the state of a disbeliever be described? Definitely, he is like the dead. Yet, the mercy of Allah (*SWT*) is still there to give him another chance to return to the right path and revive himself once again. Moreover, Allah (*SWT*) will grant him a light of belief by which he can walk amongst men sunk in darkness to guide them to the right path. What a touching example compared to those who were destined to live in the darkness of disbelief, who do not even think of getting out of it. Instead, their disbelief is always gorgeously decorated and fancied to them.

Reason behind the title: Professing to the belief in the Oneness of Allah in both intention and action

A final question remains: Why is this surah named Al-An'am?

Al-an'am refers to the cattle people pasture and eat; yet what is the connection between *al-an'am* and a surah that talks about the belief in the Oneness of Allah (*SWT*)? The correlation between them is profound. The surah deals with the belief in the unity of Allah (*SWT*) and warns people of restricting this belief to the reiteration of "I profess to the belief in the unity of Allah" to oneself while their lives do not

attest to that. Rather, one should profess to the belief in the unity of Allah in terms of both intention and practice.

Many profess to the belief in the unity of Allah (*SWT*) and would affirm to that, and there is no room for doubt about their belief. Nevertheless, if we were to examine their life and whether they follow Allah's decrees in all aspects, we would find things quite different.

Professing to the belief in the unity of Allah (*SWT*) must not be in terms of intention only. Instead, we must profess to that belief in terms of all our behaviors as well as our daily life.

The surah was named as such because the people of Arabia used to consider cattle as their primary resource and as a necessity for their life. Hence, they dealt with it as their own, and claimed that Allah (*SWT*) had nothing to do with it. Allah (*SWT*) says, what can be translated as**, "And they made for Allah of whatever tillage and cattle that He propagated, an assignment; so they said, "This is for Allah", according to their assertion, and, "This is for our associates" (i.e., what they associate with Allah). So, whatever is for their associates does not get to Allah, and whatever is for Allah, then (this is what) gets to their associates. Odious is whatever (way) they judge!"(TMQ, 6:136).**

Allah (*SWT*) then says, what can be translated as**, "And they have said, "These are cattle (Arabic an'aam includes cattle, camels, sheep and goats) and tillage sacrosanct; none shall feed on them except whom we decide", according to their assertion, and cattle whose backs have been prohibited, and cattle over which they do not mention the name of Allah, fabricating (lies) against (Him). He will soon recompense them for whatever they were fabricating. And they have said, "What is within the bellies of these cattle is exclusively for our males and prohibited to our spouses; and in case it is dead, then they shall be partners in it". He will soon recompense them for their describing; surely He is Ever-Wise, Ever-Knowing" (TMQ, 6:138-139).**

Therefore, this can be regarded as a warning against professing to the belief in the Oneness of Allah (*SWT*) in terms of intention only, without it affecting application aspects. Thus, beware of professing to the belief in the Oneness of Allah (*SWT*) in terms of intention only, while contradicting it with your actions. That is why Allah (*SWT*) chose this example of incorrect application to name the surah. He has done it so that one would become fearful and question his application every time he reads the ayahs dealing with the belief in the unity of Allah and prohibiting polytheism.

The path of safety

Since professing to the belief in the Oneness of Allah (*SWT*) encompasses both intention and application, the surah concludes with what can be translated as, **"Say, "Surely my prayer, and my rites, and my living, and my dying are for Allah, The Lord of the worlds. No associate has He; and this I am commanded, and I am the first of the Muslims" (Literally: of the ones who have surrendered to Allah). Say, "Shall I inequitably seek other than Allah for Lord and He is the Lord of**

everything?" And every self earns nothing except what is to its own account" (TMQ, 6:162-164).

He Who has this ability is most worthy of pure professing to the belief in His unity in terms of all intellectual, spiritual, and practical aspects of our lives. All of these notions are summarized in three core ayahs of the encounter present throughout the entire surah. They can be translated as,

- **"Say, "Shall I take to myself as constant patron other than Allah, The Originator (Literally: The Renderer) of the heavens and the earth"" (TMQ, 6:14)**;
- **"(say,) "Then, shall I inequitably seek other than Allah for arbiter, and He is (The One) Who has sent down to you the Book (clearly) expounded?"" (TMQ, 6:114);**
- **"Say, "Shall I inequitably seek other than Allah for Lord and He is the Lord of everything?" (TMQ, 6:164)**.

The above-mentioned ayahs focus on the three core ideas of the belief in the Oneness of Allah: the belief in the Oneness of Allah in terms of the Oneness of His Lordship, in terms of love, and in terms of appealing to His *shari'a* (Islamic law).

The ending of the surah: The succession

Allah (*SWT*) stresses, through the ayahs of this surah, on His ownership of the earth, His creativity of its creation, and His absolute authority. He then gave us the earth and made us successors on it. Allah says in what can be translated as, **"And He is (The One) Who made you succeeding each other (in) the earth" (TMQ, 6:165).**

Notice here the nice gesture linking the objective of surat Al-An'am and that of surat Al-Baqara (our responsibility for the earth). Moreover, the ending of this surah prepares us for surat Al-A'raf, which deals with the struggle between right and wrong on the earth. This can be observed in the ayah that can be translated as, **"…and has raised some of you above others (Literally: above "some" others) in degrees, that He may try you in what He has brought you" (TMQ, 6:165).**

One can notice the relationship between these wonderful three surahs, as if they all send one unified message: O Muslims, now that you understand the importance of professing to the belief in the unity of Allah in terms of both intention and application (Surat Al-An'am), Allah (*SWT*) is giving you this earth to apply His *shari'a* in practice. Consequently, you, Muhammad's nation, are responsible for the earth (Surat Al-Baqara), so where do you stand in the struggle between right and wrong over succession (Surat Al-A'raf)?

Surat Al-A'raf (The Battlements)

Surat Al-A'raf is Makkan, and was revealed after surat Saad. It follows surat Al-An'am in the Qur'an and consists of 206 ayahs.

The strikes of right against wrong

This surah was revealed at a time when the combat between the Muslims and the disbelievers was fierce, specifically when the Prophet (*SAWS*)[27] ordered the Muslims to publicize the *da'wa* (missionary activity). This was a new phase; a phase of publicity and confrontation, when perhaps some people would have feared harm or embarrassment. The surah was revealed in these conditions and in such an atmosphere to talk about the conflict between right and wrong, and to point out that this struggle is a permanent and everlasting universal rule, which existed since the beginning of creation and will continue until the Day of Judgment.

The surah begins with the struggle between Adam (*AS*) and Satan with the beginning of creation, and follows that by the conversation between the dwellers of *jannah* (paradise) and those of hell. Hence, this struggle results in having a group in *jannah* and another in hell. Afterwards, the surah draws a timeline depicting, throughout the history of mankind, the struggle between each Prophet and his people. At the end of the struggle, the unjust people were always annihilated due to their corruption. In each section of the surah you are being asked: Where do you stand in this conflict? Determine your position.

This core idea perfectly suited the Prophet's companions' conditions in Makka. Furthermore, it suits people in every time and place. A struggle between right and wrong will exist in every era, at the level of countries and nations, as well as on the personal level, between man and oneself.

Perhaps, You are the reason!

The objective that the surah's events and notions revolve around is the necessity of determining a position in the struggle. O Muslims, you must determine your standing: Which group do you choose to be among? Do not remain passive.

This notion clearly appears in the stories of the Prophets that are encountered in this surah. The surah focuses on the separation between the believers, who were saved by Allah (*SWT*), and the disbelievers. However, it does not mention any passive category because man basically must have a determined position in life.

For example, Nuh's (Noah) story is concluded by what can be translated as, **"So they cried him lies; then We delivered him, and the ones with him, in the ship(s), and We drowned (the ones) who cried lies to Our signs; surely they were a wilfully blind people" (TMQ, 7:64)**.

As for Hud's (*AS*) story, Allah says, what can be translated as, **"So We delivered him, and the ones with him, by a mercy from Us; and We cut off the last trace of**

[27] All Prayers and Blessings of Allah be upon him

(the ones) who cried lies to Our signs and in no way were they believers" (TMQ, 7:72).

With regard to Lut's (Lot) story, Allah says, what can be translated as**, "And in no way was the answer of his people (anything) except that they said, "Drive them out of your town; surely they are a folk who constantly purify themselves". So We delivered him and his family, except his wife" (TMQ, 7:82- 83)**.

With regard to Shu'ayb's (*AS*) story, Allah says, what can be translated as**, "The chiefs who waxed proud among his people said, "Indeed we will definitely drive you out, O Shu'ayb, and the ones who have believed with you, from our town, or (else) you indeed will definitely go back to our creed"" (TMQ, 7:88)**.

With regard to Saleh's (*AS*) story, Allah says, what can be translated as, **"The chiefs who waxed proud from among his people said to whomever were deemed weak, to whomever of them believed, "Do you know that Saleh is an Emissary from his Lord?" They said, "Surely in whatever he has been sent with, we are believers"" (TMQ, 7:75)**.

All the previous ayahs share the same perspective; you either become among the believers or among the disbelievers. There is no room for passive groups in the above-mentioned stories.

"…so let there be no restriction in your breast " (TMQ, 7:2).

The beginning of the surah clearly proclaims that above-mentioned notion. Allah says, what can be translated as, **"A Book sent down to you, (i.e., the Prophet) so let there be no restriction in your breast on account of it" (TMQ, 7:2)**. You are required to publicize the teachings of Islam, and should not allow anyone's gaze or criticisms make you feel ashamed of it. Sometimes, some are embarrassed to reveal righteousness owing to the power of wrongness or its spread.

Likewise, a Muslim woman should never feel ashamed of her *hijab* (veil), and a Muslim should never fear people's harm. Therefore, the true Muslim has to determine his cause and settle his issues, because Allah (*SWT*) says at the beginning of the surah, what can be translated as, **"…so let there be no restriction in your breast on account of it, that you may warn thereby" (TMQ, 7:2)**. Those ayahs, as we pointed out earlier, are a symbol of the beginning of the public *da'wa* phase.

The third ayah of this surah emphasizes the same notion. Allah says, what can be translated as, **"Closely follow what has been sent down to you (i.e. the believers) from your Lord, and do not ever follow patrons apart from Him" (TMQ, 7:3)**. This is an assertive request to follow righteousness immediately and without hesitation, passiveness, or consideration of the other paths.

Adam (*AS*) and *Iblis* (Satan): "So he misled them both by delusion" (TMQ, 7:22)

The ayahs 7:20-7:22 describe the struggle between Adam (*AS*) and *Iblis* since the beginning of mankind. Thus, how did *Iblis* mislead Adam and Hawa' (Eve)? That is portrayed in what can be translated as, **"So he misled them both by delusion"**

(TMQ, 7:22). *Iblis*' method of seduction was to leave them in a state of perplexity and indecision; hence the usage of the word *fa'adallahuma* (he misled them), which relates to the one who hangs his bucket into a well then leaves it in the middle without deciding its position. Therefore, positive action and determination of one's position are some of the strongest soldiery of righteousness, whereas passivity and hesitation are the paths of disobedience, even if followed by a believer.

Nakedness: *Iblis*' weapon

Notice *Iblis*' focus on one type of corruption, which is nakedness. This is expressed in what can be translated as, **"Then *ash-shaytan* (the all-vicious, i.e., the devil) whispered to them (both) to display to them that which was overlaid (i.e., hidden) from them of their shameful parts" (TMQ, 7:20)**. As a result, **"…as soon as they (both) tasted the tree, their shameful parts appeared to them" (TMQ, 7:22)**.

Hence came the divine decree to cover up, and the warning against all facets of exposing private parts, in what can be translated as**, "O Seed (or: sons) of Adam! We have readily sent down on you a garment to overlay your shameful parts, and a vesture (fine clothes; or feathers)" (TMQ, 7:26).** Allah also says, what can be translated as, **"O Seeds (or: sons) of Adam! Definitely do not let *ash-shaytan* tempt you just as he brought your parents (literally: your two fathers) out of the Garden, plucking out from them (both) their garments to show them their shameful parts" (TMQ, 7:27).** Furthermore, Allah says, what can be translated as, **"O Seeds (or: sons) of Adam! Take your adornment at every mosque" (TMQ, 7:31).**

You should, therefore, learn from this surah. Haven't you noticed the number of warning in these ayahs? Learn from this surah that you have to cover up your private parts and to lower your gaze. Young women must learn chastity and decency, and determine their position on *hijab* without hesitation.

Nakedness is *Iblis*' weapon ever since the beginning of mankind. Its proliferation aids the propagation of vices and facilitates disobedience. As a result, Allah (*SWT*) comments on Adam's (*AS*) story by what can be translated as, **"Say, "My Lord has only prohibited obscenities (i.e. abominations, unlawful sexual intercourse), whatever of (these) are outward and whatever are inward"" (TMQ, 7:33).**

No third party

The surah divides people into two categories: dwellers of *jannah* and dwellers of hell.

It takes us afar to the Day of Judgment, as if we could hear the conversation taking place between the two parties. Allah says, what can be translated as, **"And the companions (i.e., inhabitants) of the *jannah* will call out to the companions of hellfire, (saying) "We have already found whatever our Lord promised us true; then have you found whatever your Lord promised true?" They will say, "Yes." Then an announcer will announce between them, "The curse of Allah be on the unjust" (TMQ, 7:44).**

There are, therefore, only two dwellings, and there's no place for a third. Hence the presence of a decisive word, in the following ayah, which separates both parties conclusively. The ayah says, what can be translated as, **"And between them is a curtain" (TMQ. 7:46)**.

Are you still hesitant? Haven't you determined your position yet? Listen then to this appeal, which can be translated as, **"And the companions of hellfire will call out to the companions of the *jannah* (saying), "Downpour on us some water, or some of whatever Allah has provided you". They will say, "Surely Allah has prohibited both to the disbelievers"" (TMQ, 7:50).** Choose for yourself either destiny and either place.

Reason behind the title

Allah (*TWT*[28]) says, what can be translated as, **"And between them is a curtain, and on the battlements are men who recognize (them) all by their mark" (TMQ, 7:46)**. This indicates that there are people on *al-A'raf* (the battlements) between the *jannah* and hellfire, whom know the dwellers of both. Those on *al-A'raf* call the dwellers of the *jannah* as indicated in what can be translated as, **"…and they will call out to the companions of the *jannah*, "Peace be upon you!" They have not (yet) entered it, and they long (Or: are eager) for that" (TMQ, 7:46).**

They fear hellfire, which is expressed in what can be translated as, **"And when their beholdings (i.e., their eyes) are turned about towards the companions of hellfire, they will say, "Our Lord, do not make us among the unjust people". And the companions of the battlements will call out to men they recognize by their mark. They will say, "In no way has your gathering (i.e., your amassing, and your multitude) availed you, neither whatever you used to wax proud of"" (TMQ, 7:47-48).**

Who are then the people of *al-A'raf*? They are those whose good deeds and sins have scaled equal because they have not determined their positions and actions in life. Since retribution and reward correspond to the nature of the deed, they will be stranded on elevated walls called *al-A'raf,* somewhere between the *jannah* and hellfire to overlook both places.

Hesitant people include many types of people and so, there will be a number of battlements and not just one. Make sure you will not be among them. O my Muslim brother/sister, take the initiative to follow the right path and do not become one of those on *al-A'raf*. Determine your position for you might even be deprived of being among those on *al-A'raf*, in case of a terrible ending, may Allah (*SWT*) forbid.

Stories of the Prophets; a schema of the struggle throughout history

To emphasize on the messages it conveys, the surah narrates the stories of five of Allah's Prophets and their confrontations with their people. These messages are:

1. The struggle between right and wrong is enduring and will never cease.
2. Wrongness will certainly be vanquished.

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[28] *TWT=Tabaraka Wa Ta`ala* = Most Blessed Most High.

3. Wrongness will be defeated because it is distant from Allah (*SWT*), and because of corruption in its different forms: moral, economic and social.

It is evident that these stories are mentioned several times in the Qur'an, so why are they more distinguished here? Their presence serves the surah's objective of determining the position in the struggle through:

- Revealing that the elements of confrontation between all the Prophets and their peoples were almost the same; in some cases even using the same words. This is all to prove that the struggle is ancient and that it repeats itself with different individuals and different nations. All the Prophets had the same *da'wa*, which is pointed out in the ayah that can be translated as, **"… O my people! Worship Allah. In no way do you have any god other than He"(TMQ, 7:59**). It can also be seen in the ayah that can be translated as, **"I constantly proclaim to you the messages of my Lord" (TMQ, 7:68).** Even the proofs were the same. Allah says, what can be translated as**, "And do you wonder (literally: have you wondered) that a remembrance from your Lord has come to you" (TMQ, 7:69).**
- The disbelievers' accusations. This is indicated in the ayah that can be translated as, **"… Surely we indeed see you in evident error" (TMQ, 7:60),** and that which can be translated as, **"… Surely we see you indeed in foolishness, and surely we indeed expect that you are one of the liars" (TMQ, 7:66).**
- The emphasis on the termination of wrongness according to the rule that says that retribution and reward correspond to the nature of the deed. The people of Thamud, for example, used to carve out homes in the mountains for safety. Their sense of security lured them into acting arrogantly towards Allah's (*SWT*) law. This is why they were punished by a commotion, which was accompanied by fear, since fear is the opposite of the sense of security. The same rule was applied also to the people of Lut (*AS*), who were overindulged in sexual lust, which led them to divert from human nature and into aberration. This is all the result of immoderation. The ayah says, what can be translated as, **"Surely you**
indeed come up with lust to men, apart from (i.e. instead of) women; no indeed, you are an extravagant people (i.e., exceeding the limits (of decency))"" (TMQ, 7:81). Hence, they were punished by a rain of stones.
- Driving the attention to the fact that the defeat of wrongness is due to corruption. In the example of Thamud, the people of Saleh (*AS*), extreme extravagance was the reason behind their annihilation, as indicated in the 74th ayah. Whereas the people of Lut (*AS*) were annihilated as a result of moral corruption and homosexuality, as indicated by the 80th and 81st ayahs. Madyan, the people of Shu'ayb (*AS*), were annihilated because of economic corruption, as indicated by the ayah that can be translated as, "… **so fill up the measure and the balance, and do not depreciate mankind their things (i.e., their goods)" (TMQ, 7:85).**
- Warning against arrogance, for it is one of the most dangerous reasons for destruction. It can be seen that the expression, which can be translated as, **"The chiefs who waxed proud from among his people" (TMQ, 7:75)** is repeated in the stories of both Thamud and Madyan. We also find that at the beginning of the surah, an expression is focused on, which can be translated

as**, "… the ones who cry lies to Our signs and wax proud against them" (TMQ, 7:36).** This expression is repeated again in the 40th ayah. For an expression to be repeated in the Qur'an, there must be a significant notion to which Allah (*SWT*) wants to alert us.

- Focusing on saving the Prophet and the believers who followed him, and on the annihilation of the disbelievers, without any reference to any passive or neutral parties. Allah says, what can be translated as, **"… We delivered him, and the ones with him" (TMQ, 7:64 & 7:72),** as well as**, "So We delivered him and his family" (TMQ, 7:83).** The surah also says, what can be translated as, **"…Indeed we will definitely drive you out, O Shu'ayb, and the ones who have believed with you" (TMQ, 7:88).**

Are you still hesitant after all of that?

Notice the Qur'an's remarks on these stories. Allah says, what can be translated as**, "And if the population of the towns had believed and been pious, We indeed would have opened upon them blessings from the heaven and the earth" (TMQ, 7:96).** Allah (*SWT*) fits all these examples within a cosmic rule; either you have faith, determine your position, and follow the Prophet, or you suffer severe hardship and dire torment from Allah *(SWT)*.

We all fall under this rule. Are you still hesitant? If you are not for the right then you are for the wrong, even if your intentions are otherwise. This is because by not taking a definite position, you have weakened the righteous followers. Furthermore, do not ever say, "I am but one individual and do not have the capacity to change anything in the struggle formula". If righteousness will need 100 sincere, successful individuals to triumph yet there are only 99, you might be the one to complete the group. However, if you fail to act in such a manner, you would be the reason for the regression of the righteous.

The story of Musa "Moses" (*AS*)

The ayahs proceed to the story of Musa with Pharaoh, his magicians and the Israelites. It is one of the most wonderful stories in terms of its display of the examples of resoluteness and hesitation.

It is worth saying here that the story of Prophet Musa is the most frequently cited story in the Qur'an. It is mentioned in 29 chapters.

However, surat Al-A'raf is the most detailed surah concerning the relationship between Musa and his people, especially after leaving Egypt. Contrary to what is mentioned in surat Al-Qasas, it does not touch upon the story of his birth or his upbringing in Pharaoh's palace. On the other hand, the story promptly commences with the struggle from the first ayah. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"…So look how was the end of the corruptors!" (TMQ, 7: 103)**, **"And Mûsa (Moses) said, "O Firaawn! (Pharaoh) Surely I am a Messenger from The Lord of the worlds" (TMQ, 7: 104).** This is revealed by Allah (*SWT*) in the surah so that we can learn lessons from the situations of determination and hesitation.

Resoluteness Starting With *Sajdah* (Prostration)

When the magicians came to seek Pharaoh's preference and to confront Musa (*AS*), they witnessed the sign that proved his message. Within a few minutes, they signaled their determination decisively and staunchly. **"So the Truth came to pass, (Literally: fell "on them") and void (Literally: became untrue) was whatever they were doing. So they were overcome over there, and they turned over belittled. And the sorcerers were cast down prostrating" (TMQ, 7: 118-120).**

Their faith started with this sincere prostration. They adhered to their belief, despite being threatened with torture and death In this respect, Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"They said, "We believe in The Lord of the worlds, The Lord of Mûsa (Moses) and Harûn" (Aaron). Firaawn (Pharaoh) said, "You have believed in Him before I permit you..." (TMQ, 7: 121-123).**

After that, Pharaoh told them, **"Indeed I will definitely cut up your hands and your legs alternately, thereafter indeed I will definitely crucify you all together" (TMQ, 7:124)**. What was the impact of his reaction on their stance? Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"They said, "Surely to our Lord we are around (Literally: turning over). And in no way do you take vengeance upon us except that we have believed in the signs of our Lord as soon they came to us…" (TMQ, 7:125-126)**. Such was their irrevocable and unhesitant response to the threat of Pharaoh. Moreover, they drew patience from the Truth and prayed to die as Muslims, **"…Our Lord, pour out upon us patience and take us to Yourself as Muslims" (TMQ, 7:126).**

Pharaoh's Corruption

After we have witnessed various kinds of corruption in the previous stories of the Prophets, there comes the story of Musa and Pharaoh to show us the worst form of corruption. Allah (*SWT*) reveals their corruption in the ayah that can be translated as, **"…He said, "We will soon massacre their sons and (spare) alive their women, and surely above them we are vanquishers" (TMQ, 7:127).** The divine punishment inflicted upon that tyrant and his people was gradual. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"So We sent upon them the deluge, and the locusts, and the lice, and the frogs, and the blood, expounded signs …" (TMQ, 7:133).** However, Allah (*SWT*) wanted to commute the punishment as He says what can be translated as, **"Then as soon as We lifted off from them the chastisement to a term that they should reach, only then did they breach (their covenant)" (TMQ, 7:135).** Thus, what was the punishment after that? Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"So We took vengeance on them, then We drowned them in the main for that they cried lies to Our signs, and they were heedless of them." (TMQ, 7:136).**

Israelites: Negativity and Hesitation

Similarly, the ayahs show us another case of hesitation exemplified in the Israelites. What was their reply when their Prophet told them, **"…Beseech Allah for help and be patient; surely the earth (belongs) to Allah. He causes whomever He decides among His bondmen to inherit it, and the (prosperous) end is for the pious" (TMQ, 7:128)**? Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"They said, "We were**

hurt even before you came up to us and even after you came to us" (TMQ, 7:129). In turn, Musa (*AS*) gave them his reply to teach them trusting Allah (*SWT*) which is a principal element leading to determination. Musa (*AS*) said, **"It may be that your Lord will cause your enemy to perish and make you successors in the earth; so He looks into how you do" (TMQ, 7:129).**

Hence, the ayahs (128-129) highlight the importance of determination and the avoidance of hesitancy as two fundamentals in the test of succession on earth; a matter which the Israelites could not understand.

Even in Faith!

Israelites appear on other occasions as a group of people living aimlessly and misguidedly with regards to faith. In ayah 138, Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And We made the Seeds (or: sons) of Israel) pass over the sea. Then they came upon a people consecrating themselves to idols they had…" (TMQ, 7:138).** A little while after crossing the sea and witnessing every step in the drowning of Pharaoh and his soldiers they said, **"O Mûsa, (Moses) make for us a god as they have gods." He said, "Surely you are a people who are ignorant" (TMQ, 7:138)**. This is a question that shows the peak of their ignorance. It was revealed in the same ayah which narrates the story of their rescue, so that Allah can show us the extent of their hesitation and instability.

"So take them with power, and command your people to take the fairest of them..." (TMQ, 7:145).

The majority of Allah's commands to Israel urged Israelites to follow Allah's orders and religion with firmness. In ayah 145, Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"So take them with power, and command your people to take the fairest of them..." (TMQ, 7:145)**, and in ayah 171 Allah (*SWT*) instructs them in what can be translated as, **"Take powerfully what We have brought you…" (TMQ, 7:171).**

Then let us see how they responded to Allah's commands. Musa (*AS*) left them and went to meet his Lord, so what did they do? In this respect, Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And the people of Mûsa (Moses) took to themselves even after him, of their (diverse) ornaments, a corporeal Calf that had a lowing (voice)…" (TMQ, 7:148).**

The ayahs strongly denied what they did, **"…Did they not see that it did not speak to them nor did it guide them upon any way? They took it to themselves and were an unjust (people). And as soon as it was made to fall down in their hands, (i.e., they regretted.) and (they) saw that they had already erred, they said, "Indeed in case our Lord has no mercy on us and does not forgive us, indeed, we will definitely be of the losers." (TMQ, 7:148-149)**. They complained of unclearness and unsteadiness in their religion and their relationship with Allah.

In such a way, the difference between the magicians and the Israelites becomes clear. The reader can feel this difference between the magicians' challenge to Pharaoh when they said, **"so decree whatever you will decree..." (TMQ, 20:72),** and can confirm this feeling when he reads, **"They said, "We were hurt even before you came up to**

us and even after you came to us" (TMQ, 8:129). He can feel this difference between **"They said, "We believe in The Lord of the worlds" (TMQ, 7:121)** which was uttered by the magicians without hesitancy, and **"O Mûsa, (Moses) make for us a god as they have gods" (TMQ, 7:138)** which was said by Israelites despite the great miracles they had witnessed.

The Three Groups

Immediately after the story of Musa (*AS*) with the Israelites, there comes the story of the Sabbath-breakers (163-167). This story succinctly illustrates how some Israelites cunningly evaded Allah's order. They committed a heinous sin by fishing on the day on which Allah (*SWT*) had forbidden them to work (Saturday). Therefore, Allah (*SWT*) tested them by sending plenty of fish in front of their eyes on Saturdays. They tried to evade Allah's order by spreading out their nets on Friday nights and collecting what they found in them on Sunday mornings. Some of the positive believers started to enjoin what is right and forbid what is wrong. They did that in order to be free from guilt in front of Allah (*SWT*) on the basis of their attempted reform, realizing that it is only Allah (*SWT*) who leads to the right path.

Other believers stood negatively. Moreover, they blamed those who were enjoining what is right and forbidding what is wrong. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And as a (certain) nation of them said, "Why do you admonish a people whom Allah (is) causing to perish or tormenting with a strict torment?" They said, "(As) a (possible) excuse to your Lord, and that possibly they would be pious" (TMQ, 7:164).**

Thus, there were a group who committed sins, a positive group who tried to guide, and a negative group who neither moved nor preached. Let us move to see what became of each group.

Rescue…Torture…. Negligence

The Sabbath-breakers did not respond to the advice of the believers. Therefore Allah (*SWT*) inflicted upon them punishment, **"So, as soon as they forgot what they were reminded of, We delivered the ones who were forbidding odious deeds and We took (away) the ones who did injustice with most miserable torment because they were acting immorally" (TMQ, 7:165).**

Allah (*SWT*) saved the positive group from punishment, and punished the disobeyers severely. The Qur'an did not mention those who stood negatively. Religious scholars differed in opinion in this respect. Some of them believed that they did not deserve to be mentioned because of their negativity, thus, their fate will be determined on the Day of Judgment as Allah (*SWT*) wishes. The other group held the opinion that that they were included with the disobeyers. They were meant to be among those whom Allah (*SWT*) says about what can be translated as, **"We took (away) the ones who did injustice" (TMQ, 7:165).** Both, they and the disobeyers would be treated equally because they kept silent in the face of sins, turning to be sinners themselves.

Some of Them Were Righteous and Others Were Far Away From That

One of the magnificent aspects in the Qur'an is that it does not tell a story for the sake of telling stories. It always concludes any story with a moral lesson and advice to plant the intended meaning behind telling the story in the mind of the reader. Thus, the end of the story of Musa (*AS*) and the Sabbath-breakers clarified an important lesson. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And We cut them up in the earth into nations, (some) of them righteous, and (some) of them lesser than that…" (TMQ, 7:168).**

This was the state of the first generation of the Israelites who got lost and was separated in different parts on the earth. Some of them were righteous and others went astray. However, the second generation had some negative and hesitant people. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Then there succeeded even after them a succession who inherited the Book, taking the advantage of this meaner (life), and saying, "Soon it will be forgiven us." And in case an advantage, the like of it, comes up to them, they will take it…" (TMQ, 7:169).**

Similarly, the ayahs end with a vivid example for us to emulate; an example enjoining us to adhere to the religion's ordinances tenaciously. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And the ones who hold fast to the Book and keep up the prayer, surely We do not waste the reward of the righteous doer" (TMQ, 7:170).**

Notice the phrase "**hold fast**" and how it indicates strong adherence to Allah's commands, especially praying. These people are honored by Allah (*SWT*). They are not only people guided to the right path but they also guide others. They are positive people as well as reformers of their society, their country, and their nation.

How Come You Cannot Determine When Your Nature Had Testified?

The ayahs, then, take us to old time, to the world of posterity. It was then when Allah (*SWT*) had made us testify to ourselves His greatness and divinity. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And (remember) as your Lord took from the Seeds (Or. sons) of Adam, from their backs, their offspring, and made them bear witness concerning themselves, "Am I not your Lord?" They said, "Yes indeed, we bear witness." (So) that you should not say on the Day of the Resurrection, "Surely we were heedless of this" (TMQ, 7:172).**

Then, how can we not move to support our religion when Allah (*SWT*) took a vow from us since the beginning of creation, even before we came to this world. A vow that we would be with the righteousness and its supporters? The love of the religion and adhering to it are divine nature endowed from Allah (*SWT*). Then, why do some people forget this pledge and forget this nature?

The Disease of Heedlessness

Allah (*SWT*) explains in the previous ayah what can be translated as, **"…(So) that you should not say on the Day of the Resurrection, "Surely we were heedless of this" (TMQ, 7:172).** It is the heedlessness. It is the most dangerous disease which might lead to cooling down the enthusiasm of following the righteousness and to the hesitation in supporting the religion. Then, what are the symptoms of this disease? Listen to ayah 179 where Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And indeed**

We have already propagated for Hell many of the jinn and humankind; they have hearts with which they do not comprehend, and they have eyes with which they do not behold, and they have ears with which they do not hear. Those are like the cattle; no indeed, they are further in error. Those are they (who are) heedless" (TMQ, 7:179).

Thus, heedlessness is the main reason behind every hesitation and lack of determination. Therefore, the last advice given to the Prophet (*SAWS*), although he is the infallible Prophet, comes before the end of the surah where Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And remember your Lord within yourself, in supplication and in fright, other than being (too) loud in words, in the early mornings and the (hours) before sunset, and do not be among the heedless" (TMQ, 7:205).**

If that is directed to our Prophet (*SAWS*), then it is more proper for us, his followers, to detect this disease and eradicate it by glorifying and making sincere *dua'a* (supplication) to Allah (*SWT*), and by reading surat Al-A'raf and understanding its meanings.

He is like a Dog

Before the end of the surah, it mentions a great number of examples and ayahs that serve the same meaning and warn the believers against heedlessness and lack of determination with regards to Allah's legislation and religion. Here comes a striking image, **"And recite to them the tiding of him to whom We brought Our signs, yet he stripped himself out of them; (i.e., he abandoned them) then Ash-Shy tan (The all-vicious one, i.e., the Devil) followed up after him, (and) so he became of the misguided. And if We had decided, We would indeed have raised him thereby, but he clung to the earth and closely followed his prejudice. So the likeness of him is like the likeness of a dog: in case you burden it, it lolls (its tongue out), or (in case) you leave it, it lolls (its tongue out)..." (TMQ, 7:175-176).**

What a striking image of that who received Allah's ayahs and was guided but he sloughed off them like a snake casting off its skin. If he had adhered to his religion, Allah (*SWT*) would have honored him. Nevertheless, he preferred the lowliness of this world. Thus, he resembles a dog getting tired and lolling his tongue out whether he is aware or not. What a striking image, that should shake every lazy and heedless person!

Prostrate With This Meaning

The best conclusion of this surah is with an ayah including prostration. This is the first ayah in the Qur'an that contains a prostration. In order to remember the determination, the resolution, and the strong will, we should remember the prostration of the magicians who challenged Pharaoh with his tyranny and unjustness. The ayah also asks us to practically show our submission to Allah (*SWT*) because this act of prostration draws the attention of the soul to put faith into practice. Thus, it signals its readiness for determining its way in life. We should prostrate to Allah (*SWT*) when reading this ayah, with this meaning in our minds. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Surely the ones who are in the Providence of your Lord do not wax too proud to (do) Him worship, and they extol Him, and to Him they prostrate**

themselves" (TMQ, 7:206).

Surat Al-Anfal (The Spoils)

Surat Al-Anfal is a Madinan surah, revealed after surat Al-Baqara. It comes after surat Al-A'raf in the Qur'an. It consists of 75 ayahs.

The Day of Separation Between Good and Evil

This surah was revealed after the Battle of Badr; some religious scholars call it "Surat Badr". The Battle of Badr was the first battle in Islam. Allah (*SWT*) calls it the day of separation in this surah because that was the day when Allah separated between the right and the wrong. It is considered the day that separated two eras in human history; an era when Islam was weak and when Islam would grow to be stronger and turn into a powerful nation defending Islam until our very day. It was a great day in human history. Thus, the whole surah was revealed to comment on that day.

If victory were to be measured in materialistic terms, then Muslims would have never recorded any victory on that day. The number of Muslims was 313. They were not prepared for fighting, neither psychologically nor in terms of fighting gear. On the other hand, the number of the disbelievers was about 1000 and they were perfectly prepared. It is worth mentioning that in this battle, the Muslims only had one horse, while the disbelievers had 300 horses. Thus, by materialistic measures, it was impossible for the Muslims to win this battle.

The Vices of *Al-Abrâr* (the pious believers)

Al-Anfal means the booty and this surah is named after this booty (The Spoils).

The Prophet's (*SAWS*) companions had a nice comment on this surah. They say, "It was because of us, the companions of the Prophet, that surat Al-Anfal was revealed when we disagreed about the booty and were ill-mannered". This ill-mannerism that they talked about is not the same as we know it today. However, they expressed their disagreement as such because of their exalted manners and their humbleness.

Provisions for Victory-worldly and Divine

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The surah tackles the principles on which victory is based, a matter that is compatible with the general atmosphere of the surah and the reason behind its revelation. After the Muslims had won the battle of Badr, this surah was revealed in order to instill the universal factors of victory within the Muslim minds, as victory is not won by chance or at random. On the other hand, it is gained through these worldly and spiritual principles.

Thus, there are two main important factors that lead to victory:

1- The belief that victory comes only from Allah (*SWT*), as Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And in no way is victory from (any- where) except from the Providence of Allah" (TMQ, 8:10).**

2- Dedication and commitment towards balancing powers with enemies, and even doing better than them if possible, in addition to the use of effective schemes and tactics to gain victory.

This surah stresses on the concept that one should trust in Allah (*SWT*), be certain that He (*SWT*) is the Powerful, and exert all one's efforts in order to gain victory. For this reason, Allah (*SWT*) revealed what can be translated as, **"… Allah is not changing (His) favor that He conferred (Literally: favored) on a people until they have changed what is within themselves…" (TMQ, 8:53).** This ayah indicates that Allah (*SWT*) is the sole force and cause behind every victory, provided that one should do everything in one's power. Therefore, we must bear in mind that victory is subject to the efforts of mankind and, thus, we must know that victory lies between both, man's work and his fate.

Some do think that victory is just a divine miracle, so you find them engrossed in *dua'a* (supplication) praying to Allah (*SWT*) to render them victorious, and then wonder why their incessant prayers are not answered. The problem is that they have not yet understood that there are other aspects that must be considered; dedication, planning, and toil. *Dua'a* alone is not sufficient when it is not accompanied by work. Depending on *dua'a* alone makes us unaware of the nature of our religion and laws of Allah (*SWT*) on Earth.

On the other hand, there are those who persist on doing all they can in devising plans and tactics. However, when they try to measure their power in comparison with that of the enemies, they find it relatively inadequate, and they consequently find themselves in a weak position. That is obviously because they focus on worldly requirements of victory and are in complete oblivion to the fact that victory is gained only through Allah (*SWT*).

The surah directs us to a balance between these two antitheses; trust in Allah's fate must always be the basis upon which we fulfill the worldly requirements of victory.

Victory is from Allah (*SWT*)

The surah begins with a question that can be translated as, **"They ask you about the spoils. (The Arabic word nafl originally means: supererogatory prayer, or gift)…" (TMQ, 8:1).** This ayah indicates people's questions about the division of spoils. **"Say, "The spoils (belong) to Allah and the Messenger; so be pious to Allah, and act righteously among yourselves (Or: make a reconciliation after differences) and obey Allah and His Messenger, in case you are believers."" (TMQ, 8:1).**

The qualities of the believers are enumerated in the ayahs that follow which can be translated as, **"Surely the believers are only the ones who, when Allah is mentioned, their hearts tremble …" (TMQ, 8:2).** It is interesting here that the answer to their queries about the division of the war spoils does not come directly after the question. Rather, the answer comes enclosed in ayah 41, divided by 40 ayahs from the original question, **"And know that whatever thing you take as booty, then for Allah is the fifth of it and for the Messenger, and for a near kinsman, and the orphans, and the indigent, and the wayfarer …" (TMQ, 8: 41).**

The reason behind this delayed answer is that when the Muslims asked about the spoils of war, all they were thinking of at that moment was their worldly gains, so Allah (*SWT*) taught them how victory is solely His and that it is only gained through Him. The initial answer is in the following ayah which can be translated as, **"Say: "the spoils (belong) to Allah and the Messenger" (TMQ, 8:1)**, and that is note to remind them that the spoils do not belong to them in the first place. The Qur'an gracefully diverts the Muslim's attention away from the spoils in order to instill the principles of victory in their minds before anything else. Later on, it explains how booties are divided. Allah (*SWT*) says towards the end of the surah what can be translated as, **"So, eat of what you have taken as booty, such as is lawful (and) good…" (TMQ, 8:69)**. Thus, Allah (*SWT*) settles what is of importance and indicates that the worldliness of a matter such as booty division is of secondary importance.

The surah is divided into two parts: the first part is mainly concerned with the concept that only Allah (*SWT*) brings victory, while the second is concerned with the worldly requirements that we should fulfill in order to gain victory.

PART ONE: "…and there is no victory except from Allah…" (TMQ, 8:10).
The first part indicates Allah's blessings upon Muslims as he helped them gain victory:

1- The setting of the battle

Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"As also as your Lord brought you (The Prophet) out of your home with the truth, and surely a group of the believers indeed are hating that (TMQ, 8: 5)**. Many of the believers did not wish to fight, but Allah (*SWT*) has already devised a plan to restore order and reveal the truth; **"And as Allah promised you (The pronouns "you" and "yours" are plural) one of the two sections should be yours, and you would like that the one other than the accoutered (i.e. owning accoutrement, the armed section) should be yours. And Allah willed to uphold truthfully the truth by His words and cut off the last trace (Literally: the rear, hind part) of the disbelievers, That He might (uphold) truthfully the truth and void the untrue, although the criminals would hate (that)." (TMQ, 8:7-8).** These ayahs are crystal-clear as the setting of the battle was arranged by Allah (*SWT*).

2- The psychological preparation for the battle

Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"As He was making drowsiness to envelop you as secure (reassurance) from Him, and sending down on you water from the heaven to purify you thereby, and to put away from you the chastisement of Ash-Shaytan, (The all-vicious :one"; i.e., the Devil) and to brace your hearts, and to make firm (your) feet thereby" (TMQ, 8:11).**

Allah (*SWT*) made the Muslims doze before the battle started and awakened them to find it drizzling, so they would perform ablution and be invigorated. Even the psychological preparation was arranged by Allah (*SWT*).

One of the *Sahabah* (the Messenger's companions) describes the scene saying that, while he was guarding the Muslim army, he dozed off. When he looked at the rest of the *Sahabah* , he found them all sleeping soundly, in spite of the atmosphere of fear and terror that dominated the scene. All that happened was in accordance with Allah's (*SWT*) plan.

3- The spiritual preparation of the army

Not only was the setting and the psychological preparation from Allah (*SWT*), but also, the psychological status of the troops on which huge sums of money were spent. The divine spiritual preparation of the Muslim troops is revealed in the following ayah which can be translated as, **"As Allah showed you them in your sleeping as few; and if He had shown them to you as many, you would indeed have been disheartened, and you would indeed have contended together about the Command; but Allah saved (i.e., handed you victory) (you). Surely He is Ever-Knowing of the inmost (thoughts) in the breasts (Literally: what the breasts own). And as He showed you them in your eyes as few, as you encountered…" (TMQ, 8:43-44).**

The Muslim troops were made to see the disbelievers few so that they would not panic and fear them, while the disbelievers were made to see the Muslims few so that they would underestimate them. The same effect was applied to the same scene but it had two totally different impacts on each side. Glory be to Allah (*SWT*) who makes victory and helps gain it.

4- The descent of the angels

The descent of the angels is evident in the ninth ayah, which can be translated as, **"As you call your Lord for succor, so He responded to you that, "I am supplying you with a thousand Angels in successive ranks " (TMQ, 8:9)**. It can also be perceived from the following ayah that can be translated as, **"As Your Lord was revealing to the Angels, (saying), "I am with you; so make the ones who believe stand firm. I will soon cast into the hearts of the ones who have disbelieved horror; so strike above the necks, and strike every finger-tip of them" (TMQ, 8:12)**.

Only Allah (*SWT*) is the Eternal Owner of Sovereignty and He alone can do as He desires. We can trust in no one but Him (*SWT*) for granting us victory. Dependence on other inferior things leads absolutely to nowhere.

5- The time and place of the battle

The ayahs move on to what is beyond psychological factors; the divine arrangement of the time and place of the battle. The battlefield itself was obviously chosen by Allah (*SWT*) as is shown in what can be translated as, **"As you were on the closer embankment, and they were on the remotest embankment, and the cavalcade (of riders) was below you; and if you had made a mutual appointment, you would indeed have differed about the promised appointment…" (TMQ, 8:42).**

The nearer slope of the valley, where the Muslim camps were situated, had a quality of sand that made rain more solid upon falling. Rain made the soil firm under the feet

of Muslims making movement around the battlefield much easier. However, on the other slope, the rain caused floods which acted as an obstacle for the disbelievers' infantries and horsemen. This is a manifestation of Allah's power, the victory Maker, the believers' Backer.

6- "You did not kill them, but Allah killed them" (TMQ, 8:17)

The surah continues until an ayah clarifies the outcome of the battle and its progress, even when the Prophet (*SAWS*) throws sand towards the faces of the disbelievers saying, "May these faces be deformed"[29], **"So, you did not kill them, but Allah killed them; and in no way did you (i.e., the Prophet) throw when you threw, but Allah threw …" (TMQ, 8:17).**

That is why the ayahs emphasize on the importance of making *dua'a* to Allah (*SWT*) for victory, as Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"…and there is no victory except from Allah…" (TMQ, 8:10).** No wonder the Prophet (*SAWS*) kept praying to Allah insistently on the day of Badr until his shirt slid back over his shoulders and all could see his armpits **that Abu-Bakr** (*RA*) said, "Take it easy, O Messenger of Allah…" Since victory is from Allah (*SWT*), one should answer His call in what can be translated as, **"O you who have believed, respond to Allah and to the Messenger when He calls you to that which enlivens you …" (TMQ, 8:24).**

PART TWO: "And prepare for them whatever power and whatever garrisoned horses you can …" (TMQ, 8:60).

1- The importance of taking the measures needed and its impact on victory

Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as**, "And prepare for them whatever power and whatever garrisoned horses you can to (spread) awe thereby into (the hearts) of the enemy of Allah and your enemy…" (TMQ, 8:60).** This ayah lucidly reveals its meaning. The very same surah that emphasizes that victory is from Allah (*SWT*) also emphasizes the importance of readiness and measure-taking. In addition to turning to Allah (*SWT*), planning is an equally significant factor in bringing about victory. Moreover, this surah tackles the issue of the balance of power, indicating that a single person fighting a whole army can never win his battle simply by saying, **"..and there is no victory except from Allah.." (TMQ, 8:10).** This is, in fact, a common misconception among us about religion and the divine laws upon which the universe functions.

It is important to say that at this point, the word **"spread awe**" is mentioned in the sense that it prevents fighting and bloodshed from ensuing. Hence, Muslims must have a deterring power that terrifies their enemies and consequently makes war a less favorable choice for the enemies. Even during wartime, Islam, in spite of all the misconceptions people have nowadays, calls for peace. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, "**and others, apart from them (i.e., besides them) that you do not know; Allah knows them …" (TMQ, 8:60).** The ayah then encourages the display of Muslim power and equipments in order to deter their enemies from fighting them. Correspondingly, Allah (*SWT*) says in the ayah that follows what can be translated as,

[29] Authentic Hadith, Muslim.

"**And in case they are bent on submission, then be bent on it and put your trust in Allah …" (TMQ, 8:61).**

2- The balance of worldly power

It is true that Allah (*SWT*) supports whoever He wishes, but one must bear in mind the balance of power and the fulfillment of the worldly requirements of victory. I am simply saying this so that no one says, "If there is a divine back-up by the angels, then why should we make preparations?" Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"O you Prophet, exhort the believers to the fight. In case there are twenty of you, patient (men), they will overcome two hundred; and in case there are a hundred of you, they will overcome a thousand of the ones who have disbelieved for that they are a people who do not comprehend. Now Allah has lightened it for you, and He has known that there is weakness in you. So, in case there are a hundred of you patient (men), they will overcome two hundred; and in case there are of you a thousand, they will overcome two thousand by the permission of Allah, and Allah is with the patient" (TMQ, 8: 65-66).**

The phrase **"by the permission of Allah"** is indicative of Allah's indisputable possession of victory. He (*SWT*) supports whomever He wants. Moreover, the ayahs indicate that patience is important in attaining victory and **"…and Allah is with the patient"** confirms that. Glory be to Allah who bound the two factors that contribute to victory in one surah.

3- Understanding the laws of war

The ayahs move on to the factors that played a role in the disbelievers' loss in the battle. Besides being disbelievers, they were not equipped with the material power which leads to victory, as indicated in what can be translated as, **"…and if there be a hundred steadfast persons they will overcome a thousand of those who disbelieve, because they (the disbelievers) are people who do not understand…" (TMQ, 8:65).** This means that they did not understand the factors that could have helped them gain victory. Moreover, they lacked the experience needed in military scheming. Muslims should learn from surat Al-Anfal, the laws of Allah (*SWT*) and the worldly requirements of victory.

4- Obeying Allah (*SWT*) and the brotherhood in the cause of Allah

Allah (*SWT*) shows that there is another worldly requirement which should be fulfilled in order to gain victory in what can be translated as, **"And obey Allah and His Messenger, and do not contend together, (and) so you would be disheartened and your vigor goes away; and (endure) patiently; surely Allah is with the patient" (TMQ, 8:46).** Unity and abandoning disputes are vital requirements of victory.

Allah (*SWT*) also says what can be translated as, **"And in case they would (like) to deceive you, then surely Allah is enough (i.e., enough Reckoner) for you; He is The One Who has aided you with His victory and with the believers, And He has brought their hearts together (Literally: joined "between" their hearts). If you had expended whatever is in the earth altogether, in no way could you have**

brought their hearts together; but Allah has brought them together…" (TMQ, 8: 62-63). Brotherhood, therefore, is one of the main factors that contribute to victory.

5- Avoidance of arrogance and vanity

This is clear in ayah 47, which can be translated as, **"do not be as the ones who went out of their residences boastfully (ungrateful) and showing off to the multitude …" (TMQ, 8:47).** This is another unfulfilled worldly requirement that led to the disbelievers' defeat; they slaughtered camels, got drunk, and boastfully celebrated even before the battle started, in order to terrify all the Arabs. Their vanity is precisely what made them underestimate their opponents and consequently lose the battle.

6- The qualities of the believers; positive and practical

Many of the ayahs in this surah harmonize the two concepts together; complete trust in Allah (*SWT*) and total preparation for action. That is precisely why the surah enumerates the traits of the believers and then concludes these descriptions with the ayah that can be translated as, **"Those are truly the ones who are believers" (TMQ, 8:4).** Moreover, towards the end of the surah, in ayah 74 specifically, the attributes of true believers reoccur and are followed by what can be translated as, **"... those are they (who truly) are believers" (TMQ, 8:74).** The same words come in both the beginning and end of the surah; however, there is a semantic difference between them. The attributes mentioned at the beginning are all related to faith, which well suits the second ayah in which Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"the believers are only the ones who, when Allah is mentioned, their hearts tremble and when His ayat (Signs or verses) are recited to them, they increase them in belief, and in their Lord they put their trust" (TMQ, 8:2).** As we can see here, the ayah encloses gentle attributes, because the ayah occurs in the part of the surah that is concerned with faith.

The main concern of the second part of the surah, however, is the requirements of victory. That is why the attributes of believers here are, **"And the ones who have believed, and have emigrated, and have striven in the way of Allah, and the ones who have given abode and helped towards victory, those are they (who truly) are believers…" (TMQ, 8:74**). True believers, therefore, possess the qualities that occur in both parts of the surah. They submit to Allah (*SWT*), worship Him, strive in His cause, fervently support His religion, live for Islam, and take all measures into consideration. For this reason comes the core ayah that can be translated as, **"O you who have believed, when you meet a community, (i.e., an enemy community) then stand firm and remember Allah much, that possibly you would prosper" (TMQ, 8:45)**. This ayah encloses all the factors of victory; **"stand firm"** is doing all in one's power (measure-taking), **"and remember Allah much"** is turning to Allah (*SWT*), the victory-maker, for support, and **"that possibly you would prosper"** is precisely the point where victory is gained. Furthermore, the passage of time cannot alter these principles. The repetition of the following ayah emphasizes this in what can be translated as, **"As was the steadfast manner of the house of Firaawn (Pharaoh) and the ones who were even before them …" (TMQ, 8:52).** The ayah makes it clear that the reason behind their doom was their arrogant disbelief (i.e. their

disregard of the divine aspect), while ayah 54 indicates the worldly reason; their injustice; **"and all were unjust" (TMQ, 8:54).**

The reason behind the title "Al-Anfal (the spoils of war)"

The spoils of war refer to worldliness. The fact is that the Muslims, after the battle of Badr, disputed; they showed hostility towards each other, and the bond of brotherhood between them was about to be shattered and all was for the sake of earthly matters. Allah (*SWT*) warns the believers from competing over matters in this life, for it may be a cause for their disunity and the loss of their brotherhood, consequently leading to material loss and loss of spiritual keys to victory. For that reason, the ayahs ordered them to take no heed of the spoils of war at all, as Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Say: "The spoils (belong) to Allah and the Messenger"" (TMQ, 8:1).** The factors that contribute to victory became instilled in their hearts and minds. When these factors were fixed, He (*SWT*) divided them in 41 ayahs until ayah 69, in which the inferiority of the matter of spoils is explained and the permission of what has already been taken is granted; **"So, eat of what you have taken as booty, such as is lawful (and) good …" (TMQ, 8:69).**

The keys to victory are, as mentioned before, turning to Allah (*SWT*) and dedication at work (in our case, preparation for war). Among these preparations are the strong bond of brotherhood and the unity among Muslims, because if brotherliness is lost and separation and disunity reign instead, loss is bound to occur. The surah, therefore, is entitled "Al-Anfal" in order to remind us of the main cause of loss.

Inheritance law repeal

The surah is adjourned with the repeal of the law of inheritance between the *Sahabah,* which implied that a man can inherit his brother in the cause of Allah (i.e. not a blood brother).[30] The last ayah of the surah can be translated as, "**the ones who are related (by blood) (Literally: near by birth "womb"; endowed with near kinship) have more right to patronage with one another (Literally: some of them to some "others") in the Book of Allah…" (TMQ, 8:75)** Thus, inheritance between those who were in brotherhood (in the cause of Islam) had been a temporary stage that preceded the battle of Badr, and that was permitted in order to deepen their feelings of duty and love towards one another. After the victory in Badr, the Muslim society was bound together in a way stronger than it ever was, as victory mends most of the psychological problems of a society.

That was surat Al-Anfal. We should make sure we fully understand the principles of victory so that Allah (*SWT*) supports our nation. We should turn to Allah (*SWT*) and be confident that He is the Maker of victory, **"and there is no victory except from Allah" (TMQ, 8:10).** Moreover, we should do everything we can in order to gain victory (e.g. pursue knowledge, succeed in our social and practical lives, and avoid

[30] Translator's note: Prophet Muhammad (*SAWS*), on arriving at Madinah, joined every Muslim from *Al-Muhajiroun* (the emigrants) with one of *Al-Ansar* (the people of Madinah who backed the Muslims and the Prophet), in brotherhood. Each one of the *Muhajiroun* shared his brother from *Al-Ansar* in everything (home, capital, etc.). This type of brotherhood ordained by the Prophet is a special case different from the mere brotherhood between all Muslims.

worldliness and mundane pleasures (i.e. the spoils)) in order to have our *dua'a* answered and our nation's dignity and superiority regained.

Features of the discipline concluded:

After the first ten surahs of Qur'an, the features of the discipline of being Allah's vicegerents crystallize. Furthermore, the objectives and messages of the surahs integrate to form a single message to the reader of Qur'an:

- Muslims, you are responsible for Earth, and here is your life discipline. (Surat Al-Baqarah).
- Adherence to this discipline is of great importance. (Surat Al-'Imran).
- Justice is the main pillar of succession. (Surat An-Nisa).
- The importance of applying the discipline and fulfilling the commitments made to put it into practice. (Surat Al-Ma'ida).
- Maintenance of the Oneness of Allah (*SWT*) both in belief and practice is crucial in this discipline. (Surat Al-An'am).
- Determine your position where discipline is concerned. (Surat Al-A'raf).
- The principles of victory are both divine and worldly; which demonstrates the discipline's comprehensiveness and realism. (Surat Al-Anfal).

It must be apparent by now that the surahs of the Qur'an accumulate to form a single chain of consistent messages and ideas. Now that the discipline has started to take shape, ten sections follow to provide us with the factors that support that discipline and they include:

- Repentance (Surat At-Tawba)
- Gratification of Allah's blessings (Surat An-Nahl); particularly, the blessing of having faith in Allah (*SWT*) in one's heart. (Surat Ibrahim)
- Moderation in calling for this discipline (Surat Hud)
- Patience and hope for Allah's victory (Surat Yusuf)

After understanding how to contemplate Allah's ayahs, let us move on to the next ten sections of Qur'an and see more of its wonders and miracles.

Surat At-Tawbah (the Repentance)

Surat At-Tawbah is a Madinan surah. It was revealed after surat Al- Ma'idah. In the order of the surahs in the Qur'an, it follows surat Al-Anfal. It consists of 129 Ayahs and is the last full surah revealed to our beloved Prophet (*SAWS*) before he passed away.

The surah was revealed at a time when the Muslim nation was getting ready to spread the message of Islam outside the borders of the Arabic Peninsula to reach all the peoples of the Earth.

This surah was revealed after the last battle fought by Prophet Muhammad (*SAWS*), the Battle of Tabouk, where 30 thousand Muslims took part in it. As mentioned before, this surah directly follows surat Al- Anfal which deals with the Battle of Badr; the first battle fought by the Prophet (*SAWS*) with only 313 Muslims. The reason behind this is so that the reader of the Holy Qur'an can notice the difference between the circumstances, conditions, and rulings of the two battles, as well as the Qur'anic commentary on both.

The Battle of Tabouk was one of the battles where the negative effect of hypocrisy was prevalent. There were many hypocrites amongst the army. There were also many believers who were left behind because they were not brisk enough to take part. Nevertheless, the Muslims won the battle and this surah was revealed to comment on that.

The Sign of Distinction

Surat At-Tawbah is the only surah that does not start with *Al-Basmallah* (invocation of the name of Allah) in contrast to all of the surahs in the Qur'an. When a Muslim reads the Holy Qur'an and starts by saying, "In the name of Allah, the All-Merciful, the Ever-Merciful", he feels from the very beginning that he is crossing a borderline between an old condition and a new one. He feels that he is plunging into a deeper spiritual world, heart and soul, leaving the materialistic world behind as he keeps hearing more of Allah's words and living with Allah's most beautiful names, which include the All-Merciful, the Ever-Merciful.

The reason behind the absence of *Al-Basmallah* at the beginning of the surah, according to most religious scholars, is due to the fact that this is a surah that deals with disbelievers and hypocrites more than any other in the Holy Qur'an. Thus, they are deprived of *Al-Basmalah* along with all the meanings of compassion and mercy that are presented there. Its first words can be translated as, **"An acquittal from Allah and His Messenger to the ones of the associators (Those who associate others with Allah) (with) whom you have covenanted." (TMQ, 9:1.**

Surat At-Tawbah has other names as well. It is called the *Exposer*, as it exposed the polytheists by numerating 55 of the hypocritical traits with which they dealt with the Prophet (*SAWS*). It is also called the *Revealer* as it reveals the flaws of the disbelievers and the languid that forsake giving support to Islam. It is also called the Sword as it is the most surah that urged Muslims for *Jihad* (fighting for Allah's cause), encouraging them to fight Allah's enemies, and warning against laziness and

languor. It is indeed a stern surah, but why then is it called At-Tawbah (the Repentance)?

The reason behind the title

Of all the aspects of our relationship with Allah (*SWT*), repentance is indeed the most tender of all. It means going back to Allah (*SWT*), resorting to Him, and giving up all sins. What, then, is the relation between repentance and the traits of both polytheists and hypocrites, and the urging for *Jihad*?

This surah is the final call for humanity. It was descended right before the concluding revelation of the Qur'an and the death of the Prophet (*SAWS*). Although the surah contains severe warnings to the disbelievers and hypocrites, along with a call for Muslims to fight for their religion, it gives everyone a final chance for repentance. In many instances, we notice the recurrence of what can be translated as, **"…so, in case they repent, it will be more charitable (i.e., better) for them." (TMQ, 9:74).**

If we look for the word *Tawbah* (repentance) and its derivatives in this surah, we will find that it is repeated 17 times in surat At-Tawbah, making it the highest number of repetition of this word in the Holy Qur'an. In surat Al-Baqarah, the longest surah in the Qur'an, the word *Tawbah* is repeated 13 times only. It is also mentioned 3 times in surat Al-Imran, 12 times in surat An-Nisa, 5 times in surat Al-Ma'idah, 6 times in surat Hud, and 1 time only in surat Al-An'am.

A call of repentance for all

Thus, we conclude that the highest number of times where the word *Tawbah* is mentioned is in this surah. What is noteworthy is that the surah does not leave out a sect or a group without including them within the range of *Tawbah.* The call was for all; disbelievers, polytheists, apostates, those who are hesitant, hypocrites, sinners, pious believers, and even the Prophet (*SAWS*) and his companions (*RA*). Whenever the surah mentions one of those groups, it reminds them of repentance or gives them the glad tidings that Allah (*SWT*) forgives them, in what can be translated as, "**Indeed Allah has already relented towards…" (TMQ, 9:117)**, and **"... So, in case they repent, it will be more charitable (i.e., better) for them" (TMQ, 9:74).**

As the surah exposes the hypocrites, it conveys to them a clear message that all of their tricks are revealed to the believers and thus leaves them no other chance but to repent. Hence, such exposure leads them to repent. It is just like when Allah (*SWT*) inflicts a hardship on someone so that it becomes a reason for his awakening and return to His path. Surat Al-Tawbah makes the hypocrites feel that they are besieged as it deprives them of all their lame excuses when Islam is set forth and clarified to everyone. Even Allah's call for the believers to fight is intended to fill the disbelievers' hearts with despair and to convince them that they will not be able to conquer the believers. Therefore, the surah leaves them with only one way out; the way of repentance.

The relation between At-Tawbah and the preceding surahs

When we divide the Qur'an into three divisions, we find that the first part consists of the seven longest surahs, ending with surat At-Tawbah. It is as if it has been revealed after the clarification of the methodology of Islam and the means to accomplish Allah's mission, only to open the gates of repentance and mercy to whoever fails to follow Allah's orders. It is indeed a blessing that it is one of the final surahs revealed to the Prophet (*SAWS*) before his death. Hence, the end of revelation as well as the end of the Qur'an marks opening the gates for repentance. Can you feel this meaning?

Some people feel the severity of this surah on the disbelievers and hypocrites, while others feel Allah's overwhelming mercy, as He accepts everyone's repentance. Yet, the latter are the ones that get closer to the actual point of the surah. It threatens the sinners only to urge them to run to repentance. Exposing the hypocrites and calling upon the believers to fight, and thus asserting the fact that they will not be conquered, are both intended to urge the disbelievers to repent.

Final calls for repentance

The surah starts in a severe and eye-catching way. In addition to the fact that it does not start with the *Basmallah*, as all other surahs do, it starts with the word "*Bara'a*" (acquittal) as Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"An acquittal from Allah and His Messenger to the ones of the associators (Those who associate others with Allah) (with) whom you have covenanted. So, wander about in the earth for four months, and know that you are unable to be (i.e. without the power to be defiant) defiant to Allah." (TMQ, 9:1-2).**

It is a strict start and a fixed time limit. Then, an alarming announcement from Allah (*SWT*) and His Messenger (*SAWS*) is given to all those who can hear it, **"And an announcement from Allah and His Messenger to mankind on the day of the Greater Pilgrimage that Allah is quit of the associators and (so is) His Messenger." (TMQ, 9:3).**

Why all this strictness? The answer is in what Allah (*SWT*) says and can be translated as, **"So in case you repent, then it is more charitable (i.e., better) for you; and in case you turn away, then know that you are unable to be defiant to Allah" (TMQ, 9:3).** The threat here is actually urging for repentance, and not vengeance. Moreover, both the **"acquittal"** and the **"announcement"** are the final calls for this repentance.

Repentance of the polytheists who joined in the battle

The surah takes us to the fifth ayah where Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"So, when the prohibiting months are drawn away, (Literally: stripped away) then kill the associators wherever you find them... every place of observation (i.e., ambush)";** however, **"But, in case they repent, and keep up the prayer, and bring the Zakat, (i.e., pay the obligatory poor-dues) then let them go their way; (Literally: pass on their way)." (TMQ, 9:5).** Despite the clear commands to fight the associators, there is still a reminder that encourages them to repent. It is true that the surah is severe in facing them. Yet, it is also true that it is so keen on urging them to go back to Allah's path.

After that, the surah informs us that we should leave no excuse for the disbelievers by calling upon them and clarifying the religion to them before fighting them. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And in case any of the associators (Those who associate others with Allah) seeks of you neighborly (protection), then grant him neighbourly (protection) till he hears the Words of Allah; thereafter convey him to his secure place." (TMQ, 9:6)**.

The ayahs follow in succession in the same rhythm; threatening but reminding of repentance. For instance, in the tenth ayah, Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"They respect (Literally: watch) neither consanguinity nor treaty towards a believer; and those are the ones (who are) transgressors." (TMQ, 9:10)**. The next ayah continues, **"So, in case they repent, and keep up the prayer, and bring the Zakat, (Pay the obligatory poor-dues.) then they are your brethren in the religion" (TMQ, 9:11)**. This ayah proves that once they repent, not only are they forgiven by Allah (*SWT*), but they are also granted the brotherhood and love of the believers.

Another warning is repeated in ayahs 12 and 14 in case the polytheists insist on fighting. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And in case they breach their oaths after their covenant, and discredit your religion, then fight the leaders of disbelief; surely they have no (binding) oaths, that possibly they would refrain" (TMQ, 9:12)**, and **"Fight them! Allah will torment them at your hands and disgrace them and grant you victory over them" (TMQ, 9:14).** This is immediately followed by an ayah that returns to repentance where Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"…and Allah relents towards whomever He decides" (TMQ, 9:15).** It is an excellent example of Islam's moderation and balance between compassion and leniency on one hand, and between reality and strictness on the other.

If this is the case with the disbelievers and hypocrites, then how will it be with the disobedient Muslims? Will Allah (*SWT*) forgive them? When Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"So, in case they repent… then they are your brethren in the religion" (TMQ, 9:11)** about the disbelievers, what would be the case when a believer sins?

Surat At-Tawbah is amongst the most surahs giving hope to Muslims of Allah's mercy. If Allah (*SWT*), the Lord of Might, repeatedly encourages even the disbelievers and hypocrites to go back to the path in repentance; and repeats the word *Tawbah* (repentance) 17 times in this surah, how can He not forgive the disobeying believers?

Repentance of languid believers that forsake giving support to Islam

We now reach ayah 24 that addresses the believers and urges them to fight for the victory of Allah's religion. The *Jihad* this ayah refers to is not limited to wars and battles, but extends to include all forms of giving aid to Islam making it a priority in a believer's life. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Say, "In case your fathers, and your sons, and your brethren, and your spouses, and your kinsmen, and riches that you have scored (Literally: committed) and commerce whose slackening you are apprehensive of, and dwellings you are satisfied with, in case**

these are more beloved to you than Allah and His Messenger and striving in His way, then await till Allah comes up with His Command; and Allah does not guide the immoral people." (TMQ, 9:24). This ayah mentions eight allowed forms of love, yet warns against letting any of those to be a reason for drifting away from Allah's path and leaving *Jihad* behind. Thus, one has to carry on Allah's orders with priority, and has to keep them beyond worldly desires lest Allah's punishment and wrath ensue, may Allah (*SWT*) forbid it!

The surah then shifts to deal with a new type of repentance; a different type other than that of the sins that people might commonly commit, like not lowering the gaze or delaying prayers. The surah invites those who forsake giving support to Islam to repent. It points out that this hideous act requires genuine repentance. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"O you who have believed, how is it with you, (that) when it is said to you, "March out in the way of Allah," you sink down heavily to the earth? Are you satisfied with the present life, (Literally: the lowly life, i.e., the life of this world) rather than with the Hereafter? Yet in no way is the enjoyment of the present life, in the Hereafter anything except a little thing." (TMQ, 9:38).**

A gentle reproach, that is followed by a strict tone in the next ayah where Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"In case ever you do not march out, He will torment you with a painful torment and will (readily) exchange instead of you another people." (TMQ, 9:39).** Beware that you all might be exchanged! Allah (*SWT*) is indeed capable to render His religion victorious, and He does not need anyone of us to do that, as He (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"In case ever you do not vindicate him, (The Prophet) yet Allah readily vindicated him" (TMQ, 9:40).**

This is followed by the ayah with the clear, broad command that excludes no one where Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"March out, light and heavy! And strive with your riches and yourselves in the way of Allah" (TMQ, 9:41)**. In order for the disbelievers to turn on their heels and repent, we need to fight them. Thus, the Muslims' struggle against them is an aid for them to repent, and head back to Allah's way. Consequently, the Muslims' failure to fight is a reason for the disbelievers to stay astray. Let us then start striving for the victory of our religion, carrying out all sorts of goodness to save ourselves and to help others repent.

Repenting of not depending on Allah (*SWT*)

Throughout the previous ayahs, the surah was about the Battle of *Honayn* and how the Muslims were overconfident due to the fact that their army had a larger number of soldiers. However, this large number did not help them in any way and they slipped into the misconception that victory depends on quantity, forgetting that it is only from Allah (*SWT*), as He says what can be translated as, **"Indeed Allah has already (granted) you victory on many battlefields, and on the day of Hunayn, when your multitude made you admire it, yet it availed you nothing; and the earth, spacious as it is, was strait for you; thereafter you turned away, withdrawing." (TMQ, 9:25).** This grave mistake requires repentance and ayah 27 points that out as Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Thereafter Allah even after that**

relents towards whomever He decides ؛and Allah is Ever-Forgiving, Ever-Merciful." (TMQ, 9:27).

Failure to aid Islam

The ayahs then switch to tackle the hypocrites who failed to aid Allah's religion. In ayah 46 Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And if they had been willing to go out (among you), they would indeed have made some preparation (Literally: prepared a preparation) for it; but Allah hated that they should be sent forth, so He discouraged them" (TMQ, 9:46).** If they had a sincere intention to march out, they would have prepared for the battle and moved forward. However, their intentions were fake and Allah (*SWT*) hated that they should join the Muslims' army and discouraged them**.** Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"…so He discouraged them, and it was said to them, "Sit with the ones sitting back." (TMQ, 9:46).**

These are indeed painful words to a Muslim. If you are denied the chance of participating in charity or missionary work, just remember that you could be subject to Allah's wrath, and that your good deeds might not be accepted. Who would take that? Who would like to be a burden on this religion?! Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And if they had gone out among you, in no way would they have increased you except in confusion…" (TMQ, 9:47).**

The ayahs then follow in succession with reproach. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as,

- **"And of them is he who says, "Give me permission (i.e., permission to be excused from fighting) and do not tempt me." Verily they have already fallen down into temptation; and surely Hell is indeed encompassing the disbelievers" (TMQ, 9:49),**
- **"And they swear by Allah that surely they are indeed of you, and in no way are they of you …" (TMQ, 9:56),** and
- **"If they could find a shelter, or (some) cavernous places, or any place of entry, they would indeed turn about and bolt away (to it)." (TMQ, 9:57)**

Ayahs 81-87 enclose a severe tone. For instance, Allah (*SWT*) says in ayah 86 what can be translated as, **"And when a surah is sent down (saying), "Believe in Allah and strive with His Messenger, "those endowed with ampleness among them ask you permission (i.e., permission to stay behind and not fight) and say, "Leave us (behind) with the ones sitting back." (TMQ, 9:86) "…The ones sitting back"**, what a moving expression! Who would accept to be sitting at home watching TV and doing nothing to aid his religion? Such a person could be very religious and keen to pray in the mosque, for example, yet very passive and would never bother to serve Islam. These type of people should be aware of ayah number 87 where Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"They are satisfied to be with the ones tarrying behind, (i.e. among the women, who generally remain behind) and their hearts are stamped upon, so they do not comprehend." (TMQ, 9:87).** How could they be on the right path if they remain in that state?

On the other hand, look at the positive example as Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"But the Messenger and the ones who have believed with him have striven with their riches and their selves; and those will have the most charitable (benefits) and those are they (who) are prosperous." (TMQ, 9: 88).**

Rejoicing in Hell

In ayah 81, there is stern reproach where Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as**, "The ones who were left behind exulted with their seat (s) behind the back of Messenger of Allah …" (TMQ, 9:81).** It clarifies how unbalanced their standards of happiness and sadness are. Who would be happy and proud of failing to support Islam? Rejoicing this is like celebrating hellfire! Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"…and hated to strive with their riches and their selves in the way of Allah, and said, "Do not march out in the heat." Say, "The fire of his strictly hotter," if they (really) comprehend * So, let them laugh a little and weep much in recompense for what they have been earning." (TMQ, 9:81-82).**

The call for everyone to repent

As aforementioned, each reproach in this surah is followed by a call for repentance. For instance we can see:

- The repentance of hypocrites and apostates; Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"… in case they repent, it will be more charitable (i.e., better) for them; and in case they turn back Allah will torment them with a painful torment in the present (life) (Literally: the lowly (life), the life of this world) and the Hereafter; and in no way do they have in the earth a constant patron or a ready vindicator." (TMQ, 9:74).**

- The repentance of the hesitant; Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And others have confessed their guilty (deeds); they have mixed a righteous deed with another odious (one). It may be that Allah will relent towards them; surely Allah is Ever-Forgiving, Ever-Merciful." (TMQ, 9:102).**

- Urging everyone to repent; Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Do they not know that Allah He, Ever He, accepts repentance from His bondmen, and He takes the donations; (i.e., Free will offering) and that Allah, He, Ever He, is The Superbly Relenting, The Ever-Merciful?" (TMQ, 9:104).**

There are three conditions for an accepted repentance:

1. Regretting the sins committed,
2. Quitting them, and
3. Determining not to go back to them again.

Take the initiative right now and repent, since delaying it is in itself a sin.

The attributes of Muslims deserving martyrdom

After having dealt with the attributes of hypocrites, the surah moves on to talk about the attributes of the true believers who made the valuable purchase that Allah (*SWT*) describes in what can be translated as, **"Surely Allah has purchased from the believers their selves and their riches for (the reward) that the Garden will be theirs; they fight in the way of Allah; so they kill, and are killed. It is a promise, truly (binding) on Him in the Tawrah, and the Injil, and the Qur'an; and who fulfills his covenant (better) than Allah! So feel glad of the tidings of the selling you have made (Literally: allegiance you have sworn) with Him; and that is the (bargain) (that is) the magnificent triumph." (TMQ, 9:111).**

Thus, the Qur'anic context incites us to learn more about the attributes of the true believers. We turn the page to read what can be translated as, **"(Triumphant are) the repentant (ones), the worshipers, the ones praising (Him), wandering (in His way), bowing down, prostrating themselves, the ones commanding beneficence and forbidding male-ficence, and the ones preserving the bounds of Allah; and give good tidings to the believers." (TMQ, 9:112).**

Repentance of the elite of the *Ummah* (Islamic nation)

So splendid is repentance that Allah (*SWT*) reminds the Prophet (*SAWS*) and his noble companions of it saying what can be translated as, **"Indeed Allah has already relented towards the Prophet and the Muhajir ûn (The Supporters, i.e., the inhabitants) and the Ansar (The Supporters, i.e., the inhabitants of Al-Madînah who sheltered and helped those who emigrated from Makkah) who closely followed him in the hour of difficulty, even after the hearts of a group of them had almost swerved aside; thereafter He relented towards them; surely He is Ever-Compassionate, Ever-Merciful to them." (TMQ, 9:117).**

Repentance, as explained by religious scholars, is the first level of being a bondman of Allah (*SWT*) as well as the last. True faith begins with sincere repentance. Moreover, it is required at the end of life. Hence, we can understand the Prophet's (*SAWS*) Hadith saying, "By Allah! I ask for forgiveness from Allah and turn to Him in repentance more than seventy times a day."[31]

A final repentance for the three left behind

Finally, there is the repentance for the three Muslims who were left behind in the Battle of *Tabouk*. Letting Islam down and failing to run for its aid is a serious sin that requires repentance. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And to the three who were left staying behind, until, when the earth, spacious as it is, became strait for them, and their selves became strait for them, and they expected that there was no shelter from Allah except in Him; thereafter He relented towards them that they might repent; surely Allah, He, Ever He, is The Superbly Relenting, The Ever-Merciful." (TMQ, 9:118).**

Do you notice the wonderful meaning in, **"thereafter He relented towards them that they might repent"**. Allah (*SWT*) has to forgive you first and guide you towards repentance. Thus, guidance is from Allah (*SWT*) and only He can help you find it.

[31] Authentic Hadith, Al-Bukhari.

Hence, my dear Muslim brothers and sisters, always repeat this *dua'a* (supplication): "Oh, Allah forgives me so that I may repent."

The best end of the best life

The first impression a reader of surat At-Tawbah gets is that it is full of threats, warnings and severe scolding. Nevertheless, this is done as the surah receives everybody with open arms for repentance. Moreover, it is indeed a tender sign in the Qur'an that Allah (*SWT*) did not name this surah "The Exposer" since Allah (*SWT*) loves to conceal the deeds of his bondmen. One more grace in this surah is that despite the fact that it deprives the hypocrites from Allah's mercy at the beginning, through depriving them of *Al-Basmalah* and the acquittal from them; it still provides everybody with mercy at the end, exemplified in Prophet Muhammad (*SAWS*) who has been sent as a messenger of mercy to mankind. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Indeed there has already come to you a Messenger from (among) yourselves. Mighty (i.e., burdensome) to him is whatever distresses you. Most eager is he for your (welfare), to the believers (he is) constantly compassionate, constantly merciful." (TMQ, 9: 128).**

This ayah is the best closure to the seven longest surahs in the Holy Qur'an. Being the last complete surah to be revealed to the Prophet (*SAWS*), it is also the best end to his life (*SAWS*). It is the farewell surah, and the greatest farewell in our religion is accepting repentance from everybody. In case this great offer of repentance is turned down, Allah (*SWT*) says in the last ayah what can be translated as, **"So, in case they turn away, then say, "Allah is enough (Reckoner) for me. There is no god except He. On Him I have put my trust; He is the Lord of the Magnificent Throne." (TMQ, 9:129).**

Dear brother and sister ask yourself whether you are going to repent or not. If Allah (*SWT*) has opened the doors of repentance to all mankind, no matter how close or far they are from His path, what would you do, being the believer that you are who loves Allah's teachings and His Book? Let us all then work and live for Islam. We also have to beware not to fail in advocating and supporting it. Furthermore, we have to have absolute faith that Allah (*SWT*) forgives whomever He pleases.

From the graces of the Qur'an

We conclude by pointing out that both surat At-Tawbah and surat Al-Anfal are consecutive, conforming to the time order of the two Battles of *Badr* and *Tabouk. surat* Al-Anfal deals with the Battle of *Badr*, the first battle of the Prophet (*SAWS*), while surat At-Tawbah deals with his last battle. The sequence of the surahs points out the difference in the Islamic community between the time when Muslims started to lead their religion to victory and the last actual and great victory. The two surahs open the field for sociologists and researchers to notice the differences between the two societies and to analyze their development; an analysis, which requires observation and critical thinking.

Qur'anic Reflections

Insights into the objectives of the Qur'anic verses

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Part 2/3

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Surat Yunus (Jonah)

Surat Yunus is a Makkan surah. It was revealed after Surat Al-Isra' and is located in the Qur'an after Surat At-Tawbah. This Surah consists of 109 ayahs.

The objective of the Surah

The objective of this surah is the manifestation of the belief in the Divine decree. Omar Ibnul-Khattab (*RA*) narrated that "One day we were sitting in the company of Allah's Apostle (peace be upon him) when there appeared before us a man dressed in pure white clothes, his hair extraordinarily black. There were no signs of travel on him. None amongst us recognized him. At last he sat with the Prophet (*SAWS*) He knelt before him placed his palms on his thighs and said: Muhammad, inform me about al-Islam. The Messenger of Allah (*SAWS*) said: Al-Islam implies that you testify that there is no god but Allah and that Muhammad is the messenger of Allah, and you establish prayer, pay *Zakat*, observe the fast of Ramadan, and perform pilgrimage to the (House) if you are solvent enough (to bear the expense of) the journey. He (the inquirer) said: You have told the truth. He (Omar Ibnul-Khattab) said: It amazed us that he would put the question and then he would himself verify the truth. He (the inquirer) said: Inform me about Iman (faith). He (the Holy Prophet) replied: That you affirm your faith in Allah, in His angels, in His Books, in His Apostles, in the Day of Judgment, and you affirm your faith in the Divine Decree about good and evil"[1]. Thus, the surah deals with this last pillar of the pillars of faith.

Inquiries and doubtfulness:

Surat Yunus deals with a dilemma that many people face today and can be illustrated through the following queries:

- Is man impelled through life, or is he granted free will?
- Why does Allah (*SWT*) guide one man to the right path and not the other?
- Why does Allah (*SWT*) protect and saves a fellow and not the other?
- How is it that our Creator, who is well aware of what we do, makes us live through circumstances of His making and then judges us according to them on the Day of Judgment?
- If Allah (*SWT*) has already predestined some people to live a life of deviation, why then are we encouraged to worship? To the same effect, some people always quite comfortably reply, "When Allah wants us to, we will" when asked why they do not pray.
- If Allah (*SWT*) has already predestined us to be dwellers of either *Jannah* (Paradise) or hellfire, why then do we have to work, since whatever we do will not change our prospective status!

This surah teaches the reader of the Qur'an how to refute the claims of such perplexed, hesitant people and to reassure his/her own self. For example, some people are so influenced by doubts that they imagine that Allah (*SWT*) is being unjust when He predestines one person or another to be a dweller of hell (we seek Allah's refuge from being dwellers of hell).

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[1] Authentic Hadith, Muslim.

Before we attempt to refute such suspicions and uncertainties, we should first provide an answer to the following question, "How do you describe one who forces another to do something and then punishes him for doing it?" Such a person is definitely unjust and mischievous. Allah (*SWT*), of course, is far from being that. This surah, then, comes to refute all those falsehoods in an unprecedented way.

The Wise does not budge

When we take into consideration the Attributes of Allah (*SWT),* it becomes quite clear that the question we asked above is most inappropriate, since the Wise cannot be unjust or ever intend frivolity.

The deeds of Allah (*SWT*), evident all around us in administrating the universe, testify his wisdom and compassion for his subjects, as they are strictly not the deeds of an unjust monarch who forces helpless people to commit deeds against their will. Indeed, His deeds overflow with wisdom, Majesty, and insightful arrangement.

The surah reinforces this notion gracefully, as it stresses on the importance of meditation upon this universe and the wisdom of its creator, thus shedding light on His supreme knowledge and wise arrangement. This surah will also make it lucidly clear that everything in the universe is a direct outcome of this wisdom. Frivolity, therefore, can never be an attribute of Allah (*SWT*), so always put you trust in Him.

The wise Book

The notions referred to above are made clear from the very beginning of the surah. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"…Those are the ayat (Verses) of the Wise Book" (TMQ, 10:1).** The Qur'an has many attributes, as we know, but "the Wise" here is used for a particular reason, just so we would realize the immense wisdom and masterly planning that stands behind Allah's destiny and words.

In the second ayah, Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as **"Was it a wonder to mankind that We revealed to a man from (among) them, (saying), "Warn mankind and give good tidings to the ones who have believed that they have a sure footing (Literally: a sincere footing) in the Providence of their Lord"? The disbelievers have said, "Surely this is indeed an evident sorcerer." (TMQ, 10:2)**. The ayah addresses those who marvel at the fact that the message of Allah (*SWT*) was revealed to Muhammad (*SAWS*) of all people. Allah (*SWT*) reveals His message to whomever He wills, and there is always a great insight behind every choice that Allah (*SWT*) makes. He chooses the deliverers of His message out of wisdom; **"Allah knows best where He makes His Message" (TMQ 6:124).**

"Conducting the Command" (TMQ, 10:2).

The ayahs move on to the dominance of Allah (*SWT*) over the universe in order to make us perceive His attributes in a way that disproves all false claims. In this respect, Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Surely your Lord is Allah, Who created the heavens and the earth in six days; thereafter He leveled Himself upon the Throne, (How He did do is beyond human understandings) conducting the Command. In no way is there any intercessor (ever) excepting ever after His**

permission. That is Allah, your Lord; so worship Him. Will you then not be mindful?" (TMQ, 10:2).

"…Conducting the Command" recurs all through the surah emphasizing Allah's wisdom and great organization**.** Again, frivolity is never consistent with Allah's immense wisdom. It is illogical, therefore, that He would unjustly force people to sin in order to meet his own plans; his predestination of them to be of the dwellers of hell.

Truth is its title

In the next ayah in which Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"To Him will be your return altogether, the promise of Allah, truly (binding)..." (TMQ, 10:4),** "truly" or truth, is the opposite of coincidence and futility. That is why it is repeated in this surah, whose subject-matter is belief in fate and destiny, 23 times; the highest number of occurrences in the Qur'an. The word occurs 23 times in a Surah of 109 ayahs. In Surat Al-'Imran, the 200-ayah-long surah, the same word occurs 13 times only. A huge difference indeed! The repetitions are in proportion to Surat Yunus' main focus; submission to Allah's fate and destiny. Anybody who is suspicious of this should speculate upon Allah's creation and impeccable administration of the universe.

The previous ayah goes on to clearly state that punishment is a direct result of blasphemy, in what Allah (*SWT*) says and can be translated as, **"To Him will be your return altogether, the promise of Allah, truly (binding). Surely He begins the creation; thereafter He brings it back again to recompense the ones who have believed and done deeds of righteousness with equity. And the ones who have disbelieved will have a drink of scalding water and a painful torment for that they have been disbelieving." (TMQ, 10:4).**

In no way has Allah created that except with the truth

The next ayah draws our attention to Allah's creation and management of the universe. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"He is The (One) Who has made the sun an illumination, and the moon a light and determined it by phases that you may know the number of years and the reckoning. In no way has Allah created that except with the truth. He expounds the signs for a people who know. Surely, in the alternation (Or: the differences) of the night and the daytime and whatever Allah has created in the heavens and the earth, are indeed signs for a people who are pious..." (TMQ, 10:5-6).** The previous ayah tempts us to contemplate on Allah's alteration of day and night. Only Allah (*SWT*) is capable of such flawless management. The one who manages all these affairs is far from being frivolous, and He would never force people into hellfire unreasonably.

Who poses such questions?

Ayah seven specifies which types of people hold such invalid beliefs. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Surely the ones who do not hope for the meeting with Us and are satisfied with the present life, (Literally: the lowly life, i.e., the life of this world) and feel composed with it, and the ones who are heedless of**

Our signs, Those (have) their abode in the Fire, for what they were earning"(TMQ, 10:7-8).

The ayah points here to a very significant observation that the surah encloses; only impious and stray people pose such questions regarding Allah's wisdom in order to relieve their consciences. Never do pious people say that Allah (*SWT*) compelled them to obey Him. The ayah also specifies the cause behind those people's misery. It is being unmindful of Allah's miracles and being unable to grasp Allah's magnificent wisdom that is evident in His creation.

The wisdom of Allah in all His deeds

The ayahs continue to confirm the notion that playfulness can never be attributed to Allah (*SWT*) as His deeds only indicate wisdom. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Say, "Who provides you from the heaven and the earth, or even who possesses hearing and beholdings, (i.e., eyesights) and who brings out the living from the dead and brings out the dead from the living, and who conducts the Command?" Then will they soon say, "Allah."." (TMQ, 10:31).** Why are they suspicious then? Allah (SWT) says what can be translated as, **"Then will you not be pious?" (TMQ, 10:31).** Thus, always observe Allah's boundaries in what you say.

Once again, we come across the words **"the True"** and **"has come true"** in the following ayah to put our hearts at ease as Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"That then is Allah, your Lord, The True; so what is there, after the Truth, except error? Then wherever are you turned about? Thus the Word of your Lord has come true against the ones who were immoral that they do not believe." (TMQ, 10:32-33).**

Then after these ayahs, Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Say, "Is there any of your associates (Those things associated with Allah) who gives guidance towards the Truth?" Say, "Allah guides to the Truth. Then is He who guides to the Truth (worthier) to be closely followed or he who finds no guidance (for himself or others) unless he is guided? What (plea) have you; how do you judge?""" (TMQ 10:35)**.

I really wonder how those who are suspicious of Allah's design judge things; how do they not submit to Allah's will, while they are living their lives in His universe. The Compeller of Heavens and Earth makes the following vow in what can be translated as, **"And they ask you to inform them, "Is it true?" Say, "Yea, by my Lord! Surely it is true indeed; and in no way can you be defiant to (Him).""" (TMQ, 10:53)** After that, Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Verily, to Allah surely (belongs) whatever is in the heavens and the earth. Verily, the promise of Allah surely is true; but most of them do not know." (TMQ, 10:55).** Thus, a big number of ayahs reinforce this same notion focusing mainly on the heart, so as to do away with any vestiges of suspicion.

Your deeds are the cause

As the ayahs focus on attributes like truth, wisdom, and wise management, they pave the way for the fact that what occurs to people is just the result of their deeds and acts.

Torment and destruction are never inflicted upon people unless they become unjust. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Surely Allah does not do injustice to mankind in anything, but mankind do injustice to themselves." (TMQ 44:10)**. People are directly responsible for what happens to them. They should not accuse Allah (*SWT*) of being unjust to them when they encounter anguish. On the contrary, they should reconsider their own deeds, as Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And We have already caused the generations even before you to perish as soon as they did injustice and their Messengers came to them with the Supreme evidences; and in no way were they to believe ؛thus We recompense the criminal people" (TMQ 13:10).** They were doomed only when their corruption and injustice became evident.

Many more ayahs stress the same notion, as Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as,
"And for the ones who have earned odious deeds, the recompense of a bad deed will be the like of it, and humiliation shall oppress them…" (TMQ, 10:27),
"There! Every person will know (exactly) what he had earned before…" (TMQ 10:30), and
"Thus the Word of your Lord has come true against the ones who were immoral that they do not believe" (TMQ 10:33).

On the other hand, the ayahs indicate that Allah's reward is not haphazardly granted. Rather, it is granted to those who well deserve it. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"To the ones who are fair-doers is the fairest reward and an increase…" (TMQ 10:26).**

Allah (*SWT*) knows his worshippers best

The surah then moves on to a new concept and introduces an abrupt question; how do you wonder at the destiny of Allah (*SWT*) when your attitude and deeds towards it are even stranger? Read the following ayah, where Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And when adversity touches man, he invokes Us to his side, or sitting, or upright, then as soon as We have lifted off him his adversity, he passes on, as if he had not invoked Us to an adversity that touched him…" (TMQ 10:12).**

This ayah depicts two different scenes in a very wonderful way; the image of a downhearted man who invokes Allah (*SWT*) at all times while lying on his side, sitting, or standing. This image implies slow motion on the part of the man invoking Allah (*SWT*). However, once the crisis is over, he rashly changes his behavior, **"he passes on"**, to indulge in life forgetting his Creator. He moves on without thanking Allah (*SWT*) for His blessing or even contemplating on the crisis he has been through. In the following ayah, Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And when We cause mankind to taste mercy even after tribulation has touched them, only then do they have a scheming against Our signs; Say, "Allah is swifter at scheming…" (TMQ, 10:21).**

This ayah explains how fate and destiny take place. If some wonder at Allah's fate, Allah (*SWT*) does know who would thank Him and who would not. The next ayah follows to elaborate more, where Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"He is**

The (One) Who makes you to travel on the land and the sea till, when you are in the ships, and the ships run with them with a good wind, and they exult with it…"(TMQ, 10:22). We have to stop here at the middle of the ayah to contemplate on how the human heart is ever so open and tender to its Creator at trying times. Yet, once a crisis clears out, the same heart is back again to being ungrateful toward its Creator.

What happened then, when the **"good wind"** and happiness was over? Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"…there comes to them (i.e., the ships) a tempestuous wind, and waves come on them from every place, and they expect that they are encompassed. They invoke Allah, making the religion His faithfully, "Indeed if You deliver us from these, (i.e., the wind and the waves) indeed we will definitely be of the thankful.""(TMQ 10:22).**

What takes place in the water is very similar to what actually happens in the ever changing sea of life. How would the passengers of the ship act after having been saved? The reply is in the following ayah as Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Yet as soon as He has delivered them, only then do they (transgress) inequitably in the earth untruthfully. (Literally: with other than the truth)." (TMQ, 10:23)** This is the peak of contradiction and deviation from the truth, because Allah (*SWT*) is Self-Sufficient as He (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"O you mankind, surely your inequity is only against yourselves. The enjoyment is of the present life; (Literally: the lowly life, i.e., the life of this world) thereafter to Us will be your return, then We will fully inform you of whatever you were doing." (TMQ, 10:23).**

What is the relation between this example and the aim of the surah? This ayah asks the reader not to wonder about the destiny of Allah (*SWT*), since He already knows who will thank Him and repent after having been saved from the calamity, and who will return to sins again.

The messages of destiny

Sometimes, fate and destiny occur because Allah (*SWT*) knows how a person will behave after having been delivered from afflictions. Before facing real afflictions, we all go through situations that manifest our attitudes when the crisis is over. One might experience minor problems and makes *dua'a* (supplication) to Allah (*SWT*) to be saved. Nevertheless, Allah (*SWT*) may torment him because He knows how that person will behave if Allah saves him as usual.

Fate and destiny are strictly products of Allah's wisdom. We may understand this wisdom, and in some cases it is beyond our comprehension. What is really important is that we should never suspect it. We should declare our absolute submission to Allah (*SWT*) and trust in Him. We should believe that He is the Wise and the All-Knowing Who is never unfair.

The Prophets and their trust in Allah (*SWT*)

The stories of the Prophets are referred to in this surah in order to demonstrate the extent to which they put their trusts in Allah (*SWT*) during their missions as

messengers to their people; namely Nuh (Noah) and Musa (Moses) (*AS*). In this respect, Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And recite to them the tiding (Literally: information) of Nûh (Noah) as he said to his people, "O my people, in case my station (here) is greatly (annoying) to you, and my constant reminding you of the signs of Allah, then on Allah I have put my trust"…" (TMQ, 10:71).**

Allah (*SWT*) says about Musa (*AS*), what can be translated as, **"And Mûsa said, "O my people, in case you have believed in Allah, then in Him put your trust, in case you are Muslims." (i.e., you have surrendered to Allah) Then they said, "On Allah we have put our trust. Our Lord, do not make us a temptation to the unjust people." (TMQ, 10:84-85).**

The Pharaoh and The people of Yunus (*AS*) (Jonah)

Towards the end of the surah, two stories are used to clarify what has been mentioned, the story of Pharaoh and that of the people of Yunus (*AS*) (Jonah). After the wisdom and impeccable arrangement of Allah (*SWT*) are fully demonstrated, two examples are provided. The first example is of Pharaoh, who denied Allah's miracles and warnings. The second is of the people of Yunus (*AS*) "Jonah", who denied the existence of Allah (*SWT*) at the beginning.

In the two examples, both Prophets, Musa and Yunus (*AS*), went to the sea, leaving behind their peoples who disbelieved in Allah's messengers, until they were tormented. What actually happened is that while the people of Yunus (*AS*) were saved, the people of the Pharaoh were drowned. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And We made the Seeds (Or: sons) of Israel) pass over the sea; then Firaawn and his hosts followed them up inequitably and aggressively till, when the drowning overtook him, he said, "I believe that there is no god except He in Whom the Seeds of believe, and I am one of the Muslims"" (TMQ, 10:90).** Here, when he claims to be a believer, the answer to this claim can be translated as, **"Do you (believe) now? And before (that) you readily disobeyed, and you were (one) of the corruptors." (TMQ, 10:91)**.

The story of the people of Yunus (*AS*) is similar to that of Pharaoh. The only difference is that they were saved at the end, as Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"So, was there a town that believed (and) so its belief profited it, except the people of Yûnus? As soon as they believed, We lifted off from them the torment of disgrace in the present life, (Literally: the lowly life, i.e., the life of this world) and We gave them enjoyment for a while." (TMQ, 10:98).**

Allah's torment had been inflicted upon them but their subsequent faith saved them from that affliction. What is the difference between Pharaoh and the people of Yunus (*AS*)? Both of them declared by the end that they believed. Moreover, the messengers of both left them when they initially refused to believe. Why, then, did Allah (*SWT*) destroy Pharaoh and rescue the people of Yunus? Can Allah (*SWT*) be unjust or even biased towards the people of Yunus? It is indeed a wonderful example of how fate and destiny take place.

"Will He not know, (He) Who created?" (TMQ, 67:14)

Allah (*SWT*) knows best what lies in our hearts. If Pharaoh were rescued, he would have returned to his original state of disbelief, while the people of Yunus (*AS*) were rescued by Allah (*SWT*) because He knew they would be true believers following the right path. This is why Allah (*SWT*) destroyed Pharaoh and rescued the people of Yunus.

This is clearly demonstrated in what can be translated as, **"…now? And before (that) you readily disobeyed…" (TMQ, 10:91**). This means that Pharaoh was given a great deal of opportunities to repent. However, he was always a wrong-doer; he always returned to his ill-deeds and corruption. He even saw the miracle of dividing the sea into two parts so the believers would cross it, and instead of contemplating upon this great miracle, he followed the believers blindly until he himself drowned. In fact, instead of reflecting on the implications of this miracle, he followed the believers not out of belief in Allah (*SWT*), but rather out of fear of destruction

On the other hand, Allah (*SWT*) knew about the sincerity of the people of Yunus (*AS*) and since He is the Merciful, He saved them and gave them another chance. They actually proved that they deserved that chance by remaining as true believers after being saved. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"We lifted off from them the torment of disgrace in the present life, (Literally: the lowly life, i.e., the life of this world) and We gave them enjoyment for a while…" (TMQ, 10:98).** They remained dutiful to Allah (*SWT*) and, consequently, enjoyed His blessings during their life. They were the winners and for that reason the surah was named after their Prophet's name.

Why the surah was entitled "Yunus"

Prophet Yunus' name is mentioned only once in the surah that carries his name, while it is mentioned more than once in many other Surahs of the Qur'an. Interestingly, only his people are referred to in this surah, and not him. He left them and was already in the whale's belly when they became believers.

This surah was entitled "Yunus" so that the people of Yunus (*AS*) remain a witness on the wisdom of Allah (*SWT*). It also reinforces the fact that man's deeds play a key role in what happens to him. After repentance, the people of Yunus maintained piety in spite of the absence of their Prophet. Thus, their story indicates that Allah's wisdom in saving them was well founded as Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"So Allah suffices as Ever-Witnessing…" (TMQ 10: 29).**

You may wonder why Allah (*SWT*) did not give Pharaoh the same chance since he may have repented in that case. The answer is in ayahs 22 and 23, which would ask you if you have even read the surah or if you believe in Allah's wisdom. Well, Allah (*SWT*) knows Pharaoh best. Moreover, fate and destiny are based on His great wisdom and are never haphazard. You may or may not understand Allah's wisdom; but rest assured that Allah (*SWT*) is the Wise and the All-Knowing Who is never unjust, so always put your trust in Him.

How do we deal with destiny?

The surah ends with a practical lesson that comprises three commandments concerning belief in fate and destiny; surrender to Allah (*SWT*), resort to no one but Him, and finally, put your trust only in Him. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And keep your (i.e. the Prophet's) face up to the religion, unswervingly upright, and definitely do not be of the associators. (Those who associate others with Allah) And do not invoke, apart from Allah, that which neither profits nor harms you; then in case you do this, then you will surely be of the unjust (people)." (TMQ 10:105-106).**

Whatever happens, your faith in fate and destiny should never waver. Moreover, believe that what Allah (*SWT*) destines is out of His mercy and is for your good. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And in case Allah touches you with adversity, then none (can) lift it off except He; and in case He wills any charity for you, then none (can) turn back His Grace; He causes it to alight on whomever He decides of His bondmen; and He is The Ever-Forgiving, The Ever-Merciful." (TMQ, 10:107).** Hence, submit to His fate and destiny to be safe in life and the hereafter**.**

Surat Hud

Surat Hud consists of 123 ayahs and was revealed in Makkah after Surat Yunus; this is also how the Surahs appear in the sequence of the Holy Qur'an.

Three consecutive Surahs with Prophets' names

There are several Surahs in the Qur'an that are named after Prophets, some of which are the three consecutive Surahs, Yunus, Hud, and Yusuf. These Surahs are united by several resemblances. They were the first Surahs of the Qur'an to be named after Prophets. They were revealed in the same sequence you would find in the Qur'an. In addition, they were revealed during the same Makkan period, which was characterized by increased distress on Muslims and the Prophet (*SAWS*).

It is important here to mention that there is a Qur'anic rule in narrating Prophets' stories. When the name of a Prophet is used as a title for a Surah, the objective of the Surah is always related to that Prophet's story, as in the example of Surat Yunus *(AS)*, whose main objective was the submission to Allah's wisdom in fate.

Another Qur'anic rule that makes one feel the glory of this book and its magnificence is that every story of Allah's Prophets ends with an ayah or a group of ayahs that clarify the moral behind the story. If one wanted to know the divine message that any story carries, one just needs to read the last line in that Surah's Prophetic story. It is a magnificent rule that is repeated in a wondrous way in the Qur'an.

Earthquakes of Trials

This Surah was revealed ten years after the Prophet's *(SAWS)* call during the darkest and hardest of all times for him. The Muslims were oppressed in Makkah, and thus, the Prophet gave permission to his companions to migrate to Al-Habasha (Ethiopia). Other companions, who were left in Makkah, remained to suffer various types of torment.

As for Allah's messenger, his state wasn't much better than the state of his companions. His uncle and protector, Abu Taleb, and his wife Khadija bint Khuwailed, who used to solace him, both died. Moreover, when the Prophet went to "Al-Taif" to invite people to Islam, they rejected him and harshly threw stones at him. At the same time, additional people in Makkah stopped converting to Islam and all tribes refused to support the Prophet *(SAWS)* or to accept this religion.

How similar today is with yesterday

The circumstances that the Prophet (*SAWS*) and his followers passed through were harsh and very much resemble the hardships that Islam and Muslims are facing now. The aura of this Surah is useful to religious youth. Open your minds and hearts in order to understand Allah's aim from this Surah.

When humans live under pressure, just like the Prophet's companions, or similar to what we are facing today, they must fall in one of the following problems:

1. Loss of hope, will, and discontinuation of efforts toward reform and Islamic work.
2. Rashness and resorting to violence or other un-calculated actions in order to enforce change.
3. Relying on enemies, throwing themselves in their arms, completely surrendering to them, and living in their shadow.

Do you see similar kinds of problems in our society? What is the solution? What does this Surah say to such people?

Surat Hud's objective is balance

This Surah deals with these dangerous phenomena in a pivotal ayah that addresses the feelings of religious Muslims who suffer from the injustice happening to Islam. It also addresses those youth who love their religion and are enthusiastic towards doing any thing to support Islam. Allah says in this Surah what can be translated as: "**So go straight, as you have been commanded, (you) and whoever repents with you, and do not be inordinate; surely He is Ever-Beholding whatever you do. And do not (seek) support (you believers) for the ones who have done injustice, (for) then the Fire (would) touch you; and in no way do you have any patrons apart from Allah, (and) thereafter you will not be vindicated (i.e., if you seek support for the ones who have done injustice)." (TMQ, 11: 112-113).**

These two ayahs come towards the end of the Surah, after all the Prophets' stories were mentioned, to give us three orders:

Endurance: **"So go straight,"** means to continue and persist in your call for Islam with patience. Never loose hope if you face difficulties. Straightness deals with the first kind of problems we have mentioned, which is the loss of hope and will.

Avoid transgression: **"do not be in ordinate"** this is the Qur'anic expression of rashness and resorting to violence.

Avoid inclination: **"Do not (seek) support (you believers) for the ones who have done injustice."** This expression is the legal expression in the Qur'an referring to inclination to enemies by embracing them as allies or friends. It also refers to the complete submission to other cultures, and the blind mimicking, which leads any person to the loss of identity and sense of belonging to the Islamic way of life.

These three instructions are the treatment for the three problems that humans suffer from when they face crisis, defeat, and dark conditions. A Muslim is required to act in moderation when faced with any crisis or problems. A Muslim should not transgress or take action in something rash or pose any inclination towards his enemies. This balanced behavior can be achieved by endurance, just as Allah ordered, and by continuing the advancement on the path of Islam through reform, regardless of the circumstances. This can happen through improving your society, presenting good to the poor and needy, and striving to be successful in your practical life.

The order "**So go straight**" is the moderation of Islam and its balanced approach in handling life matters.

This Surah deals with the situation we are living in nowadays. It is, in fact, an evidence of Islam's validity in reforming at any given place and time. Therefore, this ayah seems to be saying to us, 'don't transgress, don't incline and travel straight'. The message of this Surah to all Muslims in every place and at every time is to be patient, continue reform with balance and moderation.

The beginning of the Surah - A book whose ayat are set clear

The Surah starts with what can be translated as: **"Alif, Lam, Ra. (These are names of letters of the Arabic alphabet, and only Allah knows their meaning here) A book whose ayat (i.e., verses, signs) are set clear; thereafter expounded from very close to (Or: close to the Grace of) One Ever-Wise, Ever-Cognizant, Alif, Lam, Ra. (These are names of letters of the Arabic alphabet, and only Allah knows their meaning here) A book whose ayat (i.e., verses, signs) are set clear; thereafter expounded from very close to (Or: close to the Grace of) One Ever-Wise, Ever-Cognizant,". (TMQ, 11:1)**

An interesting detail with respect to the correlation of the Qur'an and Surah is that the previous Surah (Surat Yunus) starts with the wise saying that can be translated as: **"In The Name of Allah, The All-Merciful, The Ever-Merciful Alif, Lam, Ra. (1) Those are the ayat (Verses) of the Wise Book."(TMQ, 10:1).**

The two Surahs start with these wise words. Therefore, what is the difference between the two?

Surat Yunus concentrates on the wisdom of Allah in His disposal of matters and His decisions in fate, while Surat Hud addresses the wisdom of Allah in His book and ayat, concentrating on the wisdom of the believer in handling his hard reality through the help of Allah's (The Wise) ayahs.

Insistence on the balanced Daw'ah (call for Islam)

The second ayah expresses clearly the meaning of persistence in calling for the way of Islam in a balanced manner, as Allah says what can be translated as: **"(Saying), "Worship none except Allah." Surely I (myself) (i.e., Muhammad) am to you a warner and a bearer of good things from Him.". (TMQ, 11:2).**
Then the verses move on to show how the enemies had disbelieved the Prophet (*SAWS*), so that the reader of the Qur'an can live in an atmosphere resembling the times of the revelations of this Surah. Allah says what can be translated as: **"Verily, (Literally: Is it not "true that"?) they surely bend their breasts to try to conceal themselves from Him. …" (TMQ, 11:5).**

Amid all these ayahs comes the seventh ayah with an interesting meaning. Allah says what can be translated as**: "And He (is The One) Who created the heavens and the earth in six days And He (is The One) Who created the heavens and the earth in six days …" (TMQ, 11:7).** What is the relation between the creation of the heavens and earth, and the atmosphere of this Surah? Gradual progress is a cosmic rule in

Allah's *(SWT)* universe. This may be, and Allah knows, why He created the heavens and earth in six days. Although He is capable of doing this in an instant, this serves as a lesson for us to move step-by-step in handling matters, with patience and calmness.

The eleventh ayah refers to the same meaning. Allah says what can be translated as: **"Except the ones who (endure) patiently and do deeds of righteousness…" (TMQ, 11:11).** The ayah says: **"patiently and do deeds of righteousness,"** although most of the Qur'an ayahs come with Allah saying: **"believed and made good deeds."** Do you see how there is wisdom behind every word and even every letter of the Qur'an, and that the ayahs of each Surah are all integrated around one topic. Allah *(SWT)* says at the beginning of the Surah what can be translated as: **"…A book whose ayat (i.e., verses, signs) are set clear A book whose ayat (i.e., verses, signs) are set clear…" (TMQ, 11:1).**

Due to the severity of the way the Prophet was doubted, the eleventh ayah of this Surah addresses the Prophet (*SAWS*) by saying what can be translated as: **"So, possibly you would leave some (ayat) (verses, signs) of what is revealed to you, and your breast would be straitened by it …" (TMQ, 11:12).** Did the Prophet leave some of what was revealed to him from Allah? Did his chest strain upon delivering the call for Islam? No, and Allah forbid that it could have happened, but the reason for this ayah was to stand beside the Prophet (*SAWS*) and beside all the believers after him in all the times and places. Stubborn disbelievers always argue with callers for Islam in a way that leads to no results. For those who love Allah's religion, Allah says what can be translated as: **"…Surely you are only a warner; and Allah is an Ever-Trusted Trustee over everything." (TMQ, 11:12).**

Thus, you are Allah slave and you must do as you are ordered to do without looking at the results, since Allah is the Only One who knows of the true end results; **"…Allah is an Ever-Trusted Trustee over everything".**

The first 24 ayahs of the Surah form a clear message to the callers of Islam; mainly, that disbelieving is a hard path. You have to be firm, stable and exert all your efforts. Then leave the whole matter for Allah and depend on Him.

Models of straightness

The following ayahs are quite consistent in their narrative, stating different stories of Allah's *(SWT)* Prophets (Nuh, Hud, Saleh, Shu'ayb, and Musa, peace be upon them all). The concentration in each story is on the Prophet's implementation of the three orders (straightness in a persistent manner, **"So go straight"**, avoiding rashness, **"do not be in ordinate",** and avoid inclination to enemies **"do not (seek) support (you believers) for the ones who have done injustice.")**

Prophet Nuh (AS) - 950 years

The first story to project the meaning of endurance, firmness, and stability was Nuh's story. It's worth mentioning that Surat Hud contains the longest of all Nuh's stories in the Qur'an, even longer than Surat Nuh itself. Nuh remained 950 years inviting his people to the religion without any response from them. Thus, he can be considered a model and an example of endurance without loss of hope.

"And indeed We already sent Nûh (Noah) to his people (saying), "Surely I am for you an evident warner. That you worship none except Allah. Surely I fear for you the torment of a painful Day." (TMQ, 11:25-26).

The words that Prophet Nuh used in addressing his people are the same as those by which the Surah starts. Allah says what can be translated as: **"(Saying), "Worship none except Allah." Surely I (myself) (i.e., Muhammad) am to you a warner and a bearer of good things from Him." (TMQ, 11:2).**

It is as if it means to say that the message is one, the call is one, and the circumstances that all the Prophets faced are the same. Stand straight and firm, like Nuh (*PBUH*).

The Righteousness of *Nuh* (Noah)

We can clearly see the resoluteness of Nuh *(AS)* and his persistence in his mission; Allah says what can be translated as, **"They said, "O *Nuh*, (Noah) you have already disputed with us and so made much disputation with us. Then come up to us with what you promise us, in case you are of the sincere", (TMQ, 11:32).**

Nuh *(AS)* continued preaching his people for hundreds of years. To those who are missionaries, the message testifies: If you think your circumstances are dire, compare yourself to Nuh *(AS),* who stayed unwavering on the path of his mission. He preached his people in many different ways without ever feeling weary or jaded, until finally, his people themselves became bored with him.

They responded by commenting that if he was telling the truth, he should bring about the torment he was talking about. Previous to this, ayahs 28-31 show us various situations of his debates with them and the various efforts and methods that were used.

Thus, Nuh's application of the first method comes to light in the surah; Allah says what can be translated as, **"So go straight, as you have been commanded…" (TMQ, 11:112).**

Distance from Recklessness in the Story of *Nuh (AS)*

What would you do if you were to be placed under the same conditions that Nuh (*AS*) faced, and was told as in what Allah says that can be translated as, **"…Then come up to us with what you promise us," (TMQ, 11:32)**. Would you turn reckless? Would you harm them? What would your response be?

Observe how Nuh (*AS*) spoke to his tribe, far from any recklessness or harshness. Allah says what can be translated as, **"He said, "Surely only Allah will be coming up to you with it, in case He (so) decides; and in no way will you be defiant to (Him). And my advice will not profit you, in case I am willing to advise you, in case Allah wills to misguide you; He is your Lord, and to Him you will be returned" (TMQ, 11:33-34).**

It is rather a soft and gentle tone that does not involve recklessness or harshness. Nuh (AS) articulated, 'the problem is not between you and me. It is Allah Who will inflict torment upon you if He so wills.'

Construct an Ark!

Allah says what can be translated as, **"And work out (i.e., make) the Ship(s)… (TMQ 11:37)**. The ayahs continue until we reach the verse in which Allah says what can be translated as, **"And it was revealed to *Nuh* (that), "Never will any of your people believe, except him who has already believed; so do not feel chagrined for whatever they were performing (TMQ, 11:36)**." In view of that, what are we to do O' Lord? Do we depart from them since they would drown? Not yet, there are divine commandments still to come and the path ahead is far from over.

Allah says what can be translated as, **"And work out (i.e., make) the Ship(s) (Arabic *fulk* "ship" can mean singular or plural) under Our Eyes and by Our revelation, and do not address Me concerning the ones who have done injustice; surely they will be drowned", (TMQ, 11:37).**

The manufacturing of an ark takes many long years. Nuh (*AS*) had lived in the desert and in order for him to construct a large ark, he needed to grow trees to build it with. Following that, he would take the wood from those trees to build an enormous ship that could accommodate all the believers and also carry two pairs from every type of animal.

That was a very difficult task and of long duration. Some scholars say that it took 100 years, some say 200 years, and others said 300 years. One might ask a question at this point; why did Allah not punish the disbelievers of Nuh in the same way that He had punished other disbelievers before? Why had Allah not miraculously sprout the trees between nightfall and its daybreak?

It is for you missionaries, so that you may learn about steadfastness and patience in obeying Allah, even if the results are not apparent and even if they have not yet been envisaged. Allah says what can be translated as, **"And it was revealed to *Nuh* (that), "Never will any of your people believe, except him who has already believed; …", (TMQ, 11:36)**.

Nuh (*AS*) realized that none of his tribes were going to believe. However, he obeyed Allah's orders and was patient. Such is a missionary of Allah. Allah ordered him to cultivate the field and he did so, even if it did not seem that the field would produce any harvest. What is essential is carrying out divine orders, spending vast efforts, and then leaving the outcome to Allah. The importance of the matter is that at the end, one would gain their reward from Allah, whether or not the field was fruitful.

No Bias, Even Towards a Child

You may be asking yourself now, where is the 'no bias' in the story of Nuh? Where is the application of what Allah has ordered? Allah says what can be translated as, **"And do not (seek) support …", (TMQ, 11:113)?**

The answer to that is in the story of the son of Nuh *(AS)*, which has not been mentioned in the entire Qur'an except in this Surah. Why?

Nuh *(AS)* called out, as Allah says what can be translated as, **"… Lord! Surely my son is of my family, and surely Your promise is the truth, and You are The Most Judicious of judges. (TMQ, 11:45)."**

What was the divine reply?

Allah says what can be translated as, **"Said He, "O *Nuh*, (Noah) surely he is not of your family; surely it is a deed not (Literally: other than being righteous) righteous; so do not ask of Me that of which you have no knowledge. Surely I admonish you that you should not be among the ignorant (46) He said, "Lord! Surely I take refuge with You that I should ask of You that of which I have no knowledge; and unless You forgive me and have mercy on me, I will be among the losers" (TMQ, 11:46-47)."**

The surah warns against inclining towards anything other than righteousness. Therefore, it clarifies Nuh's disownment of his child, who died in disbelief. Fatherhood compassion could drive some to be inclined towards their children, despite the mistakes those children make. Allah says what can be translated as**, "… so said, "Lord! Surely my son is of my family, " (TMQ 11-44)**.

Thus, the surah was revealed to teach us that there should be no leniency when it comes to the disbelieving, even if it was among us, amid our homes and within our children, who are our offspring. Nuh (*AS*) was a role model and a leader in the rejection of the bootless and in the non-inclination towards it.

The Commentary: Be Patient

As we have previously stated, we shall read, as in the end of all stories of the Prophets, a commentary on the story and a conclusion in the last of its ayahs. In the story of Nuh *(AS)*, Allah says what can be translated as**, "That is of the tidings of the Unseen that We reveal to you; in no way did you (yourself) know it, neither your people, even before this. So (endure) patiently; surely the (fair) end is for the pious" (TMQ, 11:49).**

Thus, the message that the story holds is **"… So (endure) patiently; …"**, proactive patience accompanied by work and productivity with no recklessness or bias.

The Messengers of Allah and Equilibrium

All the stories of the Prophets contained in this Surah (Shu'ayb, Saleh, Lut, and Hud) serve the same denotation and compose a practical application of the core ayah in the surah (ayah 112) with its three axes:

Allah says what can be translated as,

1. **"So go straight, as you have been commanded, …", (TMQ, 11: 112).**

2. **"…and do not be inordinate; …", (TMQ, 11: 112).**

3. **"And do not (seek) support (you believers) for the ones who have done injustice, …", (TMQ, 11: 113).**

Thus, if we take for example the story of Shu'ayb, keeping in mind the possibility of applying those guidelines in all stories, we shall see the following:

- The resoluteness of rectitude and betterment with balance. Allah says what can be translated as, **"… Decidedly I would (do) nothing except reformation, (i.e., acting righteously) so far as I am able to …", (TMQ, 11: 88).**

- The unified message that all Allah's messengers have called for (even in using the same words). Allah says what can be translated as, **"And ask forgiveness of your Lord, thereafter repent to Him; …", (TMQ, 11: 90).**

- The harsh circumstances and denial. Allah says what can be translated as, **"They said, "O Shuaayb, in no way do we comprehend much of what you say; and surely we indeed see you weak among us. And had it not been for your clan, we would indeed have stoned you, …" (TMQ, 11:91).**

- The refraining from reckless replies. Allah says what can be translated as, **"He said, "O my people, is my clan mightier against you than Allah? …," (TMQ 11:92).**

What is noticeable is that Shu'ayb used the same diction as Nuh *(AS)* in referring the matter to Allah; indeed, He shall be The One to hold them accountable. Allah says what can be translated as, **"… Surely my Lord is Supremely Encompassing whatever you do," (TMQ, 11:92).**

In parallel, the non-inclination of people is clearly present; Allah says what can be translated as, **"… And be on the watch; (Literally: watch for yourselves) surely I will be with you, constantly watching," (TMQ, 11:93).**

So forth, until this ayah (94) came with victory for the Prophet and the believers, Allah says what can be translated as, **"And as soon as Our Command came, We safely delivered Shuaayb and the ones who believed with him by a mercy from Us …,"(TMQ, 11:94).**

Therefore, to all young people who cherish Islam and wish to serve and protect it, learn from this noble surah and from its numerous stories how to be poised when calling people to Islam in times of extreme trial and distress.

Why was the Surah named Hud?

There remains one last question: Why was the surah named Hud, despite the fact that the story of Nuh (*AS*) is longer than that of Hud (*AS*) in this surah?

The answer is that the three axes of the surah (resoluteness, the absence of tyranny and recklessness, and familial leniency) have appeared in the story of Hud in a clear

and predominant manner, which led to naming the surah 'surah of balance and non-recklessness' after Hud.

For he told his tribe, when denial has become intense, in what Allah says what can be translated as, **"… He said, "Surely I call Allah to testimony and you bear testimony that I am quit of whatever you associate (with Allah) (45) Apart from Him; so (devise) plotting against me, altogether; thereafter do not respite me," (TMQ, 11:54-55).** Have you ever seen such a strong and challenging statement?

Besides that, there appears the resoluteness and rectitude of Hud (*AS*) on the righteous path. Allah says what can be translated as, **"Surely I have put my trust in Allah, (Literally: I entrust "my self" to Allah) my Lord and your Lord; in no way is there any beast whatever except that He is taking it by the forelock. Surely my Lord is on a straight Path," (TMQ, 11:56).**

Then, **"So, in case you turn away, then I have already proclaimed to you what I have been sent with to you, and my Lord will make other people than you to succeed you; and you will not harm Him anything. Surely my Lord is Ever-Preserving over everything", (TMQ, 11:57).** Here appear non-recklessness and non-violence.

These words have strongly encompassed all axes of the surah, which again are: resoluteness, the absence of tyranny and recklessness, and familial leniency. The responsibility falls back on all successors of Hud, from the persistence in missionary activities, abolishing oppression, and steadfastness. For that reason, the Prophet (*SAWS*) said: "Surat Hud has caused my aging", and that was for the power of its diction in rousing steadfastness on the path of Allah and His statute. Also, for the power of *Hud*, as a role model in keeping the balance in steadfastness, without being reckless or biased.

Remember the Hereafter as the Path of Equilibrium

Before the conclusion of the surah, come the ayahs (103-108) meaningful of the hereafter to reassure the believers that this life, even if it involved a gloomy and unjust reality, is not the provenance, and that the hereafter is what would fulfill the divine justice. Hence, be patient with the dire realities of this life.

Allah says what can be translated as, **"Surely in that is indeed a sign for him who fears the torment of the Hereafter; that is a Day mankind is to be gathered to, and that is a Day to be witnessed (103) And in no way do We defer it except to a term (already) fixed (Literally: numbered) (104) The Day it comes up, no self will speak except by His permission. So (some) of them are wretched, and (some) happy (105) So, as for the ones who are wretched, then they will be in the Fire; therein there will be for them groaning and sighing (106) Eternally therein (abiding) so long as the heavens and the earth (endure), except whatever your Lord decides; surely your Lord is The Sublime Performer of whatever He wills (107) And as for the ones who are made happy, then they will be in the Garden, eternally therein (abiding), so long as the heavens and the earth (endure), except whatever your Lord decides: a gift uninterrupted." (TMQ, 11:103-108).**

Pointers that aid in Resoluteness

The conclusion of the surah consists of the two core ayahs that we have discussed:

Allah says what can be translated as, **"So go straight, as you have been commanded, (you) and whoever repents with you, and do not be inordinate; surely He is Ever-Beholding whatever you do (112) And do not (seek) support (you believers) for the ones who have done injustice, (for) then the Fire (would) touch you; and in no way do you have any patrons apart from Allah, (and) thereafter you will not be vindicated (i.e., if you seek support for the ones who have done injustice)", (TMQ, 11:112-113).**

Thus, what is it that helps in staying steadfast and carrying out those three commands?
How does one stay resolute and patient with an outstretched hand, without weakness in leniency?

The answer is: Allah says what can be translated as**, "And keep up the prayer at the two extremities of the daytime and in the early reaches of the night. Surely the fair deeds will put away the odious deeds. That is a Reminding to the mindful (114) And (endure) patiently, (for) then surely Allah does not leave to waste the reward of the fair-doers", (TMQ, 11:114-115)**.

What helps you young man with **"So go straight …," (TMQ, 11:112):**

- Devotion; "**And keep up the prayer …", (TMQ 11:114).**

- Patience, Allah says what can be translated as**, "And (endure) patiently, (for) then surely Allah does not leave to waste the reward of the fair-doers", (TMQ, 11:115).**

- Work, resolving issues, and calling to Allah's path. Allah says what can be translated as**, "And in no way would your Lord indeed cause towns to perish with injustice (while) their population are righteous-doers", (TMQ, 11:117).**

The observation is that Surat Yunus, Surat Hud, and Surat Yusuf were all revealed together in the same period of time. Their order in the revelation of the Qur'an is also the same. It was revealed during the ordeal of the Prophet (*SAWS*) and his companions in Makkah, after the death of Khadijah and Abu-Taleb. It dealt with similar troubles.

The reason for choosing the name of a Prophet for each title of the three Surahs is that the Prophet's story contains the moral that provide for the surah and its objective. These three Surahs speak to us now, because we are living the same phase, adversity, and darkness.

Therefore, let us be steadfast in obeying Allah. Let us beware of recklessness and oppression. Let us, also, beware of being inclined to other civilizations and get

thrown into their lap, where we surrender and live in their shadows, forget our association to Islam, and lose our identity.

This is the core of Surat Hud.

Surat Yusuf (Joseph)

Surat Yusuf is Makkan and was revealed during the same time and circumstances Surat Hud and Surat Yunus were revealed. It is considered to be the longest surah in the Ever-Glorious Qur'an in terms of the story it has. It includes the story of Prophet Yusuf (*AS*) "Joseph" from the beginning until the end. It consists of 111 ayahs.

The Best of Stories:

Novelists comment on Surat Yusuf saying that it includes all the craft and components of fiction: suspense, description, coherence, and symbolism. For example, the story commences with a dream that Prophet Yusuf (*AS*) had and ends with the explanation of that same dream. The shirt of Prophet Yusuf (*AS*), which is used as a means of exonerating his brothers, is later used as evidence of their betrayal. This shirt is later used as a means of exonerating Yusuf himself from the false accusation of molesting the wife of Al-Aziz.

Moreover, one of the wonders of this story is that its meanings and events are vividly dramatized for the reader, as if he is actually seeing and hearing them. Also, it is one of the most fascinating and striking stories you will ever read.

We barely need to solicit novelists' recognition of the story, as Allah Himself is the One Who substantiates its quality and excellence. He says what can be translated as, "**We, Ever We, narrate to you the fairest of narratives in that We have revealed to you this Qur'an." (TMQ, 12:3).** However, the purpose of having this surah in the Ever-Glorious Qur'an is scarcely limited to telling a story. On the contrary, its real purpose is summarized in the last line of the story in which Allah says what can be translated as, "**They said, "Is it sure that you, indeed you, are Yûsuf?" (Joseph) "I am Yûsuf," he said, "and this is my brother. Allah has already been bounteous to us. Surely whoever is pious and (endures) patiently, then surely Allah does not waste the reward of the fair-doers**." **(TMQ, 12:90).**

Thus, the core idea of the story is:

Allah is Omniscient and we are Deficient in Knowledge

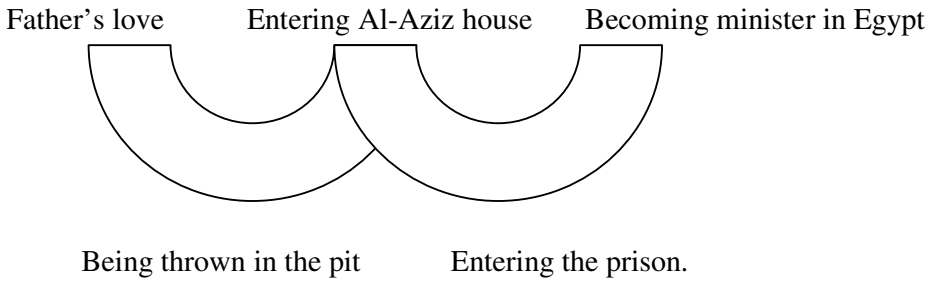
The aim of Surat Yusuf is to educate us that Allah's (*SWT*) manipulation of things is different from the limited perception of humans. It is as if it is telling us, "have faith in what Allah (*SWT*) plans, and be patient and do not give up."

The events in the surah are weird; they run contrary to what they seem to be. Yusuf is loved by his father, and this seems good. Nonetheless, Yusuf is thrown down a pit by his brothers as a result of that love. Furthermore, although the incident of throwing Yusuf in the pit appears vicious, Yusuf consequently moves to the house of al-Aziz. The presence of Yusuf in the house of al-Aziz is apparently a good thing, however, Yusuf is sent to prison afterwards. Moreover, whereas the imprisonment of Yusuf appears to be a very bad thing, yet Yusuf is appointed as the minister of finance in Egypt.

What Allah (*SWT*) wants to pass to us through the story of Yusuf (*SAWS*) is that He is the only One Who plans things. One may conceive of incidents as bad, however, this deficient perception characteristic of humans is far from realizing Allah's (*SWT*) discretion and wisdom in His judgment.

The Road of Curves:

When we read through the life-story of Yusuf (*SAWS*), we notice that there are three highs and two lows. This can be represented as follows:



The distressful stages in the life of Prophet Yusuf (*AS*) vary in their intensity. Which is more difficult: the pit or the prison? He stays in the prison for nine years, but he stays in the pit for only three days. However, these days in the pit are more difficult because he was still a little boy. In the midst of all these misfortunes, Yusuf stands firm by his morals and is not moved by the vicissitudes of life.

You are a Slave in Both Cases:

If you Muslims undergo hard times, learn from Prophet Yusuf *(AS*) who, despite all adverse circumstances, remained patient and hopeful. Similarly, learn from him how to cope with periods of tranquillity and comfort by being humble and loyal to Allah (*SWT*). Thus, the surah teaches us that there are ups and downs in man's life. Nobody leads a life of either utter prosperity or utter hardship. He is being tested in both cases. The story of Prophet Yusuf (*AS*) is the story of adhering to morals in both cases of hardship and prosperity. Prophet Yusuf (*AS*) is patient and does not lose hope in misfortunes. He is also loyal and humble to Allah (*SWT*) in prosperity. Thus, he abides by morals in times of prosperity and difficulty.

Between the Surah and the Biography:

As previously mentioned, the surah was sent down almost in the same circumstances of Surat Hud and Surat Yunus, and at a time when persecution of Prophet Muhammad (*SAWS*) and his companions had intensified. These circumstances are similar to those faced by Prophet Yusuf (*AS*). For example, Prophet Yusuf (*AS*) was separated from his father. Similarly, when the surah descended upon our Messenger (*SAWS*) in the tenth year of his mission, he had already lost his uncle Abu-Taleb and his wife Khadijah (*RA*). Leaving his family behind, Prophet Yusuf (*AS*) left his father's country, Palestine, and went to Egypt. Two years after the revelation of the surah, our Messenger (*SAWS*) left Makkah and travelled to Madinah. Thus, the surah of Yusuf

prepares the Messenger for the misfortunes and afflictions he will face. Also, it prepares all the believers to face misfortunes in their lives. That is the reason why scholars comment on it by saying that any distressed person who reads this surah is bound to become happy.

Yusuf the Human:

It is important to realize that the surah focuses on the life of Prophet Yusuf (*AS*) as a man. However, Surat Ghafir sheds light on Yusuf the Prophet when Prophet Musa (*AS*) "Moses" says to his people in Allah's words what can be translated as, **"And indeed Yûsuf (Joseph) already came to you earlier with the supreme evidence (s), yet in no way did you cease being in doubt concerning what he came to you with …."(TMQ, 40:34).**

The experience of Yusuf in this surah is merely the experience of a human being, and it ends up in ultimate success both in this life and in the hereafter. As for this life, he is appointed as the Egyptian minister of finance. For the hereafter, he resists the temptations of the wife of al-Aziz and the other women in the city. Thus, it is a story of human success. It is a story of a patient human being who does not lose hope, despite all the circumstances which he undergoes. His success is unpredictable as he moves from misfortune to misfortune: his brothers' hatred, slavery, his emigration from his country, the seductiveness of the wife of Al-Aziz, and putting up with lies and false accusations.

Where are the Miracles in the Story?

The story does not refer to any miracles happening during the events Prophet Yusuf encounters. Some may consider the vision itself a miracle, but any ordinary person may have a vision. The surah concentrates on how Allah (*SWT*) paves for him the way to success, just as He would do to any other person. For instance, Allah teaches Prophet Yusuf how to render visions. Allah says what can be translated as, **"And thus your Lord will select you and teach you (a portion) of the interpretation of discourses …. (TMQ, 12:6).** However, the success of Prophet Yusuf (*AS*) is achieved by taking advantage of the qualifications bestowed upon him by Allah.

"Never Give up Hope on Allah's Mercy":

The story of Prophet Yusuf (*AS*) is the story of the success of a person who has lived through difficult circumstances and who is not equipped with the necessary potentialities for success. However, he refuses to give up hope. The ayahs of the surah are full of hope. For instance, when Prophet Yaqub (*AS*) "Jacob" lost his second son, and his calamity is duplicated, He says in Allah's words what can be translated as, **"… and do not despair of relief from Allah; surely none despairs of relief from Allah except the disbelieving people." (TMQ, 12:87).** This ayah does not mean that the hopeless person is a disbeliever. It means that he acts like a disbeliever because he does not realize that nobody knows what Allah plans in the universe and that Allah is the Generous, the Merciful, and the Wise in all that He does.

Success is Achieved by Allah's Support:

Part of the greatness of this magnanimous Prophet consists in the fact that when has succeeded in his life occupying senior positions, he is not carried away by the euphoria of victory by showing humility to Allah and feeling grateful to Him. He says at the end of the story what can be translated as, "**Lord! You have already brought me (my share) of kingship and You have taught me (my share) of the interpretation of discourses. O Originator (Literally: Renderer; i.e., Creator) of the heavens and the earth, You are my Ever-Patronizing Patron in the present (life) (Literally: the lowly (life), the life of this world) and the Hereafter, Take me up to You as a Muslim (One who submits to you) and join me with the righteous**." **(TMQ, 12:101).** Notice his humbleness when he says, "**and join me with the righteous**" as if the righteous preceded him and he wanted to join them. Thus, Prophet Yusuf (*AS*) has succeeded in the test of prosperity by being grateful and humble to Allah, and in the test of misfortunes by being patient and hopeful.

You are up to it:

The comment on the experience of Prophet Yusuf (*AS*) comes in a wonderful ayah for two reasons: to assure Prophet Muhammad (*SAWS*) of the fulfillment of Allah's promise and His victory, and afterwards to pass it to his people so that they may know it for certainty. Listen to this ayah with all your heart and soul, "**Till, when the Messengers finally despaired and expected that they were counted liars, Our victory came to them. So, whoever We decided will be safely delivered. And Our violence will not be turned back (i.e., turned away from) from the criminal people.**" **(TMQ, 12:110).**

The Summary of the Experience:

The surah concludes with a core idea. After Prophet Yusuf (*AS*) becomes victorious and fulfills all his wishes, he says what can be translated as, "**They said, 'Is it sure that you, indeed you, are Yûsuf?' (Joseph) "I am Yûsuf, " he said, "and this is my brother. Allah has already been bounteous to us. Surely whoever is pious and (endures) patiently, then surely Allah does not waste the reward of the fair-doers**." **(TMQ, 12:90).**

The story of Prophet Yusuf (*AS*) teaches us that whoever wants to succeed and bears in mind a goal he wishes to accomplish, he will certainly achieve it via patience and hope, seeking Allah's support and not succumbing to despair: **"They said, 'Is it sure that you, indeed you, are Yûsuf?' (Joseph) "I am Yûsuf, " he said, "and this is my brother. Allah has already been bounteous to us. Surely whoever is pious and (endures) patiently, then surely Allah does not waste the reward of the fair-doers." (TMQ, 12:90).**

In these words, Prophet Yusuf (*AS*) summarizes for us his own experience in life which, as mentioned before, is a mere human experience. Thus, whoever wants to succeed in life has to first fear Allah. Second, he has to request Allah's assistance. Third, not only does he have to be patient in coping with the misfortunes, but he also has to conquer the obstacles surrounding him.

The patience recommended here is conducive to being positive and perseverant. It follows that one should, for example, take advantage of every opportunity to learn a new skill, as Prophet Yusuf (*AS*) has done, since he learned how to manage finance during his stay at the house of al-Aziz. This is the reason why Prophet Yusuf says in Allah's words what can be translated as, "**He (Yûsuf) said, "Set me over the lands treasuries. Surely I am constantly-persevering, (i.e., guardian) constantly-knowing." (TMQ, 12:55).**

O youth! Learn from Prophet Yusuf (*AS*) these two things: be successful in your professional life and excel in this life and hereafter through knowledge and hard work; and second, to resist temptations and abstain from them so that you can win the *Jannah* (Paradise).

Surat Ar-Ra'd (Thunder)

Surat Ar-Ra'd is a Madinan Surah. It succeeded Surat Muhammad in revelation. It follows Surat Yusuf in the order of Surahs of the Qur'an. It consists of 43 ayahs.

Power of Truth

Surat Ar-Ra'd is one of the most magnificent Surahs of the Qur'an. Its message is that truth is strong and deep-rooted, though it may sometimes seem unperceivable. Falsehood, on the other and, is weak and vulnerable though it may also seem rife sometimes. It remains fragile and worthless.

Gulled by the insincere glamour of falsehood, many people overlook such a simple fact. Falsehood takes several forms, such as widespread pornography, sweeping sinfulness, mendacious employees or merchants, as well as an unjust nations oppressing the Islamic nation and seizing its rights. These are all different forms of the frail power of falsehood.

Impact of Falsehood on People

Hoodwinked by falsehood, people grow afraid of it when they fail to perceive these facts. They, therefore, underestimate the truth they possess and might sometimes even try to imitate untruth. We often see many people thinking highly of a man having a lucrative business built on theft, fraud, and deceit. Since this is a common practice, such people deem there is no harm in following suit.

Surat Ar-Ra'd addresses people of this sort. It reminds them that the power of untruth, no matter how widespread or overt it is, is fragile and rootless. No matter how long truth is shrouded or rendered covert, it remains solid and deep-rooted.

Truth and the Recited Book

The Surah opens by emphasizing the fact that Allah (*TWT*) is the Truth, and so is the Book sent down by Him. Allah says what can be translated as, **"Alif, Lam, Mîm, Ra (These are the names of letters of the Arabic alphabet, and only Allah knows their meaning here). Those are the ayat (Verses, signs) of the Book; and that which has been sent to you from your Lord is the Truth, but most of mankind do not believe" (TMQ, 13:1).**

As the first ayah mentions the Book of Allah (*SWT*), the next two ayahs (2-3) proceed to tackle the omnipotence of Allah (*AW)* manifested in the universe. They somehow address people as a whole telling them that if they deny the Recited Book (the Qur'an), then they should look at Allah's seen book (the whole universe). In the second and third ayahs, Allah says what can be translated as, **"Allah is He Who raised up the heavens without pillars you (can) see, thereafter He levelled Himself up on the Throne; (How He did so is beyond human understanding) and He subjected the sun and the moon, each one running to a stated term. He conducts the Command; He expounds the signs that possibly you would have certitude of the meeting with your Lord" (TMQ, 13:2);** and **"And He is (The One) Who extended the earth and made therein anchorages and rivers; and of**

all products He made therein two pairs, enveloping the daytime with the night ...” (TMQ, 13:3).

Thus, Allah (*SWT*) has two books in this universe. Both lead to Him and each one gives evidence of and substantiates the other.

The Recited Book (the Qur'an) asks that a Muslim ponder over the seen book (the universe) through many ayahs like the ones we have just mentioned. On the other hand, the seen book further reinforces one’s belief in the Qur'an.

Truth and the Seen Book

Who is the Conductor? Who is the Omnipotent? Who is the Owner of the universe? Would you follow Him or follow falsehood?

The Surah proceeds to discuss the seen book (the universe), and how it leads to the greatness of the Creator (*JWA*). Allah says what can be translated as, **"And in the earth are tracts neighbouring each other, and gardens of vineyards and plantation, and palms in pairs and other than in pairs, (Or: having the same root or different ones) watered with one water; and We have graced some of them over others (Literally: some “others”) in crop. Surely in that are signs for a people who consider” (TMQ, 13:4).**

Touring the Sovereignty of Allah (*SWT*)

Part of the magnificence of the Surah is that it lands one gradually and downwardly in the sovereignty of Allah (*SWT*) for him to meditate upon the universe and its signs. If we consider ayahs 2-4, we shall find that they start with the heavens, moving down to the sun and the moon, and then earth, mountains, and rivers. After that, they deal with how farm lands are divided into contiguous plots and with the varied crops they yield. You feel as if you were on a plane descending from above, holding in your hands the Qur'an as a guide substantiating these signs and asking you to look at the sovereignty of Allah (*SWT*) from the higher to the lower. It makes you wonder about who raised the heavens up without pillars for land division and how the water, which supplies all kinds of crops, springs from one source; Allah.

Their Saying is Wondrous

Following all these ayahs and signs, Allah (*SWT*) comments saying what can be translated as, **"And in case you would wonder, then (really) wondrous is their saying, “When we are dust, will we surely be (raised) indeed in a new creation …” (TMQ, 13:5).**

Are you still in wonder despite witnessing all of Allah’s sovereignty in the universe, and how He (*SWT*) is ever-Determiner over giving life to the dead? How could anyone with a sound mind doubt the power of Allah (*SWT*)? Therefore, the ensuing ayahs shift focus to another side of Allah's omnipotence: the ability to reconcile all contradictions in the universe.

Only Allah is Capable of Reconciling Them All

The Surah begins to highlight the contradictions found in this peculiar universe. There exist almost 32 contradictory phenomena in nature. Nobody, save Allah (*SWA*), can ever harmonize these contradictions. By observing such contradictions, we can discern the secrets of the greatness of Allah (*SWT*). Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"… wombs subsiding (i.e., what wombs fall short of or exceed) and increase, (i.e., what wombs fall short of or exceed) …" (TMQ, 13:8)**; **"… he who keeps his saying secret and who speaks aloud and he who conceals himself in the night and he who sallies by daytime" (TMQ, 13:10)**; **"… for fear and longing (of Him) …" (TMQ, 13:12)**; **"… willingly and unwillingly …" (TMQ, 13:15)**; **"… neither profit nor harm … the blind and the beholding … the darkness and the light …" (TMQ, 13:16)**; **"… Truth and the untruth …" (TMQ, 13:17)**; **"… outspreads … determines … present life … the Hereafter …" (TMQ, 13:26)**; and **"… erases … makes firm …" (TMQ, 13:39)**.

It is as if these magnificent ayahs were addressing us in wonder: 'how you do not surrender to Allah (*SWT*), although He is the whole Truth Who owns the whole universe with all of its contradictions, and Who can reconcile them all! This reiterates the core idea of the Surah being that truth is solid and well-founded, whereas falsehood is weak and transient.

Delusive Happiness

The ayahs unfold to provide us with three examples that amazingly and miraculously serve the objective of the Surah. The first example of which is considered the key to understanding the Surah and its core idea mentioned earlier. Let us read ayah 14 where Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"To Him is the call of Truth …" (TMQ, 13:14).** There is a call for the youth to tread on the path leading to Allah (*SWT*) because the complete truth lies in it. What about falsehood? What does it look like? Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"…And the ones upon whom they invoke, apart from Him, do not respond to them in anything, except it is as one who stretches out his hands to water that it may reach his mouth; and in no way will it reach it …" (TMQ, 13:14).** I swear that one can barely come across similes of truth and falsehood that are more striking than these Qur'anic figures of speech.

Allah (*TWT*) likens people pursuing untruth to a man looking at his reflection in the water, trying to reach his mouth, but to no avail. Therefore, all of those who go after untruth shall remain searching forever for chimerical happiness. They think that it is in sipping a goblet of wine, in hankering after and singing a four-letter song, or in laying their hands on illicit money. However, they shall never find happiness just like the man who is trying to reach his mouth that is reflected on the water surface, and as Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"… in no way will it reach it" (TMQ, 13:14).**

Correspondingly, the youth are hereby warned not to be deluded by falsehood, regardless of how glittering and shiny it might be. Even if it disguises itself as balls attended by both boys and girls where dancing and abandon prevail, even if some

people veneer it with flimflam like ‘courage, ’ ‘modernity, ’ and ‘tradition-buster’; falsehood is inevitably doomed and truth shall always remain to be the real essence.

Untruth: Scum Floating on the Surface of Water

Allah (*SWT*) gives us another remarkable example to underline the fact that truth is strong and deep-rooted even if it is covert, and that falsehood is fragile and has no value even if it rises to the surface and swells up. Note the following ayah where Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"He sends down from the heaven water so that valleys flow, each to its determined (course) …" (TMQ, 13:17).** Water falling from the sky stands for truth and good, descending with the revelation from heaven. What is the effect of this water? Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"… so that valleys flow, each to its determined (course)…" (TMQ, 13:17).** Observe the power and greatness of this water and how it flows in the valley to carry good to the people. What happens next? Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"… so that the flood carries away (on its surface) a swelling scum …" (TMQ, 13:17).** Worthless stray and leftovers gather on the water surface and cover it such that the valuable matter is overlaid. Accordingly, good and the water, which are used in cultivation, are overwhelmed with worthless stray and scraps (scum).

Allah (*SWT*) gives another amazing example. He says what can be translated as, **"… And from that on which they kindle fire (i.e., or) seeking (to make) ornaments or belongings, out of that there is a scum like it …" (TMQ, 13:17).** Therefore, if you put a piece of gold onto fire to test its purity, the impurities inside shall rise to the surface and the precious metal precipitates below. The same principle works for water. It is as if Allah (*SWT*) is telling us that this is water and that is fire, but the same principle holds for both. By the same token, both truth and falsehood have identical shapes and essences. Falsehood shall always rise to the surface whereas the good shall remain underneath. However, good is deep-rooted even if you do not see it, and falsehood is doomed even if it rises to the surface.

Thus Allah Strikes the Truth and the Untruth

Here stands a clear comment on these two examples to confirm their agreement with the objective of the Surah. **"… Thus Allah strikes the Truth and the Untruth …" (TMQ, 13:17).** What shall the fate of those two be?

Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"… So, as for the scum, then it goes away as jetsam (i.e., vanishes as useless) and as for whatever profits mankind, then it stays in the earth. Thus Allah strikes the similitude” (TMQ, 13:17).**

Thus, let us call for truth and accompany its people and followers, whom Allah (*SWT*) refers to in what can be translated as, **"For the ones who have responded to their Lord, (the reward) is the fairest …" (TMQ, 13:18).**

Why “Ar-Ra'd” (Thunder)?

We are left with the reason behind the title of the Surah. The reason consists in the fact that thunder is a model for contradiction. Scientifically speaking, thunder carries contradictory charges: positive and negative. From the angle of religious belief,

thunder carries terror and fright along with good and rain to people. Thunder sounds horrible from the outside but deep inside it extols Allah (*SWT*). Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And the thunder extols (with) His praise and the Angels out of the fright of Him; and He sends the stunning (thunderbolts) (and) so He afflicts with them whomever He decides. And they dispute about Allah, and He is strict in (equitable) contriving" (TMQ, 13:13).**

Its as if the signs of creation in the Surah, with the example of thunder topping the list, are conveying the same message: be careful not to be fooled by appearances but rather search deep inside.

The Greatness of the Qur'an

After the aforementioned ayahs have illustrated the influence of the seen book (the universe) of Allah (*SWT*) distinguishing truth from untruth, Allah (*SWT*) strikes a far more amazing example based on His Recited Book. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And if there had been a Qur'an whereby the mountains were made to travel or the earth were cut up (into pieces) or the dead were spoken to- no indeed, to Allah is the Command altogether ..." (TMQ, 13:31).**

This ayah means that should there be anything that could move mountains or make earth travel or give life to the dead, it would be this Qur'an. The ayah simply denotes that this amazing universe can only be moved by this Qur'an. Why? It's because the Qur'an embodies the whole truth on earth. This confirms what Allah (*SWT*) says in what can be translated as, **"To Him is the call of Truth ..." (TMQ, 13:14).**

For that reason, you are kindly asked to read Surat Ar-Ra'd and live with the truth sent down by Allah (*SWT*), as truth is the speech of Allah (*SWT*). It is the Qur'an. It is the road to good and righteousness. After reading this holy Surah, do not ever let yourself be misled by untruth, regardless of how much it builds up and how high it rises above truth because falsehood is ultimately fragile and rootless.

Surat Ibrahim (Abraham)

The Objective of the Surah: The Blessings of Belief and the Afflictions of Disbelief

When asked, "What is the greatest blessing endowed by Allah", many people would refer to mundane affairs such as their spouse, children, home, or money. On the other hand, when asked about the worst affliction undergone, they would mention worldly problems such as loss of money, or ruined business. To remove such misconceptions, Allah points out in Surat Ibrahim (*AS*) "Abraham" that the greatest blessing ever is the blessing of belief in Allah, and the worst affliction is disbelief and estrangement from Allah (*SWT).*

Is darkness identical to light?

The surah constantly juxtaposes truth and untruth, believers and disbelievers, as well as light and darkness. The opening of the surah unmistakably bears this meaning, **"Alif, Lam, Mîm, Ra (These are the names of letters of the Arabic alphabet, and only Allah knows their meaning here). A Book We have sent down to you that you may bring mankind out of the darkness (es) to the light by the permission of their Lord, to the path of The Ever- Mighty, The Ever-Praiseworthy" (TMQ, 14:1).** It is as if man is being asked to observe the darkness and light, to ponder over Allah's (*SWT*) blessing, and to opt for either of them.

Two-sided day

By referring to the story of Prophet Musa (*AS*) "Moses" in the fifth ayah, Allah further accentuates the same meaning, , **"And indeed We already sent Mûsa (Moses) with Our signs (saying), "Bring out your people out of darkness (es) to the light and remind them of the Days of Allah. Surely in that are signs indeed for everyone (who is) most patient, constantly thankful" (TMQ, 14:5).**

What could be the relationship between the Days of Allah and being patient and thankful? The Days of Allah were those days on which Allah had perished those who were unjust to their respective peoples, and spared those who were righteous. Thus, it was a blessing endowed upon the believers and an affliction for the disbelievers. A believer should learn his lesson from those days of learning to be patient, enduring, as well as more thankful for the generous blessing of belief, **"Surely in that are signs indeed for everyone (who is) most patient, constantly thankful" (TMQ, 14:5).**

As commanded by Allah, Prophet Musa (*AS*) went about conveying Allah's message to his people constantly reminding them of His greatest blessings to them, **"And as Mûsa said to his people, "Remember the favor of Allah upon you as He delivered you from the house of Firaawn, (Pharaoh) (who were) marking you out for odious torment, constantly slaying your sons and (sparing) alive your women; and in these (acts) was a tremendous trial from your Lord" (TMQ, 14:6).**

The path of Allah (*SWT*) is both, a blessing and an honor and any other path brings but belittlement and humiliation. Prophet Musa (*AS*) clearly says in Allah's words

what can be translated as, "**Indeed in case you thank (Him), indeed I will definitely increase you" (TMQ, 14:7).**

Allah (*SWT*)has made a general rule and a divine promise to whoever thanks Him for His generous blessings; **"And as your Lord has notified (you), "Indeed in case you thank (Him), indeed I will definitely increase you and indeed in case you disbelieve, surely My torment is indeed strict" (TMQ, 14:7).**

Though the ayah applies to whom Allah-endowed His blessings, its occurrence amongst those ayahs dealing with the blessing of belief underscores the significance of thanking Allah for the blessing of belief in particular. In so doing, Allah will grant us more of this particular blessing. Else, Allah is Ever-Affluent and will surely dispense with the worlds. Allah says what can be translated as, **"And Mûsa (Moses) said, "In case you disbelieve, you and whoever is in the earth altogether, then surely Allah is indeed Ever-Affluent, (Literally: Ever-Rich) Ever-Praiseworthy" (TMQ, 14:8).**

The messages of Prophets

Next, the ayahs tackle the issue of the confrontation between the believers and disbelievers. Unlike other Surahs addressing each Prophet's issue with his people, this surah does not deal with each and every Prophet because the objective here centers around the blessing of belief and the affliction of disbelief. This surah deals with the Prophets as a whole along with their respective peoples. For instance, Allah says what can be translated as, "**Their Messengers said to them…" (TMQ 14:11**); **"And the ones who disbelieved said to their Messengers…" (TMQ 14:13**); **as well as "Their Messengers said, "Is there any doubt regarding Allah, The Originator (Literally: Renderer; i.e., creator) of the heavens and the earth? He calls you that He may forgive you (some) of your guilty deeds..." (TMQ, 14:10).**

Have you ever mulled over the significance of this blessing? Allah the Mighty and the Compeller is calling on you in order to absolve your from your sins, yet He can dispense with you.

Observe the Prophets' repeated emphasis that their knowledge of, and belief in Allah (*SWT*) represent His greatest bestowments ever. Allah says what can be translated as, **"…but Allah bestows His Bounty to whomever He decides of His bondmen…" (TMQ, 14:11).**

Blessings and afflictions

References to various blessings and afflictions recur in the surah: Allah says what can be translated as, **"And indeed We will definitely make you to dwell (in) the land even after them; that (is) for him who fears My station and fears My threat" (TMQ, 14:14).**

In contrast, Allah (*SWT*) strongly warns of His afflictions in other ayahs. He says what can be translated as, **"Beyond him (is) Hell, (i.e., Hell awaits every stubborn potentate after his life) and he is given to drink of festering water, Which he gulps and almost cannot find it palatable; (i.e., He is barely able to drink it) and**

death comes up to him from every place, and in no way will he be dead; and beyond him is a harsh torment. (Such) is the likeness of the ones who have disbelieved in their Lord: their deeds are like ashes on which the wind blows severely upon a tempestuous day…" (TMQ, 14: 16-18).

Many ayahs unfold, proceeding to the sermon of *Iblis* (Satan) in hell, which is considered the worst affliction of all to be sent down on the disbelievers.

***Iblis*'s sermon**

Allah says what can be translated as**, "And Ash-Shaytan (The all-vicious "one", i.e., the Devil) says, as soon as the Command is decreed, "Surely Allah promised you a promise of Truth, and I promised you, then I failed you; and in no way did I have any all-binding authority over you except that I called you, so you responded to me..." (TMQ, 14:22).**

Just imagine the sorrow overwhelming the audience of this sermon! How come they heed Satan at a time when he is washing his hands of them? Allah cites Satan as saying what can be translated as, **"…So do not blame me and blame yourselves. In no way can I be a screamer (i.e., able to every for help for you) for you, and in no way can you be screamers for me. Surely I disbelieved in your associating me (with Allah) earlier" Surely the unjust will have a painful torment" (TMQ, 14:22).** Can you imagine an affliction worse than this?!

The good word

Ayahs now reach a core idea. This core idea clearly points out that belief is the greatest blessing ever. Allah (*SWT*) exemplifies the case for us saying what can be translated as, **"Have you not seen how Allah has struck a similitude? A good word is as a good tree…" (TMQ, 14:24).** People might think that most blessings are materialistic, but Allah (*SWT*) gives us this example to show that one word or one blessing is greater than all the material blessings man can conceive of! Allah says what can be translated as, **"Have you not seen how Allah has struck a similitude? A good word is as a good tree: its root is firm and its branch is in the heaven. It brings its crop every season (Literally: every while) by the permission of its Lord; and Allah strikes similitude's to mankind that possibly they would remind themselves" (TMQ, 14:24-25).**

Just as trees bear good crops, so does the deep-rooted and lofty-branched tree of *la ilaha ila Allah* (there is no god but Allah) which yields believing people. Examples of such people include disciples of the Qur'an, callers to Allah's path, positive people, and other benevolent believers. Indeed, it does bring its crops every season by the permission of Allah. These crops are in the form of good deeds and righteous acts that remain as an ever-running *sadaqah* (charity) even after the person is deceased.

On the other hand, the word of disbelief is fragile, wicked, rootless and branchless. Allah says what can be translated as, **"And the similitude of a wicked word is as a wicked tree: uprooted from above the earth; in no way does it have any stability" (TMQ, 14:26).**

Do not try to change Allah's blessings

The ayahs continue to corroborate the same core idea, which is the blessing of belief and the affliction of disbelief. Allah unequivocally says what can be translated as, "**Have you not regarded the ones who the favor of Allah with substituted disbelief and caused their people to inhabit the Residence of futility?" (TMQ, 14:28).** What will their retribution be? Allah says what can be translated as, "**Hell, wherein they are roasted; and miserable is the residence!" (TMQ, 14:29).**

Oh Muslim brethren, do not ever let go of or repudiate the blessing of belief, which Allah (*SWT*) has bestowed upon you. Do not be one of those about whom Allah says what can be translated as, **"And they made up compeers to Allah, that they (might) lead (people) into error away from His way…" (TMQ, 14:30).**

How can we thank Allah the Mighty for this great blessing of belief? Allah says what can be translated as, **"Say to My bondmen who have believed (that) they keep up the prayer and expend of what we have provided them, secretly and in public…" (TMQ, 14:31);** and He adds**, "…And in case you number the favor(s) of Allah, you (cannot) enumerate them**" **(TMQ, 14:34).**

The surah goes on enumerating other blessings that Allah (*SWT*) has endowed upon us. Allah says what can be translated as, **"Allah is He Who created the heavens and the earth and sent down from the heaven water…"; "…And He subjected to you ships to run in the sea at His Command"**; and He says, **"…And He subjected to you the rivers"; "And He subjected to you the sun and the moon, both in a steadfast manner, and He subjected to you the night and the daytime" (TMQ, 14:32-33).**

Why has Allah (*SWT*) subjected all those blessings for us? So that we may feel Allah's power, feel His blessings, and follow His path.

Allah states in ayah 34 what can be translated as, **"…And in case you number the favor(s) of Allah, you (cannot) enumerate them" (TMQ, 14: 34).** Allah (*SWT*) does not imply that we have already started counting. Instead, He states that if we only made an attempt to count the particulars of one blessing (e.g., the sun), we would not be able to do so; Let alone the greatest blessing of all, which is the blessing of belief and following Allah's (*SWT*) path.

Ibrahim as a role model

The surah concludes with a comparison between two models. The first one is of a man, Prophet Ibrahim (*AS*), who lived on Allah's blessings and internalized the blessing of belief. The other one is of people living away from Allah's path, being unjust to themselves and to their communities. Prophet Ibrahim's (*AS*) thankfulness for the blessings received is always evident, **"Praise be to Allah, Who has bestowed upon me, though being great with (years), (i.e., though I am old) Shuaayb and Ishaq; (Ishmael and Isaac, respectively) surely my Lord is indeed Ever-Hearing of invocation" (TMQ, 14:39).**

In a wonderful supplication and prayer, Prophet Ibrahim (*AS*) implores Allah to fulfill the blessing of posterity granted onto him with a greater blessing. He prays for Allah to preserve his religion for him and his offspring through *Salah* (Prayers). Allah says what can be translated as, **"Lord! Make me one who keeps up the prayer and of my offspring (ones who keep up the prayer), our Lord, and graciously accept my invocation. Our Lord, forgive me, and my parents, and the believers upon the Day when the reckoning will come up" (TMQ, 14:40-41).**

Observe this compassion from our father Ibrahim invoking Allah to help us and our children keep prayers. Allah says what can be translated as, "**And warn mankind of the Day when the torment will come up to them**" **(TMQ, 14:44).**

Finally, the surah concludes with ayahs carrying harsh expressions against unjust and stray people. Allah says what can be translated as, **"And definitely do not reckon that Allah is heedless of what the unjust (ones) are doing; surely He only defers them to a Day (when) be holdings will glaze over. Hurrying with their heads protruding, their glances not returning towards them, and their heart-sights (as) air. And warn mankind of the Day when the torment will come up to them. Then the ones who did (an) injustice will say, "Our Lord, defer us to a near term, (then) we will answer Your Call and closely follow the Messengers" (But) did you not swear earlier that in no way will you (face) extinction?" (TMQ, 14:42- 44).**

Is there any affliction, disgrace and humiliation worse than this?

The greatest blessing of all is to avoid that situation and the worst affliction of all is to be amongst those about whom Allah says what can be translated as**, "And you will see the criminals upon that Day interlinked in the fetters. Their apparels of pitch, and their faces enveloped by the Fire" (TMQ, 14:49-50).**

Surat Ibrahim is all about the blessing of belief and the affliction of disbelief. It was named after our father Prophet Ibrahim (*AS*) being a model of a man quite gratefully internalizing Allah's whole blessings. Please read this surah and thank Allah for this great bestowment. Being grateful to Allah promotes you along the ranks of belief. Allah says what can be translated as, **"…Indeed in case you thank (Him), indeed I will definitely increase you" (TMQ, 14:7).**

Surat Al-Hijr (Thamood's Habitation)

Surat Al-Hijr was revealed in Makkah after Surat Yusuf. In the Holy Book it comes after Surat Ibrahim and has 99 ayahs.

For the callers of Islam only

This surah was revealed during a time when the Prophet (*SAWS*) and the Muslims were experiencing all forms of harsh abuse. It was sent during a time very similar to modern times when Islam was perceived in a suspicious and derogatory manner.

Being subject to belittling can sometimes be more difficult to cope with than actual physical harm. To find oneself being faced by a strong opposition, despite one's strong belief that they are on the right path, is very harsh on that person. Surat Al-Hijr was sent to reassure the Prophet (*SAWS*) and all his followers throughout the centuries by saying to them: "Do not be afraid, for you are protected and Allah (*SWT*) will protect His religion. Place your trust in Him (*SWT*), do not be overwhelmed by your enemies' strength, and continue in your path of inviting people to Allah's path (*SWT*)."

Surat Al-Hijr is a surah that is directed at the callers of Allah (*SWT*). It is sent to those who love Islam and love to associate themselves with it. It is a surah specifically sent as a spiritual and divine reassurance for those callers whom people ridicule because of their strong understanding of the teachings of their religion. It also comforts the young women who are ridiculed because of their *hijab* (modest Islamic clothing). It is as if the surah is saying to these people: "Place your trust in Allah (*SWT*) and do not be overwhelmed by your enemies' might. Go on in your path of inviting people to Allah's path and guiding them to Islam."

Objectives of the surah

The objective of this surah is therefore very clear: Allah (*SWT*) is the Preserver of His religion and He (*SWT*) alone will ensure that it is established on this earth. Therefore, do not be overwhelmed by other civilizations and do not take notice of those who insult and doubt your convictions. Instead, focus on your efforts on inviting people to Allah (*SWT*) and worshipping Him (*SWT*) alone. It is a comforting and encouraging message to all those who fear for Islam, due to the present trials we are going through.

These implications are made clear throughout the surah, from beginning to end.

In the first few ayahs, Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Leave them to eat and enjoy, and let them be preoccupied with (false) hope. They will come to know!" (TMQ, 15:3).**

Allah (*SWT*) says, at the end of the Surah, what can be translated as, **"So glorify the praises of your Lord and be of those who prostrate themselves (to Him)." (TMQ, 15:98).**

These ayahs therefore reiterate the fact that one should not be distracted by the power of others. One should instead focus on their own worshipping through *Dhikr*

(invoking the name of Allah (*SWT*)), prostrating to Him (*SWT*), and ensuring that they remain steadfast and consistent in their actions until the end of their life. Allah (*SWT*) says, what can be translated as, **"And worship your Lord until there comes unto you the certainty (i.e. death)." (TMQ, 15:99).**

The ayahs of preservation mentioned in the surah

The surah refers to Allah's protection of several points, which include:

1. The Preservation of the Qur'an. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Verily, it is We Who have sent down the *Dhikr* (i.e. the Qur'ân) and surely, We will guard it (from corruption)" (TMQ, 15:9).** Have you forgotten that the Book that serves as your guide is preserved? It confirms that the One (*SWT*) who is able to preserve His Book is able to preserve His (*SWT*) religion and those who follow and invite others to it.

2. The Preservation of the heaven from *Iblis* (Satan) by making it an enjoyable sight for those who look at it. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And indeed, We have put the big stars in the heaven and We beautified it for the beholders. And We have guarded it (near heaven) from every outcast *Shaitân* (devil)." (TMQ, 15:16-18).**

3. The Preservation of the earth. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And the earth We have spread out, and have placed therein firm mountains, and caused to grow therein all kinds of things in due proportion." (TMQ, 15:19).** If the heavens and the earth have been protected to this extent, what do you think is the extent to which Allah (*SWT*) has protected His (*SWT*) Book and religion?

4. The protection of *rizq* (sustenance) on this earth, **"And the earth We have spread out, and have placed therein firm mountains, and caused to grow therein all kinds of things in due proportion. And We have provided therein means of living, for you and for those whom you provide not [moving (living) creatures, cattle, beasts, and other animals]. And there is not a thing, but with Us are the stores thereof. And We send it not down except in a known measure." (TMQ, 15:19-21).** Therefore, the Qur'an, the earth, and the believers are all protected.

5. The protection of the believers from the *Iblis* as Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Certainly, you shall have no authority over My slaves, except those who follow you of the *Ghâwûn* (*Mushrikûn* and those who go astray, criminals, polytheists, and evil-doers)." (TMQ, 15:42).**

6. It is further gratifying that the following ayahs, which gave glad tidings to the believers informing them that they will enter paradise, point out the concept of protection. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"(It will be said to them): 'Enter therein (Paradise), in peace and security." (TMQ, 15:46),** and **"No sense of fatigue shall touch them, nor shall they (ever) be asked to leave it." (TMQ, 15:48).**

Therefore, as a believer, you have been protected just as the Book of Allah (*SWT*), the heavens, and the sustenance have been protected. Allah (*SWT*) has indeed protected all of this for your own benefit to boost your heart and spirituality.

Iblis and Adam

As mentioned in previous Surahs, the stories mentioned in any surah are intended to stress on the objectives of that surah. The story of Adam and *Iblis* serves that same purpose. Throughout the Qur'an, the details of this story focus on Adam *(AS)*. However, in Surat Al-Hijr the focus is on *Iblis* himself. Allah (*SWT*) says in the Qur'an what can be translated as, **"[*Iblîs* (Satan)] said: "O my Lord! Give me then respite till the Day they (the dead) will be resurrected." Allâh said: "Then, verily, you are of those reprieved, Till the Day of the time appointed." [*Iblîs* (Satan)] said: "O my Lord! Because you misled me, I shall indeed adorn the path of error for them (mankind) on the earth, and I shall mislead them all. "Except Your chosen, (guided) slaves among them." (TMQ, 15:36-40).**

Notice *Iblis*'s consistent method of temptation, compelling man by making evil on earth seem attractive. This confuses concepts as well as distorts those with weak beliefs. However, the sincere servants of Allah (*SWT*) are protected by Allah's mercy and He (*SWT*) replies to *Iblis*'s temptations with what can be translated as, **"(Allâh) said: "This is the Way which will lead straight to Me. Certainly, you shall have no authority over My slaves, except those who follow you of the *Ghâwûn* (*Mushrikûn* and those who go astray, criminals, polytheists, and evil-doers)." (TMQ, 15:41-42).**

This surah is the surah of protection, for you are protected and so are the heavens, the earth, and the Qur'an. Why then should you ever be afraid? The surah was sent in order to comfort the Prophet (*SAWS*) and his followers, telling them that they are protected at a time when the enmity towards them in Makkah was at its peak. Today, it is a comfort to all those who make *da'wa*, assuring their protection. One is always protected as long as they maintain their closeness to Allah (*SWT*), as He (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Certainly, you shall have no authority over My slaves, except those who follow you of the *Ghâwûn* (*Mushrikûn* and those who go astray, criminals, polytheists, and evil-doers)." (TMQ, 15:42)** The *'ghawwoon'* are those who chose the path of *Iblis* and are therefore, deprived from this spiritual and divine protection. *Iblis* is aware of this reality when he says to Allah (*SWT*), **"Except Your chosen, (guided) slaves among them." (TMQ, 15:40)**

When you are guaranteed protection from Allah (*SWT*) why should you ever fear?

The people of the rocky tract (Al-Hijr)

The question that now needs to be answered is why was the surah was given this name?

Al-Hijr is the area where the tribe of Thamood (the people of Saleh *(AS)*) lived. However, what relationship does this have to the theme of protection?

The people of Al-Hijr did not believe in Allah's (*SWT*) miracles and refused to follow the path of *Iman* (belief in Allah (*SWT*)). Consequently, they felt that Allah (*SWT*) was going to punish them, so they began to search for a place where they could feel secure. The only place they found was Al-Hijr or the 'rocky tract'. In this new found home, they began to develop their civilization to an extent where they were hewing out houses from the mountain's rocks to feel secure. Allah (*SWT*) says in the Qur'an what can be translated as, **"And verily, the dwellers of *Al-Hijr* (the rocky tract) denied the Messengers. And We gave them Our Signs, but they were averse to them. And they used to hew out dwellings from the mountains (feeling themselves) secure." (TMQ, 15:80-82).** They believed that if they lived within these mountains, they would shield themselves against the punishment and torture of Allah (*SWT*). This is why they began to build their houses within the mountains to protect themselves from floods and other natural disasters. So what happened?

Allah (*SWT*) says in the Qur'an what can be translated as, **"But *As-Saihah* (torment - awful cry) overtook them in the early morning (of the fourth day of their promised punishment days**)." **(TMQ, 15:83)** No wall or mountain was able to protect them from that cry which came in the early morning, which is a sign of security, whereas night is always associated with fear and insecurity. It is as if the message to man is that protection comes from Allah (*SWT*) alone.

Do not be in astonishment with their civilization. It did not protect them from the might that Allah (*SWT*) mentions at the start of the surah. The method in which the tribe of Thamood was punished was unique in the sense that no other people had experienced it; a *Saihah* or an awful cry which no wall, wind, water, or rock can serve as protection.

This is why the surah was named Al-Hijr as a symbol of the strength of civilizations that could overwhelm us. It reminds us not to be overcome by such nations, reminding us that there is no protector except Allah (*SWT*).

The story of Lut *(AS)* (Lot)

To reiterate this meaning, Allah (*SWT*) mentions the story of Lut *(AS)* with obvious signs. The people of Lut *(AS)* were punished when they were at the peak of dwelling in their lusts. Allah (*SWT*) says in the Qur'an what can be translated as, "**Verily, by your life (O Muhammad *SAWS*), in their wild intoxication, they were wandering blindly" (TMQ, 15:72).** They were also punished in the morning as Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And We made known this decree to him, that the root of those (sinners) was to be cut off in the early morning." (TMQ, 15:66)** Allah (SWT) also describes their punishment in what can be translated as, **"So *As-Saihah* (torment - awful cry) overtook them at the time of sunrise" (TMQ, 15:73).**

Guidelines for callers of Allah (*SWT*) throughout time

Now that the reader of this surah has come to feel and appreciate the extent to which Allah (*SWT*) protects the believers in a way that no one else can, the surah begins to provide important guidelines, derived from the stories included in it, that implement its objectives:

1. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And indeed, We have bestowed upon you seven of *Al-Mathâni* (seven repeatedly recited Verses), (i.e. *Sûrat Al-Fâtihah*) and the Grand Qur'ân." (TMQ, 15:87).** In place of all that has been granted to others from power to materialistic property, Allah (*SWT*) has granted you Surat Al-Fatiha with its amazing meanings and the grand Qur'an. Hold on to what He (*SWT*) has granted you, be proud of it, and do not aim at anything else besides it. The following ayah reasserts this concept:

2. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Look not with your eyes ambitiously at what We have bestowed on certain classes of them (the disbelievers), nor grieve over them. And lower your wings for the believers (be courteous to the fellow-believers)." (TMQ, 15:88).** So do not be in awe with the materialistic objects of this world that are given to other civilizations and be proud of your Islam and be humble towards your fellow Muslim brothers and sisters. Do not be overwhelmed by Western technology and its modern buildings, for the divine law which was applied to the people of Al-Hijr applies to them as well; there is no protector but Allah (*SWT*).

3. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Therefore proclaim openly (Allâh's Message - Islâmic Monotheism) that which you are commanded, and turn away from *Al-Mushrikûn* (polytheists, idolaters, and disbelievers - See V.2:105)." (TMQ, 15:94).** Openly call to the way of Allah (*SWT*) despite any hardships that you may encounter because Allah (*SWT*) is The Protector. This ayah was the turning point during the time of the Prophet (*SAWS*). It shifted making *da'wa* in secret to making it in the open with public propagation of the message. The *sahabah* (companions of the Prophet (*SAWS)*) experienced some difficulty with regards to this issue and this ayah was sent to reassure them that they were protected by Allah (*SWT*) despite their being ridiculed.

4. "**Therefore proclaim openly (Allâh's Message - Islâmic Monotheism) that which you are commanded, and turn away from *Al-Mushrikûn* (polytheists, idolaters, and disbelievers - See V.2:105). Truly! We will suffice you against the scoffers." (TMQ, 15:94-95).**

5. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Indeed, We know that your breast is straitened at what they say. So glorify the praises of your Lord and be of those who prostrate themselves (to Him). And worship your Lord until there comes unto you the certainty (i.e. death)." (TMQ, 15:97-99).** Being ridiculed is unpleasant, and despite being convinced of Allah's (*SWT*) protection of oneself, a Muslim may tire of the comments of others. This ayah gives an antidote for this problem; it provides an outstanding end to the theme of protection this surah centres about. It is like a practical application of the concept to allow a person to feel this spiritual and divine protection. It is the antidote of glorifying Allah (*SWT*) and worshipping Him (*SWT*) until death. Let them ridicule you, for their end will not be different to that of the people of Al-Hijr. Indeed, you are protected.

Have a high zeal for your religion, work on improving yourself and inviting others to the way of Allah (*SWT*), and you will enjoy the protection and care of Allah (*SWT*) in this world, and you will earn the reward of Paradise in the hereafter.

Surat An-Nahl (The Bees)

Surat An-Nahl is Makkan. It was revealed after Surat Al-Kahf. It consists of 128 ayahs and falls in order after Surat Al-Hijr in the Qur'an. Many scholars agree that it is "The Surah of Blessings."

Remember it and be thankful

If one is to sit down and write all the blessings that Allah (*SWT*) had bestowed on him on a piece of paper then reads Surat An-Nahl, one would find all those blessings mentioned in the surah. Likewise, if one would read the surah, then writes down all the blessings that he/she comes across in it, one would find out that they have encompassed all that could possibly be imagined.

It is indeed "The Surah of Blessings". It calls upon the reader's attention to the blessings of Allah (*SWT*) that permeate the universe; beginning with the basic blessings, such as life necessities, to the inconceivable and disguised blessings that people usually forget, take for granted, or are even unaware of. After a comprehensive presentation of each group of blessings comes a conclusive ayah to remind us that Allah (*SWT*) is the provider of all those blessings. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And whatever favor you have, (then) it is from Allah; …" (TMQ, 16:53);** or **"And in case you number the favor (s) of Allah, you will not enumerate them; …" (TMQ, 16:18).**

There are many ayahs in the surah that explain the different sections of blessings, warning against the abuse of the blessing by using it to commit sins. In contrast, these ayahs urge mankind to thank Allah (*SWT*) and to employ those blessings in what they are created for.

Surat An-Nahl and Surat Ibrahim:

One might reflect that Surat Ibrahim also focuses on the blessings of Allah (*SWT*), so how is it connected to Surat An-Nahl? Surat Ibrahim focuses on one single blessing only, namely faith, as its main axis and the most important of Allah's blessings. In contrast, Surat An-Nahl covers all of Allah's blessings, starting with the simplest most basic life necessities to the most important of all, which are faith and revelation. For that reason, Surat An-Nahl starts with a reference to the same blessing that Surat Ibrahim starts with; revelation.

In Surat Ibrahim, Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Alif, Lam, Mîm, Ra (These are the names of letters of the Arabic alphabet, and only Allah knows their meaning here). A Book We have sent down to you that you may bring mankind out of the darkness (es) to the light by the permission of their Lord, …" (TMQ, 14:1),** and **"He (always) sends (i.e., He has been sending down) down the Angels with the Spirit of His Command upon whomever He decides among His bondmen, …" (TMQ, 16:2).**

An incessant presentation:

The surah starts with a presentation of Allah's blessings:

- The blessing of revelation, which is the first blessing in the surah; Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"He (always) sends (i.e., He has been sending down) down the Angels with the Spirit of His Command upon whomever He decides among His bondmen, (saying), "Warn that there is no god except I; so be pious to Me" (TMQ, 16:2).**

- The blessing of the creation of earth and the heavens; Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"He created the heavens and the earth with the truth. Supremely Exalted be He above whatever they associate (with Him)" (TMQ, 16:3).**

- The blessing of the creation of man; Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"He created man of a sperm-drop; yet, (behold) how he is an evident adversary" (TMQ, 16:4).** The souls that inhabit our bodies are themselves a blessing from Allah (*SWT*), after He had created us from naught.

- The blessing of animals (cattle) as a source of food, clothes, and a means of transportation; Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And the cattle- He created them for you; in them is warmth and (various) uses (i.e., profits) and of them you eat" (TMQ, 16:5);** and **"And horses and mules and asses for you to ride, and as an adornment; and He creates what you do not know" (TMQ, 16:8).**

  This ayah includes the means of transportation during the Prophet's (*SAWS*) days as well as the reference to all modern means of transportation in present world as Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"… and He creates what you do not know**.", **(TMQ 16:8),** which includes planes, cars … etc. that are all blessings that Allah has bestowed on us

- The blessing of water, falling down from the skies; Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"He is The One Who sends down to you from the heaven water of which you have drink, and of which (you have) trees, wherein you mark for (your herds) to graze"(TMQ, 16:10).**

- The blessing of plantation; Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Therewith He causes to grow for you plantation, and olives, and palms, and vineyards, and all (kinds of) products. Surely in that is, indeed, a sign for a people who meditate" (TMQ, 16:11).**

- The blessing of the subjection of the universe to man; Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And He has subjected to you the night, and the daytime, and the sun, and the moon. And the stars are subjected to His Command. Surely in that are indeed signs for a people who consider" (TMQ, 16:12).**

  This entire universe in its magnitude is subjected to you so you would live and fulfill your obligation for the Vicegerency. Imagine the world without the blessing of the subjection of the universe to mankind. Imagine the earth without oxygen, or without a sun providing light and warmth.

- The blessing of the adornment of earth; Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And whatever He has propagated for you in the earth of different colors. Surely in that is indeed a sign for a people who constantly remember" (TMQ, 16:13).**

  This is a blessing that people see every day, but unfortunately goes unnoticed. We took those blessings for granted and this surah shakes our senses and revives them all over again. It draws back our attention to perceive Allah's blessings in the universe.

Help your heart

Remembering Allah's blessings is essential to maintain a pious heart. Therefore, if you seem to be unable to contemplate upon them, I recommend that you follow these steps:

- Write down the blessings you know and speculate upon them.

- Remember and repeat "*Al-Hamdu l'Allah*" (Praise be to Allah) wherever you go even if it is done on your way to run an errand.

- Ponder upon Allah's blessings on you as you start your prayers reading Surat Al-Fatiha. For each *raka'a* (section of a prayer), have a specified blessing in mind, contemplate upon it, and thank Allah (*SWT*) for it. Evoking the blessings helps the heart to thank Allah (*SWT*) Who bestowed them. Man thanks his equals, the human beings, day and night but how many times does he really thank the Giver? How many times in a given day does a man say "*Al-Hamdu l'Allah*"?

More blessings

The ayahs go on numerating to us more blessings that Allah, The Lord of the worlds, brings from sources unimaginable to us, among which:

- The blessing of the subjection of the sea to mankind; Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And He is the One Who subjected the sea that you may eat of it fresh flesh and draw forth out of it ornaments for you to wear …" (TMQ, 16:14).**

Could one imagine that this scrumptious meat comes from the depths of such grisly growler sea? The problem of mankind lies in the fact that those blessings have become habitual to him and that he has taken them for granted. Surat An-Nahl comes to remind people of Allah's blessings, to revive our sense of wonder, and to evoke our feelings of gratitude for Allah (*SWT*).

- The blessing of the creation of mountains; Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And He has cast in the earth anchorages (i.e., mountains) so that it should not reel with you, …" (TMQ, 16:15**). For Allah (*SWT*) has made anchorage of mountains, which protects, as modern science has proven,

the earth against earthquakes.

- The blessing of the creation of the stars; Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And way marks; and by the star they are guided" (TMQ, 16:16).** These stars point us in all directions when traveling, in addition to the *qibla* (the direction of Makkah).

- The blessing of cattle's milk; Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And surely in (the) cattle (there) is indeed a lesson for you. We give you to drink of what is in their bellies, even between filth and blood, exclusively (pure) milk, palatable to the drinkers", (TMQ, 16:66).**

  Can you imagine the area from which pure milk comes in pleasant taste and odor, from among blood and stool? Nevertheless, it comes clean and pure without a drop of blood or dung! **"exclusively (pure) milk, palatable to the drinkers".**

- The blessing of knowledge, hearing, and sight; Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And Allah brought you out of your mothers' bellies not knowing anything …" (TMQ, 16:78);** then he gave us the tools to acquire science, **"… and He has made for you hearing and be holdings (i.e. eye sights) and heart-sights, (i.e., perception "s") that possibly you would thank (Him)" (TMQ, 16:78).**

- The blessing of birds; Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Have they not regarded the birds subjected in the firmament of the heaven? In no way does anyone hold them except Allah. Surely in that are, indeed, signs for a people who believe" (TMQ, 16:79).**

  The question here is, which one of us would take that into consideration and be thankful? Who would employ his bestowed blessings and use them in what pleases Allah (*SWT*) to gain His contentment?

"And in case you number the favor (s) of Allah, you will not numerate them" (TMQ, 16:18)

After mentioning all those blessings comes a core ayah; Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And in case you number the favor (s) of Allah, you will not enumerate them; surely Allah is indeed Ever-Forgiving, Ever-Merciful" (TMQ, 16:18)**. But what is to be counted? Do we count the known and tangible blessings or the intangible ones? If we assume that we could count up the concrete blessings, could we then calculate the benefits that each blessing encompasses? In the Qur'an, Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And in case you number the favor (s) of Allah, you will not enumerate them …"** He did not say the "favors" altogether! (In Arabic the translation of "favor", as mentioned in this ayah, means only one).

However, the ayah ends with, **"…surely Allah is indeed Ever-Forgiving, Ever-Merciful"**, to illustrate that man does not usually thank Allah (*SWT*) for the blessings

and that if Allah (*SWT*) were not merciful and forgiving, He would have severely tortured mankind for not thanking Him for his magnificent blessings.

Abusing the blessings

The objective of the surah is not limited to enumerating the blessings, but it also includes putting emphasis on their use, as well as employing them for what they are created for. Hence, after each wave of mentioning a blessing there is an ayah that warns against the abuse of blessings (ayahs 19-29).

Ayah 24, for instance, denounces those who do not appreciate or even deny the blessing of revelation; Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And when it is said to them, "What has your Lord sent down?" they say, "Myths of the earliest (people)" (TMQ, 16:24).** For this reason, they were destined to have an inauspicious ending; Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as**, "That they may carry their encumbrances complete on the Day of the Resurrection and (some) of the encumbrances of the ones that they lead into error without (any) knowledge …" (TMQ, 16:25).**

The ayah that follows depicts a horrifying scene of those who deny Allah's blessings; Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"The ones that were before them did already scheme; then Allah came upon their structure from the foundations, so the roof collapsed upon them from above them, and the torment came upon them from where they were not aware" (TMQ, 16:26).**

In contrast, there come the ayahs 30-32, directly following the aforementioned ayahs to bring about glad tidings to those who best utilize Allah's blessings upon them. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And it will be said to the ones who were pious, "What has your Lord sent down?" They will say, "Most Charitable!" (i.e., He has sent down the best) …" (TMQ, 16:30)** Observe that divine praise of those who acknowledge and appreciate the blessing of revelation, in comparison to those who deny it in ayah 24.

Next, and in ayah 32, Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Whom the Angels take up while they are goodly. They say, "Peace be on you! Enter the Garden for whatever you were doing" (TMQ, 16:32).** This too is juxtaposed with ayah 28, where Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"(The disbelievers are the ones) whom the Angels take up while they are unjust to themselves. So they will cast forth-full submissiveness. "In no way were we doing anything odious …",(TMQ, 16:28).**

The blessing of sending messengers and the guidance

Those two highly important blessings recur in the holy surah. Sending messengers to mankind with Allah's laws and methodology is the greatest blessing ever for the people in all ages. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And indeed We have already sent forth in every nation a Messenger (saying), "Worship Allah and avoid the *Taghût* ..." (i.e., false gods)" (TMQ, 166:36).**

Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as: **"And in no way did We send (even) before you, except men to whom We revealed. "So ask the population of the Remembrance, in case you (i.e. the pagan Arabs) do not know. With clear evidences and the Scriptures, (i.e., the *Zubur*, pl, of *Zabûr*, usually understood to be the psalms) and We have sent down to you (i.e. the Prophet) the Remembrance that you may make evident to mankind what has been sent down (ever since) and that possibly they would meditate", (TMQ, 16:43-44).**

Have you written among the blessings that Allah (*SWT*) has bestowed upon us sending Prophet Muhammad (*SAWS*)? How about the revelation of the Ever-Glorious Qur'an that has the ayahs we read and live? Have you ever thought of applying the Qur'an and the Prophet's *sunnah* with the intention of thanking Allah (*SWT*) for those two grand blessings?

Whatever blessing you have, it is from Allah

After a list of successive blessings comes a core and conclusive ayah to comment; Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And whatever favor you have, (then) it is from Allah …" (TMQ, 16:53).** This ayah draws our attention to the fact that recognizing Allah's blessings is a step towards thanking The Creator for the blessing, which is contingent on gratitude; and gratitude in turn is the guarantee for the continuance of blessings. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And as your Lord has notified (you), "Indeed in case you thank (Him), indeed I will definitely increase you …" (TMQ, 14:7).**

If man would trace back everything in his life to its origin, he would find that he actually possesses nothing that is originally his; starting with his basic needs like clothes, food, and drink, to the latest in modern technologies, such as space shuttles, computers, and cars. They all are based on the raw material that Allah (*SWT*) makes available to us and are also products of the human mind, which in turn is the greatest blessing He had bestowed upon us.

The misuse of blessings

Once again, the surah warns against the abuse of blessings, this time, describing a group of people who pray only when in tribulation, then turn to polytheism when in good times (ayahs 53-55); how would their destiny wind out? Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"That they may disbelieve in what We have brought them. So enjoy (this life); then eventually you will know" (TMQ, 16:55).**

In such case, Allah's blessing turns into some sort of introduction to a well-deserved retribution, "**So enjoy (this life) …".** Thus, if you find Allah's blessings upon you are incessantly increasing while you are negligent in thanking Him or in using them in good deeds, then beware that you will pay for this eventually.

Of the most horrific manifestation of the abuse of blessings is *wa'd al-banat* (burying female children alive); Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And when one of them is given the tidings of (the birth) of a female, his face lingers blackened and he is ever-repressed (with sorrow) (58) He hides himself from (Literally: overlays himself beyond) (the sight) of the people because of the odious tidings**

(given) him, whether he should retain it in degradation or shove it in the dust..." (TMQ, 16:58-59). It is inconceivable that after Allah's bestowal of such blessing, man would actually utilize it in sinning by killing an innocent soul!

The blessing of mercy and concealment

One of the blessings that Allah (*SWT*) bestowed on His worshippers is His patience with them and concealment of their sins; Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And if Allah should take mankind to task for their injustice, in no way would He leave hereon any beast ...", (TMQ, 16:61).**

Imagine if Allah (*SWT*) lifted his mercy and concealment of your sins! Imagine if Allah (*SWT*) disclosed your sins just for one single day! What if you woke up one day only to find posted on your door: Yesterday, he committed such and such? Or even worse; what if Allah (*SWT*) would have a list of your sins simply inscribed on your forehead? What if there would be an odor for every sin you commit?

It is indeed one of the greatest blessings of Allah (*SWT*) that what is exposed from our deeds is only the accepted and the good; concealed is all what is ugly of our sins. All praise and gratitude are for Allah (*SWT*).

The blessing of rain and revelation

Of the blessings that are concurrently mentioned in the surah is the blessings of revelation and rain; Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And in no way have We sent down upon you the Book except that you may make evident to them that wherein they have differed, and as a guidance and a mercy to a people who believe" (TMQ, 16:64);** and **"And Allah sends down from the heaven water; so He gives life therewith to the earth after its death …" (TMQ, 16:65).**

One might wonder about the secret behind those two blessings being inseparable! Each blessing resembles the other; while revelation is sent to people carrying benevolence, rain pours down to revive earth. Revealed ayahs, in the same manner, revive hearts, after they have been hardened. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And thus We have revealed to you a Spirit of Our Command... " (TMQ, 42:52);** and **"And is he who was deceased, then We gave him life ..." (TMQ, 6:122).**

Alcohol as a misuse of blessings

Once again, the surah warns against the misuse of blessings; Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And of the products of the palms and the vineyards you take to yourselves there from an intoxicant and a fair provision ..." (TMQ, 16:67).**

This ayah was revealed before the prohibition of alcohol; it does not talk about alcohol jurisprudentially, it rather warns against it as a form of misuse of blessings. Alcohol originates from fine fruits that are part of great blessings that Allah (*SWT*) has provided. However, some people changed its use into something other than what it was created for; they used it as a substance that deteriorates their minds and

humiliates them, a dangerous aspect of using the blessings for purposes other than the ones intended.

Social blessings

One might inquire about the blessing of a wife and family in this ayah!
Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And Allah has made for you of yourselves spouses, and made for you from your spouses sons (i.e. sons and daughters; seeds) and grandchildren, and He has provided you of the good (things)…) (TMQ, 16:72).**

A peaceful family life is one of the finest blessings that Allah (*SWT*) has bestowed on us. Therefore, the following ayah is a harsh one that warns against ingratitude of the blessing. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"… Is it then that they believe in untruth, and in the favor of Allah they (do) disbelieve? And they worship, apart from Allah, that which does not possess (power to give) them (any) provision for them from the heavens and the earth, and they are unable to (provide) anything" (TMQ, 16:72-73).**

The very homes that we inhabit are also a blessing; Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And Allah has made for you of your homes a dwelling …" (TMQ, 16:80).** So is the furniture that we utilize; **"…and made for you from the skins of (the) cattle homes (that) you find light on the day of your sojourning and on the day of your stationary abode, and of their wool (Literally: wools) and of their furs and of their hairs furnishings and an enjoyment for a while" (TMQ, 16:80);** the clothes we wear; **"…and He has made for you of the mountains nestled (refuges), and He has made for you apparels to protect you from the heat and apparels to protect you from your (own) violence ..." (TMQ, 16:81);** and even the simplest of all, the shade that we relax under; **"And Allah has made for you of what He created shades ..."; (TMQ, 16:81).**

For such reasons comes this core ayah; Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"… Thus He perfects His favor upon you, that possibly you would be Muslims (Literally: surrender "to Him")" (TMQ, 16:81).**

The danger of abusing the blessings

A succession of ayahs continues in the same context, as mentioned before; a wave of blessings, exhortation in using them in the approved manner, then the warning against their abuse. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"They recognize the favor of Allah; thereafter they deny it; and most of them are the disbelievers", (TMQ, 16:83).** It is clear now that ignoring the blessings could result in falling into atheism, Allah forbids.

The following is a string of intense ayahs that warn against breaking Allah's covenant after having all those bestowed blessings; Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And do not be as she who breaks her yarn, even after it is strongly spun, (Literally: powerfully spun) into strands...", (TMQ, 16:92); "And do not take to yourselves your oaths fraudulently among yourselves for that a foot should slide back after firm (steadiness) …" (TMQ, 16:94); "And do not trade the covenant**

of Allah for a little price …" (TMQ, 16:95); "Whatever is in your presence is depleted, and whatever is in the Providence of Allah is enduring ..." (TMQ, 16:96).

Other ayahs follow to warn against ingratitude; Allah (SWT) says what can be translated as, **"And Allah has struck a similitude: a town that was secure (and) well composed, its provision coming up to it opulently from every place, then it disbelieved (i.e., they were unthankful) in the amenities of Allah; so Allah made it taste the garment of hunger and fear for the things they were working out (i.e., doing)" (TMQ, 16:112).**

It would have been more appropriate had those people acted as Allah (*SWT*) commanded. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as**, "So eat of what Allah has provided you, lawfully good, and thank (Him) for the favor of Allah, in case it be Him only that you do worship" (TMQ, 16:114).**

***Ibrahim's* (Abraham) (*AS*) gratefulness to Allah (*SWT*)**

The surah concludes with the story of a man, who was grateful to Allah, he is Prophet *Ibrahim* (*AS*). What attracts one's attention is that the surah describes him with one of his traits that serves the surah*'s* objective; Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Thankful for His amenities …" (TMQ, 16:121).**

The surah indicates that being grateful to Allah (*SWT*) guarantees His guidance. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"… He selected him and He guided him to a straight Path" (TMQ, 16:121).**

The reason behind the title

Now we arrive to the reason behind the title of the surah. Why is the surah not entitled "the Surah of Blessings", since it is inundated with blessings? Why "An-Nahl" (the bees) in particular? Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And your Lord revealed to the bees, (saying), "Take to yourselves, of the mountains, homes, and of the trees, and of whatever they trellis. Thereafter eat of all (kinds of) products, (and) so insert (yourselves) (Or: follow) through the ways of your Lord, tractable (to you)." (Literally: made subservient) There comes out (Literally: goes out) of their bellies a drink of different colors, wherein is a cure for mankind ..." (TMQ, 16:68-69).**

Firstly, the organization of the bees' kingdom, and the way they secrete honey are per se great blessings of Allah (*SWT*) and among His miracles on earth. Secondly, the ayahs mentioned above start with **"…And your Lord revealed to the bees …"** which points out that bees follow the divine inspiration, obey Allah (*SWT*), and accurately abide by what they have been instructed to fulfill: **"…Take to yourselves … eat … so insert (yourselves) (Or: follow) through ...".**

Bees, therefore, constitute an exemplary model that employs the blessings of Allah (*SWT*). They obeyed Allah (*SWT*), carried out His orders, and as a result, Allah blessed them with bellies that generate curative and useful honey for all those that inhabit earth.

Please observe the following Qur'anic expression; **"…There comes out (Literally: goes out) …"** The ayah does not come in the imperative mode "bring out honey", because when inspiration was followed and when Allah's method was applied, then the honey came forth curative and useful. Likewise, if the nation follows Allah's revelation and abides by His methodology, the "honey" of the guiding light will come readily for the whole society.

One interesting fact in the kingdom of bees is that it is basically dependant on females. The commands in Arabic are really addressed to females; **"… eat … so insert (yourselves) (Or: follow) through ..."** This is obviously the case since the drone's sole mission is to impregnate the queen, while the responsibility of labor, construction, and honey secretions fall on the females.

Qur'an and honey cure bodies and souls

Magnificently enough, the word "cure" occurs in the Qur'an only twice; once describing the Qur'an itself and once describing honey! Qur'an and honey, therefore, are equally curative. Allah (*SWT*) enumerates a great deal of blessings in this surah (including the blessing of revelation) and warns us against misusing them. Therefore, if we use the blessing of honey the right way, we would cure our bodies. Likewise, if we would properly use the Qur'an, we would cure our minds, hearts, and souls.

Provide for the cost of honey

This was Surat An-Nahl, the surah of blessings. When you remember the blessings that Allah (*SWT*) has bestowed on you, but do not feel gratitude for Him, with every iota of your being, then you truly need to look within yourself, because you have not benefited from the surah. It is the surah of praise, the surah of knowing Allah's blessings and of thanking Him for them.

We ought to ask ourselves whether we have employed Allah's blessings to gain His acceptance, or have we used them in committing sins? One who abuses the blessings of Allah must fear this ayah; Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And Allah has struck a similitude: a town that was secure (and) well composed, its provision coming up to it opulently from every place, then it disbelieved (i.e., they were unthankful) in the amenities of Allah; so Allah made it taste the garment of hunger and fear for the things they were working out (i.e., doing)" (TMQ, 16:112).**

He, who utilizes Allah's blessings in disobedience, shall live an insecure life; his fortune in life shall diminish and he would live in poverty, famine, and fear. Therefore, among the most important graces that Allah had bestowed on the *Quraish* tribe (with whom Prophet Muhammad (*SAWS*) lived in Makkah) was security. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"So let them worship The Lord of this House (3) Who has fed them against hunger and secured them from fear", (TMQ, 106:3-4).**

A practical project

Why not follow our recitation of this surah with a practical project that intensifies our appreciation of Allah's blessings and heightens our interaction with Surat An-Nahl? First, read Surat An-Nahl, then trace the blessings of Allah (*SWT*) and write them all down; regulate those blessings into parts of your everyday life by using some specific examples (e.g. shelter, family, or food). After that, think of the best way of utilizing these blessings to please Allah (*SWT*). That way, you would have fulfilled Allah's aim in this surah.

May Allah be our Ever-Helper.

Surat Al-Israa (The Night Journey)

The Surah was revealed in Makkah after Surat Al-Qasas (the stories). It comes after Surat An-Nahl in the Qur'an, and consists of 111 ayahs. It is also known as the Surah of Israelites.

A Majestic congregation

In order to grasp the core ideas and the objectives of the surah, it is essential to refer to the story of *Al-Isra',* the night journey of Prophet Muhammad (*SAWS*) from Makkah to Jerusalem, that was followed by *Al-Mi'raj,* his ascension to the seventh Heaven. Given the magnitude of the latter, why is it that the surah is not entitled *Al-Mi'raj* instead, and what secret could the current title possibly hold?

An equally significant event occurred alongside this one; the greatest congregation in the history of mankind. *Al-Aqsa* mosque was filled up with the cream of the crop; the Prophets of Allah (*SWT*) from Adam (*AS*) to Isa (*AS*) "Jesus" were all waiting for the Prophet (*SAWS)* to be their *Imam* (leader in prayer).

The Imam of the Prophets and messengers

The Prophet (*SAWS*) led the prayer of the Prophets symbolizing the transference of the divine message they bore to the Muslim nation. It also indicates the Prophet's (*SAWS*) leadership in a holy place, *Al-Aqsa* mosque. Muhammad (*SAWS*) and his nation are now responsible for the Book i.e. the message sent by Allah (*SWT*) to mankind, the message that had been taken up by messengers, one after another. Nuh (*AS*) "Noah" carried the message with his sons after the flood. Then, Ibrahim (*AS*) "Abraham" was succeeded by Musa (*AS*) "Moses", Isa (*AS) "*Jesus*"*, and eventually Muhammad (*SAWS*) and his nation.

The responsibility of the Scripture

Each of these Prophets was ordered to guard the Book of Allah (*SWT*) and enjoin upon his people to guard it and to abide by its rules. However, they always failed to fulfill this obligation after their Prophet's passing away. They distorted the Book and changed its commandments. Upon doing so, Allah (*SWT*) replaced them with another nation to entrust it with the Scripture. The last nation to be in charge of the Scripture was the Israelites, who corrupted earth and did not comply with the Book's instructions. For this reason, the surah is also entitled after them as it tackles the shift of the Book's responsibility from them to the nation of Muhammad (*SAWS*), indicated in the fact that all the Prophets sent to the people of Israel prayed with Prophet Muhammad (*SAWS*) as their *Imam.* Thus, Allah (*SWT*) replaced them with the nation of Muhammad (*SAWS*) and this surah is a declaration of the delivery of the message.

The objective of the Surah: feel the value of the Qur'an

How this could be the objective of the surah and how it is related to *Al-Isra'* can be explained by the following; the Qur'an and the Book are mentioned in Surat Al-Israel, more than in any other surah, which is indicative of the importance of treasuring the Qur'an. *Al-Isra'* itself is a representation of the transfer of the Book to the nation of

Muhammad (*SAWS*); as if it invites us, the nation in charge of this Book, the Qur'an, to recognize its value and make sure not to let go of it like our predecessors did lest Allah (*SWT*) would replace us as He did with them.

Make it your Imam

Now, since we are roughly in the middle of our journey with explanation of the Ever-Glorious Qur'an, let us go through the surah and try to feel its greatness through its ayahs.

The transfer of the Book through nations

The surah starts with the *Al-Isra'* incident as Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"All Extolment be (to Him), Who made His bondman to set forth by night from the Inviolable Mosque to the Further (Literally: Remotest) Mosque, around which We have blessed..."** (TMQ, 17:01). **In the next ayah, Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, "And We brought Mûsa (Moses) the Book..." (TMQ, 17:02).** This ayah comes after the incident of *Al-Isra'* to emphasize that mentioning it is to declare the transfer of the Scripture from Israelites to the nation of Muhammad (*SAWS*). Thus, we find that the second ayah tackles the nation that had the scripture before as Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"and We brought Mûsa (Moses) the Book and We made it a guidance to the Seeds (Or: Sons) of Israel) (saying), "Do not take to yourselves any trustee apart from Me" (TMQ, 17:02).** How did the scripture reach them? Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Offspring of whomever We carried with Nûh, (Noah) surely he was a constantly thankful bondman." (TMQ, 17:03).**

Hence, the three ayahs are a concrete representation of the transfer of the scripture among nations. What did they do with the scripture? Why were they replaced? The answer is in what Allah (*SWT*) says and can be translated as, **"And We decreed for Seeds (Or: Sons) of Israel) in the Book: "Indeed you will definitely corrupt in the earth twice, and indeed you will definitely (become) exalted a great exaltation." (TMQ, 17:04).**

The Ayahs from 4 to 7 go on to demonstrate how the previous nation did not assume its responsibility until we reach the pivotal ayahs that declares that the scripture is the responsibility of the Muslim nation. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as**, "Surely this Qur'an guides to (the way) that is more upright, and gives good tidings to the believers who do deeds of righteousness that they will a great reward, And (gives the tidings) that that the ones who do not believe in the Hereafter, We have readied for them a painful torment" (TMQ, 17:09-10).**

Therefore, cling to this Book, and let it be your shield, for it guides you, Muslims, to what is best for you.

The record of the afterlife

Amidst the speech about the Day of Judgment comes an ayah about the Book of the Day of Judgment, the Book of the good and bad deeds, in order to illustrate the destiny of those who do not stick to the Allah's Book on earth. Allah (*SWT*) says

what can be translated as, **"And every man We have imposed on him his bird (of augury) upon his neck, and "We will bring out for him, on the Day of the Resurrection, a Book (that) he will meet with, spread open. Read your Book! Your self suffices you this day as a constant-reckoner against you" (TMQ, 17:13–14).**

The Book is a major issue in the life of Muslims for if they do not read it, understand its essence, and apply it to their lives, what would they do with the Book of the afterlife?

The commandments of the Book

As of the second quarter, the surah deals with the greatness of the Book, as it orders us to do what is necessitated by pure human intuition. Any man of sound judgment and pure nature, cannot, upon reciting the Qur'an, but admit its greatness. Among such commandments are:

- Being dutiful to one's parents; Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And your Lord has decreed that you should not worship any except Him (only) and (to show) fairest companionship to parents; in case ever one or both of them reaches old age (Literally: being great "in years") in your presence, do not say to them, "Fie!" nor scold them; and speak to them respectful words (Literally: say to them an honorable saying). And lower to them the wing of humbleness out of mercy and say, "Lord! Have mercy on them, as they reared me (when I was) small" (TMQ, 17:23–24).**

- Using money for the common good; Allah says what can be translated as, **"And bring to a near kinsman his true (right) and (to) the indigent and the wayfarer; and do not squander wantonly (Literally: in "wanton" squandering). Surely the squanderers have been brethren of Ash-Shayâtîn (The all-vicious ones, i.e., the devils), and Ash-Shaytan has ever been ever-disbelieving to his Lord" (TMQ, 17:26–27).**

- Balancing miserliness and squandering; Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And do not set up your hand shackled to your neck, (i.e., Do not be niggardly) nor outspread it widespread altogether, (Literally: outspread it all outspreading, i.e., do not be a spendthrift) for then you will sit blamed and regretfully rejected" (TMQ, 17:29).**

The call of intuition

All of those are commandments that address a sound mind and a pure nature and no body can possibly disregard or desert them, especially that they are well-devised to serve the common good. Thus, Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as,

- **"And do not kill your children in apprehension of want; We provide for them and for you (too); surely the killing of them has been a great sinning" (TMQ, 17: 31).**

- **"And do not come near to adultery; surely it has been an obscenity and odious as a way"(TMQ, 17: 32).**

Since the ayahs address the pure nature, they describe z*ena* (unlawful sex) as **"odious as a way"** for it is an extremely foul deed even if some of the weak souls do not find it so. Adopting such an evil way leads to nothing but destruction and disasters like murders, lack of *rizq* (sustenance), darkness of faces (the troubled state of mind that shows on the face), confusion of lineage, and a miserable sad life. Moreover, Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as,

- **"And do not kill the self that Allah has prohibited, except by truthful (right) (Literally: with the truth)" (TMQ, 17:33).**

- **"And do not draw near the wealth of the orphan except in the fairest (manner)..." (TMQ, 17:34).**

- **"And fill up the measure when you measure, and weigh with the straight equitableness... (TMQ, 17: 35).**

- **"And do not pursue what you have no knowledge of; surely hearing and beholding and heart-sight, (Or: perception) all of those will be questioned of" (TMQ, 17:36).**

- **"And do not walk in the earth merrily; surely you will never pierce the earth, and you will never reach the mountains in height" (TMQ, 17:33-37).**

Such words cannot possibly be rejected or deserted; the Book quite plainly orders Muslims to do all these good things and warns them against what may cause their destruction. Allah says (*SWT*) what can be translated as, **"All the bad aspects of these (the above mentioned things) are hateful to your Lord" (TMQ, 17:38).**

For this reason, these ayahs are followed by an interesting comment; Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"That is of (the) Wisdom your Lord has revealed to you..." (TMQ, 17:39).** All the forth mentioned concepts constitute great wisdom and lead to a decent existence here and in the afterlife. Nevertheless, whoever disregards them is guaranteed a long stay in hell as Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"and do not make up with Allah another god, (or) then you will be cast in Hell blamed (and) rejected" (TMQ, 17:39).** This illustrates the greatness of the Qur'an since in ayah after ayah, Allah (*SWT*) informs Muslims that all the good they could ever need is simply in it. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And indeed We have already propounded (i.e., Our warnings) in this Qur'an that they may constantly remember; and in no way does it increase them except in repulsion" (TMQ, 17:41).**

The value of the Qur'an

Thus, the ayahs do not only establish the greatness of the Qur'an and the significance of its commandments, but also they enumerate the qualities of the Book from one

ayah to the other as this surah is considered the one with the largest number of references to the Book.

For example, the Qur'an acts as a shield of protection for its people. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And when you read the Qur'an, We make between you and the ones who do not believe in the Hereafter a screened curtain. And We make lids upon their hearts so that they could not comprehend it, and (we make) in their ears an obstruction. And when you mention your Lord alone in the Qur'an, they turn their backs in repulsion" (TMQ, 17:45-46).**

Furthermore, the Qur'an includes historical secrets and civilization-building norms. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And decidedly not a city is there excepting that We will be causing it to perish before the Day of the Resurrection, or We will be tormenting it with a strict torment. That has been in the Book inscribed" (TMQ, 17:58).**

The stress laid on the greatness of the Qur'an in Surat Al-Israel is quite palpable to readers who have started the journey with us and have reached Part 15, the middle of it. Readers are by all means encouraged to sense the significance of the Qur'an and are not advised to read it indifferently, simply because the ayahs such as the ones discussed here offer them a great opportunity to improve their status on the Day of Judgment. The Prophet (*SAWS*) says, " On the Day of Judgment, the reciter of the Qur'an will be summoned: "Read, and be promoted (be raised to sublimity) and recite melodiously (i.e. the Qur'anic verses) for your (religious) rank accords with the last ayah you recited."[2]

Dear Muslim brother/sister, the number of the levels of *Jannah* (Paradise) equal that of the Qura'nic ayahs. Don't you want to go to *Jannah*? Don't you dream of it? Don't you want Al-*Ferdaos Al-A'ala* (the highest level of *Jannah*)? If you do, then always read the Qur'an, especially in *Al-Fajr* prayer (the dawn prayer) and in *Qiyam* (night prayers). In this regard, Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Keep up the prayer at the sinking of the sun to the dusk of the night and (the reading) of the Qur'an at dawn; surely the reading of the Qur'an at dawn has been witnessed" (TMQ, 17:78).** Allah (*SWT*) also says what can be translated as**, "And keep constant vigil with it (The Qur'an) (part) of the night (These are the late night supererogatory prayers) as an accordance for you; it may be that your Lord will make you rise again to a praised station." (TMQ, 17:79).**

A cure and mercy to believers

Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And We are sending down, of the Qur'an, that which is a cure and a mercy to the believers; and it increases the unjust in nothing except in greater loss" (TMQ, 17:82)**. As mentioned in Surat An-Nahl, the word "cure" in Qur'an is only associated with Qur'an and honey. This is because honey is a cure to bodily diseases while Qur'an is a cure to the hearts and souls that truly understand its value.

The challenge of Qur'an

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[2] Good Hadith, narrated by Al-Albany.

Many are the ayahs that tackle the greatness of Qur'an in this surah. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, "**Indeed in case humankind and the jinn gathered together to come up with the like of this Qur'an, they would not come up with its like, even if they were backers of one another" (TMQ, 17:88).**

Be proud of this challenge that will continue to exist until the Day of Judgment. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And indeed We have already propounded for mankind in this Qur'an every type of similitude; yet most of mankind have refused (all) except constant disbelief" (TMQ, 17:89).**

All the requirements of human well-being are in Qur'an, yet the majority of people choose to disbelieve.

The role of the Qur'an

Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as**, "And with the Truth We have sent it down, and with the Truth it has come down; and in no way have We sent you except (as) a constant bearer of good tidings and a constant warner. And (this is) a Qur'an; We have distinctly separated (its verses) that you may read it to mankind staidly, (Or: at intervals) and We have been sending it down successively (i.e., by successive revelation on different occasions)"(TMQ, 17:105-106).**

The Surah was entitled "Surat Al-Israel" so that every time we read it, we remember the Prophet (*SAWS*) when he first received the divine message during his *Al-Isra'* and handed it to us afterwards.

Since we are responsible for the Qur'an, we should read it frequently, not only in Ramadan but in all months. We should consider, spread, apply, and teach it to those around us.

The lovers of Qur'an

The end of the surah is reminiscent of people who loved the Qur'an, and perceived the objective of this surah in such a way that they reacted sincerely to the Book and got overwhelmed by its words. In this regard, Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, "**Say, "Believe in it or do not believe. Surely the ones who were brought the knowledge even before it, when it is recited to them, collapse upon their faces (Literally: up to the chins) constantly prostrating, and they say, All Extolment be to our Lord! Decidedly the promise of our Lord has indeed been performed! And they collapse upon their faces weeping, and it increases them in submissiveness. (A prostration is to be performed here)" (TMQ, 17: 107-109).**

It is a blessing from Allah (*SWT*) that we see a number of young people nowadays reacting to the Qur'an the way those people used to do, especially in Ramadan. They get so affected by it that they **"collapse upon their faces (Literally: up to the chins) constantly prostrating" (TMQ, 17:108)**. Whenever they listen to the ayahs of the Qur'an, **"increases them in submissiveness" (TMQ, 17:109),** which is very reassuring. When the youth reach such a level in dealing with Qur'an, this foretells a promising future for this nation.

It raises nations and destroys others

If we were not like the lovers of the Qur'an mentioned above, Allah (*SWT*) uses the same ayah to warn us of being replaced, saying what can be translated as, **"Believe in it or do not believe..."(TMQ, 17:107).** Throughout ages, the bygone nations were negligent and indifferent to the Books of Allah (*SWT*). Hence, it has been moved from a nation to another until it reached us. What then would be the punishment in case we failed to fulfill our obligation towards it?

The punishment on the Day of Judgment will be tougher because we are the last nation to bear this responsibility. We should not fall short of such task. Rather, we should strive to fulfill this responsibility. Nothing can ensure the nation's progress, dignity, and usher it into enlightenment except for this Book. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"...A Book We have sent down to you that you may bring mankind out of the darkness(es) to the light" (TMQ, 14:01).**

Treasures of *Hasanat* (rewards)

When you read the Qur'an, try to feel, in addition to its greatness and significance, the heaps of *Hasanat* (rewards) that accompany the recitation of Qur'an.

The Prophet (*SAWS*) says, "Whoever recites a letter from Allah's Book (the Noble Qur'an), he will be credited with one virtue, and a virtue gets a ten-fold reward. I do not say that *Alif-Lam-Mim* is one letter, but *Alif* is a letter, *Lam* is a letter and *Mim* is a letter**".**[3]

If you recite **"In The Name of Allah, the All-Merciful, the Ever-Merciful,"** which comprises 29 letters (in Arabic), you receive the reward of one hundred and ninety *Hasanat.* Consequently, on reading a chapter/part of the Qur'an, which includes an average of seven thousand letters, the Muslim is granted 70 thousand *Hasanat* at regular times. Can you imagine what the reward be in the favorable times of *Al-Fajr* prayer, *Al-Qiyam* (night prayer), or Ramadan; where the reward is doubled?

If thousands of *Hasanats* are granted for reciting a chapter, which normally does not consume more than 45 minutes, how many are given to those who apply Qur'an and listen to it with the intention of applying and abiding by it? What about those who understand Qur'an and know the objective of every surah? Try to imagine the huge amount of *Hasanat* a Muslim would get if he/she feels that Qur'an is a huge responsibility and arouses the interest of people around him/her in reading Qur'an and explains to them some of its ayahs

A young Muslim who recites Surat Al Israel and understands Allah's objective should deal with the Qur'an, from now on, with absolute seriousness, devoting his life to Qur'an in the aim of joining the lovers of Qur'an, who are special to Allah (*SWT*).

From Al-Israel to Al-Kahf (The Cave)

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[3] Authentic Hadith, Al-Albany.

Interestingly, the meanings of Qur'an run all through it, since they link Surahs together. In our case, an idea links the end of Surat Al-Israel to the beginning of Surat Al-Kahf. After Surat Al-Israel which ends with a *Sajdah* (prostration) that enables us to feel the beauty of the Qur'an, fall in tears out of the fear of Allah (*SWT*), and thank Him for his great blessing (i.e. Qur'an), comes Surat Al-Kahf, which starts with pure gratitude to Allah for such a blessing. In this respect, Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Praise be to Allah Who has sent down upon His bondman the Book and has not made to it any crookedness" (TMQ, 18:01).**

Surat Al-Kahf (The Cave)

Surat Al-Kahf is a Makkan Surah. It was revealed after Surat Al-Ghaashiyah, but in the order of the Qur'an it comes after Surat Al-Isra'. It consists of 110 ayahs.

Threads for One Fabric

Surat Al-Kahf consists of four stories: The story of the people of the cave; that of the man with the two gardens; that of Prophet Musa *(AS)* (Moses) and Al-Khidr; and that of Dhul Qarnain. Several ayahs follow each story for further comment. Thus some questions are to be raised : What do these stories then have in common? Why is the Surah named Surat Al-Kahf? Why should it be read every Friday?

The Advantages and Rewards for whoever reads Surat Al-Kahf

The Prophet (*SAWS*) said, "He who reads Surat Al-Kahf on Friday, Allah will light for him radiance that stretches from his feet to the holy Ka'ba."[4].

The Prophet (*SAWS*) also said, "…and he who reads the last ten ayahs of Surat Al-Kahf, Al-Dajjal will not be able to harm him."[5].

And in another Hadith, "…whoever among you encounters him – Al-Dajjal – should read upon him the opening ayahs of Surat Al-Kahf."[6].

What is Al-Dajjal's relationship with Surat Al-Kahf and what do the stories within the Surah have in common? Let's then have a brief survey of the four above mentioned stories.

The cave of mercy

The first story talks about young men who believed in Allah *(SWT)* and called to Him despite the fact that the tribe they lived in was ruled by an unjust king who did not believe in Allah *SWT)*. The young men presented their religion (surrender to Allah as an only One Lord) to their people, but the the latter rejected them. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And We made their hearts firm and strong (with the light of Faith in Allah and bestowed upon them patience to bear the separation of their kith and kin and dwellings) when they stood up and said: "Our Lord is the Lord of the heavens and the earth, never shall we call upon any *iIlah* (god) other than Him; if we did, we should indeed have uttered an enormity in disbelief. These our people have taken for worship *illah* (gods) other than Him (Allah). Why do they not bring for them a clear authority? And who does more wrong than he who invents a lie against Allah... but no one knows its true meanings except Allah" (TMQ, 18:14-15).**

The young men began to call people to Allah *(SWT)*, but they were denied and oppressed. Thus, Allah *(SWT)* inspired them to seek refuge in the Cave. Allah *(SWT)*

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[4] Sahih Al-Game': 6471.
[5] Sahih Al-Targhib: 225.
[6] Muslim: 2937.

says what can be translated as, **"…then seek refuge in the Cave; your Lord will open a way for you from His Mercy and will make easy for you your affair (i.e. will give you what you will need of provision, dwelling)… but no one knows its true meanings except Allah" (TMQ, 18:16).**

Allah *(SWT)* supported them with great miracles: they dwelled in the cave for **"three hundred (solar) years, adding nine (for lunar years)" (TMQ, 18:25).** Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"…And you might have seen the sun, when it rose, declining to the right from their Cave, and when it set, turning away from them to the left, while they lay in the midst of the Cave…but no one knows its true meanings except Allah" (TMQ, 18:17).**

"And you would have thought them awake, whereas they were asleep. And We turned them on their right and on their left sides…" (TMQ, 18: 18). All of these miracles were accomplished for the sake of protecting these young men. In fact, they awoke 309 years later to find that the people around them had become believers and that they were now part of a new society, filled with faith.

Arrogance challenging faith

The second story is that of a man upon whom Allah *(SWT)* bestowed His blessings and bounty. The man became absorbed in his new fortune, forgetting completely who granted it to him, and responding with challenge and doubt. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And put forward to them the example of two men: unto one of them We had given two gardens of grapes, and We had surrounded both with date-palms; and had put between them green crops (cultivated fields)…And he went into his garden while in a state (of pride and disbelief) unjust to himself. He said: "I think not that this will ever perish… but no one knows its true meanings except Allah" (TMQ, 18:32-35).** Money had seduced him and distracted him from turning to Allah (*SWT*). **"And I think not the Hour will ever come, and if indeed I am brought back to my Lord, (on the Day of Resurrection), I surely shall find better than this when I return to Him." His companion said to him during the talk with him: "Do you disbelieve in Him Who created you out of dust (i.e. your father Adam), then out of *Nutfah* (mixed semen drops of male and female discharge), then fashioned you into a man?" (TMQ, 18:36-37).** The fate of the man whose money left him arrogant and conceited: **"So his fruits were encircled (with ruin). And he remained clapping his hands (with sorrow) over what he had spent upon it, while it was all destroyed on its trellises, and he could only say: "Would that I had ascribed no partners to my Lord" (TMQ, 18:42).**

How to behave with regard to Allah's predestination of events

The third story is that of Prophet Musa (*AS*) and Al-Khidr. Prophet Musa *(AS)* was asked by his people about who was the most knowledgeable on earth. Prophet Musa *(AS)* replied that he himself was. He thought that he had enough knowledge to earn that title, especially because he was one of Allah's favored Prophets. However, Allah (*SWT*) revealed to him that there was a learned man elsewhere. For this reason, He commanded him *(AS)* to go to where the two seas met. Musa (*AS*), accompanied by a boy servant, traveled a great distance until he was overcome by fatigue. He then told

his servant, **"Truly, we have suffered much fatigue in this, our journey" (TMQ, 18:62).**

He was extremely exhausted by the time he met up with the righteous and more knowing man. The type of knowledge that man had is in fact the trust in Allah's predestination: the way Allah predetermines and arranges the course of events in life. There is also wisdom in Allah's predestination which makes necessary for one to know for certain that Allah alone handles life matters. This knowledge, in short, is learning how to know Allah *(SWT)* in the correct way in so far as His handling of life matters is concerned.

Before Prophet Musa *(AS*) could accompany Al-Khidr on his journey, the latter set forth a few conditions. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Ask me not about anything till I myself mention of it to you… but no one knows its true meanings except Allah" (TMQ, 18:70).** Prophet Musa *(AS)* replied, **"If Allah wills, you will find me patient, and I will not disobey you in aught" (TMQ, 18:69).**

The trip was marked by three incidents which seem very negative or malicious at first glance:

1- The ship Al-Khidr pierced because there was an unjust king who was taking away every ship by force.
2- The child Al-Khidr killed because he was not dutiful towards his parents who were righteous. His disobedience caused them too much trouble.
3- The wall Al-Khidr rebuilt because it was damaged in part, without recompense for his work especially in a town he wasn't warmly welcomed. In fact, a treasure belonging to two orphan boys was buried beneath it. It would have been stolen had he (Al Khidr) not built the wall.

Allah's wisdom seems to be not apparent at first glance in the way the three above-cited incidents are arranged; Al-Khidr's acts seem not to be justified. This is to prove to the believers that Allah (*SWT*) may handle matters in ways we may not understand. Consequently, we may neither grasp the wisdom behind this nor appreciate the goodness or the positive effects this may have on our life. This is the type of knowledge, not found in any book, that Allah *(SWT)* wishes to teach not only to Prophet Musa *(AS)* but to us as well.

Verily, We established him in the earth

The last story is that of Dhul-Qarnain, the just king who spread truth, justice and goodness on earth. He had also the material means (scientific and technological) needed to achieve success and progress in life.

Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as**, "Verily, We established him in the earth, and We gave him the means of everything…but no one knows its true meanings except Allah" (TMQ, 18:84).** The king traveled eastwards and westwards to spread guidance on earth and fill it with justice and righteousness. On his journeys, he reached people who scarcely understand a saying. They said to him, **"O Dhul-Qarnain! Verily Ya'juj and Ma'juj (Gog and Magog) are doing great mischief in**

the land. Shall we then pay you a tribute in order that you might erect a barrier between us and them?" (TMQ, 18:94).

Despite the fact that he was capable of building the barrier alone, he asked for help so that they may learn a lesson from it. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as**, "So help me with strength (of men), I will erect between you and them a barrier…but no one knows its true meanings except Allah"** (**TMQ, 18:95).** He built the barrier, which has remained standing until today. However, we do not know where the barrier actually is, and thus will not be able to know where Ya'juj and Ma'juj's are located until their appearance before the Day of Judgment.

The connection between the four stories

We must remember that the Qur'an does not just narrate stories in quite a random manner; they rather form an integral structure and serve a specific meaning. For example, the story of Prophet Musa *(AS)* does not mention the Pharaoh or the miracle of the stick because the meaning intended in this case is different from that found in either of those stories. What is then the thread which ties the four aforementioned stories together?

The stories talk about the major trials and temptations in human life:

1- **The trial of religion**: the case of people's evil acts towards a believer in the form of harm, torture or threats which may cause his loss of faith, deviation from religion or fear. This was the trial the people of the cave experienced and passed.

2- **The trial of wealth:** this was the trial of the man with the two gardens, who was so proud of his wealth that he considered the hereafter not to be true. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And I think not the Hour will ever come, and if indeed I am brought back to my Lord, (on the Day of Resurrection), I surely shall find better than this when I return to Him…but no one knows its true meanings except Allah " (TMQ, 18:36).**

3- **The trial of knowledge**: The case of a man who boasts of the knowledge he possesses to the extent that he feels arrogant and hence forgets about modesty. Such a man may learn things of no benefit to him or to his community. Or else he may misuse the knowledge he was granted in a way that may harm him or the society in which he lives. The trial of knowledge is illustrated in the story of Prophet Musa *(AS)* and Al-Khidr. Prophet Musa (*AS*) thought that no one on earth was more knowledgeable than him. However, once he realized that this was untrue, he traveled a long distance to meet the more knowing man and to learn from him in a truly respectful and modest relation of a pupil to his teacher. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Musa said to him (Khidr): "May I follow you so that you teach me something of that knowledge (guidance and true path) which you have been taught (by Allah)? But no one knows its true meanings except Allah" (TMQ, 18:66).**

4- **The trial of power**: The example of a man who, given all the means to achieve material and technological success to push civilization forward and to

gain authority and power, denies Allah, abuses power and oppresses his people. In contrast to this sets the story of Dhul-Qarnain. The latter is presented as a just king who attributes his wealth and power to Allah *(SWT)* alone. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"He said: "As for him (a disbeliever in the Oneness of Allah) who does wrong, we shall punish him, and then he will be brought back unto his Lord, Who will punish him with a terrible torment (Hell). "But as for him who believes (in Allah's Oneness) and works righteousness, he shall have the best reward, (Paradise), and we (Dhul-Qarnain) shall speak unto him mild words (as instructions)…but no one knows its true meanings except Allah" (TMQ, 18:87-88). Dhul-Qarnain said: "This is a mercy from my Lord..." (TMQ, 18:98).**

The stimulus of temptation

The four basic trials and temptations mentioned above represent the thread that tie the four stories together in Surat Al-Kahf. Half-way in the Surah, between the first two stories and the two remaining others, we are told that the stimulus of temptation is the enemy of Allah *(SWT)*, namely, Iblis (Satan). Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, "**Will you then take him (*Iblîs*) and his offspring as protectors and helpers rather than Me while they are enemies to you? What an evil is the exchange for the *Zâlimûn* (polytheists, and wrong-doers)...but no one knows its true meanings except Allah"** (TMQ, 18:50). Who, in their right mind, would take Allah's enemy and theirs as a master and defender?

Protection from temptation

The main idea of the Surah is protection from temptation. As it is mentioned in the Hadith before, the Surah safeguards one from the greatest trial in the history of Mankind, from Prophet Adam (*AS*) until the Day of Judgment. It is that of Al-Dajjal. In this respect, the Prophet (*SAWS*) says: "Between the creation of Adam and the Day of Judgment, there exists no greater trial than that of Al-Dajjal."[7] A question is then to be raised : What is the connection between the trial of Al-Dajjal and the four aforementioned trials and temptations?

Al-Dajjal will appear before the Day of Judgment and present the four temptations. He will try to push people to abandon their faith and will ask them to worship him and not Allah *(SWT)*. Allah (*SWT*) will give him the ability to perform miracles: Al-Dajjal then may promise to bring to life one's mother and father if one rejects Allah *(SWT)* and believes in him instead. Everybody will be tempted except those blessed by Allah *(SWT)*. Al-Dajjal has the temptation of wealth: he simply commands the sky to rain down on a particular piece of land and vegetation then flourishes. He will be able to transform a barren desert land into a beautiful green garden. He also has the temptation of knowledge: he captivates people with what he knows which leads some of them to believe in him. Finally, he has the temptation of power: he subjugates people to his strength and authority in many parts of the earth except Makkah and Al-Madinah. These are serious temptations that all Muslims, in all parts of the land and throughout all of time, must beware of. Reading Surat Al-Kahf and understanding the

[7] Muslim: 2946.

meanings within it, especially the four stories and the divine messages they carry can do this.

Objectives of the Surah: Protection from trial and temptation

The four stories in the Surah are linked together through the string of trials. Each story is followed by comments which point out the lessons to be learned from it and how we can protect ourselves from trials and temptations. This is the magnificence of the Qur'an; it does not tell stories for their own sake but to serve the end of the Surah namely protection from trials and temptations and to emphasize the lessons to be learned after each story. In this respect, the whole thrust of the Surah is to make the following message crystal clear: protecting oneself from the various forms of temptation. One may wonder how this can be made.

'Lifeboats'

1- The importance of having righteous companions

The first trial is that of religion which was mentioned in the story of the people of the cave. In order for one to remain steadfast in one's religious conduct and be protected from this trial, Surat Al-Kahf advises:

a) Be in righteous company: **"And keep yourself (O Muhammad, *SAWS*) patiently with those who call on their Lord (i.e. your companions who remember their Lord with glorification, praising in prayers, and other righteous deeds) morning and afternoon, seeking His Face; and let not your eyes overlook them, desiring the pomp and glitter of the life of the world" (TMQ, 18:28).** Having good companions in life and striving to keep such companionship helps one to remain committed to his religious principles.

b) Remembering the hereafter: The hereafter is the ultimate destiny of both believers and disbelievers. By thinking continuously about it the Muslim protects himself from the various temptations he experiences **"Verily, We have prepared for the *Zâlimûn* (polytheists and wrong-doers.), a Fire whose walls will be surrounding them (disbelievers in the Oneness of Allah). And if they ask for help (relief, water), they will be granted water like boiling oil that will scald their faces. Terrible is the drink, and an evil *Murtafaq* (dwelling, resting place.)!"(TMQ, 18:29).**

2- Avoidance of Becoming Attached to this Life

There are two lessons to be learned regarding protection from the trial of wealth to which the man with the two gardens was subjected:

1. Understanding the true purpose of this life: This is mentioned very clearly in the Ayah coming immediately after the story of the man with the two gardens. **"And put forward to them the example of the life of this world."** I hereby invite you, my Muslim brothers, to take a long and contemplating look, , at the type of life you are attached to : "**it is like the water (rain) which We send down from the sky,"** so what happened to it **"And the vegetation of the**

earth mingles with it," so simply and so quickly and what else **"But (later) it becomes dry and broken pieces, which the winds scatter. And Allah is Able to do everything"** (**TMQ, 18:45).** The ayah lays out a picture in which we see quick flashes from the beginning of life to its middle and then to its end. The stages pass by quickly, and are tied together by the Arabic letter "fa" (meaning 'and') **[And …mingles... becomes dry and broken pieces]** which implies quick vanishing and thus refer to the nature of life itself. This life is passing; do not become attached to it, my brother in Islam, if you really want to be protected from trials and temptations.

2. Remembering the hereafter: Remember in particular the time you will stand in front of Allah, The Compeller. It is as if remembering the hereafter is a basic requirement one should meet in order to be protected from all trials (the trial of religion as well as that of wealth): **"And (remember) the Day We shall cause the mountains to pass away (like clouds of dust), and you will see the earth as a leveled plain, and we shall gather them all together so as to leave not one of them behind" (TMQ, 18:47**).

   "And they will be set before your Lord in (lines as) rows, (and Allah will say): "Now indeed, you have come to Us as We created you the first time…" (TMQ, 18:48).

   "And the Book (one's Record) will be placed (in the right hand for a believer in the Oneness of Allah, and in the left hand for a disbeliever in the Oneness of Allah), and you will see the *Mujrimun* (criminals, polytheists, sinners), fearful of that which is (recorded) therein. They will say: "Woe to us! What sort of Book is this that leaves neither a small thing nor a big thing, but has recorded it with numbers!" And they will find all that they did, placed before them, and your Lord treats no one with injustice" (TMQ, 18:49).

3- Humility

To be granted protection from the trial of knowledge, one must be humble first to Allah *(SWT)* then in case one is a learner, to the teacher (the example of Musa's relation to Al Khidr). This can be found in ayah 69: **"Musa said (to Al Khidr)** despite the fact that he was one of the favored Prophets of Allah *(SWT)* and the only one to speak with Him directly**: "If Allah wills, you will find me patient, and I will not disobey you in aught." (TMQ, 18:69)**. So beware of arrogance which may stem from the fact that you have high academic degrees, that you have encyclopedic knowledge or that you have learnt the Qur'an by heart . This may keep you from being humble to Allah (*SWT*).

4- Sincerity

The trial of power can be overcome through sincerity and humility to Allah *(SWT)* and by attributing one's power and strength to Him: **"(Dhul-Qarnain) said: "This is a mercy from my Lord…"** (TMQ, 18:98).

The Surah warns those who associate partners with Allah on the one hand and those who are not sincere in their acts of worship *(SWT)* on the other. Allah says what can be translated as : **"Say (O Muhammad): "Shall We tell you the greatest losers in respect of (their) deeds? "Those whose efforts have been wasted in this life while they thought that they were acquiring good by their deeds. "They are those who deny the *Ayat* (proofs, evidence, ayahs, lessons, signs, revelations, etc.) of their Lord and the Meeting with Him (in the Hereafter). So their works are in vain, and on the Day of Resurrection, We shall assign no weight for them" (TMQ, 18:103-105).** This ayah is directed towards the polytheists, it warns them against associating partners with Allah *(SWT)*. It concludes with the instruction for the believers to be sincere in their worship of Allah (*SWT*) alone. The Ayah addresses both categories in a parallel way.

"So whoever hopes for the Meeting with his Lord, let him work righteousness and associate none as a partner in the worship of his Lord" (TMQ, 18:110).

Whoever seeks Allah's full acceptance of his deeds in the hereafter must satisfy to the following conditions : his work in this life must be done correctly in conformity with the *Sunnah* (sayings and deeds of Prophet Muhammad *SAWS*), and must be wholly dedicated to Allah (*SWT*). These two conditions are mentioned in the closing ayah of Surat Al-Kahf.

The magnificence of the surah

Throughout the Surah, we see many comments and brilliant remarks that increase our love and attachment to the Qur'an and to this Surah, and at the same time serve the objective and core idea of the Surah.

A lot of movement and positiveness

It is noticeable that there is a lot of movement in the Surah. All of the stories in the Surah deal with lively people who have constructive plans: ranging from the people of the cave who left their homes and their families and sought refuge in the cave ("…**then seek refuge in the Cave**"), to Prophet Musa' *(AS)* journey to the junction of the two seas until he was worn out (**"truly, we have suffered much fatigue in this, our journey"**). We also see much movement when he accompanied Al-Khidr on his journey: **"So they both proceeded, till, when they embarked the ship, he (Al-Khidr) scuttled it… Then they both proceeded, till they met a boy, and he (Al-Khidr) killed him… Then they both proceeded, till, when they came to the people of a town, they asked them for food…" (TMQ, 18:71-77).**

Movement is also apparent in the story of Dhul-Qarnain: **"So he followed a way" (TMQ, 18:85).** Not only that, but he traveled the earth from east to west: **"Until, when he came to the rising place of the sun...Until, when he reached between two mountains" (TMQ, 18:90-93).** And he directed the people he was helping: **"So help me with strength (of men)" (TMQ, 18:95).** They did not simply stand there and watch him building the barrier, they were asked to assist him for it will make them acquire a certain know-how.

This all goes to prove that we can protect ourselves from trials and temptations by being active and positive and not by giving in and being passive. If a person is harmed or hurt in a particular place or region on earth, he should move to another place for the sake of practicing his religion. It is for this reason that Islam decrees immigration for the sake of preserving one's religion (faith). The Surah hints at this issue through the story of the people of the cave: the latters "immigrated" and sought refuge in the cave.

It is a pleasant matter that this Surah is to be read on Friday which is a holiday for the Muslims. Instead of being idle and lazy on that day, the Muslims should read it and thus learn how to be active and positive because passivity makes them easily a prey to trials and temptations.

The Qur'an and protection from trials and temptations

It is interesting to note that the Surah starts and ends with reference to the the Qur'an because it is a shield against temptation provided that we read it and understand the core ideas and objectives of its Surahs.

"All the praises and thanks be to Allah, Who has sent down to His slave (Muhammad, *SAWS*) the Book (the Qur'an), and has not placed therein any crookedness" (TMQ, 18:1).

"Say (O Muhammad, *SAWS*, to mankind): "If the sea were ink for (writing) the Words of my Lord, surely, the sea would be exhausted before the Words of my Lord would be finished..." (TMQ, 18:109).

In other words, nothing surpasses Allah's *(SWT)* words and actions. The first and foremost helper and protector is His Book: allusions to this truth are made both before and after the four trials and temptations.

Da'wa (missionary activity meaning the Call to Allah) and Protection From Trials and Temptations

Another interesting point in the Surah is the fact that the four stories mentioned in it involve all of the aspects of the Call to Allah *(SWT)* :

Young men calling a king (the people of the cave).
A man calling his companion (the man with the two gardens).
A teacher calling his pupil (Al-Khidr and Prophet Musa (*AS*).
A king calling his people (Dhul-Qarnain).

This carries a very important meaning : the call to Allah *(SWT)* along with one's attachment to the Qur'an act significantly to protect one from trials and temptations.

Believing in the unseen

We notice that the mentioning of the unseen is found in many parts of the stories in the Surah. The story of the people of the cave is full of obscurities: how long they stayed in the cave, the location of the cave, and their number. There is an entire ayah (ayah 22) that evokes the controversy about their number …why?

There is also a certain vagueness about the location of the barrier built by Dhul-Qarnain, and where Ya'juj and Ma'juj will appear, as well as the actions of Al-Khidr and Prophet Musa' *(AS)* questions…why is this so?

It is as if the Surah reminds us that Allah alone knows the unseen, that situations in life appear in a way we don't understand. The Surah hence urges us to have trust in Allah and surrender to Him so that we can be assured protection from temptation *insh'Alla*h (if Allah wills).

The cave of da'wa

There remains one last question: Why is the Surah called Surat Al-Kahf?

By simply hearing the word 'cave', a person may feel afraid, terrified and confused. So when the phrase **"seek refuge in the cave"** is uttered, two things are associated in his mind: darkness and the feeling of fear in such a dark place. However, Allah (*SWT*) makes the cave mentioned in the ayah a safe place and sends down his mercy upon the young men : **"…then seek refuge in the Cave; your Lord will open a way for you from His Mercy" (TMQ, 18:16).**

Allah (*SWT*), who alone knows the unseen, predetermines the course of events in a way Man totally ignores and can never predict as in the case of the young men who sought refuge in the deserted cave and ignored what will happen to them. Surat Al-Kahf (the cave) was called so in order to make Man aware of his ignorance of the unseen and to tell the Muslim : "leave the unseen to Allah and put your trust in Him. Just as the young men sought refuge in the cave and Allah sent down his mercy upon them, do seek refuge in the 'cave of Da'wa (the call to Allah) and surrender your situation to Allah *(SWT)* so that He will spread for you of His mercy and pave the way for you to obtain whatever you like.

Surat Maryam (*AS*) (Mary)

Surat Maryam is Makkan. It was revealed to Prophet Muhammad *(SAWS)* after Surat Fatir and is set in the Holy Qur'an after Surat Al-Kahf. It is composed of 98 Ayahs.

Pomp and glitter of life

Each person would love to have offspring, so when Allah grants him children, his main preoccupation is to secure their living and to provide their needs. In one's youth, one is concerned with: having children, bringing them up, feeding them, educating them, and securing the required medical care whereas in old age he thinks rather about what they will inherit from him.

Loving one's children is in fact an instinct that Allah *(SWT)* instilled in people. Surat Maryam in the Holy Qur'an not only emphasizes this fact but also asks parents the following questions: why do you want to have children? Is it only for self-enjoyment? What will you leave them after your death? Just money and properties?!!!

Bequeathing religion for children

Surat Maryam includes a more elevated reason for having children - protecting religion by leaving it to the following generations to preserve it and to stick to its rules. This is the best legacy for children, much better than material goods which like life itself are bound to disappear. It is as if the Muslim delivers the lantern of religion to his child. The latter, in turn leaves it to the grandchild, and so on. It's not right at all to have a pious generation followed by others who know nothing about religion, even about the superficial issues. Desires and fornication prevail in the society as children are not educated according to the religious rules. All they inherit from their parents is simply money.

The core idea of Surat Maryam thus is children and the question of inheriting religion. This is one of the Surahs where "children" and "inheritance" are frequently mentioned.

'Divine Families'

This Surah refers to people who had children with the intention of leaving them religion as a trust. The Surah mentions: Prophet Zakariya (*AS*) (Zachariah) and his son Yahya (*AS*) (John), Maryam (*AS*) (Mary), Imran's daughter, and her son Isa (*AS*) (Jesus), Ibrahim (*AS*) (Abraham), Isma'il (*AS*) (Ishmael), Ishaq (*AS*) (Isaac), and Yaqub (*AS*) (Jacob). It is as if this Surah addresses all parents and asks them, "Are you keen on raising your children in a way that guarantees their safe arrival to Allah's *(SWT)* path? Are you keen on bequeathing them Allah's *(SWT)* religion and instilling the rules of Islam in them?"

Prophets Zakariya (*AS*) and Yahya (*AS*)

From the outset of the Surah, we realize Prophet Zakariya's (*AS*) wish to have a child. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"*Kaf-Ha-Ya-Ain-Sad*.** [These Arabic letters are one of the miracles of the Qur'an, and none but Allah (Alone) knows their

meanings]. **(This is) a mention of the mercy of your Lord to His slave Zakariya. When he called out his Lord (Allah) a call in secret. He said: "My Lord! Indeed my bones have grown feeble, and gray hair has spread on my head, and I have never been unblessed in my invocation to You, O my Lord! "And verily I fear my relatives after me, and my wife is barren. So give me from Yourself an heir. "Who shall inherit me, and inherit (also) the posterity of Yaqub (Jacob) (inheritance of the religious knowledge and Prophet hood, not of wealth.). And make him, my Lord, one with whom You are Well-Pleased!" (Allah said) "O Zakariya (Zachariah)! Verily, We give you the glad tidings of a son, whose name will be Yahya (John). We have given that name to none before (him)." (TMQ, 19:1-7).**

It is as if Zakariya is saying, "O Allah! I find no one (heir) to shoulder the responsibility of religion. My wife is sterile, and I have no hope to have a child. Yet, I am keen on Your religion".

How wonderful was his jealousy and vigilant care for Allah's *(SWT)* religion. Prophet Zakariya (*AS*) was afraid because Israelites living at his time were unworthy to such a responsibility. Thus, he prayed for Allah *(SWT)* to give him a child to assume that responsibility after him. As he was so honest and faithful in his prayers, Allah (*SWT*) responded in what can be translated as, **"O Zakariya! Verily, We give you the glad tidings of a son, whose name will be Yahya. We have given that name to none before (him)." (TMQ, 19:7).**

How was Yahya (*AS*) raised and educated? Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"O Yahya! Hold fast the Scripture [the Taurat (Torah)]." And We gave him wisdom while yet a child." (TMQ, 19:12).**

Though people's desire to have children and the will to secure their future by all means are a matter of instinct created by Allah (*SWT*), such instinct should be used for the sake of obeying Allah *(SWT)*. Hence, we have to raise our children with the same fear from Allah *(SWT)* and the same care to teach them to obey Allah *(SWT)* and thus hold the flag of His religion.

Maryam (*AS*) and Isa (*AS*)

Maryam's (*AS*) story does not differ from Zakariya's (*AS*). Her mother, Imran's wife, vowed her to Allah (*SWT*), before knowing she would have a baby girl, to free Jerusalem from the Roman invasion. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"O my Lord! I have vowed to You what (the child that) is in my womb to be dedicated for Your services (free from all worldly work; to serve Your Place of worship)". (TMQ, 3:35).**

In Surat Maryam, Maryam bequeathed such a trust to her son. When she approached her people carrying her son Isa (*AS*), Allah (*SWT*) describes this situation saying what can be translated as, **"They said: "How can we talk to one who is a child in the cradle?" (TMQ, 19:29).** They did not know that this boy in the cradle would carry the message of religion and of *Da'wa* (missionary activity). Allah (*SWT*) clarifies this saying in what can be translated as, **"He ['Isa] said: "Verily I am a slave of Allah, He has given me the Scripture and made me a Prophet; "And He has made me**

blessed wheresoever I be, and has enjoined on me *Salat* (prayer), and *Zakat*, as long as I live. "And dutiful to my mother, and made me not arrogant, unblessed (TMQ, 19:30-32).

Children's duty towards their parents

Surat Maryam is one of the Qur'an Surahs that strongly focus on duty towards one's parents. That was indeed Yahya's (*AS*) most important trait. This is clear as Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And dutiful towards his parents" (TMQ, 19:14)**, and so was Isa (*AS*), **"And dutiful to my mother" (TMQ, 19:32)**.

Apparently, a child cannot be dutiful towards his parents unless he is brought up in a good and right environment. Hence, Surat Maryam makes clear to the parents that they have to prepare their children to carrying the trust of religion and defending it. By doing so, they enjoy their children's righteousness and obedience and will be greatly rewarded by Allah *(SWT)* in the hereafter.

Ibrahim (*AS*) and his father

The following Ayahs refer to a completely opposite example: Ibrahim (*AS*) a son who believed in Allah (*SWT*), and who was trying to help his father get to the right path. He was so merciful toward his father that he kept calling him in a loving and tender manner to Allah *(SWT)*. Allah *(SWT)* describes Ibrahim's (*AS*) situation saying what can be translated as, **"O my father! Why do you worship that which hears not, sees not and cannot avail you in anything? "O my father! Verily there has come to me of the knowledge that which came not unto you. So follow me, I will guide you to the Straight Path." (TMQ, 19:42-43).**

Try to learn, our youth, from Ibrahim (*AS*) the good manners in calling to Allah when talking to the elder people, especially your parents. People mostly repel from religion because of ill-mannered youths who are religious, but at the same time do not address people politely. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"O my father! Worship not Shaitan (Satan). Verily Shaitan (Satan) has been a rebel against the Most Gracious (Allah). "O my father! Verily I fear lest a torment from the Most Gracious (Allah) should overtake you, so that you become a companion of Shaitan (Satan) (in the Hell-fire)." (TMQ, 19:44-45).**

Although his father was a disbeliever, Ibrahim (*AS*) treated him so politely and righteously that Allah (*SWT*) granted him his two good sons. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"So when he had turned away from them and from those whom they worshipped besides Allah, We gave him Ishaq and Yaqub, and each one of them We made a Prophet. And We gave them of Our Mercy (a good provision in plenty), and We granted them honor on the tongues (of all the nations, i.e. everybody remembers them with a good praise)." (TMQ, 19:49-50)**. His being righteous and dutiful to his father was the reason of his having two good sons, who were "a delight of the eye" (dear ones) to him, and who shouldered the responsibility of carrying the lantern of religion after him.

Isma'il (*AS*) (He commanded his family to perform the prayers and pay *Zakat* "Alms")

Generations passed one after another, each one delivering the trust of religion to the next one. Ayahs refer to Isma'il (*AS*), and Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And he used to enjoin on his family and his people *As-Salat* (the prayers) and the *Zakat* and his Lord was pleased with him." (TMQ, 19:55).**

It is made clear that each generation delivered the message to the one coming after. The Ayahs refer also to Musa (*AS*) (Moses) and highlight the same meaning, as Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And We granted him his brother Harun (Aaron), (also) a Prophet, out of Our Mercy." (TMQ, 19:53).**

After mentioning all these bright examples, the Ayahs make a wonderful comment so as to praise those who bequeath the lantern of religion to their children. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Those were they unto whom Allah bestowed His Grace from among the Prophets, of the offspring of Adam, and of those whom We carried (in the ship) with Nuh (Noah), and of the offspring of Ibrahim and Israel, and from among those whom We guided and chose. When the Verses of the Most Gracious (Allah) were recited unto them, they fell down prostrate and weeping." (TMQ, 19:58).**

Inheriting the lantern of religion through generations was a rule for all Prophets (May Allah be pleased with them all) since Allah (*SWT*) appointed Adam as successor on earth. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"of the offspring of Adam" (TMQ, 19:58)**. Unfortunately, they were succeeded by generations who cared only for raising their children to fulfill desires and accumulate riches. They did not contemplate Surat Maryam in the Holy Qur'an, and they never considered the importance of bequeathing religion to their children. Thus, their children did not care about praying and followed the path of desire. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Then, there has succeeded them a posterity who have given up *As-Salat* [i.e. made their *Salat* to be lost, either by not offering them or by not offering them perfectly or by not offering them in their proper fixed times] and have followed lusts. So they will be thrown in Hell." (TMQ, 19:59).**

Dear brother in Islam, determine which path you would like to follow together with your family. With whom would you like to be resurrected? is it with those **"whom Allah bestowed His Grace" (TMQ, 16:58)**, or with those **"who have given up *As-Salat* [i.e. made their *Salat* to be lost, either by not offering them or by not offering them perfectly or by not offering them in their proper fixed times] and have followed lusts."? (TMQ, 19:59).**

If you belong to the first category, you will be happy because Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Such is the Paradise which We shall give as an inheritance to those of Our slaves who have been *Al-Muttaqun*" (TMQ, 19:63)**. As the reward is similar to the work done, if your children inherit religion from you, then you will inherit Paradise together with them.

Beware of being one of them

If you belong to the second category, beware of Allah's (*SWT*) warning. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Have you seen him who disbelieved in Our *Ayat***

(this Qur'an and Muhammad *SAWS*) and said: "I shall certainly be given wealth and children [if I will be alive (again)]." (TMQ, 19:77). On the one hand, a child might be a blessing, a good remembrance, and a *Sadaqa* (regular charity) for the parents. On the other hand, he or she might be a reason for the parents' disbelief and disobedience. The Surah emphasizes the same point : one shouldn't wish to become a parent only for its own sake but for the sake of religion as well.

Allah (*SWT*)

The Ayahs then move to another meaning; you people need to have children, but Allah (*SWT*) is never in need for them. The Surah rebukes those who claim that Allah (*SWT*) has a son, be He glorified and exalted. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And they say: "The Most Gracious (Allah) has begotten a son (or offspring or children) [as the Jews say: 'Uzair (Ezra) is the son of Allah, and the Christians say that He has begotten a son ['Isa (Jesus) *AS*], and the pagan Arabs say that He has begotten daughters (angels and others.)]. Indeed you have brought forth (said) a terrible evil thing. Whereby the heavens are almost torn, and the earth is split asunder, and the mountains fall in ruins, that they ascribe a son (or offspring or children) to the Most Gracious (Allah). But it is not suitable for (the Majesty of) the Most Gracious (Allah) that He should beget a son (or offspring or children). There is none in the heavens and the earth but comes unto the Most Gracious (Allah) as a slave. Verily He knows each one of them, and has counted them a full counting. And every one of them will come to Him alone on the Day of Resurrection (without any helper, or protector or defender)." (TMQ, 19:88-95).**

The same Surah refers to people's insistent need for children, yet denies that Allah (*SWT*) needs to have a child, because He *(SWT)* is the Ever Living. People need to have children because they get old and eventually die.

Waves and breezes

The first section in the Surah focuses on man's need to have children and offspring. Thus, the Ayahs were so tender in referring to this, while the endings of the syllables are strong, **"(This is) a mention of the mercy of your Lord to His slave Zakariya. When he called out his Lord (Allah) a call in secret… as a mercy (or a grant) from Us". (TMQ, 19:2-3, 13).**

This Surah is one among many in the Holy Qur'an to refer to the word "mercy" and Allah's *(SWT)* name "the Compassionate". The word "mercy" and its derivatives are mentioned 20 times in this Surah.

As for the second section of the Surah, it denies the claim that Allah (*SWT*) has a son in strong and forceful words. This suits the fabrication made by some people, claiming that Allah (*SWT*) has a son. Hence, the Surah uses both tender and harsh language without changing the cadence of the Surah or the effects it has on the reader, which proves the miraculous nature of the Holy Qur'an.

Why was the Surah named Maryam?

This Surah mentions a number of people who delivered the lantern of religion to their children (Ibrahim, Zakariya, and Isma'il), so why was it called Maryam?

Because the mother is the real person who is able to deliver religion to her children, she is the one who raises the children and fosters them, until they grow and become mature. Thus, the Surah was named after Lady Maryam, because of the importance of the woman's role, and because Lady Maryam was an excellent model for a woman who successfully delivered the message of religion to her son after inheriting it from her family.

Surat Ta-Ha

Surat Ta-Ha is Makkan. It comes after Surat Maryam both in the order of revelation and the order of the Holy Qur'an. It is composed of 135 Ayahs.

We have not sent down the Qur'an unto you (O Muhammad) to cause you distress

The objective of this Surah is clear from the first Ayah, as Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Ta-Ha. We have not sent down the Qur'an unto you (O Muhammad *SAWS*) to cause you distress". (TMQ, 20:1-2).**

This means that Allah's *(SWT)* religion and way are never meant to cause people to suffer; it is rather the way of happiness. There can be no distress with Islam despite all the difficult circumstances and obstacles facing religious and pious people. Yet, man suffers only when he deviates away from the right path of Allah *(SWT)*, as Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"We have not sent down the Qur'an unto you (O Muhammad *SAWS*) to cause you distress" (TMQ, 20:2).**

Youth who are not religious, or who want to be so but fear that this will bring them unhappiness if they follow Allah's *(SWT)* right path, can benefit from this Surah more than anybody else. Most of them think that following the right way of Allah *(SWT)* will cause them depression and will deprive them of the pleasures of life and means of entertainment. This is a completely wrong concept: the Surah highlights the fact that Islam is the source of real happiness and shows that those who get away from it will suffer in life and in the hereafter. What a wonderful meaning! How can this Surah stress it? Let's go through the Ayahs from the very beginning.

How can you suffer while being with Allah the Compassionate?

The Surah starts with a remarkable introduction that attracts hearts, as Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Ta-Ha. We have not sent down the Qur'an unto you (O Muhammad *SAWS*) to cause you distress but only as a Reminder to those who fear (Allah)." (TMQ, 20:1-3).** The Holy Qur'an will never be the source of misery for you Muslims; it will rather act as a reminder which will lead you to happiness. Allah *(SWT)* says can be translated as, **"A revelation from Him (Allah) Who has created the earth and high heavens. The Most Gracious (Allah) rose over (Istawa) the (Mighty) Throne (in a manner that suits His Majesty)." (TMQ, 20:4-5).** Who sent this method for us? Of course, Allah the Compassionate did. Allah's (*SWT*) best name the Compassionate was mentioned directly after the reference to suffering so that people would know that the religion of Allah the Compassionate can never be the cause of suffering. How can man suffer due to the method set by Allah (*SWT*) who owns all the best names (attributes)? Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Allah! La ilaha illa Huwa (none has the right to be worshipped but He)! To Him belong the Best Names." (TMQ, 20:8)**

Musa (*AS*) being happy with Allah's *(SWT)* method

The Surah then gives an example that we all know well: Prophet Musa (*AS*). Allusion is made to stress the hardships he endured while he was performing Da'wa (the call to Allah) thanks to the care and support of Allah (*SWT*).

The Surah conveys the message that even though the Qur'an is a method of happiness and rest, life will not be in smooth waters all the time without any problems or sorrows. Life is rather full of complications and difficulties, especially if you are a believer who carries the message of Allah *(SWT)* and calls for it. Nevertheless, such difficulties do not cause suffering (suffering in this context means sadness, depression, sorrow, or distress), because a believer is always connected to Allah (*SWT*) and seeking continuously his help and support. Accordingly, a believer is always satisfied and reassured.

Illuminating words

The story of Musa *(SAWS)* stresses the mercy and compassion of Allah (*SWT*) that mark the fact of experiencing difficulties in one's life. The way the story is narrated in this Surah and the choice of words are totally different from those used to present other events in Musa's life elsewhere in the Holy Qur'an. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"When he saw a fire, he said to his family: "Wait! Verily, I have seen a fire; perhaps I can bring you some burning brand there from, or find some guidance at the fire." (TMQ, 20:10)**.

The Ayahs starts with a friendly question in order to support Musa (AS) in the hard mission and lighten the burden that he carried. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And what is that in your right hand, O Musa?" (TMQ, 20:17).**

When Prophet Musa (*AS*) prayed for Allah (*SWT*), he asked according to what he knew about Allah's *(SWT)* methodology: happiness, tranquility and facilitation. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"[Musa] said: "O my Lord! Open for me my chest (grant me self-confidence, contentment, and boldness)."And ease my task for me; "And loose the knot (the defect) from my tongue, (i.e. remove the incorrectness from my speech)" (TMQ, 20:25-27).** The Ayahs hence continue to address him gently and compassionately. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as: **"Allah said: "Grasp it and fear not; We shall return it to its former state" (TMQ, 20:21); "(Allah) said: "You are granted your request, O Musa!" (TMQ, 20:36); "And indeed We conferred a favor on you another time (before)." (TMQ, 20:37); "And I endued you with love from Me, in order that you may be brought up under My Eye" (TMQ, 20:39).**

Do you see how many times the words "fear not" were repeated? It serves as a proof for the victory Allah *(SWT)* grants for believers. This is the result of the trust Musa's (*AS*) mother had in Allah *(SWT)*, and her obedience to Allah (*SWT*) when He commanded her to throw her baby boy into the river. It is also a compensation for Musa (*AS*) who was then thrown as a baby in a dark box (ark). Musa's *(AS)* mother exerted herself and got tired in resisting to her human weakness. In turn, Musa (*AS*) got tired of his confrontation with Fi*raawn* (the Pharaoh). Yet, Allah *(SWT)* wonderfully reassured them. This is the situation of believers; despite the afflictions they may experience, they are always satisfied and reassured.

Such questions are to be asked: why do we put barriers between us and religiousness? Why do we fear being religious, although it is our path towards happiness?

Blessings of divine care

The Holy Qur'an was very tender with Prophet Muhammad (*SAWS*). Allah *(SWT)* provided him with many of the things that He provided Prophet Musa *(AS)* with. For example, Allah *(SWT)* mentions Prophet Musa's (*AS*) prayer in the Holy Qur'an, and says what can be translated as, **"O my Lord! Open for me my chest (grant me self-confidence, contentment, and boldness)" (TMQ, 20:25)**, while He (*SWT*) addressed Prophet Muhammad (*SAWS*) saying what can be translated as, **"Have We not opened your breast for you (O Muhammad *SAWS*)?" (TMQ, 94:1)**; Allah (*SWT*) said to Prophet Musa (*AS*) what can be translated as, **"in order that you may be brought up under My Eye" (TMQ, 20:39),** while He (*SWT*) said to Prophet Muhammad *(SAWS)* the same that can be translated as, **"So wait patiently (O Muhammad *SAWS*) for the Decision of your Lord, for verily, you are under Our Eyes" (TMQ, 52:48)**. It is as if those Ayahs which are closely related to each other make clear that everything has been complete for Prophet Muhammad (*SAWS*).

Magicians tasted happiness

Although the Pharaoh in Musa's *(AS)* story strongly harmed the magicians who believed in Allah *(SWT)*, they never felt misery. The Pharaoh threatened them, and Allah (*SWT*) describes this saying in what can be translated as **"[Fir'aun (Pharaoh)] said: "Believe you in him [Musa] before I give you permission? Verily he is your chief who has taught you magic. So I will surely cut off your hands and feet on opposite sides, and I will surely crucify you on the trunks of date-palms, and you shall surely know which of us [I (Fir'aun - Pharaoh) or the Lord of Musa (Allah)] can give the severe and more lasting torment."" (TMQ, 20:71)**. Allah (*SWT*) mentions their answer in what can be translated as, **"Verily we have believed in our Lord, that He may forgive us our faults, and the magic to which you did compel us. And Allah is better as regards reward in comparison to your [Fir'aun's (Pharaoh)] reward, and more lasting (as regards punishment in comparison to your punishment)." (TMQ, 20:73)**. How beautiful are those words when said by people who have just announced their belief in Allah *(SWT)*, thus clarifying who is miserable and who is happy. Allah *(SWT)* confirms this saying in what can be translated as, **"Verily whoever comes to his Lord as a Mujrim (criminal, polytheist, sinner, disbeliever in the Oneness of Allah and His Messengers), then surely, for him is Hell, wherein he will neither die nor live. But whoever comes to Him (Allah) as a believer (in the Oneness of Allah), and has done righteous good deeds, for such are the high ranks (in the Hereafter), 'Adn (Eden) Paradise (everlasting Gardens), under which rivers flow, wherein they will abide forever: such is the reward of those who purify themselves (by abstaining from all kinds of sins and evil deeds which Allah has forbidden and by doing all that Allah has ordained)." (TMQ, 20:74-76).**

It is an overwhelming happiness, springing from the hereafter and reaching our lives in this world. Believers feel strong enough to face the oppressors and tyrants on earth without any fear, simply because they know the taste of real happiness.

Misery away from Allah's *(SWT)* method

The same story reflects the opposite side, which is As-Samery, who misled the Israelites and deluded them into worshipping the golden calf. The last Ayah in Musa's *(AS)* story describes the misery of As-Samery, as Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translates as **"Musa said: "Then go away! And verily, your (punishment) in this life will be that you will say: "Touch me not (i.e. you will live alone exiled away from mankind); and verily (for a future torment), you have a promise that will not fail." (TMQ, 20:97).**

This story is followed by some ayahs that comment on it and clarify the main objective of the Surah : real happiness lies in following the path of religion, while misery is in keeping away from it. Allah (*SWT*) describes this saying in what can be translated as, **"Thus We relate to you (O Muhammad *SAWS*) some information of what happened before. And indeed We have given you from Us a Reminder (this Qur'an). Whoever turns away from it (this Qur'an - i.e. does not believe in it, nor acts on its orders), verily, they will bear a heavy burden (of sins) on the Day of Resurrection, They will abide in that (state in the Fire of Hell) - and evil indeed will it be that load for them on the Day of Resurrection" (TMQ, 20:99-101).** Allah (*SWT*) comments on the happiness and misery of people in the hereafter saying what can be translated as, **"And (all) faces shall be humbled before (Allah), Al-Hayyul-Qayyum (the Ever Living, the One Who sustains and protects all that exists). And he who carried (a burden of) wrongdoing (i.e. he who disbelieved in Allah, ascribed partners to Him, and did deeds of His disobedience) will be indeed a complete failure (on that Day). And he who works deeds of righteousness, while he is a believer (in Islamic Monotheism), then he will have no fear of injustice, nor of any curtailment (of his reward)." (TMQ, 20:111-112).**

Prophet Adam and happiness

When the Surah reaches the story of Prophet Adam (*AS*), it focuses through it on the objective of the Surah. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Then We said: "O Adam! Verily, this is an enemy to you and to your wife. So let him not get you both out of Paradise, so that you will be distressed." (TMQ, 20:117).** Hence, abandoning the methodology set by Allah (*SWT*) and following the path of *Iblis* (Satan) are the main reasons for one's misery in the hereafter. Accordingly, the ayahs go on depicting the various forms of happiness found in *Jannah* (Paradise), and Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Verily, you have (a promise from Us) that you will never be hungry therein nor naked. And you (will) suffer not from thirst therein nor from the sun's heat." (TMQ, 20:118-119).** This rule applies to Adam *(AS)* and his offspring, even after he had got out of *Jannah* (Paradise), as Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"He (Allah) said: "Get you down (from the Paradise to the earth), both of you, together, some of you are an enemy to some others. Then if there comes to you guidance from Me, then whoever follows My Guidance he shall neither go astray, nor shall be distressed." (TMQ, 20:123).**

Real misery

The word "distress" and its derivatives have been mentioned three times in this Surah, as Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as: **"We have not sent down the Qur'an**

unto you (O Muhammad *SAWS*) to cause you distress" (TMQ, 20:2); "So let him not get you both out of Paradise, so that you will be distressed." (TMQ, 20:117); "whoever follows My Guidance he shall neither go astray, nor shall be distressed." (TMQ, 20:123). The aim of this is that no one should be afraid of being religious or of following the path of Allah *SWT)*, as real happiness lies in the full adherence to the religion of Allah *(SWT)*. As for those who repel from this methodology, the following ayahs describe in quite a horrible way their misery both in this life and in the hereafter. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"But whosoever turns away from My Reminder (i.e. neither believes in this Qur'an nor acts on its teachings.) Verily, for him is a life of hardship,"** in this life. Allah describes their misery in the hereafter in what can be translated as, **"We shall raise him up blind on the Day of Resurrection. He will say: "O my Lord! Why have you raised me up blind, while I had sight (before)." (Allah) will say: "Like this: Our Ayat (proofs, evidence, verses, lessons, signs, revelations, etc.) came unto you, but you disregarded them (i.e. you left them, did not think deeply in them, and you turned away from them), and so this Day, you will be neglected (in the Hell-fire, away from Allah's Mercy)." And thus do We requite him who transgresses beyond bounds [i.e. commits the great sins and disobeys his Lord (Allah) and believes not in His Messengers, and His revealed Books, like this Qur'an], and believes not in the Ayat (proofs, evidence, verses, lessons, signs, revelations, etc.) of his Lord; and the torment of the Hereafter is far more severe and more lasting." (TMQ, 20:124-127).**

Highest levels of happiness

The highest level of happiness is to be satisfied with yourself, with your life, and Allah *(SWT)*, and to feel that He (*SWT*) is satisfied with you. This is highlighted at the end of the Surah, where Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"So bear patiently (O Muhammad SAWS) what they say, and glorify the praises of your Lord before the rising of the sun, and before its setting, and during some hours of the night, and at the ends of the day (an indication for the five compulsory congregational prayers)" (TMQ, 20:130)**. Where does all this lead to? Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, "t**hat you may become pleased (with the reward which Allah shall give you)." (TMQ, 20:130).**

Glorifying, mentioning and obeying Allah *(SWT)* represent the only way to reach the highest level of happiness, which is satisfaction. In fact, happiness is nothing but satisfaction, a feeling of which many are deprived in spite of all the desires and pleasures they attain in life. They were deprived of satisfaction, a blessing that the believer obtains by glorifying Allah *(SWT)* and obeying Him (*SWT*).

For all those who seek happiness, for those youth who committed forbidden deeds in search of happiness but gained nothing, please read Surat Ta-Ha, where Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Ta-Ha. We have not sent down the Qur'an unto you (O Muhammad *SAWS*) to cause you distress" (TMQ, 20:1-2).**

Surat Al-Anbiya (The Prophets)

Surat Al-Anbiya is Makkan. It was revealed to Prophet Muhammad *(SAWS)* after Surat Ibrahim, and is set in the Holy Qur'an after Surat Ta-Ha. It is composed of 112 Ayahs.

The role of Prophets in reminding humanity

The Surah deals with the stories of Prophets (May Allah be pleased with them all) that Allah (*SWT*) sent to humanity, and their role in reminding people. Those Prophets (May Allah be pleased with them all) are the best creatures Allah (*SWT*) created; they guided the world to righteousness and happiness. Surat Al-Anbiya moves in the same pattern, it shows the message of each Prophet (May Allah be pleased with them all) and how each of them called his people to the right path of Allah *(*SWT), how he worshiped Allah (*SWT*) and prayed for Him humbly. Finally, the Surah proves, as we will see, the unity of all Prophets' missions (May Allah be pleased with them all).

The danger of unawareness

The very first mission of Prophets (May Allah be pleased with them all) is to awaken people from their unawareness, because it has always been the cause of misleading people over ages and everywhere, and the causes of the rejection of all the previous Prophets' (May Allah be pleased with them all) messages. It is such a dangerous illness that infects people and societies, taking them away from Allah *(SWT).*

People are either pious worshipers of Allah *(SWT)*, or dissolute disobedient ones, but the real danger lies in the intermediate type, those unaware, careless people who are away from obeying Allah (*SWT*). Therefore, the Surah starts by a tough warning from this disease and its symptoms through three successive ayahs, where Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Draws near for mankind their reckoning, while they turn away in heedlessness. Comes not unto them an admonition (a chapter of the Qur'an) from their Lord as a recent revelation but they listen to it while they play. With their hearts occupied (with evil things). Those who do wrong conceal their private counsels, (saying): "Is this (Muhammad SAWS) more than a human being like you? Will you submit to magic while you see it?"" (TMQ, 21:1-3).**

(While they turn away in heedlessness… while they play… With their hearts occupied)

The model in worship and attitude

One of the most important objectives of the Surah is to ask you, my brother in Islam, the following question, "Who is the model in your life?" and if we ask most of the contemporary youth this question, how many of them will answer that Prophet Ibrahim (*AS*) is their model? How many will say that Prophet Yusuf (*AS*) is? How many will mention Prophet Muhammad (*SAWS*)? How many of them will mention singers or actors? How many will say they have no model at all?

Thus, Surat Al-Anbiya focuses on this meaning, and highlights two bright sides in each Prophet's (May Allah be pleased with them all) life: on the one hand, his worshiping, obedience and fear of Allah (*SWT*), and on the other hand, his call to Allah and his role as a reformer. The Surah wants to tell you, "These are the models you should follow in so far as your relation to Allah *(SWT)* and to people are concerned, i.e. in worshiping and in Da'wa (missionary activity).

Unity of vocabulary in supplication and responding

The Surah includes a lot of ayahs which describe supplications of the Prophets (May Allah be pleased with them all), and show how Allah (*SWT*) responded to them. For example, Allah *(SWT)* mentions Prophet Nuh's (AS) supplication as what can be translated as, "**And (remember) Nuh, when he cried (to Us) aforetime." (TMQ, 21:76);** Ayyub's (*AS*) supplication is mentioned by Allah (*SWT*) as what can be translated as, **"And (remember) Ayyub, when he cried to his Lord" (TMQ, 21:83);** Yunus (*AS*) prayed to Allah (*SWT*) when he was in the inside the belly the whale, and Allah (*SWT*) describes his prayer as what can be translated as, **"But he cried through the darkness" (TMQ, 21:87)**; and Zakariya's (*AS*) supplication is mentioned by Allah (*SWT*) as what can be translated as, **"when he cried to his Lord: "O My Lord! Leave me not single (childless)" (TMQ, 21:89)**.

This impressive atmosphere of the Prophets' (May Allah be pleased with them all) communion with Allah *(SWT)* was followed by one word, the same word in responding to all the Prophets (May Allah be pleased with them all), "**So We"(TMQ, 21:88 and TMQ, 21:90).** Note that the Holy Qur'an uses the Arabic letter 'fa' meaning 'and' but translated in this context 'so' used with the verb 'to respond' on purpose to show Allah's *(SWT)* quick response to the Prophets' (May Allah be pleased with them all) prayers.

And thus we do deliver the believers

We have to stop for a while at the prayer and supplication of Prophet Yunus (*AS*). Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as **"So We answered his call, and delivered him from the distress. And thus We do deliver the believers (who believe in the Oneness of Allah, abstain from evil and work righteousness)." (TMQ, 21:88)**. The Ayah does not only refer to Allah's *(SWT)* response to his prayer, but to Allah's *(SWT)* response to the prayers of all believers as well, **"And thus We do deliver the believers" (TMQ, 21:88)**.

Dear Muslim brother, pray to Allah *(SWT)* in a way similar to the faithfulness and sincerity of the Prophets (May Allah be pleased with them all), and Allah *(SWT)* will respond to you immediately if He wills.

An integral whole

The unity of vocabulary in the prayers and supplications of Prophets (May Allah be pleased with them all) proves the unity of their missions and the fact that they are complementary to one another. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Truly! This, your Ummah [Shari'a or religion (Islamic Monotheism)] is one religion, and I am your Lord, therefore worship Me (Alone)." (TMQ, 21:92)**. All Prophets

(*AS*) belong to the same nation, and every Prophet (May Allah be pleased with them all) had a role in setting the bases of religion, until Prophet Muhammad (*SAWS*), the last Prophet, came to complete that huge building . Prophet Muhammad (*SAWS*) has said an expressive Hadith to highlight this meaning, "The similitude of mine and that of the Apostles (before me) is that of a person who constructed a building and he built it fine and well and the people went round it saying: Never have we seen a building more imposing than this, but for one brick, and I am that brick (with which you give the finishing touch to the building)."

This is why the Surah focuses on the fact that each Prophet (May Allah be pleased with them all) was sent for his own people, whereas Prophet Muhammad (*SAWS*) was sent to all mankind , Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as **"And We have sent you (O Muhammad SAWS): not but as a mercy for the 'alamin' (mankind, jinn and all that exists)." (TMQ, 21:107)**. Thus, Prophet Muhammad (*SAWS*) was sent not only to all humanity, but also to other worlds like that of Jinn.

Why don't we take him (*SAWS*) as a model? Why do you insist on not following him, although he was sent as a mercy from Allah *(SWT)* to the entire world?

Dramatic ending

As the Surah starts with the serious impact of unawareness, its closing Ayahs are very strong so as to awaken the hearts from this illness. It is as if the Surah says, "If you do not take those Prophets (May Allah be pleased with them all) as an example, you will all get back to Allah (*SWT*) on a hard day, as Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as **"when We shall roll up the heaven like a scroll rolled up for books" (TMQ, 21:104)**. Try to imagine that horrible day, and the sound of Heaven when being folded like a book. Allah (*SWT*) confirms this saying in what can be translated as **"As We began the first creation, We shall repeat it. (It is) a promise binding upon Us. Truly, We shall do it." (TMQ, 21:104).**

The earth is theirs

Those who follow the steps of the Prophets (*AS*) are the real victorious ones in this life and the winners in the hereafter. Hence, the strong Ayahs describing doomsday are followed by what Allah (*SWT*) says and can be translated as **"And indeed We have written in Az-Zabur [i.e. all the revealed Holy Books - the Taurat (Torah), the Injeel (Gospel), the Psalms, the Qur'an,] after (We have already written in) Al-Lauh Al-Mahfuz (the Book that is in the heaven with Allah), that My righteous slaves shall inherit the land (i.e. the land of Paradise)." (TMQ, 21:105)**. Those Ayahs want to say to the Prophets' (May Allah be pleased with them all) followers, "Follow the example of Prophets (May Allah be pleased with them all) so as to inherit the earth". The next Ayah describes the act of taking the Prophets (AS) as models: by worshiping Allah (*SWT*) as the Prophets (*AS*) did, Allah (*SWT*) will reward one with inheritance of the earth. Allah (*SWT*) describes this saying what can be translated as **"Verily, in this (the Qur'an) there is a plain Message for people who worship Allah (i.e. the true, real believers of Islamic Monotheism who act practically on the Qur'an and the Sunnah - legal ways of the Prophet *SAWS*)." (TMQ, 21:106)**.

After delivering a lot of messages clarifying Allah's *(SWT)* methodology, Surat Al-Anbiya invites you, the reader of the Qur'an, to follow the Prophets (*AS*), especially Prophet Muhammad (*SAWS*), in the way they worshipped Allah (*SWT*), in their devotion to religion, in their defense of it and in the efforts they made to spread it all over the world. You will be worthy of the inheritance of the earth according to the methodology that Allah (*SWT*) has set and will be righteous. Allah *(SWT)* confirms this saying in what can be translated as **"that My righteous slaves shall inherit the land (i.e. the land of Paradise)." (TMQ, 21:105).**

Surat Al-Hajj (The Pilgrimage)

Surat Al-Hajj is Madinan, yet, some parts of it are Makkan. It follows Surat An-Nur in the order of revelation, and Surat Al-Anbiya in the order of the Qur'an. It consists of 78 Ayahs.

One of the marvelous Surahs of the Qur'an

Why? Because some of its Ayahs were revealed in Makkah and some in Madinah; some were sent down at night and some during day time; some were sent down in the city and some while traveling. Not only that, but the Surah also has other distinctive features; it is the only Surah named after one of the pillars of Islam. Thus, the importance of Hajj arises, as it is evident that the main focus of this Surah is that vital pillar of Islam.

Pilgrimage is the key word

If we read Surat Al-Hajj from the very beginning, we will find that it tackles the issue of the Day of Judgment. From the first Ayah, focus is made on the Day of Judgment and resurrection. The Ayahs then move to *Jihad* (fighting in the cause of Allah (*SWT)*), and then worship and servitude to Allah *(SWT)*, as all creatures in sky and on earth prostrate themselves to Allah *(SWT)*. However, what is the relationship between all of these issues? How are they related to pilgrimage?

When a Muslim performs this major form of worship or when he lives with his soul with pilgrims and imagines to be one of them, he understands well Allah's *(SWT)* intention from this Surah. Pilgrimage is a worship that plays a vital role in setting up the strong bases of the nation. It is as if the Surah is telling the readers to perform Hajj in a right way, just as Prophet Muhammad *(SAWS*) did, in order to train themselves and thus become used to living according to social and moral principles. Such principles basically guide the nation as a whole including both individuals and social groups.

A practical reminder

The Surah starts with reminding people of the Day of Judgment in a tough way. In the first Ayah, Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"O mankind! Fear your Lord and be dutiful to Him! Verily, the earthquake of the Hour (of Judgment) is a terrible thing" (TMQ,, 22: 1).** What is the relationship between Hajj and the Day of Judgment?

Most of the rituals of Hajj remind us of the Day of Judgment. In fact I would like to ask the reader, even if he has not the opportunity yet to perform Hajj, to visualize the moments of Hajj: descending Arafat Mountain, going to Mozdalifa in order to throw the stones while it is too hot, too crowded, and we have to wait for a very long time. Everyone prays to Allah *(SWT)* submissively, saying "Here we are Allah, at your service; here we are." The simple white clothes of Hajj remind one of the winding sheets in which the dead are shrouded. All this reminds one of one's nakedness on the Day of Judgment, along with the crowdedness, hot sun and sweat overwhelming people on that day.

Hajj and the scenes of the Day of Judgment

The Ayahs start afterwards to depict the horrors of that day, so you can feel as if you see them in front of your eyes: **"The Day you shall see it, every nursing mother will forget her nursling, and every pregnant one will drop her load, and you shall see mankind as in a drunken state, yet they will not be drunken, but severe will be the Torment of Allah" (TMQ, 22: 2).**

The Ayahs then shift to resurrection and the scene of people getting out of their graves, with dust covering their faces and bodies. Hence, the Ayah reminds us that all people were originally created from dust. **"O mankind! If you are in doubt about the Resurrection, then verily We have created you (i.e. Adam) from dust…" (TMQ, 22: 5).**

After two days of wearing the Hajj clothes, you become covered with dust from tip to toe. What is more important is when you perform the Hajj exactly as the Prophet *(SAWS)* did. If you decide to spend your night at Mozdalifa, you see most of the people extremely tired, as if they are dead. At dawn people rush out of their place of residence as if they are rising from graves; all of them are wearing white clothes and move towards the place where the ritual of the throwing of stones can be performed. Therefore, the Ayah comes as a reminder of resurrection, as Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And surely, the Hour is coming, there is no doubt about it; and certainly, Allah will resurrect those who are in the graves"** (TMQ, 22: 7).

Thus, we see the first result of Hajj in educating Ummah (Islamic nation) preparing muslims them for the Day of Judgment, through the experience they live while performing Hajj rituals.

Hajj rituals: the utmost obedience to Allah *(SWT)*:

The Ayahs 26-37 mention the various Hajj rituals, the until reaching the central Ayah comes which can be translated as**, "and whosoever honors the Symbols of Allah, then it is truly from the piety of the hearts" (TMQ, 22: 32).**

What is the Divine wisdom behind these great rituals?

During Hajj, you should carry out strict and specific directives imposed by Allah (*SWT*) otherwise your hajj is spoilt. A Muslim circumambulates seven times around a stone; goes to and fro seven times between two stones; and throws stones on a place full of stones. He/She performs many rituals may be without knowing the real wisdom lying behind, yet he/she only performs them in obedience to Allah's *(SWT)* orders. This is the utmost form of obedience to Allah *(SWT).* The Muslim is also prepared through such rituals to another religious duty in Islam: *Jihad* (fight for the cause of Allah).

***Hajj* and *Jihad*:**

The Ayahs about Jihad come immediately after those talking about Hajj. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Truly, Allah defends those who believe" (TMQ,**

Al-Hajj: 38), and says what can be translated as, "Permission to fight (against disbelievers) is given to those (believers) who are fought against, because they have been wronged; and surely, Allah is Able to give them (believers) victory"(TMQ, 22: 39).

It is as if Hajj is a practical exercise preparing for Jihad. In fact, it is a tiresome act: The pilgrim like the Mujahid (fighter in the cause of Allah) keeps moving from a ritual to another, from a place to another without rest. In short, Hajj is one of the most sublime forms of worship, where the Muslim abandons most of his/her habits so as to accustom himself/herself to seriousness and to overcoming hardships.

Hajj and submissiveness to Allah (*SWT)*:

The wonder of Hajj is that it makes you feel that the whole universe is in total submission to Allah *(SWT).* On the day of Arafa, you feel that you are not the only one who prostrates to Allah *(SWT)* and prays to Him; but the tent, the mountain, and the whole universe are doing so. You, a helpless human, in turn, join these creatures in their submissiveness to Allah *(SWT).* This is evident in Ayah 18, in which Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"See you not that whoever is in the heavens and whoever is on the earth, and the sun, and the moon, and the stars, and the mountains, and the trees, and *Ad-Dawabb* [moving (living) creatures, beasts], and many of mankind prostrate themselves to Allah. But there are many (men) on whom the punishment is justified. And whomsoever Allah disgraces, none can honor him. Verily, Allah does what He wills"(TMQ, 22: 18).**

The ummah's (Nation's) life between two prostrations:

It is worth mentioning that the first Surah revealed to the Prophet's *(SAWS)* at the beginning of his mission, to contain an ayah which demands prostration is Surat Al-Alaq in which Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Nay! (O Muhammad)! Do not obey him (Abu Jahl). Fall prostrate and draw near to Allah!"(TMQ, 96:19),** whereas the last Surah in which there is an Ayah which demands prostration is Surat Al-Hajj, which was revealed in the last days of the Mission, and in which Allah (*SWT)* says what can be translated as: **"O you who have believed! Bow down, and prostrate yourselves, and worship your Lord and do good that you may be successful" (TMQ, 22: 77).**

The difference between the two Ayahs and the two prostrations shows the great shift in the nation's life, from the first order of prostration which was directed only to the Prophet *(SAWS)* in Surat Al-Alaq, to the last order of prostration which was directed to the whole nation in Surat Al-Hajj. It is a typical shift in a short period of time, from the Prophet *(SAWS)* alone in Hira' cave to an entire nation of worshipers and fighters.

Could you please intend Hajj, this great duty or at least intend Umrah, so as to train yourself on the values mentioned in this Surah?. You can also read Surat Al-Hajj with the intention of learning from the lessons of Hajj and the inherent meanings, even if the chance of performing Hajj has not occurred to you yet.

Surat Al-Mu'minun (The Believers)

Surat Al-Mu'minun is Makkan. It follows Surat Al-Anbiya' in the order of revelation, and Surat Al-Hajj in the order of the Holy Book. It consists of 118 Ayahs.

How far do their traits apply to you?

This Surah mentions the most important traits of the believers, and displays in comparison the traits of the disbelievers. It is as if the Surah asks the reader of the Qur'an "How far do the traits of those believers apply to you?" It also draws your attention to a very important meaning, namely the fact that these traits include both manners and worship; the first trait is related to worship, and the next one is related to manners, and so on. Therefore, I invite you to test and evaluate yourself according to these traits by giving scores about your answers for the questions you will be asked.

Faith test

The Surah begins with what can be translated as**, "Successful indeed are the believers" (TMQ,: 23: 1).** Who are they? How can we be among them? Let's try to answer the questions:

"Those who offer their prayers with all solemnity and full submissiveness" (TMQ,: 23: 2). How do you perform your prayers? Do you concentrate while praying? How much score do you give to yourself for this question?

"And those who turn away from dirty, false, evil vain talk, falsehood, and all that Allah has forbidden" (TMQ,: 23: 3). Do you talk in an ill way about other Muslims? Do you move among people with words that cause problems and hatred? Do you hold your tongue from gossiping and useless speech? Do you abstain from attending assemblies where people talk badly about each other?

"And those who guard their chastity" (TMQ,: 23: 5). How much are you preserving your sight from mischievous looks? How are chastity and abstaining from the way that leads to adultery apply to you?

"Those who are faithfully true to their *Amanat* (all the duties which Allah has ordained, honesty, moral responsibility and trusts) and to their covenants" (TMQ,: 23: 8). How much do you cling to honesty, whether in minor issues, such as the tape or the book you borrowed from your friend, or in the responsibility of spreading religion among people?

"And those who strictly guard their (five compulsory congregational) prayers (at their fixed stated hours)" (TMQ,: 23: 9). Do you pray regularly on time? Are you keen on praying in groups? How much score do you give yourself on keeping prayers?

If you've succeeded the test, I congratulate you

If such traits apply to you with a high percentage, then you should be happy, for Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"These are indeed the inheritors; Who shall**

inherit the Firdaus (Paradise). They shall dwell therein forever (TMQ,: 23: 10-11). Congratulations – you have won a divine prize, in addition to a divine declaration that enables you to inherit the earth in this life, and enjoy Heaven in the Hereafter.

History of believers – fate of disbelievers

The Ayahs shift to the history of the believers on earth, mentioning the stories of the Prophets, and focusing on the fact that every generation of Prophets inherits the trait of believing in Allah *(SWT).* Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Then, after them, We created another generation" (TMQ,: 23: 31), "Then, after them, We created other generations" (TMQ,: 23: 42).**

The fate of disbelievers is referred to between these two Ayahs, as if the two Ayahs tell the believers who have done the test before, "Stick to the road of faith; never abandon prayers, so that you would not face the same destiny of disbelievers". Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"So *As-Saihah* (torment - awful cry) overtook them in truth (with justice), and We made them as rubbish of dead plants. So away with the people who are *Zalimun* (polytheists, wrong-doers, disbelievers in the Oneness of Allah, disobedient to His Messengers)" (TMQ, 23: 41). "Then We sent Our Messengers in succession. Every time there came to a nation their Messenger, they denied him; so We made them follow one another (to destruction), and We made them as *Ahadith* (the true stories for mankind to learn a lesson from them). So away with a people who believe not!" (TMQ, 23: 44).**

Do you see how can the deviation from the road of faith lead to damnation?

Better and nobler traits

The Ayahs mention afterwards some other traits of the believers, which are considered as being higher in level than the previous ones. Let's read together ayahs 56 and 57.

Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as**, "Verily those who live in awe for fear of their Lord" (TMQ, 23: 57).** At the beginning of the Surah, submissiveness was required while praying. In this situation, however, there is a higher level of worshipping: to be filled with fear of Allah *(SWT)* in every moment of your life, and while doing any thing.

Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And those who believe in the *Ayat* (proofs, evidence, verses, lessons, signs, revelations, etc.) of their Lord; And those who join not anyone (in worship) as partners with their Lord" (TMQ, 23: 58-59).** They do not seek the satisfaction of anyone but Allah *(SWT)* in their worship, whether by 'greater' polytheism (believing in a god other than Allah (*SWT*), or 'smaller' polytheism (hypocrisy in worship). You should seek nothing but only the reward and recompense from Allah *(SWT).*

Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And those who give that (their charity) which they give (and also do other good deeds) with their hearts full of fear (whether their alms and charities have been accepted or not), because they**

are sure to return to their Lord (for reckoning)" (TMQ, 23: 60).

These are the most apparent of the believers' traits: worshiping Allah *(SWT)*, carrying out His orders, and then fearing Him. Why? Lest the work (deeds) would be declined. Lady Aisha *(AS)* (Prophet Muhammad's wife) asked the Prophet *(SAWS)* about the previously mentioned Ayah; she said, "Are these who drink alcoholic drinks and steal?" Allah's Messenger replied: "No! O the daughter of As-Siddiq, but they are those who fast, pray, and practice charity and they are afraid that (their good) deeds may not be accepted (by Allah) from them."[8]

A Divine testimony

Having all those traits, the believers deserve another divine testimony. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"It is these who hasten in the good deeds, and they are foremost in them" (TMQ, 23: 61).** They never miss a chance for getting more reward from Allah *(SWT)*.

Supplication …After Work:

Surat Al-Mu'minun closes in a wonderful way: Allah (SWT) teaches us a nice supplication which can be translated as**, "And say (O Muhammad): "My Lord! Forgive and have mercy, for You are the Best of those who show mercy!" (TMQ, 23: 118).**

Why did the Surah conclude with this supplication in particular? Because the believers, who have all of the traits mentioned in the Surah might err or fail to keep up with the same level of faith. Consequently, there should be a final Ayah that leads one back to the way of Allah *(SWT),* asking for His forgiveness for the faults committed by a human who is by nature prone to mistakes.

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[8] *Munqati'* (Disconnected) Hadith, narrated by Ibn Hejr, p. 73/5

Surat An-Nur (The Light)

Surat An-Nur is Madinan. It follows Surat Al-Hashr in the order of revelation, and Surat Al-Mu'minun in the order of the Holy Book. It consists of 64 Ayahs.

Houses of light

Surat An-Nur is the Surah of social conventions and manners. It focuses on regulating people's lives at home, seeking to maintain courteous relations between people, reaching a state of harmony and morality in the society; and shows how to purify the community from crimes and sin.

Gossipmongers

Surat An-Nur was revealed in reply to the rumors spread by the hypocrites about Lady Aisha (May Allah be pleased with her); they accused her of committing adultery, although Allah *(SWT)* Himself proved her innocence in the Qur'an. What happened is that when Lady Aisha went with the Prophet *(SAWS)* in Al-Mustalaq Conquest, and the army stopped to have some rest, Lady Aisha lost her necklace. While she was searching for it, the men carried her *hawdaj* (a closed tent placed on the camel), not thinking that she was not there, as she had a slim figure. When she came back, she found that the army had left, and she was left alone in the desert.

The Prophet *(SAWS)* was used to keep somebody in the rear of the army, so as to guide anyone who misses it. At that time, it was Safwan Ibn Al-Mu'attal who found Lady Aisha alone, so he put her on a camel without speaking to her or even looking at her, until they entered Al-Madinah. The hypocrites made use of this incident to their own benefit; they began spreading rumors that Lady Aisha and Safwan – Allah *(SWT)* forbid – committed adultery. People began to spread these false rumors, even some believers fell into the trap, and they said "No smoke without fire". Muslims argued about that matter: some were puzzled; some did not believe it at all; and some did. No ayahs were revealed to the Prophet *(SAWS)* for a whole month, which was a test for the whole society.

A divine declaration of innocence

The Revelation ceased to occur to the Prophet *(SAWS)* until the whole society releases all latent thoughts and attitudes about that matter. It was a hard test, indeed, which lasted until ayahs from Surat An-Nur were sent down to prove Lady Aisha's innocence? Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Verily those who brought forth the slander (against 'Aisha the wife of the Prophet) are a group among you. Consider it not a bad thing for you. Nay, it is good for you. Unto every man among them will be paid that which he had earned of the sin, and as for him among them who had the greater share therein, his will be a great torment" (TMQ, 24: 11).**

This Ayah declares, frankly, that Lady Aisha is innocent, and that what happened was flagrant lies and falsehood. Whoever contributed to spreading such lies in the society, mainly Abdullah Ibn Abu Salul, the head of the hypocrites, will have a tremendous torment.

Not an evil

The previous Ayah comments on the slander which spread like hellfire among Muslims. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as**, "Consider it not a bad thing for you. Nay, it is good for you" (TMQ, 24: 11).** How can there be any benefit or good in this?

The whole Islamic society, was to learn from this incident, and we too shall learn from it. Moreover, the set of the social rules mentioned in this Surah are beneficial for all the Muslims in every part of the earth forever, as Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, "Nay, it is good for you".

They thought highly of themselves

The first comment on the incident was what Allah *(SWT)* said and can be translated as, **"Why then, did not the believers, men and women, when you heard it (the slander), think good of their own people and say: "This (charge) is an obvious lie?" (TMQ, 24: 12).** This is a great Ayah that teaches us how to act when rumors about others' honor spread. The situation for which this Ayah was revealed was that Abu-Ayyub Al-Ansari asked his wife had she been in Aisha's shoes, would she have done as the rumors said? She replied in the negative, so he told her: "And Aisha is better than you." In turn, she asked him, had he been in Safwan's shoes, would he have done as the rumors said? He replied in the negative, so she told him: "And Safwan is better than you." Thus, the Ayah praises their magnificent deed to set them as a good example for all the Muslims. What is nice about the Ayah is that its wording is "the believers, men and women, thought highly of themselves", although "they thought highly of their companions", as if it tells the Muslims: "Think highly of each other, exactly as you think of yourselves. You are all believers, so let the hypocrites think of you as they like." The Ayahs inspire the feeling that one's ill talk about one's brother/sister in Islam is considered ill talk about oneself, and that highly thinking of brothers/sisters means defending oneself.

Beware of harming others' reputations

Beware, O Muslim, of harming others' reputations, especially women; beware of listening to the devil's whispers about it; and beware of spreading the news of scandals and rumors, which makes you think wrongly of others, falling into the great sin that the Surah mentions, which is slandering innocent women.

Those who spread the false rumors, as well as those who believed them among the Muslims, had neither witnesses nor evidence. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Why did they not produce four witnesses? Since they (the slanderers) have not produced witnesses! Then with Allah they are the liars" (TMQ, 24: 13).**

However, Allah's *(SWT)* mercy always precedes His anger. He *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Had it not been for the Grace of Allah and His Mercy unto you in this world and in the Hereafter, a great torment would have touched you for that whereof you had spoken" (TMQ, 24: 14).**

You consider it a little thing, while for Allah *(SWT)* it was very great

The Ayahs shift again to describing the gravity of the situation. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"When you were propagating it with your tongues, and uttering with your mouths that whereof you had no knowledge, you counted it a little thing, while with Allah it was very great; And why did you not, when you heard it, say: "It is not right for us to speak of this. Glory be to You (O Allah)! This is a great lie; Allah forbids you from it and warns you not to repeat the like of it forever, if you are believers" (TMQ, 24: 15-17).**

All these Ayahs are commenting on the aforementioned incident, so this was a warning to the Companions of the Prophet (SAWS), and to the whole Islamic nation, against ill speaking about women's reputations. Some young men might say a word or make a gesture in this respect; they might even be joking without aiming at harming anybody, but the Ayahs give them a clear serious warning. Allah (SWT) says what can be translated as**, "You counted it a little thing, while with Allah it was very great"** (TMQ, 24: 15). The Ayahs then forbid them to repeat such an action, as Allah (SWT) says what can be translated as**, "Allah forbids you from it and warns you not to repeat the like of it forever, if you are believers" (TMQ, 24: 17).**

Thus, we see that this story was beneficial to the society of Madinah and to all Islamic societies. Let's review together the Ayahs of this Surah and try to realize the meanings intended by Allah *(SWT)* in this Surah.

Grave crime - strong beginning

How does the Surah begin? In an unconventional way. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"(This is) a Surah which We have sent down and which We have enjoined, (ordained its laws)" (TMQ, 24: 1),** which is a strong beginning for a Surah. However, all the Surahs of the Qur'an were revealed and enjoined, so why does this Surah begin in this style? It is as if the Surah wants to powerfully protect the society, so the means of protection should be so influential so as to draw attention to the importance of the coming rules.

Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"(This is) a Surah which We have sent down and which We have enjoined, (ordained its laws); and in it We have revealed manifest *Ayat* (proofs, evidence, verses, lessons, signs, revelations - lawful and unlawful things, and set boundaries of Islamic Religion), that you may remember" (TMQ, 24: 1).**

What is the first of these rules?

Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"The fornicatress and the fornicator, flog each of them with a hundred stripes. Let not pity withhold you in their case, in a punishment prescribed by Allah, if you believe in Allah and the Last Day. And let a party of the believers witness their punishment" (TMQ, 24: 2).**

Although the basis of our religion is mercy and compassion, Allah *(SWT)* states in the Ayah what can be translated as, "**Let not pity withhold you in their case, in a punishment prescribed by Allah"**.

Although our religion commands not to expose each others' faults, as Allah *(SWT)* is The Protector who likes to protect everyone, as far as adultery is concerned Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And let a party of the believers witness their punishment". (TMQ, 24: 2).**

Replying to suspicion

The enemies of Islam begin to attack this religion, describing it as a merciless, barbarian one in applying laws. Unfortunately, some Muslims are embarrassed to reply to these insinuations; sometimes they even believe them. I would like to say to such persons: "Don't judge Islam until you have read Surat An-Nur as a whole, so that you would realize the greatness of Islam in solving the social problems."

Means of protection

The reason for the strong start of the Surah is that it sets definite guarantees to prevent committing adultery. If one commits it ignoring all such set of laws and rules, this means that one's nature is badly distorted, so there must be a deterring penalty.

The Surah contains seven means of safety that protect the Muslim, as well as the society, against committing adultery. They also keep the society pure, virtuous and incorruptible. In this Surah, one reads about the rules of asking for permission before entering others' houses, helping young people to get married, prohibiting fornication, lowering one's gaze, women's Hijab, and abstaining from ill talking about others' reputation without witnesses. Then, there comes the penalty in the right timing, so that it would be a mercy for the society and a restraint to those deviants who are extremely lustful and corrupt. What are these means?

Society-enlightening ethics

1. **Asking Permission:**

   No man shall enter a woman's house while she is alone, especially if he is an in-law; no man shall sit alone with a woman whom he could marry and children should not enter their parents' rooms at anytime without permission and this applies to servants too who should abide by the same rule. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"O you who believe! Enter not houses other than your own, until you have asked permission and greeted those in them; that is better for you, in order that you may remember; And if you find no one therein, still, enter not until permission has been given. And if you are asked to go back, go back, for it is purer for you. And Allah is All-Knower of what you do" (TMQ, 24: 27-28).**

   Then, Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as**, "O you who believe! Let your slaves and slave-girls, and those among you who have not come to the age of puberty ask your permission (before they come to your presence) on three occasions" (TMQ, 24: 58).** These Ayahs are the regulations of life inside the Muslim house, to be applied for both children and servants. Listen to the regulations that Allah *(SWT)* sets, and that can be

translated as, **"before *Fajr* prayer, and while you put off your clothes for the noonday (rest), and after the *'Isha'* (late-night) prayer. (These) three times are of privacy for you; other than these times there is no sin on you or on them to move about, attending to each other" (TMQ, 24: 58).** These are the times when one gets undressed, either to sleep or to change clothes.

The Ayahs continue as Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And when the children among you come to puberty, then let them (also) ask for permission, as those senior to them (in age). Thus Allah makes clear His *Ayat* (Commandments and legal obligations) for you. And Allah is All-Knowing, All Wise" (TMQ, 24: 59).**

What a great religion that penetrates inside one's home in order to regulate it, insuring happiness and protection against evils and vices.

2. **Lowering one's gaze:**

In order to keep the society away from the road to sin, Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Tell the believing men to lower their gaze (from looking at forbidden things), and protect their private parts (from illegal sexual acts). That is purer for them. Verily, Allah is All-Aware of what they do" (TMQ, 24: 30).**

The order of lowering one's gaze and keeping chastity is not directed only to men, but also to women with the same wording. **"And tell the believing women to lower their gaze (from looking at forbidden things)" (TMQ, 24: 31).**

3. **Helping young people get married:**

The adultery penalty could not be applied if young people cannot afford to get married. Therefore, one of the most important rules given in the Surah is encouraging the well-to-do to help young people to get married. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And marry those among you who are single (i.e. a man who has no wife and the woman who has no husband) and (also marry) the *Salihun* (pious, fit and capable ones) of your (male) slaves and maid servants (female slaves). If they be poor, Allah will enrich them out of His Bounty. And Allah is All-Sufficient for His creatures' needs, All-Knowing (about the state of the people)" (TMQ, 24: 32).** Thus, young people who cannot afford marriage are protected from falling into sin. One should help them, keeping in mind that the reward is from Allah *(SWT).*

4. **Prohibiting fornication:**

The Ayahs also warned parents (and societies) who force their daughters to commit adultery as a means to gain financial profits. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as**, "And force not your maids to prostitution, if they desire chastity, in order that you may make a gain in the (perishable) goods of this worldly life. But if anyone compels them (to prostitution),**

then after such compulsion, Allah is Oft-Forgiving, Most Merciful (to those women, i.e. He will forgive them because they have been forced to do this evil act unwillingly)" (TMQ, 24: 33).

The Surah, with all its strict rules, protects women and warns against using their womanly attractions as a commodity, as this does injustice to them, and consequently leads to corrupting the whole society.

5. **Hijab for women:**

After the orders of taking permission,, lowering one's gaze, helping young people to get married, and prohibiting fornication, there comes the command to make women wear hijab. This is one of the most important means of protecting men, whether bachelors or married, from committing adultery, as a result of the obscene scenes they set eyes on whether in the street, in newspapers, in satellite channels and the mass media. Hijab, on the one hand, and lowering one's gaze, on the other hand, are considered as guarantees for the protection and purity of the society. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And tell the believing women to lower their gaze (from looking at forbidden things), and protect their private parts (from illegal sexual acts) and not to show off their adornment except only that which is apparent (like both eyes for necessity to see the way, or outer palms of hands or one eye or dress like veil, gloves, head-cover, apron, etc.), and to draw their veils all over *Juyubihinna* (i.e. their bodies, faces, necks and bosoms)" (TMQ, 24: 31).**

By repeating **"not to show off their adornment"** twice in the same Ayah, it has been made clear that the whole body of the woman is adornment, so she is not allowed to reveal any part of her body except the face and the hands, as the Prophet *(SAWS)* told us.

The Ayahs not only command women to wear the *hijab*, but it also describes it in detail. The shape of the proper *hijab* is thoroughly described as Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"to draw their veils all over Juyubihinna (i.e. their bodies, faces, necks and bosoms)";** the hijab should cover the chest and the neck. The Ayah also determines for the Muslim woman those to whom she may reveal her adornment, as Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"and not to reveal their adornment except to their husbands, or their fathers, or their husband's fathers" (TMQ, 24:31).**

Such detailed description, having been made, how can one say that wearing the hijab is not a duty in Islam? The Ayahs in this Surah, as well as in Surat Al-Ahzab, discussed this issue in a detailed way and unquestionable statements.

6. **Prohibiting the spread of vices:**

Islam has forbidden people to spread vices in the society, as Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Verily, those who like that (the crime of) illegal**

sexual intercourse should be propagated among those who believe, they will have a painful torment in this world and in the Hereafter. And Allah knows and you know not"(TMQ, 24: 19).

I would like to say to all the mass media which spread vices and nudity in the society; to all those who spread the news of scandals and distort the reputation of others, listen to these Ayahs and beware of Allah's *(SWT)* punishment. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Verily, those who accuse chaste women, who never even think of anything touching their chastity and are good believers are cursed in this life and in the Hereafter, and for them will be a great torment; On the Day when their tongues, their hands, and their legs (or feet) will bear witness against them as to what they used to do."(TMQ, 24: 23-24).**

There must be four witnesses

Thus, it is clear that Islam calls for the application of all these guarantees so as to insure that the society is free of all the causes and stimuli of committing adultery. If one can afford to get married, women wear hijab, people abide by lowering their gaze, ads vanish, fornication is prohibited and then someone commits adultery, does he really deserve the adultery penalty? Of course not, because there must be four trustworthy witnesses or he must confess, so that he can be whipped or flung. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And those who accuse chaste women, and produce not four witnesses, flog them with eighty stripes, and reject their testimony forever. They indeed are the *Fasiqun* (liars, rebellious, disobedient to Allah); except those who repent thereafter and do righteous deeds; (for such) verily, Allah is Oft-Forgiving, Most Merciful." (TMQ, 24: 4-5).**

That is why he deserves penalty

As the Ayahs reveal that there must be four witnesses in order to apply the penalty, a very tough condition is being put. This is a form of Allah's *(SWT)* mercy. That penalty is applied only to whoever transgresses all the rules laid down in the Surah and commits adultery. Not only this, but he also commits it in front of four people, which means that he has done it in public! Who acts in this manner deserves really no mercy; he should be treated cruelly. This explains the strong start of the Surah, as Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Let not pity withhold you in their case, in a punishment prescribed by Allah", (TMQ, 24:2)** as a person who commits such an act tries to ruin the whole society.

The greatness of Islam is revealed in the fact that if there were only three witnesses, or if one of the four witnesses drew back his testimony, the three witnesses are the ones who will be whipped, as protecting others' reputation is the most important thing and the basic issue in this respect in Islam.

There is no thirst for punishment in Islam

The aforesaid statements reveal that Islam is not thirsty for setting punishments. The Companions of the Prophet *(SAWS)* are a good example for us to follow in applying the rules of Islam. When Omar Ibn Al-Khattab was the Emir of the Believers

(Caliph), he saw an act of adultery, but with no other witnesses. He turned angry and told the Muslims "I saw and heard by myself; I'm going to penalize them." Ali Ibn Abu-Taleb asked him, "Do you have other witnesses?" Omar replied "No, but I'm the Commander of the Believers, and I saw and heard." Ali replied, "You must bring four witnesses, otherwise you will be yourself whipped instead!!" Who can one claim, after all this, that Islam is blood-thirsty?

Repentance

All the penalties stated at the beginning of the Surah are the final remedy after all the rules that guarantee the protection of the society from committing sins. If a young man or girl commits adultery, and their country does not apply Allah's *(SWT)* regulations, or if such regulations are incomplete in the society (such as the difficulty of marriage, spreading of sins, and the absence of hijab), what can he or she do?

The answer is of course: strictly nothing. Nothing can be done immediately. They should repent to Allah. The greatness of this Surah lies in the fact that after every part which speaks about Allah's *(SWT)* rules, there is another part which speaks about His mercy and opens the door for repentance. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Except those who repent thereafter and do righteous deeds" (TMQ, 24: 5).**

"And had it not been for the Grace of Allah and His Mercy on you (He would have hastened the punishment upon you)! And that Allah is the One Who forgives and accepts repentance, the All-Wise" (TMQ, 24: 10).

"And had it not been for the Grace of Allah and His Mercy on you, (Allah would have hastened the punishment upon you). And that Allah is full of Kindness, Most Merciful" (TMQ, 24: 20).

"And all of you beg Allah to forgive you all, O believers, that you may be successful" (TMQ, 24: 31).

Repentance is the way to safety of the societies where there is shortage in the guarantees of protection against sins, or those where Allah's *(SWT)* laws are not applied for a reason or another.

Towards Light

An important question poses itself: why is this Surah called "An-Nur"? Some might reply "Because Allah (*SWT*) says in this Surah what can be translated as, **"Allah is the Light of the heavens and the earth" (TMQ, 24: 35).** This is crystal clear, but what is the relation between this Ayah and the social rules of conduct abundant in the Surah? Why was not the Surah named the Surah of social rules or something anything of the sort?

The significance of this is that applying those instructions and rules enlightens the society; Allah's *(SWT)* laws are the illuminating light of the society and the alternative opposite is confusion and chaos; which applies to most of the societies in our present time. Many houses are living in darkness (ignorance) and many societies miss the light because their people have not read Surat An-Nur. When these societies

reject Allah's *(SWT)* laws, sins prevail and troubles increase. For all these reasons, the Surah was called "An-Nur", being the light which protects people, purifies them from lusts, and keeps their reputations safe from ill talk, and illuminates the road to Allah *(SWT)*.

Allah *(SWT)* is the Light of the heavens and the Earth

What is the source of this light? It is Allah *(SWT)*. He *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Allah is the Light of the heavens and the earth" (TMQ, 24: 35).** Allah's *(SWT)* light is represented in His laws and guidance.

Where does this light descend? Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as**, "In houses (mosques), which Allah has ordered to be raised (to be cleaned, and to be honored), in them His Name is remembered" (TMQ, 24: 36).**

On whom does this light befall? Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Men whom neither trade nor sale (business) diverts from the Remembrance of Allah" (TMQ, 24: 37).**

As to those who deviate from this light, Allah (*SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"As for those who disbelieve, their deeds are like a mirage in a desert. The thirsty one thinks it to be water" (TMQ, 24: 39),** as they did not follow Allah's *(SWT)* light and preferred to live in chaos. Allah *(SWT)* also says what can be translated as, **"Or [the state of a disbeliever] is like the darkness in a vast deep sea, overwhelmed with waves topped by waves, topped by dark clouds, (layers of) darkness upon darkness: if a man stretches out his hand, he can hardly see it! And he for whom Allah has not appointed light, for him there is no light" (TMQ, 24: 40).**

Do you see the consequences of giving up divine guidance? Do you see how unveiling and spreading scandals make individuals, societies and even the whole world wandering in the darkness of sins?

Divine Light Prerequisites

Listen again to the central Ayah, where Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Allah is the Light of the heavens and the earth. The parable of His Light is as (if there were) a niche and within it a lamp: the lamp is in a glass, the glass as it were a brilliant star, lit from a blessed tree, an olive, neither of the east (i.e. neither it gets sun-rays only in the morning) nor of the west (i.e. nor it gets sun-rays only in the afternoon, but it is exposed to the sun all day long), whose oil would almost glow forth (of itself), though no fire touched it. Light upon Light! Allah guides to His Light whom He wills. And Allah sets forth parables for mankind, and Allah is All-Knower of everything" (TMQ, 24: 35).** The niche is an opening in the wall which surrounds the lamp and protects it. In order to keep the light, there should be a bottle to protect it. It is as if this great Ayah tells Muslims, "If you apply Allah's *(SWT)* laws (the light of society) and protect it, and make your hearts like the bottle which encompasses the light, you shall guarantee that it remains illuminated throughout your life."

This light requires a source of illumination, which is, in this case, your work and positiveness as believers. It is as if the Ayahs tell you to find the source of light so as to illuminate the whole society. This is why the beginning of the Surah was a strong one. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"(This is) a Surah which We have sent down and which We have enjoined" (TMQ, 24: 1),** as it calls for acting positively and illuminating the society by Allah's *(SWT)* light.

Clarifying ayahs

Amongst the creative points in the Qur'an, is that it stresses the word "light" to refer to Allah's *(SWT)* laws. What are then the most distinguished features of light? They can be summed up in three words: guidance, manifestation and revelation.

As light reveals truths, the words "manifest" and "plain Ayahs" are repeated in the Surah nine times. The Surah begins with Allah's *(SWT)* saying what can be translated as, **"and in it We have revealed manifest Ayahs" (TMQ, 24: 1).** After speaking about every set of social rules, there comes Allah's words that can be translated as, **"And Allah makes the Ayahs plain to you" (TMQ, 24: 18),** or his words that can be translated as, **"And indeed We have sent down for you Ayahs (proofs, evidence, verses, lessons, signs, revelations, etc.) that make things plain" (TMQ, 24: 34).** These laws are the guide of believers to the right path.

This is also the reason why Lady Aisha's innocence was revealed in this Surah, as light reveals truths.

That's also why the Surah puts the condition of bringing four witnesses, a fact which in itself provides the evidence before the adultery penalty can be applied. This evidence is the revealer and the light.

Please let this Surah, as well as the rules of social conduct included in it, be a guiding light to you and your family. You should also hang on to Allah's *(SWT)* laws so as to enlighten your society with it and lead all the people to spread light in the whole world.

Surat Al-Furqan (The Criterion)

Surat Al-Furqan is Makkan. It was revealed after Surat Ya-Seen, and it comes after Surat An-Nur in the order of the Qur'an. It has consists of 77 ayahs.

The objective of Surat Al-Furqan

This Surah speaks about the unpleasant fate of those who disbelieve in Allah, His apostle and His book. Hence, we find in it three main ideas:

- The kinds of disbelief that the Prophet *(SAWS)* faced.
- Warning against the unpleasant fate of disbelief.
- Support for the Prophet *(SAWS)* and his companions.

All the ayahs of this Surah clearly focus on these three ideas. It is called Al-Furqan because it shows through the above-mentioned three ideas how religion and the Qur'an set a clear borderline between right and wrong.

Disbelief and support

This holy Surah was revealed in a time when the polytheists were going too far in mocking the Prophet *(SAWS).* Therefore, its ayahs came to support the Prophet *(SAWS)* and his companions and to refute those who disbelieved him.

In this respect, Allah (SWT) says in the beginning of the Surah what can be translated as, **"Those who disbelieve say: "This (the Qur'an) is nothing but a lie that he (Muhammad *SAWS*) has invented, and others have helped him at it. In fact they have produced an unjust wrong (thing) and a lie. And they say: "Tales of the ancients, which he has written down: and they are dictated to him morning and afternoon." (TMQ, 25:4-5).**

Disbelief takes different forms : From denying the Qur'an and describing it as **"Tales of the ancients,"** to denying the Prophet *(SAWS):* **"And they say: "Why does this Messenger (Muhammad SAWS) eat food, and walk about in the markets (as we). Why is not an angel sent down to him to be a warner with him? Or (why) has not a treasure been granted to him, or why has he not a garden whereof he may eat?" And the Zalimun (polytheists and wrong-doers) say: "You follow none but a man bewitched. See how they coin similitudes for you, so they have gone astray, and they cannot find a (Right) Path."(TMQ, 25:7-9).**

After disbelief comes a wonderful support for the Prophet *(SAWS)* **"Blessed be He Who, if He wills will assign you better than (all) that - Gardens under which rivers flow (Paradise) and will assign you palaces (i.e. in Paradise)", (TMQ, 25:10).**

The ayahs that follow show the fate of the disbelievers **"Nay, they deny the Hour (the Day of Resurrection), and for those who deny the Hour, We have prepared a flaming Fire (i.e. Hell). When it (Hell) sees them from a far place, they will hear its raging and its roaring. And when they shall be thrown into a narrow place**

thereof, chained together, they will exclaim therein for destruction. Exclaim not today for one destruction, but exclaim for many destructions." (TMQ, 25:11-14).

Being deserted by devils of mankind and Jinn

The ayahs then show an uglier form of disbelief**, "And those who expect not a Meeting with Us (i.e. those who deny the Day of Resurrection and the life of the Hereafter) said: "Why are not the angels sent down to us, or why do we not see our Lord?" Indeed they think too highly of themselves, and are scornful with great pride." (TMQ, 25:21).**

What will be their fate? **"And (remember) the Day when the Zalim (wrong-doer, oppressor, polytheist) will bite at his hands, he will say: "Oh! Would that I had taken a path with the Messenger (Muhammad SAWS). Ah! Woe to me! Would that I had never taken so-and-so as a Khalil (an intimate friend)! He indeed led me astray from the Reminder (this Qur'an) after it had come to me. And Shaitan (Satan) is to man ever a deserter in the hour of need." (TMQ, 25:27-29).** Sure, their bad friends deserted them, and Satan who used to stimulate them, actually abandoned them.

Between the ayahs describing the disbelievers and those talking about their fate lies a calming ayah, **"The dwellers of Paradise (i.e. those who deserved it through their Islamic Monotheistic Faith and their deeds of righteousness) will, on that Day, have the best abode, and have the fairest of places for repose." (TMQ, 25:24).**

Beware of deserting the Qur'an

Then there is a serious complaint against whoever deserts the Qur'an: **" And the Messenger (Muhammad *SAWS*) will say: "O my Lord! Verily, my people deserted this Qur'an (neither listened to it, nor acted on its laws and teachings)" (TMQ, 25:30).** Beware of deserting the Qur'an, because it is your way to differentiate between right and wrong, between darkness and light and between belief and disbelief.

The disbelief of the polytheist has no limits. They search for any possible reason to proceed in the way they do. They refute the gradual revelation of the Qur'an**," And those who disbelieve say: "Why is not the Qur'an revealed to him all at once?" (TMQ, 25:32).** But Allah *(SWT)* answers them in the most magnificent way: **"Thus (it is sent down in parts), that We may strengthen your heart thereby. And We have revealed it to you gradually, in stages. (It was revealed to the Prophet SAWS in 23 years.)" (TMQ, 25:32).** So this ayah answers the disbelievers' pretension, and strengthens the Prophet's heart at the same time.

The ayahs go on in the same pattern we explained before: Mentioning one kind of disbelief, and then mentioning its fate and meanwhile calming the Prophet *(SAWS).*One of the kinds of disbelief is shown in the following ayah: **"And when they see you (O Muhammad *SAWS*), they treat you only in mockery (saying): "Is this the one whom Allah has sent as a Messenger?" (TMQ, 25:41).** Consequently, the ayahs support the Prophet *(SAWS)* and present Allah's promise to assist him, **"And no example or similitude do they bring (to oppose or to find fault in you or**

in this Qur'an), but We reveal to you the truth (against that similitude or example), and the better explanation thereof." (TMQ, 25:33). The ayahs, afterwards, warn against the fate of disbelievers**, "Those who will be gathered to Hell (prone) on their faces, such will be in an evil state, and most astray from the (Straight) Path." (TMQ, 25:34).**

The main reason for disbelief

Some people may wonder why is all this disbelief and fabrication? The answer is provided in ayah 43. This central ayah states that the reason for disbelief is following one's desires: he who follows his desires always says that it is the fault of others, never his **"Have you (O Muhammad SAWS) seen him who has taken as his ilah (god) his own vain desire? Would you then be a Wakil (a disposer of his affairs or a watcher) over him?" (TMQ, 25:43).** What can you do for this kind of person who has worshipped his own desires instead of Allah *(SWT)*? Such acts nullify his mind and spoil his nature. Would you then be a Wakil (supporter or defender) over him?

Have you not seen how your Lord spread the shadow?

The Surah continues with the same rhythm: showing the types of polytheists' disbelief, indicating their fates, then calming and supporting the Prophet *(SAWS).* It then manifests the signs of Allah *(SWT)* in the universe. What is magnificent in the Qur'an is that if the Surah speaks about the signs of Allah *(SWT)* in the universe, the ayahs will not be dispersed. On the contrary, they will suit the general theme of the Surah. In the same way, and as we've mentioned before, the Prophets' stories come in a Surah to serve its objective.

What do we see in Surat Al-Furqan? The dominant theme of the Surah is disbelieving the Prophet *(SAWS),* while its purpose is supporting and calming the Prophet. Here comes a wonderful sign in the universe to serve this purpose: **"Have you not seen how your Lord spread the shadow. If He willed, He could have made it still"(TMQ, 25:45).** This ayah connotes that He who spreads the shadow as a mercy for His worshippers, is able to shade them with His mercy, and save them from the harm that results from the disbelievers' denial. The spread of shadow provides tranquility and peace to the hearts of the believers because the Creator who has created perfectly these signs backs them up.

Night of mercy

After that, Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as: **"And it is He Who makes the night a covering for you, and the sleep (as) a repose, and makes the day Nushur (i.e. getting up and going about here and there for daily work, after one's sleep at night, or like resurrection after one's death)"(TMQ, 25:47).** The choice of the night is done on purpose: it indeed throws shadows of tranquility and mercy. Then Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as**: "And it is He Who sends the winds as heralds of glad tidings, going before His Mercy (rain); and We send down pure water from the sky. That We may give life thereby to a dead land."(TMQ, 25:48-49).** We see here that Allah's *(SWT)* signs in the universe: wind and rain promise

believers of Allah's *(SWT)* mercy, purifies them and enlivens their hearts. This attenuates the contempt and denial they are suffering from.

The apex of disbelief

After the disbelievers' denial of the Prophet *(SAWS)* and the Qur'an, the ayahs take us before the end of this Surah to an extreme kind of disbelief. They disbelieve in Allah The Most Gracious **"And when it is said to them: "Prostrate yourselves to the Most Gracious (Allah)! They say: "And what is the Most Gracious? Shall we fall down in prostration to that which you (O Muhammad SAWS) command us?" And it increases in them only aversion. "(TMQ, 25:60).** This is the top of impoliteness towards Allah *(SWT)* and the ayahs answer them in a very wonderful manner; not by telling them who is The Most Gracious, but by describing his slaves: **"And the (faithful) slaves of the Most Gracious (Allah)".** This is to let them know The Most Gracious through the qualities of the believers. This is an honour and a support from Allah *(SWT)* to the believers, as if He is saying to those obstinate disbelievers: Ask them about The Most Gracious.

The believers honored by Allah

Answering the polytheists in this manner is the greatest honor for The Most Gracious's slaves. Their qualities represent a grace from the Most Gracious. Allah says in what can be translated as : **"And the (faithful) slaves of the Most Gracious (Allah) are those who walk on the earth in humility and sedateness, and when the foolish address them (with bad words) they reply back with mild words of gentleness. And those who spend the night in worship of their Lord, prostrate and standing. And those who say: "Our Lord! Avert from us the torment of Hell. Verily its torment is ever an inseparable, permanent punishment. Evil indeed it (Hell) is as an abode and as a place to rest in. And those who, when they spend, are neither extravagant nor niggardly, but hold a medium (way) between those (extremes). And those who invoke not any other *ilah* (god) along with Allah, nor kill such person as Allah has forbidden, except for just cause, nor commit illegal sexual intercourse - and whoever does this shall receive the punishment. The torment will be doubled to him on the Day of Resurrection, and he will abide therein in disgrace. Except those who repent and believe (in Islamic Monotheism), and do righteous deeds; for those, Allah will change their sins into good deeds, and Allah is Oft-Forgiving, Most Merciful. And whosoever repents and does righteous good deeds; then verily, he repents towards Allah with true repentance. And those who do not bear witness to falsehood, and if they pass by some evil play or evil talk, they pass by it with dignity. And those who, when they are reminded of the Ayat (proofs, evidence, verses, lessons, signs, revelations, etc.) of their Lord, fall not deaf and blind thereat. And those who say: "Our Lord! Bestow on us from our wives and our offspring the comfort of our eyes, and make us leaders of the Mutaqueen (the pious). "(TMQ, 25:63-74).** The Ayah "**and make us leaders of the Mutaqueen (the pious)"** signifies that the Muslim's wish to be a leader is a requested good thing (without loving headship or greed for life) in order to be an *imam* (leader) for believers and one who helps them achieve piety. One of the splendors of the previous ayah is that it equally relates to the slaves' excellence in worship and in good manners. You see a clear sequence: the characteristics related to worship, then those related to manners. This connotation is

made throughout the Surah to assert that those who deserve the title: **"slaves of The Most Gracious"** do not separate between acts of worship and good manners.

As for you, who denied The Most Gracious, I would like to invite you to listen to what Allah (*SWT)* says at the end of the Surah**: "Say (O Muhammad *SAWS* to the disbelievers): "My Lord pays attention to you only because of your invocation to Him. But now you have indeed denied (Him). So the torment will be yours for ever (inseparable, permanent punishment)."(TMQ, 25:77).** Hence, we find that the ayahs of Surat Al-Furqan always sets a clear borderline between right and wrong, while referring to members of each party. They differentiate between the believers' bliss with Allah's *(SWT)* support for them, and the hell of the disbelievers who are threatened with severe torment.

Surat Ash-Shu'ara (The Poets)

This Surah is Makkan. It was revealed after Surat Al-Waqi-ah, and it comes after Surat Al-Furqan in the order of the Qur'an. The number of its Ayahs is 227.

Narrate on my behalf even one ayah

Surat Ash-Shu'ara is about the importance of conveying the message to people through the best effective means. In the time of Prophet *Musa* (Moses), the means was magic, and at the age of Prophet Mohammad *(SAWS),* it was poetry and poets (hence comes the name of the Surah).

This Surah was revealed in a time when the Muslims needed to learn the methods of information and communication. The beginning of the public preaching of the message of Islam had then begun. The Prophet *(SAWS)* stood on Al-Safa Mountain and announced that the call to Islam had to be done publicly for the first time in Makkah. In this way, the Surah shows clearly the importance of the means of communication and information in the process of Da'wa (Calling to Allah and Islam).

The danger of audible speech

Media is a double-edged sword. It is used either to mislead people or to guide them. For this reason, Allah (*SWT)* ended the Surah saying what can be translated as**: "As for the poets, the erring ones follow them, See you not that they speak about every subject (praising people - right or wrong) in their poetry? And that they say what they do not do. Except those who believe (in the Oneness of Allah - Islamic Monotheism) and do righteous deeds, and remember Allah much, and vindicate themselves after they have been wronged (by replying back in poetry to the unjust poetry (which the pagan poets utter against the Muslims)). And those who do wrong will come to know by what overturning they will be overturned"(TMQ, 26:224-227).**

Poets in the time of Prophet *(SAWS)* or Media in our current time may mislead people and prevent them from worshipping Allah *(SWT).* On the other hand, they may give people the right information about religion and hence guide them to righteousness. Therefore, preachers to Allah's *(SWT)* way should use these means, the role of which grows in our age.

Keys of the hearts

As we have seen before, the Prophets' *(SAWS)* stories come in a Surah to serve its objective. When the Surah spoke about Prophet Musa *(AS)*, it stated how he had feared his words might not produce the desired impact on his people. He said **"And my breast straitens, and my tongue expresses not well. So send for Harun (Aaron) (to come along with me)". (TMQ, 26:13).** All Prophets *(SAWS)* stories that came in the Surah were focusing on the dialogue of the Prophet *(SAWS)* with his people. This is what we find in the stories of Musa *(AS)*, Ibrahim (Abraham) *(AS)*, Noah *(AS)*, Hud *(AS)*, Saleh *(AS)*, Loot *(AS)* and Shu'aib *(AS*). We find the focus on "he said and they said". The style of the dialogues in the Surah is wonderful. It prepares the Prophet *(SAWS)* to begin the stage of public preaching, which was

declared clearly in Ayah 214 **"And warn your tribe (O Muhammad *SAWS*) of near kindred"**.

Masterpieces of media dialogues

For example, the dialogue of Prophet Musa *(SAWS)* with *Firaawn* is a wonderful style of dialogue**, "And go both of you to Fir'aun (Pharaoh), and say: 'We are the Messengers of the Lord of the 'Alamin (mankind, jinn and all that exists), so allow the Children of Israel to go with us. (Fir'aun (Pharaoh)) said (to Musa): "Did we not bring you up among us as a child? And you did dwell many years of your life with us. And you did your deed, which you did (i.e. the crime of killing a man) while you were one of the ingrates"(TMQ, 26:16-19).** A great accusation made by *Fir'aun* against Musa *(SAWS)*. What should be the answers of preachers to Allah's *(SWT)* way in such a situation**? "Musa said: "I did it then, when I was ignorant (as regards my Lord and His Message). So I fled from you when I feared you. But my Lord has granted me Hukm (i.e. religious knowledge, right judgment of the affairs and Prophet hood), and made me one of the Messengers"(TMQ, 26:20-21).** He no longer cares about the accusation made in the past as he moves from defense to attack saying**: "And this is the past favor with which you reproach me: that you have enslaved the Children of Israel". (TMQ, 26:22).**

Here the exchange of accusations comes to an end, and a preaching dialogue starts. Listen with me to these Ayahs, **"Fir'aun (Pharaoh) said: "And what is the Lord of the 'Alamin (mankind, jinn and all that exists)? (Musa) said: "The Lord of the heavens and the earth, and all that is between them, if you seek to be convinced with certainty." (TMQ, 26:23-24). "Fir'aun (Pharaoh)) said to those around: "Do you not hear (what he says)? (Musa) said: "Your Lord and the Lord of your ancient fathers!"(TMQ, 26:25-26).**

"(Fir'aun (Pharaoh)) said: "Verily, your Messenger who has been sent to you is a madman!" (Musa) said: "Lord of the east and the west, and all that is between them, if you did but understand!"(TMQ, 26:27-28).

We see that Prophet Musa *(AS)* lengthens his answer to the question **"And what is the Lord of the 'Alamin (mankind, jinn and all that exists)?"(TMQ, 26:23)** in order to affect the audience without giving much attention to the absurd attitudes of Fir'aun after the first question.

The role of media in the story of Musa *(AS)*

In the same story, we notice Prophet Musa's *(AS)* desire to affect people in the best possible way, where he says to *Fir'aun*, **" (Musa) said: "Even if I bring you something manifest (and convincing)?"(TMQ, 26:30).** What does that mean? It was magic, which was the best means to affect people in the time of Prophet Musa *(AS)* as we have said (exactly as the role of poets in the time of Prophet *(SAWS)* or the role of media personnel in our time).

Also we see how the 'party of the Wrong' (Fir'aun and his soldiers) also focuses on feeding public opinion. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as **"They said: "Put**

him off and his brother (for a while), and send callers to the cities". (TMQ, 26:36). They want this confrontation to be public **" And it was said to the people: "Are you (too) going to assemble?"(TMQ, 26:39).**

Prophet Ibrahim *(AS)* and the preaching dialogue

In Prophet Ibrahim's *(SAWS)* story, we find another style of dialogue, which the Surah teaches us. He starts with a rational dialogue in confronting them saying: **"He said: "Do they hear you, when you call on (them)? Or do they benefit you or do they harm (you)?"(TMQ, 26:72-73).** Because their reply was weak, he says: **"He said: "Do you observe that which you have been worshipping - You and your ancient fathers? Verily they are enemies to me, save the Lord of the 'Alamin (mankind, jinn and all that exists)"(TMQ, 26:75-77).**

When Prophet Ibrahim *(SAWS)* mentions Allah the Great and Almighty, he elaborates by mentioning the attributes of Allah (*SWT*) **"Who has created me, and it is He Who guides me. And it is He Who feeds me and gives me to drink. And when I am ill, it is He who cures me. And Who will cause me to die, and then will bring me to life (again). And Who, I hope, will forgive me my faults on the Day of Recompense, (the Day of Resurrection)". (TMQ, 26:78-82).**

Because the Qur'an is the core of the Prophet's *(SAWS)* preaching, we find that the Ayahs that spoke about the Qur'an in the Surah, show how it considerably affect people. At the very the beginning, we read Allah *(SWT)* saying what can be translated as **"These are the Verses of the manifest Book (this Qur'an)."(TMQ, 26:2).**

At the end of the Surah, and after the stories of the Prophets (Peace be upon them all), Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as: **"In the plain Arabic language"**. (TMQ, Surat Ash-Shuara 195). The language and rhetoric used should be suitable for the context in which the people lived. Hence, Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as: **"And if We had revealed it (this Qur'an) unto any of the non-Arabs, and he had recited it unto them, they would not have believed in it". (TMQ, 26:198-199).**

The Ayahs of the Surah are very clear in guiding Muslims and callers to the way of Allah *(SWT)* to use the best and clearest means for preaching in any given time and place.

Media devoted for the cause of Allah *(SWT)*

Dear Muslim brother, when you read Surat Ash-Shu'ara, always remember that media should be one of the means used in preaching, it should not be used to promote sins, temptations and fornication; this is the Surah's first message for mass media. The second one is addressed to the whole *Ummah* (Nation), especially callers to the way of Allah *(SWT)*: that is by using the more influential ways in their address to people, taking as a model the distinguished dialogue of Allah's *(SWT)* apostles with their people within the Surah.

The Surah was called Ash-Shu'ara, in order to use the best means in performing *Da'wa* (Call to Allah). In addition, the Surah cautions against using double-edged means (media being one of them) in disobeying Allah *(SWT)*. Instead, they should be

used to obey Him. Let the Prophets Ibrahim (AS), Musa (AS), and Mohammad *(SAWS)* be our examples in the way their distinguished and influential dialogues guide people.

Surat An-Naml (The Ant)

Surat An-Naml is a Makkan. It comes after Surat Ash-Shu'ara both in the order of revelation and in the order of the Qur'an. It consists of 93 ayahs

Surah of civilization excellence

Surat An-Naml talks about the civilization excellence : it evokes the idea that Muslims should own a powerful civilization through science, technology, military and material power in order to defend and protect Allah's *(SWT)* religion. The Surah addresses those who believe that Islam is only about praying, shedding tears (symbolizing submission to and fear from Allah) and reciting Qur'an. These acts are important, yet they should be associated with the means that enable Muslims to lead the world and manage it in accordance with Allah's *(SWT)* methodology. Moreover, Muslims' civilization excellence, scientific and technological progress help in Da'wa (call to Allah) (by encouraging people to embrace Islam). Da'wa produces much more impact on people than if the Muslims were in a situation of failure. In brief, the Surah tells the *Ummah* (nation) of Prophet Muhammad *(SAWS)*, you will not gain the respect of other nations nor will you play a leading role unless you have civilization excellence and catch up with state-of –the-art-technology.

Thus, we notice that every Qur'anic Surah conveys a clear message to Muslims, completing the Qur'anic Surahs exhibition of Allah's *(SWT)* Method and showing us how the Qur'an Surahs are connected to one another to form an integral structure. After Surat Ash-Shu'ara, which highlights the pivotal role that media plays, comes Surat An-Naml, which underlines the importance of civilization excellence. Both serve the same goal, which is the importance of civilization excellence and the use of all the means in this world (material or technological) for the Muslims to reach supremacy and to be influential in relation to other civilizations.

The successful establishment

The symbol of civilization excellence in this Surah is Solaiman (*AS*) (Solomon) and his kingdom, which combined faith and success in life. Such establishment corresponds to what is known today as a multinational company, it employs different types of creatures: people, Jinn, birds, ants and animals. Let us then consider the details of civilization excellence in Solaiman's (*AS*) kingdom and how the story, in its exacting detail treat the different aspects and dimensions of civilization excellence and success in life:

1. **Underlining the importance of knowledge**

"And indeed We already brought Dawud (David) and Solaiman (Solomon) knowledge…" (TMQ, 27:15). There is no superiority without science. A Muslim student cannot serve Islam unless he/she was successful in his studies at school and university because this is the essence of Islam. **"And they (both) said, "Praise be to Allah, Who has graced us over many of His believing bondmen." (TMQ, 27:15).** Favored them with what? With knowledge of course and He also gave them another favor, which is recognizing the value of the grace of knowledge and thanking Allah *(SWT)* for it. The nation whose students cheat

in order to pass the exams and obtain degrees and certificates do not appreciate the value of knowledge, it can never be revived or compete with other nations.

2. **Passing on to successive generations**

"And Solaiman was Dawud's heir." **(TMQ, 27: 16)** so that success would not be restricted to a certain generation. It should rather be inherited and preserved by successive generations to guarantee the persistence of superiority and the compiling of experiences within the establishment.

3. **Mastering languages**

"…he said, "O you mankind, we have been taught the language (Literally: the manner of pronunciation) of (the) birds," (TMQ, 27: 16). Mastering foreign languages facilitates communication and interaction with others from other civilizations.

4. **Abundance of potentials**

"…and we have been brought (much) of everything; surely this is indeed the evident Grace." (TMQ, 27:16). Solaiman's *(AS)* kingdom had been granted human and natural resources and it did its best to preserve and develop them.

5. **Clever administration right management**

"And his hosts were mustered to Solaiman," (TMQ, 27: 17) Sulaiman's *(AS)* great kingdom was rather a multinational company or say a "multi-creature" company. All creatures are there **"of the jinn and humankind and birds. So they were duly dispensed. " (TMQ, 27: 17).** It was composed of humans, jinns, birds, animals, and many other creatures. The word 'marshaled', denotes the huge number and the variety of such soldiers. Accurate organization and job description is clear in Allah's *(SWT)* words in what can be translated as, **"So they were duly dispensed." (TMQ, 27:17).** All creatures play their roles in accordance with their skills and potentials.

6. **Training**

"Till, when they came up to the Valley of Ants," (TMQ, 27:19) what is the relationship between this journey to the ant's valley and Solaiman *(AS),* his soldiers and the order of his kingdom? Such a company trains its staff; Solaiman *(AS)* trains them takes them to different places. The holy ayah describes part of their training. During their tour, they reached the valley of the ants, where a dialogue between the ant and its companions took place, **"… an ant said, "O you ants, enter your dwellings so that Solaiman and his hosts would not definitely crush you, (while) they are not aware." (TMQ, 27: 18).**

7. **Strictness and determination**

The Surah depicts strictness and determination in dealing with members in Solaiman's *(AS)* institution. The call is made before each meeting. The ayah can be translated as, **"And he reviewed the birds; then he said, "What is it with me that I do not see the hoopoe? Or is he among the absent? Indeed I will definitely**

torment him with a strict torment or indeed I will definitely slay him, or indeed he should definitely come up to me with an evident, all-binding authority." (TMQ, 27: 20, 21). Solaiman *(AS)* not only asked where the hoopoe was but asked also for the reason for his absence which, in fact, shows how orderly was the kingdom. The hoopoe is a tiny soldier; his absence doesn't really affect the army's power but violates the discipline in Solaiman's kingdom and should thus be strictly reprimanded.

Members devotion to the mission

Solaiman's *(AS)* story reveals that the kingdom members are not less devoted to their mission than their king. The hoopoe flew from Palestine to Yemen to gather information about a kingdom that worshipped the sun instead of Allah *(SWT),* he stood before the king in boldness and said what can be translated as, **"I have encompassed that which you have not encompassed," (TMQ, 27: 22)** he had studied the situation very well and brought accurate and true information, **"and I have come to thee from Saba to you with a tiding of certitude." (TMQ, 27: 22)** then he continues his speech about the kingdom he saw: **"Surely I found a woman ruling over them, (Literally: a wife possessing them) and she has been brought (much) of everything, and she has a magnificent throne. I found her and her people prostrating to the sun, apart from Allah; and Ash-Shaytan (The ever-vicious, i.e., the Devil) has adorned (i.e., made attractive) their deeds to them, so has barred them from the way, so that they are not guided, (TMQ, 27: 23, 24).** He does not behave as a normal employee; rather he felt that he was responsible for the company's mission, its affairs and its goal. He wondered in agony and jealousy, **"So that they do not prostrate (themselves) to Allah, Who brings out what is hidden in the heavens and the earth. And He knows whatever you conceal and whatever you make public." (TMQ, 27: 25).**

Then he remembered that he had said about the queen in what can be translated as, **"she has a magnificent throne"** so he quickly add what can be translated as**, "Allah, there is no god except He, The Lord of the Magnificent Throne." (TMQ, 27: 26).** If only we had in the nation of Mohammad *(SAWS)* a thousand hoopoes like Solaiman's *(AS).* A hoopoe, positive in his actions, devoted to his nation and feeling responsibility towards it.

Accuracy in conveying information

The ayahs continue to display the pleasant dialogue between the hoopoe and Solaiman (AS) **"(Solaiman) said, "We will soon look whether you have (spoken) sincerely or whether you are among the liars." (TMQ, 27: 27).** This means that the information brought was analyzed and examined although the hoopoe told Solaiman *(AS)* before, **"…and I have come from Sabato to you with a tiding of certitude." (TMQ, 27: 22)** but the successful company must scrutinize and check the information validity before any decision-making. **"Go with this book (i.e., letter) of mine, then cast it to them; thereafter turn away from them, (and) so look what (answer) they return." (TMQ, 27: 28).** Thus Solaiman *(AS)* examined the people of that kingdom. Muslims should learn from Solaiman's *(AS)* kingdom what success, organization and knowledge really means.

***Shoorah* (consultation) is the pivot of success**

On the other hand, there is another example of success in the kingdom of Sheba. The reason behind its success is the queen's consultation of the people; she does not take any decision without consulting them. This ayah can be translated as, **"She said, "O you chiefs, pronounce to me concerning my command; in no way have I affirmed (Literally: cutting) a command until you bear witness." (TMQ, 27: 32).** Although the queen did not embrace the right religion of Allah *(SWT),* she used an important element in the fields of administration and management which is consultation. Their response was in what can be translated as, **"They said, "We are endowed with power, and we are endowed with strict violence, (i.e., we are strong and able to fight) and the command (rests) with you; so look into what you command (us)." (TMQ, 27:33).** Unlike the determined hoopoe who was precise in his judgment and decision concerning the case he is dedicated for, Sheba's army was indecisive. Compare that to an army within which a member says what can be translated as, **"I have encompassed that which you have not encompassed**," (TMQ, 27: 22) which is the essence of consultation and victory, and an army within which a member says what can be translated as, **"…and the command (rests) with you; so look into what you command (us)." (TMQ, 27: 33).**

Divine civilization

The Queen of Sheba wanted to examine the real intentions of Solaiman *(AS)* in what can be translated as, **"And surely I am sending to them a present, so I am waiting to look into what the emissaries return with." (TMQ, 27: 35**). However Solaiman *(AS)* became angry and said what can be translated as, **"Would you supply me with wealth? Then what Allah has brought me is more charitable (i.e., better) than what He has brought you. No indeed, (but) you exult with your present." (TMQ, 27: 36).** He undertakes a divine mission and he does not seek to accumulate riches. He did not use the means of success and civilization excellence to oppress nations and rob wealth but he wished to use it to convey Allah's *(SWT)* message to all people.

Technological excellence

Solaiman's kingdom had an unequal military power in what can be translated as, **"Return to them. So indeed we will definitely come up against them with hosts they cannot withstand (Literally: of no withstanding). Indeed, we will definitely drive them out there from humiliated, and they will be (utterly) belittled." (TMQ, 27: 37).** The ayah reflects the elements of civilization excellence that Solaiman's *(AS)* kingdom excelled in, such as : efficient management and strong military power. There is also another important element, which lead to the astonishment of the Queen of Sheba and her embracing Islam.

Her throne arrived before her

As soon as Solaiman *(AS)* knew that the queen was coming to negotiate with him he asked his soldiers to bring him her throne, as stated in the ayah that can be translated as, **"He said, "O you chiefs, whichever one of you will come up to me with (i.e., bring) her throne before they come up to me as Muslims?" (Or: in surrender). (TMQ, 27:38).** A jinn and a man of knowledge competed to bring the throne as

quickly as possible. Such a religious kingdom controlled and the whole earth and attained supremacy.

When the Queen arrived she was asked what can be translated as, **"Is your throne just like this?" (TMQ, 27: 42) "She said, " (It is) as though it were the (very) one." (TMQ, 27:42).** She replied in a diplomatic and ambiguous way so that she would not seem not to recognize her throne, which was looking slightly different, and not to take the risk to say it's hers and thus be considered as a liar. Wonders strongly affected her heart and rendered her ready to accept Islam.

The power of science led her to embrace Islam

Ayah (44) comes at the end of Solaiman's story to sum its core and its objective. One should actually listen to it by feeling it with one's heart and mind. This is made clear in what can be translated as, **"Enter the tower." Then as soon as she saw it, she reckoned it a pool, and she uncovered both her shanks." (TMQ, 27: 44)** She did so because the palace was built on water and its entrance was covered with glass so she tucked up her skirt, as she was afraid of getting wet. **"He said, "Surely it is a tower smoothed of crystal.""" (TMQ, 27:44).** Thanks to Solaiman's kingdom full grasp of technology of that age his palace was steady on the surface of the water and its reception was covered with transparent glass. So pure was the glass that the Queen pulled up her dress lest it should get wet. Amazed by such outstanding capabilities and civilization excellence, the Queen embraced Islam. as stated in what can be translated as, **"She said, "Lord! Surely I have done injustice to myself, and I (now) surrender (i.e., I am a Muslim) with Solaiman to Allah, The Lord of the worlds."(TMQ, 27: 44).**

Pharaoh and the civilization excellence

Just before the story of Solaiman *(AS),* the Surah briefly depicted, along seven ayahs, how Pharaoh and his people rejected Musa's *(AS)* message because Musa *(AS)* did not possess such aspects of civilization that Solaiman *(AS)* had. This is revealed in the ayah which can be translated as, **"Then as soon as Our signs came to them, a beholding, (i.e., as a proof from Allah) they said, "This is evident sorcery." (TMQ, 27: 13).** This is to stress the influential power of development and science and that people follow whosoever posses knowledge and technology.

Elements of Civilization Excellence

The Sublime Target

It is clearly manifested in Solaiman's *(AS)* words, **"Lord! Dispense me to thank (You) for Your favor wherewith You have favored me and (both) my parents, and to do righteousness that satisfies You, and cause me to enter by Your mercy, among Your righteous bondmen." (TMQ, 27: 19).** And in his words, **"This is of the Grace of my Lord that He may try me, whether I thank (Him) or be ungrateful" (TMQ, 27: 40).** He thanked Allah *(SWT)* for such blessings by using them to spread faith on earth.

Knowledge

"And indeed We already brought Dawud (David) and Solaiman (Solomon) knowledge" (TMQ, 27: 15). As there is no civilization without knowledge and scientific excellence and what is more important is their perception of the value of knowledge.

State- of-the-Art Technology

"It was said to her, "Enter the tower." Then as soon as she saw it, she reckoned it a pool, and she uncovered both her shanks." (TMQ, 27: 44).

Strong Military Power

"Return to them. So indeed we will definitely come up against them with hosts they cannot withstand" (TMQ, 27: 37).

Feeling of responsibility

The hoopoe's journey to the kingdom of Sheba for the sake of *Da'wa* (missionary activity) is a perfect example.

Looking back at the previous elements, how many of them do our Islamic nation possess? I would like to ask the readers of the Qur'an: what have you done to build up a successful nation like that of Solaiman *(AS)*?

Allah's might and power is always superior

The brilliance of the Qur'an, in its presenting of the elements of civilization excellence is quite obvious in Surat An-Naml. Although the Surah focuses on substantial means and elements of success, it uses miracles as examples: A fluently speaking hoopoe and a wise ant that advises its companions. Moreover there are Solaiman's (AS) words in what can be translated as, **"we have been taught the language of birds," (TMQ, 27: 16)**. By the end of the Surah Allah *(SWT)* the Almighty says what can be translated as, **"And when the Saying befalls them, We will bring out for them from the earth a beast that will speak to them that mankind had no certitude in Our signs." (TMQ, 27: 82).** Miracles are mentioned abundantly in the Surah so that people may not be utterly materialistic in adopting means of progress and civilization excellence. The Surah seems to be warning man against being completely taken away by civilization, forgetting that only Allah *(SWT)* grants such success and that there are other reasons for development linked to faith and the unseen other than what came in the Surah.

Can there be another god besides Allah (*SWT*)?

The Surah then shifts from talking about civilization excellence to displaying Allah's *(SWT)* power in the universe so that man may not be lured by civilization, forgets his God and live a materialistic life, void of soul as in the western civilization. We find wonderful Ayahs that warmly address the heart and awaken it from its slumber to get acquainted with his Lord.

Say, **"Praise be to Allah, and peace be on His bondmen whom He has elected." Is Allah Most Charitable, or whatever they associate (with Him)? (TMQ, 27:59) .**

"Is not He the (Most Charitable) Who created the heavens and the earth and sent down for you from the heaven water? So We caused to grow therewith-enclosed orchards, full (Literally: owing, comprising) of delight. In no way can you germinate its trees. Is there a god with Allah? No indeed, (but) they are a people who (unjustly) set up equals to Him." (TMQ, 27: 60).

The beauty and order in the world's creation surpasses any civilization excellence **"Is not He (Most Charitable) Who made the earth a residence, and made amidst it rivers, and made for it anchorages, (i.e., firm mountains) and made a partition between the two seas? Is there a god with Allah? No indeed, (but) most of them do not know." (TMQ, 27: 61).**

Don't be proud of your power and strength, Man: **Is not He (Most Charitable) Who answers the constrained person when he invokes Him, and lifts off odious (happenings) and makes you successors of the earth? Is there a god with Allah? Little is that of which you are mindful. (TMQ, 27: 62).**

Is not He (Most Charitable) Who guides you in the darkness's of the land and the sea and Who sends the winds, bearing good tidings before (Literally: between the two Hands of) His mercy? Is there a god with Allah? Supremely Exalted be Allah above whatever they associate (with Him). Is not He (Most Charitable) Who begins creation, (and) thereafter He brings it back again, and Who provides you from the heaven and the earth? Is there a god with Allah? Say, "Offer your proof, in case you are sincere." (TMQ, 27: 63-64).

Thus, balance is established between civilization excellence and faith in Allah *(SWT),* the Owner of the universe who has indeed power and authority over everything.

Why call it "the ants"?

Although the ants were mentioned in only one ayah, the Surah, which tackles civilization excellence, was called An-Naml (ants), why? The ants' kingdom give an example of civilization excellence in a nation of insects, which possesses all means of development: building storehouses, organizing their armies, as well as exits and entrances. They even use centralized air conditioning systems in their dwellings. It is an organized nation, which has surpassed other nations through science and technology and became worthy of being mentioned in the Qur'an as a model of civilization excellence.

People usually belittle ants, so Allah *(SWT)* chose them as an example and ordered us to imitate them. Every time one reads the Surah, one may be reminded of how this tiny weak insect could achieve such progress and over stepped many insects while you Muslim left other civilizations to over step you?

The ant's wisdom and positiveness

Amazingly, the core ayah of the Surah (the ayah where the ant addresses its fellow ants) contained marvelous notes about civilization to be learned from a small ant in what can be translated as, **"Till, when they came up to the Valley of Ants, an ant said, "O you ants, enter your dwellings so that Solaiman and his hosts would not definitely crush you, (while) they are not aware." (TMQ, 27:18).**

The ant positively addressed its companions and did not flee although it risked dying under the feet of Solaiman's *(AS)* soldiers. Its care for its companions exceeded its fear for her life. Moreover, its speech contained marvelous hints at the qualities of leadership and management. It told them what to do before warning them against the danger so that they may not panic (**get into your habitations**), then she expressed the problem and type of danger they are facing lest Solaiman *(AS)* and his hosts crush you (under foot). People in times of danger don't think and this causes lot of damages. Thus, the efficient leader had to give the solution before describing the problem so that the people would grasp his directives while being in a calm state of mind to accept orders and carry them out.

It also knew Solaiman's *(AS)* reputation, it assured its companions that Solaiman *(AS)* and his soldiers could never intentionally harm them in what can be translated as, **"without knowing it." (TMQ, 27:18)**. This was why Solaiman *(AS)* smiled when he heard it. This little ant is a good example of leadership in emergencies, which marks civilization excellence.

Surat Al-Qasas (The Narrative)

This Surah is Makkan, yet some of its ayahs were revealed during hijra (Prophet Muhammad's *(SAWS)* emigration from Makkah to Madinah). It comes after Surat An-Naml both in the order of the Qur'an and that of revelation. It consists of 88 ayahs.

Serious moments

Some of the ayahs of the Surah were revealed when Prophet Muhammad *(SAWS)* was migrating from Makkah to Madinah with tears in his eyes for leaving it and saying: "Allah knows that you are the most beloved country to my heart, had it not been that your people expelled me, I wouldn't have ever left you".

In such difficult circumstances, Surat Al-Qasas was revealed to give the Prophet *(SAWS)* and the believers' important guidelines on Da'wa.

A Prophet's experience

The main topic of Surat Al-Qasas is the story of Musa *(AS)* focusing on certain aspects of his story: His birth, being thrown in the river, being raised in Pharaoh's palace, leaving Egypt to Madyan, his marriage to Shu 'aib's (Jethro) *(AS)* daughter, his return to his homeland after ten years, his victory over Pharaoh. The whole Surah is a comment on all those stories and another story which is that of Qaroon(Korah).

It is noteworthy that Surat Al-Qasas, unlike the other Surahs, is the only one in the Qur'an which focuses on Musa's *(AS)* life away from the Children of Israel. Thus, what is the aim of the Surah? And what is the link between the events of Musa's *(AS)* story and Prophet Muhammad's *(SAWS)* hijra?

For We shall restore him to thee…will bring thee, back to the place of return

The Surah addresses Prophet Muhammad *(SAWS)* while leaving Mecca assuring him that he will return to it victoriously after leaving it secretly. There is an analogy between Allah's *(SWT)* promise to Musa's *(AS)* mother in the ayah which can be translated as, **"For We shall restore him to thee, and We shall make him one of Our Messengers" (TMQ, 28: 7)** and Allah's *(SWT)* promise to Prophet Muhammad *(SAWS)* in what can be translated as, **"Verily He Who ordained the Qur'an for thee, will bring thee, back to the Place of Return. Say: "My Lord knows best who it is that brings true guidance, and who is in manifest error.""(TMQ, 28: 85).** The story of Musa *(AS)* starts from ayah 7 with Allah's *(SWT)* promise for Musa's *(AS)* mother, which was fulfilled by the end of the story. Then came the promise to the Prophet *(SAWS)* that Allah will bring him to back to Makkah victorious although he left it secretly and Allah *(SWT)* used the same word (bring back) in the promise as if He wants to say: That He who has fulfilled his promise to Musa and his mother will bring you back to Makkah victorious.

The objective of the Surah, hence, is to trust Allah's *(SWT)* promise and to be cocksure that it will come true no doubt no matter how long it takes or how difficult circumstances are.

A promise

On the one hand, Musa *(AS)* had left Egypt for eight years and added two years as she got married with Shu 'aib's daughter. Shu'aib then told him what can be translated as, **"I intended to wed one of these my daughters to thee, on condition that thou serve me for eight years; but if thou complete ten years, it will be (grace) from thee. But I intend not to place thee under a difficulty: thou wilt find me, indeed, if Allah wills, one of the righteous."" (TMQ, 28: 27)**. Consequently, he then returned to Egypt after ten years. Prophet Muhammad *(SAWS),* on the other hand, victoriously conquered Makkah eight years after hijra and the Mission of Islam was completed in the tenth year. Both promises are the same and were fulfilled in exactly the same interval of time and under the same difficult conditions. Musa *(AS)* fearfully left Egypt as he was warned in what can be translated as, **"the Chiefs are taking counsel together about thee, to slay thee so get thee away, for I do give thee sincere advice" (TMQ, 28: 20).** Prophet Muhammad *(SAWS)* secretly left Makkah by night after the disbelievers had conspired to kill him.

Such similar incidents raise a question : Are we really confident about Allah's *(SWT)* victory? Allah *(SWT)* promised us that He will grant us victory in what can be translated as, **"Allah has promised, to those among you who believe and work righteous deeds, that He will, of a surety, grant them in the land, inheritance (of power), as He granted it to those before them; that He will establish in authority their religion, the one which He has chosen for them; and that He will change (their state), after the fear in which they (lived), to one of security and peace: `They will worship Me (alone) and not associate aught with Me.' If any do reject Faith after this, they are rebellious and wicked." (TMQ, 24: 55).** It is a promise among many of Allah's promises *(SWT)* like this one which can be translated as, **"for We shall restore him to thee"** (TMQ, 28: 7) and that one which can be translated as "**and Verily He Who ordained the Qur'an for thee, will bring thee, back to the Place of Return." (TMQ, 28: 85)** It is a promise made by Allah *(SWT)* and will be fulfilled just like the above cited ones (even if it takes eight or ten years or even more). After reading Surat Al-Qasas, do we really have faith that Allah *(SWT)* will grant us victory?

The cost of Da'wa

The fulfillment of Allah's *(SWT)* promise requires many sacrifices and self-struggle on the side of the *Da'ia* (the one who makes Da'wa). That is why the Surah pointed out the change in the place of Da'wa as in the story of Musa *(AS)* and the Prophet *(SAWS)* which is clear in the ayah which can be translated as, **"They say: "If we were to follow the guidance with thee, we should be snatched away from our land."" (TMQ, 28: 57).** The road of da'wa is not an easy one because it is full of sacrifices and leaving the homeland

But at its end there is glory and victory.

The will of Allah *(SWT)* the will of falsehood

One may learn from Surat Al–Qasas how to trust Allah's *(SWT)* promise. In the third ayah only the believers were addressed because they are the ones who believe in Allah's *(SWT)* promise in what can be translated as, **"We rehearse to thee some of the story of Musa and Fir'aun in Truth, for people who believe" (TMQ, 28: 3).** In the forth ayah we find out that Musa *(AS)* and the believers with him were in a difficult situation just like Prophet Muhammad *(SAWS)* in what can be translated as, **"Truly Fir'aun elated himself in the land and broke up its people into sections, depressing a small group among them: their sons he slew, but he kept alive their females: for he was indeed a maker of mischief." (TMQ, 28: 4).**

Few words portraying Pharaoh's power and the Children's of Israel's weakness. However, the fifth ayah brings Allah's *(SWT)* promise in what can be translated as, precaution **"And We wished to be gracious to those who were being depressed on the land, to make them leaders (in faith) and make them heirs" and another greater promise of power "To establish a firm place for them in the land, and to show Fir'aun, Haman, and their hosts, at their hands, the very things against which they were wary." (TMQ, 28: 5,6).** Such was Pharaoh's will and Allah's *(SWT)* will. Will Allah's *(SWT)* will come true?

Musa's *(AS)* mother

After the ayahs which portray Pharaoh's oppression and the ayahs of Allah's *(SWT)* promised victory, the seventh ayah says what can be translated as, **"So We sent this inspiration to the mother of Musa: "Suckle (thy child)," (TMQ, 28: 7)** as if this verse marks the beginning of promise's fulfillment, how?

After referring to Pharaoh's power and oppression and hinting at the necessity for change, the Surah moves to completely a different situation : a mother feeding her child, so what is the link? This states that victory starts from mothers who feed their children, with the milk, adhering to religion and trust in Allah's *(SWT)* promise. What is wonderful about such an ayah is that it did not tell Musa's *(AS)* mother: (when thou hast fears about him, hide him) or (embrace him) but it said what can be translated as, **"but when thou hast fears about him, cast him into the river," (TMQ, 28: 7)** it is meant to tell her 'throw him into the river and have trust in Allah *(SWT)*, why? Because He says what can be translated as, **"for We shall restore him to thee, and We shall make him one of Our Messengers."" (TMQ, 28: 7)**. It is the story a nation's birth, which started with a child thrown into the river and a mother's trust in Allah's *(SWT)* promise.

Women's role in the defense of religion

Surat Al-Qasas highlights women's role in bringing victory to religion. The main leading figures in the Surah who helped Musa *(AS)* carrying out his role were four women: the first was Musa's *(AS)* mother in what can be translated as, **"So We sent this inspiration to the mother of Musa" (TMQ, 28: 7)** who protected Musa *(AS)* through her behavior which resulted from her deep faith in Allah's *(SWT)* promise. Then was his sister in what can be translated as, **"And she said to the sister of (Musa), "Follow him," so she (the sister) watched him in the character of a stranger, and they knew not. Thus did We restore him to his mother, that her eye might be comforted, that she might not grieve, and that she might know that**

the promise of Allah is true; but most of them do not understand." (TMQ, 28: 11, 13). She was the sister who brought Musa *(AS)* back to his mother. The third was Pharaoh's wife in what can be translated as, **"The wife of Fir'aun said: "(Here is) a joy of the eye, for me and for thee: Slay him not. It may be that he will be of use to us, or we may adopt him as a son."" (TMQ, 28: 9).** The fourth was Shu 'aib's daughter whom he married in what can be translated as, **"She said: "My father invites thee that he may reward thee for having watered (our flocks) for us."" (TMQ, 28: 25).** She was even the one who suggested this idea to her father in what can be translated as, **""O my (dear) father! Engage him on wages: truly the best of men for thee to employ is the (man) who is strong and trusty."" (TMQ, 28: 26).** Those four women played a pivotal role in Musa's *(AS)* life with the help of Allah the Almighty.

Similarly in the life of Prophet Muhammad *(SAWS)* women played a very significant role such as: Khadijah *(RA)* who supported Prophet Muhammad *(SAWS)* with her money and love; Umm Salama, Aisha *(RA)* and the rest of the Mothers of the believers, not to mention Somaiya, the first martyr in Islam, Fatima, Prophet Muhammad's *(SAWS)* daughter and the mistress of all women. Hence, it is clear how the lives of both Prophets are quite similar. Some incidents are even close to today's events. This all conveys the same meaning: "Muslims have faith in Allah's *(SWT)* promise."

The fulfillment of the promise

Surat Al-Qasas contains seven promises made by Allah *(SWT)* as follows:
Allah says in what can be translated as, **"So We sent this inspiration to the mother of Musa: "Suckle (thy child), but when thou hast fears about him, cast him into the river, but fear not nor grieve: for We shall restore him to thee, and We shall make him one of Our Messengers.""** **(TMQ, 28: 7)** which contains two promises; (We shall restore him to thee) and (We shall make him one of Our Messengers). The first was fulfilled as the ayah says what can be translated as, **"Thus did We restore him to his mother, that her eye might be comforted, that she might not grieve, and that she might know that the promise of Allah is true; but most of them do not understand." (TMQ, 28: 13).** This to assure Musa's *(AS)* mother, Prophet Muhammad *(SAWS)*, you, me and the whole nation of Islam that Allah *(SWT)* never fails to fulfill His promises and that His religion will be always victorious no doubt. But where are those who will sacrifice and move like Musa's *(AS)* mother and the Prophet *(SAWS)* to bring victory to this religion?

The second promise **(We shall make him one of Our Messengers)** was fulfilled as mentioned in ayah number 30 in what can be translated as, **"But when he came to the (Fire), a voice was heard from the right bank of the valley, from a tree in hallowed ground: "O Musa! Verily I am Allah, the Lord of the Worlds...." (TMQ, 28: 30).** Allah *(SWT)* also gives a guarantee when he says what can be translated as, **"they shall not be able to touch you" (TMQ, 28: 35)** and His promise was fulfilled in what can be translated as, **"So We seized him and his hosts, and We flung them into the sea: now behold what was the End of those who did wrong!" (TMQ, 28: 40),**

We notice that there is always a long or a short span of time between the promise and its fulfillment : may be ten or forty years according to the will of Allah *(SWT).*

The Adhan (call for prayers) of sovereignty on the day of conquering Makkah

Allah *(SWT)* promised Prophet Muhammad *(SAWS)* that he will conquer Makkah and fulfilled His promise and Prophet Muhammad *(SAWS)* returned to Makkah. Bilal *(RA)* called for prayers (Azan), the idols were destroyed and the companions kept repeating Allah's *(SWT)* words in what can be translated as, **"And say: "Truth has (now) arrived, and Falsehood perished: for Falsehood is (by its nature) bound to perish."" (TMQ, 17: 81)** and what can be translated as, **"Verily We have granted thee a manifest Victory" (TMQ, 48: 1).**

Allah's *(SWT)* promise about defeating Persians and Romans was fulfilled as in His words that can be translated as, **"Allah has promised, to those among you who believe and work righteous deeds, that He will, of a surety, grant them in the land, inheritance (of power), as He granted it to those before them; that He will establish in authority their religion, the one which He has chosen for them; and that He will change (their state), after the fear in which they (lived), to one of security and peace: `They will worship Me (alone) and not associate aught with Me." (TMQ, 24: 55).**

Amaar Ibn-Yassir

The Divine promise was fulfilled in the fifth ayah in what can be translated as, **"And We wished to be gracious to those who were being depressed on the land, to make them leaders (in faith) and make them heirs," (TMQ, 28: 5)** not only for the children of Israel but also fulfilled to a great companion that is Amaar Ibn- Yassir *(RA).* When Omar Ibn- Al-Khattab *(RA)* appointed Amaar Ibn-Yassir *(RA)* to be ruler of Iraq and sent with him an assistant. Although Amaar *(RA)* was unqualified for this post, he assumed it for a whole month then Omar *(RA)* brought him back to Madinah. When asked why he chose Amaar Omar replied, "In Allah's book I found regarding all of Allah's promises have been fulfilled for us and the whole nation of Muhammad *(SAWS)* and I read Allah's promise", **"And We wished to be gracious to those who were being depressed on the land, to make them leaders (in faith) and make them heirs," (TMQ, 28: 5)** and you Amaar are one of those weak people and I wanted people to see Allah's promise being fulfilled; so go I have appointed you a ruler of Iraq for a month so that people might watch Allah's promise coming true"

Soraqa Ibn-Malik and Chosroes' bracelets

Prophet Muhammad's *(SAWS)* trust in Allah's *(SWT)* promise was also very obvious during Hijra. When Prophet Muhammad *(SAWS)* was being chased and Soraqa followed him to either kill or capture him to win the award from Quraysh (100 camels). However, every time he tried to approach Prophet Muhammad *(SAWS)* he would fall off his horse even though he was a brilliant knight. Soraqa says, "I then knew that he was a protected man", means that there was something hindering him. He asked for peace and said, " I wanted to arrest you Muhammad but I couldn't and I wanted to win the award so give me something (that may compensate him for losing

the award). Prophet Muhammad *(SAWS)* promised Soraqa that he would, one day be given Chosroes' Bracelets and asked Abu-Bakr *(RA)* to write to Soraqa a note guaranteeing his right. Why didn't he promise him to give him a dates harvest or some money? Why Chosroes' bracelets? It is Prophet Muhammad's *(SAWS)* confidence in Allah's *(SWT)* promise.

Soraqa kept the note until the time of Omar Ibnul-Khattab's *(RA)* Caliphate. Persia then was conquered and Muslims took the treasures of Chosroes and brought them to the mosque. Omar *(RA)* ascended the pulpit and said, "Where is Soraqa?" and there he came an old man and said, "Yes Oh prince of the believers", so Omar *(RA)* said, "Here you are, these are Chosroes' bracelets your promise which the Prophet *(SAWS)* has promised you when he was alive." The whole mosque burst into tears and turned their eyes to the Prophet's *(SAWS)* house who was true in what he promised. May peace and blessings be upon Muhammad. So Muslims trust in Allah's *(SWT)* promise like your Prophet *(SAWS)* did.

Allah Showed Me the Earth

Just as he promised Soraqa with Chosroes' bracelets he has promised us and said that Allah showed him the earth and that he could see that the sovereignty of his Ummah will reign. Surat Al-Qasas tells us how to realize this in what can be translated as, **"That House of the Hereafter We shall give to those who intend not high-handedness or mischief on earth: and the End is (best) for the righteous" (TMQ, 28: 83).** Those who deserve to reign the world and lead humanity are those who do not seek high-handedness or mischief. "The end is best for the righteous" means that victory is only for righteous.

Qaroon was high-handed

The ayah that can be translated as, **"That House of the Hereafter We shall give to those who intend not high-handedness or mischief on earth: and the End is (best) for the righteous." (TMQ, 28: 83)** came to comment on the story of Qaroon who to show that Qaroon's power and superiority resulted in his high-handedness and mischief so his end was that he was swallowed by earth in what can be translated as, **"Then We caused the earth to swallow him up and his house; and he had not (the least little) party to help him against Allah, nor could he defend himself." (TMQ, 28: 81).**

Thus the Surah talks about the fulfillment of Allah's *(SWT)* promise for the true believers (the children of Israel, Musa's mother and Musa *(AS)*) **"those who intend not high-handedness or mischief on earth" (TMQ, 28: 83)**, that is why Qaroon's story came as example about those who do not intend high-handedness or mischief on earth and to warn us from them.

The name of the Surah

Why was the Surah given this name? The word 'qasas' in language means following up something until the end as in Allah's *(SWT)* words that can be translated as, **"And she said to the sister of (Musa), "Follow him,"" (TMQ, 28: 11),** which means follow up news about him and in the ayah that can be translated as, **"So when he**

came to him and narrated the story," (TMQ, 28: 25) which means he narrated the story from A to Z.

The Surah was so called to show us that if we follow up events till the end we would find that all of them ended with the fulfillment of Allah's *(SWT)* promises and that the end was best for the righteous. The problem with some people is that they do not follow up the story they only see one chain in the struggle between good and evil that is the defeat of the good and think that Allah's *(SWT)* promise will not be fulfilled. Thus, from now on every time you come across the word "Qasas" remember the end of the stories of this holy Surah and remember that Allah's *(SWT)* promise of victory will come true no doubt no matter how long it will take.

Musa *(AS)* in Surat Al-Qasas and Surat Al-Kahf

There is an analogy between the story of Musa *(AS)* in Surat Al-Qasas, and in Surat Al-Kahf. In Surat Al Kahf, Musa *(AS)* was bewildered by what Al-Khidr did when he drowned the ship, killed the boy and showing generosity to the people who refused to host them.

Nevertheless, those three incidents happened to Musa *(AS)* as Surat Al-Qasas says; his mother threw him into the river, he unintentionally killed one of Pharaoh's soldiers, and the father of the two ladies hosted him for ten years.

Thus, what Allah *(SWT)* promised happened in both Surahs in spite of all the hard circumstances because Allah *(SWT)* does as He wishes. Sometimes incidents repeat themselves and what was surprising for you one day may happen to you on another day as explained in the ayah which says what can be translated as, **"Thy Lord does create and choose as He pleases" (TMQ, 28: 68).**

Be sure that Allah *(SWT)* has power over all things and that He is the Owner of the whole universe and runs it the way He wants as explained in this ayah which can be translated as, **"And Allah hath full power and control over His affairs; but most among mankind know it not." (TMQ, 12: 21).**

Qur'anic Reflections

Insights into the objectives of the Qur'anic verses

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Part 3/3

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Surat Al-Ankabut (The Spider)

Surat Al-Ankabut is Makkan. It was revealed after Surat Ar-Rum. It comes after Surat Al-Qasas in the Holy Qur'an. It consists of 69 ayahs.

The objective of the Surah is made clear from the very beginning in what can be translated as, **"Alif-Lâm-Mîm. [These letters are one of the miracles of the Qur'an, and none but Allah (Alone) knows their meanings.] 2. Do people think that they will be left alone because they say: "We believe," and will not be tested…" (TMQ, 1-2:29).** O believers, strive to overcome trials and have fortitude and self-control. Thus, it is the Surah of trials.

These trials are an inevitable part of a Muslim's life. They are a *sunnah* of the universe ordained by Allah (*SWT*) upon earth. Some may ask, 'Why are we sent these trials? Would it not have been better for us to live a peaceful life, praying, fasting and worshipping Allah (*SWT*) with no trials or tragedies?' Those who ask these questions have not understood the Allah's *(SWT)* Wisdom and Intention in creating this world. This world was created as a trial for the hereafter and without these trials, it would not be possible to rank people in [the different levels of] paradise. It would not be possible to distinguish between those who deserve the highest *ferdaws* (the highest level of paradise), those who deserve the lowest level of paradise, and those who do not deserve to enter paradise at all until they pass through some punishment. Accordingly, it is a necessity for the Justice of Allah (*SWT*) to put His Worshippers through trials in order to distinguish the bad from the good.

***Sunnah* of the universe**

As such, the beginning of the Surah is what can be translated as, **"Alif-Lâm-Mîm. [These letters are one of the miracles of the Qur'an, and none but Allah (Alone) knows their meanings.] 2. Do people think that they will be left alone because they say: "We believe," and will not be tested…" (TMQ, 1-2:29).** Is it reasonable to think you are believers just because you say, "We believe" with your lips? Even if you are sincere in saying so, there must be a test, **"and will not be tested…"**

The rule is that believers are put through afflictions so do not assume that they occur to you alone. In fact, the third ayah states that these ordeals are a sunnah of the universe in what can be translated as, **"And We indeed tested those who were before them" (TMQ, 3:29).** Why do You do this Allah *(SWT)*? The answer comes in the same ayah in what can be translated as, **"And Allah will certainly make (it) known (the truth of) those who are true, and will certainly make (it) known (the falsehood of) those who are liars, (although Allah knows all that before putting them to test)" (TMQ, 3:29).** The tests reveal the true believer from those who allege belief. Accordingly, ayah eleven reveals the same meaning in what can be translated as, **"Verily, Allah knows those who believe, and verily, He knows the hypocrites [i.e. Allah will test the people with good and hard days to discriminate the good from the wicked, although Allah knows all that before putting them to test]" (TMQ, 11:29).**

Here, a question presents itself: Would not Allah (*SWT*) know as He is the Knower of the entire Unknown, who will succeed in this trial and endure and who will fall and go astray? Then why the need for affliction? The answer is that Allah (*SWT*) sends these trials so that you humans know, that they can be a proof against you on the Day of Judgment.

It would have been sufficient for Allah (*SWT*) to tell you on the Day of Judgment; "I know that if you had been in such a situation you would have done such and such. Go and enter hellfire." But Allah (*SWT*) with His Wisdom, Mercy and Justice sends us these trials in this life and reckons your actual actions in the hereafter as explained in what can be translated as, **"And Allah will certainly make (it) known (the truth of) those who are true, and will certainly make (it) known (the falsehood of) those who are liars, (although Allah knows all that before putting them to test)" (TMQ, 3:29).**

Do not suppose, Brother in Islam, that this world is effortless and devoid of troubles, even if you are a believer. Faith will not relieve you from the trials of this world and the person is afflicted according to his or her faith. This is why Allah (*SWT*) says in Surat Al-Ankabut that if you crave for Allah's rewards, you should have patience and strive to overcome these trials and tests. Do so until you meet Allah *(SWT)* and He will reward you because meeting Allah (*SWT*) is near and inevitable as is pointed out in what can be translated as, **"Whoever hopes for the Meeting with Allah, then Allah's Term is surely coming and He is the All-Hearer, the All-Knower" (TMQ, 5:29).** It should not come to mind amidst all this talk about trials that Allah (*SWT*) needs your striving. Your striving and endurance are for you alone. Allah (*SWT*) is self-sufficient of our deeds, our worship and of the whole world. We are the insignificant and need Him for everything. Allah *(SWT)* states what can be translated as **"And whosoever strives, he strives only for himself. Verily, Allah stands not in need of any of the 'Alamin (mankind, jinn, and all that exists)" (TMQ, 6:29).**

One of the most crucial trials the Surah discusses is to be tried in our religion (creed), such as when a believer is harmed with the intention to make him deviate from Allah's *(SWT)* religion. The Surah stresses that this is harm, not punishment. However, when judgment is deficient and the scales become unbalanced, the weak believer assumes that people's harm to him is the worst kind of punishment. For this reason, the Surah emphasizes that this assumption is erroneous, for only Allah (*SWT*) can punish as stated in what can be translated as, **"Of mankind are some who say: "We believe in Allah." But if they are made to suffer for the sake of Allah, they consider the trial of mankind as Allah's punishment; and if victory comes from your Lord, (the hypocrites) will say: "Verily we were with you (helping you)." Is not Allah Best Aware of what is in the breasts of the 'Alamin (mankind and jinn)" (TMQ, 10:29)**

The toughest trials

The ayahs in the Surah continue to discuss the same theme. Trials reveal people's beliefs, test what may be hidden in their hearts and expose the true from the false. For this reason, it mentions another trial, that of parents who push their son to move away from obeying Allah (*SWT*), either out of fear for their child or out of arrogance towards Allah's *(SWT)* religion. Allah *(SWT)* states what can be translated as, **"And We have enjoined on man to be good and dutiful to his parents; but if they strive to make you join with Me (in worship) anything (as a partner) of which you have no knowledge, then obey them not. Unto Me is your return and I shall tell you what you used to do" (TMQ, 8:29).** This is a difficult and demanding trial. Will the believer treat his parents righteously despite the fact that they are disbelievers ?

Means of being saved from trials

One of the nice things about the Surah is that it starts off by stating that trials are a part of people's lives and that they are extremely difficult. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Do people think that they will be left alone because they say: "We believe," and will not be tested" (TMQ, 2:29).** Nevertheless, it ends with a wonderful ayah that shows us that trials are in fact easy Allah (*SWT*) will guide and help us to overcome them if we strive against them. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"As for those who strive hard in Us (Our Cause), We will surely guide them to Our Paths (i.e. Allah's religion - Islâmic Monotheism). And verily, Allah is with the Muhsinun (good doers)" (TMQ, 69:29).** This ayah was revealed in Makkah when *jihad* (striving for the cause of Islam with the sword) had not yet been decreed. Thus, this ayah refers to striving against both one's self and trials. As if it says, 'Strive against yourselves, and succeed, then you will guarantee victory over the internal and external enemy.'

The leaders of *Mujahedeen* (fighters for the cause of Allah)

The Surah then relates the story of how the Prophets Nuh *(AS)* (Noah), Ibrahim *(AS)* (Abraham), Lut *(AS)* (Lot), Shu'aib *(AS)* and Musa *(AS)* (Moses) faced trials and strived against them. Looking at the story of Prophet Nuh *(AS)* that was revealed in the Surah, we find that it is the only Surah that mentions the duration of his *da'wa* (call to Allah's *(SWT)* religion) which is nine hundred and fifty years. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"and he stayed among them a thousand years less fifty years [inviting them to believe in the Oneness of Allah (Monotheism), and discard the false gods and other deities]" (TMQ, 14:29).** This shows the believers that trials are inevitable and even the Prophets did not avoid them.

When we know the extent of Prophet Nuh's *(AS)* perseverance and patience it helps us to endure the trials we will face, which are certainly much less than that of the Prophet. Another trial is discussed after that of Prophet Nuh *(AS)* is that of Prophet Ibrahim *(AS)* and his patience with his people when they said, "Kill him or burn him." Then Allah *(SWT)* saved him from the fire. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Verily, in this are indeed signs for a people who believe" (TMQ, 24:29).** This proves to us in a practical way that Allah (*SWT*) assists us in confronting these trials. Nevertheless, we are demanded to go on striving against them as stated in what can be translated as, **"As for those who strive hard in Us (Our Cause), We will surely guide them to Our Paths (i.e. Allah's religion - Islâmic Monotheism). And verily, Allah is with the Muhsinûn (good doers)" (TMQ, 69:29).**

Why Al-Ankabut?

What remains is to discuss the reason for naming the Surah Al-Ankabut. When Allah (*SWT*) sets a similitude through the example of a creature, the objective of the Surah is then based on the example given and the analogy made. For example, Surah An-Naml is the Surah of superiority of civilizations with the ant colony as its symbol. Ant colonies are exceptionally organized and embody the features of a civilization. The purpose of Surat An-Nahl is gratitude for blessings. It shows us how these creatures follow Allah's (*SWT*) commands and produce delicious and beneficial honey that cures people. This proves to us that following the commands of *Shariah* (Islamic doctrine) will bring out the light of guidance, which is a cure for people just like honey. The question of why this Surah discussing trials was named after the spider remains.

Similar to its threads

The reason for this name is that trials are similar to the threads of a spider's web. The nature of trials is that they are intertwisted and interconnected. It is not possible to distinguish between one trial and another. They are many and complicated, covering all aspects of a person's life. Yet they are fragile and weak, if one asks for Allah's *(SWT)* help in facing them. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as**, "But verily, the frailest (weakest) of houses is the spider's house - if they but knew" (TMQ, 41:29).**

Typically, humans rushes quickly to search for a savior when they are put to test through trials. Unfortunately, they usually ask for help from other than Allah (*SWT*) and turn to other humans. This is why Allah (*SWT*) in the Surah tells us that if turn to humans for help order to escape from the trials, you will be as one who sought refuge in a spider's web, a weak, fragile house that does not protect or shelter its occupants. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"The likeness of those who take (false deities as) Auliya' (protectors, helpers) other than Allah is the likeness of a spider who builds (for itself) a house; but verily, the frailest (weakest) of houses is the spider's house - if they but knew" (TMQ, 41:29).** The meaning here is that one of the toughest and most dangerous trials is to satisfy people at the expense of your religion or that you seek help or rely on anyone other than Allah (*SWT*).

The weakest of houses

The spider's web is fragile due to the weakness of its threads and it is also weak from a social standpoint. After the male fertilizes the female, the female kills the male and throws him out of the web. Then, when the spider's offspring become mature, they, in turn, kill the mother and throw her out of the web. What a strange home, the worst it may exist.

The Surah gives the example of the spider to show us that the spider's crowded threads, though complicated they may appear, are similar to trials in the fact that they are both fragile. The example demonstrates that seeking help from anyone other than Allah (*SWT*) is exactly the same as seeking refuge in the spider's web, a place indeed physically and socially fragile. *Sobhan Allah* (Glory be to Allah) for choosing this name for the Surah of trials to warn people against imitating this insect in its life and acts.

Surat Ar-Rum (The Romans)

Surat Ar-Rum is a Makkan. It was revealed after Surat Al-Inshiqaq. It comes after Surat Al-Ankabut in the order of the Qu'ran. It is composed of 60 ayahs.

Allah's signs are clear and sure

The phrase "and among His Signs is," is more frequently used in this Surah than in any other Surah in the Qur'an. This in itself shows the objective of the Surah : 'Allah's signs are clear and sure, so how do still you disbelieve?' Thus, the Surah takes us around the universe all over Allah's *(SWT)* Dominion and reminds us that Allah's *(SWT)* signs are clear enough to boost our faith in His Greatness and Power. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And among His Signs is this, that He created for you wives from among yourselves, that you may find repose in them, and He has put between you affection and mercy. Verily, in that are indeed signs for a people who reflect. And among His Signs is the creation of the heavens and the earth, and the difference of your languages and colors. Verily, in that are indeed signs for men of sound knowledge" (TMQ, 21-22:30).**

The ayahs make clear in a wonderful way that (one is lead to deduce) Allah (*SWT*) has two books in His Dominion: the visual book, that is the universe and the book to be read, namely the Qur'an. The wonder of both books is that they are closely related: the meaning of each of them lead to that of the other. For example, Surat Ar-Rum is a Surah to be read, yet it invites you to look at Allah's *(SWT)* visual book to find evidence of Allah (*SWT*). The more you observe the universe and contemplate it, the more it drives you to Allah's *(SWT)* written book. Glory to the One who made for all kinds of people, illiterate and educated, Arabs and non-Arabs, old and young, a book to read and find evidence of Allah (*SWT*).

Of his signs

The ayahs ensue in a consecutive display of Allah's *(SWT)* clear signs in the universe. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as**, "and among His Signs is the creation of the heavens and the earth, and the difference of your languages and colors. Verily, in that are indeed signs for men of sound knowledge. And among His Signs is your sleep by night and by day, and your seeking of His Bounty . . ." (TMQ, 22-23:30), "And among His Signs is that He shows you the lightning, for fear and for hope, and He sends down water (rain) from the sky, and therewith revives the earth after its death . . ." (TMQ, 24:30), "And among His Signs is that the heaven and the earth stand by His Command . . ." (TMQ, 25:30).**

This Surah consists of 60 ayahs; please verify for yourself how many times the word 'Signs' occurs. After you read this Surah go out to the natural world and ponder Allah's *(SWT)* creation for five minutes. Who created this universe and excelled in creating it? Who made these awesome signs? Who restored husbands' relationships with their wives and created between them love and compassion?

Ayah 46 takes us to another of Allah's *(SWT)* signs. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"and among His Signs is this, that He sends the winds as glad tidings, giving you a taste of His Mercy (i.e. rain) . . ." (TMQ, 46:30)** and another, **"Allah is He Who sends the winds, so that they raise clouds, and spread them along the sky as He wills, and then break them into fragments, until you see rain drops come forth from their midst!"**

(TMQ, 48:30). Even in the creation of the human being Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Allah is He Who created you in (a state of) weakness, then gave you strength after weakness, then after strength gave (you) weakness and grey hair," (TMQ, 54:30).** It is as if this Surah guides you to Allah's *(SWT)* visual book. It tells you, 'look at Allah's *(SWT)* signs and how they surround you from all sides, how can the ungrateful disbeliever not believe them? How can some people doubt Allah's *(SWT)* power?'

The Romans: a historical sign

The question remains why this Surah was named Surat Ar-Rum. The reply is because at the beginning of the Surah Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"The Romans have been defeated," (TMQ, 2:30).** Yet what is the relation between Ar-rum and the Surah? Why wasn't this Surah named the Surah of signs?

The naming of this Surah has historical significance, for during the time of the Prophet (*SAWS*) there was a war between the Romans and the Persians. The Persians were overwhelmingly victorious while the Romans were badly beaten. The ayahs in the Surah inform the believers that the Romans will triumph over the Persians in an odd number of years (i.e. from three to nine years).

Allah (*SWT*) illustrates in the Surah His astounding signs [of creation] in the universe. He addresses those who disbelieve and are stubborn stating that if you see these signs and disbelieve, here is a factual sign that will happen before your eyes, specifically the victory of the Romans over the Persians in less than ten years. This ayah is directed towards us in modern times just as it was directed towards our predecessors. How did the Prophet (*SAWS*) who lived in Makkah know that the Romans would eventually triumph over their enemies?

Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Alif-Lâm-Mîm. [These letters are one of the miracles of the Qur'an, and none but Allah (Alone) knows their meanings]. The Romans have been defeated. In the nearest land (Syria, Iraq, Jordan, and Palestine), and they, after their defeat, will be victorious. Within three to nine years. The decision of the matter, before and after (these events) is only with Allah, (before the defeat of the Romans by the Persians, and after the defeat of the Persians by the Romans). And on that Day, the believers (i.e. Muslims) will rejoice (at the victory given by Allah to the Romans against the Persians). With the help of Allah. He helps whom He wills, and He is the All-Mighty, the Most Merciful." (TMQ, 1-5:30).**

The prediction in the Qur'an was precisely fulfilled after nine years and the Surah was named Surat Ar-Rum to draw the attention of disbelievers to these factual signs since they did not believe the visual signs in the universe. In fact, there is another sign about this incident that our predecessors did not understand or notice, one that strengthens our faith in this revealed book and its remarkable signs.

The Surah says that the battle happened in the lowest earth, [another meaning of the Arabic word *'adna'* is lowest as well as nearest]. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"The Romans have been defeated. In the nearest land (Syria, Iraq, Jordan, and Palestine), and they, after their defeat, will be victorious" (TMQ, 2-3:30).** Modern science tells us that the location of the battle in the Dead Sea basin is the lowest point on earth. This is a sign that cannot be denied by anyone in our modern times (please refer to the books dealing

with the Scientific Truths and Miracles in the Qur'an) for more details). What rebuttal do disbelievers of ancient or modern times have after hearing these ayahs?

An economic sign

Allah *(SWT)* also explains to us another sign in the Surah, an economic sign that we see in the world today. Not a scientific sign but an economic one. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And that which you give in gift (to others), in order that it may increase (your wealth by expecting to get a better one in return) from other people's property, has no increase with Allah; but that which you give in Zakat (sadaqa - charity etc.), seeking Allah's Countenance, then those, they shall have manifold increase" (TMQ, 39:30).** The meaning here is that interest does not increase money but in fact decreases it. The modern economic theory proves that the best way to have a stable economy is to have the interest rate set at 0%, i.e. cancel all interest. Modern economic theory also proves that *Zakat* (charity) is the best method for development.

What brings this reference about interest in the middle of the Surah of signs? *Sobhan Allah* (Glory be to Allah)**,** it is as if the Surah tells all people over the ages to look at the signs of Allah *(SWT)* in every field: in history, geology and economics. *Zakat* is a developmental approach, while interest is a means to decrease money and make the economy suffer [through inflation].

Before ending, there are several comments that must be referred to:

The apparent and the hidden signs

At the beginning of the Surah Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"They know only the outside appearance of the life of the world (i.e. the matters of their livelihood, like irrigating or sowing or reaping, etc.), and they are heedless of the Hereafter" (TMQ, 7:30).** This ayah comes in a Surah full of the signs of Allah *(SWT)* to tell us that there are many more signs and proofs of Allah *(SWT)* that we do not see or understand the wisdom behind them. As a matter of fact such signs are not always what they seem to be.

What was apparent about the Romans is that they were defeated and broken. Yet, the eventual outcome was victory over the enemy in a very short time. It is apparent that interest increases money and *Zakat* decreases it but the Surah proves otherwise. Interest eventually leads to economic ruin, contrary to *Zakat*, which leads to development. It is as if the meaning directed to the believers is to have trust in Allah's *(SWT)* promise and confidence in His Wisdom and Running of the universe.

Surat Luqman

Surat Luqman is a Makkan. It was revealed after Surat As-Saffaat and comes after Surat Ar-Rum in the Qur'an. It consists of 34 ayahs.

The Surah of Child Rearing

The purpose of the Surah can be derived from its name, which shows us Luqman's rearing of his son and advising him as mentioned in the Surah. It is the Surah of child rearing that conveys wonderful methods to raise them according to Allah's *(SWT)* Decree. It comprehensively discusses child rearing from a religious and worldly standpoint. This child rearing covers the following areas:

- *Tawheed* (Monotheism) of Allah (*SWT*)
- Being dutiful to one's parents
- The importance of worship and reactivity
- Understanding the realities of the world
- Good behavior and manners
- Planning one's life

Subhan Allah, all this is present in the Surah and in only 34 verses? This is a Surah that must be taught in our schools. Our children must read and memorize this Surah to grow up following the guidelines that Luqman used with his son. Not only that, parents must learn it before their children so that they learn from the Qur'anic instruction, the instruction of Luqman and the method of religious and worldly child rearing.

The Themes of Luqman's Child Rearing

Not associating partners with Allah (*SWT*)

This is a theme evident in the entire Surah, because the first principle our children should be raised on is believing in Allah (*SWT*) as an only One Lord and thus the monotheism of Allah and not associating partners with Him. How can we do this? We must show them Allah's *(SWT)* Dominion in the universe and take them on outings and trips to see natural vistas and to see for themselves Allah's *(SWT)* flawlessness in His Creations. We must get them to know about the greatness of The Creator (*SWT*) from the wonder of His Creations.

Observe how Luqman instructs his son in what can be translated as, **" . . .O my son! Join not in worship others with Allah. Verily joining others in worship with Allah is a great Zulm (wrong) indeed," (TMQ, 13:31).** He begins by severely cautioning his son from the notion of s*hirk* (polytheism), then after two ayahs moves on to a practical lesson as stated in what can be translated as, **" "O my son! If it be (anything) equal to the weight of a grain of mustard seed, and though it be in a rock, or in the heavens or in the earth, Allah will bring it forth. Verily, Allah is Subtle (in bringing out that grain), Well-Aware (of its place)," (TMQ, 16:31).** The marvel of this ayah makes it particularly suitable as an example that young children can understand. At the same time, the ayah expresses a significant meaning for adults also and conveys the Omnipotence, Extent and Knowledge of Allah (*SWT*).

Being dutiful to one's parents and informing children of their parents' munificence, so that they understand the meaning of gratitude, thanking Allah (*SWT*) and their parents.

Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And We have enjoined on man (to be dutiful and good) to his parents. His mother bore him in weakness and hardship upon weakness and hardship, and his weaning is in two years - give thanks to Me and to your parents. Unto Me is the final destination," (TMQ, 14:31).** Even though the matter at hand is being dutiful to one's parents, there is a reminder of not committing polytheism even if it is for the sake of obeying one's parents. Thus, the Qur'an teaches us that the two matters should not collide with one another. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"But if they (both) strive with you to make you join in worship with Me others that of which you have no knowledge, then obey them not . . ." (TMQ, 15:31).** It also teaches us to balance duty towards parents and abandon polytheism in what can be translated as, **"but behave with them in the world kindly . . ." (TMQ, 15:31).**

The importance of worshipping and being positive in life.

Allah *(SWT)* states what can be translated as, **"O my son! Aqim-As-Salât (perform As-Salât), enjoin (on people) Al-Ma'rouf - (Islâmic Monotheism and all that is good), and forbid (people) from Al-Munkar (i.e. disbelief in the Oneness of Allah, polytheism of all kinds and all that is evil and bad) . . ." (TMQ, 17:31).** Child rearing is not only securing food, drink, residence, clothes and medicine for children, which are home management matters, but also raising children up on worshipping Allah (*SWT*). This does not mean child rearing is limited to teaching children how to pray, as many parents would suppose, but we must sow in their hearts the need to be positive and active in their relation with people of their community, commanding good and forbidding wrong and guiding people to the right path.

Understanding the realities of the world

Some parents raise their children to be wasteful, excessively spending and depending on their parents' money. They assume that this is securing for their children all their needs for living in this world. In fact, what is needed is to inform children of the realities of the world and its changing nature. The world will not be eternal for the parents and the children must learn to depend on themselves. Allah (*SWT*) relates what Luqman says in the ayah that can be translated as, **". . .and bear with patience whatever befalls you. Verily, these are some of the important commandments (ordered by Allah with no exemption) . . ." (TMQ, 17:31).** Specifically, if children are raised up to be proactive as instructed in the previous ayah that can be translated as**, " . . . enjoin (on people) Al-Ma'rouf - (Islâmic Monotheism and all that is good), and forbid (people) from Al-Munkar (i.e. disbelief in the Oneness of Allah, polytheism of all kinds and all that is evil and bad) . . ." (TMQ, 17:31)** then the matter needs much patience, because being active and calling for Allah *(SWT)* is a path full of problems and difficulties.

Good behavior and manners

Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And turn not your face away from men with pride, nor walk in insolence through the earth. Verily, Allah likes not any arrogant boaster. " * "And be moderate (or show no insolence) in your walking, and lower your**

voice. Verily, the harshest of all voices is the braying of the Asses" (TMQ, 18-19:31). It is vital to deal with people politely and courteously down to the smallest details, such as in walking and talking. A person should neither raise his cheek in arrogance, nor demean himself, but he should strike a middle path in walking (walking in a humble and modest way). Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And be moderate (or show no insolence) in your walking" (TMQ, 19:31).** He should not raise his voice more than is necessary for one to be heard.

Defining a goal in life and planning for the future

One of the wonders of this Surah is that it also covers this theme in child rearing. This is evident from Allah's saying which can be translated as, **"And be moderate (or show no insolence) in your walking" (TMQ, 19:31).** This ayah completes the series of manners and good behaviors that Allah (*SWT*) discusses in the Surah, as it means one should walk around with dignity, without arrogance or haughtiness. **"And be moderate (or show no insolence) in your walking"** may also mean that you must have a purpose and goal with each step, so that you don't live a life with no purpose [another meaning for the Arabic word *aqsid* is purpose, so the ayah could read as, "And have purpose in your walking"].

Have a compassionate manner for child rearing

Notice how many instructions are covered in tremendous parental love and feeling. When I read these ayahs it is as if I feel Luqman, the gentle man, instructing his son gently and telling him before each teaching, "My son, my son." The Surah tells parents to befriend their children and win them over before instructing them. Brother Muslim, talk to them about your experiences and mistakes in life. Use friendship to advise them before using stronger Do's and Don'ts. This makes the Surah truly remarkable as a practical guide in so far as the duty of child rearing is concerned.

Allah's knowledge and power

Since monotheism is the primary focus of child rearing, we see that the Surah focuses on monotheism to which we should draw our children's attention while teaching them. Looking at the beginning of ayah eleven, we see that it concentrates on this theme, especially when Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"He has created the heavens without any pillars that you see, and has set on the earth firm mountains lest it should shake with you . . ." (TMQ, 10:31).** This vision presents to fathers an important method to sow monotheism in the hearts of children. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"This is the creation of Allah. So show Me that which those (whom you worship) besides Him have created . . ." (TMQ, 11:31).** Many other ayahs carry the same message when Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"See you not (O men) that Allah has subjected for you whatsoever is in the heavens and whatsoever is in the earth, and has completed and perfected His Graces upon you, (both) apparent (i.e. Islâmic Monotheism, and the lawful pleasures of this world, including health, good looks, etc.) and hidden [i.e. One's Faith in Allah (of Islâmic Monotheism) . . ." (TMQ, 20:31).** Until we get to a remarkable example of Allah's *(SWT)* Knowledge Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And if all the trees on the earth were pens and the sea (were ink wherewith to write), with seven seas behind it to add to its (supply), yet the Words of Allah would not be exhausted. Verily, Allah is All Mighty, All-Wise," (TMQ, 27:31).** This ayah is an

extraordinary example of using nature, to instruct them about Allah's *(SWT)* Knowledge and His span over all creation.

Not blindly following

The Surah concentrates on the dangers of raising children upon blindly following their parents' belief without understanding it. On one hand, it shows that love and kindness must be the major characteristics of child-parent relationship, so that the child is convinced with the parents' teachings. On the other hand, it is prohibited for children to follow their parents' religion [if it is not Islam]. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And when it is said to them: "Follow that which Allah has sent down", they say: "Nay, we shall follow that which we found our fathers (following)." . . ." (TMQ, 21:31).**

The ayahs clearly show that both the father and the son are responsible for their actions in the life of this world on the Day of Judgment. The father will not benefit his son at all as stated by Allah *(SWT)* when He says in what can be translated as, **"O mankind! Be afraid of your Lord (by keeping your duty to Him and avoiding all evil), and fear a Day when no father can avail aught for his son, nor a son avail aught for his father . . ." (TMQ, 33:31).** Thus, it is crucial to raise them up on proper *iman* (faith), correct *a'akidah* (principles) and good traits.

Ending the Surah: Allah's (*SWT*) knowledge

Just as the Surah starts with monotheism, its ending concentrates on Allah's *(SWT)* Knowledge and Power, and the incapability of the created in knowing anything from His Unseen. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Verily Allah, with Him (Alone) is the knowledge of the Hour, He sends down the rain, and knows that which is in the wombs. No person knows what he will earn tomorrow, and no person knows in what land he will die. Verily, Allah is All-Knower, All-Aware (of things)" (TMQ, 34:31).** There are five hidden spheres of information no one but Allah *(SWT)* knows: the time of the Day of Judgment, the time of rainfall, the type of fetus before its creation, future events and where each person will die and be buried. O Muslims! Raise your children up to have faith and belief in Allah (*SWT*) and His monotheism in this way.

And we gave Luqman wisdom

One of the nice things about this Surah is that it primarily focuses on wisdom, for the Surah starts with Allah's *(SWT)* words that can be translated as, **"Alif-Lâm-Mîm. [These letters are one of the miracles of the Qur'an, and none but Allah (Alone) knows their meanings]. These are Verses of the Wise Book (the Qur'an)." (TMQ, 1-2:31).**

Even when the Surah *debases* those who block the way to Allah (*SWT*), He says what can be translated as, **"And of mankind is he who purchases idle talks (i.e. music, singing, etc.) to mislead (men) from the Path of Allah without knowledge" (TMQ, 6:31).** Consequently, mindless chatter is the opposite of wisdom. Not only that, in the first ayah Luqman is mentioned when Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And indeed We bestowed upon Luqman Al-Hikmah (wisdom and religious understanding) saying: "Give thanks to Allah."" (TMQ, 12:31).** It is as if Luqman's advice to his son is the cream of his wisdom and experience in life and he is passing it on to those who follow.

Finally, I would like to ask you the following questions: Will you take Luqman and his wisdom as an example in rearing your children? Have you made note down of the points guidelines through which you will raise your children? We ask Allah (*SWT*) to help us rearing our children according to His Path (Methodology), Qur'an and *Shariah*.

Surat As-Sajdah (Prostration)

At this point, we come to Surat As-Sajdah, whose core idea is : The Prostration. The Surah is that of submission to Allah (*SWT*) and for this reason, the name it is given is the symbol of submission and resignation to the will of Allah *(SWT)*: Prostration. The Prophet (*SAWS*) used to read this Surah in the Fajr (dawn) prayer every Friday- which is both a feast day and a holiday for Muslims- so that he may begin the blessed day with submission and humility to Allah (*SWT*).

Why not be one of them?

In the Surah, we see Allah's *(SWT)* commendation of the pious who submit to Him. This can be found in the ayah that contains the prostration (orders the Muslim to prostrate to Allah as soon as he reaches it while reciting the Qur'an) : **"Only those believe in Our Ayat (proofs, evidence, verses, lessons, signs, revelations, etc.), those who, when reminded of them, fall in prostration, and glorify the Praises of their Lord, and they are not proud (arrogant)." (TMQ, 32:15).**

Therefore, when you read this ayah, do quickly prostrate to Allah (*SWT*) so that you may be one of those who submit to Him, and whom you should take as models. In reading the Surah further, another picture is painted in what can be translated as: **"Their sides forsake their beds, to invoke their Lord in fear and hope, and they spend (in charity in Allah's Cause) out of what We have bestowed on them." (TMQ, 32:16).** Even when they go to bed, their bodies refuse sleep. Notice the brilliance of the expression, **"Their sides forsake their beds…" (TMQ, 32:16).** Too many people, the bed and sleep represent rest and relaxation; however, those who submit to Allah (*SWT*) refuse sleep due to the extent of their love of worship, their fear of Hellfire, and their longing for Paradise.

Note how Allah (*SWT*) honoured those who submitted to Him from the Israelites in this world even before the Hereafter in what can be translated as:

"And We made from among them (Children of Israel), leaders, giving guidance under Our Command, when they were patient and used to believe with certainty in Our Ayat (proofs, evidence, verses, lessons, signs, revelations, etc.)." (TMQ, 32:24).

Beware of being from them

Whoever does not submit to Allah (*SWT*) by his own will in this life, will submit to Him in the Hereafter by force, without reward, and with painful torment. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And if you only could see when the *Mujrimun* (criminals, disbelievers, polytheists, sinners) shall hang their heads before their Lord (saying): "Our Lord! We have now seen and heard, so send us back (to the world), that we will do righteous good deeds. Verily! We now believe with certainty."" (TMQ, 32:12).**

Another ayah shows us how submission to Allah in the Hereafter will not help those who submit only then in what can be translated as:

"Say: "On the Day of Al-Fath (Decision), no profit will it be to those who disbelieve if they (then) believe! Nor will they be granted a respite."" (TMQ, 32:29).

However, Allah (*SWT*) gives time to those who are proud and arrogant until their return to Him. He sends upon them misfortunes and distress in this life in the hope that they may submit to Him. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And verily, We will make them taste of the near torment (i.e. the torment in the life of this world, i.e. disasters, calamities, etc.) prior to the supreme torment (in the Hereafter), in order that they may (repent and) return (i.e. accept Islam)." (TMQ, 32:21).**

It is as if the Surah presents to you both examples and asks you: To which group do you belong in what has been translated to mean:

"Is then he who is a believer like him who is a *Fasiq* (disbeliever and disobedient to Allah)? Not equal are they." (TMQ, 32:18).

Death is a true fact

Due to the fact that it is a Surah of submission the mention of death appears so that the heedless may wake up from their oblivion and submit to Allah (*SWT*). Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Say: "The angel of death, who is set over you, will take your souls. Then you shall be brought to your Lord."" (TMQ, 32:11).**

The Prophet (*SAWS*) used to read it in the Fajr prayer every Friday, for the sake of its gentle and humble meanings, in order to renew his intention of humility and submission to Allah (*SWT*) in this life before standing in front of Him in the Hereafter.

If you feel lassitude in your worship to Allah (*SWT*) and wish to increase your vivacity and renew your submission to Him, do read Surat As-Sajdah and ask Allah (*SWT*) to aid you in that respect.

Surat Al-Ahzab (The Allied Parties), Surat Saba' (Sheba), Surat Fatir (The Originator), Surat Ya-Seen, Surat As-Saffat (The ones ranged in ranks), Surat Sad

In our Qur'anic reflections, we come to the 22nd and 23rd chapters of the Qur'an. These chapters consist of six Surahs: Al-Ahzab, Saba', Fatir, Ya-Sin, As-Saffat, and Sad. The Surahs have one theme and one core idea, namely, surrendering to Allah (*SWT*).

The Meaning of Islam

After having read 22 chapters of Allah's *(SWT)* book (the Qur'an) and the main features of the Qur'an have become clear to us, we must ask ourselves a question: How is our relationship with Allah (*SWT*)? What is the title of our religion? What does the word Islam even mean?

If we check in a dictionary, we find that the word Islam means submission and surrender to Allah (*SWT*). This is what can be understood when Allah (*SWT*) says about Prophet Ibrahim (*SAWS*) in what can be translated as: **"When his Lord said to him, "Submit (i.e. be a Muslim)!" He said, "I have submitted myself (as a Muslim) to the Lord of the *'Alamin* (mankind, jinn and all that exists)." (TMQ, 2:131).** That is, I surrendered to the Lord of the *'Alamin* and submitted myself to Allah (*SWT*).

Therefore, these six Surahs ask, is it not high time you surrender and submit yourself to Allah (*SWT*)? It is noteworthy to mention that the Qur'an ask you to surrender to Allah *(SWT)* after it has presented to you Allah's *(SWT)* methodology and discipline in the first 22 chapters of the Qur'an. It's as if to say, after you have understood the wisdom and grandeur of Allah's *(SWT)* revelation and the principle laws of Islam and after you have felt the brilliance in the ayahs and signs of Allah's *(SWT)* omnipotence, surrender to Him. Surrender, even if you are dissatisfied with just a small part of a situation, or if you are not fully comfortable with a certain matter. Surrender, because the title of your religion is "surrender and submission."

Core ideas of surrender and submission:

These six Surahs revolve around one core idea, which is that of surrender and submission to Allah (*SWT*) in all aspects of life:
Surat Al-Ahzab: Surrendering to Allah *(SWT)* in difficult situations.
Surat Saba': Surrendering to Allah *(SWT)* is the path to the survival of civilizations.
Surat Fatir: Surrendering to Allah *(SWT)* is the path to honour.
Surat Ya-Sin: Surrendering to Allah *(SWT)* through persisting on the mission of calling people forth to Islam, even if one has given up hope in the mission being effective.
Surat As-Saffat: Surrendering to Allah *(SWT)* even if you don't understand the wisdom behind Allah's *(SWT)* orders.
Surat Sad: Surrendering to Allah *(SWT)* and returning to righteousness without stubbornness.

Here we understand the reason behind for these Surahs appearing in the 22nd chapter, after the presentation of Allah's *(SWT)* methodology and discipline. By this time, we grasp the meaning and realize the title of our religion and what Allah *(SWT)* wants from us. Thus, it is about time we surrendered to Him.

We emphasize that this is a humble, small-scale work on our part, with the intention to facilitate the reading of the Qur'an for young Muslims and to increase their interaction with it. We do not claim that this is all that can be said on the topic. No doubt there are those who are more knowledgeable in the interpretation of the meanings of the Qur'an; however, there should also be those who try to relate the meanings of the Surahs with one another and understand Allah's *(SWT)* purpose in them, since the Qur'an has endless depth.

After this brief introduction, let us explore together the Surahs of surrender and submission to Allah (*SWT*).

= Surat Al-Ahzab (The allied parties) =

Surrendering to Allah in difficult situations:

This Surah is, by the way, one of the best Surahs in the Qur'an to portray the different difficult situations that people may go through. The incident of Al-Ahzab (which is also called the Conquest of the Trench) was itself a very difficult situation. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as**, "When they came upon you from above you and from below you, and when the eyes grew wild and the hearts reached the throats, and you were harboring doubts about Allah. There, the believers were tried and shaken with a mighty shaking." (TMQ, 33:10-11).**

Through all of the ayahs, the Surah focuses on obedience to Allah *(SWT)*, surrender and submission to Him in these situations.

Social situations:

Further on, another difficult situation is mentioned, which is that of Zaid's divorce from Zaynab bint Jahsh (*RA*) and the Prophet's *(SAWS)* subsequent marriage to her: **"So when Zaid had accomplished his desire from her (i.e. divorced her), We gave her to you in marriage…" (TMQ, 33:37).**

After that comes the prohibition of adoption and the abolition of this custom that was so ingrained in the Arab spirit. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Call them (adopted sons) by (the names of) their fathers…" (TMQ, 33:5).** This decree began with the Prophet *(SAWS)* when his adoption of Zaid became null and Zaid's name returned to Zaid ibn Haritha rather than Zaid ibn Muhammad. This was quite embarrassing for both Zaid (*RA*) and the Prophet (*SAWS*). The ayah, therefore, comments upon this situation in what can be translated as, **"There is no blame on the Prophet *(SAWS)* in that which Allah has made legal for him." (TMQ, 33:38).**

Another difficult situation is presented: the Prophet's *(SAWS)* wives who ask for more money. This is not greed or a desire for luxury on their part, but because the economic situation during their time was extremely hard. However, Allah (*SWT*) wished to test them with a challenging ordeal because they were the Mothers of the believers. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"O Prophet (Muhammad *SAWS*)! Say to your wives: "If you desire the life of this world, and its glitter, then come! I will make a provision for you and set you free in a handsome manner (divorce). "But if you desire Allah and His**

Messenger, and the home of the Hereafter, then verily, Allah has prepared for *Al-Muhsinat* (good-doers) amongst you an enormous reward."" (TMQ, 33:28-29)

Your Hijab is the symbol of your ultimate surrender

Hence, we see that the Surah includes many difficult and/or embarrassing situations that the Muslim may experience. It brings us to a situation that is enormously difficult for women but, at the same time, tests the degree to which they will surrender to Allah's *(SWT)* commands – the hijab. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"O Prophet! Tell your wives and your daughters and the women of the believers to draw their cloaks close round them when they go abroad" (TMQ, 33:59)**

This ayah, along with the 31st ayah of Surat An-Nur, mentions meticulously the details of a Muslim woman's hijab. In Surat An-Nur, the details of how to cover the upper body are clarified: **"…and to draw their veils over their bosoms…"** In Surat Al-Ahzab, the ayah discusses the coverings of the lower part of the body: **"… cast their outer garments over their persons (when abroad)…"** Will you, O Muslim sister, surrender to Allah *(SWT)* and accept His command of the hijab? Or will you be among those who say, I am not yet convinced of the concept of hijab…

Surrender without hesitation

If someone still insists upon not carrying out the orders of Allah *(SWT)* until he understands the wisdom behind them, then read what this important ayah says about the concept of submitting surrender to Allah *(SWT)*. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"It is not for a believer, man or woman, when Allah and His Messenger have decreed a matter that they should have any option in their decision." (TMQ, 33:36)**

So it is inadmissible for anyone to protest and refuse any command given by Allah *(SWT)* and say that he needs to be convinced first of the concept behind this command. Young men and women, surrender to Allah *(SWT),* for the ayahs in the Qur'an, throughout 20 of its chapters, have made clear the wisdom of Allah *(SWT)* and His plan for His creations and the wonder in the laws He has placed (which proves that our religion does not ask that people follow blindly nor does it disable minds from thinking on their own). It is high time you surrender.

It's as if the meaning is that Allah *(SWT)* wants from us to worship Him through two kinds of commands. On the one hand, those whose reason and wisdom are known and clear, such as the prohibition of meat not slaughtered and alcohol, which the Muslim fulfills wholeheartedly and strengthens his faith in Allah's *(SWT)* prudence in His laws. On the other hand, those whose reasons are not mentioned but Allah (*SWT*) wishes us to fulfill them whether or not we understand the wisdom behind them. This is so that He may test our unconditional and unwavering submission to Him.

Obedience of Allah in the Surah

Since the core idea of the Surah is obedience to Allah *(SWT)* and surrender to His orders, we see that the word "obedience" is mentioned in the Surah seven times and honesty with Allah *(SWT)* is mentioned eight times. Not only that, but the very first ayah in the Surah orders the Prophet (*SAWS*) to be sincerely and wholeheartedly obedient to Allah *(SWT)* and no one else.

Allah *(SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"O Prophet! Fear Allah, and hearken not to the Unbelievers and the Hypocrites" (TMQ, 33:1)**

There are many other ayahs that carry the same meaning as Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And obey not (the behests) of the Unbelievers and the Hypocrites, and heed not their annoyances, but put thy Trust in Allah…" (TMQ, 33:48)**

The fourth ayah focuses on devoting one's obedience to Allah *(SWT)* alone when Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Allah has not made for any man two hearts in his (one) body…"** The fate of those who obey humans and not Allah *(SWT)* will be like those who say what can be translated as, **"And they would say: "Our Lord! We obeyed our chiefs and our great ones, and they misled us as to the (right) Path." (TMQ, 33:67)**

The Surah confirms that this matter does not apply only to the Prophet (*SAWS*), but to all of the Prophets of Allah *(SWT)* when Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And remember We took from the Prophets their covenant: As (We did) from thee: from Noah, Abraham, Moses, and Jesus the son of Mary: We took from them a solemn covenant:" (TMQ, 33:7)**

The surrender of the Heavens and the Earth

The Surah ends with on a gentle note; Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"We did indeed offer the Trust to the Heavens and the Earth and the Mountains; but they refused to undertake it, being afraid thereof: but man undertook it; - He was indeed unjust and foolish; - "(TMQ, 33:72)**

There are two types of ways to surrender to Allah *(SWT).* One can either submit to Allah *(SWT)* by one's own choice and freewill, or can be a servant to Allah *(SWT)* without having to choose. The first type is the one the heavens and the earth feared, knowing how uneasy is to carry the moral responsibility and perform duties. For this reason, they chose the second type of surrender, which is that of submission to Allah (*SWT*) without being given the choice of fulfilling Allah's commands.

As for man, he has carried this moral responsibility – "…**He was indeed unjust and foolish…"** However, the ayah does not mean that man is unjust and foolish because he carries this responsibility but he will be so if he does not surrender to Allah *(SWT)* after having taken it.

For this reason, the conclusion of Surat Al-Ahzab is: Surrender to Allah *(SWT)* and know that He has entrusted you with a tremendous responsibility, one feared by even the grandest of Allah's *(SWT)* creations. They preferred surrendering to Allah *(SWT)* without choice.

The reason behind the Surah's title

As for the Surah's name and how it came about, we must go back to the Battle of the Trench, in which Al-Ahzab (the allied parties) surrounded Madinah from every corner and every side. What was the Muslims' reaction in this difficult situation? Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"When the Believers saw the Confederate forces, they said: "This is what Allah and his Messenger had promised us, and Allah and His Messenger told us what was true." And it only added to their faith and their zeal in obedience. " (TMQ, 33:22)**

Do you see how the surrender to Allah *(SWT)* is constantly repeated throughout this Surah?

However, there is another reason for the Surah's name other than the Ahzab (the allied parties) that appeared outside of Madinah. Internally, Madinah had been divided into groups: The group of hypocrites, the group of those who hesitated or were afraid and the third group which we must not forget – the group of women who brought victory to Islam. There are many ayahs in the Surah, which talk about this particular group, such as ayah 35 which can be translated as, **"…Verily, the Muslims (those who submit to Allah in Islam) men and women, the believers men and women (who believe in Islamic Monotheism)…"** There is also the group of believers who trusted have trust in Allah *(SWT)* and who had a wonderful testimony from Allah *(SWT* were highly praised by Him*)* for their submission as Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Among the Believers are men who have been true to their covenant with Allah: of them some have completed their vow (to the extreme), and some (still) wait: but they have never changed (their determination) in the least." (TMQ, 33:23).**

Reconcile the groups…to establish civilization

The Surah is named so for the many groups found both outside and inside of Madinah There is no doubt that reforming the groups inside of Medina and being victorious over them is, by far, much harder than winning over the groups outside of the city. Allah *(SWT)* finished off the former group by sending them a strong wind as mentioned in the ayah that can be translated as, **"…We sent against them a hurricane and forces that ye saw not…" (TMQ, 33:9).** As for the groups inside, if they are reformed, our nation (of Islam) will be one of strong civilization, similar to that of Saba', which is discussed in the Surah that follows this one. It is as if the relationship between the two Surahs is summarized in the following statement: "O groups inside, surrender to Allah *(SWT)* and fuse together, for this is the way to preserve civilizations".

= Surat Saba' (Sheba) =

The surrender of civilizations to Allah

Surat Saba', like Surat Al-Naml, is a Surah that discusses the issue of success in civilizations; it continues the meaning started by Surat Al-Naml. Surat Al-Naml focuses on working with the building blocks of civilization, from education to technological development to management, whereas Surat Saba' asks those who wish to build a culture and a nation: What is the basis of this culture? What is the foundation? The objective of the Surah is the importance and the need for of faith in modern civilization.

The Surah discusses two contrasting types of civilizations: One that believes in Allah *(SWT)* and surrenders to Him, that of Dawud *(AS)* and Solaiman (*AS*) and one that disobeys Allah *(SWT)* and refuses His path, that is of Saba'.

The Surah's order in the Qur'an after Surat Al-Ahzab emphasizes, as mentioned earlier, that reformation of the groups inside with faith is the path to building a strong civilization.

Two civilizations on the scale

The first type, which is that of a believing and trusting civilization, can be found in Prophet Dawud (*AS*), who was granted power and authority by Allah *(SWT)*. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And indeed We bestowed grace on Dawud (David) from Us (saying): "O you mountains. Glorify (Allah) with him! And you birds (also)! And We made the iron soft for him."" (TMQ, 34:10)**. When Prophet Dawud *(AS)* surrendered to Allah *(SWT)* and worshiped Him wholly and completely, Allah *(SWT)* made even the iron obedient to him and made the entire universe under his command. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And to Solomon (We subjected) the wind, its morning (stride from sunrise till midnoon) was a month's (journey), and its afternoon (stride from the midday decline of the sun to sunset) was a month's (journey i.e. in one day he could travel two months' (journey). And We caused a fount of (molten) brass to flow for him…" (34:12)**. Notice the words "glorify," "soften," and "to flow," for they are all indications of how Allah *(SWT)* put the entire universe under the command of this believing civilization. In Surat Sad, one of several Surahs, which discuss the topic of surrendering to Allah *(SWT)*, we see how Allah *(SWT)* strengthened Prophet Dawud's *(AS)* rule. Allah *(SWT)* states what can be translated as, **"And (so did) the birds assembled: all obedient to him [Dawud (David)] [i.e. they came and glorified Allah's Praises along with him]. We made his kingdom strong…" (TMQ, 38:19-20).**

The second type of civilization is one that refuses to surrender to Allah *(SWT)* and is punished and annihilated for such a refusal. This Surah is named after such a people so that it may be a lesson to be learned by others. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Indeed there was for Saba' (Sheba) a sign in their dwelling-place - two gardens on the right hand and on the left; (and it was said to them:) "Eat of the provision of your Lord, and be grateful to Him." A fair land and an Oft-Forgiving Lord! But they turned away (from the obedience of Allah), so We sent against them *Sail Al-'Arim* (flood released from the dam), and We converted their two gardens into gardens producing bitter bad fruit, and tamarisks, and some few lote-trees. Like this We requited them because they were ungrateful disbelievers. And never do We requite in such a way except those who are ungrateful (disbelievers)." (TMQ, 34:15-17).**

The Jinn in the Surah

Along with these two civilizations, the Surah mentions the jinn and how they were completely submitted and devoted to Prophet Solaiman (*AS*) and his people. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"…and there were jinn that worked in front of him, by the Leave of his Lord. And whosoever of them turned aside from Our Command, We shall cause him to taste of the torment of the blazing Fire." (TMQ, 34:12)**. This particular civilization was not granted any power or authority or knowledge, as the ayah proves in what can be translated as, **"Then when We decreed death for him [Solaiman (Solomon)], nothing informed them (jinn) of his death except a little worm of the earth, which kept (slowly) gnawing away at his stick. So when he fell down, the jinn saw clearly that if they had known the Unseen, they would not have stayed in the humiliating torment." (TMQ, 34:14).**

The jinn worked diligently, fearing Solaiman *(AS)*, who observed them and their actions. They did not know however, that Prophet Solaiman *(AS)* died leaning on his chair. They didn't know anything about this matter until the worms of the earth gnawed at Solaiman's *(AS)* stick. This is just a simple incident, yet it exposes this civilization, which was obedient and submissive without knowledge.

A universal method

After presenting both types of civilizations, the Surah generalizes the concept and points out that the civilizations' disbelief in Allah *(SWT)* brings its downfall in what can be translated as, **"And those before them belied; these have not received even a tenth of what We had granted to those (of old); yet they belied My Messengers. Then how (terrible) was My denial (punishment)!" (TMQ, 34:45).** After mentioning the ancient nations, the Surah points out that there had been nations ten times stronger and more powerful than Quraish, yet their civilizations had been wiped out because the concept mentioned above had applied on them.

Therefore, guidance is offered for anyone wishing to establish a civilization or build a nation. For those of you with plans to build the glory of Islam –you should know it, and keep it in mind as you work on your mission. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Say (to them O Muhammad *SAWS*): "I exhort you to one (thing) only: that you stand up for Allah's sake in pairs and singly, and reflect (within yourselves the life history of the Prophet *SAWS*): there is no madness in your companion (Muhammad *SAWS*)…" (TMQ, 34:46).**

= Surat Fatir (The Originator) =

Surrender is the way to glory

Surat Fatir continues the discussion of surrendering to Allah *(SWT).* We saw that, in Surat Saba', surrendering to Allah *(SWT)* is the way to preserve and maintain civilizations. Surat Fatir takes the message a little further. It states that surrendering to Allah *(SWT)* does more than that; it is the way to honor and prestige in this life. Some people think that surrendering to Allah *(SWT)* and submitting to Him is a disgrace and a discredit to them; however, the Surah makes clear that true honor and glory can be achieved only through Allah *(SWT)* in what can be translated as, **"Whosoever desires honor, (power and glory), then to Allah belong all honor, power and glory [and one can get honor, power and glory only by obeying and worshipping Allah (Alone)]. To Him ascend (all) the goodly words, and the righteous deeds exalt it (i.e. the goodly words are not accepted by Allah unless and until they are followed by good deeds)…" (TMQ, 35:10).**

How can you not surrender?

The Surah takes the message even further. It asks why we do not surrender to Allah *(SWT)* and we are in dire need of Him and He is rich and does not need us or anyone in the world? Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"O mankind! it is you who stand in need of Allah. But Allah is Rich (Free of all needs), Worthy of all praise. If He willed, He could destroy you and bring about a new creation. And that is not hard for Allah." (TMQ, 35:15-17).**

The Surah began by mentioning the angels and indicating that despite the greatness in their creation and their power, they submit to Allah *(SWT)* and surrender to Him in all of their affairs. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"All the praises and thanks be to Allah, the (only) Originator [or the (Only) Creator] of the heavens and the earth, Who made the angels messengers with wings, two or three or four…" (TMQ, 35:1).**

The Originator of the Heavens and the Earth

Why is the Surah's title one of Allah's 99 names, The Originator?

Surat Fatir shows us Allah's *(SWT)* wonders in the universe so that we may know Him well and truly believe that all glory and honor belongs to Him and surrender to Him and submit to no one but Him. Why, then, does the Surah focus on this particular name – The Originator?

A word synonymous with "Originator" is "Creator." In the Arabic language, when the phrase "something is originated" (Fatara) is said, it means to have been split into two halves. The Ayahs in the Surah focus on Allah's *(SWT)* greatness through the principle of duality found in the universe. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as: **"All the praises and thanks be to Allah, the (only) Originator [or the (Only) Creator] of the heavens and the earth…" (TMQ, 35:1).**

"Whatever of mercy (i.e. of good), Allah may grant to mankind, none can withhold it; and whatever He may withhold, none can grant it thereafter…" (TMQ, 35:2).
"And the two seas (kinds of water) are not alike: this is palatable, sweet and pleasant to drink, and that is salt and bitter…" (TMQ, 35:12).

"See you not that Allah sends down water (rain) from the sky, and We produce therewith fruits of various colors, and among the mountains are streaks white and red, of varying colors and (others) very black. And likewise of men and *Ad-Dawabb* [moving (living) creatures, beasts], and cattle, are of various colors…" (TMQ, 35:27-28).

Other ayahs mention contrasting pairs in what can be translated as, **"Not alike are the blind (disbelievers in Islamic Monotheism) and the seeing (believers in Islamic Monotheism). Nor are (alike) darkness (disbelief) and light (Belief in Islamic Monotheism). Nor are (alike) the shade and the sun's heat. Nor are (alike) the living (i.e. the believers) and the dead (i.e. the disbelievers)…" (TMQ, 35: 19-22).**

It's as if it is saying to us: Who has the ability to run the universe with these contrasting pairs other than Allah *(SWT)*? Surrender to Him and submit to His greatness.

The Surah demonstrates to us, through most of its ayahs, Allah's *(SWT)* power and ability in the universe so that we may know Him well and trust that all honor belongs to Him. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Verily! Allah grasps the heavens and the earth lest they should move away from their places, and if they were to move away from their places, there is not one that could grasp them after Him…" (TMQ, 35:41).**

= Surat Ya-Seen =

This Surah makes clear a type of submission that the Muslim should perform and this is submission to Allah (*SWT*) while calling people to Allah *(SWT)*. This is done by insisting on His claim, whether people accept guidance or not, because this is a kind of devotion and worship through which you can be devout and close to Allah (*SWT).*

Therefore the Surah gives two examples of people: those with lively, kind hearts and those hard-hearted people. Since the person doesn't know what's in the hearts of people he cannot

know who will accept and follow guidance and who will grow obstinate and give himself up to arrogance. Thus he has to call all people to Allah *(SWT)* no matter the results may be.

The reason behind sending down this Surah:

The Surah starts with those who refuse guidance from Allah *(SWT)* in what can be translated as, **"And it is equal to them whether you have warned them or you have not warned them, they do not believe." (TMQ, 36: 10).** Then it quickly shifts to those who accept and follow guidance in what can be translated as, **"Surely you only warn him who closely follows the Remembrance and is apprehensive of The All-Merciful in the Unseen. So give him the good tidings of forgiveness and an honorable reward." (TMQ, 36: 11).**

The Surah pictures both categories of people, a fact which explains the reason why it was sent down to Prophet Mohamed (*SAWS*) before *Hijra* (emigration from Makkah to Madinah). At this time, Islam stopped spreading and Muslims started to feel desperate.

In this respect, we find many Ayahs (verses) encouraging Prophet Mohamed (*SAWS*) and strengthening his will to go on with his call in what can be translated as, **"Surely you are indeed of the Emissaries. On a straight Path. (This is) the successive sending down of The Ever-Mighty, The Ever-Merciful, That you may warn a people; In no way were their fathers warned, so they are heedless." (TMQ, 36: 3-6).**

The Surah raises the question: Will you obey Allah *(SWT)* and surrender to Him and go on with your call? Only Allah *(SWT)* knows what hearts conceal, therefore you should go on with your call.

An example model for of submission:

The Surah mentions the famous story of the city, to which Allah *(SWT)* sent three Messengers in what can be translated as, **"And strike for them a similitude: the companions (i.e., the inhabitants) of the town, as the Emissaries came to it, As We sent to them two (men). Yet they cried them lies, so We reinforced them with a third. Then they said, "Surely we are (sent) to you as Emissaries." (TMQ, 36: 13-14).**

Allah *(SWT)* has sent three Messengers to this city but only one man felt responsible for this Religion and had a great attitude as stated in what can be translated as**, "And (there) came from the remotest part of the city a man going speedily. He said, "O my people, closely follow the Emissaries! Closely follow (the ones) who ask of you no reward, and they are rightly guided. And for what should I not worship Him who originated me, and to Him you will be returned?" (TMQ, 36: 20-22).**

It is the story of a man who did not stand still without calling people for Allah (*SWT)* with the excuse that Allah *(SWT)* sends Messengers to the city. He insisted on going on to convince his people even though they did not listen to the Messengers sent to them and who were much better than he. Thus we see that the story relates directly to the main pivot of the Surah; you should never feel desperate while calling people to Allah *(SWT)*.

Ayahs of creation and their ends:

The Surah focuses on death and resurrection, reminding us all (Muslims, disbelievers, obedient, and disobedient) that we will die one day; that is why we should go on calling any person to the right path because Allah *(SWT)* might guide this person to His path before death. This aspect is closely connected to the ayahs that focused on the ends of things; reminding disbelievers of death which is the end of rejection and the end of the whole creation in what can be translated as, **"And the sun runs to a repository for it; that is the determining of The Ever-Mighty, the Ever-Knowing. And the moon, We have determined it by phases, till it becomes again (Literally: goes back) like the old date-stalk." (TMQ, 36: 38-39).** This means that there is an end for both the sun and the moon as well as for all living creatures.

Read Ya Seen for your dead people

In addition, it clarifies the meaning of Prophet Mohamed's *(SAWS)* Hadith: "Read Ya Seen for your dead people." This does not mean that the Surah should be read in graves, as many people do. Nevertheless it should be read for the living, even those who are about to die because since they are still breathing, they should be guided. It is really a beautiful and important meaning to all those calling for Allah *(SWT)*.

= Surat As-Saffat (The ones ranged in ranks) =

This Surah sheds light on one single meaning and this is surrendering to Allah's *(SWT)* orders even if you don't understand the meaning behind it. Therefore it gives a fine example of Ibrahim *(AS)*(Abraham) who was asked to slaughter his son Isma'il *(AS)*(Ishmael). He accepted the order without hesitation or inquiries about the reason behind such an order. It is as if the Surah says: you Muslims will receive some orders, which you will not understand the reason behind. Therefore you have to follow Ibrahim *(AS)* in fulfilling such divine orders.

The submission of the father and the son:

In the story of Ibrahim *(AS)* there is a complete submission to Allah, Almighty. Ibrahim *(AS)* left his people and emigrated for the sake of Allah *(SWT)* and said what can be translated as**, "And he said, "Surely I am going to my Lord, soon He will guide me."**(TMQ, 37: 99). The Surah then pictures his longing and need for a son when he says what can be translated as, **"Lord! Bestow upon me one of the righteous."** (TMQ, 37: 100). Allah *(SWT)* then responds to his prayer saying what can be translated as, **"So We gave him the good tidings of a forbearing youth." (TMQ 37: 101).**

Can you imagine his happiness then! An old man living far from his land and people. Can you imagine how much he is attached to this young boy, who is not an ordinary boy, but "a boy ready to suffer and forbear."

We then read in the Ayah (102) what can be translated as, "**Then when he (His son) reached the age of endeavoring with him" (TMQ, 37: 102).** After the boy had grown up, Ibrahim *(AS)* had a hard dream as can be translated as**, "he said, "O my son, surely I see in a dream (Literally: time of sleeping)" (TMQ, 37: 102)**, not a direct command from Allah *(SWT)*, or through *Jibril* (Gabriel), but through a night vision. Nevertheless Ibrahim *(AS)* never hesitated because he knew that the vision (the term vision is used instead of dream) of Messengers is always true. He did not ask for a reason, but told his son what can be

translated as, **"he said, "O my son, surely I see in a dream (Literally: time of sleeping) that I should slay you; so, look, what do you see?" (TMQ, 37: 102).**

This question was not to express his hesitation to slaughter his son, but Ibrahim *(AS)* wanted his son to share the reward. What did Isma'il *(AS)* say? He was left by as a little boy in a lonesome desert by his father who is going to slaughter him but Isma'il said what can be translated as, **"He said, "O my (dear) father, perform whatever you are commanded; you will soon find me, in case Allah (so) decides, among the patient." (TMQ, 37: 102).**

Then comes the main Ayah in the Surah in what can be translated as, **"So, as soon as they had both surrendered, and he dashed him upon his brow."(TMQ, 37: 103).** The question that arises in this situation is: Weren't they already Muslims by the time of this command? Yes, but the word [submitted] in this state reveals the comprehensive meaning of Islam, which is surrendering to Allah (*SWT*) without hesitation.

Why the Surah was called "As-Saffat":

As-Saffat are the angels who surrender to Allah, Almighty, therefore the Surah starts by describing these faithful creatures.

It is also worth noticing that whenever a Surah in the Qur'an begins with mentioning angels, this means that the main pivot of this Surah will be surrendering to Allah (*SWT*), because they are the symbol of such a meaning.

Submission to Allah *(SWT)* willing or unwilling:

If the person refuses to submit during his lifetime, there is a warning in the Surah against the horror of the Day of Judgment as what can be translated as, **"And bid them stand; surely they are to be questioned, How is it that you do not vindicate one another? No indeed; (but) they are today submitting themselves." (TMQ 37: 24-26).** As if it says, " You either surrender willing in life, or you will be forced to surrender in the hereafter."

So surrender to all of Allah's *(SWT)* commands and laws, even if you do not know the reason behind them. However Allah *(SWT)* with His Mercy has given convincing reasons for the majority of his commands. Yet He kept the meaning behind some of these commands hidden so as to know who will obey and who will disobey, and behave arrogantly.

= Surat Sad =

All chapters in parts 22 and 23 express one idea, which is submission to Allah *(SWT)*. This Surah reveals the meaning, that although you Muslim surrender to Allah's *(SWT)* orders and commands, you might do wrong. The question is will you turn back to Him repentantly? Or will you remain arrogant, and insist on your opinion?

Going back to the right path without being stubborn:

The Surah relates the story of three Messengers who made quick decisions, but they soon realized their mistake. This is one of the most important types of submission to Allah *(SWT)* because he who is arrogant never surrenders to the right path, and if he finds himself doing

wrong he will insist on it. Therefore the Surah relates the story of Satan who is the symbol of arrogance.

Dawud "David" turning repentantly to Allah:

The first story mentioned in the Surah is that of the Messenger Dawud (David) *(AS)*, when two antagonists disputed with each other in front of him and asked him in what can be translated as**, "As they entered upon Dawudؑ then he was alarmed of them. They said, "Do not fear (anything); two adversaries we are. One of us has been inequitable to the other, (Literally: some of us against some "others") so judge between us with the truth, and do not act injudiciously, and guide us to the level path." (TMQ, 38: 22).** However Dawud *(AS)* gave a quick verdict in the favor of one of them, but he quickly reverted to Allah *(SWT)* in what can be translated as**, "He (Dawud) said, "Indeed he has already done an injustice to you in asking for your ewe (in addition) to his ewes; and surely many intermixes are indeed inequitable one against the other, (Literally: some of them are unfair to some "others") except the ones who have believed and done deeds of righteousness, and how few they are!" And Dawud surmised that We had only tempted (Or: tried) him; so he asked forgiveness of his Lord, and he collapsed bowing down and turned penitent. A prostration is to be performed here. So We forgave him that, and surely he has in Our Providence proximity indeed and a fair resorting." (TMQ, 38: 24-25)**

Solaiman "Solomon" turning repentantly to Allah *(SWT)*:

The second story is that of Solaiman, Dawud's son (*PBUT*) in what can be translated as, **"And We bestowed on Dawud (David) Solaiman; (Solomon) how excellent a bondman he was! Surely he was a constant resorter (to Us)." (TMQ, 38: 30)**

The ayahs explain Solaiman's quick repentance in what can be translated as, "**As there were set (in parade) before him at nightfall light-footed (Literally: standing on three feet) coursers. Then he said, "Surely I have loved the love of (earthly) charitable (things) better than the Remembrance of my Lord, "until (the sun) disappeared behind the curtain (Literally: made herself disappear with the curtain)."(TMQ, 38: 31-32)**

When he realized that the horses diverted him from invocation of Allah *(SWT)*, he decided to kill them. He said what can be translated as, **"Turn them back to me!" Then he took to striking (Or: slashing) their shanks and necks. (TMQ, 38: 33)**

The ayahs also describe another example of his repentance; **"And indeed We already tempted Solaiman, (Solomon) and We cast upon his chair a corporeal (form); thereafter he turned penitent." (TMQ, 38: 34)**

Ayoub repenting to Allah:

Finally comes the story of Ayoub (*SAWS*) when he swore to hit his wife a 100 times. Then came the words from Allah that can be translated as, **"And (we said) "Take in your hand a jumble of rushes, then strike therewith, and do not break (your oath)." Surely We found him a patient (man). How excellent a bondman he was! Surely he was a constant resorter (to Us)."(TMQ 38: 44).**

Thus he repented and turned back to the right path, and Allah *(SWT)* found him a way so as not to break his oath, He ordered him to take 100 thin sticks and hit his wife slightly.

It is noticed that the stories of the Messengers in the Surah concentrated on their servitude to Allah (*SWT*):

Dawud- what can be translated as, **"(Endure) patiently what they say; and remember Our bondman Dawud (David) (a man) possessing prowess (Literally: hands). Surely he was a constant resorter (to Allah)." (TMQ, 38: 17).** This means that he quickly turned to Allah.

Sulaiman- what can be translated as, **"how excellent a bondman he was! Surely he was a constant resorter (to Us)." (TMQ, 38: 30).**

Ayoub- what can be translated as **"Surely We found him a patient (man). How excellent a bondman he was! Surely he was a constant resorter (to Us)." (TMQ, 38: 44)**

We notice the repetition of the meanings of servitude to Allah *(SWT)* and turning to Him in true devotion.

Iblis "Satan" and arrogance:

On the contrary to the Messengers who turned repentantly to Allah *(SWT)*, the Surah reveals a completely different example of Iblis "Satan" in what can be translated as**, "So the Angels prostrated themselves, all of them all together, Except Iblis; he waxed proud, and was (one) of the disbelievers." (TMQ, 38: 73-74)**

His arrogance was the main reason behind his rejection of Faith, therefore Allah *(SWT)* confronts him saying what can be translated as, **"Said He, "O Iblis, what prevented you to prostrate yourself to what I created with My Hands? Have you waxed proud, or are you of the exalted?" (TMQ, 38: 75).** The result was what can be translated as**, "Said He, "Then get (Literally: go out) out of it; so surely you are a constant outcast. And surely My curse is on you till the Day of Doom." (i.e., Judgment)." (TMQ, 38: 77-78)**

This horrible example of Iblis becomes clear at the end of the Surah, so that we can compare between those who submitted to Allah *(SWT)*, and Iblis, Allah's *(SWT)* enemy who was driven away from His Mercy because of his arrogance.

Surat Az-Zumar (The Hordes)

This Surah is Makkan. It comes after Surat "Saba'a" in the order of revelation and after "Sad" in the order of the Qur'an. It consists of 75 Ayahs.

A secret between Allah and His servant:

This Surah is one of the most beautiful Surahs of the Qur'an because it includes ayahs with wonderful meanings. Its objective is clear : One should be sincere to Allah in whatever one does, shouldn't seek ostentation but rather Allah's satisfaction. He, who wants to put himself to test on the level of sincerity in his work, should read then this Surah, and open his heart to its ayahs.

The level of sincerity:

You should never seek people's satisfaction, expecting them to say about you : he is a pious man, he has learnt the Qur'an by heart, he prays regularly in mosques and so forth. Be sincere to Allah *(SWT)* when you worship Him; and, you, my Muslim sister, be sincere to Allah *(SWT)* through obeying and satisfying your husband.

You, parents, be sincere through raising up your children, and encourage them to obey Allah *(SWT)* and advocate Islam. Be sincere throughout your life, so that you might guarantee being among the group of the Believers in heaven and among those who grasped well the meaning of this Surah and Allah's objective in it.

It is to Allah that sincere devotion is due.

This aspect is quite clear from the very beginning of the Surah what can be translated as, **"Surely We have sent down to you the Book with the Truth; so worship Allah, making the religion faithfully His. Verily the faithful religion is for Allah. And the ones who take to themselves patrons apart from Him (say), "In no way do we worship them excepting that they may bring us near in proximity to Allah." Surely Allah will judge between them concerning that wherein they differ among themselves. Surely Allah does not guide him who is a liar, a most disbelieving (person)." (TMQ, 39: 2-3).**

Words and ayahs about sincerity succeed one another. We read what Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Say, "Surely I have been commanded to worship Allah, making the religion faithfully His. And I have been commanded to be the first Muslim." (Literally: of the Muslims = of those who surrender (to Him) Say, "Surely I fear, in case I disobey my Lord, the torment of a Tremendous Day." Say, (This is addressed to the Prophet) Allah I worship, making my religion faithfully His. So worship whatever you decide on, apart from Him." Say, "Surely the losers are they who lose their (own) selves and their own families on the Day of the Resurrection. Verily that is the evident, all-deserved loss." (TMQ, 39: 11-15).**

Therefore, the ayahs emphasize the same meaning, which is the complete sincerity to Allah *(SWT)* in worship and work.

Let your work be as pure as milk:

There is an Ayah in Surat "Al-Nahl" which clarifies, in a wonderful way, the meaning of sincerity: Allah says what can be translated as, **"And surely in (the) cattle (there) is indeed a lesson for you. We give you to drink of what is in their bellies, even between filth and blood, exclusively (pure) milk, palatable to the drinkers." (TMQ, 16: 66)**

This white milk comes out from the remains and blood, a drop of which if mixed with milk will spoil it. Can you be sincere in your devotion to Allah *(SWT)*, and purify it from any defects? Can you sacrifice every second in your life for the sake of Allah *(SWT)*: when you speak to people about Islam, when you pray, when you read the Qur'an, and myself when I write this book. We should all be sincere to Allah *(SWT)* so that He might accept our work and good deeds.

Which is better for you?

Allah *(SWT)* then sets a similitude in accordance with the meaning of sincerity when He says what can be translated as, **"Allah has struck a similitude: a man in whom associates are at variance with each other, and a man wholly submissive to (one) man. Are the two equal (in likeness)? Praise be to Allah; no indeed, (but) most of them do not know." (TMQ, 39: 29).** Is he who works for one master equal to the person who works for more than one? Is the employee working under the supervision of one boss similar to the one who gets orders from many, with different opinions and different jobs? That is why the phrase, "Praise be to Allah," comes directly after this example. Indeed, the fact of having only one Lord (Allah *(SWT)* is a blessing for which we should be grateful.

Being sincere to Allah *(SWT)* in your deeds is useful to the heart, as it arouses your spirits in this world, and increases your reward in the hereafter.

Types of sincerity:

The ayahs of the Surah deals with all types of sincerity. The first type is being sincere in worship when Allah says what can be translated as, **"Is he who is devoutly (praying) at various times of the night, prostrate and upright, being wary of the Hereafter, and hoping for the mercy of his Lord (the same as the disbeliever)? Say, "Are the ones who know equal to the ones who do not know?" Surely only the ones endowed with intellects would remind themselves."(TMQ, 39: 9).**

A bright example for a person who is sincere in his worship of Allah *(SWT)*, and who does not seek people's good opinion and estimate. He rather seeks to satisfy his Lord. He, therefore, does his best in worshiping Allah *(SWT)* praying at night while people are asleep.

Then comes another type of sincerity; one that is more important than what has just been said. It is sincerity in repentance, even when you turn back to Allah *(SWT)* in repentance in the ayahs that can be translated as, **"Say, (This is addressed to the Prophet) "O My bondmen who have been extravagant against themselves, (i.e., who have committed sins) do not feel despondent of the mercy of Allah! Surely Allah forgives guilty (deeds) all together; surely He, Ever He, is The Ever-Forgiving, The Ever-Merciful. And turn penitent to your Lord, and surrender to Him, even before the torment comes up to you; thereafter you will not be vindicated." (TMQ, 39: 53-54).**

Notice the expression, "**turn penitent**." It reveals the quick repentance to Allah *(SWT)*. From this we conclude that sincerity helps the person to go on obeying Allah *(SWT)* and turning back to Him in repentance.

If they ask for help, He will offer it to them:

At the end of the Surah the ayahs warn us against false worshiping and associating partners with Allah in what can be translated as**, "Say, "Is it then, other than Allah you (willfully) command me to worship, you ignorant ones?" And indeed it has already been revealed to you (The Prophet) and to the ones before you: "Indeed in case you associate (other gods with Allah), indeed your deeds will definitely be frustrated and indeed you will definitely be among the losers. No indeed, (but) Allah you (must) then worship and be among the thankful." (TMQ, 39: 64-66).**

How could a person be insincere to Allah *(SWT)* to whom all things in heaven and earth belong? False worshiping and insincerity are an underestimation of Allah's *(SWT)* Greatness (Allah forbid). Then comes the Ayah saying what can be translated as, **"And in no way did they estimate Allah His true estimate; and the earth all together will be His grasp on the Day of the Resurrection, and the heavens will be folded in His Right Hand. All Extolment be to Him, and Supremely Exalted be He above whatever they associate (with Him)! (TMQ, 39: 67).** All those who associate partners with Allah *(SWT)*, whether openly or secretly, do not really understand the Greatness of Allah (*SWT*).

An end that arouses spirits:

We then come across some humble ayahs that move hearts as they describe scenes from the Day of Judgment: the conditions of people in hell and of those in heaven. Such ayahs purify you from false worshiping and hypocrisy or ostentation, and increase your fear from Allah *(SWT)* which consequently help you in repentance and worship. Read what can be translated as**, "And the Trumpet is blown; then whoever is in the heavens and whoever is in the earth will (get) stunned, excepting whom Allah decides (to exempt). Thereafter it will be blown another time; then, only then will they be upright, looking on! (TMQ, 39: 68).** Then Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And the ones who disbelieved will be driven in hordes to Hell until when they have come to it, its gates will be opened, and its Keepers will say to them, "Did not Messengers come up to you from among yourselves reciting to you the signs of your Lord and warning you against the meeting of this your Day?" They will say, "Yes indeed, but the word of torment has come true against the disbelievers." (TMQ, 39: 71). "And the ones who were pious to their Lord will be driven in hordes to the Garden till when they have come to it, and its gates will be opened, and its Keepers will say to them, "Peace be upon you! You have been good, so enter (into) it eternally (abiding)." (TMQ, 39: 73).**

What a difference between the destinations of both people and between the expressions, "Its gates will be opened," in both cases. The magnificence of the Qur'an is clear in using the word "and" to express this difference.

People from both parties will be led to the place Allah reserved for them (Paradise or Hell) where they will settle forever. They will both be led in company with the type of people (believers, disbelievers) with whom they spent their lifetime. **"And the ones who were pious to their Lord will be driven in hordes to the Garden till when they have come to**

it, and its gates will be opened, and its Keepers will say to them, "Peace be upon you! You have been good, so enter (into) it eternally (abiding)." (TMQ, 39: 73).

Allah (SWT) says about the destiny of the disbelievers what can be translated as,

What is the difference between both ayahs? Only the one who is interested in learning and understanding the Qur'an can notice the difference. On the one hand, the disbelievers will be led to Hell frightened, suddenly the gates of hell open to them (Allah forbid). On the other hand, the believers move peacefully in one crowd looking forward to heaven, and its gates open to them.

What a great expression, and a wonderful meaning. You will notice that there is not a letter in the Qur'an that has no meaning or significance. This is what we refer to as the inimitable nature of the Qur'an in so far as the style and meaning are concerned.

Don't you wish to follow them?

The Surah ends with ayahs that soften the heart and fill it with craving for heaven in what can be translated as, **"And the ones who were pious to their Lord will be driven in hordes to the Garden till when they have come to it, and its gates will be opened, and its Keepers will say to them, "Peace be upon you! You have been good, so enter (into) it eternally (abiding)."And they will say, "Praise be to Allah, Who has sincerely (made good) His promise to us and has made us inherit the earth for us, to make our location in the Garden where we decide. So how favorable is the reward of the (good) doers." And you will see the Angels encircling round about the Throne extolling with the praise of their Lord; and (justice) will be decreed between them with the Truth; and it will be said, "Praise be to Allah, the lord of the worlds."(TMQ, 39: 73-75).**

Why Az-Zumar?

As usual, there remains an important question : what is the wisdom behind the name of the Surah. I think, and Allah alone knows the truth about it, that what helps you most in being sincere and devoted to Allah *(SWT)* in your work (deeds) is being in a righteous company. Consequently, the reward you will have for your sincere devotion is to be in the hereafter with the righteous people you spent your lifetime with, the believers. As scholars state Allah (SWT) prefers to make people enter paradise in groups and not one by one.

The Surah was given that name to remind us of both parties. You have to choose for yourself how to be sincere, and with which one you would like to belong to.

Surat Ghafir (The Forgiver)

Surah Ghafir is Makkan. It follows Surat Az-Zumar both in the order of revelation and in that the Qur'an. It consists of 85 Ayahs.

Invite people to the path of Allah and leave it all to Him

The main focus of the Surah is the importance of *Da'wa* (missionary activity) and entrusting Allah (*SWT)* with everything in the course of such mission. But, why should one entrust Allah while performing Da'wa?

A person who shoulders the responsibility of *Da'wa* faces a lot of obstacles and difficulties during his/her mission. Hence, dear Moslem brother/sister, if you choose the path of *Da'wa*, the path of Allah's messengers and Prophets, you have to know that it is full of obstacles. You also have to know that you have to leave everything to Allah (*SWT*), entrusting Him with anything that occurs. A central Ayah in this Surah addresses you, saying what can be translated as, "**Surely We indeed vindicate Our Messengers and the ones who have believed in the present life (Literally: lowly life, i.e., the life of this world) and upon the Day when the (noble) Witnesses rise up," (TMQ, 40: 51).**

This Ayah is directed to you as well as to Prophets (**Our Messengers and the ones who have believed**), and promises you with victory from Allah (*SWT*) in the present life before the afterlife (**in the present life (Literally: lowly life, i.e., the life of this world) and upon the Day when the (noble) Witnesses rise up**). Thus, you have to entrust Allah (*SWT*) with the whole matter.

Best words and best deeds

Surat Ghafir is among many Surahs that encourage people to take the responsibility of the most honorable mission in the world throughout history, i.e. *Da'wa*. It is the path taken by messengers and Prophets, therefore one must be keen on following it, and even to dedicate one's life to deliver good and righteousness to people.

Yet, this mission is not a difficult one. It does not require persons of genius or scholars to handle it. Thus, you can talk to your colleagues and friends about Islam, and its greatness and mercy. You can even spread useful Islamic tapes or books that help in teaching people the truths about their religion and bring them closer to Allah (*SWT*). O Moslem sister! You can talk to your girl companions about chastity and shyness with whatever means that reaches their hearts easily. You don't have to wait for the results, you have to work and leave it to Allah (*SWT*) who guides whom He (*SWT*) wants to His right path.

I take refuge in my Lord and your Lord

As the Surah talks about *Da'wa* and about confiding to Allah (*SWT*) leaving everything in His hands, these meanings appear clearly twice in the story of Prophet Musa (*AS*) "Moses". Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, "**And Firaawn (the Pharaoh) said, "Leave me (alone) (i.e., Keep away from me) to kill Mûsa, and let him invoke his Lord. Surely I fear that he may exchange your religion or that he may cause corruption to appear in the land." (TMQ, 40: 26).**

When *Firaawn* threatened to kill Musa, Musa (AS) continued his *Da'wa,* inviting people to the path of Allah (*SWT*) and His religion, and he depended on Allah in handling all that would happen. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, "**And Mûsa said, "Surely I take refuge in my Lord and your Lord from every proud (one) who does not believe in the Day of Reckoning." (TMQ, 40: 27).**

I confide my command to Allah

The second example of confiding to Allah (*SWT*) is embodied in a believer from Firaawn's house. This man concealed his belief, but when he saw Firaawn and his followers weaving a conspiracy to kill Musa (AS), he said what can be translated as, "**Will you kill a man for that he says, 'My Lord is Allah' "(TMQ, 40: 28).** Firaawn was shocked to find a man of his followers defending Musa (AS), and all the attendees were sure that he would destroy that man. Yet, the honest believer immediately confided his command to Allah (*SWT*) saying what can be translated as, "**Then you will soon remember what I say to you; and I confide my Command (Or: my affair) to Allah. Surely Allah is Ever-Beholding (His) bondmen." (TMQ, 40: 44).**

What happened after this? "**So Allah protected him against the odious (things) of their scheming," (TMQ, 40: 45).**

It is as if the meaning of the ayah is, "O Muslim! Call people to the path of Allah and don't ever be afraid of any person or of being blamed. Confide in Allah and depend on Him seeking refuge from your enemies, as Musa (AS) said what can be translated as, **"Surely I take refuge in my Lord and your Lord" (TMQ, 40: 27).**

Obstacles along the path

The path of *Da'wa* is hard and full of obstacles and hardships, but all these are mush easier than those faced by Prophet Musa (AS) and the believer of Firaawn's house. Hence, if anyone mocks you, insults you, or makes your life hard, you have to resort to Allah (*SWT*) confiding in him, and keep on the track of *Da'wa.* The whole Muslim nation is obliged to perform *Da'wa,* as Surat Al-'Imran mentions what can be translated as, "**You have been the most charitable nation brought out to mankind: you command beneficence, and forbid maleficence, and believe in Allah" (TMQ, 3: 110).**

What is it that makes us the most charitable nation? Commanding beneficence and forbidding maleficence first, then believing in Allah (*SWT*). This clarifies this great obligation that distinguishes us among other nations.

The shortest way to hearts

Not only does this Surah encourage believers to perform *Da'wa,* but it also guides us to the best means of helping people. This is clear through the story of the believer of Firaawn's house, and the means used by this divine preacher in inviting his people to the path of Allah. Let's all learn wonderful Qur'anic lessons teaching us how to invite people to the path of Allah (*SWT*).

Logical persuasion

Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, "**And a believing man of Firaawn's (Pharoh) house who kept back his belief said, "Will you kill a man for that he says, 'My Lord is Allah, ' and he has come to you with the supreme evidence (s) from your Lord? And in case he is a liar, then his lying is upon himself, and in case he is sincere, some of that which he promises you will alight on you" " (TMQ, 40: 28).**

The man is telling his people, "Listen to him then decide whether to accept or to refuse. Yet, you have to know that if he is lying, the consequences will be set upon him only, but if he is sincere, you will bear the results and get destroyed". This talk is logical and wise, and it depends on simplifying facts.

Modesty with people

After using the logical method, the believer moved to another one. He said what can be translated as, "**O my people, today the kingdom is yours, you being topmost in the land; yet who will vindicate us against the violence of Allah in case it comes upon us?" (TMQ, 40: 29).**

Can you see how smart the believer was, especially in selecting the right words when talking to his people? When he talked about the kingdom and authority he said, "**the kingdom is yours**", and so he referred to their greatness and talked about their high positions. Yet, when he talked about the torture of Allah (*SWT*) he said, "**who will vindicate us**". In this context he got himself in to make them feel that he was one of them, that he was not belittling them because of his belief, and that he cared for them as he cared for himself.

Thus, from just one Ayah we can learn two lessons:

- Addressing people with the titles they like and setting them in their right positions when talking to them "**today the kingdom is yours, you being topmost in the land**".
- Not being arrogant when talking to people, and letting them feel that the preacher is one of them "**who will vindicate us**".

Sincere Feelings

After this the preacher moved to the emotional aspect of *Da'wa,* as he said what can be translated as, "**And O my people, surely I fear for you the Day of Summoning**." **(TMQ, 40: 32).** If you want to impress people, you have to love them and make them feel your love, mercy and fear for them from the torture of Allah (*SWT*). Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, "**O my people, surely I fear for you the like of the Day of the (allied) parties" (TMQ, 40: 30).**

Using History in *Da'wa*

After using logic and emotions, there comes the role of history. The believer quoted from history to invite people to follow the path of Allah (*SWT*). He told them what can be translated as, "**O my people, surely I fear for you the like of the Day of the (allied) parties, The like of the steadfast manner of the people of Nûh, (Noah) and Aad, and Thamû and the ones even after them; and in no way does Allah will an injustice for (His) bondmen" (TMQ, 40: 30-31).**

A person who performs *Da'wa* should have encyclopedic knowledge and culture, especially about history and past nations, so as to encourage people learn from their ancestors.

Reminding People of the Day of Judgment

At the end, the believer started talking about the Day of Judgment, because reminding people of that day is one of the most powerful means that should be used by preachers in *Da'wa.* He said what can be translated as, "**And O my people, surely I fear for you the Day of Summoning**." (TMQ, 40: 32), i.e. the Day of Judgment, and "**The Day you turn away, withdrawing; in no way would there be a safeguard for you from Allah; and whomever Allah leads into error, then in no way would anyone be a guide for him" (TMQ, 40: 33).**

He then got back to history, saying what can be translated as, "**And indeed Yû (Joseph) already came to you earlier with the supreme evidence (s)" (TMQ, 40: 34).** After this, he moved to using emotions, saying what can be translated as, "**O my people, closely follow me; I will guide you in the way of right-mindedness." (TMQ, 40: 38).** He then started to remind them of the Day of Judgment, saying what can be translated as, "**O my people, surely this present life (Literally: lowly life, i.e., the life of this world) is only a (passing) enjoyment, and surely the Hereafter is (really) the Home of Residence" (TMQ, 40: 39),** before resorting to the logical methodology that can be translated as, "**And O my people, how is it with me that I call you to deliverance, and you call me to the Fire? You call me to disbelieve in Allah and to associate with Him that of which I have no knowledge, and I call you to The Ever-Mighty, The Superb Forgiver" (TMQ, 40:40-42).**

The believer then concluded his preaching by confiding his command to Allah (*SWT*). He said what can be translated as, "**Then you will soon remember what I say to you; and I confide my Command (Or: my affair) to Allah. Surely Allah is Ever-Beholding (His) bondmen." (TMQ, 40: 44).** What a wonderful stand and an amazing argument used by the Islamic preacher. This man was not a Prophet, but his jealousy for the religion of Allah (*SWT*) and his love for Islam was the reason for his being mentioned in the Holy Qur'an, to be a model followed by Islamic preachers till the Day of Judgment in using the most suitable means in performing *Da'wa*.

Supplication …the title for confidence in Allah

Supplication is one of the most important signs of confiding in Allah (*SWT*), and this is why the Surah focuses much on supplication. At the very beginning the Surah mentions the angels' supplication for believers, which can be translated as, "**The ones who bear the Throne, and the ones around it, extol with the praise (s) of their Lord and believe in Him, and they ask forgiveness for the ones who have believed, "Our Lord, You embrace everything in mercy and knowledge; so forgive the ones who repent and closely follow Your way, and protect them from the torment of Hell Fire" (TMQ, 40: 7).**

The Surah concluded with an ayah famous for encouraging people to supplicate, which can be translated as, "**And your Lord has said, "Invoke Me and I will respond to you. Surely the ones who wax too proud to do Me worship will soon enter Hell utterly abject" (TMQ, 40: 60).**

Throughout the Surah, many ayahs holding the same meaning were mentioned. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, "**So invoke Allah, making the religion faithfully His" (TMQ, 40: 14).**

A person who will not pray or supplicate to Allah in life will regret it in the Hereafter, as Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, "**They will say, "They have erred away from us; no indeed, we used not to invoke anything earlier." (TMQ, 40: 74).** They try will hard to pray and supplicate, but it will not do them any good after leaving it in life. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, "**They will say, "Then do you invoke!" And in no way is the invocation of the disbelievers in anything except in error" (TMQ, 40: 50).**

If you need support while preaching and calling people to Allah, besides confiding in Allah and submitting to Him, read the Surah of *Da'wa* and confidence, read Surat Ghafir with this intention.

Surat Fussilat (Expounded), Surat Ash-Shura (Counsel), Surat Az-Zukhruf (Decoration), Surat Ad-Dukhan (Smoke), Surat Al-Jathiyah (Kneeling), Surat Al-Ahqaf (The sand dunes)

These six Surahs have many traits in common. The first trait is that they all start with the letters *Ha Mim* that is why they are called the *Hawamim* (i.e. the Surahs that begin with the Arabic letters *Ha Mim*)

***Ha Mim* and the initial letters**

All of these Surahs start with the letters *Ha Mim*. What is therefore, the significance of these letters? We have previously mentioned in Surat Al-'Imran that Allah (*SWT*) wanted to challenge the Arabs with the meaning of these letters. What is implied is that these letters are the primary materials used for writing prose and poetry just like in daily life the primary materials found in our surroundings such as: iron, metals and wood, are used to make: cars, furniture, and buildings. However, the challenge lies in whether you can create from these materials a living human being. In that manner, the challenge is about the letters themselves.

Letters are the primary materials of our language. Can we, however, create from them a Qur'an? And can we breathe life into these letters? Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And thus We have sent to you (O Muhammad) *Ruh* (a Revelation, and a Mercy) of Our Command " (TMQ, 42:52).** Thus, Allah *(SWT)* put forth the challenge of coming up with something like a Qur'an. (It is worth mentioning that this particular *ayah* (verse) belongs to one of the *Hawamim* Surahs)

A single key for a single purpose

The Surahs that begin with the same initials must have something in common. It seems that *Alif Lam Mim and Ha Mim* are the symbols (or the code) of the Surah's topic and main idea. Furthermore, all of the Surahs that begin with this symbol are similar in their topics and purpose (As in Surat Al-Baqara, Surat Al-'Imran and Surat Al-Ankabut).

Obviously, all the *Hawamim* Surahs begin with the same initials (*Ha Mim*) because they share the same purpose. In order to know this purpose, we have to examine first the points that these Surahs share:

1. They are all Makkan Surahs (revealed in Makkah).
2. They all start by illustrating the value and the greatness of the Qur'an.
3. They all mention the story of Musa (*AS*) (Moses) with the Israelites.
4. They all illustrate how the Message was transferred from the Israelites to Muhammad's *(SAWS)* nation.
5. They all encourage unity and warn against division.
6. They all end with granting forgiveness and more time.

Let us then start by examining these meanings and connecting them together to discover what Allah *(SWT)* wanted us to understand from these noble Surahs.

1. The value of the Qur'an:

All of these Surahs start by mentioning the value and greatness of the Qur'an:

In Surat Fussilat, Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"*Ha-Mim*. A revelation from (Allah), the Most Gracious, the Most Merciful" (TMQ, 41:1 & 2).**

In Surat Ash-Shura, Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as**, "*Ha-Mim*. *'Ain-Sin-Qaf*. Likewise Allah, the All Mighty, the All Wise sends Revelation to you (O Muhammad) as (He sent Revelation to) those before you" (TMQ, 42: 1 & 2 & 3).**

In Surat Az-Zukhruf, Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"*Ha-Mim*. By the manifest Book (i.e. this Qur'an that makes things clear). (TMQ, 43:1& 2).**

In Surat Ad-Dukhan, Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"*Ha-Mim*. By the manifest Book (this Qur'an) that makes things clear" (TMQ, 44:1& 2).**

In Surat Al-Jathiyah, Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"*Ha-Mim*. The revelation of the Book (this Qur'an) is from Allah, the All-Mighty, the All-Wise." (TMQ, 45:1 & 2).**

In Surat Al-Ahqaf, Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"*Ha-Mim*. The revelation of the Book (this Qur'an) is from Allah, the All-Mighty, the All-Wise." (TMQ, 46:1& 2).**

2. The story of Musa *(AS)* and the Israelites:

In Surat Fussilat, Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And indeed We gave Musa (Moses) the Scripture, but dispute arose therein." (TMQ, 41:45).**

In Surat Az-Zukhruf, Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as **"And indeed We did send Musa (Moses) with Our *Ayat* (proofs, evidence, verses, lessons, signs, revelations, etc.) to Fir'aun (Pharaoh) and his chiefs (inviting them to Allah's religion of Islam)" (TMQ, 43:46).**

In Surat Ad-Dukhan, Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And indeed We tried before them Fir'aun's (Pharaoh) people, when there came to them a noble Messenger [i.e. Musa (Moses)], Saying: "Deliver to me the slaves of Allah (i.e. the Children of Israel). Verily, I am to you a Messenger worthy of all trust."** (TMQ, **44:17 &18),** and **"And indeed We saved the Children of Israel from the humiliating torment" (TMQ, 44:3).**

In Surat Al-Jathiyah, Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And indeed We gave the Children of Israel the Scripture, and the understanding of the Scripture and its laws, and the Prophethood" (TMQ, 45:16).**

In Surat Al-Ahqaf, Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And before this was the Scripture of Musa (Moses) as a guide and a mercy." (TMQ, 46:12).**

The story of Musa *(AS)* is the most frequently mentioned story in the Holy Qur'an. One might wonder what the reason behind that is. In fact, it is because the story of Musa *(AS)* contains two main points. The first is his relationship with *firaawn* (Pharaoh: the king of

ancient Egypt), which represented one of the strongest confrontations in the struggle between good and evil. The second is his relationship with the Israelites who were the last nation to lead humanity before Muhammad's *(SAWS)* nation. Hence, this story is important so that the Muslim nation could learn from their predecessors' mistakes and from their manner of guiding humanity.

3. Transferring the Book (Message) from the preceding nation (the Israelites) to Muhammad's nation:

Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"He (Allah) has ordained for you the same religion (Islâmic Monotheism) which He ordained for Nuh (Noah), and that which We have revealed to you (O Muhammad), and that which We ordained for Ibrahim (Abraham), Musa (Moses) and 'Isa (Jesus) saying you should establish religion (i.e. to do what it orders you to do practically), and make no divisions in it (religion) (i.e. various sects in religion)." (TMQ, 42:13).**

This Surah includes an important ayah, which can be translated as, **"…you should establish religion (i.e. to do what it orders you to do practically"** This ayah is the central point of all the *Hawamim* Surahs. How is this so? that is what we will see once we understand the purpose of all the Surahs.

The following ayahs also convey the same meaning:

In Surat Al-Jathiyah, Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Then We have put you (O Muhammad) on a (plain) way of (Our) commandment [like the one which We commanded Our Messengers before you (i.e. legal ways and laws of the Islâmic Monotheism)]. So follow you that (Islâmic Monotheism and its laws)," (TMQ, 45:18).**

In Surat Az-Zukhruf, Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And verily this (the Qur'an) is indeed a Reminder for you (O Muhammad) and your people (Quraish people, or your followers), and you will be questioned (about it)." (TMQ, 43:44).**

In Surat Al-Ahqaf, Allah *(SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"And before this was the Scripture of Musa (Moses) as a guide and a mercy. And this is a confirming Book (the Qur'an) in the Arabic language." (TMQ, 46:12).**

4. Unity and the danger of division:

In Surat Fussilat, Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And indeed We gave Musa (Moses) the Scripture, but dispute arose therein" (TMQ, 41:45).**

In Surat Ash-Shura, Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **" He (Allah) has ordained for you the same religion (Islâmic Monotheism) which He ordained for Nuh (Noah), and that which We have revealed to you (O Muhammad), and that which We ordained for Ibrahim (Abraham), Musa (Moses) and 'Isa (Jesus) saying you should establish religion (i.e. to do what it orders you to do practically), and make no divisions in it (religion) (i.e. various sects in religion)." "And they divided not till after knowledge had come to them, through (selfish) transgression between themselves "(TMQ, 42:13 & 14).**

In Surat Az-Zukhruf, Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"But the sects from among themselves differed. So woe to those who do wrong [by ascribing things to 'Isa (Jesus) that are not true] from the torment of a painful Day (i.e. the Day of Resurrection)!" (TMQ, 43:65).**

In Surat Al-Jathiyah, Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And gave them clear proofs in matters [by revealing to them the Taurat (Torah)]. And they differed not until after the knowledge came to them, through envy among themselves." (TMQ, 45:17).**

5. Forgiveness and more time

It is interesting to see how all these Surahs ended by granting forgiveness, more time, and instructing people to be patient.

In Surat Ash-Shura, Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Say (O Muhammad): "No reward do I ask of you for this except to be kind to me for my kinship with you." (TMQ, 42:23)** and**, "And verily, whosoever shows patience and forgives, that would truly be from the things recommended by Allah." (TMQ, 42:43).**

In Surat Az-Zukhruf, Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"So turn away from them (O Muhammad), and say: *Salam* (peace)! But they will come to know." (TMQ, 43:89).**

In Surat Ad-Dukhan, Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Wait then (O Muhammad); verily, they (too) are waiting." (TMQ, 44:59).**

In Surat Al-Ahqaf, Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Therefore be patient (O Muhammad) as did the Messengers of strong will." (TMQ, 46:35).**

After presenting the points that these Surahs have in common, the following question remains: what is the central purpose and feature they all share?

Between *Da'wa* (missionary activity) and confrontation:

These Surahs are situated in the Qur'an after Surat Ghafir and before Surat Muhammad. It is the same order in which these Surahs were revealed for they are all Makkan Surahs revealed after Surat Ghafir, and before Surat Muhammad which is a Madinan one (revealed in Madinah).

If we contemplate about the purpose of the two Surahs that are positioned before and after the *Hawamim* Surahs, we will find that Surat Ghafir discusses the importance of *Da'wa* to Allah *(SWT)* whereas Surat Muhammad discusses the importance of fighting for the sake of Allah *(SWT)* and advocating religion. Thus, we may say that these Surahs, as a whole, represent a transitional stage between *Da'wa* and confrontation.

Nevertheless, what does this have to do with the previously mentioned four points which include the value of the Qur'an, the Israelites (including those who inherited the Book), and the importance of unity, and granting forgiveness and more time?

Duties and prohibitions:

The aim of these Surahs is to make the Muslim nation aware of the fact that it has become responsible for the Qur'an, according to Allah's *(SWT)* order on this earth. Therefore, there are duties and prohibitions to be taken into consideration. Also, a number of significant points are required to be qualified for this responsibility.

Thus, all of the above mentioned Surahs started by highlighting the value of the Qur'an and mentioning the story of Musa *(AS)* and the Israelites as well as the transferring of the Book from them to Muhammad's *(SAWS)* nation.

Moreover, each one of these Surahs illustrates the importance of unity and the dangers of division because the loss of the Israelites and the preceding nations were caused by their division. The Surahs also highlight the importance of granting forgiveness and more time because they were revealed during the stage of introducing the Book and of calling to its adherence (i.e. the stage between *Da'wa* and confrontation). Hence, it was necessary to grant others forgiveness in order to present the Book in a sound and correct manner.

After portraying the general points and purposes that the *Hawamim* Surahs share, let us now see how each one of them serves their joint purpose, which is: You are responsible for this humanity, and there are duties and prohibitions you must consider.

= Surat Fussilat (Expounded) =

The first of these obligations for the Ummah of Prophet Mohamed *(SAWS)* is to understand the Qur'an and to receive it with due preservation, attention and understanding. But what is the relation between this Surah and the general objective mentioned before?

The *Ha Mim* series (Surahs that begin with the letters *Ha and Mim*) as we have noticed, represent transitional stage of calling for confrontation. The first Surah in this series shows the clarity of Allah's *(SWT)* message to mankind, its detailing and facilitation. This can be deduced from the name of the Surah "Fussilat" as indicated by the core ayah at the beginning of this Surah. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, "**A book, whereof the verses are explained in detail; an Arabic Qur'an, for people who understand" (TMQ, 41: 3).**

Good Reception:

Surat Fussilat deals with the importance of good reception of Allah's *(SWT)* commands.

The clarity of the transmission and reception is a must for any message to be properly delivered, in addition to the understanding of the used language. This was indicated in the first *ayahs* (verses) of this Surah. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"A Book, whereof the verses are explained in detail." (TMQ, 41: 3).** We notice this meaning clearly when Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, "**Had we sent this as a Qur'an (in language) other than Arabic, they would have said: "Why are not its verses explained in detail? What! A foreign (tongue) and an Arab (messenger) " (TMQ, 41: 44).**

This Surah shows us who benefits from the Qur'an, Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Say: It is a guide and healing to those who believe" (TMQ, 41: 44).** It is as if it says to the disbelievers, "Do not you understand that the problem lies in yourselves and your

receiving set." Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And for those who believe not, there is deafness in their ears, and it is blindness in their eyes." (TMQ, 41: 44).**

Thus the Surah mentions the characteristics of the good receiver of Allah's *(SWT)* commands. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **" In the case of those who say, " Our lord is Allah ", and, further, stand straight and steadfast, the angels descend on them " from time to time ", " fear ye not! " "They suggest", "Nor grieve! " (TMQ, 41: 30).**

Good reception necessitates belief in Allah *(SWT)*, then straightness in obedience to him. Calling people to Allah *(SWT)* and guiding them to His way facilitate the good receipt of Allah's *(SWT)* commands.

Bad reception of revelation:

On the contrary, the Surah reveals how people look after their interest only even in their relation with Allah the Exalted. This is one of the most serious things, which impede the sound reception of Allah's *(SWT)* signs and His Divine Decree and predestination. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Man does not weary of asking for good "things", but if ill touches him, he gives up all hope " and" is lost in despair. When we give him a taste of some mercy from us, after some adversity has touched him, he is sure to say, " This is due to my "merit"…" (TMQ, 41: 49 –50) "When we bestow favors on man, he turns away, and gets himself remote on his side" (TMQ, 41: 51).**

Despite all of these concerns, which are a part of the human nature, the reception will remain sound and Allah's *(SWT)* signs, which are an evidence of His incomparable greatness, will remain clearly visible. Thus, the following glorious ayah comes to indicate that. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Soon will we show them our signs in the "furthest" regions " of the earth", and in their own soul, until it becomes manifest to them that this is the truth." (TMQ, 41: 53).**

Therefore, before completing recitation of the Ha Mim series rectify yourself so that you can benefit from these obligations and warnings, which you need during assuming your responsibility on earth.

= Surat Ash-Shura (Counsel) =

We see in Surat Ash-Shura that what is forbidden is dispute and separation, and the obligation that protects from indulging in dispute is consultation. This is the theme of Surat Ash-Shura.

Yes for disagreement, no for dispute:

It is due to the beauty of this Surah that it deals with dispute in a realistic way and emphasizes that it is natural among people that they differ. There is no problem in that as we see when Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Whatever it be wherein you differ the decision thereof is with Allah." (TMQ, 42: 10).** But when it dealt with disunion, it warned against it severely. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Namely, that you should remain steadfast in religion and make no division therein" (TMQ, 42: 13).** It rebuked those from preceding nations who indulged in it. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be

translated as, **"And they become divided only after knowledge reached them, being insolent to another" (TMQ, 42:14).**

The Surah confirmed that disagreement is normal and logical because it is impossible for all people to agree on the same opinion in all matters. What is forbidden is division and dispute (Therefore the word division is repeated four times in this Surah). However what is the solution to maintain union in spite of difference in opinions? It is the mutual consultation, which if we maintain in all our affairs, in our houses, with our children and in our companies and institutions, we will safeguard our nation against the same separation the predecessors suffered.

= Surat Az-Zukhruf (Decoration) =

Surat Az-Zukhruf emphasizes the basic meanings of the *Ha Mim* series and directs attention towards one of the warnings that can endanger the responsibility of guarding the Book. This warning is clearly evident through the name of the Surah, which is Az-Zukhruf or temptation by the vanities of this world and its false glitter. Thus, the Surah sheds light on material appearances and people being dazzled by them, as this is one of the grave reasons behind neglecting the divine message. The Surah confirmed, by contrast, that real adornment and felicity do not exist in this life but in paradise, which has been promised to the pious.

The worldly life enjoyment:

The mention of gold and silver is repeated in this Surah more than any other. If those material appearances were equal to a mosquito wing for Allah *(SWT*, He would deprive disbelievers of them. It was possible, due to their contemptible value, that Allah *(SWT)* might grant disbelievers many of these appearances but He did not so that the believer may not be tempted and follow them.

Listen with me to these ayahs as Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And were it not that (all) people might become one community we would provide for everyone that blasphemes against the Most Gracious, silver roofs for their houses, and (silver) stair-ways on which to go up* And (silver) doors to their houses, and couches (of silver) on which they could recline. And also adornments of gold. But all this was nothing but enjoyment of the present life: the Hereafter, in the sight of your Lord, is for the righteous."(TMQ,: 43:33-35).**

Real adornment:

While the Surah mentions the evanescent enjoyment of this life and calls people for asceticism in it, it also reveals the real adornment and that is paradise and what Allah *(SWT)* has prepared for the pious in it. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Enter you the garden, you and your wives, in (beauty and) rejoicing*To them will be passed round, dishes and goblets of gold: there will be there all that the souls could desire, all that the eyes could delight in: And you shall abide there in (for aye)" (TMQ,: 43:70-71).**

It is as if the meaning is, "O believers do not be dazzled by this life's ornament. Do not be deceived by its enjoyment because the hereafter's enjoyment prepared for the pious is more important and splendid."

Shortsightedness:

The Surah goes on criticizing those who measure things based on appearances. It talks about the polytheists as follows in what can be translated as, **"Also, they say: why is not this Qur'an sent down to some leading men in either of the two (chief) cities?"(TMQ, 43:31).**

They denied the Qur'an, not because of the Qur'an itself, but because it was not sent down to the rich chiefs and people of high rank. Thus, the following ayah answers them in what can be translated to mean, **"Is it they who would portion out the mercy of your Lord" (TMQ, 43:31).**

Unfortunately, we find many people who use the same logic as disbelievers in the above-mentioned ayah. They refuse religion either out of fear for some accustomed appearances to which they were accustomed or because they disdain to deal with the religious people. To those we say: Read Surat Az-Zukhruf and do not set this life ornament as a barrier between you and religion.

The ayahs go on stating life enjoyment in what can be translated to mean, **"Is then one brought up among trinkets, and unable to give a clear account in a dispute (to be associated with Allah)?" (TMQ, 43:18).** In the next ayah Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And they make into females angels who themselves serve Allah" the word females is a reference to the material appearances that one seeks.**

Pharaoh and material appearances:

This is Pharaoh who wanted to disprove Musa *(AS)* (*Moses*) so he was deceived by his material strength. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Does not the dominion of Egypt belong to me, (witness) these streams flowing underneath my (palace)? What see you not then?" (TMQ, 43:51).**

Pharaoh's view about Musa *(AS)* was a material one. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Am I not better than this (Moses), who is a contemptible wretch and can scarcely express himself clearly? "(TMQ, 43: 52-53).** Pharaoh was immersed in material appearances to the extent that he asked Musa *(AS)* to bring golden bracelet from the heaven, as if this bracelet would make him believe in Allah *(SWT)*.

Issa (Jesus) son of Mary: Symbol Of asceticism:

As a contrary example to Pharaoh, that man who has been blinded by this worldly life and its materialism, comes *Issa* (*AS*) (Jesus) in what can be translated as, **"When (Jesus) the son of Mary is held up as an example, behold your people raise a clamor thereat (in ridicule)" (TMQ, 43:57).** This noble Prophet *(AS)* was a good example to children of Israel in asceticism and lightening worldly ornament. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"He was no more than a servant: we granted our favor to him, and we made him an example to the children of Israel" (TMQ, 43:59).**

What was then his message? We notice that his mission included two central core points connected with the *Ha Mim* Surahs in what can be translated to mean:

"When Jesus came with clear signs, he said: Now have I come to you with wisdom" (TMQ, 43:63). This wisdom is the substitute for all these appearances in which Issa's people took an interest. (This is consistent with the objective of Surat Az-Zukhruf) **"And in order to make clear to you some of the (points) on which you dispute" (TMQ, 43:63).** (This is accordant with Surat Ash-Shura objective of union).

Beware of adornment:

Surat Az-Zukhruf, through guiding Muslims to assume their responsibility towards the Qur'an, warns that if they cling to the material appearances, they will not prosper.

Is there any reason behind the deterioration of our nation in this era other than hanging on to material appearances and being dazzled by the western material civilization?

The Surah warns also those who take friends on the basis of material appearances as Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Friends on that Day will be foes, one to another except the righteous"** Then comes the comment when Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"The (Qur'an) is indeed a reminder for thee and for thy people; and soon shall you (all) be brought to account" (TMQ, 43:44).**

This is the real honor and divine glory. It lies in adhering to the Holy Qur'an and acting in accordance with Islamic teachings. This ayah shows us how the objective of Surat Az-Zukhruf comes under the general objective of the *Ha Mim* series which is: Beware of seeking glory in material appearances and do adhere to the Qur'an because in it lies your exaltation and glory.

= Surat Ad-Dukhan (Smoke) =

Surah Az-Zukhruf has warned man against the danger of being overpowered by the deceiving materialistic luxury of life and against its effect on the *Ummah's* (nation) duties towards the Qur'an and religion in general. Surah Ad-Dukhan then comes to warn against the allurement of power and high-handedness.

The end of evil-doers in life

Harsh words in the verses comment on the end of evildoers and whoever toes their line as Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"They left how many gardens and springs, And plantations and how honorable a station, And what comfort they used to (enjoy) cheerfully! Thus (it was); and We made another people to inherit (these favors). So, in no way did the heaven and the earth weep for them, and in no way were they respited." (TMQ, 44: 25-29).**

Surah Az-Zukhruf states that *Firaawn* (Pharaoh) rejected *Musa (AS)* (Moses) because he was deceived by his materialistic possessions. Surah Ad-Dukhan, on the other hand, cites another reason, which is his power and high-handedness as Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"From Fir'aun; (Pharaoh) surely he was exalted, of the extravagant." (TMQ, 44: 31).**

The torment of evildoers in the afterlife

The Surah describes a horrible scene of The Day of Judgment of those who were diverted away by power and high-handedness and who forgot obeying Allah *(SWT)* when they are tortured**.** Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Surely the Tree of Az-Zaqqum, Is the food of the constantly vicious. Like molten metal, it boils in the bellies, As the boiling of scalding water." (TMQ, 44: 43 - 46).**

Allah's *(SWT)* also says what can be translated as, **"Taste! Surely you, (only) you are (i.e., you used to think that you were mighty) the constantly mighty, the constantly honorable!" (TMQ, 44: 49)** is a horrifying image of the torture in the afterlife that will befall those who went astray from the path of Allah *(SWT)* and were proud of their power and authority in this life.

= Surat Al-Jathiyah (Kneeling) =

Surat Al-Jathiyah addresses the Muslims who shoulder the Trust of Allah *(SWT)* and hold the Qur'an in their hearts. The Surah warns them against arrogance and conceit as Allah *(SWT)* says in what can be translated as, **"Woe to every constantly vicious (and persistent) falsifier, (Who) hears the signs (i.e. ayah, signs or verses) of Allah recited to him; thereafter he persists in waxing proud, as if he has not heard them; so give him the (good) tidings of a painful torment. And when he knows anything of Our signs, he takes them to himself in mockery; those will have a degrading torment." (TMQ, 45: 7-9).**

The arrogant usually cannot preserve the message and loses sight of the truth. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And as for the ones who have disbelieved, (it will be said), "So, were not My ayah being recited to you, yet you waxed proud, and you were a criminal people?" (TMQ, 45: 31).**

The Prophet *(SAWS)* said, "The person who has an atom weight of arrogance in his heart will not be permitted to enter Paradise."

This is why the Surah is called *Al-Jathiyah* (bowing the knee) to remind us about the arrogant nations who were deceived by their power and authority. This Surah describes to us the humility that awaits them in the Hereafter in what can be translated as, **"And you will see every nation kneeling. Every nation will be called to its Book. (It will be said), "Today you will be recompensed for whatever you were doing." (TMQ, 45: 28).**

The arrogant thinks that he is a counterpart of Allah *(SWT)* so the Surah ends with an *ayah* (verse) that makes any heart that carries arrogance tremble as Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And to Him (belongs) the Supreme Grandeur in the heavens and the earth; and He is The Ever-Mighty, The Ever-Wise." (TMQ, 45: 37).**

= Surat Al-Ahqaf (The Sand Dunes) =

Surat Al-Ahqaf brilliantly concludes*, Hawamim* (the Surahs that start with *Ha-Mim*). It features the different responses to the Qur'anic doctrine manifested in the previous Surahs. There were negative responses such as *Aad* in what can be translated as, **"And remember the brother of Aad, as he warned his people beside (i.e., in the valley of) the Sand Dunes and already warnings had passed away even before him, and even behind him, (saying), "Do not worship anybody except Allah! Surely I fear for you the torment of a tremendous Day." (TMQ, 46: 21).** They rejected his message strongly in what can be

translated as, **"They said, "Have you come to us to falsely (diverge) us from our gods? Then come up to us with (i.e., bring us) what you promise us, in case you are of the sincere."" (TMQ, 46: 22)** and even when they saw Allah's *(SWT)* punishment, arrogantly, in what can be translated as, **"Then, when they saw it as a traversing (cloud) proceeding towards their valleys, they said, "This traversing cloud will be (giving) us rain!" No indeed, (but) it is what you sought to hasten, a wind wherein is a painful torment," (TMQ, 46: 24).**

Even Jinns responded

The Jinns were the example that Allah *(SWT)* chose for the positive response to His call. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And (remember) as We turned about to you a batch of the jinn listening to the Qur'an; so, as soon as they were in its presence they said, "Hearken!" Then, as soon as it was accomplished, they turned back to their people, constantly warning." (TMQ, 46: 29).** This proves that only Allah *(SWT)* bestows guidance and that man has no power in this matter. So what was their reaction when they heard the call of Allah *(SWT)*? Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as**, "And (remember) as We turned about to you a batch of the jinn listening to the Qur'an; so, as soon as they were in its presence they said, "Hearken!" Then, as soon as it was accomplished, they turned back to their people, constantly warning. They said" 'O our people, surely we have heard a Book that was sent down even after Musa, (Moses) sincerely (verifying) what was before it, (Literally: between its two hands) guiding to the Truth and to a straight road." (TMQ, 46: 29-30).** Even Jinns believed Musa *(AS)* and hailed the value of the Qur'an and the role of Muslim generations in preserving it (notice how the integration among the Surahs of the Qur'an is quite obtrusive). After urging patience and tolerance in the previous Surahs, Surat Al-Ahqaf ends with what can be translated as, **"O our people, answer the Caller of Allah, and believe in Him, (and) He will forgive you (some) of your guilty (deeds), and (offer) you neighborly (protection) from a painful torment." (TMQ, 46: 31).**

Responding to parents

The Surah presents another kind of response, which is obedience to the parents. Again two examples are cited. The positive response in what can be translated as**, "And We have enjoined on man to show fairest (companionship) to his parents. His mother conceived him under compulsion, and she brought him forth under compulsion, and his pregnancy (i.e., the time he is in the womb) and his weaning are thirty months. Until, when he reaches full age, and reaches forty years, he says, "Lord! Dispense (to) me that I may thank (You) for Your favor wherewith You have favored me and my parents (both), and that I may do righteousness satisfying You, and make me righteous in my offspring. Surely I repent to You, and surely I am one of the Muslims." (i.e., one who surrenders to Allah)" (TMQ, 46: 15).** On the other hand, there is the negative response of disobedience and cruelty in what can be translated as, **"And he who says to his parents, "Fie upon you (both)! Do you (definitely) promise me that I will be brought out, when already generations have passed away before me?" And they both ask Allah for succor, "Woe to you! Believe; surely the promise of Allah is true." Yet he says, "In no way is this anything except myths of the earliest (people)." (TMQ, 46: 17).**

The subsequence and integration of Surahs

In the Qur'an, the *Hawamim* fell between Surah Ghafir, which stressed the importance of *Da'wa*, and Surat Muhammad, which is known as the Surah of Fighting. Thus, the verses that urge patience and tolerance increase towards the end of the Surahs. In Surah Az-Zukhruf there was what can be translated as, **"Yet pardon them, and say, "Peace!" Yet eventually they will know." (TMQ, 43: 89).** The meaning is clearer in Surah-Ad-Dukhan, it starts with what can be translated to mean, **"So be on the watch for a Day when the heaven will come up with an evident smoke," (TMQ, 44: 10)** and ends with what can be translated to mean, **"Then be on the watch; surely they (too) are on the watch" (TMQ, 44: 59).**

Patience…Confrontation…. Then conquer and victory

It seems that the *Hawamim* are the last Surahs that grant a respite to disbelievers. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"That (is) what Allah gives as good tidings to His bondmen who have believed and done deeds of righteousness. Say, "I do not ask of you a reward for it, except amity for kinship." And whoever scores (Literally: commits) a fair deed, We will give him increase of fairness (i.e., goodness) therein. Surely Allah is Ever-Forgiving, Ever-Thankful." (TMQ, 42: 23), "O our people, answer the Caller of Allah, and believe in Him, (and) He will forgive you (some) of your guilty (deeds), and (offer) you neighborly (protection) from a painful torment" (TMQ, 46: 31).** Then the last verse in Surat Al-Ahqaf gives the final command of tolerance in what can be translated as, **"Therefore patiently persevere, as did (all) Messengers of inflexible purpose; and be in no haste about the (Unbelievers)" (TMQ, 46: 35).**

The following Surah is Surat Muhammad, the Surah of fighting then Surat Al-Fath, which declares that victory is in the offing. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Surely We have given you an evident conquest, (Literally: conquered for you; or: opened for you)" (TMQ, 48: 1).**

We pray to Allah *(SWT)* that the readers of the Qur'an have gained love of the *Hawamim* and that they start memorizing them and reflecting on the integration of their ayahs and goals.

Surat Muhammad, Surat Al-Fath (Conquest), Surat Al-Hujuraat (The Apartments)

These three Surahs are Madinan and all focus on Prophet Muhammad *(SAWS)*: believing him, obeying him and urging discipline with him.

= Surat Muhammad =

The Surah consists of 38 Ayahs. It mentions acceptance and abortion of deeds 12 times. This is closely associated with obeying Allah *(SWT)* and obeying the Messenger *(SAWS)*. For instance, Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"O you who have believed, obey Allah, and obey the Messenger, and do not void your deeds." (TMQ, 47: 33).** Thus, it can be deduced that the message of the Surah is that obeying Prophet Muhammad *(SAWS)* and following his *Sunnah* are the criteria upon which deeds are either accepted or aborted. Hence, one should reflect on this meaning while reading the Surah and wonder about one's attitude towards Prophet Muhammad's *(SAWS) sunnah,* worship and manners.

Obedience is the criterion of following

The Surah was entitled "Muhammad" to remind Muslims that following Prophet Muhammad *(SAWS)* is the criterion of the acceptance of their deeds or their rejection. This is because any path other than that of Prophet Muhammad *(SAWS)* (meaning different from his *sunnah)* is misguided. Therefore, if you are wondering about the acceptance of your deeds, check your obedience to the Prophet (*SAWS*) and your following of his *sunnah* because this is the correct criterion.

Let's reflect on the ayahs of the Surah learn how to follow our Prophet (*SAWS*) as Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"The ones who have disbelieved and barred from the way of Allah, (He) will make their deeds to err away. And the ones who have believed and done deeds of righteousness and have believed in what has been successively sent down upon Muhammad-and it is the Truth from their Lord-He will expiate for them their odious deeds and will make righteous their state. That is because the ones who have disbelieved have closely followed untruth and the ones who have believed have closely followed the Truth from their Lord. Thus Allah strikes their similitudes for mankind." (TMQ, 47: 1-3)** and **"And the ones who have disbelieved, then misfortune is for them, and He will make their deeds to err away. That is for that they hate what Allah has sent down, so He has frustrated their deeds." (TMQ, 47: 8-9).**

The contrast is quite evident. Then Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"So know that there is no god except Allah, and ask forgiveness for your guilty deed, and for the male believers and female believers; and Allah knows your moving about and your lodging." (TMQ, 47: 19)**. This shows that asking Allah's *(SWT)* forgiveness and the word of monotheism guarantee the acceptance of deeds by Allah *(SWT).*

"But more fitting for them, Were it to obey and say what is just"

Then comes a central ayah in the Surah, where Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as**, "And the ones who have believed say, "Had a srah been successively sent down!" Then, when a clear srah is sent down, and therein fighting is mentioned, you see the ones in**

whose hearts is sickness looking at you with the look of one enveloped by the swooning of death; yet worthier of them would be. Obedience and beneficent saying. Then, when the Command is resolved, then if they were sincere to Allah, indeed it would be more charitable (i.e., better) for them" (TMQ, 47: 20-21). It is better for the disbelievers, if they wish their deeds to be accepted, to obey Prophet Muhammad *(SAWS)* and say good words. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"That is for that they have closely followed what causes wrath from Allah and hated His all-blessed Satisfaction; so He frustrated their deeds." (TMQ, 47: 28).**

This is followed by many ayahs that stress the same meaning as Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And if We had (so) decided, We would indeed have shown them to you. Then you would indeed recognize them by their marks, and indeed you would definitely know them by the distortion in their saying, and Allah knows your deeds." (TMQ, 47: 30), "you who have believed, obey Allah, and obey the Messenger, and do not void your deeds." (TMQ, 47: 33). "So do not feel feeble and call for (your) submission while (Literally: and) you are the most exalted ones; and Allah is with you, and He will never divest you of your deeds." (TMQ, 47: 35).**

It seems that the Surah addresses the Muslims affirming that any path other than that of Prophet Muhammad (*SAWS)* is misguided. Imam Ibn Hanbal said, "I studied the Qur'an and I found that obeying the Messenger has been mentioned 33 times" then he recited what can be translated as, **"Do not make the calling of the Messenger among yourselves like your calling of one another (Literally: some of you to some others). Allah already knows the ones of you who sneak away seeking shelter (i.e., to disobey him). So let the ones who fail (to obey) His Command beware that temptation may afflict them or painful torment may afflict them." (TMQ, 24: 63).**

How far you still are from the following saying of Allah *(SWT)* that can be translated as, **"And in no way should a male believer or a female believer, when Allah and His Messenger have decreed a Command, have the choice in their Command. Whoever disobeys Allah and His Messenger, then he has readily erred away into evident error." (TMQ, 33: 36)?** How about Allah's *(SWT)* saying what can be translated to mean, **"(Yet) no, by your Lord, they will not believe till they make you judge regarding what they controvert among themselves. Thereafter they should not find in themselves any restriction about whatever you have decreed, and should submit in full submission." (TMQ, 4: 65)** We clearly see that the ayahs of Surah Muhammad join many other ayahs of the Qur'an which relate to following the Prophet (*SAWS*).

Obedience in *Jihad* (fighting for the sake of Allah)

The Surah is called the Surah of fighting because the word 'fighting' is abundantly mentioned in it. Fighting is one of the most difficult commands to be obeyed. Hence, it seems as if the Surah is stressing that *Jihad* for the sake of Allah *(SWT)* is a true testimony to the sincere following of Prophet Muhammad *(SAWS)*. In addition, the order to fight is a divine trial and test as Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And indeed We will definitely try you until We know the ones of you who strive and the ones who are (steadfastly) patient and (we will) try your tidings (i.e., test your news to see who is a liar)". (TMQ, 47: 31).** Thus the ayahs feature different reactions of believers and hypocrites to such divine exam. Allah *(SWT)* states what can be translated as, **"And the ones who have believed say, "Had a srah been successively sent down!" Then, when a**

clear srah is sent down, and therein fighting is mentioned, you see the ones in whose hearts is sickness looking at you with the look of one enveloped by the swooning of death; yet worthier of them would be." (TMQ, 47: 20).

Obedience in spending

Therefore, the aim of the Surah is crystal-clear; it urges Muslims to follow Prophet Muhammad *(SAWS)* in all the moments of life especially in *jihad*. They should do so whether it is jihad in the battlefield or one's striving to purify oneself and resist one's desires. Since spending is the first prerequisite of *jihad*, the last ayah of the Surah stimulates Muslims to spend and strongly warn them against stinginess. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Now, you are these called to expend in the way of Allah. Then among you (some) are miserly; and whoever is miserly, then he is miserly only upon himself. And Allah is the Ever-Affluent, (Literally: Ever-Rich) and you are the poor ones. And in case you turn away, He will (readily) exchange you for another people; thereafter they will not be your likes." (TMQ, 47: 38).**

Finally, beware replacement

Having severely reprimanded the disbelievers and warning them against disobeying Prophet Muhammad *(SAWS)*, the Surah now addresses the believers briefly but strictly in what can be translated to mean, **"Now, you are these called to expend in the way of Allah. Then among you (some) are miserly; and whoever is miserly, then he is miserly only upon himself. And Allah is the Ever-Affluent, (Literally: Ever-Rich) and you are the poor ones. And in case you turn away, He will (readily) exchange you for another people; thereafter they will not be your likes." (TMQ, 47: 38).**

It is a serious rule, which reminds the believers that if they ever refrain from following Prophet Muhammad (*SAWS*) and obeying his orders, they shall be subject to severe punishment and serious consequences, which is "replacement". Allah *(SWT)* will bring forth other people who will be more capable of protecting Allah's *(SWT)* religion. The loss here will be enormous. **"…thereafter they will not be your likes." (TMQ, 47: 38)**. They would be better than you.

= Surat Al-Fath (The Conquest) =

The Surah was revealed after the Al-Hudaybia peace treaty, during a period of great depression for Prophet Muhammad's *(SAWS)* companions.

Revealed when morale was suffering

In the seventh year of the *hijra* (emigration from Makkah to Madinah) after the Battle of Al-Ahzab, the conflict between Muslims and polytheists was at its peak. Prophet Muhammad *(SAWS)* had a vision that he will enter *Al-Masjid Al-Haram* (The Sacred Mosque), so prepared himself and his companions to go to Makkah for *Umrah* (lesser pilgrimage), not battle. Nevertheless, when they reached Al-Hudaybia, the polytheists refused to allow the Muslims to enter Makkah. The Prophet *(SAWS)* then decided to sign a peace treaty with the polytheists of Makkah and it later came to be known as the Al-Hudaybia peace treaty.

The terms of the treaty were blatantly unfair for Muslims, which caused the Prophet's *(SAWS)* companions to become extremely upset at the Prophet's *(SAWS)* acceptance of it. Their sadness increased when they were prevented from entering *Al-Masjid Al-Haram* for performing *Umrah* and from fighting the polytheists. They felt they had accepted a bad deal for their religion.

At this difficult time, the Surah was sent down. Imagine yourself in the place of the Companions, strengthening the soul with the promise of *Umrah*.

The Prophet's happiness with the Surah

The name of the Surah explains its objective. It is the Surah of victories and divine generosity for this *Ummah* (Muslim nation). It was sent to enumerate the victories that Allah *(SWT)* will bestow upon the Muslims. Prophet Muhammad *(SAWS)* rejoiced with this Surah and said, "I have been sent a Surah that is better than anything on earth," and the Companions asked, "What is it Messenger of Allah?" He replied, "Surat Al-Fath."

Let us take a look at the Surah, so that we might rejoice as our beloved Prophet Muhammad *(SAWS)* rejoiced.

The Surah of divine victories

Even though the Surah consists of 29 verses, it relates many divine victories compared to the number of those Ayahs. Allah *(SWT)* grants Muslims eleven victories, favors, and good fortunes in this Surah:

1. Forgiveness of Sins**: Surely We have given you an evident conquest, (Literally: conquered for you; or: opened for you) That Allah may forgive you your guilty (deeds)-whatever of them has gone forward and whatever is postponed-and perfect His favor upon you, and guide you (The Prophet) on a straight Path, (TMQ, 48:1-2).**
2. Fulfillment of Favor**: "His favor upon you." (TMQ, 48:2).**
3. Guidance**: "And guide you (The Prophet) on a straight path." (TMQ, 48:2).**
4. Victory: **"And that Allah may vindicate you with a mighty victory." (TMQ, 48:3).** Notice that forgiveness comes before victory.
5. Sending tranquillity into the hearts of Muslims: **" He is (The One) Who sent down serenity (or: tranquillity) into the hearts of the believers, that they may increase in their belief to their belief." (TMQ, 48:4).**
6. Admitting those who believe into heaven**: "That He may cause the male believers and the female believers to enter the Gardens beneath which the rivers run, eternally (abiding) therein." (TMQ, 48:5).**
7. Exposing and punishing hypocrites and polytheists**: "And that He may torment the male hypocrites and the female hypocrites, and the male associators and the female associators, the ones surmising ill surmises of Allah." (TMQ, 48:6).**
8. Allah's Satisfaction with the believers: **"Indeed Allah has already been satisfied with the believers." (TMQ, 48:18).**
9. Material gains**: "Allah has promised you much booty to take." (TMQ, 48:20).**
10. Promising Muslims admission to *Al-Masjid Al-Haram* (The holy Mosque in Makkah)**: "Indeed Allah has already vouchsafed to His Messenger the vision of**

The Truth: "Indeed you will definitely enter the Inviolable Mosque, in case Allah (so) decides secure." (TMQ, 48:27).

11. Security and peace**: "(some of you) heads clean-shaven, (and some) hair cut short, not fearing. Yet He knew what you did not know, and so set up for you, apart from that a near conquest." (TMQ, 48:27).**
12. Manifestation of Islam: **"He is (the One) Who has sent His Messenger with guidance and the Religion of the Truth, that he (would) make it topmost above all religion." (TMQ, 48:28).**

It wasn't until this Surah was revealed that the companions of Prophet Muhammad *(SAWS)* had been told the precious good news that Islam will prevail the whole world.

Praise be to all of the Prophet's cCompanions

This Surah has more praise for the companions of Prophet Muhammad *(SAWS)* than any other Surah, notwithstanding the dissatisfaction they expressed regarding the peace treaty of Al-Hudaybia at the beginning. Allah *(SWT)* knew that their satisfaction was not for their own sake, but for the sake of Allah *(SWT)* and His Religion.

Notice the ayah Allah *(SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Surely the ones who swear allegiance to you, surely swear allegiance only to Allah: the Hand of Allah is above their hands." (TMQ, 48: 10).** Why did the Prophet's companions deserve all these victories, and all that praise? Ayah 18 answers this question saying what can be translated as, **"Indeed Allah has already been satisfied with the believers as they were swearing allegiance to you beneath the tree. So He knew what was in their hearts, then sent down serenity upon them; and requited them with a near conquest." (TMQ, 48: 18).**

This refers to the instance when Othman's *(RA)* murder was rumored and Prophet Muhammad *(SAWS)* took a pledge from his companions to fight for Othman's *(RA)* revenge. They pledged to fight until death in the cause of Allah *(SWT).* When their loyalty reached the point of giving their lives for Allah *(SWT)*, He revealed to them a quick victory.

Examples of victory

By reflecting on the meanings of the Surah, we notice that the ayahs considered the Al-Hudaybia peace treaty a victory, even though it did not appear to be so. This caused Omar Ibn Al-Khattab *(RA)* to ask, "Is it a victory?" and the reply was, "O Omar, it is a victory." The strange thing is that the peace treaty was called a victory while the Qur'an did not describe even the battle of Badr as such.

In addition, the word 'victory' was repeated four times throughout the Surah. This makes of it the Surah in which the word is the most frequently used, even though its ayahs are only 29. Not only that, it was also described as, "a mighty victory," and twice as, "a speedy victory." The ayahs did not only focus on victory, but also mentioned, "much booty," twice. I guess you will be asking yourself the same question as Omar *(RA)*, "Where is the victory?"

This victory was an increase in the rate of spread of Islam, because the number of those who embraced Islam after the treaty of Al-Hudaybia (in just two years) was twice more than the number of those who embraced it throughout the 20 previous years of *Da'wa* (missionary activity).

Even though the Prophet's *(SAWS)* companions wished to fight and were prepared for it, the ayahs showed that the real victory was the spread of Islam in the Arabian Peninsula, because the best atmosphere for Islam to spread and gain converts is peace. This is the glory of Islam. History testifies to its being a religion of peace. In fact, the times of its greatest expansion was during peace not war and thus we understand why the word 'tranquility' was mentioned in the Surah three times.

Characteristics of the people of victory

The last ayah describes the characteristics of those who deserved such divine victory in what can be translated as, **"Muhammad is the Messenger of Allah, and (the ones) who are with him are strict against the steadfast disbelievers, constantly merciful among themselves. You see them constantly bowing themselves, (and) constantly prostrating themselves, seeking Grace from Allah and all-blessed Satisfaction. Their mark is on their faces, (being) the trace of prostration; that is their likeness in the Tawrah; (the Book revealed to Musa (Moses), of which the extant Torah is a corruption) and their likeness in the Injil (The Book revealed to Isa (Jesus), of which the extant Gospel is a corruption) is as a plantation that brings out its shoot; then it upholds it; then it grows stout; then it matures level upon its stalks, wonderful to the diligent planters, that through them He may enrage the steadfast disbelievers. Allah has promised the ones of them who have believed and done deeds of righteousness forgiveness and a magnificent reward". (TMQ, 48: 29).**

The importance of this ayah is that when it described the characteristics of those who deserve victory as it was mentioned in *Taurat* (Torah), it praised their servitude to Allah *(SWT)* in what can be translated as, **"Their mark is on their faces, (being) the trace of prostration; that is their likeness in the Tawrah; (the Book revealed to Musa (Moses), of which the extant Torah is a corruption) and their likeness in the Injil (The Book revealed to Isa (Jesus), of which the extant Gospel is a corruption) is as a plantation that brings out its shoot; then it upholds it; then it grows stout; then it matures level upon its stalks, wonderful to the diligent planters, that through them He may enrage the steadfast disbelievers." (TMQ, 48: 29)".**

In fact, Jews gave priority to materialism over spirituality, whereas Christians did the opposite. Thus, this ayah came to show that the *Ummah* that deserves divine victory is the one that combines both, without exaggerating one over the other. That is why the Prophet's *(SAWS)* companions deserved victory.

The magnificence of Surat Al-Fath made Prophet Mohammed *(SAWS)* recite it when entering Makkah victorious. When he reached the final ayah rejoicing Allah's *(SWT)* victory, his companions recited it crying when they felt they had been given the victory that Allah *(SWT)* promised them. The Surah is one of the most wonderful in that it takes us to the time of the conquest of Makkah as if we were with Prophet Mohammed *(SAWS)* and his companions, optimistic about Allah's *(SWT)* victory for us. This will happen if we follow our Prophet *(SAWS)* and his companions in the characteristics they embody as mentioned in the last ayah.

Between Surat Muhammad and Surat Al-Hujuraat

As we have mentioned, this Surah is a completion of the Surah of war, Surat Muhammad. It deals with victory and domination, a natural conclusion to fighting and striving for the sake of Allah *(SWT)*. If we look at the endings of both Surahs, we will find a great connection.

Surat Muhammad ended with what can be translated as, **"And in case you turn away, He will (readily) exchange you for another people; thereafter they will not be your likes." (TMQ, 47: 38)**. What are their characteristics? The answer comes at the end of Surat Al-Fath in what can be translated as**, "Muhammad is the Messenger of Allah, and (the ones) who are with him are strict against the steadfast disbelievers, constantly merciful among themselves." (TMQ, 48:29).**

Thus, we conclude that Surat Muhammad spoke about following the Prophet *(SAWS)*, while Surat Al-Fath mentioned the characteristics of those who do so.

= Surat Al-Hujuraat (The Apartments) =

This Surah speaks about the rules of behavior especially towards the Prophet *(SAWS)*. Thus, we can understand the sequence of the three Surahs, and how their main pivot is Prophet Muhammad *(SAWS)*: Surat Muhammad shows that following the Prophet *(SAWS)* is the manual for accepted deeds; Surat Al-Fath reveals the characteristics of those upon whom Allah *(SWT)* will bestow victory in what can be translated as, **"Muhammad is the Messenger of Allah; and (the ones) who are with him . . ." (TMQ, 48:29).**

This Surah, Al-Hujuraat, addresses specifically those upon whom Allah *(SWT)* will bestow victory, stating that they should behave themselves according to established social conduct, especially with the Prophet *(SAWS)*. The qualities mentioned at the end of Surat Al-Fath namely self-sacrifice, *jihad* (fight for the sake of Allah), and balance between worship and worldly success, are cited in Surat Al-Hujuraat.

Conduct with Allah's decree

Surat Al-Hujuraat is the Surah of the good manners and decency towards all sides, above all Allah's *(SWT)* Decree. Allah says in what can be translated as**, "O you who have believed, be not forward before (Literally: between the Two Hands of) Allah and His Messenger, (i.e., do not ant) and be pious to Allah; surely Allah is Ever-Hearing, Ever-Knowing." (TMQ, 49:1).**

This ayah tells the Prophet's companions not to be in haste for new ayahs to be revealed and to conduct themselves properly with Allah's *(SWT)* Decree. Applying this ayah in our daily life requires submission to Allah's *(SWT)* Decree and the Prophet's *(SAWS)* Sunnah and not transgressing them.

Conduct with the Prophet *(SAWS)*

Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as:

1. **"O you who have believed, do not raise your voices above the Prophet's voice, and do not be loud in your speech to him, as you are loud to one another, (Literally: as some of you are loud to (some) others) (for fear) that your deeds would be frustrated, while you are not aware." (TMQ, 49:2).**

2. **"Surely (the ones) who tone down their voices in the presence of the Messenger of Allah, those are they whose hearts Allah has tested for piety…" (TMQ, 49:3).**
3. **"Surely (the ones) who call out to you from beyond the apartments, most of them do not consider. And if only they (waited) patiently, until you go out to them, that would be more charitable (i.e., better) for them..." (TMQ, 49:4-5).**

Conduct with news and information

We should not circulate or repeat any news nor should we pass judgment before making sure that such news is true, Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as**, "O you who have believed, in case an immoral (person) comes to you with a tiding, then (ascertain) the evidence, for that you may afflict a people in ignorance, (and) then you become remorseful for what you have performed" (TMQ, 49:6).**

Conduct with the Believers

Allah *(SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"Surely believers are only brothers." (TMQ, 49:10)**. Brotherhood in belief strengthens relations between people and strengthens belief; without it, many disagreements happen and belief weakens.

Conduct while making peace

Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And in case two sections of the believers fight each other, then make a righteous (reconciliation) between them both; (Literally: act righteously between them) then in case one of them is inequitable to the other, then fight the one that is inequitable until it concedes to the Command of Allah. So in case it concedes, then make a reconciliation between them both with justice, and be equitable. Surely Allah loves the equitable (ones)." (TMQ, 49:9).**

Conduct with social relationships

Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"O you who have believed, let not any people scoff at (another) people who may be more charitable than they; neither let women scoff (other) women who may be more charitable (i.e., better) than they. And do not defame one another, (Literally: do not defame yourselves) nor revile one another by nicknames. Miserable is the name, evident immorality, after belief! And whoever does not repent, then those are they who are the unjust." (TMQ, 49:11).**

"O you, who have believed, avoid much surmise; surely some surmise is a vice. And do not spy on each other, (Literally: some of you on some others) nor backbite one another;" (TMQ, 49:12).

Conduct with humanity in general

Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, "**O you mankind, surely We created you of a male and a female, and We have made you races and tribes that you may get mutually acquainted. Surely the most honorable among you in the Providence of Allah are the most pious" (TMQ, 49:13).**

It is noticed that good conduct has declined among people, even though it is more comprehensive than other morals. The whole thrust of the Surah is that Muslims should mend and reform themselves and improve their behavior with the Prophet *(SAWS)* before facing the world. This way they will earn the respect of all people and this fine conduct that they practice so well, will be transferred to others that they meet.

Behaving oneself with Allah *SWT*

This is the final moral mentioned in the Surah, and is achieved by realizing the real blessing of belief and that it is from Allah *(SWT)*. No one should assume that their faith is a favor towards Allah *(SWT)*, but it is Allah *(SWT)* who graces us with such a blessing. Allah *(SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"They would oblige you that they have become Muslims! Say, "Do not oblige me by your Islam. No indeed, (but) Allah obliges you that He has guided you to belief, in case you are sincere." (TMQ, 49:17).**

Why is the Surah named Al-Hujuraat?

Some people used to call out to the Prophet *(SAWS)* outside his *hujaraat* (rooms), which is impolite in dealing with the Messenger of Allah *(SWT)*. The Surah was given this name because the most important focus of all the previously mentioned morals is the Prophet *(SAWS)*. Thus, all Muslims would learn that they could not go face the world and deal with nations with these manners, they must behave appropriately with their Prophet *(SAWS)* first.

The Surah started with how to behave with the Prophet *(SAWS)*, and ended with how to behave with Allah *(SWT)*. The meaning is that behaving well with the Prophet *(SAWS)* and obeying him will result in Allah *(SWT)* supporting you in the rest of your behavior so that you emerge to the world with the type of conduct described in Surat Al-Hujaraat.

If you want to strengthen your ties to the Messenger of Allah *(SAWS)*, read the three Surahs: Muhammad, Al-Fath, and Al-Hujuraat, and ask Allah *(SWT)* to support you in incorporating these noble meanings into your life.

Surahs of the Twenty-Sixth Part

This Surah is the start of known as Al-Mufassal in the Qur'an, which is the group of Surahs that start from the beginning of this Surah 'Qaf' and continue to the end of the Holy Qur'an.

We notice that the last four parts of the Qur'an focus on the revival of faith in the believers' souls, which is aa fact which helps that helps us understand the ordering of Surahs in the Qur'an. The Qur'an first presents this divine path from the beginning of Surat Al-Baqara to Surat Al-Anfal. The following Surahs then focus on the means that Muslims must have so as to safeguard this divine path. Such means include embracing the causes of progress and development, adopting the manners of Prophets and submitting to Allah *(SWT).* As for the final Surahs of the Qur'an, the focus is primarily on strengthening the faith of the believers, reforming their hearts and reminding them of the Day of Judgment to aid them in adhering to this path, to seize responsibilities related to it, and transfer it to humanity at large.

Choose between these two paths

The Surahs of the 27th part of the Qur'an, together with Surat Qaf, are united with the question of choice: between guidance and going astray, and between heaven and hellfire. For this reason, you will discern in all these Surahs a presentation of the two paths and a call to choose: between the path to heaven and the path of hellfire, between Allah's *(SWT)* blessing and affliction, between provision or deprivation from Allah *(SWT)*, between extravagant materialism or spiritualism or a balance between both. All the mentioned paths and contrasts reflect the attributes of a Surah in this part.

= Surat Qaf (The Witnessed Day) =

The first of these Surahs, Surat Qaf, places strong emphasis on the hereafter and resurrection. Beginning with death, which is the starting stage of the Day of Judgment, Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And the stupor of death comes with the Truth; that is what you were averting." (TMQ, 50:19),** to the blow of the Trumpet and its enormity, Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And the Trumpet is blown; that is the Day of the Threat. And every self will come, (and) with it a driver and a constantly present witness." (TMQ, 50:20-21).**

We are shown horrifying scenes from this Day and the arguments between the wreckers and their devil companions:

Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And his comrade will say, "This is what is closely kept with me constantly ready." "Cast, you both, in (to) Hell every stubborn, most disbelieving (one)," (TMQ, 50:23-24).**

The ayahs of Creation: Thus will be the resurrection

Even the Ayahs of creation in this Surah lucidly serve the meaning of resurrection and the emergence to the land of gathering. An example would be Allah's *(SWT)* saying, which can be translated as, **"And We have been sending down from the heaven water blessed; so We caused to grow thereby gardens and a grain of harvest, And palm-trees aloft with spathes tiered. A provision for the bondmen; and therewith We give life to a deceased country. Thus is the going out (of the graves)." (TMQ, 50:9-11).** Why do we have all

these Ayahs? They are for us to ascertain that He who has revived the earth after its death is capable of raising the dead from their graves, Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, "**Thus is the going out (of the graves)." (TMQ, 50:11).**

For the softening of your hearts

Therefore, my Muslim brothers and sisters, read this Surah if you want your hearts to soften, because it is a reminder of the hereafter. This is the reason why the Messenger of Allah *(SAWS)* sometimes delivered Friday *khutbahs* (sermons) reciting this Surah alone and without the addition of another word would come down from his preaching platform. The Prophet's *(SAWS)* companions would be deeply touched by this sermon to the extent that they would wait for him to deliver the same one another time. If only we could see this *sunnah* (Prophet's guidance) being performed in Friday sermons again.

Scenes of the two groups

After the mentioning of resurrection and the horrors of the Day of Judgment and the dangers of Hellfire, the Surah depicts the final state of the two groups. Since we are given the choice between the two states, Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"On the Day We will say to Hell, "Are you filled?" And it will say, "Is there any further increase?" (i.e., more to come)." (TMQ,: 50: 30).** An extremely frightening Ayah, would you let yourself be amongst those whom Hell has asked for more? The Ayah that comes immediately after depicts the exact opposite scene, Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And the Garden will be drawn forward for the pious, without being afar." (TMQ,: 50: 31).** A perfect transition from the picture of Hellfire as it asks for more people to Heaven as it approaches its people and prepares and beautifies itself for receiving them. This is why the question once again repeats itself; with which group would you rather be?

Reasons of deviation

If we contemplate the Ayahs of this Surah, we will notice that they concentrate on the three inclinations that lead to deviation, so that we can avoid them and protect our hearts against corruption, Allah *(SWT)* willing:

1. The whispering of the soul:
   Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And indeed We already created man, and We know whatever his self whispers within him, and We are nearer to him than the jugular vein." (TMQ, 50:16).**

2. The Companion (devil):
   Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"His comrade will say, "Our Lord, in no way did I cause him to be inordinate; but he was in far error." (TMQ, 50:27).**

3. Heedlessness:
   Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Indeed you were already in (a state of) heedlessness of this. Then (now) We have lifted off from you your covering; so your beholding today is very sharp." (Literally: iron "like")" (TMQ, 50:22).**

The Muslim heart

That is why the Surah hence concentrates on the soundness of the heart-that is being free from these diseases- at its end. Look at the words 'penitent and heedful' for example; to whom do they really refer? Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Who is apprehensive of The All-Merciful in the Unseen and comes with a penitent heart." (TMQ, 50:33).** Another reference: Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Surely in that there is indeed a Reminding to him who has a heart, or is eager (Literally: cast "his" hearing) on hearing, and is a constantly present witness (to the Truth)." (TMQ, 50:37).** Do you now notice the importance of the heart's soundness in properly choosing one of the two paths?

The Surah is then concluded with the best way to help reforming the heart and helping it make the right choice, Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, "**We know best whatever they say; and in no way are you a potentate over them. So remind by the Qur'an him who fears (My) threat." (TMQ, 50:45).** Therefore, this Qur'an and particularly Surat Qaf and the Surahs that follow, are the way to the soundness of the heart. I urge you, brothers and sisters, to read this Surah and learn it by heart with the intent of keeping your heart sound.

We realize now why this Surah started with an oath by the Qur'an; for it is the greatest aid in achieving the heart's soundness and consequently choosing the right path. We have to mention here that the Surahs: Qaf, Adh-Dhariyat, At-Tur, and An-Najm, all started with an oath and it is worth mentioning here that the objectives of these Surahs are related to the Ayahs that contain the oaths as we noticed in Surat Qaf.

= Surat Adh-Dhariyat (The Winnowers) =
= So flee to Allah =

Surat Adh-Dhariyat concentrates on the fact that provision is in Allah's *(SWT)* hand and that giving and deprivation are through Allah's *(SWT)* command in this world and the hereafter. Therefore if you deviate from Allah's *(SWT)* path and obedience, where will you go? What land would bear you? And what sky would shade you? Therefore, at the beginning of this Surah we notice that there are four oaths:

Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And (by) the winnowers with (swift) winnowing." (TMQ, 51:1):** It is a powerful wind that scatters the clouds preventing the falling of rain. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Then (by) the bearers of heavy burdens, (Or: obstruction)." (TMQ, 51:2):** Another powerful wind, but this one gathers the clouds causing rain to fall, absolutely the contrary of the first one. The Surah hence started with two Ayahs that represent the giving and deprivation of provision, as if saying: it is up to you to choose.

In Surat Qaf, the message was: heaven has approached and hell is calling on its residents, so choose between them. While in Surat Adh-Dhariyat, the message is clear: giving and deprivation are in Allah's hand (*SWT*), and that is the reason of naming this Surah so; for us always to remember that Allah *(SWT)* may deprive us from our provision and send us Adh-Dhariyat if we turn away from His path. Do you feel the greatness of the Qur'an and the clarity of its ayahs?

Let us now continue with the oaths:

Allah says what can be translated as, **"Then (by) the runners with ease," (TMQ, 51:3):** They are the ships that float on the sea holding the livelihood of people. Then Allah *(SWT)* goes on to say what can be translated as, **"Then (by) the dividers by the Command." (TMQ, 51:4):** They are the angels who distribute provisions among people.

As if this oath is addressing you: who is the Charitable and Beneficial one? Who is the Beneficial and the Afflicter? You had better choose the path of the one who ordered the angels to distribute provisions, commanded the winds to gather and scatter the clouds, and managed people's food (sustenance) and needs; for His promise is a truth, the meeting with Him is a truth, heaven is a truth, and hell is a truth. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And (by) the winnowers with (swift) winnowing. Then (by) the bearers of heavy burdens, (Or: obstruction). Then (by) the runners with ease, Then (by) the dividers by the Command. Surely what you are promised is indeed sincere. And surely the Doom is indeed befalling." (TMQ, 51:1-6).**

So flee to Allah

While the Surah started by mentioning the fact that provision is in Allah's hand *(SWT)*, at the same time it assures the believers that their provision is reserved in heaven and they are not going to lose it. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as**, "And in the heaven is your provision and whatever you are promised. So by The Lord of the heaven and the earth, surely it is indeed true as (it is true) that you (can) pronounce (your languages)." (TMQ, 51:22-23).** Don't you believe yet, even after Allah *(SWT)* swore on it? Listen then to what Allah *(SWT)* says in these Ayahs, which can be translated as, **"And the heaven (is also a sign). We have built it with (Our) Hands (i.e., Capability) and surely We are indeed extending (it) wide. And the earth, We have laid it out (as) a bedding, so how excellent are the Smoothers! (i.e., Those who make the earth as a cradle) And of everything We created pairs, that possibly you would be mindful." (TMQ, 51:47-49).** After you have believed that giving and deprivation are in the hands of Allah *(SWT)*, Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"So flee to Allah! Surely I am an evident, constant warner from Him to you." (TMQ, 51:50),** a marvelous and central ayah in this Surah. Flee to Allah *(SWT)* oh believers, turn to Him and choose His path.

For this reason, several Ayahs with the same meaning follow; Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And remind; then surely reminding profits the believers." (TMQ, 51:56).** This is the main purpose of creating you, to choose the path of serving Allah *(SWT)*. Then, Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"In no way would I have from them any provision; and in no way would I have them to feed Me. Surely Allah is The Superb Provider, The Owner of Power, The Ever-Pervading." (TMQ, 51:57-58).**

Have you seen how Surat Adh-Dhariyat in its entirety revolves around the same issue: choose the path of Allah *(SWT)* for he is the All-Provider.

The Generosity of Ibrahim (*AS*) (Abraham) out of his Trust in Allah

The story of Ibrahim *(AS)*, which is mentioned in this Surah, is also suitable for the issue of provision. We view the good omen that angels show to Ibrahim's wife. Though she was old and sterile, they promised her with a new type of provision, a child. As if the Surah tackles the issue of provision with all its aspects. Listen to what Allah *(SWT)* said in what can be translated as, **"So came forward his wife, clamoring; (literally: with a clamor) then she**

beat her face, and said, "An old sterile woman!" (TMQ, 51:29). So she was astonished to know that she would bear a child under such circumstances, but the angels, Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"They said, "Thus your Lord has said; surely He, Ever He, is The Ever-Wise, The Ever-Knowing." (TMQ, 51:30).**

The words used in telling the story themselves serve the meaning and we can almost feel the generosity of our master Ibrahim *(AS)* in them. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Has the discourse about Ibrahim's (Abraham) honored guests come up (to your knowledge)? As they entered to him, then they said, "Peace!" He said, "Peace! (You) are a people disclaimed (by me)." (i.e., not recognized by me) So he went apart to his family, then came with a plump calf; So he laid it near them and said, "Will you not eat?"(TMQ, 51:24-26)**. We see the haste in which Ibrahim *(AS)* prepared the food he wanted to offer, "**So he went apart to his family"** in addition to his generosity "**then came with a plump calf"** As if the meaning is: trust Allah for he is the All-Provider, and trust the divine generosity and be generous yourself.

= Surat At-Tur (The Mount) =

(Every person will be a constant pledge for whatever he has earned)

Continuing the issue of choice, Surat At-Tur stresses the fact that the destiny of every human being in the hereafter is subject to his deeds and earning in this world; thus, the central ayah in it is what can be translated as, **"Every person will be a constant pledge for whatever he has earned" (TMQ, 52:21).**

On the one hand, beliers will face their destiny, as Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Then woe upon that day to the beliers. They are the ones who play at their wading, (i.e., become absorbed). The Day when they are repulsed to the fire of Hell with (contemptuous) repulsing. This is the Fire that you used to cry lies to! So, is this magic, or is it you (who) do not behold? Roast in it! So (endure) patiently (in it) or do not (endure) patiently, equal it is to you!" (TMQ, 52:11-16).**

On the other hand, Allah *(SWT)* describes the destiny of the pious as what can be translated as, **"Surely the pious will be in Gardens and Bliss, Jesting with what their Lord has brought them, and their Lord will protect them from the torment of Hell-Fire. 'Eat and drink, (rejoicing) with wholesome appetite for whatever you were doing'" (TMQ, 52:17-19).** This is completely the opposite of the beliers' characteristics, as if the meaning is choose either of the two ways.

This constant contrast held between the two parties throughout the Qur'an has a great impact on the believers' souls, and it is one of the reasons behind the influence of the Qur'anic ayahs on them. The ayahs then show us why those believers are eventually the winners; Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"They say, 'Surely we were before among our families, (feeling) timorous; Then Allah was bounteous to us, and protected us from the torment of the Pestilential Wind. Surely we used earlier to invoke Him; surely He, Ever He, is The Ever Benign, The Ever Merciful" (TMQ, 52:26-28).** Haven't you made your choice yet? Aren't you eager to be with them?

Harmony and consistency between the Surahs

The wonder of Qur'an is crystal clear, as Surat At-Tur gracefully concludes in harmony with its beginning and with the following Surah's. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And for (part) of the night, then (also) extol Him, and at the withdrawing of the stars" (TMQ, 52:49).** This is an atmosphere of night extolment that fits the beginning of the Surah **"(And (by) At-Tur, (The Mount)"** which is the mountain on which Allah *(SWT)* spoke to Musa (*AS*) (Moses) and assigned him to bear His Message.

The closing of Surat At-Tur is Allah's *(SWT)* saying, what can be translated as, **"and at the withdrawing of the stars",** while the start of Surat An-Najm can be translated as, **"And (by) the Star when it tumbles down"** as if each of the Surahs of the Qur'an paves the way to the other.

= Surat An-Najm (The Star) =

Knowledge and science are the gift of Allah

Surat An-Najm discusses the issue of choice as well, yet between two sources of science and knowledge: Allah's *(SWT)* revelation on the one hand and illusions and doubts on the other.

And in no way does he pronounce (any word) out of prejudice

The most credible science and the firmest knowledge is what is a revelation from Allah *(SWT)* to His noble Messenger. That is why Allah *(SWT)* says about His Messenger in the Ayahs what can be translated as, **"And in no way does he pronounce (any word) out of prejudice. Decidedly it is nothing except a revelation revealed. One of valiant powers has taught him" (TMQ, 53:3-5),** so the method of revelation, that Jibril (*AS*) (Gabriel) has carried from Allah (*SWT*), is the most dependable and trusted way of knowledge and science.

The Surah then presents an aspect of *Al-Israa* and *Al-Mi'raj* incident (the night journey of Prophet Muhammad from Makkah to Jerusalem and his ascension to the seventh Heaven), where knowledge and vision were true and not limited to telling and narration. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Owner of resolute splendor; (Literally: ability to transform; to convey revelation, i.e. Jibril "Angle Gabriel) so he leveled himself. (When) he was on the most exalted horizon Thereafter he (came) within reach, then hung suspended * So he was at two bows (distance) or (even) closer (still). Then He (Allah) revealed to His bondman what He revealed. In no way did the heart-sight lie (about) what it saw. Will you then wrangle with him about what he sees? And indeed he did already see him (during) another descent. At the Lote-Tree of the Utmost Boundary" (TMQ, 53:6-14).** It is as if this Ayah is addressing disbelievers "how do you accuse the Messenger of Allah of lying when he has already seen the greatest of his Lord's signs?" Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as), **"In no way did (his) beholding (i.e., the eyesight) swerve, and in no way was it inordinate. Indeed he has already seen of the signs of his Lord, the greatest" (TMQ, 53:17-18);** how do you consider someone a liar when the source of his knowledge and science is Allah (*SWT*)?

Bottom Line: Science and assurance are the characteristics of methodology.

Their knowledge is nothing but a set of illusions

Knowledge is lucidly re-mentioned in Surat An-Najm, stressing the importance of verifying knowledge and taking it from its credible sources. The Surah presents for us two paths: the path of revelation that we explained at the beginning of the Surah and the path of those who follow their surmise and illusions, as Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Decidedly they closely follow nothing except surmise and what (prejudices) the selves yearn to; and indeed the guidance has already come to them from their Lord" (TMQ, 53: 23).** What proofs do those people have? They base their knowledge on extremely unsound sources like wishing and Allah *(SWT)* refers this as what can be translated as, **"Or even should man have whatever he covets?" (TMQ, 53:24).**

The Surah continues describing their floundering and suspicions, as Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Surely the ones who do not believe in the Hereafter do indeed name the Angels with female naming" (TMQ, 53:27).** So they are floundering in their suspicion and surmise, **"And in no way do they have any knowledge thereof. Decidedly they closely follow (nothing) except surmise, and surely surmise does not avail anything against the Truth" (TMQ, 53:28).** The Surah then reaches a point where Allah *(SWT)* proves their shallowness and poor knowledge, **"That is their attainment of knowledge. Surely your Lord is He Who knows best the ones who have erred away from His way, and He knows best the ones who are guided" (TMQ, 53:30).** Hence, the message of the Surah is 'authenticate your sources before making judgments and when talking about knowledge.'

The Star…why?

A question is raised in this context: why was the Surah named An-Najm (The Star)? Why did it start with an oath that can be translated as, **"And (by) the Star when it tumbles down" (TMQ, 53:1)?** What does that have to do with knowledge?

Swearing by the star suggests that it tumbles and falls down, but your companion (Muhammad) has come with a methodology that in no way have the same destiny. Allah *(SWT)* proves this, saying what can be translated as, **"In no way has your companion (The Prophet) erred, and in no way is he misguided" (TMQ, 53:2).** Allah *(SWT)* sent this methodology and it is stronger than the Heaven and Earth. What a strong comparison and a splendid meaning. This religion and this revelation are more powerful than the sun and harder than the stars that we see.

The blessing of credible knowledge

You will not feel the blessing of receiving knowledge from Allah's *(SWT)* revelation and the Qur'an unless you communicate with people from the West, especially those who extract their knowledge only from material sources. Just then you can feel their confused thinking and their faltering in the simplest of issues and axioms that Islam has already answered. Therefore, fellow Muslims, now that you have read this Surah, you have to select the source of your information and base your knowledge and deeds on that source. Allah *(SWT)* would reward you the best recompense. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And to Allah belongs whatever is in the heavens and whatever is in the earth that He may recompense the ones who have done odious (deeds) for what they have done and recompense the ones who have done fair (deeds) with the fairest reward" (TMQ, 53:31).**

Coherence between the Surahs

The ending of Surat An-Najm **"So prostrate yourselves to Allah and worship (Him)" (TMQ, 53:62)** is in clear harmony with the beginning of Surat Al-Qamar, **"The Hour (The Arabic noun is feminine) has drawn near, and the moon (The Arabic noun is masculine) is cloven." (TMQ, 54:1)**. The link between them is the message saying, "get prepared for the Day of Resurrection proved by the revelation of Surat Al-Qamar, by prostrating yourselves to Allah *(SWT)* and worshipping Him."

Blessings and indignations

Two among the Surahs of choice, Surat Al-Qamar and Surat Ar-Rahman, come in part 27 and complete each other :. The message of the former Surah is "Get to know Allah *(SWT)* through indignations" while the message of the latter is "Get to know Allah *(SWT)* through blessings".

= Surat Al-Qamar (The Moon) =

The message of this Surah is again to choose either of the two paths: observe Allah's *(SWT)* retaliation upon past disbelieving nations and decide whether to follow their path or avoid it.

Take the people of Nuh (*AS*) (Noah) as an example, as Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"The people of Nuh (Noah) cried lies before them; so they cried lies to Our bondman and said, 'A madman' and he was scared" (TMQ, 54:9).** Therefore, Nuh *(AS)* invoked Allah *(SWT)* against them **"So, he invoked his Lord, (saying), 'I am overcome, so vindicate me!'" (TMQ, 54:10).** What was the result? Then **"We opened the gates of the heaven to torrential water. And We made the earth to erupt forth springs, so the waters met for a Command already estimated" (TMQ, 54:11-12).**

We then move to another scene of Allah's *(SWT)* retaliation upon beliers. Allah *(SWT* says what can be translated as, **"Aad cried lies. How then were My torment and My warnings? * Surely We sent against them a most clamorous wind in a day of ill-luck, continuous" (TMQ, 54:18-19).**

As for the people of *Thamud*, Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Thamud cried lies to the warnings" (TMQ, 54:23).** The result of their denial was dreadful, as Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Surely We sent against them one Shout; so they were as the chaff of a pen-builder" (TMQ, 54:30).**

With regard to the people of *Lut* (*AS*) (Lot), Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"The people of Lut (Lot) cried lies to the warnings. Surely We sent against them a (squall of) gravel, except the house of Lut; (Lot) We safely delivered them before dawn" (TMQ, 54:33-34).** Another example is the people of *Firaawn* (Pharaoh), as Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And indeed the warnings already came (also) to the house of Firaawn; (Pharaoh) * They cried lies to Our signs, all of them, so We took them (away) with the taking of an Ever-Mighty, Supreme Determiner" (TMQ, 54:41-42).**

And indeed We have already left it for a sign. Is there then any who will recollect?

We notice that the Ayahs that show the retaliation of Allah (*SWT*) upon previous nations have some factors in common. The denial of disbelievers was the main reason behind their destruction. Therefore, mentioning torment is linked with words like **"Aad cried lies … Thamud cried lies"**, even Makkah's disbelievers were described in the ayahs as **"And they have cried lies and closely followed their prejudices; and every Command is settled" (TMQ, 54:3).**

Any people, who belie Allah (*SWT*) and His Prophets (may Allah's Peace and Blessings of be upon them all), without even reflecting on His ayahs, would face torment and become an example for people to come. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as **"And indeed We have already left it for a sign. Is there then any that will recollect?" (TMQ, 54:15).** Hence, the Surah concentrates at the beginning on a sign that the disbelievers of Makkah witnessed and Allah *(SWT)* describes this as what can be translated as, **"The Hour has drawn near, and the moon is cloven" (TMQ, 54:1).** It is as if the message is that now that you have seen this great sign, beware of denying it lest you become a sign yourself to warn others. Yet, they turned away and cried lies, which is described by Allah *(SWT)* as what can be translated as, **"And in case they see a sign, they veer away and say, 'A continuous sorcery!'" (TMQ, 54:2).**

The same words are used to comment on the end of each previous nation's story. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"How then were My torment and My warnings? And indeed We have already made the Qur'an easy for remembrance. Is there then any that will recollect?" (TMQ, 54:21-22).**

Universal norm

The Surah then comments on former nations' stories indicating that Makkah's disbelievers are not better than their ancestors. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Are your steadfast disbelievers more charitable than those ones? Or even do you have an acquittal (from torment) in the Zubur? (i.e., better)" (TMQ, 53:43).** The same rule applies to all beliers and proud, as Allah says what can be translated as, **"And indeed We have already caused your sects to perish; is there then any that will recollect?" (TMQ, 54:51).**

Shouldn't those signs, the cleaving of the moon and the stories of former nations, be enough for them? Then another Ayah is set to threaten them, as Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Soon the gathering will be routed and (they) will turn their backs" (TMQ, 54:45).** What a horrible warning by Allah (*SWT*) referring to the Battle of Badr and the disbeliever's defeat that would accompany it. A far harsher warning than the Battle of Badr and any other worldly calamities follows as Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"No indeed, (but) the Hour is their appointment, and the Hour is more calamitous and more bitter" (TMQ, 54:46).**

"And indeed We have already made the Qur'an easy for remembrance"

While narrating the destruction of beliers, the Surah demonstrates that the Qur'an is the sole means to avoid torment and that this Qur'an was made easy for people to reflect on and learn from as Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And indeed We have already made the Qur'an easy for remembrance. Is there then any that will recollect?" (TMQ, 54:17).** It is as if the meaning is to abide by the path of Allah *(SWT)* and take upon yourself

learning the Qur'an by heart, attending to and reflecting on it. Hence, you get to know Allah *(SWT)*, become secure from His torment and be able choose the path of right-mindedness.

= Surat Ar-Rahman (The All-Merciful) =

Surat Ar-Rahman, along with Surat Al-Qamar, form an integral part of our knowledge of Allah *(SWT)* as they shed the light upon His blessings and pave the way for us to choose the path of belief.

They are your Muslim brothers in duties

Among all the Surahs of the Qur'an, this Surah is particularly characterized by including the new meaning that both jinn and men are committed to duties and are equally addressed by the Qur'an. This Surah therefore shows that jinn are directly addressed in what can be translated as, **"Soon shall We settle your affairs, O both ye worlds!"(TMQ, 55:31),** as if it asks the jinn too "to choose", for the belief path is now clear with all its outlines and signs. Then comes another ayah addressing the two worlds, stating what can be translated as, "**O ye assembly of Jinns and men! If it be ye can pass beyond the zones of the heavens and the earth, pass ye! Not without authority shall ye be able to pass" (TMQ, 55:32).**

Moreover, the most frequently repeated ayah in this Surah which can be translated as, **"Then which of the favors of your Lord will ye deny?"** is addressing both jinn and men, for it states **"your Lord"** and orders both of them to thank Allah (*SWT*) for His blessings and not to deny them. When this ayah was revealed, the Prophet (*SAWS)* said, "…when I read this Surah on the jinn, their response was better than yours. They answered, "We do not deny any of your blessings Allah, all the praise is for You"[1]. It is a marvelously significant meaning and a very pleasant answer to the question **"Then which of the favors of your Lord will ye deny?"** Please think about it whenever you read Surat Ar-Rahman and deeply thank Allah *(SWT)* by heart and soul for all His blessings.

The blessings of Allah *(SWT):*

The Surah then goes on listing the great blessings that we enjoy without really realizing their value. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as **"And the Firmament has He raised high, and He has set up the Balance (of Justice) in order that ye may not transgress (due) balance. So establish weight with justice and fall not short in the balance. (TMQ, 55:7-9).** The balance that Allah *(SWT)* set for judgment in heavens and earth and for judging all creatures is one of the most significant blessings He *(SWT)* bestows upon us. Yet when man deviated from the right path and exceeded his limits, injustice and corruption prevailed.

The Surah demonstrates more blessings, as Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, "**He has let free the two bodies of flowing water, meeting together. Between them is a Barrier which they do not transgress" (TMQ, 55:19-20)** and within the process of enlisting these great blessings, the same question is repeated over and over again.

Choose one of the two paths

[1] At-Tirmidhi, 2624.

Following the same pattern characterizing the Surahs of *juza* (chapter) 27 of the Qur'an, Surat Ar-Rahman demonstrates two categories of people. First, the one that denied Allah's *(SWT)* blessings. Allah (*SWT)* says what can be translated as, "**On that Day no question will be asked of man or Jinn as to his sin. Then which of the favors of your Lord will ye deny? (For) the sinners will be known by their Marks: and they will be seized by their forelocks and their feet. Then which of the favors of your Lord will ye deny? This is the Hell which the Sinners deny: In its midst and in the midst of boiling hot water will they wander round" (TMQ, 55:39-44).** This is directly followed by the mention of the second category (i.e. the people of paradise) to strengthen the effect of these ayahs and thus enhance the opportunity of making the right choice. In this respect, Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, **"But for such as fear the time when they will stand before (the Judgment Seat of) their Lord, there will be two Gardens. Then which of the favors of your Lord will ye deny?" (TMQ, 55:46-47).**

Verily, this is one of the best Surahs that lead Muslims to recognize the blessings of Allah *(SWT)*. This accordingly leads them to identify the right path and remain steadfast on it.

= Surat Al-Waqi'ah (The Event) =

Surat Al-Waqi'ah clearly aims at giving Muslims the opportunity to choose one of the following categories:

1. The forerunners who are considered the nearest to Allah *(SWT)*
2. The people of the Right Hand
3. The people of the Left Hand

This is a brief summary of this Surah, it begins with what can be translated as, **"And ye shall be sorted out into three classes. Then (there will be) the Companions of the Right Hand; what will be the Companions of the Right Hand? And the Companions of the Left Hand, what will be the Companions of the Left Hand? And those Foremost (in Faith) will be foremost (in the Hereafter) (TMQ, 56:7-10).**

The Surah then goes on telling about them and the about the fate awaiting each category of them till it concludes with the mention of the same three categories once more. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, "**Thus, then, if he be of those Nearest to Allah, (There is for him) Rest and Satisfaction, and a Garden of Delights. And if he be of the Companions of the Right Hand, (For him is the salutation), Peace be unto thee, from the Companions of the Right Hand. And if he be of those who treat (Truth) as Falsehood, who go wrong, For him is Entertainment with Boiling Water, And burning in Hell Fire" (TMQ, 56-88-94).**

Contemplate on his dominion and choose

After the Surah mentions the fate awaiting each of the three categories, it urges you to contemplate upon Allah's *(SWT)* creation and check your inclination and belief then actually make the right choice. This contemplation should cover all the blessings that Allah *(SWT)* bestows on man and the latter being initially created by Allah *(SWT*) from a minor sperm. Allah (*SWT*) says what can be translated as, "**Do ye then see? The (human Seed) that ye throw out, Is it ye who create it, or are We the Creators?" (TMQ, 56:58-59).** The Surah then continues to demonstrate the miraculous processes of sowing and growing and thus states what can be translated as, **"See ye the seed that ye sow in the ground? Is it ye that**

cause it to grow, or are We the Cause?" (TMQ, 56:63-64). It then mentions another great blessing (i.e. the water that we drink). Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"See ye the water which ye drink? Do ye bring it Down (in rain) from the Cloud or do We?" (TMQ, 56:68-69).** The Surah then moves to the creation of fire **"See ye the Fire which ye kindle? Is it ye who grow the tree which feeds the fire, or do We grow it?" (TMQ, 56:71-72).**

Dear Muslim brother, if you recalled all these blessings and could realize that they are all created by the order of Allah *(SWT)* with no effort exerted on your part, you have to instantly glorify Allah *(SWT)*. In this respect the Surah mentions what can be translated as, **"Then celebrate with praises the name of thy Lord, the Supreme" (TMQ, 56:74).** All the praise is to Allah the Supreme.

Choose before you die

Right before the end, the Surah reminds us of death to urge you Muslims to make your choice before you die and leave this world. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Then why do ye not (intervene) when (the soul of the dying man) reaches the throat. And ye the while (sit) looking on. But We are nearer to him than ye, and yet see not" (TMQ, 56:83-85).** These are very difficult and tough moments, they make you wonder who will be among the nearest people to Allah *(SWT)* and will not experience such hard moments. Who will be among the people of the Right Hand and whose life will be concluded with suffering? I seek refuge with Allah *(SWT)* from such a fate.

A reminder between two Ayahs of praise

We find that Surat Al-Waqi'ah is concluded with an ayah that can be translated as, **"So celebrate with praises the name of thy Lord, the Supreme" (TMQ, 56:96).** This comes in conformity with concluding Surat At-Tur with an ayah of praise that can be translated as, **"And for part of the night also praise thou Him, and at the retreat of the stars" (TMQ, 52:49),** as well as, the conclusion of Surat An-Najm with an ayah of prostration that can be translated as, "**But fall ye down in prostration to Allah, and adore" (TMQ, 53:62).** Praise and worship are the greatest help that man can get when choosing the Right Path and adhering to it for as long as he lives, *insha Allah* (if Allah wills).

As the previous consecutive Surahs have a line connecting the conclusion of each of them to the beginning of the following one similarly, we can see that Surat Al-Waqi'ah is concluded with an ayah of praise that can be translated as, **"So celebrate with praises the name of thy Lord, the Supreme" (TMQ, 56:96).** The following Surah that is Surat Al-Hadid begins with an ayah of praise as well, for Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Whatever is in the heavens and on earth, let it declare the Praises and Glory of Allah: for He is the Exalted in Might, the Wise" (TMQ, 57:01).**

= Surat Al-Hadid (Iron) =
The balance between spirituality and materiality

Surat Al-Hadid also tackles the choice between materiality and spirituality. However, it never asks you to choose between them but rather encourages you to strike a balance between them.

The Muslim *Ummah* (Nation) and iron:

Before we start discussing this Surah, I must mention a depressing fact; the fact that our Ummah that reads about iron in its Qur'an does not actually know about manufacturing iron. This Surah includes a central ayah- that can be translated as, "**and We sent down Iron, in which is (material for) mighty war, as well as many benefits for mankind" (TMQ, 57:25),** but unfortunately Muslims are not applying it at present**.**

Iron is considered today the very symbol of heavy industry, for iron as illustrated by the ayah, can be either a "**(material for) mighty war"** (i.e. military industries) or used for the **"benefit of man kind"** (i.e. the hi-tech industry). Actually it is the main core of industry at the times of war and piece alike. But where do we stand from this concept and from the scientific, industrial and technological development?

After realizing this distressful fact, let's try to understand the meaning delivered by Allah *(SWT)* in this Surah to be able to perceive the balance and comprehensiveness of Islam and thus catch up with the procession of development and civilization

The Balance

What is the aim of this Surah? This Surah asks you to achieve a balance between materiality and spirituality by telling us about two categories of people. The first category completely dedicates itself to worshipping Allah *(SWT)* and absolutely nothing else, whereas, the second category became very hard and cruel as it dedicates itself to work and to other worldly affairs rather than the acts of obedience that it may have done to please Allah *(SWT)*. Then the Surah shows that both groups are wrong and both have deviated from Allah's *(SWT)* path

Excessive materiality

The following ayah addresses the second category in a marvelous way that moves even the cruelest heart**,** as it reminds them of Allah (*AW*), in what can be translated as, **"Has not the time arrived for the Believers that their hearts in all humility should engage in the remembrance of Allah and of the Truth which has been revealed (to them), and that they should not become like those to whom was given Revelation aforetime, but long ages passed over them and their hearts grew hard? For many among them are rebellious transgressors." (TMQ, 57:16).** It is a very gentle reproof from Allah (*SWT*) that was felt by the Companions though they were among the most submissive people and so they said : "Allah (SWT) has sent down this ayah to reprove us because our their hearts have hardened".

Another ayah directly follows this ayah where Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"Know ye (all) that Allah giveth life to the earth after its death" (TMQ, 57:17)** so what is the tie between the hardness of the hearts and the rain? It is as if the ayah wants to say that Allah *(SWT)* who can bring the dead barren soil to life with rain can also bring the cruelest hearts to the path of submission by *Dhikr* (the mentioning of Allah)

Excessive spirituality

The other category includes those who were excessively involved in the world of spirituality, totally abandoning worldly affairs. Allah *(SWT)* describes them in what can be translated as,

"Then, in their wake, We followed them up with (others of) Our messengers: We sent after them Jesus the son of Mary. And bestowed on him the Gospel; and We ordained in the hearts of those who followed him Compassion and Mercy" (TMQ, 57:27). So far, all this is good and desired but pay attention to the second part of the ayah which states what can be translated as, **"but the Monasticism which they invented for themselves, We did not prescribe for them: (We commanded) only the seeking for the Good Pleasure of Allah; but that they did not foster as they should have done. Yet We bestowed, on those among them who believed, their (due) reward, but many of them are rebellious transgressors."** It is worth noting here that both ayahs discussing extravagance either in materiality or in spirituality were concluded with the same phrase, **"but many of them are rebellious transgressors"**. Why? Because deviating from the path is considered a transgression (as transgressed lexically means deviated in Arabic). Accordingly, detaching one's self from the worldly life and completely dedicating oneself to worship is equally considered a transgression as hardening the hearts and staying away from all the spiritual aspects of life.

An Ummah that is justly balanced

It is as if the Surah delivers to us the following message: you, Ummah of Muhammad, are moderate, so you should not incline to one of the two extremes. You are justly balanced between the gentleness of the heart and the closeness to Allah *(SWT)* on the one side and the success in life on the other side. Thus the significant central ayah comes to illustrate this concept in a wonderful way when stating what can be translated as, **"We sent aforetime Our messengers with Clear Signs and sent down with them the Book and the Balance (of Right and Wrong), that men may stand forth in justice; and We sent down Iron, in which is (material for) mighty war, as well as many benefits for mankind" (TMQ, 57:25).** This part stresses upon the materialistic side and achieving success in life, then moves to what can be translated as, **"that Allah may test who it is that will help, Unseen, Him and His messengers"** to make us realize that this is the typical use of iron, (i.e. to support the religion of Allah through military and technological industries).

Furthermore, the Surah states clearly that this rule is not subject to change throughout generations. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"And We sent Noah and Abraham, and established in their line Prophethood and Revelation: and some of them were on right guidance" (TMQ, 57:26).** The ayah talks about those who understood Allah's *(SWT)* religion and who knew how to achieve a balance between materialism and spirituality. Finally, the ayah concludes again with what can be translated as **"but many of them became rebellious transgressors."**

Balance is the magic key to light

It is worth mentioning that the word *'nour'* (light) is mentioned three times in a way that unmistakably shows us the essence of balance in Islam**:**

1. On earth: Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"O ye that believe! Fear Allah, and believe in His Messenger, and He will bestow on you a double portion of His Mercy: He will provide for you a Light by which ye shall walk (straight in your path)" (TMQ, 57:28).**
2. On *As-sirat* (the path over hell). Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as **"One Day shalt thou see the believing men and the believing women how their Light runs forward before them and by their right hands" (TMQ, 57:12).**

3 In heaven: Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"and the Witnesses (who testify), in the eyes of their Lord: they shall have their Reward and their Light" (TMQ, 57:19).**

4 Please contemplate at the superiority and balance of this religion**.** The Surah assures you that your keenness on being submissive to Allah *(SWT)* will surely grant you light in this life of the world as well as in the hereafter when you will pass *as-sirat.* Moreover, the Surah mentions a light that belongs to a specific group of people that is the group of martyrs. Allah *(SWT)* says what can be translated as, **"and the Witnesses (who testify), in the eyes of their Lord: they shall have their Reward and their Light" (TMQ, 57:19)** because they were the ones who used iron in the shape of military equipments and this way could attain the peak of success in life and supporting Allah's *(SWT)* religion on the one hand and sacrificed their lives for the sake of Allah *(SWT),* which enabled them to attain the best spiritual status and closeness to Allah *(SWT)* on the other. Thus Surat Al-Hadid represents an obvious marvelous balance**.**

The balance in Allah's *(SWT)* creation

From the very beginning the Surah shows us clearly that Allah *(SWT)* governs the universe with amazing balance, as it includes several paradoxes. It states with what can be translated as, **"He is the First and the Last, the Evident and the Immanent: and He has full knowledge of all things" (TMQ, 57:03)." He it is Who created the heavens and the earth …He knows what enters within the earth and what comes forth out of it, what comes down from heaven and what mounts up to it" (TMQ, 57:04). "He merges Night into Day, and He merges Day into Night" (TMQ, 57:6).**

As if the ayah says that none but Allah *(SWT)* can bring all these contradictions together, praise be to Him. He has the absolute power over this dominion, he can make it as perfectly balanced as it is. He ordered his creatures to seek balance in their life to keep their hearts from becoming hard and keep themselves from inclining towards one of the two extremes: materiality or spirituality.

You still have not chosen?

This was a presentation of *juzu* 27 (the 27th part) of the Qur'an and its Surahs that urge you to choose, and impose questions on you like:

- Would you choose the path of heaven or hellfire? (Surat Qaf and Surat At-Tur).
- Would you like to be one of the forerunners and the people of the Right or one of the denying people? (Surat Al-Waqi'ah).
- Would you prefer blessings or misfortunes? (Surat Ar-Rahman and Surat Al-Qamar).
- Would you like to get your knowledge from the revealed Surahs or from doubtful suspicious sources? (Surat An-Najm).
- Would you choose Allah's *(SWT)* boon and bestowal or deprivation? (Surat Adh-Dhariyat).

- Would you choose excessive materialism, excessive spirituality or a balanced way between both? (Surat Al-Hadid).

- Finally we appeal to Allah *(SWT)* to help us making the right choice and make us benefit from what we learned of the Surahs of *juzu* 27.

Surahs of the Twenty-Eighth Part

We have reached the twenty-eighth part. The Surahs of this section all have the same theme, as we have seen in the previous section.

The Core Idea: Belonging to Islam

Throughout the Qur'an so far, various themes have been discussed in exacting detail; ranging from social morality (in Surat Al-Hujurat) to the secrets behind civilization excellence (in Surat An-Naml). In the twenty-seventh part, the issue of choosing the right path and deciding between paradise and hell was discussed. The Surahs we are looking at now, in the twenty-eighth part, have all one core idea: the sense of belonging to Islam.

It is as if the meaning is: After you, Muslims, have known the Qur'an and have understood the essence of Allah's religion, you must now belong to it. Some people might think that they belong to Islam because they perform all the obligatory acts of worship like prayers or fasting, but they really miss the point. There is a great difference between "I pray" and "I fast" on the one hand and "I belong to Islam" on the other.

Belonging to Islam means loving Allah and the Prophet Muhammad (*SAWS*), more than anything else, and loving all fellows Muslims because they belong to the same religion as you do. Belonging to Islam entails not being fascinated by other cultures because you take pride in belonging to your own religion. In short then, the twenty-eighth part is about clinging to your own beliefs and not blindly following other people or cultures. It should not be understood, however, that Muslims should be hostile toward others; they are simply encouraged to keep their own identity, thoughts and values without resenting any other party. It is amazing how this part of the Holy Qur'an explains clearly how we can strike a balance between holding on to our own beliefs and not being hostile to others.

The series of Surah*s* illustrating "Belonging":

There are nine Surahs in this part. By looking at their titles, we can see that they form a tightly cohesive series with "belonging" as a common factor:

1. Surat Aj-Jumu'a (Friday Congregation), Surat As-Saf (The Ranks), Surat Al-Hashr (The Mustering): All call for unity, collaboration and joint effort.
2. Surat Al-Mumtahina (The Woman Tested): A test of belonging.
3. Surat Al-Munafiqoon (The Hypocrites): A warning against hypocrisy; the social illness that could divide Muslims and drive them apart from each other and away from their religion.
4. Surahs At-Tahreem (Prohibition), At-Talaq (Divorce), At-Taghabun (Mutual Loss and Gain): A warning against being diverted from belonging to Islam and against being carried away by the luxuries of life (children, wives and wealth).

These Surahs, especially At-Talaq and At-Tahreem, stress the importance of the family. The latter is the starting point of fellowship and of partnership among members of the society. In other words "belonging" begins with a strong solid Muslim family and ends with a strong unified Muslim community.

Women's role in "Belonging":

Among the wonders of this part is that it starts with a story of a woman complaining about the ill-treatment of her husband (Surat Al-Mujadalah – The Dispute), then it concludes with Surat At-Tahreem which poses two role models for women: the Pharaoh's wife and Mariam (Mary), Imran's daughter.

The common issue here is women; they are the makers of men, the ones who raise children and teach them the meaning of belonging. If women knew their value in Islam, if they knew how Islam honors them, they would truly belong to it and therefore would spread this notion of affiliation to Islam to the whole *Ummah*.

That is why this part starts by restoring women's rights (in Surat Al-Mujadalah) and winds up by setting the similitude through two women. If women took note of their rights and their role in this religion, they would consequently spread this fellowship on to all the people. Hence, giving rise to new generations that will achieve the objectives of the twenty-eighth part.

Women in the Surah*s* of the Qur'an:

In the previous parts we have seen how most of the Surahs in the Qur'an lay stress on the role of women. In Surat Al-Imran (Imran's Family), in which 'stability' was discussed, Maryam (*AS*) and Imran's wife were two epitomes of stability. In Surat An-Nisa' (The Women), the most important aspect of justice, the dominant theme, was that of treating women fairly. Surat An-Naml, which discusses civilization excellence, clearly praises the Queen of Sheba for the way she ruled her people justly and led them into believing in Allah.

Do you see how Islam gives great attention to women, and how the Qur'an presents them as a central theme in many of its Surahs? Although all this is quite evident, there are still some cynics who say, "Is there any attention given to women in the Qur'an? Why does the Qur'an always address men? Why does it always use the masculine form? To those people we say: In the Arabic language the general form of address used is the masculine form. That's how Arabic works[2]. Therefore, the Qur'an addresses both men and women using the masculine form. However, it always stresses the fact that they are partners in Islam; not only that, but that women have an even more important role since they are the ones who actually spread this notion of being an integral part of the society, as shown in this part.

[2] In the Arabic language, both sexes could be addressed using one pronoun, the masculine. The distinction between masculine and feminine in Arabic is not only in third person pronouns, but also in adjectives and verb conjugations. It would be quite cumbersome to use both forms each time. It is also a fact that a group of men and women are addressed by the plural masculine pronoun. (The translator's addition).

= Surat Al-Mujadalah (The Dispute) =

The origin of belonging: Women's Rights

The objective of this Surah is: Renouncing all the other religious or philosophical methodologies and remain attached to Islam.

It begins with the story of a family dispute; a woman complaining about her husband to the Prophet Muhammad (*SAWS*). Her husband had told her, "I swear that, from now on, you are to me like the back of my mother."[3] This meant that he could no longer treat her as a wife, in the physical and sexual sense. A great injustice, indeed! This was one of the most despicable habits of the pre-Islamic era and unfortunately it is still present until now in the society of Al-Madinah in Saudi Arabia. Therefore, this Surah was revealed from above the seventh heaven to restore the rights of the women in what can be translated as, **"Indeed Allah has heard the statement of she (Khaulah bint Tha'labah) who disputes with you (O Muhammad) concerning her husband (Aus bin As-Sâmit), and complains to Allah. And Allah hears the arguments between you both. Verily, Allah is All-Hearer, All-Seer." (TMQ, 58:1)**.

Can you see the real value of women in Islam? This woman was arguing with the Prophet (*SAWS*), yet this Surah was named after her, isn't that a privilege? Then the verdict of Allah was revealed from above the seventh heaven restoring her right back to her. What has all this got to do with the issue of belonging?

The twenty-eighth part starts by safeguarding a family threatened with a break-up. It defends a woman being subjected to injustice in the most intimate situation of her marital life. This was done for two reasons:

1. The first requirement for "belonging" is a strong solid family capable of preserving society's connection with the religion.
2. Acknowledging the value of women and giving them their rights intensify their love for Islam and their feelings of belonging to it. Consequently this encourages them to spread these feelings to the whole community.

The fifth ayah – directly after the ayahs of *az-zihar*[4] – warns those who mistreat their wives in what can be translated as, **"Verily, those who oppose Allah and His Messenger (Muhammad - *SAWS*) will be disgraced, as those before them (among the past nation) were disgraced." (TMQ, 58:5)**

Near the end of the Surah, the same warning is repeated in what can be translated as, **"Those who oppose Allah and His Messenger (Muhammad - *SAWS*) will be among the lowest (most humiliated)." (TMQ, 58:20)**

Which side are you on? The party of Allah or that of Shaytan (Satan)? Who is your real ally?

- Are you on this side? **"They are the party of *Shaytan* (Satan). Verily, it is the party of *Shaytan* (Satan) that will be the losers!" (TMQ, 58:19)**.

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[3] Meaning: you are no longer lawful for me to approach as a wife.

[4] This term describes the situation where a husband takes the oath, "You are to me like the back of my mother." Hence, his wife is no longer lawful for an intimate relation. The initial ayahs of Surat Al-Mujadalah, describing this whole situation, are named "ayahs of *az-zihar*".

- Or that one? **"They are the Party of Allah. Verily, it is the Party of Allah that will be the successful." (TMQ, 58:22)**.

The use of the word "party" shows that Islam is not only about individual acts of worship; praying and fasting. Muslims should unite in the party of Allah, and belong to it; they should strongly and clearly reject Satan's party. This way we will have achieved the objective of the Surah and become among those who prosper, *insha Allah* (if Allah wills).

The threat danger of hypocrisy:

We are asked to declare full allegiance to Allah on the one hand and to renounce the atheists on the other. The Surah warns us from those who wear masks to hide their real faces, they are the hypocrites. They are the hidden threat that can jeopardize our brotherhood and unity, **"Have you (O Muhammad) not seen those (hypocrites) who take as friends a people upon whom is the Wrath of Allah? They are neither of you (Muslims) nor of them, and they swear to a lie while they know." (TMQ, 58:14)**. The first problem with the hypocrites lies in their allegiance and relationship with the enemies of Allah. That is why Allah says what can be translated as, **"Allah has prepared for them a severe torment. Evil indeed is that which they used to do." (TMQ, 58:15)**.

The ayah*s* expose them, in what can be translated as **"…they say within themselves, 'Why should Allah punish us not for what we say?' Hell will be sufficient for them; they will burn therein. And worst indeed is that destination!" (TMQ, 58:8)**.

Signs of hypocrisy:

This Surah was revealed to warn the believers against, *az-zihar*[5], a phenomenon which, like *Najwa* (conspiring or counseling secretly), represents a form of social hypocrisy. In this respect, Allah says what can be translated as, **"Secret counsels (conspiracies) are only from *Shaitân* (Satan), in order that he may cause grief to the believers. But he cannot harm them in the least, except as Allah permits. And in Allah let the believers put their trust" (TMQ, 58:10)**.

"Allah has heard":

From these words we understand that the Surah is stressing the endless knowledge of Allah and His realization of everything. This is meant to let you know that Allah knows the secret and what is even beyond, so you would have no allies but Muslims, not even in your thoughts. The Surah begins with what can be translated as, **"Indeed Allah has heard the statement of her (Khaulah bint Tha'labah) who disputes with you (O Muhammad) concerning her husband ..." (TMQ, 58:1)**. Allah also says what can be translated as, **"Have you not seen that Allah knows whatsoever is in the heavens and whatsoever is on the earth? There is no *Najwâ* (secret counsel) of three but He is their fourth," (TMQ, 58:7)**.

Note the choice of Allah's names in this Surah. Most of them reflect His infinite knowledge and awareness, **"…Allah is All-Hearer, All-Seer" (TMQ, 58:1)** - **"…Allah is All-Aware of**

[5] Refer to the previous footnote.

what you do" (TMQ, 58:3) - "…Allah is Witness over all things" (TMQ, 58:6) - "…Verily, Allah is the All-Knower of everything" (TMQ, 58:7).

Declaring allegiance:

The Surah concludes with a crucial ayah about total allegiance to Allah and the need to renounce all His enemies, **"You (O Muhammad) will not find any people who believe in Allah and the Last Day, making friendship with those who oppose Allah and His Messenger (Muhammad), even though they were their fathers or their sons or their brothers or their kindred…" (TMQ, 58:22)**. There is a tone of strong rebuke that we rarely hear in the Qur'an. Never love anyone who is against your religion. This is not just about your deeds but your emotions as well. It should be noted that this includes methodologies, cultures and civilizations which oppose Islam. If they are not posing any threat or are not fighting us, then there is no harm in dealing with them, as we will see later in Surat Al-Mumtahina. However, if they oppose Allah and His Messenger, even if they were from our closest kin or most intimate friends, we are asked to renounce them. If we do that, Allah brings us good tidings, in what can be translated as, **"…For such He has written Faith in their hearts, and strengthened them with *Rûh* (proofs, light and true guidance) from Himself. And He will admit them to Gardens (Paradise) under which rivers flow to dwell therein (forever). Allah is pleased with them, and they with Him. They are the Party of Allah. Verily, it is the Party of Allah that will be the successful." (TMQ, 58:22**).

This was Surat Al-Mujadalah. It started with relating the incident of a woman who complained about her husband to the Messenger of Allah *(SAWS)* and how Islam restored her rights, and ended by raising a question: You, reader of the Qur'an, which side are you on? We ask Allah *(SWT)* to grant us full membership in His religion.

= Surat Al-Hashr (The Gathering) =

Surat Al-Hashr tells the story of the Jews of Banu An-Nadir, and how they were expelled from Madinah after breaching a treaty with the Prophet (*SAWS*). Two groups of people are addressed in the Surah:

1. Those who helped the traitors and supported them; the hypocrites.
2. Those who stood firm and renounced the enemies of Allah; the believers.

I'm sure you can see how the sense of belonging is a major theme in this part. Let's examine these two groups whose true natures were revealed in this Surah.

The hypocrites – weak bonding:

When the Prophet (*SAWS*) wanted to expel the Jews, the hypocrites instantly started negotiating with them. These ayahs were revealed to expose them, in what can be translated as, **"Have you (O Muhammad) not observed the hypocrites who say to their friends the disbelievers: '(By Allah) If you are expelled, we (too) indeed will go out with you, and we shall never obey any one against you; and if you are attacked, we shall indeed help you.' But Allah is Witness that they verily are liars." (TMQ, 59:11)**. Note the use of the phrase "**their friends**"; the hypocrites are not the friends of the believers any more; they belong to the disbelievers. It is as if the Ayah is asking you: Which side are you on? To which party do you belong?

The ayah*s* continue to expose their falsehood and deception: **"Surely, if they (the Jews) are expelled, never will they (hypocrites) go out with them; and if they are attacked, they will never help them. And (even) if they do help them, they (hypocrites) will turn their backs, and they will not be victorious. Verily, you (Muslims) are more fearful in their (Jews of Banû An-Nadîr) breasts than Allah. That is because they are a people who comprehend not (the Majesty and Power of Allah)." (TMQ, 59:12-13)**.

The disbelievers will never form a strong alliance or bond together, simply because they lack the faith and the comradeship to do so. They will renounce each other; just like Satan who will have the same reaction towards his followers later on, **"(Their allies deceived them) like *Shaytan* (Satan), when he says to man: 'Disbelieve in Allah.' But when (man) disbelieves in Allah, *Shaytan* (Satan) says: 'I am free of you, I fear Allah, the Lord of the *'Alamin* (mankind, jinn and all that exists)!'" (TMQ, 59:16)**.

The believers - strong bonding:

The alternative is then to belong to the party of Allah, **"(And there is also a share in this booty) for the poor immigrants, who were expelled from their homes and their property, seeking Bounties from Allah and to please Him, and helping Allah (i.e. helping His religion) and His Messenger (Muhammad - *SAWS*). Such are indeed the truthful (to what they say)" (TMQ, 59:8)**. This is the utmost manifestation of belonging in word and deed. Can you see that? **"And (it is also for) those who, before them, had homes (in Al-Madinah) and had adopted the Faith, love those who emigrate to them, and have no jealousy in their breasts for that which they have been given (from the booty of Banû An-Nadîr), and give them (emigrants) preference over themselves even though they were in need of that. And whosoever is saved from his own covetousness, such are they who will be the successful" (TMQ, 59:9)**.

Al-Muhajereen (the immigrants) had a profound belonging to Islam; they left their homes and went to Madinah, where they were blessed by an extremely warm welcome from *Al-Ansar* (the supporters). The latters had a strong sense of belonging as well; they took in their brothers and sisters in Islam despite their poverty and poor economic conditions. Throughout history, immigration is usually accompanied with problems and antagonism between the immigrants and original citizens. Yet, the relationship between the *Muhajereen* and the *Ansar* was exemplary; it was full of selflessness, love and sacrifice.

The next ayah shows the unity of this *Ummah* through the following generations, in what can be translated as, **"And those who came after them say: "Our Lord! Forgive us and our brethren who have preceded us in Faith, and put not in our hearts any hatred against those who have believed. Our Lord! You are indeed full of kindness, Most Merciful" (TMQ, 59:10)**.

Can you see how beautifully the Qur'an describes the characteristics of the believers? Can you see how it shows that all the generations of our *Ummah* follow the same idea, the same methodology? Even in our differences, Allah tells us that we should not, in any way, demean those who preceded us, but say instead, **"Our Lord! Forgive us and our brethren who have preceded us in Faith, and put not in our hearts any hatred against those who have believed. Our Lord! You are indeed full of kindness, Most Merciful" (TMQ, 59:10)**. Can you see the great difference between the two teams? The team of the believers would

sacrifice dearly for the sake of their brothers and their unity, whereas the team of those who take Allah's enemies as allies would betray their allies as soon as they have the opportunity to do so.

"Had We sent down this Qur'an on a mountain…":

Then there comes another marvelous ayah; an ayah that tears our hearts out of fear of Allah, **"Had We sent down this Qur'an on a mountain, you would surely have seen it humbling itself and falling asunder, into pieces, by the fear of Allah" (TMQ, 59:21)**. What has this ayah got to do with the expulsion of Banu An-Nadir? The Jews thought that their fortresses would protect them from the believers, as Allah says in what can be translated as, "…**And they thought that their fortresses would defend them from Allah! But Allâh's (Torment)…**" **(TMQ, 59:2)**. This ayah came asking them: How did you ever think that these fortresses would protect you from the wrath of Allah? This Qur'an can shatter mountains into pieces, so what about your fortresses? None but Allah (*SWT*) can grant victory and alliance.

"He is Allah…":

At the end there come three magnificent ayah*s* with Allah's most beautiful names, all of which show the Power, Glory and Magnificence of Allah: **"He is Allah, beside Whom none has the right to be worshipped, the All-Knower of the unseen and the seen. He is the Most Gracious, the Most Merciful. He is Allah beside Whom none has the right to be worshipped, the King, the Holy, the One Free from all defects, the Giver of security, the Watcher over His creatures, the All-Mighty, the Compeller, the Supreme. Glory be to Allah! (High is He) above all that they associate as partners with Him. He is Allah, the Creator, the Inventor of all things, and the Bestower of forms. To Him belong the Best Names. All that is in the heavens and the earth glorify Him. And He is the All-Mighty, the All-Wise." (TMQ, 59: 22-24)**.

The Surah started by glorifying Allah and exalting Him, **"Whatsoever is in the heavens and whatsoever is on the earth glorifies Allah." (TMQ, 59:1)**, and ended in the same way, **"All that is in the heavens and the earth glorify Him. And He is the All-Mighty, the All-Wise." (TMQ, 59:24)**. It is as if the conclusion of this Surah stresses one theme: Why do you not want to belong to Allah, He Who has the most beautiful and glorious names? Belong to Allah and to no one but Him!

= Surat Al-Mumtahina (The Woman Tested) =

The objective of Surat Al-Mumtahina is quite obvious from the very beginning; **"O you who believe! Take not My enemies and your enemies (i.e. disbelievers and polytheists) as friends…" (TMQ, 60:1)**. Of course, you can see that the themes of allegiance to Muslims and renunciation of the disbelievers are prominent all through this part. Therefore, this Surah brings us four tests of belonging:

1. Hateb Ibn-Abi-Balta'a.
2. The immigrating women.
3. The balance between loyalty and renunciation.
4. The believing women, before they took the pledge of allegiance.

Let's examine these tests together.

Hateb Ibn-Abi-Balta'a and disclosing secrets:

The Prophet (*SAWS*) was secretly setting up an army to surprise the disbelievers and enter Makkah, so that they would surrender without any bloodshed in the Holy Shrine. However, one of the companions (Hateb Ibn-Abi-Balta'a) sent a secret message to his family in Makkah, warning them about the attack. The whole situation put this believer's loyalty to test. This ayah was revealed to blame him for what he did, in what can be translated as, **"O you who believe! Take not My enemies and your enemies (i.e. disbelievers and polytheists) as friends, showing affection towards them, while they have disbelieved in what has come to you of the truth, and have driven out the Messenger (Muhammad) and yourselves (from your homeland) because you believe in Allah your Lord! If you have come forth to strive in My Cause and to seek My Good Pleasure, (then take not these disbelievers and polytheists as your friends)…" (TMQ, 60:1)**. Then a warning follows, for those who would befriend Allah's enemies, **"…You show friendship to them in secret, while I am All-Aware of what you conceal and what you reveal. And whosoever of you (Muslims) does that, then indeed he has gone (far) astray from the Straight Path" (TMQ, 60:1)**.

What is noticeable about the ayah is that it reproached Hateb in a very gentle tone. Allah assured him, his people and us that he is still regarded as a believer, "**O you who believe**". It also states that the enemies of Allah are also his enemies. "**Take not My enemies and your enemies...**" Moreover, it reminded him of Allah's pleasure, "**If you have come forth to strive in My Cause and to seek My Good Pleasure...**" Can you see how the Qur'an dealt with this matter, which would be regarded as 'high treason' in today's military codes? It dealt with it in such a gentle and amicable way.

"Ibrahim and those with him…. we renounce you":

Allah then presents an example of full membership in Allah's religion and renunciation of all the other ways of life in what can be translated as, **"Indeed there has been an excellent example for you in Ibrâhîm (Abraham) and those with him, when they said to their people: "Verily, we renounce you and whatever you worship besides Allah: we have rejected you, and there has started between us and you hostility and hatred forever until you believe in Allah Alone" - except the saying of Ibrâhîm (Abraham) to his father: "Verily, I will ask forgiveness (from Allah) for you, but I have no power to do anything for you before Allah. " Our Lord! In You (Alone) we put our trust, and to You (Alone) we turn in repentance, and to You (Alone) is (our) final Return" (TMQ, 60:4)**.

I believe you can see now that all of the twenty-eighth part is a presentation of examples of those who belong to Islam and those who do not. Young men and women, I plead with you, before you finish reading the Qur'an, the regulations set by Allah *(SWT)*, you have to fully grasp the idea of allegiance to Muslims and renunciation of the disbelievers.

The test of the female-believers before taking the pledge of allegiance:

This test is the main reason behind the title of the Surah, "The Woman Tested". Listen to Allah saying what can be translated as, **"O you who believe! When believing women come**

to you as emigrants, examine them; Allah knows best as to their Faith, then if you ascertain that they are true believers, send them not back to the disbelievers." (TMQ, 60:10). This ayah talks about discusses a very important issue for any society that would like to preserve its belonging to Islam. The ayah instructed Muslims to test immigrant women before allowing them to be part of their community to guarantee that no skeptics or deceivers would be permitted into the Muslim community. Women have the keys to the stability of any society. They are the ones who have the ability to maintain the solidarity and unity of the members of their society and to preserve their adherence and devotion to their religion. Now can you see how the Muslim community values and honors women? Can you understand the role women play in maintaining the society's relationship to Allah's religion? All of this is so obviously illustrated from Surat Al-Mujadalah to Surat Al-Mumtahina.

The test of justice with non-Muslims:

So as not to misinterpret "total loyalty versus renunciation" as being an animosity towards non-Muslims or as being a renunciation to all People of the Scripture[6] "*Ahlul-Kitab*", even those of them who are not fighting us, the Surah adds an important rule in dealing with non-Muslims: **"Allah does not forbid you to deal justly and kindly with those who fought not against you on account of religion nor drove you out of your homes. Verily, Allah loves those who deal with equity." (TMQ, 60:8).** Just look at the magnificence of the Qur'an. Coming from the very same Surah as this ayah, "**O you who believe! Take not My enemies and your enemies (i.e. disbelievers and polytheists) as friends…**" **(TMQ, 60:1)**, we see, "**to deal justly and kindly with those who fought not against you**" **(TMQ, 60:8)**. Islam is in fact asking us to **"deal justly and kindly"**. We should be fair to them because, "**Allah loves those who deal with equity**". Whom should we renounce then, and who should be our enemies?

"It is only as regards those who fought against you on account of religion, and have driven you out of your homes, and helped to drive you out, that Allâh forbids you to befriend them. And whosoever will befriend them, then those are the wrong-doers (those who disobey Allâh)." (TMQ, 60:9). Even towards the disbelievers who are showing animosity we are asked to show rationality, **"Perhaps Allâh will make friendship between you and those whom you hold as enemies." (TMQ, 60:7)**.

This is how the surah strikes a balance between belonging to Islam and renunciation of the disbelievers. We should renounce the disbelievers who are fighting us but treat those who live with us in peace with justice and forgiveness. That way Muslims will not misunderstand this important principle that distinguishes our religion.

How far you still are you from all these tests? How loyal are you to the religion of Allah and how far did you renounce the Western methodologies contradicting your religion? Are you balanced in the way you grasp the sense of belonging? Or do you renounce all disbelievers, whether they are hostile or peaceful?

Try to ask yourself these questions after reading Surat Al- Mumtahina.

= Surat As-Saf (The Ranks) =

[6] Those who believe in the Gospel and the Torah.

The title explains itself: Muslims, unify your ranks to bring victory to Allah's religion. The central ayah in this Surah can be translated as, **"Verily, Allah loves those who fight in His Cause in rows (ranks) as if they were a solid structure." (TMQ, 61:4)**.

The Israelites[7] and belonging:

The Surah talks about the Israelites and how Musa (Moses) (*AS*) suffered from their feeble faith and weak sense of belonging to Allah's religion, **"And (remember) when Musa (Moses) said to his people: "O my people! Why do you annoy me while you know certainly that I am the Messenger of Allah to you?" (TMQ, 61:5)**. The result was, **"So when they turned away (from the Path of Allah), Allah turned their hearts away (from the Right Path)." (TMQ, 61:5)**.

Then Isa (Jesus) *(AS)* came with the same message to the same people, **"And (remember) when 'Îsâ (Jesus), son of Maryam (Mary), said: 'O Children of Israel! I am the Messenger of Allah unto you, confirming the Taurât [(Torah) which came] before me, and giving glad tidings of a Messenger to come after me, whose name shall be Ahmad'[8]…" (TMQ, 61:6).** Still their weak bond persisted, **"…But when he (Ahmad - *SAWS*) came to them with clear proofs, they said: 'This is plain magic.'" (TMQ, 61:6)**.

Why don't you strive for unity?

After that comes a crucial ayah, **"They intend to put out the Light of Allah (i.e. the Religion of Islam, this Qur'an, and the Prophet Muhammad - *SAWS*) with their mouths. But Allah will bring His Light to perfection even though the disbelievers hate (it)" (TMQ, 61:8)**.

The meaning is quite clear: Muslims, you must strive for unity and stand up for your religion because your enemies do not want you to unite or to be victorious. You now know that Allah will bring the light of His religion to perfection, whether the disbelievers like it or not, so why is your sense of belonging to this religion so weak? The following ayah brings glad tidings in what can be translated as, **"He it is Who has sent His Messenger (Muhammad - *SAWS*) with guidance and the religion of truth to make it victorious over all (other) religions even though the idolaters hate (it)" (TMQ, 61:9)**. This religion will vanquish its enemies and stand out amidst all the other religions and methodologies, so come on, hurry up, be a part of this religion so that in the end, *insha Allah* (If Allah wills), you will be among the ones who prosper.

"Be you vindicators of Allah":

The Surah concludes with a call to all the believers: Prove your belonging! In this ayah, Allah says what can be translated as, **"O you who believe! Be you vindicators (in the Cause) of Allah…" (TMQ, 61:14)**. Praying and fasting are not enough; you have to strive in the cause of Allah. This order is not limited to the *Ummah* of Muhammad (*SAWS*), it was also requested from the followers of all the other Prophets like Isa (*AS*), **"O you who believe! Be you vindicators (in the Cause) of Allah as said 'Îsâ (Jesus), son of Maryam (Mary), to the Disciples: "Who are my helpers (in the Cause) of Allah?" The Disciples**

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[7] *Bani Israel*: The descendants of Israel.

[8] Ahmad is the second name of Prophet Muhammad – SAWS and it literally means: "One who praises Allâh more than others".

said: "We are Allâh's helpers" (i.e. we will strive in His Cause!). Then a group of the Children of Israel believed and a group disbelieved. So We gave power to those who believed against their enemies, and they became the victorious." (TMQ, 61:14).

= Surat Al-Jumua'a (Friday Congregation) =

The objective of Surat Al-Jumua'a is to stress the solidarity and unity of Muslims. *Al-Jumua'a* (Friday) prayer is the symbol of the unity of Muslims dwelling in a given quarter, a district or land. Muslims meet on a weekly basis and listen to the *Jumua'a* sermon, strengthen their ties and discuss their problems. Yet, why is this meaning lacking in our mosques? I wish that those who are giving the *Jumua'a* sermons would reconsider what they are doing to achieve the real purpose behind it. I wish that those who pray, men, children or women, would go to each *Jumua'a* prayer with the intention of renewing their ties with their fellow Muslims.

Essential elements in the *Jumua'a* sermon:

The Surah starts with the essential elements that should be present in any *Jumua'a* sermon. Listen to Allah's words in what can be translated as, **"It is He who sent among the unlettered ones a Messenger (Muhammad - *SAWS*) from among themselves…" (TMQ, 62:2).** What is the mission of this Messenger? What is the mission of anyone representing him for the *Jumua'a* sermon, **"…reciting to them His Verses, purifying them (from the filth of disbelief and polytheism), and teaching them the Book (this Qur'an) and *Al-Hikmah* (*As-Sunnah*: legal ways, orders, acts of worship of Prophet Muhammad - *SAWS*)." (TMQ, 62:2).** Hence the elements are:

- Reading the Qur'an and interpreting it.
- Purifying the souls.
- Teaching the Sunnah of the Prophet, and his Ahadith.

"Come to the remembrance of Allah":

The Surah is concluded with the most important things a Muslim should do to prove his/her belonging to Allah, **"O you who believe (Muslims)! When the call is proclaimed for the *Salâh* (prayer) on Friday (*Jumua'a* prayer), come to the remembrance of Allah and leave off business…" (TMQ, 62:9).** One of the signs of your belonging is your eagerness to respond once the call for prayer has been proclaimed. Hence, you would be united with fellow Muslims in the quarter you dwell in, leaving all the distracting worldly matters behind you. Allah says, in continuation, what can be translated as, **"That is better for you if you do but know!" (TMQ, 62:9).**

The Surah tells us the story of some of the Prophet's companions, when they left him giving the sermon and hurried to meet one of the convoys that was entering Makkah, **"And when they see some merchandise or some amusement they disperse headlong to it, and leave you (Muhammad - *SAWS*) standing [while delivering *Jumua'a* religious sermon]. Say: 'That which Allah has is better than any amusement or merchandise! And Allah is the Best of providers.'" (TMQ, 62:11).** We can see that the companions, despite their devotion and their status, were only humans after all, just like us. They might be distracted at a moment of need or anxiety. Still, their best traits were; quick repentance and submission to Allah.

"As the likeness of a donkey which carries huge burdens of books":

On the other hand, the Surah presents a horrifying example for those who are weak in fellowship with the believers, **"The likeness of those who were entrusted with the (obligation of the) Taurât (Torah) (i.e. to obey its commandments and to practice its laws), but who subsequently failed in those (obligations), is as the likeness of a donkey which carries huge burdens of books (but understands nothing from them). How bad is the example of people who deny the *Ayat* (proofs, verses, signs, or revelations) of Allah. And Allah guides not the people who are wrong-doers." (TMQ, 62:5).**

Be careful! Don't be one of those! Don't attend the sermon without being aware of its importance, and knowing what Islam is really about. Belong truly to Islam, and show the signs of your loyalty and your connection to your religion through the *Jumua'a* prayer and through your interaction with your fellow believers. This was the message in Surat Al-Jumua'a. May Allah renew these meanings in the hearts of our youth, every week and with every *Jumua'a* sermon.

= Surat Al-Munafiqun (The Hypocrites) =

This Surah *puts forward* a warning against a social ailment that could be detrimental to the fellowship of the *Ummah* by undermining its unity. That is why the Surah begins, from the very first ayah, to describe the lies and deceit of the hypocrites, **"When the hypocrites come to you (O Muhammad - *SAWS*), they say: 'We bear witness that you are indeed the Messenger of Allah.' Allah knows that you are indeed His Messenger, and Allah bears witness that the hypocrites are, by all means, liars." (TMQ, 63:1)**.

"Allah knows that you are indeed His Messenger":

Some might think that there is a repetition in the part, "**Allah knows that you are indeed His Messenger…**" However, in Arabic, if we want to evaluate the importance of a certain sentence or phrase, we simply cross it out and see how much this affects the meaning. Removing the underlined part from the sentence would suggest that Allah bears witness that the hypocrites are liars in what they are bearing witness to. This would hence, transform the whole meaning, so this part is indispensable. Not a single word or letter is extra or superfluous in the whole Qur'an; every letter and word has its purpose.

Endangering loyalty:

Look at the aspects of hypocrisy in their lives as shown in the following ayah, **"And when you look at them, their bodies please you; and when they speak, you listen to their words. They are as blocks of wood propped up." (TMQ, 63:4)**. They have slick and polished appearances, yet deep inside, **"They think that every cry is against them." (TMQ, 63:4)**, that is why, **"They are the enemies, so beware of them." (TMQ, 63:4)**.

The following Ayah exposes their arrogance towards Islam and the Messenger of Allah (*SAWS*), **"And when it is said to them: 'So that the Messenger of Allah may ask forgiveness from Allah for you,' they twist their heads, and you would see them turning away their faces in pride." (TMQ, 63:5)**.

"But honor, power and glory belong to Allah, to His Messenger and to the believers":

Their leader, Abdullah Ibn-Ubai Ibn-Saloul was so insolent to the extent of insulting the Prophet (*SAWS*), **"They (hypocrites) say: 'If we return to Al-Madinah, indeed the more honorable will expel from there the lowly.'" (TMQ, 63:8)**. He meant that he is **"more honorable"** and that the Prophet (*SAWS*), Allah forbid, is **"the lowly"**. Instantly the same ayah disputes this claim in what can be translated as, **"But honor, power and glory belong to Allah, and to His Messenger (Muhammad – *SAWS*), and to the believers, yet the hypocrites know not." (TMQ, 63:8)**. This is a very powerful ayah. If you don't feel the glory of belonging to this religion, beware that you might have one of the traits of hypocrisy in you. Remember the words Al-Farouk (Omar Ibnul-Khattab) when he said, "We are the people who have been glorified through Islam, if we strive for glory through any other means but Islam we will certainly be humiliated by Allah".

"Let not your properties divert you":

The Surah is concluded by mentioning the things that distract us from belonging to Islam, as a prelude to Surahs At-Taghabun, At-Talaq and At-Tahreem, which discuss this issue in detail. Allah says what can be translated as, **"O you who believe! Let not your properties or your children divert you from the remembrance of Allah. And whosoever does that, then they are the losers." (TMQ, 63:9)**.

Properties (money, estates …etc) and children were the hypocrites' major concern. Beware my Muslim brother! Don't let these things divert your attention from remembering Allah and from coming together with your fellow believers, or else you will be at the risk of becoming a hypocrite yourself. What is the solution then? Spend in charity, "**And spend (in charity) of that with which We have provided you before death comes to one of you, and he says: 'My Lord! If only You would give me respite for a little while (i.e. return to the worldly life), then I should give *Sadaka* of my wealth, and be among the righteous." (TMQ, 63:10)**. Spending in charity is the best shield for the hearts against the ailment of hypocrisy and all other diversions.

= Surat At-Taghabun (Mutual Loss and gain) =
= Surat At-Talaq (Divorce) =
= Surat At-Tahreem (Prohibition) =

As mentioned before, these Surahs discuss the diversions that distract us from our belonging to Islam. Just by reading the titles we can see that they are all about social distractions.

He who is distracted by his money, his wife and his children from remembering Allah and his religion is a deluded person. He will suffer greatly on the Day of Mutual Loss and Gain, **"The Day when He will gather you (all) on the Day of Gathering, - that will be the Day of mutual loss and gain (i.e. loss for the disbelievers as they will enter the Hell-fire and gain for the believers as they will enter Paradise)." (TMQ, 64:9)**.

"Your wealth and your children are but a trial":

The Surah unveils this reality so we wouldn't be taken in by those worldly pleasures. Allah says what can be translated as, **"O you who believe! Verily, among your wives and your children there are enemies for you (who may stop you from the obedience of Allah);**

therefore beware of them!" (TMQ, 64:14). Then there comes the following ayah, **"Your wealth and your children are but a trial, whereas Allah! With Him is a great reward (Paradise)." (TMQ, 64:15)**.

We note here that, according to the first ayah, only some of your wives and children are enemies, but not all of them. However, they are all "but a trial" and those who will pass this test will be rewarded with great bliss, *insha Allah* (if Allah wills).

Just as in Surat Al-Munafiqun, the mention of trials is followed by an order to spend in charity, **"So keep your duty to Allah and fear Him as much as you can; listen and obey, and spend in charity; that is better for yourselves." (TMQ, 64:16)**. Allah also says what can be translated as, **"If you lend Allah a goodly loan (i.e. spend in Allah's Cause), He will double it for you, and will forgive you. And Allah is Most Ready to appreciate and to reward, Most Forbearing." (TMQ, 64:17)**.

Dear brothers and sisters, spend in Allah's cause to prove your loyalty to your religion and methodology and to safeguard your heart from attachment to worldly pleasures.

Don't leave your wife:

To make sure that people do not misunderstand Surat At-Taghabun and think that they should desert their wives and children in order to devote themselves to the worship of Allah, Surat At-Tahreem gives a further explanation, **"O you who believe! Ward off yourselves and your families against a Fire (Hell) whose fuel is men and stones, over which are (appointed) angels stern (and) severe, who disobey not, (from executing) the commands they receive from Allah, but do that which they are commanded." (TMQ, 66:6)**. Don't desert your children or walk out on your wife leaving them without guidance and companionship. Take their hands and lead them to the Right Path, so that you will all be saved from hell.

Surat At-Talaq (Divorce)
= Say No to Argument =

The name of the Surah represents one of the most common forms of social disunity. Yet, the Surah asserts that we should maintain the solidarity within our society and not argue, even during divorce. We see many ayah*s* stressing the fact that we should fear Allah,

- **"…And fear Allah your Lord (O Muslims)…" (TMQ, 65:1).**
- **"…And whosoever fears Allah and keeps his duty to Him, Allah will make a way for him to get out (from every difficulty)…" (TMQ, 65:2).**
- **"…and whosoever fears Allah and keeps his duty to Him, He will make his matter easy for him…." (TMQ, 65:4).**
- **"…and whosoever fears Allah and keeps his duty to Him, He will expiate from him his sins, and will enlarge his reward…" (TMQ, 65:5).**

This Surah shows the ethics of separation and divorce in the life of a Muslim family. These principles are all under one main theme "fearing Allah". Not fearing Allah, in such circumstances, will not only break up one family but it will also extend to the whole society.

Surat At-Tahreem (Divorce)
= The Role of Women in Belonging =

The end of the twenty-eighth part is linked to its beginning: women's role in Islam. It reminds women that they are the ties that bind the society. Muslim women are responsible for themselves and it is their duty to belong, as well. Their husbands will not be able to help them when the judgment is due; and we are reminded of the stories of the wives of Nuh (*AS*) and Lut (*AS*), **"They were the wives of two of our righteous slaves, but they both betrayed them (by rejecting their doctrine). So they [Nûh (Noah) and Lût (Lot)] availed them (their respective wives) not against Allah and it was said: 'Enter the Fire along with those who enter!'" (TMQ, 66:10)**.

On the other hand, we see the exact opposite with the wife of a committed atheist and tyrant *Firaawn* (the Pharaoh); she was a loyal believer, **"And Allah has set forth an example for those who believe: the wife of Fir'aun (Pharaoh), when she said: 'My Lord! Build for me a home with You in Paradise, and save me from Fir'aun (Pharaoh) and his deeds, and save me from the people who are *Zâlimûn* (polytheists, wrong-doers and disbelievers in Allah)'" (TMQ, 66:11)**.

The next example is Maryam, the daughter of Imran, whose belonging was symbolized by her chastity, modesty (*Haia'a*[9]) and dutiful worship, **"And Maryam (Mary), the daughter of 'Imran who guarded her chastity. And We breathed into her womb [through Our *Rûh* [i.e. Jibril (Gabriel)], and she testified to the truth of the Words of her Lord, and (also believed in) His Scriptures, and she was of the obedient (to Allah)." (TMQ, 66:12)**.

We ask Allah to bless us Muslims with more women like these two. We ask Allah to guide the youth of this *Ummah* to read the twenty-eighth part, understand its meanings and belong to their religion and Qur'an.

[9] The term *Haia'* covers a large number of concepts which are to be taken together, amongst them are; self-respect, modesty, bashfulness, and morality, etc.

Surahs of the Twenty-Ninth Part

Legislative obligation:

The main message in this part is about the necessity to perform *Da'wa* (missionary activity of calling others to Islam) and to convey the discipline of Islam to the whole world. In the previous part we came to realize the importance of belonging to Islam and we felt the sweetness of loyalty to Allah's religion. Now we have to start telling other people about our discoveries, spreading this light of truth with every drop of will, wisdom and power we possess.

Da'wa is a duty of all Muslims, no matter how little their information about religion. The Prophet (*SAWS*) said, "Quote on my behalf, even if it is just one ayah"[10]. On his first day as a Muslim, Abu-Bakr called 6 of the *Sahabah* (Companions) to Islam, although his information about Islam back then was much less than yours.

For example, if you know a Hadith about the importance of *Salat* (prayer), tell it to your friends; share the information! Talk about loving Allah, about the beauty of paradise or about the Day of Judgment. These are very simple issues to talk about and you don't need to have extensive knowledge. You will find valuable information in part 29, the part of *Tabarak*[11].

Surat Al-Mulq (The Dominion)
= Know the One you will call to =

The first Surah of this part tells you about the One you will call to; you have to know Allah before you start calling people to Islam. Get to know His dominion and greatness, **"Blessed be He in Whose Hand is the dominion; and He is Able to do all things." (TMQ, 67:1)**.

Get to know how He perfected His universe, **"Who has created the seven heavens one above another; you can see no fault in the creation of the Most Gracious. Then look again: 'Can you see any rifts?' Then look again and yet again: your sight will return to you in a state of humiliation and worn out." (TMQ, 67:3-4)**.

Look at the birds above you, look at the seas below you and ask yourself, "Who can control all of this except Allah?" Allah says what can be translated as, **"Do they not see the birds above them, spreading out their wings and folding them in? None upholds them except the Most Gracious (Allah). Verily, He is the All-Seer of everything." (TMQ, 67:19)**. Allah also says what can be translated as, **"Say (O Muhammad - *SAWS*): 'Tell me! If (all) your water were to sink away, who then can supply you with flowing (spring) water?'" (TMQ, 67:30)**.

All these meanings pave the way for anyone aiming to start *Da'wa*. Fill your heart with love for Him, before you start calling others to His religion.

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[10] Authentic Hadith, Narrated by Bukhari, 3461.

[11] The 29th part is named "*Tabarak*" since this is the first word that occurs in the first Surah of this part (Surat Al-Mulq).

Surat Al-Qalam (The Pen), or Nun
= Manners and Behavior of Those Who Call to Islam =

Surat Nun sets forth the principles of *Da'wa*; with two examples: the Prophet Muhammad (*SAWS*) as the model with great moral principles on one side, and those who do not abide by these principles and hence gain nothing from their *Da'wa*, on the other.

Allah says what can be translated as, **"And (O Muhammad) obey you not everyone *Hallaf Mahîn* (the one who swears much and is a liar or is worthless); a slanderer, going about with calumnies; hinderer of the good, transgressor, sinful; cruel, and moreover base-born (of illegitimate birth). (He was so) because he had wealth and children." (TMQ, 68:10-14)**.

The Surah narrates the story of some people who owned a beautiful garden. Their miserliness forced other people to hate them and eventually Allah took everything away from them. The story is warning us not to be miserly. Tightfistedness is one of the worst characteristics that those who call to Allah could have. It hampers their efforts in calling to Islam and prevents people from listening to them.

To perform *Da'wa*, a Muslim should be skilful in his religion, and he can reach such level through continuous reading and studying. That is why this Surah is named "The Pen" and that is why it was the second Surah to be revealed, right after Surat Al-Alaq in which Allah's first word to Muhammad was **"**Read**"**. How can we claim to be part of this *Ummah*, the *Ummah* of "Read" and how can we spread its religion without being committed to reading and studying?

Surat Al-Haqqah, (The Inevitable)
= The Day of Judgment =

This Surah comes to you with a stack of information about how you can call your brothers and sisters, and all the people around you to Islam. *Al-Haqqah* is one of the names of the Day of Judgment. Reminding people of this day is one of the most important means you can use to soften the hearts of others and awaken them from their slumber. You see in it the horrors of facing The Subduer, **"That Day shall you be brought to Judgment, not a secret about you will be hidden." (TMQ, 69:18)**. The Surah then moves swiftly to the destiny everybody will have after the records have been handed out, **"Then as for him who will be given his Record in his right hand will say: 'Here! Read my Record! Surely, I did believe that I shall meet my account!' So he shall be in a life, well-pleasing. In a lofty Paradise…" (TMQ, 69:19-22)**.

You can taste the sweet victory and imagine the happiness in this person's eyes when reading this ayah. Why can't you be like him? Why don't you tell others to follow the same pattern?

On the other hand, we see, **"But as for him who will be given his record in his left hand, will say: 'I wish that I had not been given my record! And that I had never known how my account is! Would that it had been my end (death)! My wealth has not availed me; My power (and arguments to defend myself) have gone from me!' (It will be said): 'Seize him and fetter him; Then throw him in the blazing Fire. Then fasten him with a chain whereof the length is seventy cubits!'" (TMQ, 69:25-32)**.

Wonderful ayah*s*! The contrast between the two cases is quite sharp! Note, however, that paradise is mentioned first. The meaning is: entice people first with paradise and then warn them against hell; incentive is far more effective than intimidation.

Surat Al-Ma'arij, (The Ways of Ascent)
= The Importance of Worship, besides Manners =

Surat Al-Qalam tells us about the traits of those who perform *Da'wa* whereas Surat Al-Ma'arij tells us about the other side aspect of their personality: worship. All those who call to Allah should combine both good manners and regular worship; not sacrificing one for the sake of the other. The Surah gives us some wonderful ayah*s* describing the devout worshipers, **"Verily, man (disbeliever) was created very impatient; Irritable (discontented) when evil touches him; and niggardly when good touches him. Except those who are devoted to prayers. Those who remain constant in their prayers; and those in whose wealth there is a recognized right, for the beggar who asks, and for the unlucky who has lost his property and wealth, (and his means of living has been straitened). And those who believe in the Day of Recompense..." (TMQ, 70:19-26)**. **"Such shall dwell in the Gardens (i.e. Paradise), honored." (TMQ, 70:35)**.

We can see that they are the very same traits mentioned in Surat Al-Muminun (The Believers). As if we are being asked: What is your status among the believers? How far you still are you from the questions raised by the 28th part? Did you strengthen your faith and increase worship before calling others to Allah?

On the other hand, let us not misunderstand the meaning to be: you can't carry on *Da'wa* until your faith is complete. Ibn-Taimiah (may Allah Bless him) said something very wise about this, "Let not any of you say that he will not call to Allah until his faith is complete. In that case he will be bound to one of two options; either a day will come when he will think that his faith is complete, that is when he is been led astray. Or he will die without completing his faith."

What is the solution then? Allah says what can be translated as, **"You (believers) are the best of peoples ever raised up for mankind; you enjoin *Al-Ma'rûf* (i.e. Islamic Monotheism and all that Islam has ordained) and forbid *Al-Munkar* (polytheism, disbelief and all that Islam has forbidden), and you believe in Allah." (TMQ, 3:110)**. The solution is for you to carry on *Da'wa*, to work on your manners and strengthen your faith; all at the same time. This does not conflict with carrying on *Da'wa*. On the contrary, calling to Allah and guiding people to the right path will help you in your worshiping and in maintaining good manners.

As we can see, the first four Surahs of this part tell us about the traits of those who carry on *Da'wa*: knowing about Allah, having skills in science and knowledge, believing in the Day of Judgment and using that for incentive rather than intimidation together with a big share of worshiping and manners. After this introduction we move on to Surat Nuh. This Surah presents to us a model of success in performing *Da'wa*.

Surat Nuh (Noah)
= An Account of How to Perform *Da'wa* =

The Surah starts with the divine duty that this great Prophet was assigned, **"Verily, We sent Nûh (Noah) to his people (saying): 'Warn your people before there comes to them a painful torment.'" (TMQ, 71:1)**. Then it moves to describing Prophet Nuh's life as a person performing *Da'wa*. Let us examine together the aspects of his missionary work and learn from this Prophet how to have a sense of being protective towards the religion of Allah. Let us learn the art of *Da'wa* as it should be.

The dedication for *Da'wa*:

We learn about how a truly dedicated person performs *Da'wa*, **"He said: 'O my Lord! Verily, I have called to my people night and day.'" (TMQ, 71:5)**.

Why is night mentioned before day? Do we normally perform *Da'wa* at night? This ayah tells us that Nuh (*AS*) used to call to Allah night and day without a break. To him it was a twenty-four-hour mission. However, his people's denial defiance was so intense, **"Yet all my calling led to nothing but (their) flight (from the truth)." (TMQ, 71:6)**. Nevertheless, he never stopped his call, **"And verily, every time I called unto them that You might forgive them…" (TMQ, 71: 7)**. See the use of the word "every time". It tells you how persistent he was, **"And verily, every time I called unto them that You might forgive them, they thrust their fingers into their ears, covered their faces up with their garments, and persisted (in their refusal), and magnified themselves with pride." (TMQ, 71:7)**.

Despite his people's rejection, Nuh was persistent in performing *Da'wa*, **"'Then verily, I called to them openly (aloud). Then verily, I proclaimed to them in public, and I have appealed to them in private.'" (TMQ, 71:8-9)**. It was like he was saying, "I've tried all the possible ways; I've spoken with them privately; I've held conferences to explain my ideas, I've addressed them in groups and individually; I've tried it all!" However, **"none but a few believed with him,"** just as it was in Surat Hud. According to some scholars only 60 believed with him. Imagine! That is almost one believer every 15 years! What kind of obstinate denial is this? What kind of dedication and persistence in *Da'wa* is this?

Surat Nuh emphasizes an important aspect of *Da'wa*: Keep on performing *Da'wa* even if nobody responds. Take Nuh (*AS*) as your model.

The art of *Da'wa*:

The Surah continues goes on describing the methods used in of *Da'wa*, **"I said (to them): 'Ask forgiveness from your Lord, verily, He is Oft-Forgiving; He will send rain to you in abundance, And give you increase in wealth and children, and bestow on you gardens and bestow on you rivers.'" (TMQ, 71:10-12)**.

In these ayahs, Nuh (*AS*) gives his people glad tidings that, if they respond to Allah's call, this will be for their own good in this life, not just in the hereafter. It is as if he is telling them, "Don't you love this world? Aren't you attached to it? Then ask for Allah's forgiveness so your lives will flourish."

Then he tries another method, **"What is the matter with you, that [you fear not Allâh (His punishment), and] you hope not for reward (from Allâh)? While He has created you in (different) stages. See you not how Allâh has created the seven heavens one above**

another, and has made the moon a light therein, and made the sun a lantern?" (TMQ, 71:13-14).

I can almost hear you all saying, "'This is exactly like Surat Al-Mulq, and the importance of knowing Allah and glorifying him so we could call others to him…" Yes; look at the intricate coherence of the Surahs! Then what else?

"And Allah has brought you forth from the (dust of) earth[12]. Afterwards He will return you into it (the earth), and bring you forth (again on the Day of Resurrection)?" (TMQ, 71:17-18). This is a reminder of death and the Day of Judgment; the same objective of Surat Al-Haqqah. Look again at the intricate coherence. Surat Nuh is giving us a practical account of the meanings discussed in the previous Surahs of this part.

The cause of extinction:

Prophet Nuh explains, in his statement, the reason for his people's denial, **"Nûh (Noah) said: 'My Lord! They have disobeyed me, and followed those whose wealth and children gave them nothing but loss.'" (TMQ, 71:21)**.

As we can see, the problem is universal; preoccupation with wealth and children. It is the same problem discussed in Surat At-Taghabun, **"O you who believe! Verily, among your wives and your children there are enemies for you (who may stop you from the obedience of Allah); therefore beware of them!" (TMQ, 64:14)**.

The Surah concludes with a supplication. This is intended to teach us that, for those who perform *Da'wa,* personal effort and endeavor to achieve their aim should always go hand in hand with supplication and turning to Allah, since He *(SWT)* is the One who guides us.

"My Lord! Forgive me, and my parents, and whoever enters my home as a believer, and all the believing men and women. And to the *Zâlimûn* (polytheists, wrong-doers, and disbelievers) grant them naught but destruction!" (TMQ, 71:28). Look how the circle of supplication gets wider as it moves from the believer, to his parents and acquaintances, then to all the believers; men and women. Indeed, a great Surah and a great account for anyone performing *Da'wa* to extract lessons and useful examples.

Surat Al-Jinn (Jinn)
= Those Performing *Da'wa* from Another World =

The 29th part then introduces us to another group performing *Da'wa*: the jinn. An extraordinary one indeed! The Surah is almost asking you, "Aren't you jealous of them?" How can the jinn respond to the call and convey it while you are oblivious and totally detached from it? Listen to Allah saying what can be translated as, **"Say (O Muhammad - *SAWS*): 'It has been revealed to me that a group of jinn listened (to this Qur'an). They said: 'Verily, we have heard a wonderful Recitation (this Qur'an)! It guides to the Right Path, and we have believed therein, and we shall never join (in worship) anything with our Lord (Allâh).'" (TMQ, 72:1-2)**.

[12] Tafssir At-Tabari.

Why can't you be like them? Why don't you take them as an example to follow?

Listen to how they challenged the disbelievers among the jinn, especially *Iblis* (Satan),**"And that the foolish among us [i.e. *Iblis* (Satan) or the polytheists amongst the jinn] used to utter against Allah things which were enormously false." (TMQ, 72:4)**. Look at how they renounced the evil deeds of the jinn and the humans alike, **"'And verily, there were men among mankind who sought refuge in the males among the jinn, but they (jinn) increased them (mankind) in sin and transgression." (TMQ, 72:6)**. This latter ayah is a warning against trying to take refuge in the jinn. Those who do so will be more miserable than they were. Listen, brothers, this warning is from the jinn themselves. They are warning you against taking refuge in them or seeking their help.

More ayah*s* follow, all showing us their wisdom and their understanding of the concept of *Da'wa* and how important it is, **"'And indeed when we heard the Guidance (this Qur'an), we believed therein (Islamic Monotheism), and whosoever believes in his Lord shall have no fear, either of a decrease in the reward of his good deeds or an increase in the punishment for his sins. And of us some are Muslims (who have submitted to Allah, after listening to this Qur'an), and of us some are *Al-Qâsitûn* (disbelievers - those who have deviated from the Right Path). And whosoever has embraced Islam, then such have sought the Right Path.'" (TMQ, 72:13-14).**

We see here words very similar to those used by Nuh (*AS*), that *Iman* (faith) will be of benefit to us in this world as well as in the hereafter, **"If they (non-Muslims) had gone on the Right Way (i.e. Islam), We (Allah) would surely have bestowed on them water (rain) in abundance." (TMQ, 72:16)**.

The connection between both Surahs is very obvious; both of them teach us the *Fiqh* (science) of *Da'wa*, its importance and methods of performing it.

Surat Al-Muzzammil (The One Wrapped in Garments)
= Your Provisions and Supplies =

Here too, the objective is quite obvious from the start, **"O you wrapped in garments (i.e. Prophet Muhammad - *SAWS*)! Stand (to pray) all night, except a little." (TMQ, 73:1-2)**. You, who are trying to call others to Allah, you will get your spiritual supply from: *Salat al-Qiyam* (the vigil night prayer). Why? Carrying on *Da'wa* is a very tough mission indeed, **"Verily, We shall send down to you hefty Words (i.e. obligations, laws)." (TMQ. 73:5)**. What has *Salat al-Qiyam* got to do with all that? **"Verily, the rising by night (for *Tahajjud or Qiyam* prayer) is very hard and most potent and good for governing oneself, and most suitable for (understanding) the Words (of Allah)." (TMQ, 73:6)**. This *Salat* makes men, and builds up those who perform *Da'wa*, and divide their daily agenda days into two parts; *Da'wa* in the morning and worship at night, **"Verily, there is for you by day prolonged occupation with ordinary duties. And remember the Name of your Lord and devote yourself to Him with a complete devotion." (TMQ, 73:7-8)**.

Then the Surah mentions Musa (AS) and the Pharaoh, **"Verily, We have sent to you (O men) a Messenger (Muhammad - *SAWS*) to be a witness over you, as We did send a Messenger [Musa (Moses)] to Fir'aun (Pharaoh). But Fir'aun (Pharaoh) disobeyed the Messenger [Musa (Moses)]; so We seized him with a severe punishment." (TMQ, 73:15-16)**. What has Musa and the Pharaoh got to do with the core idea of this Surah?

Salat al-Qiyam (Night Prayers) is our first shield against tyrants and obstinate disbelievers, as in the case of Musa (AS) and the Pharaoh. It is as if we are being told to pray at night to be stronger and more capable of *Da'wa* in the morning. A very clear formula is presented to us in Surat Al-Muzzammil. The Surah concludes with what we can translate as, **"Verily, your Lord knows that you do stand (to pray at night) a little less than two thirds of the night, or half the night, or a third of the night, and also a party of those with you. And Allah measures the night and the day. He knows that you are unable to pray the whole night, so He has turned to you (in mercy). So, recite you of the Qur'an as much as may be easy for you. He knows that there will be some among you sick, others traveling through the land, seeking of Allah's Bounty, yet others fighting in Allah's Cause. So recite as much of the Qur'an as may be easy (for you), and perform *As-Salât* (*Iqâmat-as-Salât*) and give *Zakât*, and lend to Allah a goodly loan. And whatever good you send before you for yourselves (good deeds), you will certainly find it with Allah, better and greater in reward. And seek Forgiveness of Allah. Verily, Allah is Oft-Forgiving, Most-Merciful." (TMQ, 73:20)**.

Night prayer was an obligation on all Muslims during the secret call to Islam, and continued to be so for quite a year after Islam was proclaimed openly. Then it became difficult for the companions to perform this prayer, so the last ayah was revealed to lessen this obligation. It came to say what can be translated as, **"So, recite of the Qur'an as much as may be easy for you." (TMQ, 73:20)**.

It is significant that in this Surah we read what can be translated as, **"…yet others fighting in Allah's Cause." (TMQ, 73:20)**. This Surah is Makkan and was revealed at the beginning of the Makkan era yet it mentions *Jihad* for the sake of Allah. This is because the night prayer is among the prerequisites of preparing for *Jihad*. Use it to get ready for *Jihad* when the time comes.

Surat Al-Muddathir (The one enveloped)
= Arise and Warn =

After you have taken your spiritual provisions and supplies and after you have known the One you will call others to and have seen wonderful examples of those performing *Da'wa* to Allah, after you have acknowledged the reality of the hereafter and learned about it, what are you doing then? Why are you standing still? **"Arise and Warn" (TMQ, 74:2)**. This Surah is urging you to move, to rise and take action by performing *Da'wa*.

"O you (Muhammad - SAWS) enveloped in garments! Arise and warn! And magnify your Lord (Allah)!" (TMQ, 74:1-3). This Ayah does not mean that you should just say, "Allahu Akkbar" (Allah is the Greatest). It is urging you to let others know the magnificence of Allah, to let the whole universe magnify Him so that the commandments of Allah can be more important in your heart than anything else.

It is especially notable in this Surah that the ayah*s* are very swift in pace and effect. In Surat Al-Muzzammil the ayah*s* were simple and slow. They suited the atmosphere of night-time, **"O you wrapped in garments (i.e. Prophet Muhammad - *SAWS*)! Stand (to pray) all night, except a little." (TMQ, 73:1-2)** and **"And remember the Name of your Lord and devote yourself to Him with a complete devotion." (TMQ, 73:8)**.

In Surat Al-Muddathir, on the other hand, the ayah*s* move more rapidly to keep pace with the swift actions of those who undertake *Da'wa,* and fill the universe with their vitality and vigor their optimism and interaction with the others, **"Arise and warn! And magnify your Lord (Allah)! And purify your garments! And keep away from *Ar-Rujz* (the idols)!" (TMQ, 74:2-5).**

"Then, when the Trumpet is sounded (i.e. the second blowing of the horn), truly, that Day will be a Hard Day - Far from easy for the disbelievers." (TMQ, 74:8-10). Look at the magnificence of the Qur'an! The pace of these ayah*s* suits the objectives and the core ideas of the Surah.

Listen to what can be translated as, **"As if they were (frightened) wild donkeys. Fleeing from a hunter, or a lion, or a predator." (TMQ, 74:50-51)**. In these ayah*s* we see the disbelievers fleeing from the right path like wild donkeys trying to escape from a ferocious lion. What an incredible metaphor to suit the swiftness and rhythm of the ayah*s*.

= Surat Al-Qiyamah (The Resurrection) =

This Surah, as its name implies, reminds us of the Day of Resurrection. Just like Surat Al-Haqqah, it provides those who will perform *Da'wa* with the basic resources to use while leading others by the hands to the right path. This is especially evident in the way it reminds us of the initial stage of the hereafter: Death. Allah says what can be translated as, **"Nay, when (the soul) reaches to the collar bone (i.e. up to the throat in its exit), and it will be said: 'Who can cure him (and save him from death)?' And he (the dying person) will conclude that it was (the time) of parting (death)" (TMQ, 75:26-30)**.

= Surat Al-Insan (Man) =

This Surah explains one of the most important concepts to all those who want to undertake *Da'wa*. This concept is: All you have to do is *Da'wa*, as for the results, you leave them to Allah. That is why we see Allah saying what can be translated as, **"Verily, We showed him the way, whether he be grateful or ungrateful." (TMQ. 76:3)**. This Surah is almost saying to all those performing *Da'wa* and their Prophet (*SAWS*): Don't give up because some people disbelieve or deny you, Allah is One who guides, **"Therefore be patient (O Muhammad - *SAWS*) with constancy to the Command of your Lord (Allah, by doing your duty to Him and by conveying His Message to mankind), and obey neither a sinner nor a disbeliever among them." (TMQ, 76:24)**. It also says, **"Verily, these (disbelievers) love the present life of this world, and put behind them a heavy Day (that will be hard)." (TMQ, 76:27)**.

= Surat Al-Mursalat (Those Sent Forth) =

Surat Al-Insan asked those performing *Da'wa* not to be troubled by other people's denial of their call, this Surah addresses a direct warning to those deniers, **"Woe that Day to the deniers (of the Day of Resurrection)!" (TMQ, 77:15)**. At the same time it tells those performing *Da'wa* not to be distressed, to seek the means and leave the results to Allah, the Lord of all worlds, **"Then in what statement after this (the Qur'an) will they believe?" (TMQ, 77:50)**.

These Surahs are extraordinarily superb in the way they talk about *Da'wa*. Although we were not able to discuss all the principles and concepts related to *Da'wa* that were mentioned in these Surahs, we have tried to shed some light on the key points in *Da'wa* and its significance, leaving t the whole arena open for the reader of the Qur'an to live with the Surahs and feel the endless grace and blessings of this Holy Book, in affirmation of the Prophet's Hadith, "Its wonders (the Qur'an) are endless"[13].

[13] Narrated by Ibn Hijr, *Al-Kafi Al-Shafy*, 53.

Surahs of the Thirtieth Part

Conclusion:

This part concludes both the Qur'an and the methodology of "Vicegerency" on earth, as set up by Allah to the whole of mankind. Having discussed the rules and the laws, having talked about the ancestors and taken them as examples, and having mentioned the prerequisites of Vicegerency in entire Surahs and parts, we come now to the thirtieth part which is composed of several short but very impressive Surahs. This part emphasizes the meanings that can help the reader apply the whole methodology : from urging us to believe in the greatness of Allah (SWT) and His abilities, reminding us that we will meet Him and return to Him on the Day of Judgment, to asserting the necessity to remember Him and thank Him.

Surat Abasa (He Frowned)
= A Reproach for the Sake of Allah =

In Surat Abasa we read the tender divine reproach given to the Prophet (*SAWS*) for turning away from a blind companion (Abdullah Ibnum-Maktum) who came to ask about a certain issue. At the time the latter came, the Prophet (*SAWS*) was talking to some of the chiefs of Quraysh. Therefore Allah revealed what can be translated as, **"He (The Prophet - *SAWS*) frowned and turned away, because there came to him the blind man (i.e. 'Abdullâh Ibn Umu-Maktûm). And how can you know? He might become pure (from sins). Or he might receive admonition, and the admonition might profit him?" (TMQ, 80:1-4)**. These ayah*s* teach us that *Da'wa* is a right of everyone and not just limited to certain categories of people. We have to learn that anyone seeking to learn any issue within the scope of *Da'wa* is indeed entitled to know it, no matter what his social stature might be.

It is worth mentioning that the Prophet's attention to the chiefs of Quraysh was neither because of their high social standard, nor out of contempt to the blind man. It was only because he thought these chiefs would have benefited Islam more had they joined its fold. He (*SAWS*) wanted them to become Muslims for the sake of Islam, not because they were rich. In this respect, the reproach came to remind him (SAWS) not to ignore anyone asking about Islam. This was intended also to teach those performing *Da'wa* to consider all people, rich or poor, young or old, without any discrimination.

Surat At-Tariq (The Night-Comer)
= The Creation and the Command are His =

This Surat reminds us of our own reality and origin, **"So let man see from what he is created! He is created from a fluid gushing forth, proceeding from between the backbone and the ribs. Verily, (Allah) is Able to bring him back (to life)!" (TMQ, 86:5-8)**. Man is created from a mere drop, originating from the backbone of the male and the ribs of the female, the same way a drop of rain brings a plant out from the soil, **"So let man see from what he is created! He is created from a fluid gushing forth, proceeding from between the backbone and the ribs. Verily, (Allah) is Able to bring him back (to life)!" (TMQ, 86:11-12)**.

The Creator of mankind and the Creator of the universe is but One. He created man, just like He created the plants, from water in which He put the secret of life.

Surat Ash-Shams (The Sun)
= Your Fate is with Your Creator =

This Surah gives an account of the cosmic phenomena that were created by Allah for the sole use of man, the most important and honored creature, **"By the sun and its brightness. By the moon as it follows it (the sun). By the day as it shows up (the sun's) brightness. By the night as it conceals it (the sun). By the heaven and Him Who built it. By the earth and Him Who spread it. By the *Nafs* (a person or a soul), and Him Who perfected him in proportion;" (TMQ, 91:1-7)**. Then the Surah stops at the (*Nafs*), or the soul to describe it and show its importance, **"Then He showed him what is wrong for him and what is right for him. Indeed he succeeds who purifies his own self (i.e. obeys and performs all that Allah ordered). And indeed he fails who corrupts his own self (i.e. disobeys what Allah has ordered by rejecting the true Faith or by doing evil deeds)." (TMQ 91:8-10)**. If only human beings had realized their value the way their Creator sees it, they would seek to answer their Lord's call, they would then love Him as He loves them.

Surat Ad-Duha (The forenoon)
= How Much His Lord Loved Him =

In contrast to the reproach in Surat Abasa, this Surah shows us how much Allah loves His Prophet Muhammad (*SAWS*), **"By the forenoon (after sunrise). By the night when it darkens (and stands still). Your Lord (O Muhammad - *SAWS*) has neither forsaken you nor hates you." (TMQ, 93:1-3)**. Don't think, Muhammad, that your Lord has deserted you or that He does not love you!

"Did He not find you (O Muhammad - *SAWS*) an orphan and gave you shelter? Did He not find you unaware and guided you? Did he not find you poor and made you rich (self-sufficient)?" (TMQ, 93:6-8). These are very tender words of endearment, filled with divine love for the Prophet (*SAWS*).

Among the blessings of this Surah is that Allah swore at the beginning by the two most serene times of the day: the forenoon and the night. The love of Allah for his Prophet is not just limited to words then; it has exceeded that to depict a whole emotional atmosphere as shown in the tender words and ayah*s* of this Surah.

Surat At-Teen (The Figs)
= You are the Best, on Condition… =

We almost see this same meaning in Surat At-Teen, **"By the figs, and the olives. By Mount Sinai. By this city of security (Makkah). Verily, We created man in the best stature (form)." (TMQ, 95:1-4)**. What have the first three ayah*s* got to do with the creation of man? This Surah identified three holy locations; land of the figs and olives; Jerusalem, Mount Sinai where Allah spoke with Musa and Makkah. All of these places are sanctified, holy shrines. After that, Allah speaks about the creation of

man in the best form and shape. It is as if we should understand the meaning as: The sanctity of the human being, for Allah, is equal to the sanctity of these holy places. Sanctify yourselves, human beings, by obeying Allah and thanking him for creating you in the best form and mold, or else, **"Then We reduced him to the lowest of the low." (TMQ, 95:5)**. Nothing will save you from this destiny except *Iman* faith and good deeds **"Save those who believe (in Islamic Monotheism) and do righteous deeds. Then they shall have a reward without end (Paradise)." (TMQ, 95:6)**.

Surat Al-Alaq (The Leech-Like Clot)
Surat An-Nasr (The Help)
= Safeguarding the Deeds =

In this part there are two Surahs; one of them was at the beginning of the revelation, namely Surat Al-Alaq, **"Read! In the Name of your Lord Who has created (all that exists). He has created man from a leech-like clot. Read! And your Lord is the Most Generous. Who has taught (the writing) by the pen. He has taught man that which he knew not." (TMQ, 96:1-5)**, and the other lamentably announced the news of the Prophet's death in Surat An-Nasr (The Help) towards the end of the revelation, **"When there comes the Help of Allah (to you, O Muhammad against your enemies) and the conquest (of Makkah)." (TMQ, 110:1)**. The latter was revealed before the death of the Prophet, bringing him glad tidings about the eventual glory and the victory of Islam, **"And you see that the people enter Allah's religion (Islam) in crowds. So glorify the Praises of your Lord, and ask His Forgiveness. Verily, He is the One Who accepts the repentance and Who forgives." (TMQ, 110:2-3)**. What is the relationship between asking for Allah's forgiveness and the victory of Islam and the greatness of the Muslims? A victorious person might be filled with conceit or arrogance, as we have seen with many victorious leaders and conquerors throughout the centuries. That is why it is important to thank Allah the Giver for His blessings and ask Him to forgive us for our lack of appreciation. These two things will not only safeguard our deeds from being lost, but will also safeguard our hearts from conceit and tyranny.

The slogan of the faithful:

That is why we see that in Islam, forgiveness always comes after great deeds. After praying we say, "I ask for the forgiveness of Allah, the One and Only, the Ever-Living, the Self-Subsisting, and to Him I repent"[14]. Through this Surah Allah teaches us that we should always give Him full credit for any blessings we get and blame ourselves for failing to ask for His forgiveness. Nobody will ever be able to counterbalance the Lord of all Greatness for what He properly deserves.

Surat At-Takathur (The Piling-up)
= Balancing between materialism and spiritualism =

Surat At-Takathur introduces us to a very important concept: We shouldn't live only to satisfy the physical needs of our bodies. We shouldn't live only for food, fun and marriage. We have to take care of our spirits as well. We have to be careful in case

[14] "*Astaghfiru-llah Alladhy La Ilaha Ila Huwa, Al-Haiul-Kayum, wa Atubu-illaih*."

money and children might distract us from remembering Allah, then we would find ourselves confronted by death. **"The mutual rivalry (for piling up of worldly things) diverts you, until you visit the graves (i.e. until you die)." (TMQ, 102:1-2)**. The Surah then warns those who live only for their self-indulgence and their physical desires, **"Nay! You shall come to know! Again nay! You shall come to know! Nay! If you knew with a sure knowledge (the end result of piling up, you would not have been occupied yourselves in worldly things). Verily, You shall see the blazing Fire (Hell)!" (TMQ, 102:3-6)**. Don't be one of those.

Inside you, you have a spirit that yearns for its own food; obedience, forgiveness, praying and *Qiyam*. If you ignore this warning then listen to this horrifying ayah about Hell, may Allah save us all from it, **"And again, you shall see it with certainty of sight! Then on that Day you shall be asked about the delights (you indulged in, in this world)!" (TMQ, 102:7-8)**. Allah *(SWT)* will ask us about every blessing He bestowed upon us, the most important of which are our bodies. Some of us have used the latters in disobeying Allah, forgetting to nourish our spirits to prepare them for the Day of Judgment.

Surat Al-Asr (The Time)
= The Solid Cemented Structure =

Next we come to Surat Al-Asr, the Surah that was described by Al-Imam Al-Shafei (*RA*) as follows, "If nothing of the Qur'an was revealed except this Surah, it would have sufficed the whole of humanity." This Surah covers all the features of Islam, in what can be translated as, **"Except those who believe (in Islâmic Monotheism) and do righteous good deeds…" (TMQ, 103:3)**. Then it stresses the importance of unity among Muslims, their cooperation to bring victory to this religion and their patience in overcoming all the obstacles that face them, **"…and recommend one another to the truth, and recommend one another to patience." (TMQ, 103:3)**. Anybody who is not following this path is a loser, **"Verily, man is in loss, except those who believe…" (TMQ, 103:2-3)**. This path is indeed the right path; the path that we ask Allah to guide us to in every *Raka'a* we pray, **"Guide us to the Straight Path. The Path of those on whom You have bestowed Your Grace, not (the path) of those who earned Your Anger (i.e. those who knew the Truth, but did not follow it) nor of those who went astray (i.e. those who did not follow the Truth out of ignorance and error)." (TMQ, 1:6-7)**. Those who have earned Allah's anger are losers and those who have strayed are also losers, but those who recommended one another to the truth and to patience are those on whom Allah has bestowed the blessing of guidance to the right path.

Making nations and civilization:

In this Surah there are very important themes. It has compiled all the assets required for making nations and civilizations such as:

- Caring about the value of time **"By the time." (TMQ, 103:1)**.
- Occupying our time with useful things, **"Except those who believe and do righteous good deeds." (TMQ, 103:2)**.

- The importance of team-work, **"and recommend one another to the truth, and recommend one another to patience." (TMQ, 103:3)**.

If the *Ummah* realized the meaning of this Surah, it would raise its awareness and all the assets of its civilization consequently would increase.

Surat Al-Feel (The Elephant)
= The Weak Plots of the Worthless =

This Surah tells us that this whole universe belongs to Allah. It tells us that Allah is capable of punishing every tyrant in every time, **"Have you (O Muhammad - *SAWS*) not seen how your Lord dealt with the owners of the Elephant? Did He not make their plot go astray?" (TMQ, 105:1-2)**. The plotting of Allah's enemies is weak. It has no real effect and it would not last for long because Allah's might will stand in its way, **"And He sent against them birds, in flocks, striking them with stones of *Sijjîl* (baked clay). And He made them like (an empty field of) stalks (of which the corn has been eaten up by cattle)." (TMQ, 105: 3-5)**. Seek Allah's help against His enemy and yours.

Surat Quraysh
= Never get used to the blessings =

Then we come to Surat Quraysh. This Surah discusses a very serious problem: getting used to Allah's blessings and taking them for granted, to the extent that some people might forget to thank Allah for them. **"(It is a great Grace from Allah) for the protection of the Quraysh, (And with all those Allah's Grace and Protections, We cause) the (Quraysh) caravans to set forth safe in winter and in summer (without any fear)." (TMQ, 106:1-2)**. They became accustomed to one of the great blessings of Allah; the safe road prepared by Him for their winter and summer journeys. Such blessings should have been answered with gratitude and worshiping Him, **"So let them worship (Allah) the Lord of this House (the *Ka'ba* in Makkah), (He) Who has fed them against hunger, and has made them safe from fear." (TMQ, 106:3-4)**.

The greatest blessings of Allah and the most basic needs of human beings are food and safety. Surat Quraysh says to those who read the Qur'an, "revive your hearts by remembering the blessings of Allah, and beware not to get used to them, since this distracts the hearts from thanking Allah the Bestower.